

Can't Stand the Heat

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Can't Stand the Heat

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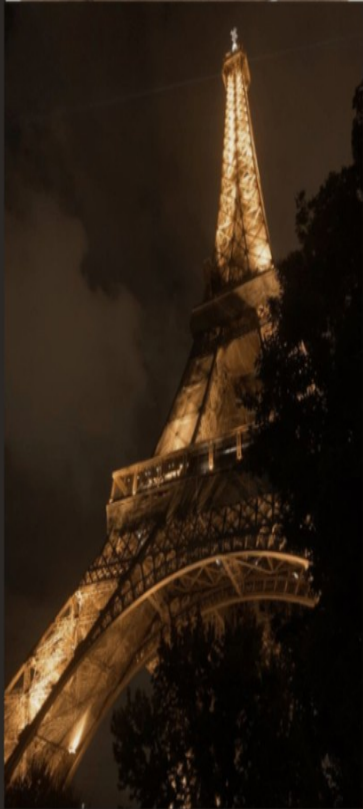
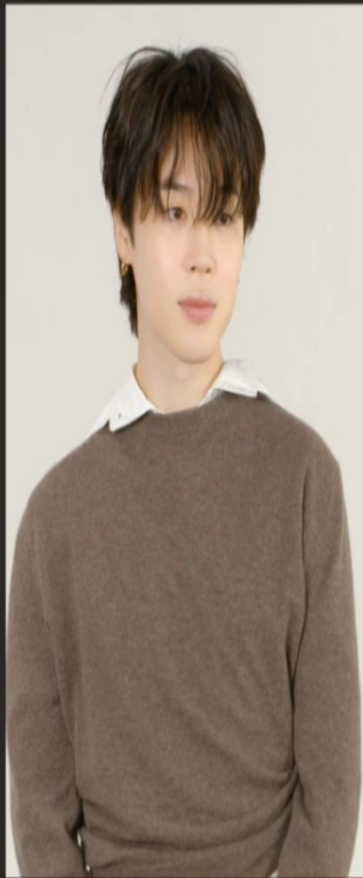
Summary

Park Jimin is a new student at the most elite culinary academy in France. He is naive, passionate, and completely out of his depth.

Chef Jeon is a cold prodigy known for both his brilliant skill and his extreme cruelty. He demands absolute perfection from his students and breaks anyone who can't handle the pressure.

Because of his raw naivety, Jimin instantly becomes Jungkook's favorite target, however, beneath the naivety lies a stubborn streak Jungkook didn't account for.

Chapter 1





The heavy wheels of Jimin's overpacked suitcase scraped against the uneven cobblestones of the courtyard, the sound echoing off the towering limestone walls of the academy.

This was the L'Académie Culinaire de Haute Volt , nestled just on the historic outskirts of Paris. It was a world-renowned institution, a place where the air itself smelled faintly of rich butter, spun sugar, and old money. To get accepted into the prestigious one-year program was statistically harder than getting into Ivy League law schools; thousands of applicants from across the globe were rejected every single summer, their culinary dreams cut short by a discouraging, cream-colored letter.

Jimin still couldn't entirely believe he was here. He certainly didn't have the elite pedigree or the wealthy background of the other students he had passed in the courtyard.

What he did have was a fierce, unwavering passion for food, and a savior back home named Mr. Frank. For the last four years, Jimin had worked at a modest, bustling neighborhood diner, scrubbing prep tables until his fingers were raw and learning how to flip eggs with a soft, quiet focus. As it turned out, Mr. Frank the owner was a secret alumnus of Haute Volt from thirty years ago. When he saw Jimin staring longingly at the academy's website late one night, he had gladly sat down and penned a glowing, tear-stained letter of recommendation. That letter, combined with Jimin's raw talent, had been his golden ticket.

Before even heading toward the residential wing, Jimin stopped dead in the center of the courtyard. He spun around in a slow, dazed circle, his eyes wide as he tried to take in everything at once.

Coming from a tiny, sleepy town where nothing ever changed, France felt like an entirely different planet.

He tilted his head back, staring up at the pale, sprawling European sky that looked so much grander than the one back home. The air here smelled entirely different, too. It was crisp and heavy with the scent of blooming lavender mixed with the rich, savory aromas drifting from the grand kitchen vents.

His eyes darted to the ornate brass plaques and beautifully carved signs mounted on the brick walls. They were covered in elegant, looping French words like Boucherie , Garde-Manger , and Pâtisserie . Jimin traced the cursive letters with his eyes, a sudden knot of anxiety tightening in his chest. He couldn't read a single syllable of it. He swallowed hard, realizing with a wave of intimidation that his complete lack of the language was definitely going to be a massive problem later.

Trying to shake off the nerves, Jimin took a deep breath, clutching the strap of his duffel bag tightly as he finally navigated the maze of hallways and pushed open the heavy oak door to his assigned dorm room.

The academy dorms were beautiful but strictly traditional repurposed from an old French estate. The room was small and cozy, with exposed dark wood beams across the ceiling, two narrow twin beds with crisp white linens, and a large, arched window that looked out over the perfectly manicured herb gardens below.

One half of the room was already impeccably organized with expensive leather luggage and sleek, high-end grooming products. Hanging perfectly on the antique wall was a vintage, high-end art exhibition poster. Whoever his roommate was, they clearly came from an incredibly wealthy family and possessed an effortless, pristine sense of style.

Ignoring his heavy luggage for a moment, Jimin walked straight over to the large, arched window and pressed his hands against the cool glass, looking out. Down below, the cobblestone courtyard was bustling, the senior students and master chefs littering the area like tiny ants from this height.

A quiet, uncontrollable giggle escaped Jimin's lips. He felt completely dazed, a wave of satisfaction washing over him. The feeling of finally being here was completely unreal, and despite every single thing that had threatened to hold him back, he had made it. He was actually here.

Suddenly, the bathroom door clicked open.

A tall guy with sharp, striking features stepped out into the bedroom, a foaming toothbrush sticking out of his mouth. He was clad in pristine, expensive designer socks and tailored trousers. He looked at Jimin, offering a casual wave, and muttered through the toothpaste:

"Bonjour! Tu es mon colocataire?"

Jimin whipped around, completely startled by the sudden person and the elegant, fast words that meant absolutely nothing to his ears. He stood there awkwardly, his hands still gripping the straps of his heavy bags, looking like a deer in headlights.

Seeing the total confusion on Jimin's face, the guy pulled the toothbrush out of his mouth. He tried again, much slower this time, his French sounding deliberate and perfectly accented. *"Est-ce que... tu es mon colocataire?"*

Jimin swallowed hard, his face turning bright pink. "Um... sorry, I don't..."

The guy's eyes widened instantly. He grabbed a tissue from his pocket, quickly wiped his mouth, and stared at Jimin as his entire demeanor shifted into a look of pure shock.

"Wait," he blurted out, his English suddenly immaculate, carrying the distinct, smooth cadence of someone who had gone to expensive international schools. "You're American?"

Jimin fidgeted with the zipper of his jacket, the fabric suddenly feeling suffocatingly hot. "Uh... yes. Oui. I... I practiced that. On the plane. Um..."

Taehyung stood there for a beat, slowly cocking a perfectly groomed eyebrow. His gaze lingered on

Jimin's white-knuckled grip on his bags, a faint, amused twitch at the corner of his lips. Under the scrutiny, Jimin's face grew even warmer, a deep, stubborn blush creeping all the way to the tips of his ears. He looked down at his scuffed sneakers, mentally cursing the translation app he'd spent ten hours staring at during his flight over the Atlantic.

Fortunately, the guy seemed to move past it in his mind. He let out a soft huff of laughter, tossing his toothbrush onto his impeccably organized desk, and extended an elegant hand toward Jimin.

"Kim Taehyung," he said, his tone instantly shifting into something deeply warm and dripping with easy, privileged confidence. "First year. I'm in the advanced cuisine block."

Jimin let out a tiny, relieved breath, glad to have a language he actually understood. He reached out his own hand, stepping forward to shake it.

"Park Jimin," he murmured, his voice timid but clear. "First year as well, and... also advanced cuisine block."

Taehyung blinked, his hand still lingering in the air for a second after they let go. A slow, highly entertained smirk spread across his face.

"Huh," Taehyung mused, tilting his head back to inspect Jimin from a completely new angle. "An American in the advanced block? Don't tell me... you specialize in burgers and... what do you guys call them? French fries."

He let out a rich, booming laugh at his own joke, his deep voice bouncing off the high stone ceiling. Jimin stood frozen, a tight, nervous smile glued to his face as he frantically debated whether he should laugh along or just sink into the floorboards.

"I'm joking, I'm joking," Taehyung waved off, though his sharp eyes were still scanning Jimin's thrifted jacket and worn-out sneakers with intense curiosity. "But seriously, what are you? An heir? A legacy placement? Your parents must have donated a whole new wing to the campus to bypass the standard French fluency track for the advanced block."

Taehyung leaned casually against his desk, crossing his arms over his chest. "Let me guess. Is your dad a Michelin-star owner in New York? Or maybe your family owns one of those massive, elite vineyard estates in Napa Valley? My parents almost bought a house out there last summer; the terroir is decent."

Jimin's throat went completely dry. The satisfaction he had felt just moments ago at the window evaporated, replaced by a cold, heavy sinking feeling in his stomach.

"Something... like that," Jimin muttered quietly, offering a small, tight nod. He desperately hoped the guy would just busy himself with his own rambling and drop the subject before he had to admit that his grand "culinary legacy" was actually a greasy four-booth diner in the middle of nowhere.

Fortunately, Taehyung barely even heard him, already moving back into his own space with that dizzying, high-energy confidence. He gestured broadly toward the empty twin bed, encouraging Jimin to finally drop his heavy luggage.

"Go on, get comfortable," Taehyung said easily, turning back to the mirror to check his hair. "I left

you the left side of the sink, and everything over there is yours. Oh, and don't mind the extra wardrobe in the corner—I had to request a second closet. I had Timothée pack entirely too many clothes."

Jimin blinked, dragging his heavy suitcase over to the left side of the room. "Timothée?" he repeated softly, setting his duffel bag onto the crisp white linens of his bed.

"My family's butler back in Madrid," Taehyung replied casually, as if everyone had a personal driver who packed their designer clothes for moving day. "He insisted I needed at least six different wool coats for the Parisian winter. Honestly, it's so exhausting."

Jimin let out another awkward, breathless laugh, the sound catching slightly in his throat.

Suddenly, a wave of pure insecurity crashed over him. Looking at Taehyung's overflowing wardrobes and impeccably organized designer setup, Jimin felt fiercely, painfully underprepared. He looked down at his solitary suitcase and the single canvas duffel bag sitting on his mattress.

With trembling fingers, he unzipped the suitcase first. The metal teeth parted loudly in the quiet room. He began pulling out his modest belongings—a few pairs of faded jeans, some plain t-shirts, a thick knitted sweater his grandmother had made him, and exactly two pairs of shoes, including the worn-out sneakers he currently had on his feet.

As he neatly stacked the modest pile of clothes, Jimin could feel the other boy watching him. Taehyung's sharp, analytical eyes were fixed on the rapidly emptying suitcase, tracking every movement.

"Wow. Very minimalist," Taehyung said, a distinctly impressed smirk playing on his lips when Jimin finally turned around to face him. He didn't say it mockingly; to a guy who had probably never had to budget a day in his life, Jimin's lack of material items actually looked like a deliberate, sophisticated lifestyle choice. "Chic."

Jimin's face burned hot, but he managed a small, sheepish nod, quietly thanking the universe that Taehyung was entirely too rich to recognize the difference between high-fashion minimalism and just being broke.

Taehyung hummed in approval, finally turning away to grab a sleek, matte-black espresso pod from a box that cost more than Jimin's weekly grocery budget back home. He popped it into a compact, state-of-the-art machine sitting on his nightstand—because apparently, the academy's world-class dining hall wasn't exclusive enough for morning caffeine.

"You'll need that focus," Taehyung continued, the machine beginning to whirl and fill the small room with the rich, intoxicating aroma of dark roast. "The advanced block is small this year. Only about twenty of us. Most of the legacy kids choose the standard track because they just want the diploma to slap on their family's restaurant group. But the advanced track..." Taehyung paused, taking a delicate sip from a tiny porcelain cup. "That's where the Director plays."

Jimin blinked, a faint line forming between his brows. "Director? Like... the head instructor?"

Taehyung froze, his porcelain espresso cup stopping mere inches from his lips. He slowly lowered it, staring at Jimin with a look of pure disbelief. He deadpan stared for a solid five seconds.

“Don’t tell me you don’t know Director Jeon.”

Jimin looked around the room, suddenly fascinated by the wood grain on the floorboards, shifting his weight from one foot to the other. “Um...”

Taehyung took another slow, deliberate sip of his espresso, closed his eyes, and muttered something under his breath in rapid, sighing French. It sounded incredibly exasperated, and Jimin desperately wished he could remember the exact phonetics of the words so he could look up how badly he’d just been insulted later.

“Director Jeon,” Taehyung began, setting his cup down with a sharp clink and looking at Jimin like he was a rare, baffling specimen, “is one of the... no, the best culinary director in all of Paris. Probably the world right now.”

Taehyung leaned back against his desk, gesturing with his hands as he launched into an elite lecture. “He won his first Michelin star at twenty-four, took over Haute Volt’s curriculum at twenty-six, and revolutionized modern French gastronomy before he even turned twenty-seven. The guy has a palate that can detect a single grain of substandard salt in a five-gallon pot of consommé. He’s a god in the industry, Jimin. Restaurants queue up for years just to have him consult on a menu.”

Jimin felt the blood completely drain from his face. His old boss, Mr. Frank, had told him the academy was strict, but he had left out the part where the man running it was a hyper-famous, twenty-eight-year-old prodigy tyrant.

“And tomorrow morning,” Taehyung added, a dangerous, highly amused spark returning to his eyes, “that exact man is going to be standing at the pass, waiting to see if we’re worth his time. So, I highly suggest you do some research, American. You’re going to need it.”



Jimin managed to slip away to his own side of the room while Taehyung continued to ramble on and on, detailing his family’s various villas scattered around the French countryside and how they compared to their estate back in Seoul.

While Taehyung’s side of the room looked like a page out of a luxury interior design magazine, Jimin’s side was decorated lightly, filled with things that brought him a quiet, familiar comfort. He carefully smoothed a plush yellow blanket over his crisp white linens, placing his favorite stuffed Jellycat bunny right against the pillow.

He arranged a few small potted plants he had purchased at a street market on the windowsill and his desk, hoping the green leaves would make the foreign space feel alive. Next to them, he stacked a few well-worn culinary reference books, before finally hanging up a few posters he’d found on

sale at a thrift store back home—intricate sketches of botanical herbs and faded prints of old antique paintings. To finish it off, he rolled out a cute cream and yellow checkered rug right by the side of his bed.

Taehyung suddenly went quiet. He stood back, crossing his arms over his chest as his sharp eyes swept over Jimin's completed space. He let out a thoughtful hum.

"I'm hungry, let's go eat?" Taehyung announced, the shift in topic so abrupt it made Jimin blink. "I assume you haven't been graced yet with a tour of the grounds?"

Without even waiting for an answer, or turning around to check if Jimin was actually following him, Taehyung spun on his designer heel and opened the heavy dorm door.

Tour? Jimin thought, his mind racing. He hadn't even known a tour was an option; he had fully expected to spend the rest of the evening staring at his translation app in a panic.

"Thought so," Taehyung called out over his shoulder as he stepped into the hallway. "Consider this my first international rescue mission."

He let out another rich laugh at his own joke, his voice echoing down the corridor.

"Wait! Um—hold on!" Jimin stammered. He frantically dropped the empty duffel bag he was holding and scrambled toward the door, nearly tripping over the edge of his new yellow rug in his haste to catch up to his whirlwind of a roommate.

Taehyung walked with a terrifying speed that had Jimin's legs working double time just to keep up. He moved through the winding, sun-drenched stone corridors like he owned them, casually tossing a hand up to point at a magnificent arched entryway or a heavy iron door without ever breaking his stride.

"Over there is the main banquet hall, built in the eighteenth century. They only open it for the winter gala and graduation," Taehyung rattled off, his voice smooth. "Down that staircase is the fermentation cellar—completely off-limits to first years, but the vintage selection down there is worth a fortune. And that wing across the courtyard is where the advanced pastry labs are. Brand new temperers, imported marble counters. It's perfect."

Jimin's head was spinning. He trotted a half-step behind, his eyes darting frantically between the gorgeous architecture and his roommate's perfectly styled hair. He couldn't help but feel a growing wave of bewilderment.

"Um, Taehyung?" Jimin asked, slightly breathless as he dodged a senior student carrying a massive copper pot. "How do you know all this already? Aren't you a first year too?"

Taehyung stopped dead in his tracks, his expensive leather clogs snapping against the stone floor.

Jimin, who was looking at a stained-glass window up above, didn't notice until it was too late. He let out a small squeak, his sneakers squeaking loudly as he threw his hands out, barely arresting his forward momentum an inch before he crashed right into Taehyung's back.

Taehyung slowly turned around. He didn't look angry, but his cocky grin was completely gone,

replaced by an expression of disbelief. He looked at Jimin as if Jimin had just asked him if the earth was flat.

“Jimin,” Taehyung said, his voice dropping an octave into a tone that was deadpan and dripping with generational wealth. “Kim Taehyung. I am part of the Kim family reign. My father, my older brother, and my grandfather all went to school on this very same campus.”

He gestured to the sprawling, red-brick estate around them with a casual, lazy flick of his wrist, as if he were simply pointing out his own backyard. “I’ve been running down these hallways since I was seven years old while my dad attended alumni dinners. The head dean literally bought me my first Mercedes for my sixteenth birthday.”

The reality of the gap between them hit Jimin like a bucket of ice water. The sweet, cozy feeling of his little yellow blanket and stuffed bunny back in the dorm room suddenly felt miles away.

“Sorry...” Jimin murmured, his voice dropping into a timid, embarrassed whisper. He nervously tucked a strand of dark hair behind his ear, wishing the ancient French stones would just open up and swallow him whole. “Right. Of course.”

Taehyung let out a soft sigh, the hard edge of his aristocratic pride melting back into his usual easygoing demeanor. He shook his head, a wry, amused smile returning to his lips.

"Over there," he began, his tone lightening up as he spun back around and pointed his long fingers across the grand, cobblestone courtyard toward a massive, imposing structure. "That is where we will be, bright and early tomorrow morning."

Jimin followed the line of Taehyung's arm, his gaze landing on the building. He froze, almost completely stopping in his tracks.

The advanced culinary block looked entirely different from the residential halls. It was made of older, weathered red brick, framed by massive, wrought-iron windows that looked dark and cavernous from the outside. Thick, twisting ivy crawled up the sides like fingers, and the heavy double doors at the entrance looked thick enough to withstand a bomb.

It felt terrifying.

But as Jimin stared at it, the initial knot of fear in his stomach twisted into something else. Beneath the terror, a strange, electric spark of excitement and eagerness loomed there, too. That building held everything he had ever dreamed of. It was the gateway to a life he had fought so hard to reach.

"Come on," Taehyung called out, snapping Jimin out of his daze. He was already several paces ahead, completely unbothered by the dramatic atmosphere. "The dining hall is probably crowded already. On move-in day, the academy kitchen makes sure to serve the top tier foods to impress the families. If we don't hurry, the legacy kids will eat all the truffle tarts."

Jimin tore his eyes away from the ominous brick building, taking a quick, deep breath to steady his racing heart.



The moment they pushed through the grand, gilded doors of the dining hall, the scale of the room made Jimin feel instantly, entirely like an outsider.

The space was breathtakingly grand, with soaring vaulted ceilings, massive crystal chandeliers that cast a warm, glittering glow over everything, and walls lined with oil paintings of famous historical chefs. But it was the noise that hit him first. A deafening symphony of rapid-fire French bounced off the marble floors.

All Jimin could hear from every direction was a chaotic blur of “Bonjour!” and “Oui, merci,” mixed with an overwhelming torrent of elegant, rolling words he couldn't even begin to translate.

His eyes darted everywhere, filled with a deep, wide-eyed curiosity, but the visual overload was just as intense. The room was packed to the brim with students and their families. It was a sea of wealth and high society—distinguished fathers in custom suits and mothers draped in silk scarves.

What truly baffled Jimin, though, were the personal butlers weaving through the crowd. He watched, completely dumbfounded, as a sharply dressed butler politely but firmly tried to persuade a weeping, dramatic mother to step away from her son's table and finally head back out to the waiting car in the courtyard.

More than the sights and the sounds, the hall was filled with the most important element of all: a rich, intoxicating aroma of world-class food.

The air was heavy and thick with the scents of melting butter, fresh rosemary, roasting meats, and sweet, spun sugar from the dessert stations. It was a beautiful, sensory masterpiece that made Jimin's mouth water, pulling at his deep passion for food. But as he stood there awkwardly beside an unbothered Taehyung, clutching the hem of his jacket, the overwhelming atmosphere pressed in on him. He had never felt smaller in his life than he did right in that very room.

Taehyung didn't seem to notice Jimin's internal crisis at all. He scanned the crowded room with a practiced, casual gaze before his eyes lit up. With a sharp snap of his fingers, he steered Jimin toward a corner table where a small group of impeccably dressed students were laughing over plates of delicate pastries.

As they approached, the group turned, and a volley of rapid, enthusiastic French erupted between them. Taehyung slid into the conversation effortlessly, laughing as he gestured wildly with his hands. Jimin stood a half-step behind him, his shoulders hunched, trying his best to look polite while understanding absolutely nothing.

One of Taehyung's friends—a tall guy with sharp, aristocratic cheekbones and a pristine white silk shirt—shifted his eyes down to Jimin. He watched Jimin's silent, wide-eyed blinking for a moment before turning back to Taehyung.

"Est-ce qu'il est muet?" the guy asked, his tone dripping with a mixture of amusement and light judgment.

Taehyung snorted, taking a sip from a stray glass of sparkling water on the table. He leaned in and replied in smooth, deadpan French, "*Pire. Américain.*"

The group let out a collective, soft chuckle. Jimin's face burned hot. Even without a translation app, he could tell from the smirks and the way they looked at him that he was the punchline of whatever joke had just been made.

But then, the tall guy stepped aside from the huddle, breaking the exclusive circle to face Jimin fully. The judgment faded into a polite, charming smile as he extended a long, elegant hand.

"Alexandre Gavonci," he said, his English carrying a thick, velvety French accent.

Jesus, Jimin thought, his mind short-circuiting. That name sounds straight out of a luxury fashion magazine.

"Park Jimin!" Jimin practically yelled over the loud, roaring chaos of the dining hall, his small-town reflex taking over as he firmly gripped the guy's hand. "Nice to meet you!"

Alexandre's smile widened slightly at Jimin's loud, earnest introduction. He didn't seem bothered by the American volume at all. Instead, his eyes swept over Jimin's flushed cheeks before he gestured toward the massive, silver-domed buffet stations lining the back wall.

"Are you hungry, Jimin?" Alexandre asked, his voice smooth and incredibly polite. "Would you like me to go with you to the line? It can be a bit... combative on the first day."

Jimin's blush flared instantly, a hot wave rushing from his neck straight to the tips of his ears. Oh, oui, merci hottie! his brain screamed, but out loud he managed a slightly breathless, "Oh... yes, thank you!"

Internally, Jimin was already losing his mind. He knew for an absolute certainty that the second he got a private moment tonight, he would be calling his best friend Hobi back home. He was going to completely spill on how everyone in France looked like a literal supermodel, and how a gorgeous guy named Alexandre Gavonci was currently acting as his personal escort.

As Alexandre turned to lead the way, Taehyung suddenly reached out, grabbing Alexandre's arm. Taehyung leaned in, his dark eyes sparkling with mischief, and whispered something quick and low right into Alexandre's ear.

Jimin watched them, holding his breath. Alexandre listened, let out a rich laugh, and rolled his eyes, playfully swatting Taehyung's hand away. He turned back to Jimin with an amused glint in his gaze.

"Come this way," Alexandre said smoothly.

Jimin quickly stepped into line behind him, finding it infinitely easier to navigate the crowded room with Alexandre's tall, broad-shouldered frame carving a path through the sea of students, parents and frantic butlers.

"I must admit, I am surprised an American is here in the advanced block," Alexandre said casually

over his shoulder, grabbing a gleaming porcelain plate from the stack and handing it to Jimin. "Most Americans and foreigners go to the other culinary school in Paris. They usually love the city lights, the cafes, the tourists. Haute Volt is... isolated. It is very traditional, and very brutal."

"I wanted a challenge," Jimin lied a little bit, his voice timid as he accepted the plate. The truth was, he went wherever Mr. Franks letter could get him, but he wasn't about to admit that while standing in front of a guy who looked like he belonged on a billboard in Milan. "And I really wanted to learn traditional French gastronomy from the best."

Alexandre paused at the first station, which was overflowing with perfectly geometric terrines and delicate seafood aspics. He looked back at Jimin, a look of genuine respect softening his sharp features.

"A challenge," Alexandre murmured, testing the words. "Well, if it is a challenge you want, you chose the right place. Tomorrow morning with Director Jeon will be... an awakening. Have you met him yet?"

"No," Jimin said, nervously placing a tiny, beautifully garnished pastry on his plate, not even knowing what it was. "My roommate Taehyung was just telling me about him. He sounds terrifying."

Alexandre let out a soft, knowing chuckle, moving down the line toward the hot entrees where the rich scent of seared duck breast and black truffles made Jimin's stomach growl loudly. "Terrifying is a polite word for Jeon Jungkook. He does not care for titles, wealth, or legacy. In a way, it makes him the fairest man in the school. But it also makes him a monster in the kitchen. If your brunoise is even a millimeter off, he will throw the entire dish into the waste bin right in front of your face."

Jimin swallowed the lump in his throat, confidence taking another tiny hit. "A millimeter?"

"Exactly a millimeter," Alexandre confirmed, before offering Jimin a reassuring smile. "But do not worry too much tonight. Eat well. The academy always provides a feast before the slaughter."

And a feast Jimin did.

The food was extraordinary, exploding with flavors that were entirely beyond anything he had ever tasted back home.

He loaded his plate with things he couldn't even name, relying on Alexandre to translate the labels. He started with a Coq au Vin that practically melted the moment it touched his tongue, the chicken braised to a deep, velvety perfection in a rich Burgundy wine. Then came the Sole Meunière, a delicate white fish pan-fried in a pooling, golden brown butter sauce with a sharp squeeze of fresh lemon that made his chest ache with pure culinary appreciation.

But the true revelation was a tiny, intricate pastry tart filled with caramelized wild mushrooms and shaved black truffles. When the earthy, rich flavors hit his tongue, Jimin actually had to close his eyes, letting out a soft, subconscious whimper of pure bliss.

When he opened his eyes, Taehyung was shooting him a heavy sideways look.

Taehyung rested his chin in his palm, watching Jimin practically inhale a second helping of the

truffle tart. A look of genuine, unfiltered pity softened his sharp features.

"Poor American," Taehyung sighed, shaking his head with a slow, mournful click of his tongue. "He has never eaten real food in his life. What do they feed you over there, Jimin?"

Jimin chewed rapidly, his cheeks completely puffed out. He swallowed hard, blushing but entirely unbothered by the teasing because the food was just that good. "We have good food," Jimin defended weakly, though even to his own ears, a diner cheeseburger felt like blasphemy compared to the masterpiece currently on his tongue.

Alexandre just laughed, patting Jimin's shoulder as the rest of the table dissolved into easy chatter. For the next hour, Jimin mostly listened, trapped in his beautiful, overwhelming bubble. He watched the grand dining hall slowly clear out as the sun dipped below the horizon, casting long, dramatic shadows through the vaulted windows. The weeping mothers were finally escorted to their luxury cars, the frantic butlers disappeared, and a heavy, anticipatory quiet began to settle over the remaining students.

By the time Jimin and Taehyung unlocked the heavy oak door to their dorm room, the campus was pitched in a freezing, pre-dawn darkness.

The easygoing, wealthy confidence Taehyung had displayed in the dining hall seemed to shift slightly as the reality of tomorrow morning crept in. The room was cool, the scent of lavender and old wood wrapping around them as they began to prepare for bed.

Jimin quietly retreated to his side of the room. He felt a sudden, fierce wave of comfort as his eyes landed on his little stuffed Jellycat sitting faithfully on his pillow. In a room inside a massive French estate, surrounded by legacy heirs and billionaire kids, that tiny corner was his only hope.

Across the room, Taehyung was already moving with a practiced, pristine routine. He carefully hung his tailored trousers in his second closet, slipped into a pair of silk pajamas that looked incredibly expensive, and stood at his side of the sink, thoroughly brushing his teeth.

Jimin changed into a pair of oversized, faded sweatpants and a soft t-shirt. He crawled under his yellow blanket, pulling it up to his chin as he watched Taehyung finish his multi-step skincare routine in the mirror.

"Hey, Jimin," Taehyung called out casually, wiping his hands on a plush towel before turning off the bathroom light. He walked over to his own bed, his frame casting a long shadow across the cream-and-yellow rug Jimin had laid out.

Jimin blinked in the dim lamplight. "Yeah?"

Taehyung climbed into bed, pulling his crisp white linens up, his expression uncharacteristically serious. "Tomorrow morning... when we walk into that building. Don't let Director Jeon see you sweat. He looks for the weakest link in the chain on day one, and he breaks them just to set an example."

Jimin swallowed hard, his fingers tightening around the fabric of his yellow blanket. He looked over at his stuffed bunny, then back to Taehyung's dark silhouette.

Taehyung slide under his covers, the fabric rustling loudly in the quiet room. "I'm serious, Jimin," he said, his deep voice cutting through the darkness with a chilling weight. "My older brother told me that on his very first day, two people left the kitchen crying before the first hour was even up. They packed their bags and never came back."

Silence stretched over the room, thick and suffocating, punctuated only by the distant, ominous rustle of the wind against the arched window. Jimin stared blankly into the pitch black, his heart hammering against his ribs. The sheer reality of what he had gotten himself into was crashing down, suffocating the lingering taste of the truffle tarts.

Finally, he called out, his voice sounding incredibly small and fragile in the vast space.

"Taehyung?"

"What."

"Is it... is it bad that I can't speak French?"

A beat passed. Then another. Across the room, Taehyung hummed softly, a slow, deliberate sound as if he were genuinely calculating the exact percentage of Jimin's impending doom.

"I don't know," Taehyung finally murmured, his tone entirely blunt. "I don't know how pleased Director Jeon will be to play chef and translator."

Jimin laid back against his pillow, his eyes trained wide and unblinking on the dark wood beams of the ceiling. The heavy silence of the room closed in around him.

Just as the anxiety threatened to completely swallow him whole, Taehyung's voice drifted across the darkness again.

"You'll be fine," He said after a beat, his tone unexpectedly softening just a fraction.

Jimin didn't move, but he listened intently as his roommate shifted under the crisp sheets.

"Not even in French will everyone completely understand him," Taehyung continued, a strange, knowing gravity in his words. "In the kitchen, that man speaks a completely different language."

Jimin imagined what that meant. A language of fire, clanging steel, and absolute precision, but he didn't question it any further. He didn't think his racing mind could handle any more theories.

"Goodnight," he said finally, his voice small and barely carrying across the room.

Taehyung answered back with a quiet, rolling phrase in French—something that sounded like a blessing for sleep—and turned over, the heavy rustle of his blankets signaling the end of the conversation. Although, as Jimin stared into the shadows, he was absolutely sure Tae wasn't sleeping either. No one could sleep on a night like this, with the weight of tomorrow pressing down on their chests.

Before arrival, they had been given incredibly clear, strict instructions on what to wear for day one. Everything had to be perfect.

Jimin turned his head toward his desk, where the moonlight cast a faint glow over his clothes. A crisp, white button-up shirt, provided by the academy, sat folded neatly on the wood surface alongside a pair of stiff black slacks. Right next to them on the floor were his brand-new black non-slip kitchen shoes, their rubber soles smelling strongly of synthetic factory clean. And sitting right on top of the folded shirt was a small, pocket-sized black notebook with a fresh pen—ordered specifically to take notes on everything the dictator was about to throw at them.

And then, Jimin finally closes his eyes.



The alarm blared at a brutal volume early that morning.

Jimin sat straight up in his bed, the heavy linen sheets rustling in the pitch black. His eyes were wide, staring into the darkness as his heart hammered a frantic rhythm against his ribs. He hadn't slept much of a wink, his mind spinning in a torturous loop of perfect juliennes and angry French directors.

A second later, a long, drawn-out sigh echoed from across the room.

Taehyung shifted, throwing his legs over the side of his mattress. He didn't say anything, but the sound was enough to let it be known that he hadn't fared any better against the insomnia.

Without a word, they both stood up and began getting ready. There was no casual morning banter, no teasing about Americans or luxury villas. Instead, they were doing enough communicating just by the lack thereof—every stiff movement and heavy breath speaking volumes about the mutual dread tight in their chests.

Jimin stood at his side of the sink, aggressively brushing his teeth while using his free hand to push his messy brown hair completely back and away from his face, trying to look as clean and put-together as possible. In the reflection of the mirror, he watched Taehyung moving like a silent, hyper-focused shadow.

Taehyung meticulously ran a handheld steamer over his white academy shirt, making sure there wasn't a single microscopic crease in the fabric. Once satisfied, he began applying an enormous, borderline excessive amount of luxury lotion to his face and hands, the rich scent of amber and cedarwood quickly filling the small bathroom.

Taehyung finally broke the silence, his voice dropping into a low, raspy morning gravel that sounded incredibly heavy.

"We should leave early," Taehyung said as he capped his lotion. "We need to get good seats."

Jimin paused, his toothbrush still halfway to his mouth. "Seats? I thought we were going straight to

the stoves?"

"No," Taehyung murmured, pulling his freshly steamed white shirt over his broad shoulders and carefully aligning the buttons. "The syllabus says we start in the amphitheater classroom for the administrative lecture and safety overview. Then we move into the actual kitchen block for the practical assessment. If we're late, we'll be stuck in the front row right under his nose or crammed in the very back where we can't see the master demonstrations. So, let's hurry."

Jimin rushed to pull on his stiff white shirt, his fingers fumbling with the buttons in his haste, before pulling on the black slacks. He quickly slipped the small black notebook into his pocket along with the fresh pen.

Taehyung stood by the threshold, looking uncharacteristically patient as he held the heavy dorm door open for them.

Outside, the sun had barely risen, casting long, weak shadows across the cobblestones in the gray, pre-dawn fog. A few other first years treaded timidly across the campus, their heads down and their hands clutching their notepads like lifelines. Nobody was talking. The cheerful, elite atmosphere of last night's dinner had completely evaporated.

Jimin bit his lip nervously as the advanced culinary building finally came into view, its dark, ivy-covered brick looking more like a medieval prison than a school in the misty morning light.

Taehyung was walking significantly slower today, his usual effortless glide replaced by a heavy, deliberate pace. He was clearly trying to overcompensate for his own nervousness, pulling his brows tight together and forcing a fiercely determined, stern look onto his face to mask whatever anxiety was twisting in his stomach.

When they finally pushed through the heavy wooden doors into the amphitheater classroom, the atmosphere inside was heavy enough to suffocate.

The steep, semicircular rows of dark walnut desks were already filling up. Students sat in rigid silence under the dim glow of the brass lamps, staring down at the empty stage below. Taehyung led the way down the steps, his leather shoes clicking softly until he slid into a row near the middle tier. Jimin scrambled into the seat right next to him, immediately setting his hands flat on the desk to hide how much they were trembling.

Taehyung's eyes darted sideways, catching the frantic movement out of the corner of his eye. Without turning his head, he reached across the small gap between their desks, his fingers clamping tightly around Jimin's wrist in a solid grip.

"Stop," Taehyung breathed, his voice barely a microscopic vibration in the quiet air. "Stop fidgeting, or Jeon will target you first."

Jimin nodded rapidly, a jolt of pure adrenaline shooting down his spine at the warning. He instantly forced his hands to go completely still against the walnut desk, choosing instead to bite his lower lip so hard it turned white, trying to funnel all his nervous energy into the pain.

A few rows ahead, Alexandre turned his head just an inch. He didn't look completely terrified like the rest of the legacy kids; instead, he threw them a knowing, heavy glance over his shoulder, a

silent 'brace yourselves' passing between them before he turned back to face the stage.

With only twenty students scattered across the steep semicircle of seats, the amphitheater wasn't actually that full. There was plenty of empty space around them, but nonetheless, the room felt unbearably, suffocatingly warm. The stagnant air seemed to press down on Jimin's chest, making his stiff white collar feel like a tight band around his throat as the seconds ticked down to the final strike of 5:00 AM.

Five o'clock came, and with it, the sharp, echoing crack of the heavy double doors swinging open.

At first, Jimin didn't want to look. He wanted to shut his eyes tight and just keep imagining the version of Director Jeon he'd built up in his head over the last twelve hours. He'd pictured someone maybe a bit heavysset from a lifetime of tasting rich, butter-laden French sauces all day. Or, conversely, maybe a terrifyingly skinny, skeletal man with a sharp nose and sunken eyes, like Anton Ego from Ratatouille .

He definitely, absolutely, was not expecting the man who actually stepped across the threshold.

Director Jeon Jungkook was young.

Jimin already knew that much. But still, he had still expected someone who looked well beyond their years. He had anticipated a man aged by the brutal, exhausting stress of the culinary world, with deep lines etched into his face, heavy dark circles under his eyes, and a rigid, overworked posture.

Instead, Jeon Jungkook looked utterly flawless, possessed of an electric, terrifying vitality.

He didn't have the weathered look of a tired chef; he had the razor-sharp presence of someone in his absolute prime. He moved with a predatory, effortless confidence down the center aisle, the slow, deliberate clicks of his leather boots echoing off the walnut desks.

He was tall, with broad, powerful shoulders that filled out a sleek black chef's coat. A striking contrast to the traditional white everyone else wore. The coat was tailored to perfection, and he had the sleeves rolled up tightly to his forearms, exposing thick, intricate tattoos that crawled all the way up his skin and disappeared under the fabric.

His dark hair was styled sharply away from his face, revealing his sharp jawline and a faint, dangerous scar on his left cheek. But it was his eyes that made Jimin's breath hitch. They were dark, piercing, and completely devoid of warmth, scanning the row of twenty students like a wolf inspecting a new pack. He walked with slow, an effortless confidence that made the entire amphitheater feel even hotter than before.

He stopped right behind the massive, stainless-steel demonstration pass at the front of the stage. He didn't offer a polite welcome to Paris! He didn't even say his name.

Instead, he gripped the edge of the metal table, leaned forward slightly, and let his dark gaze freeze the room.

The moment he did, a torrent of sharp, rapid-fire French cut through the stagnant air of the amphitheater.

"*Debout*," he commanded, his voice low but carrying a terrifying weight that echoed off the high walls.

Instantly, the nineteen students slammed their notebooks shut and rose to their feet in perfect, synchronized military precision. Jimin, completely lost without a translation, froze for a split second in pure panic before realizing what was happening. He frantically scrambled to his feet, his chair scraping loudly against the floorboards—a horrific, screeching noise that broke the sacred silence of the room.

Because the universe evidently loomed with a personal hatred for him, Director Jeon's piercing, dark eyes snapped directly to the noise, landing promptly on Jimin.

Jungkook tilted his head slightly, his gaze tracking Jimin's flushed face with a terrifying stillness.

"*Quel est ton nom?*" he asked, the words dropping from his lips like heavy stones.

Jimin opened his mouth, his chest tightening as twenty pairs of eyes drifted toward him. He swallowed hard, then closed his mouth completely, his mind a total, blank static. He had no idea what the man had just said.

Director Jeon let out a short, sharp laugh, though the sound was entirely void of humor. He looked away for a fraction of a second, shaking his head. "*Ils deviennent plus stupides chaque année*," he muttered mostly to himself, a brutal insult that made a few of the kids in the front row stiffen.

Jungkook's eyes snapped back to Jimin, narrowing into slits as he repeated the question, his voice dropping into a dangerous, low cadence that was still entirely, ruthlessly in French.

"*J'ai demandé quel est ton nom. Réponds.*"

The words were sharp and absolute, but to Jimin, they were just a blur of beautiful, terrifying sounds. He didn't know what they meant. He didn't know if he was being asked for his name, his credentials, or his immediate resignation. The absolute panic made his ears ring, and out of the corner of his eye, he could see Taehyung staring straight ahead, his jaw locked tight, completely frozen.

Jimin took a deep, shaky breath, his fingers digging into the seams of his stiff black slacks as he forced himself to speak.

"Um... I'm sorry, sir... um, Director..." Jimin stammered, his small voice sounding incredibly fragile in the hot, suffocating room. "I... I don't speak French..."

The end of his sentence frayed into a quiet, pathetic whisper. The silence that followed was deafening, stretching out like a tight wire as Director Jeon just stood at the front of the stage, his dark eyes boring literal holes straight through Jimin from across the room.

For three agonizing seconds, Jungkook didn't move. He just stared at Jimin, his head tilted slightly, as if he were looking at a strange creature. Jimin was becoming more and more used to that look since the second he stepped off the plane.

Slowly, Jungkook leaned back, letting go of the stainless-steel pass. He crossed his arms over his chest, a smirk playing on his lips that didn't reach his cold, piercing eyes. When he spoke again, the language flipped to English. His English was nearly perfect, with only a slight, accent on a few words that made his voice sound incredibly smooth and dangerous.

"Ah," Jungkook murmured, his voice dripping with mockery. "Excuse my French. How could I be so rude?"

Jimin jumped at the blatant sarcasm, his heart doing a violent stutter in his chest.

"Well, let me say this in a way we both can understand," Jungkook continued. His tone immediately dipped, losing every shred of that mock politeness and turning into a low, terrifying growl. "What is your name?"

Jimin took a deep, shaky breath, his fingers digging into the seams of his stiff black slacks as he forced his voice to work.

"P-Park Jimin, sir," he stammered, his small voice sounding incredibly fragile in the hot, suffocating room.

Jungkook hummed, a slow, deep sound that vibrated through the silent classroom. He turned his gaze away from Jimin, looking out at the rest of the nineteen students who were still standing completely frozen.

"Jimin, everybody," Jungkook announced to the room, his dark eyes snapping back to pin Jimin to the floor. "Everybody, Jimin."

Jimin shrunk under the sudden, immense scrutiny. He felt every single eye in the room drilling into him, his face burning a furious, violent crimson.

"Let's see... who here is up for a pop quiz," Jungkook said, his tone casual but his eyes sharp as needles as he scanned the rigid rows of students. He paused, letting the collective spike of panic settle over the room before his gaze locked onto the middle tier. "Who here can speak English?"

Slowly, one by one, every single student in the room raised their hand. Even Taehyung's hand went up smoothly. Jimin swallowed hard, looking around. Of course they could. With their family lines, endless money, and years of elite private schooling, being multilingual was just an inevitable byproduct of their upbringing.

Jungkook hummed, a low vibration in his chest as he lazily scanned the sea of raised hands. He didn't look impressed. If anything, he looked bored.

"And..." Jungkook continued, his voice dropping an octave as a dangerous smirk tugged at the corner of his lips. "Let's see... who here can speak French."

The response was instant. Nineteen hands shot straight into the warm, heavy air of the amphitheater.

Jimin sat entirely frozen, his arms glued to his sides as his heart dropped straight into his stiff, non-slip shoes. He was the only one. The lone, glaring exception in a room full of prodigies. He didn't

raise his hand, and under Jungkook's mocking, icy glare, he had never felt more naked in his life.

"Due to an unfortunate burden," Jungkook murmured, his voice cutting through the heavy silence with smooth, cutting precision, "I will speak English."

He paused, letting the weight of his irritation settle over the room before his dark eyes locked onto Jimin. "An American who flies all the way over the Atlantic to attend the most prestigious, traditional culinary institution in the world... only to not even know the language."

Jungkook slowly looked out at all the students, a lazy, calculating glint in his dark eyes as he walked along the edge of the stage.

"When I visited the Americans, I learned a very common phrase of theirs," Jungkook said, his nearly perfect English dripping with a slow, toxic sweetness. "It went something like... oh, Jimin, maybe you can help me..."

Jimin's breath hitched as Jungkook's eyes locked onto him.

"If you don't have anything nice to say..." Jungkook paused, lifting a finger to tap his chin in mock contemplation, staring right at Jimin's frozen face. "...then don't say it at all.... But I think I'm gonna change that rule."

His hand dropped, and his expression flattened into something cold and absolute.

"In my kitchen, the rule will be: if you have something mean to say, say it in French."

He seamlessly shifted into sharp, rapid-fire French, his voice echoing off the high walls as he looked at the rest of the room. "*Comme en ce moment, je vais dire ce que nous pensons tous... de stupides Américains.*"

A few of the legacy students in the front tier let out a quiet, synchronized laugh, the sound ringing sharply against the walnut desks.

Jimin felt a sudden, fierce heat rush to his face, followed instantly by a humiliating sting behind his eyes. Even without a translation, the laughing faces and the heavy weight of the room made the insult painfully clear. Hot tears began brimming in his eyes, blurring his vision.

Right next to him, Jimin saw Taehyung's jaw clench so hard a muscle ticked fiercely in his cheek. His dark eyes quickly darted over to look at Jimin, a rare, genuine flash of concern breaking through his cold armor before he forced himself to look straight ahead again.

Jungkook rounded the demonstration stand again, his polished leather boots clicking rhythmically against the floorboards as he targeted the center aisle, his dark gaze locked onto Jimin's burning face.

Jungkook let the cruel, low laughter ripple through the amphitheater for just a second longer before his dark eyes snapped back to the crowd, instantly cutting the amusement out of the room.

"*Asseyez-vous,*" he commanded, the French word dropping like an iron shutter.

The nineteen legacy students instantly dropped back into their seats with synchronized, silent precision. Jimin, still reeling from the burning sting of the insult, sank back into his own chair a half-second too late, his heavy non-slip shoes scraping faintly against the floorboards. He blinked fiercely, forcing the hot tears to pool without spilling over his lashes, his knuckles white as he gripped the edge of his walnut desk.

Jungkook stepped to the very edge of the stage, leaning forward slightly as he gripped the rim of the stainless-steel pass. The playful mockery was entirely gone, replaced by a cold, predatory intensity that made the room feel even more suffocatingly hot.

"Look at the person to your left," Jungkook's voice cut through the silence, low, smooth, and dangerously calm—returning to that flawless, chilling English that felt like a blade pressed to Jimin's throat. "Look at the person to your right."

Jimin kept his eyes locked straight ahead, terrified that if he moved a muscle, a tear would escape and track down his cheek.

"By midterms, one of them will have packed their bags and begged for a tuition refund because they couldn't handle the heat," Jungkook continued, his dark, piercing gaze slowly sweeping across the semicircular rows, pausing with deliberate weight when it brushed past Jimin's coordinates. "I am not here to teach you how to hold a spoon. If you cannot handle staying up all night until your fingers bleed, and your work is still expected to be nearly perfect, leave my academy right now."

He paused, waiting. The silence stretched so thin it felt like glass about to shatter under the pressure.

No one moved.

No one even dared to change their breathing pattern.

Satisfied with the collective terror, Jungkook began pacing the front of the stage, his leather boots clicking rhythmically as he spoke. "Under your desks, you will find your knife kits, aprons, and chef's hats. You get only one set per semester. If you lose it, you pay for the loss, and you pay for the new kit. If you show up to my kitchen without either, you get a zero for your daily mark. Am I clear?"

The students nodded rapidly in unison, a chorus of silent, frantic agreement rippling through the rows.

Jungkook suddenly stopped his pacing, his boots coming to a sharp halt. He paused, his sharp gaze locking onto one boy in the front row in particular—a legacy kid whose posture had gone completely rigid under the sudden focus.

"In the kitchen, how do you address your director?" Jungkook asked quietly.

The kid looked around frantically, his face turning a deep, embarrassed red as twenty pairs of eyes pinned him to his seat. He swallowed hard, his voice cracking slightly. "Um... Director?"

Jungkook scoffed, a short, dark laugh bursting from his throat that was entirely empty of any real humor.

"Until the day you are no longer my student, you will address me in one of two ways," Jungkook said, his voice dropping into a dangerously low, gravelly register that seemed to vibrate the very wood of the desks. "Yes, Chef, and No, Chef. Am I clear?"

A few of the students nodded frantically, while others weakly mumbled a scattered, timid, "Yes, Chef..."

Jungkook stopped dead in his tracks. He slowly raised a single eyebrow, his piercing dark eyes sweeping across the rows with absolute, freezing disapproval at the pathetic, uncoordinated response. The silence that followed lasted only a heartbeat, but it felt like an eternity.

"Am I clear?" he demanded again, sharper this time, his tone cutting through the warm, heavy air like a whip.

"Yes, Chef!" everyone barked in unison, their voices instantly rising much louder, echoing sharply off the high walnut walls of the amphitheater as they finally found their collective spine.

"Open your notebooks," Jungkook commanded, his hands resting flat against the stainless-steel pass as he looked out over the rigid rows of students. "I will explain everything once. If you do not keep up, close it, and when you get back to your room, pack your bags and call your mommy's and daddy's."

The blunt, cutting remark hung heavily in the suffocating warmth of the room.

From his seat in the middle tier, Jimin squinted his eyes at the man on the stage. His body was still visibly shaking, a lingering tremor of pure humiliation and adrenaline vibrating through his limbs from the insults, but beneath the fear, was something else.

He gripped his fresh pen tightly over the blank page of his small black notebook. He felt small, he felt mocked, and he felt completely out of his mind for even being here—but he wasn't going to be the one packing his bags. He fixed his gaze stubbornly on the dark, tattooed director, more determined than ever to catch every single word that left the man's mouth.

Chapter 2



Jungkook turned to the massive slate chalkboard behind the pass. He picked up a piece of white chalk, the sharp clack of it hitting the slate echoing like a gunshot through the silent amphitheater.

"Open your notebooks," he repeated, not bothering to look back at them as he began to write in a fluid, elegant, yet aggressively sharp script.

"To be a culinary chef at this academy does not mean you love food," Jungkook said, his voice carrying effortlessly without the microphone. "Passion is cheap. Passion is what housewives use when they bake Sunday dinners. Here, you are culinary athletes. You are machines of precision."

He spun around, the chalk gripped tightly between his fingers.

"Rule number one: *Mise en place*," he barked, spelling it out on the board in bold letters: *MISE EN PLACE*. "For those who don't know it means 'everything in its place.' In my kitchen, it means absolute mental and physical organization. If a single grain of pepper is out of alignment at your station, your mise is broken. If your mind is scattered, your mise is broken. If your uniform is wrinkled, you have failed before you have even turned on your burner."

He began to pace the front of the stage again, his dark eyes locking onto the students who were frantically scribbling down every syllable. Jimin's pen flew across his paper, his hand cramping, but he refused to look away from the board.

"Your grading matrix is binary," Jungkook continued coldly. "You do not get partial credit for trying hard. Every daily mark is out of one hundred. If you make a mistake on a technique, you lose fifty points. If you are late, you get a zero. If you fail a practical evaluation, you fail the semester. There is no curving. There is no extra credit."

Jungkook stopped dead center, his posture imposing and dominant. A dark, dangerous smile tugged at the corner of his lips, though his eyes remained entirely freezing.

"However, for the one who survives, there is a prize," Jungkook murmured, his voice dropping into a low, tantalizing register. "At the end of the year, the single student who displays exceptional, flawless skill will be chosen. You will design and execute the main course at the annual Grand Gala. You will cook for the Dean, the President of this institution, myself, and a panel of world-renowned Michelin-starred chefs. It is an automatic ticket to any kitchen on the planet."

The atmosphere in the room shifted instantly. Jimin could feel the sudden, fierce spike of greed and ambition radiating from the legacy students in the front rows. They weren't just terrified anymore; they were hungry.

Jungkook saw the shift, and his smile turned razor-sharp.

"So let me make this entirely clear to you," Jungkook warned, his voice cutting through their sudden daydreams like a blade. "This is not a place to make friends. This is not a place to team up, or share notes, or offer comfort. This is a chopping block. If you are not the absolute best, then this is not the place for you."

His eyes slowly swept up the tiers, passing over the wealthy legacy kids before stopping dead on Jimin. Jungkook's gaze lingered, heavy and mocking, and almost silently daring.

Jungkook stepped away from the pass, his sharp eyes pinning the entire room to their seats as he transitioned to the core of his philosophy.

"Now, let us speak about perfection," Jungkook said, his voice dropping into smooth rhythm. "I do not tolerate mediocrity. I expect every single cut of a bell pepper to be perfectly uniform, down to the millimeter. I expect every single grain of salt to be precisely measured and purposeful. This kitchen does not accept 'half-assed.' It does not accept 'I did my best.' Your best is completely irrelevant to me if it is not flawless."

He paused, his gaze dropping to the heavy stainless-steel prep table beside him, his fingers tracing the cold edge.

"If you bring a dish to my pass that is anything less than perfect," Jungkook murmured, before his eyes snapped up, flashing with a sudden, volatile heat. He didn't raise his voice, but the venom in his tone made the entire room flinch. "Je vais prendre ton assiette, et puis... je vais la jeter dans cette putain de poubelle."

The French words cut through the heavy air like a guillotine.

Jimin sat frozen, his heart hammering against his ribs. He didn't need a translator to understand the universal threat behind the delivery. From his seat, he subtly cut his eyes to the left and right, looking around the amphitheater.

The silence was deafening. A few of the wealthy legacy students in the front row suddenly looked incredibly uncomfortable, shifting in their seats, while a couple of others quietly cleared their throats to break the suffocating tension. Jungkook just stood there, completely unmoved by their discomfort, waiting for the weight of his promise to sink in.

"Am I clear?" Jungkook asked, his voice a low, steady rumble that demanded submission.

This time, the answer was instantaneous. Every single person in the room—including Jimin, whose voice mixed into the chorus with a desperate, shaky determination—barked out in unison: "Yes, Chef!"

Jungkook's lips pulled back into a dark, satisfied smile. He paced slowly toward the center of the stage, his hands clasping behind his back.

"Now... I am no mediocre instructor," Jungkook said, his tone shifting into something almost conversational, though the underlying threat never left his eyes. "I do offer help. But I only offer it if I see that you are willing to take that help and actually apply it. What I do not do is tears, or complaining, or lying. Any of those three will instantly earn you half a mark off your total grade."

Jimin blinked hard, a quiet wave of relief washing over him. He swallowed heavily, incredibly grateful that the tears that had been threatening to spill earlier had finally evaporated under the sheer heat of his own adrenaline. He kept his chin up, forcing his face to remain a blank, stoic mask.

"Now... enough of that," Jungkook said, dismissing the entire syllabus with a sharp wave of his hand. "We will begin introductions. This will help me better remember who will actually be in my kitchen, and who will run home scared before tomorrow morning."

He leaned back against the edge of the heavy presentation table, crossing his arms over his chest. His dark eyes flicked upward, slowly scanning the terraced rows of terrified students.

"Who would like to go first?"

Almost immediately, a kid in the very front row shot his hand up into the air.

Jimin quietly let out a long, shaky breath, his shoulders dropping a fraction of an inch. He was profoundly thankful that Jungkook hadn't just singled him out again and told him to continue his disastrous introduction from earlier.

Jungkook tilted his head, giving a slight, silent motion with his chin for the boy to stand.

The kid rose from his seat with a practiced, haughty confidence that practically screamed wealth. He smoothed down the front of his pristine, custom-tailored white chef's jacket, a few strands of perfectly styled blond hair falling effortlessly into his face.

"Hello, Chef," he began, his voice dripping with an elite, thick accent that carried easily across the stage. "I am Eric Boucher. I am from southern Italy."

Jungkook's expression didn't change. He kept his arms crossed, his dark eyes tracking Eric with a cold, unreadable intensity that would have made anyone else break a sweat.

"Boucher," Jungkook repeated, the French name rolling off his tongue with absolute precision. "A French surname, but you're from southern Italy. Your family runs the luxury resort chain in Positano, correct?"

Eric's chest puffed out a bit more, a smug, satisfied smile pulling at his lips. He clearly thought he was already in the director's good graces. "Yes, Chef. My father is the executive director, and my grandfather was—"

"I don't care about your family," Jungkook cut him off, his voice entirely flat. The brutal interruption made Eric's smile vanish instantly, his posture stiffening. "Your status does not give you a head start on my line, Boucher. Sit down."

Eric swallowed hard, his face flushing a bright, embarrassed red as he hurriedly sank back into his seat, his previous haughty confidence completely shattered in a matter of seconds.

Jimin watched the exchange from the middle tier, his fingers tight around his pen. A cold sweat broke out down his spine. If Jungkook was willing to publicly humiliate a wealthy legacy student

whose family practically owned European luxury dining, Jimin didn't even want to think about what the man would do to someone like him.

Jungkook's gaze didn't linger on Eric for even a second. His eyes swept back out over the rows, his sharp, predatory smile returning.

"Next," Jungkook commanded.

A few more people went, including Taehyung, who stood up with an easy, relaxed posture that seemed completely unfazed by the tension in the room. When Taehyung introduced himself, Jungkook's eyes narrowed slightly, a glimmer of recognition passing through them.

"Kim," Jungkook noted, his voice flat. "Your older brother was a fair student in my advanced masterclass last winter. I hope you are even better. Don't embarrass your name."

Taehyung just offered a respectful bow and a calm, "I won't, Chef," before sitting back down.

The moment Taehyung's thighs hit the bench, Jungkook's predatory gaze shifted. He peered straight up into the middle tier, locking onto Jimin.

Jimin looked away immediately, dropping his eyes to his notebook. Shit, he thought, his chest tightening as his breath caught in his throat. Shit, shit, shit.

"American," Jungkook said. The word rolled off his tongue slowly, drawing out slightly around his sharp accent, heavy with a mocking sort of amusement. "You were so eager to speak earlier. What happened? Please stand. We only have a few more students left."

Jimin exhaled a shaky breath and forced his legs to push him up. Standing on his feet, he instantly felt that same suffocating heat from earlier rushing straight to his face. Every eye in the amphitheater was on him.

"Hello, Chef," Jimin began, his voice a little softer than he intended. He cleared his throat, trying to find his footing. "I'm Park Jimin, and I'm from Saugerties..."

Jungkook lifted a single, dark brow, his arms still crossed over his chest. "Where is that?"

Jimin's face flushed a deep, burning crimson. He nervously shifted his weight from one foot to the other. "Oh... um. It's a small town... in upstate New York..."

He trailed off as the room grew entirely quiet. The prestigious, wealthy legacy students around him didn't even try to hide their judgmental glances, whispering or raising an eyebrow at the mention of a random American town they had obviously never heard of.

Jungkook tilted his head, his dark eyes narrowing into an icy, critical stare as he let the silence stretch for a long, agonizing moment.

"A small town," Jungkook repeated, his voice dangerously smooth. "And how exactly does a boy from a small American town hear about the most prestigious, traditional culinary academy in Paris?"

Jimin swallowed hard, his fingers twisting the fabric of his uniform trousers behind his back. The absolute lack of pretense in the room was terrifying. He looked down at his desk, then back up at Jungkook's impassive face, his words suddenly stumbling out over each other.

"Well... the funny thing is," Jimin began, his voice pitching slightly higher with nerves. "I worked at a diner... since high school, it's—yeah. And my boss, he... well, he actually went here a really long time ago. And he always told me I had a gift for flavors, so... yeah. He helped me apply, and well, he wrote me a letter of recommendation. I guess he just has the gift of gab, because here I am."

Jimin offered a small, weak smile, desperately hoping a little lighthearted humor might break the ice.

Except no one laughed at his joke.

The word diner instead was hanging in the air like a foul odor.

The silence that followed was suffocating. In the front row, Eric Boucher let out a quiet, mocking snicker that was quickly mirrored by a few other legacy students.

A diner?

The boy from New York had trained on greasy flat-tops flipping burgers, while they had been learning classical French mother sauces in private estates.

Jungkook didn't laugh. His expression actually grew colder, his eyes raking over Jimin from head to toe, dissecting him right there on the tier.

"A diner," Jungkook said, the word sounding heavy and completely foreign on his tongue. He stepped closer to the edge of the stage, leaning forward slightly. "You flipped pancakes and served burnt coffee, and you think that qualifies you to stand in my kitchen?"

Jungkook didn't blink. He just kept his dark, freezing gaze locked on Jimin, his head tilted slightly to the side as if he were studying a bizarre glitch in his otherwise perfect classroom.

"The gift of gab," Jungkook repeated slowly, his accent making the American phrase sound incredibly foolish. "So, you are not here because of your flawless skills, or your understanding of gastronomy, or your family's culinary legacy. You are here because an old man in a greasy apron wrote a nice letter."

Jimin opened his mouth, but a sudden, familiar tight knot formed in his throat. He was entirely sure that if he tried to say anything else, he was going to start crying right there in front of everyone. He blinked rapidly, staring down at his hands.

He had never been so bad at first impressions in his life.

"I... um... no si—Chef..." Jimin stammered, scrambling to correct himself. "I'm very determined to become a chef. I—"

Jungkook rolled his eyes, his posture shifting as he grew instantly bored of the words. "Next," he

called out, completely cutting Jimin off.

Jimin blinked, the rejection stinging worse than the heat in the room. He slowly lowered himself back down onto the wooden bench, his knees feeling a little like jelly. Even with his eyes glued to his desk, he could still feel the heavy, critical stares of the other students burning into the side of his face.

A sudden wave of intense homesickness hit him so hard it made his chest ache. Right now, he wanted nothing more than to be back home in New York with his mom and dad, safely tucked away on the couch, watching Family Feud over a big bowl of ice cream. It was a million miles away from this cold, terrifying room.

He looked down at his lap, tilting his head forward as he tried to hide a single, rogue tear that had managed to escape and track down his cheek. He took a deep, quiet breath, forcing the air into his lungs to get himself together before he finally wiped his face and looked back up.

Another student was already speaking, their voice droning on about some prestigious background, but the moment Jimin raised his head, he froze.

Jungkook was already watching him. The director's dark, freezing gaze lingered on Jimin's face for a heavy, unreadable beat—noting the flushed cheeks, the fierce look of determination trying to mask the hurt—before he casually looked away to address the rest of the class.

"Tomorrow, you all will arrive here at 6:00 AM sharp," Jungkook commanded, his voice cutting through the room one last time. "You will come dressed in the same clothing you have on now so... wash accordingly. You will wear your hat and your apron. You will bring your knife kit and your notepads. You will wear no jewelry, or anything of the sort. Your hair will be tied back or pushed completely out of your face, and your shoes will be closed-toed and non-slip. Am I clear?"

"Yes, Chef!" the room chorused back.

"Dismissed."

Jimin felt insanely hot as he stood to his feet, a wave of dizzying residual heat washing over him. His fingers were stiff as he grabbed his pen and shoved his notepad into his bag. He slung the strap over his shoulder, his heart still thumping against his ribs as he began walking down the steep wooden steps toward the main exit doors at the bottom of the amphitheater.

Predictably, the try-hard legacy students all scrambled to crowd around Jungkook on their way out. They swarmed the front pass like a flock of eager seagulls, bowing, throwing out desperate pleasantries, and practically tripping over each other.

"Thank you, Chef!"

"It is an honor, Chef!"

"I can't wait to learn from you, Chef!"

From the middle of the stairs, Jimin scoffed in his head.

One thing about being from New York—he didn't take shit lightly. Sure, he might cry, and yeah, maybe he secretly wished he could spontaneously combust and disappear from the face of the earth, but he wasn't a pushover. He wasn't about to kiss the ass of a guy who had just spent the last hour publicly gutting him for coming from a diner.

So, instead of walking down the main steps and passing right by the chef's little fan club, Jimin veered off to the side. He marched straight toward the auditorium's heavy side exit, raised his hand, and firmly pushed the door open, letting it swing shut behind him with a heavy, satisfying thud.



The moment Jimin unlocked the door to his dorm, the dam in him completely broke. He threw his bag onto the floor, kicked off his shoes, and practically dove face-first onto his mattress, burying his face deep into his pillow.

For the next hour, Jimin was a complete wreck.

First came the muffled, angry crying—the kind that soaked the pillowcase as he let out all the humiliation he'd been forcing down in the amphitheater. He curled into a tight ball, his body shaking as he replayed every single agonizing second of his introduction. Jungkook's words echoed in his head like an obnoxious, repeating track.

Then came the screaming stage. Jimin would abruptly sit up, grab his pillow, press it tightly over his mouth, and screech at the top of his lungs until his throat felt raw. He punched the mattress twice, wishing the memory would just format itself out of his brain.

By minute forty-five, the tears had dried up, leaving behind a hot, vengeful spike of pure pettiness. Jimin sat cross-legged on his bed, his eyes narrowed as he stared blankly at his wall. He began contemplating how hard it would be to find a printer in Paris, print out a high-resolution photo of Chef Jeon's stupidly perfect, smug face, and tape it to a cork dartboard. He'd aim right between those sharp, needle-like eyes. Every day. Before 6:00 AM.

Just as he was visualizing the exact trajectory of a dart hitting Jungkook's nose, his phone buzzed violently on the nightstand. The screen lit up with a FaceTime call from.....

Hobi:))<3

Jimin lunged for the phone, swiping accept and propping it up against his lamp.

"Oui oui my—oh my god, what happened?!" Hoseok's bright, energetic face instantly filled the screen, shifting from a wide smile to utter shock when he saw Jimin's blotchy, swollen face and messy hair. "Did someone die? Did you lose your passport? Tell me you didn't get deported on day one."

"Worse," Jimin groaned, collapsing back onto his back and staring at the ceiling so the camera just

captured his chin. "Hobi, I met Satan today and he wears a black chef's jacket, and he is twenty-eight years old."

Hoseok blinked on screen, letting out a confused, high-pitched laugh. "Wait, what? Who?"

"Chef Jeon," Jimin ranted, his voice cracking as he waved his hands wildly in the air. "The director! Hobi, he literally singled me out in front of the entire lecture hall. He made fun of Saugerties! He made fun of the diner! He told me—get this—he basically told me I got into the school on a fluke."

"He said what?" Hoseok's snapped, his face contorting into a scowl. "Who does this guy think he is? A fluke? Jimin, you worked your ass off at that diner for years! You can cook better than anyone I know!"

"He doesn't care!" Jimin whined, rolling over on his side to look at the screen, his bottom lip trembling just a little. "He said if our plates aren't perfect, he's going to throw them in the putain de poubelle. That means the fucking garbage, Hobi! In French! He's insane!"

Hoseok sighed softly, his expression softening with sympathy. "Oh, Jiminie... I'm so sorry. Are you gonna be okay? Do I need to book a flight to beat his ass and save yours?"

Jimin went quiet for a second. He looked around his tiny room, his eyes landing on his pristine, white academy apron resting on the chair. The anger from earlier flared up again, heavy and stubborn.

"I'm going to be fine," Jimin muttered, his jaw tightening. "Because I'm not giving him the satisfaction of seeing me upset. If he wants to throw my food in the garbage, he's gonna have to walk his happy ass over to the trash can every single day, because I am showing up tomorrow at 6:00 AM sharp."

On the screen, Hoseok's expression softened into deep understanding. He shook his head. "You know what? Don't hold it in. Seriously, Jiminie, let it out. Right now. Just scream. Let all that toxic energy out of your system."

Jimin blinked, wiping his eyes. "Right now? I mean I already—"

"Yes! Right now! Do it with me. On three. One... two... three—"

Jimin threw his head back, squeezed his eyes shut, and let out a loud, lung-bursting, completely unhinged scream straight at his ceiling. It was a pure release of a day's worth of humiliation and anger. On the other end of the line, true to his word, Hoseok was matching him decibel for decibel, screeching into his microphone like a madman.

The two of them were completely lost in their therapeutic screaming match when suddenly, a loud click echoed through the room.

The front door swung wide open.

Jimin's voice cut off with a sharp gasp, his throat clicking shut mid-shout. Over the phone, Hoseok was still yelling for another full second before he realized the audio had gone entirely quiet on Jimin's end.

Taehyung stood frozen in the doorway. He was holding a plastic bag from a local bakery, his face completely contorting into a mask of confusion and horror. He looked at Jimin, who was sitting cross-legged on the bed with a tear-streaked face, and then glanced at the phone screen where Hoseok was awkwardly clearing his throat.

"... what the hell?" Taehyung said, his voice a mix of bewilderment and concern as he slowly lowered the bakery bag.

Jimin's face went from a blotchy, tear-streaked pink to a violent, burning crimson in a matter of two seconds.

"Oh, sorry... Hobi, I'll call you back," Jimin sputtered frantically, lunging across the mattress toward his phone.

Hoseok's voice crackled through the speaker, trying to say something like, "Wait, who is that—?" but Jimin didn't even let him finish. He hit the red button, entirely intending to send a massive apology text later for cutting him off so brutally, and awkwardly tossed the phone across the bed sheet.

Taehyung just shook his head, a faint, amused smile breaking through his initial confusion. He stepped fully into the small room, shutting the door behind him with his heel, and began rounding the desk. He slipped off his shoes with practiced ease, placing them neatly by the entryway before walking over with the bakery bag.

"Chef sure did have a field day with you," Taehyung said. His tone wasn't mocking or teasing; he stated it plainly, more like a brutal fact they both just had to accept.

Jimin winced, the reminder of the lecture hall making his stomach do a slight flip.

"You held your own though," Taehyung shrugged, tossing the plastic bag of pastries onto the desk. He walked over to the edge of the bed and dropped down, leaning back on his hands. "Just don't break. That's all that matters in his kitchen."

Jimin cleared his throat, his eyes dropping down to his lap as he nervously picked at a loose thread on his bedspread, trying to swallow down the residual embarrassment of being caught screaming at his ceiling.

"Why didn't you tell me you're not rich or whatever?" Taehyung asked, completely unbothered as he bit into a fresh, flaky croissant, sending a small shower of crumbs onto his lap.

Jimin shrugged, keeping his eyes on his fingers as he continued to pick at the thread on his blanket. "Dunno... just thought... it was like a requirement here to be filthy rich."

Taehyung snorted, shaking his head. "No. Well... yes, in some cases. But being the relatable and down-to-earth person, I am, I don't care about stuff like that. Last summer, I actually went to Bolivia to help the needy. Trust me, Jimin, I understand."

Jimin's eyebrows instantly knitted together. He frowned, staring at Taehyung in absolute confusion. He racked his brain, trying to figure out at what point during his rambling speech about flipping

pancakes he had accidentally implied he was needy , rather than just a perfectly standard, middle-class guy.

"I'm not...", Jimin began slowly, tilting his head. He let out a quiet sigh, realizing it was a losing battle against Taehyung's unique worldview. "Thanks,"

Taehyung hummed, swallowing his bite and pointing the tip of his pastry toward the plastic bakery bag on the desk. "Do you want one?"

Jimin instantly shook his head, his stomach giving a slight, defensive roll. He couldn't look at another croissant right now, let alone eat one, after completely stuffing himself full of them the previous night in a bout of homesick, jet-lagged stress eating. "No, I'm good."

"Suit yourself," Taehyung said, popping the last bite into his mouth and dusting the remaining crumbs off his hands. He looked around the tiny, sterile room, his eyes lingering on the bare walls before snapping back to Jimin. "Well... this is Sceaux , let's go out. What do you do for fun?"

Jimin bit his lip, his mind going completely blank. What did he do for fun? Back in Saugerties, fun meant driving around with Hobi, getting late-night milkshakes at McDonalds, or just hanging out on the porch.

Paris felt like a different planet.

Taehyung let out a dramatic, long-suffering sigh, throwing his hands up in the air. "Never mind... put on some shoes and come with me."

Jimin hesitated for a fraction of a second before nodding. He turned away under the guise of grabbing his things, discreetly wiping the last traces of moisture from his eyes. He was completely certain Taehyung had already seen him crying anyway, but his pride insisted on the gesture.

He reached into his small closet, slipping into his favorite gray zip-up jacket, and slid his feet into his trusty, heavily beat-up white sneakers. They were worn at the heels and stained from months of rushing around the diner back home, but they were comfortable. He turned back around to face Taehyung, pulling his jacket zipper up to his chest.

"Jimin," Taehyung began, his eyes slowly dropping to scan his new friend from head to toe. He paused, his expression turning into something akin to gentle pity. "With my last claim about helping the needy... I also do a lot of clothing charity donations. So please... feel free to ask me any day for some... clothing."

Jimin's eyebrows slammed together. He frowned deeply, dropping his chin to look down at his outfit. "What's wrong with how I'm dressed?"

Taehyung loudly cleared his throat, his eyes darting to the ceiling for a split second before snapping back with a smooth, completely unconvincing look. "Nothing! Like I said before... it's chic."

He gave Jimin one last, highly wavering smile that completely betrayed his words, before turning on his heel and throwing the apartment door open to lead the way.

The mid-afternoon air was crisp as they walked through the sprawling, cobblestone campus of the

academy. Massive, centuries-old stone buildings draped in ivy towered over them, making the whole place feel more like a royal estate than a school.

As they reached the outskirts of the grounds, the grand architecture smoothly transitioned into a charming Parisian neighborhood. A row of narrow, colorful storefronts, boutique flower shops, and cozy outdoor coffee shops appeared, their wicker chairs spilling out onto the pavement.

Jimin couldn't help himself. He kept falling a few steps behind, holding his phone up to snap candid, beautifully framed photos of the vintage green shop awnings, the morning fog lifting over the slate roofs, and the warm glow of the café windows. It was exactly the kind of aesthetic he'd definitely be posting to his feed later to prove to everyone back home—and himself—that he was actually in Paris.

"Jimin, did you hear me?" Taehyung asked suddenly.

He had slowed his pace, his hands shoved effortlessly into the pockets of his expensive trousers as he strolled down the pavement like a high-fashion model.

"Um, no, sorry..." Jimin muttered, quickly shoving his phone into his jacket pocket and jogging a couple of steps to catch up.

"I asked how old you are," Taehyung said, looking over at him.

"Oh! I'm twenty-three!" Jimin said with a bright smile, happy to talk about something normal. "What about you?"

Taehyung hummed, his stride faltering for a microsecond as a look of genuine confusion crossed his face. He stared at Jimin, blinking. "No way I'm younger than you," he said, almost to himself, as if trying to compute the information. "I turn twenty-three this December."

Jimin hummed, totally unfazed. "Lucky you! People born in December get Christmas and a birthday right next to each other. I was always so jealous of that."

Taehyung stopped walking for a beat, turning his head to give Jimin a very specific look. It was that same blank, slightly bewildered stare he'd given him about every hour they'd known each other. The kind that made Jimin feel just a little bit unsure of himself, like he'd accidentally spoken a completely different language.

But as Taehyung broke into a small, head-shaking smile and started walking again, Jimin just shrugged it off. He was growing used to it by now. He figured it was just Taehyung's unique, wealthy way of showing endearment.

"So, what made you come here despite your family legacy?" Jimin asked, wanting to break the brief silence and steer the conversation back to something they actually shared.

Taehyung kicked a small, loose pebble on the cobblestone pavement, his hands still deep in his pockets. "I want to become a chef. Maybe open a restaurant of my own... maybe even become an instructor here one day."

Jimin hummed at the thought, picturing Taehyung standing at the front of that massive lecture hall.

He'd certainly be a hell of a lot nicer than Director Jeon. "That sounds amazing."

"You?" Taehyung asked, glancing over.

Jimin's eyes beamed, a genuine, radiant smile breaking across his face as the sheer excitement of his lifelong dream pushed away the lingering clouds of his morning breakdown.

"Oh, I've dreamed ever since I was little of opening a restaurant right in the heart of Paris!" Jimin said, his hands coming out of his pockets to gesture excitedly. "I used to watch Ratatouille when I was little and imagine that was me! Not the rat, obviously, but Linguini."

He let out a bright, melodic laugh at his own joke, his eyes crinkling at the corners. He waited a second, but when Taehyung just kept watching him with that same curious, unblinking intensity, Jimin's hands slowly dropped back to his sides. The sudden rush of confidence wavered, and his shoulders shifted subtly.

"I don't know..." Jimin finished in a much smaller, quieter voice, his gaze dropping to his beat-up sneakers as they walked. "I just... I love cooking more than anything."

Taehyung was silent for a second, his head tilted slightly as he processed the cartoon reference and the sudden burst of raw, unfiltered emotion.

"Americans are very annoyingly expressive," Taehyung said finally, a thoughtful tone in his voice. "It is weird... but also funny."

Jimin's eyes gleamed, a quiet, triumphant warmth spreading through his chest. He took a mental victory lap. Yes, he thought to himself. Finally. One good impression. He hadn't completely scared off the wealthy legacy student with his small-town diner background or his movie references.

Taehyung suddenly skidded to a halt on the cobblestones, his eyes darting toward a charming storefront across the street with a vintage striped awning.

"Oooo... let's get some ice cream!" he said, his previous modeling posture completely vanishing as he pointed eagerly at the shop window.

Jimin nodded eagerly, his previous homesick thoughts of ice cream practically manifesting in front of him. "Okay!"

A bright, melodic bell chimed above the door as they pushed it open, stepping into a cozy shop that smelled heavily of sweet cream, caramelized sugar, and vanilla. Standing behind the counter was an older French woman with a warm, wrinkled face, wearing a long, flowy floral dress and a crisp white apron that was heavily stained with colorful smudges of melted ice cream.

Taehyung immediately adjusted his posture, offering a polite, charming nod. "*Bonjour, madame,*" he said in flawless, smooth French.

Jimin offered his most polite, radiant smile to the woman. Her eyes crinkled, and her eyebrows pulled together in absolute endearment the moment she looked at him.

"*Oh, tu es si petit et mignon, comme un œuf!*" she cooed loudly. Before Jimin could even blink, she

reached right across the glass display case and pinched his cheek, shaking it gently.

Jimin let out a nervous, high-pitched laugh, his shoulders tensing as he stood completely frozen under her grip. He darted his eyes toward Taehyung, pleading for help. "What did she say?"

"She says you look like an egg," Taehyung said, entirely nonchalant as he scanned the handwritten flavors on the chalkboard menu, though a heavy, amused smirk was pulling at the corners of his lips.

"What?!" Jimin squeaked, his voice cracking slightly while the lady still had his cheek firmly pinched between her fingers.

The woman patted his cheek one last time with a heavy sigh, looking at his frame. *"Il est si osseux... Je vais donner un peu plus à ton ami,"* she said to Taehyung in a motherly tone.

Taehyung responded smoothly in French, his smirk widening. *"Le sucre va le rendre encore plus fou."*

The woman let out a loud, booming laugh, waving her hand at Taehyung before she rounded the corner of the counter toward the deep freezer wells filled with mounds of freshly churned ice cream.

"What flavor?" Taehyung asked, tapping his fingers against the glass.

Jimin quickly stepped closer, his eyes darting up to the chalkboard menu. His stomach did a little nervous flutter as he stared at the elegant cursive writing. He could only make out a few basic words like *Chocolat* and *Vanille*, while the rest of the exotic French flavor names looked like complete gibberish to his eyes.

"Something maybe... fruity?" Jimin asked, squinting at the board and hoping he wasn't accidentally ordering something weird.

Taehyung let out a soft, dramatic sigh, but it was playful. He turned to the older woman, his accent shifting into smooth, effortless French as he gestured toward Jimin. *"Pour lui, quelque chose de fruité. Fraise et mangue, s'il vous plaît."*

The woman nodded understandingly, her expression instantly shifting into a mission of maternal nourishment. Jimin just stood there, watching silently as she grabbed a giant metal scoop and went to work.

First, she scooped out Taehyung's order—three elegant, perfectly rounded scoops of a rich, dark chocolate ice cream.

Then, she turned her attention to Jimin's cup.

With agonizing slowness, the red and bright yellow ice cream began to pile up, filling his cup well past the brim. One scoop. Two. Three. Four. Five. Jimin's eyes widened to the size of saucers as the mountain of vibrant colors grew higher and higher, the cup practically overflowing.

The entire time she was scooping, the woman kept shooting Jimin these profoundly pitiful looks,

shaking her head slightly as if she were looking at a stray puppy that hadn't eaten in weeks.

But she wasn't done. With a defiant nod, she took a flat spade, scraped a huge, extra dollop of leftover vanilla from the very bottom of a nearby container, and plopped it right on top of the peak like a crown.

She slid the massive, heavy cup across the counter to Jimin with a proud, satisfied smile. "*C'est gratuit.*"

Taehyung just gave the woman a charming, knowing smile, already digging into his own three scoops of chocolate with a small plastic spoon. He adjusted his bag over his shoulder, offering a polite nod as he murmured his goodbyes in French. "*Merci, madame. Au revoir.*"

Jimin could only smile helplessly, balancing the massive, tower of ice cream in both hands. Before he could even take a step back toward the door, the older woman reached right across the counter again, her face melting into pure endearment as she pinched his cheek one last time with an affectionate squeeze.

"Thank you!" Jimin squeaked out, his voice slightly muffled by her grip, hoping the English phrase was universal enough to convey his gratitude.

The woman laughed, a warm, musical sound, and waved her hand dismissively as if telling him to go eat and put some meat on his bones.

The bell above the door chimed merrily as they stepped back out onto the cool, damp Parisian sidewalk. Jimin let out a long breath, his face still tingling from the double cheek-pinch and looked down at the massive mountain of melting red and yellow ice cream in his hands.

"See?" Taehyung said, taking a slow, elegant bite of his chocolate. "You're practically a local celebrity already, Egg."

Jimin rolled his eyes at the nickname, but the heavenly scent wafting from his overflowing cup was too tempting to ignore. He dug his plastic spoon deep into the vibrant mountain, getting a perfect mix of red strawberry and yellow mango, and popped it into his mouth.

His eyes instantly went wide. "Wow," he breathed, his voice muffled around the spoon. "This is so good!"

The fruit flavors were incredibly fresh and intense, nothing like the artificial syrups back home. Totally forgetting his previous vow to never look at another sweet again, Jimin began eagerly diving back in for more, completely losing himself in the rich, velvety texture.

But as they strolled back toward the gates of the campus, the brisk Parisian air proved to be no match for the sheer volume of the dessert. Slowly but surely, the towering scoops began to lose their structure. By the time they passed the academy archway, the vibrant red and yellow had melted into a thick, soup-like mush at the bottom of the paper cup.

Jimin finally dropped his plastic spoon with a heavy, dramatic sigh. He groaned softly, pressing a hand against his stomach, which felt like it might actually pop after tackling seventy percent of a family-sized portion of ice cream.

Taehyung glanced over, throwing his own empty cup into a nearby stone bin and looking entirely pristine. "What's wrong, Egg? Defeated by a little ice-cream?"

"Nope, never better, actually..." Jimin lied through his teeth, forcing a tight, completely unconvincing smile as he kept a protective hand over his agonizingly full stomach.

They made their way back to the residential hall, the grand, imposing architecture of the dorm building doing absolutely nothing to soothe Jimin's sudden food coma. But the moment they stepped into the echoing stone stairwell to head up to their floor, the cozy, ice-cream-induced peace was instantly shattered.

Coming down the steps were three boys from their lecture hall—the ones from the front row who had spent the entire morning probably jerking off together over Chef Jeon's face.

The moment their eyes landed on Jimin, the atmosphere shifted. Their eyes went wide with malicious glee, and they immediately muffled a chorus of sharp snickers behind their hands, nudging each other aggressively.

Jimin froze on the step, his grip tightening around the railing.

"Diner boy," the ringleader sneered, leaning over the stone banister with a mocking, lazy grin. "See you bright and early tomorrow... I'd like my eggs sunny-side up."

The other two exploded into loud, echoing laughter, the sound bouncing off the high stone walls of the stairwell. They practically tumbled down the remaining steps, deliberately brushing past Jimin and Taehyung with lingering, snide chuckles as they vanished out the heavy exit doors.

Jimin stood rooted to the spot, his mouth slightly open, his eyes wide and burning with pure offense. The residual warmth from the ice cream shop vanished in a second, replaced by a hot, furious rush of adrenaline.

Quite frankly, Jimin wondered what the hell was the deal with him and egg references today.

But beneath the bizarre coincidence, the old, familiar sting returned with a vengeance. His chest tightened, and that hot, prickling sensation gathered right behind his eyes. He wanted to cry again. He wanted to pull his gray jacket over his head, stomp up to his room, and crawl back under his covers.

Before the first tear could even think about escaping, Taehyung stepped up right beside him. He leaned in, giving Jimin's shoulder a firm, grounding nudge that practically jolted him out of his spiral.

"Let them talk," Taehyung said, his voice dropping into a rare, deadly serious register as he watched the exit door swing shut. "Jeon doesn't take lightly to sharp tongues other than his own."

Jimin blinked, looking over at him.

"Those idiots think they're safe because of their names," Taehyung continued, a faint, sharp smirk returning to his lips as he started walking up the stairs again, expecting Jimin to follow. "But trust

me, if Eric and his little shadows try that arrogant routine in the kitchen tomorrow, Director Jeon will use them for mincemeat. Come on"



The next morning, after falling asleep incredibly early due to the unforeseen, catastrophic circumstances of his ice cream food coma, Jimin's eyes snapped open at exactly 4:00 AM. His alarm hadn't even gone off yet, but his body didn't care about sleep—the cold, hard knot of fear already bubbling up in his stomach was better than any shot of espresso.

He sat up, rubbing his eyes, just as the bathroom door clicked open.

Taehyung stepped out, a white towel slung loosely around his waist and steam billowing out behind him. Jimin blinked sleepily, staring for a second, and genuinely wondered what the hell was in the water in Paris.

Why did everyone at this academy look like a literal Greek god?

First Taehyung, and then, unfortunately, evil Chef Jeon with those terrifyingly broad shoulders and sharp jawline.

It wasn't fair.

"Good morning, sleepyhead," Taehyung said smoothly. He walked over to the vanity, picked up a small glass bottle, and poured a few drops of scented oil onto his fingers, effortlessly raking it through his damp hair.

Jimin let out a long, dramatic yawn, raising his arms above his head to stretch out his tense muscles. "Morning..."

They got ready in a quiet, focused silence, the heavy reality of the upcoming morning hanging over the room. Jimin slipped into the bathroom for a quick, scalding shower to shock his nervous system awake. Once dried off, he pulled on his black uniform slacks and the crisp, stiff white chef's shirt.

He hopped around the small space, clumsily sliding his feet into his shoes while simultaneously brushing his teeth, tilting dangerously to the side as he tried to catch his balance against the sink.

When he finally finished and rinsed his mouth, he stepped back into the bedroom to find Taehyung already ready.

He was sitting at his desk, the long, immaculate white strings of his apron already tied perfectly in the front. His chef's hat sat neatly to the side, and his leather knife kit was resting in his lap. He had his notepad open, his eyes scanning his notes from the lecture with an intense, uncharacteristic focus.

"Are you nervous?" Taehyung asked, his voice low in the quiet room. He didn't even look up from the page.

"Yes," Jimin said honestly, not even trying to play it cool.

He reached for his own apron, wrapping the heavy cloth around his waist. His hands were shaking just a little bit, making it difficult, but he forced his fingers to cooperate, tightening the strings firmly around his middle like he was strapping on armor for battle. He stared at his knife kit on the bed, his heart already starting its familiar, anxious thumping.

"Well," Taehyung began, finally looking up from his notepad. His expression was completely devoid of his usual airy nonchalance. "Don't fuck up, and don't cry... those are the words my father told me when he dropped me off."

He closed the book with a sharp snap and shoved it smoothly into his back pants pocket. He picked up his chef's hat from the desk, giving it a quick, practiced shake. "It's 5:15. We should get going."

Jimin swallowed hard, the bluntness of the advice hanging in the cool air of the dorm room. Oddly enough, it helped.

"Right," Jimin said, pulling his shoulders back and grabbing his own knife kit and hat from the bed. "Let's go."

The hallways of the residential building were dead silent as they stepped out, the dim morning lights casting long shadows on the stone floor. A few doors down, they heard the muted rustle of other students frantically getting ready, but nobody was talking. The entire campus felt like a military barracks preparing for war.

As they pushed open the heavy glass doors of the dorm and stepped out into the morning, a sharp, icy breeze hit Jimin's face, completely wiping away any residual grogginess. The sky was a deep, ink-black velvet, and the fog was so thick he could barely see three feet in front of his own feet.

Beside him, Taehyung walked with a strange, quiet dignity, his chin tilted up as he ignored the biting cold. Jimin gripped the handle of his knife kit tighter, his knuckles turning white. He kept replaying Taehyung's words over and over in his head like a mantra.

Don't fuck up. Don't cry.



The kitchen was absolutely gorgeous. Every stainless-steel surface caught the harsh overhead fluorescent lighting, gleaming so brightly it almost made Jimin squint. As he walked down the center aisle, he noticed that each student had a small, frosted-glass nameplate designating exactly where they were supposed to stand.

Jimin scanned the rows until his eyes landed on his own nameplate, and he let out a long, quiet sigh of relief. He and Taehyung were assigned to the exact same table, positioned directly across from each other. Looking across the wide prep surface, he caught Taehyung's eye and saw a subtle wave of relief wash over his roommate's face as well. At least they would be facing this nightmare together.

Within minutes, the rest of the class filtered in, filling the massive room with the nervous rustle of starched shirts and heavy footsteps. The layout of the kitchen was massive and terrifyingly organized.

There were five long, heavy iron cooking tables arranged in neat rows, with exactly four students assigned to each one—meaning Jimin and Taehyung shared their table with two other anxious classmates.

Directly behind their table sat the actual cooking zone: four individual industrial gas stoves, flanked by four sets of every essential tool required for the day. Above their heads, heavy copper and stainless-steel pans, whisks, ladles, and spatulas hung from sturdy iron hooks, perfectly spaced and polished to a mirror shine.

Jimin looked around, his eyes wide as he took in the sheer scale of the pristine equipment. Back at the diner, he worked with warped non-stick skillets and a flat-top grill that had a permanent tilt to the left.

The two boys occupying the other side of their iron table looked even younger than them, practically like deer's caught headlights. One of them shifted frantically from foot to foot, his knuckles white as he gripped the edge of the station, while the other kept his chin tucked firmly into his chest, refusing to look up from the floor.

Jimin tried to offer them a sympathetic glance, but as his eyes scanned the room, they locked right with Eric.

Eric was standing two tables over. His head was tilted back, his chin jutting out with an obnoxious air of unearned royalty. The moment he caught Jimin looking, he flashed a slow, sharp, sideways grin. There wasn't an ounce of kindness in it.

Jimin quickly tore his eyes away, his cheeks burning slightly as he focused instead on the massive silver clock mounted on the far wall. The second hand ticked closer.

56...57....58....59... 6:00.

Right on the dot, the heavy double doors of the kitchen swung open with a resounding, echoing slam.

Chef Jeon walked in.

The entire room went so violently silent you could have heard a pin drop on the cobblestones outside.

Chef Jeon was dressed in a sharp, pitch-black chef's jacket and a matching black apron that made him look even more imposing than he already was. His sleeves were pushed up to his elbows,

revealing veins mapped out across his forearms, and his eyes were intensely focused, dark and completely unreadable.

He didn't speak a word as he began to walk down the aisles, his heavy leather shoes clicking rhythmically against the tile floor. He scanned each student from head to toe, his gaze lingering like a laser sight.

When he reached the halfway through the row, Jungkook stopped abruptly in front of a boy who looked about three seconds away from passing out from pure stress.

"Why are your pants stained?" Jungkook asked, his voice low, smooth, and cutting through the dead silence of the kitchen.

The boy's eyes dropped frantically to his lower leg, where a small smudge of brown—probably just a bit of damp dirt from the foggy walkway outside—marred the fabric. The student opened his mouth to explain, his lips trembling, but before a single syllable could escape, Jungkook simply clicked his pen. He wrote something down on his clipboard with a sharp, swift flick of his wrist. Then, without a word of feedback, he kept moving.

Jimin watched from across the room, his heart hammering against his ribs like a trapped bird. He tracked Jungkook as the man rounded the corner of the final row and started pacing down their aisle. It felt exactly like watching Jaws close in. Jimin physically had to bite down on the inside of his bottom lip to stop himself from visibly shaking as those heavy footsteps drew nearer.

Suddenly, the footsteps stopped.

Right next to him.

Jimin kept his eyes locked straight ahead, staring at the polished iron table, but he could feel Jungkook's presence radiating heat right beside him. Jungkook raked his eyes up Jimin's frame. But instead of moving on to the next student like he had with everyone else, the chef shifted his weight to the left, taking a deliberate step to view him from a different angle. He repeated the agonizing process, slowly tracking Jimin all the way from the tips of his shoes, up his apron, to the top of his chef's hat.

Jimin was absolutely positive his face was burning as red as a tomato under the intense scrutiny.

Jungkook hummed to himself—a tiny, low sound in the back of his throat—and casually wrote something down on his clipboard.

Jimin's stomach completely dropped to his shoes. Panic spiked through him, and he instantly darted his eyes downward, frantically scanning his own shirt, his apron, his hands—trying to find whatever microscopic flaw he could have possibly missed. But he couldn't find a single thing. He was spotless.

As Jungkook began to step away, that sudden, hot anger from yesterday bubbled right back up into Jimin's chest, temporarily overriding his fear.

Jungkook rounded the heavy metal chef's table at the front of the room, the designated stage where he would demonstrate the techniques for every class before the students were expected to replicate

them perfectly. He set his clipboard down with a sharp clatter and cleared his throat, the sound echoing off the tile walls.

"This is the first class I've had in a while where everybody actually came back for more," he said, a small smile pulling at his lips, though it didn't reach his dark eyes. "Under your tables, you will find a basket of potatoes. You each have four. That is all you will be given for the entire period. If you ruin them, you fail the module."

He paused, waiting.

A frantic rustle filled the kitchen as twenty students scrambled at once. Jimin reached beneath the heavy iron table and pulled out a small wicker basket containing four earthy, brown Russet potatoes. He set them down neatly beside his unrolled knife kit, his heart doing a nervous little flutter.

"Today, although this is an advanced course, we will begin with fundamental classic French knife cuts," Jungkook announced, stepping behind his station. "Potatoes are the perfect medium because they require you to waste as little product as possible while achieving absolute geometric perfection. If your cuts are uneven, your food cooks unevenly. In my kitchen, that is unacceptable."

He reached into his own roll and pulled out a sleek, matte-black chef's knife. "Come closer."

Immediately, the try-hard students—with Eric leading the charge—rushed forward, crowding the front of the demo table and completely blocking the view. Jimin, refusing to be left in the back, managed to squeeze his way in near the edge of the counter, his notepad open and pen clicked ready.

Jungkook picked up his first potato, slicing off the sides to form a perfect, flat-sided brick. "We start by squaring off the vegetable. Do not throw away the trim; that is for purées and stocks. First cut: Pont-Neuf." With terrifying precision, he sliced the potato into thick, blocky batons. "Exactly one-third of an inch thick and three inches long. These are your traditional steak fries. Every angle must be ninety degrees."

He moved with an effortless, fluid speed that made Jimin's jaw drop.

"Next, we take those same batons and downsize them for the Allumette, or matchstick cut," Jungkook continued, his voice smooth and hypnotic over the rhythmic thump-thump-thump of his blade against the wood. "One-eighth of an inch thick. Precision is key here; if they are too thin, they burn. Too thick, they stay raw."

Halfway through the second demonstration, Jimin found his eyes drifting away from the potato entirely. He found himself staring at Jungkook's hands. The chef's fingers were long and steady, his knuckles covered in dark, intricate tattoos that shifted under the harsh kitchen lights. Strong veins trailed up the back of his hands, disappearing beneath the rolled-up sleeves of his black jacket where his forearms flexed with every micro-adjustment of the knife.

Jimin suddenly blinked, a hot blush rushing to his cheeks. He violently shook the thought away, gripping his pen tighter and forcing his eyes back up to the cutting board.

"From the Allumette, we move to dice," Jungkook said, completely unaware of Jimin's internal

panic. He gathered the matchsticks and cut across them with blinding speed. "This is the Brunoise. Tiny, perfect cubes measuring one-eighth of an inch on all sides. Used for delicate sauces and garnishes. If I see a single rectangle in your pile, you start over."

Finally, he picked up a fresh potato, holding it firmly against the board. "And lastly, the Tourné. This is a turned vegetable." Using a smaller, curved paring knife, Jungkook began carving the potato in mid-air with rapid, flicking motions. "Seven sides. Perfect football shape. Smooth, curved faces with sharp ridges on both ends. This takes years to master. You have three remaining potatoes to show me all four cuts."

He slid his knife back into his kit and looked up, his gaze sweeping over the silent, intimidated crowd. "You have forty-five minutes. Begin."

Jimin walked back to his station, the heavy weight of the countdown already pressing down on the room. As he stepped up to his iron table, he took a deep, steadying breath.

He was used to knife work. This wasn't entirely foreign territory. Back home, he spent countless hours at the burger station, flying through stacks of tomatoes, crisp lettuce, and thick onions until his hands smelled like them for days. And on Sundays, his mom would always have him at the kitchen counter, dicing up neat little piles of onions and cucumbers for her soups. He knew how to handle a knife.

But as he unzips his leather case, the pristine, razor-sharp edge of his own chef's knife looked completely different under these harsh French lights. It didn't look like a tool for comfort food anymore; it looked like an weapon of judgment and death.

Jimin reached into the wicker basket, his fingers trembling slightly as they brushed against the rough skin of the first potato. He lifted it out and set it down against the cold, iron surface of his cutting board.

Across the table, Taehyung was already moving with a quiet, practiced elegance, his knife slicing smoothly through his own vegetable to square it off. Jimin swallowed the lump in his throat, gripped the handle of his knife, and tried to channel the muscle memory of those busy Sunday mornings. He just needed to square it off. Ninety-degree angles.

Don't fuck up, and don't cry.

Jimin took a deep breath, aligned his blade, and made his first cut. To his immense relief, his hands stopped shaking the moment the steel met the vegetable. Slice. Slice. Slice. The muscle memory from those endless hours at the diner and his mom's kitchen counter kicked in. He squared off the potato into a neat brick, then carefully began slicing it into the thick Pont-Neuf batons. It was actually going well.

But around him, the kitchen was a complete war zone.

"Wasted product. Trash," Jungkook's voice boomed from a few tables over, cold and entirely merciless.

Thud.

"Uneven. Trash."

Thud.

The sound of ruined potatoes dropping into the heavy plastic trashcans echoed through the room like wildfire. Every dull thud was accompanied by a student's muffled gasp or a quiet, defeated sigh. The pressure in the room was suffocating, rising with every step the chef took.

Jimin kept his head down, desperately trying to focus on downsizing his batons into the tiny, matchstick Allumette cuts.

Then, he heard it. The distinct, rhythmic click of heavy leather shoes turning into his aisle. Jungkook was coming right toward his table.

Jimin's heart leaped straight into his throat. His fingers suddenly went slick with potato starch, and as he tried to adjust his grip for the delicate Brunoise dice, his knife completely betrayed him. The heavy blade slipped right out of his hand, clattering loudly against the iron table with a sharp, ringing clank that felt deafening in the silent room.

Jimin froze, his hands hovering in mid-air, his stomach bottoming out.

Right on cue, Jungkook rounded the corner of the table. He didn't say a word at first. He just stood there, towering over the station, his dark eyes boring absolute holes right into the top of Jimin's head.

Jungkook clicked his tongue—a sharp, disapproving sound that made Jimin want to melt—and slowly lowered his gaze to look down at Jimin's cuts.

Panic spiked through Jimin's veins, but the sheer humiliation of standing there empty-handed in front of the chef kicked him into overdrive.

Refusing to look like a complete amateur, Jimin leaned forward, his fingers scrambling against the cold iron table to snatch the handle of his knife back up. He gripped it tight, his knuckles turning white as he forced his arm into a rigid, ready position, desperately trying to pretend his hand wasn't shaking.

Jungkook watched the frantic movement, his eyebrows twitching upward in slight amusement at the sheer desperation. He didn't say a word about the drop. Instead, he stepped closer, leaning his heavy frame over the counter to inspect the neat piles of potato sticks Jimin had managed to finish before the mishap.

Jungkook leaned in closer, his dark eyes narrowing as they swept over the small piles. For a second, Jimin actually thought he might survive this. The Pont-Neuf batons were straight, and the matchstick Allumettes were almost perfectly uniform.

But then, Jungkook's gaze locked onto something tiny. Hidden right at the bottom of the Brunoise pile was a single, microscopic piece of potato that wasn't a perfect cube—a tiny, irregular rectangle that had slipped through when Jimin's hand had started to shake.

Jungkook didn't say a word. He just let out a low, breathy hum, reached out, and forcefully grabbed

the edges of Jimin's heavy cutting board.

With a smooth, terrifyingly casual flick of his wrist, Jungkook snatched Jimin's own chef's knife right out of his white-knuckled grip. Before Jimin could even process the motion, Jungkook used the flat side of the blade to scrape the entire morning's worth of meticulous, perfect cuts straight off the board.

Swoosh.

The neat piles of potato sticks tumbled through the air and fell into the large plastic trashcan by the aisle with a dull, heavy thud .

Jungkook set the cutting board back down with a hollow click, sliding the knife back across the wood toward him. He clicked his pen, wrote a swift note on his clipboard, and moved on to the next student without sharing a single word of explanation.

Stunned, Jimin stood entirely rooted to the spot, his hands hovering over the empty station and his mouth hanging wide open in absolute disbelief.

Across the iron table, Taehyung's knife never stopped moving, but his eyes snapped up. He shot Jimin a fierce, burning look that practically screamed at him to get a grip and keep going, throwing a subtle shake of his head to break his roommate out of the trance.

Jimin inhaled sharply, forcing the cold air into his lungs as he looked around the station. The younger kid right next to him was already on his very last potato, his hands trembling so violently that the tip of his knife was visibly rattling against the cutting board. It was a bloodbath, but Jimin refused to let Jungkook win this easily.

He refused to give up.

Wiping his palms against his black apron, Jimin reached back down into the wicker basket. His fingers wrapped around his third potato, and he yanked it out, setting it down with a firm, defiant smack right in the center of his empty board.

He didn't have time to mourn the lost cuts. He gripped his knife again, his jaw locked tight with that hot, bubbling anger, and sliced off the first side to square it off. Forty-five minutes was ticking away, and he was going to make this one flawless.

Jimin tuned out everything else. He pulled his brows together, his eyes narrowing into a glare of pure, intense focus as he worked. Slice. Slice. Slice. He squared the third potato into a perfect, flawless brick, refusing to let his eyes wander or his grip slip this time.

Around him, the atmosphere in the kitchen was splitting into two completely different worlds.

"Excellent. *Parfait* ," Jungkook's low voice murmured a couple of tables over. Eric and a few of the other front-row try-hards were finishing up, their plates neatly organized with textbook-perfect cuts. Hearing Jungkook actually praise someone—even if it was in that cool, detached tone—made Jimin's blood boil with a fresh wave of determination.

But on the other side of the room, the sounds were devastating. Several students were breathing

shakily, their chests heaving as they stared down at their mangled vegetables, completely lost in the geometry of the Tourné cut. A few others, currently staring at their very last ruined potato, seemed to have given up entirely. They just stood at their stations with slumped shoulders and hollow eyes, completely willing to take the zero just to make the torture stop.

Jimin refused to be one of them.

His blade moved with a rhythmic, aggressive pace. He cut the thick Pont-Neuf batons, measuring them by eye against the three-inch standard he'd memorized. Then, he downsized them into the matchstick Allumettes, his thumb acting as a steady guide, locking his wrist to ensure every single piece was exactly one-eighth of an inch.

He didn't care if his back was getting stiff or if his stomach was still tight from yesterday's ice cream food coma. He just focused on the steel and the starch, working through the panic until the raw anger in his chest turned into pure, cold precision.

The rhythmic, heavy click of leather shoes returned, cutting through the sound of Jimin's rapid slicing. Jungkook was back in their aisle.

The shadow of the chef's towering frame fell over the iron table first. Jungkook stopped on Taehyung's side, leaning down slightly to inspect the neat rows of vegetables. He looked over Taehyung's slices, his sharp eyes calculating the margins, before giving a single, short nod.

"*Parfait*," Jungkook murmured, the word slipping out smoothly as he clicked his pen to mark down a high score.

Then, he shifted his weight, stepping around the corner of the table to stand directly beside Jimin.

Jimin kept his jaw locked, his eyebrows tightly knit together as he finished his very last Brunoise cut. He refused to look up. He could feel Jungkook's dark, critical gaze tracking the movement of his blade, weighing every single millimeter of potato on the wood.

Jungkook clicked his tongue—that same, infuriatingly casual sound.

Jimin watched him out of the corner of his eye, a pure, utter, bubbling rage igniting in his chest. He wanted to throw the knife. He wanted to scream. Instead, he forced himself to stand completely still as Jungkook slowly shook his head.

"You still have a pit in the edge of this cut," Jungkook said, his voice entirely flat and devoid of any warmth. He pointed the tip of his pen toward the Pont-Neuf stack, where a microscopic speck of brown potato eye lingered on the very corner of one baton. He didn't even wait for Jimin to respond before his eyes scanned the rest. "The matchsticks are uneven. Trash."

Without a single shred of hesitation, Jungkook reached out to slide the board toward the edge of the table, ready to discard the hard work for a second time.

Jimin watched him do it. He stood there, entirely frozen, as the flat side of the blade scraped hours of desperate, meticulous focus into the dark void of the trashcan for the second time. Thud.

This time, something inside Jimin snapped. The hot, suffocating wall of anger and humiliation

broke through his filter. Before he could stop himself, he opened his mouth and a sharp, frustrated sound tore from his throat—halfway between a scoff and a gasp of pure defiance.

Jungkook stopped dead in his tracks.

The heavy leather shoes ceased their rhythm instantly, right at the edge of the aisle where he was about to walk off. The entire kitchen seemed to drop an additional ten degrees. Slowly, the chef turned back around, his dark eyes narrowing into freezing slits as they locked onto Jimin.

"I'm sorry," Jungkook said, his voice dropping into a dangerously low, quiet register that made the hair on the back of Jimin's neck stand up. "What was that?"

Jimin blinked, the sudden realization of what he'd just done hitting him like a physical blow. The fiery rage evaporated in a second, replaced by a wave of pure, overwhelming panic. He looked away, staring hard at the empty, scraped-clean wood of his cutting board as his eyes instantly brimmed with hot, stinging tears. He desperately forced himself to look down, blinking rapidly to keep them from spilling over his lashes.

Don't cry. Do not cry.

Jungkook lingered for a terrifyingly long three seconds, his gaze boring into the side of Jimin's burning face.

"Fifteen minutes," Jungkook announced loudly, his voice echoing over the entire class, though his eyes remained harshly fixed right on Jimin's trembling frame. "You have fifteen minutes left to present acceptable work."

With a sharp turn of his shoulder, he finally walked away, his black apron snapping against his legs as he headed back toward the front of the room.

Jimin closed his eyes, forcing his lids shut so tightly that small spots danced in the darkness behind them. He took a deep, shuddering breath, deliberately shutting out the harsh glare of the fluorescent lights and the terrifying sound of Jungkook's retreating footsteps.

Instead, he let himself go home.

He imagined his mom standing right beside him at the crowded kitchen counter, her warm, familiar voice coaxing him through the stress, telling him to just breathe. Then his mind drifted to the greasy, comforting warmth of the diner. He could practically hear Mr. Frank barking orders from the grill, and his coworkers laughing over the chaotic clatter of thick ceramic plates during a late-night rush. He remembered their funny, ridiculous midnight conversations, the way they joked around to make the grueling double shifts fly by.

They believed in him.

They knew he belonged in a kitchen.

Slowly, Jimin opened his eyes. The stinging tears were gone, replaced by a quiet, steady resolve.

Across the iron table, Taehyung was staring at him with a deeply questioning, worried look, but

Jimin completely ignored it. He didn't have time to explain. He reached down into his basket, grabbed his third potato, and set it on the board.

This time, he was more focused on not being focused. He knew what he was doing. The problem was the suffocating fear of the man in the black jacket. So, as his knife met the vegetable, Jimin deliberately filled his mind with something else. He tuned out the icy, clinical atmosphere of the academy kitchen. He stopped listening for the trashcans. He just let his hands do what they had been trained to do for years, letting the warmth of his memories shield him from the cold reality around him as the final fifteen minutes began to tick away.

Jimin worked with a blinding, ferocious speed, driven by a cocktail of absolute determination and pure, unadulterated fury. He was fucking mad as hell. He didn't care about the ticking clock anymore; he just cared about proving this arrogant man wrong. Slice, slice, slice. The blade moved like an extension of his own hand, completely riding on the rhythm of his anger.

Out of the corner of his eye, he caught the shadow of Jungkook lingering nearby, watching. Jimin didn't flinch. He brought the knife down for his final, microscopic Brunoise cut, perfection etched into every single millimeter of the starch.

The second the blade hit the board for the last time, Jimin set his knife down with a deliberate, controlled tap. He stood perfectly straight, his jaw set so tight his teeth literally ached and stared straight ahead at the white tiled wall. He refused to look down. He refused to look small.

Jungkook approached the station, his heavy leather shoes coming to a halt right beside Jimin. The chef leaned down, lowering his frame over the iron table to inspect the final layout. As he bent closer, a wave of his fragrance—a dominant, expensive, and devastatingly sharp cologne—radiated off him, completely invading Jimin's senses and mixing with the starchy scent of the kitchen.

Jungkook stared at the piles. He didn't move. He didn't breathe. For what felt like an absolute eternity, the kitchen was dead silent, the seconds stretching out like torture as those dark eyes calculated every single angle.

Slowly, Jungkook leaned back up to his full height. He turned his head, his piercing gaze locking directly onto Jimin's defiant stare.

He clicked his pen.

" *Parfait* ," Jungkook said.

The word was low and smooth, but it was delivered much harsher, sharper, and heavier than it had been for any of the other students in the room. Jungkook scribbled something swift on his clipboard, his eyes lingering on Jimin for one last tense second before he finally turned on his heel and walked away.

Chapter 3



Before the end of class, Jungkook stood in front of the students at the master demo table. His hands were clasped loosely behind his back as his dark eyes raked over the exhausted rows of people in front of him.

"If today you struggled with basic cuts," Jungkook began, his voice cutting through the heavy silence like ice, "you may want to tonight consider your purpose for being here. This academy does not carry dead weight." He paused, letting the harsh words sink in. "The kitchen remains open until midnight. So, you may practice if you are that determined to succeed.....Dismissed."

A collective, quiet shuffle broke out as everyone began to clear their stations. Jimin carefully wiped down his blade, packed his knife back into his leather kit, and stepped away from the iron table. As he walked toward the exit, a strange, heavy sensation prickled against the back of his neck. He could feel Jungkook watching him from the front of the room, those unreadable eyes tracking his movements, and it instantly made him feel hot and incredibly nervous.

Suddenly, a firm tap on his shoulder jolted him out of his skin. Jimin jumped, nearly dropping his bag.

"Ah, sorry Jimin! I didn't mean to scare you," a smooth voice chuckled.

Jimin turned around to see Alexandre standing there, a warm, easy smile on his face. Jimin's cheeks instantly flushed at the sight of the boy, his ears burning a bright, telltale pink. "O-oh, it's okay. I was just...."

Taehyung caught up to them a second later, swinging his own kit over his shoulder as they all walked out of the practical kitchen together. Before pushing through the heavy exit doors, Jimin couldn't help himself—he cast one quick glance back over his shoulder. Sure enough, his gaze locked right with Chef Jeon's. The chef hadn't moved an inch, still standing at the front, watching Jimin leave with an intense, calculated stare.

Jimin quickly looked back ahead, his heart doing a chaotic little flip.

"Good job in there guys, honestly. A lot of people near me didn't even finish their piles. They just completely froze up under the pressure." Alexandre began.

Jimin blinked, caught off guard by the sudden praise.

The boy let out a low chuckle, his curly brown hair shifting effortlessly over his forehead as he shook his head in genuine impression. "I guess Americans have got some real skill after all. Not many people can stare down Chef Jeon after he dumps their station twice and still pull off a flawless cut."

Jimin's cheeks instantly flushed a deeper shade of crimson at the words. "O-oh, thank you. I guess I was just... too pissed off to give up, I think."

"Well, it worked," Alexandre said, flashing Jimin one last warm, dimpled smile before gesturing toward the end of the hall. "I've got to run to my next seminar, but I'll see you guys around the campus."

"Au revoir, Taehyung," Alexandre said, offering a smooth, casual nod before turning on his heel.



The afternoon sun slanted sharply through the small window of the dorm room, throwing a long, bright rectangle across Jimin's unmade bed. He was lying flat on his stomach, his chin propped up on a pillow, aggressively typing into the search bar of his laptop.

His forearms still throbbed with a dull, tight ache, and his fingers were stiff, but the lingering adrenaline from the morning wouldn't let him rest. He had to know who this guy thought he was.

He hit enter, and a flood of articles, culinary journal features, and high-res restaurant reviews practically exploded onto the screen. Jeon Jungkook. The youngest chef in Europe to secure three Michelin stars for a flagship Parisian establishment. A prodigy. A perfectionist.

A fucking pain in the ass.

Jimin scrolled down, his lip curling in a slight sneer as he clicked on an archived piece from a prominent food magazine. It was an interview from a few years ago, back when Jungkook was actually a senior student at this exact academy.

There was a photo attached to the header. Jungkook was standing in a sunlit kitchen, wearing a stark white student uniform, his sleeves rolled up to reveal forearms that were already heavily tattooed. Even back then, he didn't look like a student—he looked like a predator waiting to strike. He was staring directly into the camera lens with a cold, unblinking intensity, his mouth set in a hard, unforgiving line.

"Damn, he's always been scary," Jimin muttered aloud to the empty room, his voice dripping with annoyance as he scrolled past the photo.

He clicked out of the article and shifted to a video tab, finding a clip of Jungkook conducting a guest masterclass for a group of professional line chefs the previous year. Jimin maximized the screen, his eyes squinting with pure disdain as the video buffered.

On screen, Jungkook was moving through a kitchen like a shadow, his dark hair falling slightly forward as he deftly filleted a whole sea bass with terrifying, surgical precision. The audio was crisp. You could hear the absolute silence of the room, broken only by the sharp, authoritative snap

of Jungkook's voice as he tore into a professional sous chef for losing two degrees of temperature on a reduction sauce.

Jimin leaned closer to the screen, his eyebrows pulled tightly together. Even through a laptop speaker, Jungkook's low, raspy cadence made Jimin's stomach do that same nervous, tightening flip it had done in the practical kitchen. He watched the way Jungkook clicked his heavy pen against his clipboard in the video, the exact same habit he'd used right before dumping Jimin's cutting board into the trash.

"Arrogant jerk," Jimin whispered, glaring at the moving image of the chef's face. He traced the movement of the blade on screen, his mind involuntarily matching it to the rhythm of his own hands from earlier. He hated how good the man was. He hated how effortlessly perfect every cut looked.

He was so deeply lost in the rabbit hole of Jeon Jungkook's career, squinting hard at the screen to catch the exact angle of the chef's wrist, that he didn't even hear the dorm room door click open behind him.

"Jimin, please, you're going to stress yourself out. Détends-toi ," Taehyung said, his voice cutting through the tense silence of the room as the door clicked shut behind him.

Jimin didn't even turn around to acknowledge him. He just shifted fluidly, sitting up and propping the heavy laptop onto his knees, his eyes still glued to the glowing screen where Jungkook was flawlessly plating a dish with a pair of long tweezers.

"I just don't understand," Jimin said, his tone tight as he stared unblinkingly at the video. "Was he born with a stick up his ass, or is he just that mean?"

Taehyung shrugged off his heavy jacket, tossing it carelessly over the back of his desk chair. He walked over to his own bed, completely unbothered by the heavy sound of Chef Jeon radiating from Jimin's laptop.

"Don't know, don't care," Taehyung muttered, stretching his arms over his head before collapsing back onto his mattress with a soft groan. "I'm just here to learn and leave. If he wants to act like a dick, let him. As long as he marks my papers, he can be as miserable as he wants."

"Easy for you to say," Jimin grumbled, finally pausing the video right on a close-up of Jungkook's dark, unreadable eyes. "He didn't throw your entire work into the garbage. Twice ."

Taehyung chuckled softly, the sound low and amused as he sat back up, propping himself up on his elbows to look at his roommate.

"I think.....maybe he sees you as *une bonne poire* ," Taehyung said, the syllables rolling effortlessly off his tongue.

Jimin paused, his fingers hovering over his trackpad as his brows knitted together in a deep frown. He turned his head to look at Taehyung. "A what? W-what is that supposed to mean?"

Taehyung grinned, leaning forward a bit. "It means 'a good pear.' But it's an old French saying. It basically means someone who is soft and easily targeted because they're too nice or too eager to

please."

Jimin glared at his roommate, the laptop suddenly heavy against his knees. "I am not une bonne ... p-pwar !" The unfamiliar words tumbled out of his mouth half-pronounced and completely clumsy, making his tongue feel thick.

Taehyung burst out laughing, a loud, unbothered sound that filled the small dorm room. "First of all, we need to work on your French. Second of all, yes, you are. Look at you right now—you're practically smoking from the ears because a man who doesn't even know your middle name threw some potatoes away."

"Because it's disrespectful!" Jimin slammed his laptop shut, the definitive snap punctuation for his frustration. He slid off the bed, his socks sliding slightly on the hardwood floor as he began to pace. "I've been working in kitchens since I was a teenager. Real kitchens. Messy, loud, sweaty ones where people actually talk to each other. I'm not some soft, eager-to-please pear!"

"Then stop acting like he's the center of the universe," Taehyung countered easily, leaning back against his pillows and watching Jimin pace like a caged animal. "You spent all morning fighting him, and now you're spending your whole afternoon researching him. If I didn't know any better, I'd say Chef Jeon is winning."

Jimin stopped dead in his tracks, his chest heaving under his oversized hoodie. The word winning struck a dangerous chord in his chest.

He didn't want Jungkook to win. He wanted to make the man look at his work and have absolutely nothing to say.

"Fine," Jimin snapped, his shoulders slumping as the fight temporarily drained out of him. "I don't want to be a soft pear!"

He tossed his laptop to the side and sank heavily back onto his bed, burying his face in his pillows with a frustrated groan.

Taehyung sat up fully, studying him from across the room. His expression was highly amused, his dark eyes sparkling with the sheer entertainment value of Jimin's existential crisis. He didn't say a word, just waited for the inevitable second wave of the rant.

It only took three seconds. Jimin rolled onto his back, staring up at the ceiling with a hard, bitter scowl, his fingers flexing against his mattress.

"He just irritates me so bad," Jimin muttered, his voice echoing off the concrete walls of the dorm. "Seriously. Where I'm from, he'd get jumped for speaking so harshly like that. You can't just talk to people like they're trash and expect them to just take it."

Taehyung let out a dramatic, breathy laugh, leaning his chin on his hand. "Oh, really? The fierce American. Are you going to gather a crowd from the local diner and wait for the chef in the alleyway behind the academy?"

"I'm just saying," Jimin grumbled. "He needs to be taken down a couple notches. He thinks he's untouchable."

"He is untouchable," Taehyung said, his amusement fading into something a bit more grounded. "The guy is set for life. He has years of experience under his belt—way more than the average twenty eight-year-old. So, maybe just consider that."

Jimin bit the inside of his cheek, staring up at the ceiling.

"Also consider," Taehyung began again, pointing a strict finger across the room at him, "that you actually have to graduate. You can't go getting yourself kicked out of school because of that quick tongue of yours."

Jimin let out a long, defeated sigh, rolling his head to the side to look at his roommate. "I don't have a quick tongue."

"Jimin, you made a sound in class today that almost caused you you're life," Taehyung countered, raising an eyebrow. "If you do that again, he won't just dump your board. He'll throw your whole kit out the window. Just play the game, okay? Keep your head down."

Jimin didn't answer. He looked past Taehyung, his gaze landing right back on the leather knife kit resting on his desk. Taehyung's advice was smart. It was. It was exactly what a normal student would do to survive.

But as Jimin felt the dull ache in his fingers from the morning's tension, a stubborn, angry spark flared right back up in his chest. He didn't want to just survive Jeon Jungkook. He wanted to beat him at his own stupid game.

"Fine, I'll bite my tongue," Jimin muttered, rolling his face back into the pillow so his voice muffled against the fabric.

Though, as the words left his mouth, he wasn't sure he even believed himself.

"Good," Taehyung said, entirely unconvinced but willing to let the subject drop as he checked his phone. "Because I don't feel like dragging your body out of the Seine."

Jimin stayed face-down, listening to the quiet rustle of Taehyung moving around the room. He forced his breathing to slow down, trying to pretend that the image of Jungkook's dark eyes and the suffocating scent of his cologne weren't still completely burned into his brain.



The next morning came far too quickly. The alarm blared into the dark room, and by 5:30 sharp, Jimin and Taehyung were stepping out of the residential building and into the brisk, quiet Parisian dawn.

The walk to the academic building was only ten minutes, but it felt like a march toward a firing

squad. They didn't speak much that morning. The heavy silence between them was filled only by the rhythmic slap of their shoes against the pavement and the occasional clink of steel from the knife kits gripped tightly in their hands. Jimin's apron was tied securely around his waist, the knots perfect, and his chef's hat was placed neatly on his head, pinning back his hair.

Outwardly, he looked like the model student. Inwardly, he was a trembling mess.

He spent the entire walk practicing biting his tongue, consciously keeping his jaw clamped shut every time his mind drifted to Chef Jeon. But the closer they got to the heavy double doors of the practical kitchen, the more a familiar, suffocating anxiety began bubbling in his stomach. It was a cold, fluttering nervousness that made his breath catch in his throat.

They pushed through the doors and entered the kitchen.

The room was already blindingly bright, the sterile fluorescent lights reflecting off the immaculate stainless steel counters. The chill of the industrial AC hit Jimin's face, instantly carrying that sharp, lingering trace of heavy woodsmoke and expensive leather.

He was already here.

Chef Jeon was standing at the front master station, leaning against the edge of the iron table with his arms crossed over his chest. He wasn't wearing his full chef's coat today—just a tight black short-sleeved shirt that showed off the web of dark tattoos climbing up his right arm, and a heavy iron-grey apron. He didn't look up the exact moment they walked in, but his dark eyes slowly tracked up from his clipboard, his gaze slicing through the humid air of the room until it landed directly on Jimin.

Jimin kept his eyes strictly forward as he walked down the aisle to his iron table, refusing to let his gaze drift even a millimeter toward the front master station. He carefully set his knife kit down on the cold surface. Taehyung followed right beside him, and they both instantly settled into perfect formation—backs straight, feet shoulder-width apart, and hands clasped securely behind their backs.

Their other tablemates arrived just seconds later, frantically sliding into their spots and mimicking the rigid posture. The entire room was suffocatingly quiet. Jimin's eyes stayed trained on the digital clock on the far wall, watching the seconds tick away as he tried with every fiber of his being to ignore the massive, dark presence of Chef Jeon at the front of the room.

The clock struck 6:00 AM.

Promptly on the dot, Jungkook rounded his table. He let the silence stretch for five agonizing seconds before he spoke, his voice low, raspy, and entirely commanding.

"The palate of France is not about addition," Jungkook began. "It is about execution. It is an intricate, unforgiving system built on centuries of discipline. you cannot just slap a piece of meat on a grill and mask it with sauce. Here, the ingredients have nowhere to hide. If your technique is flawed, the dish is ruined."

He reached down, lifting a whole, raw chicken from a chilled tray and placing it squarely on his cutting board.

"Which brings us to poultry," Jungkook continued, his dark eyes sweeping over the room, pausing for a fraction of a second on Jimin before moving along. "To understand French cuisine, you must understand how to respect the animal. You do that through precision."

Before he picked up his knife, Jungkook raised a heavy hand and motioned with two blunt fingers for the class to step forward. "Come close. I will not repeat myself."

The silence shattered as students scrambled from behind their stations, moving with an anxious rustle. Jimin moved quickly, slipping his small notepad and a cheap black pen from his apron pocket. He squeezed into the front row, standing just inches from the edge of the master table. The sharp scent of Jungkook's cologne hit his senses instantly, thick and suffocating in this close proximity.

Jungkook didn't acknowledge the crowd. His dark eyes were entirely focused on the cutting board as he began.

"The seasoning is minimal but still needed," Jungkook rasped, his voice vibrating through the short distance between them. "Coarse sea salt and freshly cracked white pepper. No black pepper—it leaves dark flecks that ruin the visual clarity of the Chasseur sauce. You will find the white peppercorns in the third pantry vault, and you will grind them by hand in a mortar. If I see a pre-ground shaker at your station, you're score will be an immediate zero."

Jimin's pen flew across the paper, his handwriting tight and hurried as his eyes glued themselves to Jungkook's tattooed hands.

"First, the breakdown," Jungkook continued, lifting the razor-sharp boning knife. "You slide the blade along the natural curve of the breast, keeping the steel flush against the carcass. To separate the leg from the thigh, you flip it over, locate the clean white line of fat running along the joint, and slice directly through it in one smooth motion. If your blade hits bone, you are forcing it. Let the knife find the seam."

With a terrifyingly effortless pop, the leg and thigh parted perfectly.

"Next, the sear," Jungkook said, moving the beautifully butchered pieces to a heavy copper saute pan. The induction burner hummed to life. "Your pan must be hot enough to make the oil shimmer. When you lay the chicken in, skin-side down, you lay it away from you, so you don't splash your station. Listen to the hiss. If it's a quiet sizzle, your pan is too cold, and your skin will turn to rubber. You leave it alone. Do not poke it, do not slide it around. Let the fat render until it reaches a flawless, golden-crisp amber."

The kitchen filled with the rich, mouth-watering aroma of crisping chicken fat. Jungkook expertly flipped the pieces, letting them color for just a minute before removing them to a side tray.

"The pan is now loaded with fond—that caramelized protein on the bottom is your flavor," Jungkook explained, his low voice holding the room captive. "Drop your minced shallots and wild chanterelle mushrooms directly into it. Let them sweat, absorbing that fat, before you deglaze with a sharp splash of dry white wine. Let it reduce by half, then stir in your rich demi-glace and diced tomatoes. The tarragon goes in at the very last second so the residual heat releases the oils without burning the herb."

The sweet scent of fresh tarragon bloomed into the air. Finally, Jungkook pulled a pristine white porcelain plate toward him.

"To plate, you create a foundation," he murmured, spooning a perfectly measured circle of the glossy, mushroom-heavy Chasseur sauce directly into the center. "The chicken breast is rested, ensuring the juices don't bleed into your sauce. You place it skin-side up, right in the center, tilting the wing joint upward to create height. You spoon a single ribbon of the sauce over the meat, glazing it, but leaving the edges of the skin perfectly dry and crunchy. Wipe the rim. Not a single smudge of grease."

With a slow, deliberate movement, Jungkook rested his palms on the edge of the counter and slid the finished plate forward. It stopped right in front of Jimin.

"Taste it," Jungkook commanded, his dark eyes dropping to Jimin's face, holding his gaze with a heavy, unblinking intensity.

Jimin swallowed hard. His fingers trembled slightly as he reached out, other students were grabbing plastic forks already eager to taste the chefs cooking. Jimin grabbed on as well and he flaked off a small piece of the chicken, ensuring he got a bit of the crackling amber skin and a deep scoop of the sauce.

He slid the bite into his mouth.

Fuck.

It was delicious.

The chicken was impossibly tender, bursting with flavor, but it was the sauce that completely made the dish. It was an explosive balance—deeply savory, sharply acidic from the wine, and perfectly rounded out by the earthy mushrooms and sweet tarragon. Jimin's eyelids fluttered, a physical wave of pleasure rushing through him so fast he wanted to close his eyes and let out a soft moan right there at the table. He had to forcibly lock his jaw shut, biting the inside of his cheek to keep the sound trapped in his throat.

He opened his eyes, only to find Jungkook staring right at him, a microscopic, dangerous smirk tugging at the corner of the chef's lips as if he knew exactly what Jimin was fighting to hold back.

Jungkook stood straight, his frame casting a slight shadow over the front row as he looked down at the class.

"You have exactly one hour," Jungkook announced, his voice dropping into that quiet, demanding register. "One hour to replicate this dish down to the very taste, the very texture, and the exact weight of the sauce. If your seasoning is off by a single grain of salt, I will know. Your time starts now."

Jimin didn't need to be told twice. He spun on his heel and moved back to his station, his heart hammering against his ribs as the chaotic clatter of twenty-other students echoed through the room. The clock was ticking, and that explosive, savory taste of the sauce was still burning on his tongue.

He bent down, pulling open the handle of the stainless-steel freezer beneath his station. The blast of icy air hit his flushed face as he reached in and grabbed the chilled, whole chicken wrapped in plastic. It felt heavy and slippery in his hands. He slammed the freezer door shut with his foot, set the bird down on his sanitized cutting board, and sliced the plastic away.

Keep your head down. Bite your tongue.

He chanted the words like a mantra in his head.

He grabbed his sleek boning knife, his fingers instantly tightening around the handle. He started with the breasts, sliding the blade flush against the carcass just like Jungkook had shown them. His hands were a little shaky from the lingering adrenaline, but his instinct kicked in, guiding the steel through the flesh. He detached the breasts, ensuring the skin remained completely intact, and carefully scraped the wing joint clean of cartilage until the bone was stark white.

But then came the leg and thigh separation.

Jimin flipped the chicken over, searching for that clean white line of fat Jungkook had mentioned. He found it, angled his knife, and pressed down to slice through the seam.

Crunch.

Jimin froze, his stomach dropping into his shoes. He hadn't hit the seam perfectly. The tip of his blade had nicked the edge of the thigh bone, shaving off a tiny, microscopic fragment of cartilage.

A cold sweat broke out across the back of his neck. He could practically feel Jungkook's heavy, suffocating gaze boring into his back from across the room, even though the chef was currently pacing a different row. Jimin quickly wiped the blade on his side towel, swallowing down the panic. He forced himself to slow down, breathing through his nose as he moved to the second leg. This time, he used the absolute tip of his knife, feeling for the natural gap in the joint, and popped it out with a clean, satisfying click .

"Come on, come on," he whispered to himself, glancing up at the clock. Fifteen minutes had already vanished.

He moved to the induction burner, placing his heavy copper saute pan on the glass. He poured in a thin layer of oil, waiting anxiously until the liquid began to loosen and shimmer across the metal. Taking a deep breath, Jimin picked up the chicken breast by the wing joint and laid it into the pan, skin-side down, making sure to lay it away from himself.

A sharp, violent hiss erupted from the copper.

Jimin let out a tiny breath of relief. The pan was hot enough. He didn't touch it. He resisted every urge to nudge the meat, remembering Jungkook's warning. He stood over the pan, watching the chicken fat begin to render out, bubbles popping furiously around the edges as the skin gradually began to take on a beautiful, uniform amber color.

While it seared, Jimin's hands flew across his station, gathering his minced shallots, slicing the wild chanterelle mushrooms into uniform pieces, and measuring out his dry white wine. His fingers were stiff, a dull ache radiating up his forearm from how hard he was gripping his tools, but he

refused to slow down.

With a pair of tongs, he carefully flipped the chicken. The skin was a gorgeous, crackling golden-brown—not quite as perfect as Jungkook's, but it was crisp and un-torn. He let the other side color for sixty seconds before transferring the meat to a resting tray.

Now came the hardest part: the Chasseur sauce.

Jimin dropped the shallots and mushrooms directly into the hot, rendered fat left in the pan. The aroma instantly bloomed, thick and savory. He tossed them until they softened, then grabbed the measuring cup of white wine.

Deglaze.

He poured the wine in, and the pan exploded with a loud hiss, steam billowing up into his face. He leaned over the pan, squinting through the vapor to watch the liquid bubble and reduce. He added the rich, dark demi-glace and the diced tomatoes, stirring continuously with a wooden spoon as the sauce began to thicken into a glossy, velvety glaze.

While Jimin's sauce was simmering, the tense silence of the kitchen was violently shattered by the sharp, echoing snap of Jungkook's voice across the room.

"Trash! Look at this station, it's a bloody battlefield!" Jungkook sneered, his voice dripping with pure disgust as he stood over a student's table three rows down. "You hacked at this bird like a butcher in a street market. Look at the skin—it's shredded! Throw it in the refuse bin and clean your station before I throw you out with it!"

Jimin flinched, his heart doing a frantic leap against his ribs. He kept his eyes strictly glued to his copper pan, stirring the bubbling, velvety Chasseur sauce as the rich aroma of tarragon blew into his face. He could hear the heavy, rhythmic click of Jungkook's boots moving down the aisle, approaching closer and closer.

Just look at the pan. Don't look up.

Suddenly, a large, dark shadow fell over his station. The heavy, suffocating scent of sandalwood and expensive leather filled his lungs. Jungkook had stopped right beside him.

Without saying a single word, Jungkook reached out, his heavily tattooed arm flexing as he picked up a clean, silver tasting spoon from Jimin's tray. He dipped the edge of the spoon smoothly into the simmering, glossy sauce.

Jimin held his breath, his whole body freezing as Jungkook lifted the spoon to his lips. The chef smacked his lips together twice, tasting the reduction, his dark eyes fixed on the bubbling liquid as he evaluated the flavor profile.

Slowly, his gaze shifted upward, locking directly onto Jimin's face.

"Have you tried this?" Jungkook asked, his voice low, raspy, and entirely unreadable.

Jimin swallowed hard, his hands tightly gripping the handle of his wooden spoon. "Oh... um, no,

Chef."

Jungkook didn't break eye contact. Instead, he turned his head slightly toward the rest of the room, his voice carrying easily over the clattering pans of the other students. "A good chef tries his dish until he becomes a great chef and doesn't have to."

Before Jimin could even process the words, Jungkook turned back to him. He didn't reach for a clean utensil, and he didn't dip it back into the pan. He kept his grip on the exact same silver spoon he had just put to his own lips—where a small, rich pool of the mushroom-heavy glaze still remained.

He held it out directly toward Jimin's face.

Jimin's brain completely short-circuited. He stared at the silver spoon resting between Jungkook's tattooed fingers, seeing the dark, glossy reduction coating the metal. Jungkook raised a single, sharp eyebrow in expectancy, nudging the spoon just a millimeter closer to Jimin's lips. The silent demand was absolute, his dark eyes boring into Jimin's, waiting to see if the *bonne poire* was going to flinch or back down from sharing the spoon.

Jimin's throat went entirely dry, a sudden, fierce heat rushing straight to the tips of his ears. He couldn't breathe. But with the other students scrambling around them and the clock ticking down, his stubborn pride flared. He refused to look weak in front of this man.

Jimin stepped forward, leaning in just enough to part his lips and take the spoon into his mouth, tasting the sauce right off the metal Jungkook had just used. His eyes stayed trained completely on Jungkook's dark, unblinking gaze the entire time, staring right back at him as his lips wrapped around the silver.

The heat of the sauce burst across his tongue, carrying the rich, savory depth of the demi-glace. It completely wrecked Jimin's focus for a split second, but as he swallowed, his eyes widened slightly. It was missing something. The balance was just a tiny bit too heavy; it lacked the bright, sharp acidity that had made Jungkook's version so explosive.

Jimin pulled back, slowly licking his lips as he stared right back into Jungkook's eyes, refusing to let the heavy intensity of the moment shake him.

Without saying a word of explanation, Jimin reached for the open bottle of dry white wine on his counter. He tilted it over the copper pan, adding another quick, deliberate splash of wine directly into the bubbling sauce to cut through the heavy fat.

Jungkook watched the movement, his eyes narrowing slightly as he tracked the precise pour. A low hum vibrated deep in his chest, and that microscopic, dangerous smirk tugged at the corner of his lips.

He tossed the spoon onto the tray and walked by, his heavy boots echoing as he moved down to terrorize the next row, leaving Jimin standing over his station with a racing heart, burning cheeks, and the taste of Chef Jeon still lingering on his tongue.

With only five minutes left on the clock, Jimin's adrenaline pumped hot through his veins. He pulled a pristine white porcelain plate toward him and began to build the dish with careful hands.

Using his spoon, he laid down a perfectly circular foundation of the rich, glossy Chasseur sauce right in the center, making sure the dark chanterelle mushrooms were distributed evenly. He carefully lifted the rested chicken breast with his tongs, placing it skin-side up over the bed of sauce, tilting the cleanly scraped wing joint upward to create that precise, dramatic height Jungkook had demonstrated. He spooned a single, elegant ribbon of the reduction over the middle of the breast, letting the edges of the amber skin remain flawlessly dry and crackling. He grabbed a damp white towel, wiping the rim of the plate until there wasn't a single microscopic smudge of grease or fingerprint left behind.

He worked with terrifying focus, making sure absolutely nothing was out of place.

Right across from him, Taehyung was finishing up too. His dish looked exceptional—clean, effortless, and perfectly balanced as he set it on his table. The student on Jimin's other side was struggling, their presentation looking a little rough around the edges, but everything was together, nonetheless.

The moment Jimin completed plating, he carefully set the dish right in front of him on the stainless-steel counter.

"Step back! Hands behind your backs!" Jungkook's authoritative shout echoed through the room.

The time was officially up. The heavy, complex aroma of seared meat, reduced white wine, and fresh tarragon lingered thick and humid in the air. The students stood perfectly rigid in their uniform lines, backs straight, hands clasped tightly behind them, their chests heaving as they tried to cool down.

Jungkook was back at the front master station. He slowly crossed his arms over his chest, his eyes sweeping over the rows of anxious faces with a cold, terrifyingly calm expression.

"Who wants to go first?" Jungkook asked, his low, raspy voice dripping with a mocking sort of amusement. "I am quite hungry."

Of-fucking-course, Eric stepped forward without a single second of hesitation.

He lifted his plate, which was admittedly beautiful and impeccably put together, and began walking down the center aisle with his chin up and his head held high, looking entirely confident.

He reached the front and set his plate down on Jungkook's master table. Jungkook didn't say a word. He just picked up a heavy silver fork sitting beside him on a clean linen napkin.

Jimin found himself holding his breath, his eyes glued to the front of the room. His knuckles turned white behind his back as he watched the chef smoothly flake off a piece of the crispy chicken skin, swirling it into the dark sauce, and lift the fork to his mouth.

Jungkook chewed for a split second, and then his face twisted into a mask of pure revulsion. Without a word, he grabbed the linen napkin on the counter and spit the food directly into it, slamming it down.

A few students in the back row loudly gasped.

Jungkook's features were contorted in disgust as he glared at Eric. "Did you measure out the correct amount of vinegar?" he asked, his voice dangerously quiet.

Eric stammered, all his previous confidence instantly evaporating. "Yes, Chef.... I..."

Jungkook cocked a single, sharp eyebrow, leaning over the table. "Ne mens pas, boucher." His voice was low and dripping with venom.

Eric looked away, his face flushing crimson. "W-when my dad makes it, he always adds more vinegar so that th—"

Before Eric could even finish the sentence, Jungkook reached out, grabbed the plate off the desk, and dumped everything straight into the heavy trash bin beside him with a loud, sickening thud.

Jimin watched the beautiful food fall into the garbage with a pained expression, his stomach twisting. The sheer waste of it, the absolute brutality of the action, made his blood run cold.

"Once again," Jungkook began, his voice rising, vibrating through the metal fixtures of the kitchen. "Your family means nothing to me! When I give you instructions, you follow them!" By the last sentence, he was openly yelling, volatile anger rolling off him.

Jimin and a few other students visibly flinched at the volume, the sound echoing sharply against the tile walls. Eric cleared his throat, his posture completely broken, his shoulders rounded in fear as he stared at the floor. "Y-yes, Chef."

Jungkook let out a harsh, mocking scoff, waving his hand to dismiss the humiliated student.

"Next?"

Not a single person moved. The kitchen fell into a dead, suffocating silence, the students standing so rigid they looked like statues. No one dared to volunteer after watching Eric's dish get obliterated and then thrown in the trash.

Jungkook hummed, a dark, deeply amused sound. "Okay, we will go down each row then, since the whole class has grown mute. Next."

The systematic slaughter began. One by one, students cautiously stepped forward, their hands shaking as they presented their plates to the executioner.

The student from the far left aisle walked up. Jungkook dipped his fork, took a bite, and immediately tossed the utensil down. "Too salty. It tastes like you scooped water directly from the Atlantic and poured it into my pan. Disgusting. Next."

The next girl stepped up, her bottom lip trembling. Jungkook didn't even chew before swallowing, his face blank. "Not enough salt. It's bland. You managed to kill the animal twice. Next."

He moved down the line like a machine, tearing through their hard work with ruthless efficiency.

"Horrible. Your tarragon is bruised and bitter because your knife is dull," he barked at a senior,

pushing the plate back so forcefully it nearly slid off the edge.

"The chicken is rubbery. You pulled it from the heat before the skin could render. Disgusting. Next."

"Sloppy. The sauce is broken. Look at the oil separating on the rim. Horrible. Clean your station and think about why you're wasting my time."

By the time he reached the middle row, the trash bin was half-full, and the air in the kitchen was thick with mutual despair. Finally, a quiet boy from the second row presented a neatly plated dish. Jungkook took a bite, chewed slowly, and didn't spit it out. He let out a rough sigh, tossing his fork onto the napkin.

"Okay," Jungkook muttered, crossing his arms. "But it could be better. The sear is uniform, but you lost the temperature on your reduction. It's thick. Sit down."

The boy practically floated back to his station in relief. Jungkook wiped his hands on his apron, his dark, predatory eyes slowly tracking across the room until they locked onto the next row.

Jimin's row.

"Next," Jungkook rasped, his gaze settling heavily on Jimin.

Jimin let out a long, slow sigh under his breath, his eyes briefly darting to the side to meet Taehyung's gaze. Taehyung gave him a microscopic, tense nod—a silent good luck.

Jimin lifted his porcelain plate, carrying the dish carefully with both hands to keep it perfectly level. He kept his eyes trained strictly forward as he walked down the center aisle, refusing to look at the trash bin or the floor. He could feel the weight of everyone's eyes on him. The whole room was holding its breath, waiting to see if the American had anything to offer.

He reached the front master station and gently set his plate down on the cold steel right in front of Jungkook.

Jungkook didn't grab a fork right away. Instead, he leaned forward, placing his large, tattooed hands on either side of the plate. He tilted his head, his dark eyes slowly and meticulously eyeing the plate. He tracked the height of the wing joint, measured the uniform amber crispiness of the skin, and stared at the glossy, dark circle of the Chasseur sauce.

Finally, Jungkook picked up his silver fork. He flaked off a precise piece of the chicken breast, gathering a bit of the mushroom reduction, and slid it into his mouth.

He chewed slowly.

Jimin's knuckles tightened against each other behind his back, his heart slamming against his ribs.

Jungkook looked up, his dark, unblinking eyes locking directly onto Jimin's face as he finished swallowing. For a second, the kitchen was so quiet you could hear the low hum of the refrigerators.

Then, Jungkook set his fork down with a dull clink. He didn't spit the food out. He didn't yell.

Instead, a terrifyingly calm, unreadable expression washed over his face.

Without breaking eye contact with Jimin, Jungkook reached out and picked up the pristine white towel tucked into his apron. He unfolded it slowly, shook it out, and then casually dropped it flat over the top of Jimin's plate—completely covering the entire dish from sight.

Jimin's breath hitched in his throat. A few students in the rows behind him whispered in confusion.

Jungkook leaned over the table, his massive frame closing the distance between them until Jimin could smell that thick, heavy scent of woodsmoke and leather. He rested his hands back on the counter, staring right into Jimin's eyes.

"The execution of the breakdown was acceptable. The sear was correct. The balance of the acidity in the sauce..." Jungkook paused, his voice dropping into a raspy, quiet register meant only for Jimin. "Was exactly what I asked for."

Jimin's heart did a sudden, hopeful leap—

"But," Jungkook continued smoothly, a cold, ruthless smirk stretching across his lips as he tapped the covered plate with one blunt finger. "I do not serve food to people who think they are too good to taste their own creation. You did not test your dish before you finished it. You guessed. You relied on luck, and then you fixed it only because I forced my hand into your dish."

Jungkook stood back up to his full height, his expression turning entirely icy as he looked out over the whole classroom.

"This kitchen is not a casino. I do not grade gamblers," Jungkook announced, his voice echoing sharply against the tile. He looked back down at Jimin, his eyes glinting with a humiliating, dominant cruelty. "Leave it covered. Take it back to your station. You will stand there for the rest of the period and look at a white cloth instead of your work, so you can remember exactly what happens when you let your pride do the cooking. Move."

Jimin stood frozen, his mouth opening slightly as he stared at the white cloth draped over his hard work.

With a slow, dismissive flick of his wrist, Jungkook slid the covered plate across the stainless steel toward him, his dark eyes fixed on Jimin, expecting him to grab it and slink back to his station like a dog with its tail between its legs.

But Jimin's feet felt like they were glued to the floor. The humiliation was a hot, heavy pressure in his chest, but beneath it, the sheer injustice of it made his voice crack.

"I'm s-sorry, Chef, but..." Jimin stammered, his hands coming out from behind his back. He looked up, forcing his eyes to lock with Jungkook's. "...does this mean I failed?"

A ripple of low, shocked murmurs broke out among the students behind him.

No one questioned the Chef.

No one pushed back.

Jungkook tilted his head, his chest expanding as he let out a short, breathy laugh that was entirely devoid of warmth. He leaned forward, resting his forearms on the counter, a dripping, sarcastic smirk twisting his lips.

" Ah, parce que tu t'attendais à une médaille d'or, peut-être? " Jungkook asked, the words rolling out slow, smooth, and laced with absolute mockery. He paused, letting the words hang in the air before adding in English, his voice dropping into a raspy whisper: "You did not follow the discipline of a true Chef. A beautiful corpse is still a corpse, Américain . Go back to your station."

Jimin's jaw clenched so hard it ached.

Suddenly, Taehyung's voice from yesterday flashed vividly in Jimin's mind.

"I think maybe he sees you as Une bonne poire..."

The realization hit Jimin like a slap to the face. He was being an absolute suck up right now. He was standing here, wide-eyed and desperate for approval, letting this bitchy man treat him like a piece of soft, easily manipulated fruit. Jungkook wanted this reaction. He was pushing the buttons on purpose just to watch him fumble and stress.

A sudden, fierce wave of offense and pure anger replaced the embarrassment in Jimin's veins. His ears burned, but his posture went rigid. He didn't look down at the floor, and he didn't apologize again.

Without a single word, Jimin snatched the covered plate off the counter. He gripped the porcelain tightly, his knuckles turning stark white, and turned on his heel. He marched back down the center aisle, his head held high and his spine straight as an arrow, refusing to let the heavy, predatory gaze of Chef Jeon see him falter for even a single step.

Despite the fierce spark of anger keeping his spine straight, a hot, suffocating prickle burned behind Jimin's eyelids. He felt like crying as he made his way back to his table, the humiliation thick and heavy in his throat. A few students along the aisle were visibly taken aback, their mouths dropping slightly at the sheer, blatant attitude Jimin was throwing toward the Director.

The second he reached his station, Jimin slammed his covered plate down onto the stainless steel. The sharp, loud clatter echoed like a gunshot through the silent room. He immediately locked his hands behind his back and stared dead forward, his eyes fixed rigidly on the far white wall, trying to blink away the moisture.

He didn't see it, but he felt the sudden shift in the room's temperature. Out of the corner of his eye, Jungkook's silhouette moved swiftly. The chef marched down the aisle, his strides cutting through the space with terrifying speed.

Before Jimin could even process the movement, Jungkook lunged forward, ripped the covered plate off the station, and slammed it directly into the heavy plastic trash bin with a violent, deafening thud . The white cloth flew off, and the beautifully plated chicken vanished into the bin.

Jimin kept his eyes locked forward, his jaw clenched so hard his teeth ground together.

"You do not slam plates in my kitchen, américain !" Jungkook roared, stepping directly into Jimin's space. The heavy, suffocating scent of him in waves. "Maybe at your diner being mediocre was normal, but in France we do not do half-assed! We respect the tools! We respect the craft!"

With every single word, Jungkook's accent grew thicker, harsher, vibrating with a volatile, unbridled fury. Jimin flinched, his shoulders dropping a fraction. Every single eye in the kitchen was glued to them now; the air was so thin it felt impossible to breathe.

"If you want to slam dishes, you can slam them into the garbage! Do I make myself clear?!" Jungkook bellowed, leaning down slightly so he was directly in Jimin's line of sight.

Jimin didn't respond. He couldn't. His throat was entirely closed up, clamped shut by a wave of raw panic. He was too terrified that if he opened his mouth even a millimeter, a sob would rip out instead of words.

Jungkook, still visibly fuming, his chest heaving under his gray apron, narrowed his dark eyes. He leaned in even closer, asking again, much slower, his voice dropping into a lethal, raspy growl. "Do I make myself clear?"

"Y-yes, Chef..." Jimin choked out.

As the words left his lips, a heavy, warm tear finally spilled over, tracking down his flushed cheek in plain sight of everyone in the room. He hated himself for it. He hated how weak it made him look.

Jungkook tilted his head, his gaze tracking the path of the tear with a cold, piercing intensity. "So now you cry? After disrespecting my kitchen? Why?"

Jimin stared straight into those dark, unforgiving eyes, his mind spinning. He wasn't sure if the question was rhetorical or literal. His breath was coming in shallow, ragged hitches.

"I..."

Jungkook crossed his arms over his chest, his jaw set as he waited, offering absolutely no mercy.

"What is the matter?" Jungkook taunted, his voice dropping into a low, mocking drawl. He took a slow step closer, his massive frame towering over the station. "You were loud enough when you were slamming my porcelain. Now you stand here leaking tears like a child who scraped his knee?"

A few students shifted uncomfortably, the tension in the room stretching until it was ready to snap. Jungkook crossed his arms, a cruel, expectant smirk tugging at the corner of his lips. "Tell me. I am waiting. Why are you crying?"

Jimin didn't look up. He didn't fire back, and he didn't try to defend his determination or his hard work. The fierce, angry spark that had kept his spine straight just moments ago completely vanished, crushed under the absolute authority of the man standing over him. He felt incredibly small, incredibly exposed, and entirely exhausted.

Another heavy tear spilled over, catching the bright kitchen light as it tracked down his flushed cheek and dripped onto the silver table. He just let it happen, giving up the fight. He balled his lips

together, his shoulders slumping as he silently accepted his fate.

Jungkook looked down at him, his expression twisting into pure, icy disgust. "Tu ne deviendras jamais rien si tu te comportes comme un putain d'enfant stupide," Jungkook hissed, the venomous syllables cutting through the silence like a razor.

Hearing the harsh, dripping tone, Jimin's eyes involuntarily flicked to the side for a split second. Across the aisle, he caught Eric and his little group of loyal senior friends instantly muffling a laugh behind their hands, clearly enjoying every single second of his public execution. The sting of their quiet amusement hit him like a physical blow, making the hot humiliation in his face burn even worse.

Jungkook didn't send him out for crying to Jimin's utter surprise. Instead, he let out a harsh, dismissive breath, stepped away from Jimin's station, and smoothly turned on his heel. He marched back up to the front master station, his heavy boots echoing sharply against the tile.

He stood behind the main counter his dark eyes sweeping over the entire room.

"You think that being nice will get you far in this industry?" Jungkook began. He didn't look at Jimin, but his posture made it entirely obvious where the lecture was coming from. "Do you think being nice and coddling your fragile feelings will make you survive a dinner service when a hundred tickets are burning on the line? You think a restaurant cares if you are having a bad day?"

Jimin kept his head down, staring rigidly at the stainless steel of his counter. He dug his fingernails hard into the meat of his palms, pressing until it hurt, desperately using the sharp physical pain to try and stop the remaining tears from falling.

"In the real world, Michelin-star chefs will not hesitate to fire you right off the line the second you slip," Jungkook continued, his voice rising in authority. "They will throw your dish in the trash, and they will replace you before the next plate goes out. Being nice does not make you a master. It makes you weak. It makes you a failure. If you cannot handle the weight of real discipline without throwing a tantrum and crying like a child, pack your bags now."

Jimin knew every single word was directed entirely at him, each sentence a deliberate, crushing blow meant to break whatever pride he had left. He kept his jaw locked, his fingers digging deeper into his palms, fighting to stay completely invisible as the chef's brutal lecture echoed through the silent kitchen.

Jungkook rested both of his palms flat against the master counter, leaning forward as his gaze swept across the room one last time.

"By the time you finish in my classroom—mark my words—you will be perfect," he vowed, his low, raspy voice carrying a terrifying weight that seemed to vibrate the very metal of the stations. "You will think perfect. You will expect perfect. You will cook perfect. You will be perfect."

He paused, his eyes cutting directly toward Jimin's row, cold and unyielding.

"Until then, do not think you are above anyone. Do not think your effort deserves a participation trophy when the results are flawed."

Jungkook straightened up to his full height, his expression turning completely indifferent as he checked the wall clock. The heavy aroma of seared poultry and caramelized tarragon still hung like a thick cloud over the students, but the energy in the room had been entirely drained.

"Tonight... some of you really need to look in the mirror and think: Am I meant to be a chef? "

He picked up a white towel, wiping his hands with slow, deliberate movements before tossing it onto the stainless steel.

"Class dismissed. You can check your module to find your grade."

The absolute silence broke into a frantic, muted flurry of motion as students immediately began clearing their stations. Jimin didn't look up. He kept his fingers dug tightly into his palms for a fraction of a second longer, letting the sting ground him, before he finally released his grip and began wiping down his silver table with trembling hands, the chef's brutal words still ringing in his ears.



Jimin sat curled up on the edge of his bed, his knees pulled tightly against his chest. His eyes, raw and swollen from hours of silent, heavy weeping, were glued to the bright screen of his phone resting on the blanket in front of him.

The screen displayed a single contact page: *Mom* .

He had been staring at those three letters for a solid hour, completely frozen. His thumb hovered over the green call icon, his hand trembling so violently he had to rest his wrist against his knee to steady it. Fresh, warm tears spilled over his lower lashes, tracking down his already stained cheeks and dripping onto his damp shirt.

He wanted to press it.

God, he wanted to press it so badly.

In his head, he had already rehearsed the conversation a hundred times. The moment she answered, he would sob into the receiver, tell her how horrible it was, how much he hated the pressure, and beg her to book him the very first flight out of France by morning. He wanted to go home. He wanted the familiar, comforting routine of his old life back. He wanted to wake up tomorrow and pretend this entire humiliating nightmare had never happened.

But his thumb stayed paralyzed in the air.

If he called her crying, if he gave up and caught a flight back home, he would have to look her in the eye and admit he couldn't do it. He would have to face his dad, and his grandma, and see the quiet disappointment or the pity in their faces after they had celebrated him coming all this way.

And then there was Mr. Frank. The thought of Mr. Frank made Jimin's chest ache with a sharp, suffocating guilt. Mr. Frank had been the one who saw something in him, the one who encouraged him to reach for something bigger than flipping burgers and wiping down greasy counters. Mr. Frank had put his faith in Jimin's talent. Going home meant proving that Mr. Frank's belief in him had been wrong.

Most of all, Jimin knew he would never be able to forgive himself. If he packed his bags and ran away because Chef Jeon, he would be letting himself down. He would be proving Jungkook right proving that he was just a soft, mediocre pear that threw tantrums and cried when things got too hard.

Was he meant to be a chef?

Jimin let out a tired, wet scoff into the quiet room.

Of-fucking-course he was.

There wasn't a single doubt in his bones, no matter how hard Chef Jeon tried to beat it out of him. He loved the rush, he loved the food, and he loved the art of it too much to let one terrifying man strip it away from him.

He let his phone slip from his hand, rolling onto his back and staring blankly up at the ceiling. He pulled his heavy yellow blanket up to his chin, wrapping himself tightly in it like a cocoon. He had been lying here like this for most of the evening, completely paralyzed by the exhaustion of the day.

The other half of his day had been spent down in the academy dining hall, where he had aggressively eaten away his pain. He had coped by shoveling a mountain of pesto pasta down his throat, followed by two mystery pastries he couldn't even name but tasted like pure, buttery sugar.

While he had been down there, though, the comfort food had come with a side of intense awkwardness. The moment he walked into the dining hall, the entire room had gone noticeably quiet. The low hum of clinking forks and chatter had completely died down, dozens of eyes tracking him as he grabbed his tray.

It was clear he had made quite the impression on his second day. Calling out the Director and getting his plate violently slammed into the trash wasn't exactly a low-profile move. They probably all thought he was a total idiot now—just a soft, easily bruised pear waiting to get squeezed out of the program by the end of the week.

"God," Jimin groaned out loud at the thought, a wave of fresh embarrassment washing over him.

He flipped back over, burying his face directly into his pillow to muffle the sound of his own frustration. He could still taste the lingering hint of pesto and sugar, but beneath it, his jaw still ached from how hard he'd ground his teeth together in the kitchen. They could think whatever they wanted. He was still here, he was still breathing, and tomorrow he was going to have to walk right back into that lion's den.

Part of him—the embarrassed, bruised part currently suffocating under a yellow blanket—never

wanted to step foot inside that kitchen again. He wanted to change his name, delete his socials, and disappear deeper into the French countryside where words like Chasseur and demi-glace couldn't hurt him.

The other part of him, the fiery, stubborn diner cook, wanted to march into class tomorrow, cook the absolute fuck out of whatever ingredient Jungkook threw at them, plate it with flawless, godly precision, and tell Chef Jeon he could shove his Michelin stars where the sun doesn't shine.

Both options were incredibly, wildly unrealistic.

He rolled onto his side, pulling the blanket tighter around his shoulders. There was no grand cinematic revenge waiting for him tomorrow, and there was no easy escape. The only realistic option was the hardest one: he had to go back, swallow his pride, keep his mouth shut, and let his cooking do the talking until Jungkook couldn't find a single damn thing to complain about.

Except that was exactly the problem: keeping a low profile and letting his cooking do the talking was nearly impossible when he was already a walking target.

Jimin stared at the shadows stretching across his bedroom wall, the reality of his situation settling heavily in his gut. He wasn't just another faceless student in a white chef's coat anymore. He was the American kid who had caught the Director's attention on day one, and the one who had just sustained a brutal, tearful public execution in front of the entire class.

Too bad God had blessed the man to be so fucking hot.

It was an undeniable, infuriating fact known amongst the entire student body. Most of the academy crushed on Chef Jeon, guys and girls alike, because objectively, the man was a walking heart throb. But he was just so scary that most people were too afraid to even let their minds wander down that path for long. One glare from him was enough to shrivel anyone's crush.

Jimin wasn't blind to it either. He had eyes. He could admit that Chef Jeon was devastatingly handsome, but whatever appeal the man had took a brutal, catastrophic hit the second he opened his mouth.

What good was a pretty face when it was attached to a volatile person who got off on humiliating people? A nice face didn't make up for the fact that he treated his students like shit on the bottom of his boots.

Still, the vivid memory of Jungkook's dark, unblinking eyes tracking him as he held out that silver spoon caused an entirely unwarranted, furious blush to creep up Jimin's neck and stain his cheeks as he lay there in the dark.

Those eyes were like a laser, always pinning Jimin right to his spot, stripping away every ounce of his defenses until he felt completely bare. It was so ridiculously overwhelming, the sheer, heavy physical presence of the man.

Jimin closed his eyes, his mind betraying him as it replayed the moment over again. He could practically feel the warmth of the white wine reduction hitting his lips again, could still smell the sharp, intoxicating scent that seemed to follow the chef everywhere. In the quiet of his room, he imagined the ghost of that faint smirk tugging at the corner of the man's lips.

Maybe he had imagined it all. Maybe his brain was just frantically filling in the gaps, the psychological trauma of the last forty-eight hours already getting to his head and making him crazy.

But no.

Deep down, beneath the anger and the humiliation, Jimin knew what he had seen.

He knew he saw it.

That tiny, deeply amused look. It was the exact same patronizing, knowing expression that Taehyung and almost everyone else gave him anytime he opened his mouth.

Jungkook didn't just think he was an amateur; he thought he was a joke.

With one last deep, steadying breath, Jimin closed his eyes and let the heavy silence of the night take over, cementing a promise to himself.

Tomorrow was a whole new day.



Jimin stood at his station, his fingers tightly gripping the edge of his stainless-steel counter. He and Taehyung hadn't spoken much since yesterday's disaster. Jimin had fallen completely mute for the most of last night, swallowed whole by an overwhelming wave of embarrassment that even a mountain of pesto pasta couldn't completely cure. This morning, their interaction had been limited to heavy, silent looks of pity exchanged across the room, and Taehyung quietly sliding a flaky croissant onto Jimin's desk before class started as a wordless peace offering. Jimin had eaten it in three desperate bites, but right now, his stomach was back to churning nervously.

The heavy double doors of the practical kitchen swung open with a sharp, familiar clack .

Chef Jeon walked in. He looked as devastatingly sharp as always, his gray apron tied impeccably tight around his waist, a silver clipboard clutched firmly in his hand. The entire room instantly went rigid, the low hum of nervous chatter evaporating into thin air as he began his slow, predatory walk down the rows for morning inspection.

As Jungkook moved down the first aisle, his heavy leather boots clicking rhythmically against the tile, Jimin's eyes darted around the room. He froze, his brow furrowing as he noticed the sudden gaps in the kitchen layout.

The two kids who usually stood the tables right next to his and Taehyung's were completely gone. Their stations stood cold, empty, and stripped of their standard toolkits. Jimin's eyes quickly swept across the rest of the room. Three other students from the far rows were missing, too.

Five gone by day three? Jimin thought, a cold sweat breaking out across his collarbone. Not even a week in, and a quarter of the class had already packed their bags and run home, unable to handle the warfare.

Jimin's heart began to hammer against his ribs as Jungkook's heavy silhouette finally approached his aisle. He braced himself, locking his jaw and staring dead ahead, fully expecting the chef to pull up yesterday's conundrum, or lingeringly taunt him just to see if he'd crack again.

Instead, Jungkook stopped in front of Jimin's station for a fraction of a second.

He didn't say a word.

Jungkook's eyes simply scanned Jimin up and down—checking the crispness of his white coat, the cleanliness of his apron, and the alignment of his knife kit—before moving right along to the next station.

His eyes didn't even meet Jimin's.

Not even for a split second.

Jimin stared rigidly ahead, completely dumbfounded. A small, relieved part of him wanted to celebrate—not being targeted today felt like a massive, unearned victory—but a deeper, more paranoid part of his brain was screaming that this was just the calm before an incredibly vicious storm.

Jungkook walked back up to the front of the room, stopping right in front of his master table. Instead of getting straight to work, he leaned his hip back against the stainless-steel counter, crossing his arms over his chest.

"It seems some took me by my word," he said, his voice echoing effortlessly through the room. He didn't look at the empty stations, keeping his dark gaze trained on the students who had actually survived the cut. "Well... since we are free of the burdens holding us back, let us continue with today's demonstration."

Except, he didn't move. He didn't reach for a frying pan, he didn't pull any fresh ingredients from the walk-in cart, and he didn't grab a single copper pot. He just stood there, his sharp eyes slowly scanning the room, letting the heavy silence stretch until everyone was visibly sweating beneath their chef's hats.

"Since we are short on numbers now," Jungkook continued, a slow, incredibly dangerous grin spreading across his lips, "we will be moving seating around."

Jimin's stomach did a violent flip.

That grin never meant anything good.

"Today's lesson will be line cooking," Jungkook announced.

A few students in the front row instantly perked up, their postures shifting. Line cooking was what they had all been waiting for—the real, fast-paced, high-adrenaline heart of a professional kitchen.

"This is a skill you must learn," Jungkook said, stepping away from the master table and beginning to pace the front floor. "You must know how to work as a team under extreme duress. You need to know how to communicate without wasting breath, how to trust the person next to you, and how to synchronize your timing perfectly so plates go out hot. On a real line, there is no time for individual pride. If one person slips, the entire service crashes into the dirt."

He stopped pacing, his eyes finally landing directly on Jimin's row, that cold, amused glint returning to his gaze.

"And since some of you have a habit of being... unpredictable when things get hot, I will be personally choosing your new line partners to ensure maximum efficiency. Or maximum exposure."

Jungkook began calling out names with a cold, systematic precision, pairing the remaining students into groups of two.

Jimin felt his eyebrows furrow and his chest tightened. He watched anxiously as Taehyung was paired up with a quiet girl from the back row, and then, just a few moments later, Alexandre was assigned to a student across the aisle. His two safety nets were completely gone. Jimin's mind immediately began to spiral into a frantic panic, his fingers twisting into the fabric of his apron beneath the counter. If he was left with one of the seniors who already resented his existence, this line cooking simulation was going to be a living hell.

In the middle of his internal tailspin, a shocking pair of words smacked him harshly across the face.

"Park Jimin and Eric Boucher."

Jimin froze. For a second, he thought he had misheard the chef's heavy French accent. But the sudden, suffocating wave of heat that flooded his bones told him otherwise.

Slowly, involuntarily, Jimin's head turned. Across the aisle, Eric was already staring right back at him. The boy didn't even try to hide his absolute delight; a slow, smug grin pulled at his lips, and his eyes twinkled with mischief.

Up at the master station, Jungkook tapped his silver clipboard against his thigh, his expression completely unbothered—though the faint, knowing glint in his dark eyes suggested this pairing was anything but an accident.

"Move to your new stations," Jungkook commanded, his voice cutting through the stunned silence. "You have two minutes to organize your line before I start. Do not waste my time."

Jimin grabbed his knife kit, lifting the heavy leather roll with a tight, defensive grip, and marched across the aisle to Eric's station.

The boy was already standing there, leaned back casually against the counter with his arms crossed. He cockily watched Jimin's every move, his eyes tracking the slight tremor in Jimin's fingers as Jimin undid the leather straps and rolled out his tools onto the stainless steel. Eric followed suit, undoing his own sleek, professional kit with an easy, effortless confidence that only came from years of being told he was the best.

Jimin kept his eyebrows tightly drawn together, refusing to look intimidated as he lifted his chin and locked eyes with the taller boy.

It was an infuriating reality, but Jimin was easily the shortest guy in the class—because apparently, being over six feet tall was a secret requirement for being French, wealthy, and enrolled in this academy. Standing directly across from Eric, Jimin felt like an ant, and Eric had his expensive leather shoe lifted, just waiting for the perfect moment to squash him into the tile.

Still, Jimin didn't let up. He straightened his spine, threw his shoulders back, and held the mocking gaze with a fierce, burning squint.

"Let us prepare our station," Eric said, a lazy smirk pulling at the corner of his lips, his English words heavy and dripping with his smooth, condescending accent.

Jimin didn't give him the satisfaction of a verbal reply that might betray his nerves. He just let out a sharp, tightly clipped hum in approval, his jaw setting as he grabbed his bench scraper and immediately began wiping down the silver counter between them, ready for whatever psychological warfare Eric—and Jungkook—were about to throw his way.

Jungkook stood tall at the front, his hands resting on his hips as his dark eyes swept over the newly paired stations.

"We will work simple today," Jungkook announced, his deep voice carrying a sharp authority that made everyone stiffen. "Just a simple Caesar salad. One person will emulsify the dressing completely from scratch and fry the garlic croûtons to a perfect golden brown, and the other will hand-tear the Romaine lettuce, shave the parmigiano-reggiano, and slice the grilled chicken breast into uniform strips."

He stepped out from behind the master table, gesturing with a sleek silver-plating tweezer.

"This will show me how well you can follow orders and move quickly. A salad is like a ticking time bomb—it is all about texture and temperature. If the greens are warm, or if the croutons get soggy from sitting in dressing too long, the dish is dead. You need to both be coordinated. Every movement must be synchronized."

He pointed a sharp finger toward the built-in under-counter cooling units at each station.

"Everything you need is in your freezer. This grade will be observation-based. I do not care how good it tastes if your line is messy, your timing is off, and the presentation looks like a dog put it together."

Jungkook checked his watch, a lethal smirk tugging at his lips as he looked up, his eyes briefly passing over Jimin and Eric.

"You have thirty minutes. Begin."

The kitchen instantly exploded into a chaotic, high-stress frenzy of metal slamming and running water.

Eric immediately leaned across the counter, his large frame blocking Jimin's view of the front as he

claimed the primary prep space. "I will do the dressing and the cooking," Eric asserted smoothly, his smug smirk fully intact as he reached down to yank open the refrigeration unit. "A delicate emulsion requires precision, américain . Go wash the lettuce. Try not to bruise it with your heavy hands."

Jimin's blood boiled, his fingers instantly tightening around his chef's knife. Eric was already trying him, treating him like a mindless dishwasher. But with Jungkook's laser eyes patrolling the room, Jimin knew a screaming match would get him kicked out instantly this time.

"Fine," Jimin hissed out through his teeth, throwing his shoulders back to match Eric's arrogant posture as best he could. "Don't burn the garlic, Boucher. I'm not carrying your grade."

Jimin's fingers worked mindlessly as he tore apart the crisp romaine leaves, but his eyes were locked on Eric across the counter.

The boy was moving at a frantic, hyper-aggressive pace, purposefully slamming metal bowls and whisking the egg yolks and anchovies with a violent, performative speed. He was very clearly trying to outpace Jimin, intentionally building up a lead to make it look like he was the one dragging his feet on the line.

"Slow down," Jimin hissed, his eyebrows drawing tight as he frantically tried to start shaving the parmigiano-reggiano while keeping his lettuce pieces uniform. "I haven't even finished the prep yet. We're supposed to coordinate the plating."

"The line waits for no one, américain ," Eric shot back with a smug, breathless chuckle. He tossed a handful of diced bread into a hot skillet with a loud, aggressive hiss of butter. "If you cannot keep up with a simple salad, perhaps you belong back in the dish pit."

Jimin let out a sharp, frustrated huff, his chest heaving. He refused to let Eric rattle him, but the sheer panic of the ticking clock was starting to take its toll. In his rush to match Eric's breakneck speed, Jimin's usual station discipline began to disappear.

A few stray shreds of parmesan spilled onto the cutting board, a discarded core of romaine sat unwashed near his knife kit, and a small pool of water from the rinsed greens pooled near the edge of the metal counter.

Suddenly, the air in their aisle turned heavy, the distinct, suffocating scent cutting through the aroma of frying garlic.

Jungkook was standing right at the edge of their station.

Jimin froze, his heart instantly leaping into his throat. He kept his eyes glued down to his cutting board, his fingers tightening around his knife as he felt the terrifying weight of the Chef's presence looming over them.

Jungkook didn't say a word at first. He just stood there, his eyes slowly tracking the state of the counter. He looked at Eric's perfectly organized side, and then his gaze shifted to Jimin's side.

"Stop," Jungkook ordered.

The command wasn't loud, but it was laced with a lethal, raspy quiet that made both Jimin and Eric instantly drop their tools and snap their hands behind their backs.

Jungkook stepped forward, his heavy boots clicking sharply. He didn't look at Eric. He leaned down slightly, bringing his face right into Jimin's line of sight, his expression a mask of cold, unyielding disgust.

"What did I say about looks?" Jungkook murmured. He pointed a finger at the water on the counter. "Look at this station. It looks like a pig sty. You are rushing, your movements are sloppy, and you are bleeding chaos into my kitchen."

Jimin's jaw clenched, his eyes stinging as he stared at the counter, desperately digging his fingers into his palms behind his back to stop the familiar threat of tears. He wanted to tell him that Eric was purposely trying to sabotage their timing, but he knew Jungkook wouldn't care.

"I do not care how fast your partner is moving," Jungkook hissed, leaning in closer until Jimin could feel the heat radiating off him. "If your station is a mess, your food is trash. Clean this disaster up. If I see one more drop of water on this steel, you are off the line."

"Yes, Chef" Jimin managed to say despite the soul crushing glare he was being thrown. He immediately grabbed a clean blue huck towel and began working frantically to clean his station, wiping down the stray cheese shreds and absorbing the pool of water until the stainless steel was completely clean.

Jungkook watched him for a beat longer, his dark eyes tracking the sharp, tense movements of Jimin's shoulders before he finally let out a low, dismissive grunt and began to step away to check the next aisle.

The second Jungkook's back was turned, Eric let out a quiet, mocking scoff from across the counter.

" *Tellement pathétique*, " Eric muttered under his breath, his voice laced with absolute arrogance as he tossed his golden croûtons in the pan. " *Le petit Américain ne sait pas cuisiner, il sait juste essuyer mes restes.* "

Jimin's hand froze on the towel. The heat in his bones flared into a white-hot spike of pure fury. Instead of reacting Jimin took a deep, shaky breath, forcing his eyes down. He was just going to ignore it. He was going to swallow the insult, keep his mouth shut, and survive the remaining fifteen minutes of the clock.

Except just two steps away from their table, Jungkook stopped dead in his tracks.

The heavy clicking of his leather boots ceased instantly, plunging their section of the kitchen into a suffocating, terrifying stillness. Eric's smug smirk faltered, his wrist freezing mid-toss as the pan went completely silent.

Slowly, Jungkook turned back toward their station.

He didn't look at Jimin. His dark, piercing gaze was locked entirely onto Eric. The cold, indifferent expression the chef usually wore had shifted into something predatory and lethal, his jaw set in a

hard, rigid line as he stepped back into their aisle.

" *Répète ce que tu viens de dire*, " Jungkook murmured. His voice wasn't loud this time; it was a low, terrifyingly smooth purr that made the hairs on the back of Jimin's neck stand straight up.

Eric's smug, arrogant demeanor vanished in an instant. The color rapidly drained from his face, leaving him looking sickly pale under his white chef's hat. He gripped the handle of his skillet so tightly his knuckles turned white, his posture going completely rigid.

"C-Chef..." Eric stammered, his confident French accent completely fracturing into a pathetic, high-pitched stutter. "*Je... ce n'était rien, Chef. Juste une... une plaisanterie.*"

" *Une plaisanterie ?* " Jungkook asked, tilting his head. He stepped closer, leaning his large, tattooed forearms right on the stainless steel counter separating them, bringing his face dangerously close to Eric's. The absolute dominance radiating off the Director was suffocating. " *Tu penses que ma cuisine est un endroit pour faire des blagues, Boucher ? Tu penses que tu es assez doué pour ouvrir ta grande gueule sur ma ligne ?* "

Eric couldn't even look him in the eye. He stared fixedly at Jungkook's apron, his chest heaving as he swallowed hard. "*Non, Chef.*"

"Then look at me," Jungkook hissed, his voice dropping into a lethal, raspy growl that echoed off the tile walls.

Eric slowly lifted his gaze, completely terrified.

Jungkook reached out, his large hand moving with lightning speed as he grabbed the edge of Eric's skillet and ripped it out of the boy's hand, slamming it down onto the cool metal table with a deafening CLANG .

"You think because you are a legacy, because you are trained, you are somehow above the discipline of this kitchen?" Jungkook said, switching back to English so the entire room—including Jimin—could understand every single word of the exchange. "You waste your breath insulting your partner instead of ensuring the timing of your dish. Your croûtons are resting in a pool of grease, your emulsion is starting to separate because you are whisking like a frantic amateur, and your station is completely out of sync."

Jimin held his breath, his eyes wide as he watched.

Jungkook leaned in even closer to Eric, his dark eyes burning. "In my kitchen, arrogance without perfection is a disease. And I do not tolerate infected cooks on my line. If I hear you speak another word that is not a kitchen command, you will be packing your knives and joining the other five cowards who quit this morning. Do I make myself clear?"

"Y-yes, Chef," Eric choked out, his voice trembling violently.

Jungkook let out a harsh, dismissive breath, pushing himself away from the counter. He didn't look at Eric again. Instead, his eyes flicked to Jimin for a fraction of a second—cold and unreadable—before he checked the master clock.

"Ten minutes left," Jungkook bellowed to the entire room, his voice returning to its commanding, authoritative register. "Plate your salads or get a zero for the day!"

They worked in total, suffocating silence for the remaining eight minutes. Eric's untouchable, arrogant pride had completely collapsed, melting into a soft, pathetic pile of slime. He didn't dare look at Jimin, let alone open his mouth; his hands shook slightly as he finished pouring the dressing, all his performative speed completely vaporized by Jungkook's wrath.

Jimin kept his head down and focused entirely on his own prep, but beneath his rigid exterior, he couldn't help but feel a tiny, unexpected spark of gratitude.

With exactly two minutes left on the clock, they began the final plating. Jimin meticulously arranged the beautifully sliced grilled chicken and the crisp, uniform romaine, while Eric carefully tucked the golden croûtons into the greens, his previous smugness replaced by a desperate need to avoid another screaming match.

"Time! Hands behind your backs!" Jungkook's voice boomed through the kitchen.

Jimin and Eric instantly dropped their plating tweezers and stepped back from the station, locking their hands firmly behind their waist.

The heavy, rhythmic click of leather boots sounded down the aisle as Jungkook made his rounds. When he finally arrived at their station, the air grew instantly thick.

Jungkook stood over their plate. The Caesar salad sat beautifully under the bright kitchen lights—the lettuce crisp and perfectly coated, the parmesan shaved into flawless ribbons, and the chicken arranged with mathematical precision.

Slowly, he reached out with one hand, extended a single finger, and hooked the edge of the white ceramic. He spun the plate precisely 180 degrees, checking the symmetry, the height of the greens, and the clean margins of the rim under the bright kitchen lights.

He let go of the plate, straightening up to his full height as his dark eyes flicked over both of them.

"By looks... this is parfait," Jungkook murmured, his voice entirely calm but carrying a rare, undeniable note of approval.

He didn't offer a smile, and he didn't linger to give them a pat on the back, smoothly turning on his heel to move to the next station down the row.

But the second those heavy leather boots moved away, Jimin felt his chest flutter violently. Internally, his brain was doing an absolute, screaming victory lap.

Parfait!!

Jimin kept his hands rigidly locked behind his back, keeping his face completely blank and professional, but he couldn't stop the fierce, triumphant heat blooming in his chest.



The kitchen was filled with the quiet, satisfying clatter of students washing down their stainless steel counters and packing away their tools. For the first time since the academy started, Jimin was packing up his station with a small, genuine smile playing on his lips.

He wasn't ending class on a bad foot. He was pretty sure that if one more disastrous thing had happened to him today, it would have sent him straight into full-blown psychosis. His sanity had been hanging by a single, frayed thread, but that one word from Chef Jeon—parfait—had woven it back together. He carefully wiped down his chef's knife with a dry towel, checking the blade one last time before sliding it into its leather sleeve.

Suddenly, a loud, sharp slap echoed through the room as Jungkook clapped his hands together at the front master table.

"Listen up," Jungkook bellowed, his deep, commanding voice easily cutting through the low hum of the kitchen.

The entire room instantly went rigid. Students froze mid-task, hands suspended over their knife rolls, eyes snapping to the front.

"Before you leave for the weekend, there is a mandatory announcement," Jungkook said, leaning his hip casually against the front counter and crossing his large, tattooed arms over his chest. "Next week, the academy is relocating. We will be taking a mandatory, week-long group trip to the city of Paris to assist with a high-profile culinary banquet."

A collective, quiet gasp rippled through the room.

"The hotel accommodations are fully covered by your tuition, as this is a strictly required curriculum trip," Jungkook continued, his dark, piercing eyes scanning the stunned faces of the class. "While in Paris, you will not just be working the banquet. You will be attending intensive workshops, specialized classes, and learning directly from some of the top Michelin-starred chefs in the country. It is a trial by fire."

Jimin's heart began to hammer a frantic rhythm against his ribs. Paris. A whole week in the culinary heart of the world, away from the suffocating, tense walls of this countryside academy.

"We leave this coming Monday, right after this weekend," Jungkook warned, his voice dropping into that lethal, no-nonsense register that meant absolute business. "Pack accordingly. You will need your full uniform kits, professional attire for the workshops, and enough discipline to last you seven days without breaking. The academy bus will leave from the front gates on Monday morning at 5:00 AM sharp."

He tilted his head slightly, a cold, knowing glint in his eyes. "If I were a smart chef, I would use the kitchen hours to my full potential before we leave. Paris will not tolerate a slow hand."

He straightened up to his full height, looking down at the crowd with a fierce, predatory intensity.

"If you are even one minute late, if you are not standing by that bus at 5:00 AM ready to move, the bus will leave without you. You will be left behind, you will miss the mandatory hours, and you will receive a permanent zero for the entire trip's grade. Do not test me on this. Dismissed."

The kitchen instantly erupted into a frantic, high-pitched frenzy of murmurs and rushed packing.



Chapter 4

Sure enough, Jimin held Jungkook to his word.

Later that same evening, despite Taehyung's persistent requests to stop stressing, to relax, Jimin found himself pulling his chef's uniform back on. He smoothed down the white double-breasted jacket, the stiff fabric comforting against his skin.

Sitting still had never been his strength.

He was itching for something more, the adrenaline from earlier still humming beneath his skin like a wire.

Jimin slipped out of the dorm building just as the late evening sun was dipping low, bleeding across the horizon and painting the sky a deep yellow. The campus was quiet, the usual weekend chatter muffled by the heavy summer air.

As he walked down the gravel path toward the practical kitchen building, his heavy knife roll swinging in his hand, Jimin actually felt a smile tugging at his lips. His chest felt lighter than it had in days. This wasn't class. There was no ticking clock, no looming threat of failure, and most importantly, no terrifying, dark-eyed chef waiting to judge his every breath. The kitchen would be completely empty, entirely his. He could finally just breathe and cook.

Jimin pushed open the heavy double doors, the familiar click of the latch echoing into the cavernous, darkened space. He stepped into the practical kitchen, the cool air smelling faintly of cleaner and lingering herbs.

His mind was buzzing with possibilities. Maybe he'd work on his knife skills, practicing perfect juliennes until his wrist ached.

Maybe he'd focus on his searing skills, getting a pan hot enough to practice achieving that flawless, golden-brown crust. Or maybe he'd just cook something completely new, taking his time to actually taste his own dishes without a specter breathing down his neck.

He walked straight to his station, his shoes squeaking softly against the tile. The row was entirely empty, bathed in the dim, yellow glow of the evening safety lights.

Jimin undid the leather straps of his knife kit, rolling it out with a satisfying thud onto the cool metal counter. With no class in session, a burst of curious energy overtook him.

He began wandering around the massive kitchen, his fingers trailing along the steel as he opened drawers, peeked into the heavy walk-in freezers, and stepped into the dry pantry.

His eyes went wide in pure wonder. The shelves were stocked with ingredients he had never heard of or seen in his life back home—strange, dried mushrooms, premium oils, and jars of spices with labels he couldn't even begin to translate.

After a few minutes of exploring, he decided to keep it simple. He grabbed a few eggs, some cured

ham, and some fresh spinach. He was going to cook his absolute favorite comfort food—a classic omelet—while simultaneously using the time to practice and perfect his knife skills.

Jimin gathered the eggs and a beautiful, thick slab of ham from the freezer. When he reached the produce bins, he hunted around until he found a leafy green that looked incredibly close to spinach. He grabbed a handful of the vibrant leaves, a determined smile on his face as he carried his haul back to his station, ready to get to work.

Jimin became completely enthralled in his own little world. He hummed a low, comforting melody under his breath, flipping open his notebook to look over the notes he had taken on Jungkook's demonstrations.

"Keep the fingers curled... anchor the blade against the knuckles..." Jimin mumbled the instructions out loud to himself, his voice soft in the empty room. He picked up his chef's knife, positioning his hand over the pile of green leaves, ready to slice them into a neat chiffonade.

Then he smelled it.

Before he heard footsteps.

Before he saw anyone.

A warm, familiar scent drifted through the kitchen.

Sandalwood.

Rich and subtle, mixed with something darker—something that instantly caused him to freeze.

Jimin's quiet humming slowly faded.

The knife in his hand stopped moving.

For a moment, he remained frozen, almost convinced his mind had simply imagined it.

Slowly, his eyes lifted from the cutting board.

Jungkook was standing right at opening of the kitchen. For a fraction of a second, the man looked slightly startled, clearly not expecting to find anyone else in the room. Then, almost instantly, his eyes narrowed and darkened.

He wasn't in his usual kitchen attire. There were no chef's whites, no apron, no clipboard. Instead, he wore a fitted gray shirt stretched across his broad shoulders and chest, the fabric following every movement as he stepped into the room. His black slacks were perfectly pressed, making him look polished even without the intimidating uniform he normally wore.

For the first time, a pair of sleek, wire-rimmed glasses sat on the bridge of his nose, his dark eyes squinting slightly behind the frames as he processed Jimin's presence.

Jimin felt his brain entirely short-circuit. He was pretty sure that if he opened his mouth, saliva would just pool out, so he wisely kept his lips pressed tightly together. His spine straightened

instinctively, his hands snapping to his sides as a fierce, sudden heat crawled rapidly up the skin of his neck.

"You startled me," Jungkook said after a second as he stepped fully into the room.

Jimin blushed, his hands squeezing into tight fists at his sides as he tried to process the sight of his teacher in casual clothes and glasses. "Oh... s-sorry, Chef..."

The man let out a low hum, dismissively waving off the apology as he walked closer. "Omelet?" Jungkook asked once he stepped over, his eyes scanning the ingredients laid out on the stainless steel.

Jimin's chest tightened, but he forced a tiny, nervous smile. "Yes, actually... I wanted to practice my knife skills, and I was kinda hungry, so I thought, why not kill two birds with one stone?" Jimin smiled faintly, hoping for a nod or a grunt of approval, but when he looked up, Jungkook was just blinking at the counter, his lips pressed into a hard, tight line. He stared at the leafy greens Jimin had proudly gathered, his eyebrows drawing together.

"Why do you have mâche?" He asked, his voice deadpan as he pointed a sharp finger at the green leaves. "If you cook that into an omelet, it will turn into a bitter, soggy paste. It will make the entire dish taste terrible."

Jimin's smile instantly vanished, a wave of heat crawling straight up his neck to his ears. He looked from Jungkook's stern face down to the leaves. "Oh... I thought it was spinach..." He trailed off miserably, his voice growing smaller and smaller as the man stepped even closer.

Jungkook didn't say a word as he walked across the dim kitchen toward the large produce fridge. Jimin stayed completely frozen at his station, his heart pounding a frantic rhythm against his ribs as he watched the Director casually open the heavy door and pull out a crisp, fresh box of baby spinach.

Jungkook walked back, setting the container down on the stainless steel with a soft thud.

Then, he just stood there. Right next to Jimin.

He tucked his hands into the pockets of his black slacks, his dark eyes fixed entirely on Jimin, waiting.

The silence stretched, thick and heavy under the yellow lights. Jimin's throat felt completely dry. He cleared it nervously, shifting his weight as the pressure of Jungkook's expectant gaze began to make his skin tingle.

"Well?" Jungkook asked after a heavy, suffocating beat.

Jimin jumped, his shoulders flinching as he quickly picked his chef's knife back up. Desperate to break the tension, he flipped open the fresh box of spinach, grabbed a generous handful of the crisp green leaves, and dumped them onto his cutting board. He immediately began mincing them into smaller pieces, the rhythmic chop-chop-chop of the blade against the wood providing a brief shield.

Now, Jimin was absolutely not one for awkward silence. He hated it. It made him feel suffocated,

like the air was being slowly sucked out of the room, especially with a Michelin star chef looming inches away. So, like any normal person trying to survive a tense moment, he blurted out the first question that popped into his head.

"Do you like omelets?"

Jungkook lifted a single brow, not moving an inch. He remained leaning slightly against the table, his dark eyes tracking the movement of Jimin's knife. "When made perfectly, yes."

Jimin beamed, a shy, involuntary smile creeping onto his face as he kept cutting. He couldn't help it; the tiny bit of conversation made him feel slightly safer. But the problem was, Jimin also had a terrible habit of oversharing when he was nervous. It was probably a horrible defense mechanism, and once he started, he couldn't stop the words from spilling out.

"M-my mom, she taught me how to make them when I was little," Jimin murmured, his pace slowing just a bit as the memory softened his expression. "Except back then, I didn't like spinach because I thought it was slimy and gross. But even then, every single time she made one for me, I still thought it was the best thing ever... I actually—"

Jimin suddenly caught himself and looked up, the sentence dying on his tongue.

Jungkook was just staring down at him, his jaw set, his dark eyes flickering behind his lenses with something dangerously close to annoyance at the sudden rambling—but there was something else swimming in his gaze, too. Something intense, heavy, and entirely unreadable that made the breath catch completely in Jimin's throat.

"Sorry," Jimin whispered, his cheeks burning as he snapped his eyes back down to the cutting board. He gripped the handle of his knife a little tighter, utterly mortified by his own big mouth. Stupid, stupid, stupid, he scolded himself internally, his blade coming down a little too fast, a little too reckless on the pile of spinach.

Instead of responding to the rambling, Jungkook just slowly lowered his head, his eyes tracking down the length of Jimin's arm until they landed squarely on his fingers.

"Your thumb is too high," Jungkook noted. His voice wasn't harsh, but it was incredibly flat, the observation hanging in the quiet air between them like a physical weight. "If you keep that angle, you will slice the tip of your finger right into the pile."

Jimin froze.

He looked down and realized Jungkook was right—in his nervous fluster, his grip had completely slipped from the proper claw position.

"Fix it," Jungkook commanded softly, his dark eyes boring into the side of Jimin's face.

Jimin swallowed hard, keeping his head dropped as he tried to adjust his hand on the spine of the blade. But the pressure of Jungkook standing right there, watching his every microscopic movement made his hands go completely stiff. He tried to force his fingers into the new, awkward angle, but his grip faltered, his palm slick with nervous sweat.

The heavy silver handle slipped right out of his fingers. The knife dropped onto the cutting board with a loud, mocking CLATTER .

Jimin's heart stopped. He stared at the fallen utensil, utterly mortified.

"This is a basic skill. The absolute foundation in a kitchen. Pick it up." Jungkook said, a low, judgmental rumble vibrating in his chest

Jimin scrambled to grab the handle, his chest tight as he gripped it again. He desperately forced his knuckles to curl inward, anchoring the flat of the blade against them, trying to mimic the textbook diagrams perfectly.

"Like this?" Jimin asked, looking up expectantly, his eyes wide and pleading for a shred of validation.

Jungkook didn't respond. He didn't nod, and he didn't offer a single word of instruction. He just stared down at Jimin's clumsy stance with an unblinking, heavy gaze, looking at him as if he were a dumb, helpless child who couldn't even tie his own shoes.

Without a word, Jungkook leaned his body forward, his height allowing him to completely shadow Jimin's workspace. He reached his right arm across the front of Jimin's chest to grab his hand, completely enveloping Jimin's smaller, trembling fingers where they gripped the knife handle.

Jungkook's skin was blisteringly hot, his palm rough and callused from years in professional kitchens.

"In Paris, the chefs will eat you alive if you ask too many questions," Jungkook said as his hands began fixing Jimin's grip. He didn't sound angry, just intensely focused, his fingers working smoothly and efficiently. "They don't have time to hold your hand. Holding a knife should be as natural as breathing. It should be easy."

As he spoke, his movements were incredibly precise. He adjusted the tilt of Jimin's wrist with a firm twist, correcting the angle of his forearm. His fingers slid down, gently but unyieldingly forcing Jimin's index finger and thumb to pinch the base of the blade correctly, curling his remaining fingers tightly around the smooth silver handle.

Then, keeping his right hand locked over Jimin's knife hand, Jungkook reached his left arm across to lightly tap the knuckles of Jimin's opposite hand, forcing those fingers to curl tightly inward into a flawless, defensive claw over the fresh spinach leaves.

"This is the anchor," Jungkook murmured.

He moved closer until he was standing directly beside Jimin, their bodies pressed together side by side. The space between them disappeared as Jungkook adjusted his stance, positioning himself so he could see the cutting board clearly. Because of his height, he had to bend slightly, lowering his head uncomfortably close to the side Jimin's face, close enough that Jimin could feel his presence more than he could think about it.

Without warning, Jungkook took control of Jimin's hand.

He guided it down toward the bunch of spinach, steadying his grip with firm, practiced pressure. Jimin's fingers followed his lead as Jungkook positioned the blade correctly, setting the angle with slow precision.

"Watch," Jungkook said quietly, his voice low and focused.

Then he moved Jimin's hand forward in a controlled motion. It was smooth and painfully slow.

The knife sliced cleanly through the spinach with effortless precision. The sharp steel tapped softly against the cutting board with each controlled pass, the sound steady and precise in the quiet kitchen.

Jimin could feel everything.

The pressure of Jungkook's hand guiding his own.

The exact angle of the blade.

The way the motion stayed consistent from start to finish, never rushing, never wavering.

"Do you feel the difference?" he asked.

Because he was leaning down so low to guide the motion, the question felt like a low, raspy whisper directed straight into Jimin's ear, the hot puff of his breath sending a wave of goosebumps cascading down Jimin's neck.

Jimin's mouth opened, but absolutely nothing came out. His vocal cords felt entirely paralyzed. Jesus, he wished Hobi could see him now. His loud, dramatic best friend would probably be screaming, but Jimin was currently fighting for his actual life, trying not to completely collapse under the chef's intense, intoxicating control.

Jimin swallowed hard, forcing a small breath into his lungs as he gave a tight, frantic nod. "Mmh," he hummed in soft approval, the sound caught in the back of his dry throat.

Jimin turned his head slightly, his eyes tracking the movement as Jungkook finally slid his hands away. The sudden loss of that blistering heat left Jimin's skin feeling instantly cold. But even though the physical touch was gone, the heavy tension didn't snap. Jungkook didn't move an inch. He remained standing pressed side by side with Jimin, his upper arm still resting against Jimin's shoulder.

His own eyes were fixed entirely on Jimin. They were intense, unblinking with a hint of something that Jimin couldn't quite place—a lingering, sharp scrutiny that felt dangerously close to a challenge.

"Now," Jungkook said, his voice dripping in annoyance. "If I see you holding it incorrectly again, I will be very displeased."

Jungkook finally straightened back up to his full height. The sudden shift of his frame made the cool kitchen air rush back in between them, but the weight of his threat hung heavily over the cutting board, leaving Jimin completely breathless under his gaze.

"Continue," Jungkook said, as if he were losing patience with how easily Jimin could be thrown off balance.

Jimin cleared his throat nervously, his fingers scrambling to fix his grip exactly the way Jungkook had just showed him. He curled his knuckles, anchoring the flat of the heavy blade securely against them. Beside him, the man let out a low, approving hum as Jimin moved the knife over to the thick slab of ham.

With his hand properly aligned, the blade glided smoothly. He diced the ham effortlessly, the uniform cubes falling away into neat piles on the wood. Jungkook's dark eyes followed his every movement, tracking the precise rhythm of the steel. Jimin had originally hoped the kitchen would be completely empty tonight, but a traitorous, quiet part of him now wished Jungkook would never leave. He wished the man would just stay right there, looming over his shoulder, watching him forever.

Trying to shake the intoxicating thought, Jimin turned away from the counter, lifting his cutting board to move over to the nearby stove. Jungkook shifted with him, his heavy steps keeping a slow, deliberate pace right behind.

"I-I... where I'm from, I've only ever cooked on a gas stove, so the electric ones here are kinda tricky..." Jimin began, his fingers reaching for the dial to turn on the burner. He was right back to his nervous rambling, his brain completely short-circuited and flustered from the lingering heat of their contact. "Not that I don't love these! I do, they're great!" Jimin continued quickly, his voice a little too high as he dumped the diced ham and the perfectly julienned spinach into the pan. His eyebrows furrowed with deep focus as he kept talking, desperately trying to fill the suffocating silence. "But with gas, it's just so—"

During his frantic rambling, Jimin was so focused on trying to look competent and talk his way through the nerves that he didn't even realize he had turned the wrong dial. The burner underneath an empty, dry skillet was rapidly glowing a dangerous, angry red, while the pan containing his carefully prepped spinach and ham sat cold.

Before the smell of burning metal could even hit the air, a large, shadow loomed over his shoulder.

Jungkook reached in. Without a single word, his forearm brushed firmly against Jimin's side as his hand snapped out. His fingers gripped the plastic dial, clicked the searing hot burner completely off, and smoothly twisted the correct knob, bringing it to a perfectly controlled, medium-low heat.

He didn't yell. He didn't even sigh this time. He just left his hand resting on the edge of the counter, silently waiting for the boy to realize just how distracted he really was.

Jimin laughed nervously, a high, breathless sound that trapped itself in the back of his throat as his face burned red. "Oh... th—"

Jungkook rolled his eyes, the sharp motion cutting Jimin off into dead silence.

"You are so busy trying to paint a picture with your mouth that you aren't even looking," Jungkook began, "Gas, electric—the fire doesn't care about your memories. If you don't pay attention to what's in front of you, you will burn the kitchen down before you even start."

Jimin swallowed hard. He felt stupid, his pulse hammering against his ribs as Jungkook's shadow wrapped completely around him.

"Eyes on the pan," Jungkook commanded softly. He took a slow breath. "And stop talking."

"Sorry... Oh... I'll stop talking..." Jimin mumbled, his voice dropping into a tiny, humbled whisper. He quickly ducked his head, his face burning so hot he was certain Jungkook could feel the heat radiating off his skin.

Jungkook let out a final, quiet grunt before finally moving back. He slid his hands comfortably behind his back, gripping his own wrists as he took a single step away, giving Jimin just an inch of breathing room.

Jimin cooked in absolute silence, the only sound in the station being the gentle, comforting sizzle of the ham and spinach rendering in the pan. Even though he was trying his absolute best to look professional, his eyes kept betraying him; he couldn't stop peeking out the very corner of his eye every single time he felt Jungkook shift.

The Director paced slowly, his heavy boots clicking rhythmically against the tile. He walked behind Jimin, his shadow sweeping over the counter as he moved to the opposite side of the station, positioning himself where he could get a much better view of the stove. Jimin's hands shook slightly under the intense scrutiny, but he managed to crack a bit of fresh salt and pepper into the whisked eggs, pouring the bright yellow mixture directly over the sizzling greens.

He carefully lowered the burner, waiting for the edges to set, when he suddenly let out a sharp gasp.

How could he forget the most important element?

Without a word, he abandoned the burner and bolted across the kitchen toward the massive produce fridge. He yanked the heavy door open, grabbed a sharp, rich block of cheddar cheese, and hurriedly rummaged through a nearby utensil drawer until his fingers wrapped around a metal hand-grater. He rushed right back to the stove, quickly twisting the knob to turn the burner up more so the eggs wouldn't stall.

Jungkook was watching his frantic movements with heavily squinted eyes.

Completely focused now, Jimin's tongue poked out just a fraction between his lips in concentration. He brought the block of cheddar down against the metal grater, long, golden shreds raining down into the center of the setting eggs. He kept grating, a little mountain of cheddar forming on the eggs, when he suddenly heard Jungkook let out a low, pained wince beside him.

"Too much cheese," Jungkook rumbled, his voice dripping with judgmental authority.

Jimin turned his head toward him, still grating the block with stubborn, rhythmic strokes. "It's better that way," he insisted, a bright, involuntary smile breaking across his face.

He couldn't help it; cheese made him happy, and the joy of comfort food momentarily overrode his paralyzing fear of the Director. He braced himself, instinctively waiting for Jungkook to immediately yell at him or rip the grater from his hands for ruining the balance of the dish.

But the shout never came. Instead, Jungkook just brought his dark brows tightly together, his mouth twisting into an expression that looked like a complicated mix of absolute culinary disgust and—maybe, just maybe - a tiny sliver of amused approval.

Sensing he had pushed his luck far enough, Jimin finally stopped grating. He set the block down, expertly slid his spatula beneath the set eggs, and flipped the omelet over, folding it into a neat, textbook trifold. With a smooth tilt of his wrist, he slid the steaming, cheese-oozing omelet out of the pan and onto a clean white plate.

"Yay!" Jimin chirped softly, completely forgetting to be professional as he did a tiny, excited bounce, clapping his hands together twice. God, he was so incredibly hungry, and the rich scent of melted cheddar and sautéed spinach was making his mouth water.

Jimin's hands froze mid-clap as the heavy silence of the kitchen rushed back into his ears. He suddenly remembered exactly who was still standing right next to him and turned slowly, the bright smile instantly faltering on his face.

He held the plate out a fraction of an inch, his eyes wide and hopeful. "How'd I do?"

Jungkook's frown deepened, a harsh line carving itself between his dark brows as he looked from the cheese-heavy omelet up to Jimin's expectant face.

"That was not practice," Jungkook said, his voice flat and unforgivingly cold. "That was just cooking. Real practice is agonizing. It is testing. It is repeating the same motion a hundred times until your wrist bleeds and your eyes burn, all to achieve standard perfection. You made a midnight snack because you were hungry."

Jimin's smile vanished completely, his shoulders dropping as a heavy frown pulled at his lips. A sharp sting of disappointment flared in his chest, but beneath it, a sudden spark of determination flared up. He didn't want to just make snacks; he wanted to be excellent. He wanted to survive Paris.

"I... do want to practice though," Jimin said softly, his voice trembling slightly but holding its ground as he looked up into the Director's piercing eyes. "I want to get better. Truly."

Jungkook didn't answer right away. He just crossed his tattooed arms over his chest, the charcoal-gray fabric straining against his biceps as he looked down at Jimin, his expression completely unreadable behind his glasses.

"Hurry and eat," Jungkook commanded, turning his head slightly toward the exit. "I don't have all night."



True to his word, Jungkook didn't let Jimin off easy. The moment Jimin swallowed the last bite of his food, the brief window of comfort slammed shut.

Jungkook stepped back up to the station, his tall frame hovering over the counter as he reached into a nearby crate and grabbed a sleek, hollow bell pepper. He set it down with a heavy thud directly in front of Jimin.

"Brunoise," Jungkook commanded flatly, his dark eyes fixed on Jimin from behind his wire-rimmed glasses. "No skin. I want perfect, millimeter cubes. If the angle of your blade is off by a hair, the skin will tear, and the batch is ruined. Begin."

Jimin's stomach did a nervous flip. A brunoise was tedious enough, but doing it with skin-on peppers required an agonizingly precise, fluid rocking motion. He swallowed hard, adjusted his grip into the flawless claw position Jungkook had just forced into his muscle memory, and brought the blade down.

Crunch.

"Too thick," Jungkook noted instantly, his voice rough beside him. "Again."

Jimin tried to adjust, his wrist trembling slightly under the weight of Jungkook's intense, unblinking scrutiny. He took a breath, sliding the blade forward, but the edge caught on the slick outer skin of the pepper, bruising the flesh instead of slicing it cleanly.

"You're dragging the heel," Jungkook snapped, his tone sharpening. "Lift the wrist. Again."

Crunch. Another uneven cube.

"Again."

"Arrête."

"Too thick."

"Tu sais cuisiner au moins ?"

The repetition quickly became a blur of suffocating pressure. Five minutes turned into twenty. A pile of rejected, mangled pepper scraps on the side of the board grew larger and larger, and with every single mistake, the air in the kitchen grew thicker, colder, and more volatile. Jimin's fingers were growing slick with sweat, his forearm burning from the tension of trying to hold the exact angle Jungkook demanded.

On the next cut, Jimin's focus slipped for a fraction of a second. The knife skidded across the pepper, completely tearing a ragged, sloppy strip of its skin.

"Stop!" Jungkook suddenly yelled, the booming command echoing violently off the walls of the empty kitchen.

Jimin flinched hard, his entire upper body jerking backward as his hands began to tremble violently against the handle of the knife. He froze, his breath catching painfully in his throat, his eyes fixed

blindly on the ruined vegetable. He had never heard the Chef raise his voice like that outside of a crowded classroom. In the quiet kitchen, it felt like a gunshot.

Jungkook let out a long, harsh sigh, his jaw clenching so tightly the muscle ticked. He stepped forward, reached out, and aggressively swept his hand across the cutting board, dumping the entire pile of Jimin's hard work into the scrap bin for what felt like the hundredth time. The loud, empty clatter of the scraps hitting the plastic rang out in the dead silence.

"You're inside your own head," Jungkook said, his voice dropping back into a terrifyingly quiet, frustrated rasp. He straightened up, turning his back to the counter as he ran a hand through his slightly undone dark hair. "We are wasting time. Put the blade down and leave. You clearly aren't getting it tonight."

The words stung worse than the yelling.

Jimin stood completely rooted to the spot, his knuckles white as he gripped the edge of the counter to keep his hands from shaking. A hot, frustrating sting pricked at the corners of his eyes, but he refused to let a single tear fall. He couldn't just walk out like a failure. Not if he wanted to get better. Not when he wanted Jungkook's approval this desperately.

"N-No," Jimin stammered out, his voice small but fiercely absolute in the quiet room. He didn't move an inch toward the door. "No, Chef."

He kept his eyes trained strictly forward, staring blankly at the empty cutting board because he was too terrified to look at the man.

Jungkook stopped mid-stride. He turned around slowly, his expression initially darkening, offended by the blatant defiance of his order. But as he looked at the boy, the rigid tension in his jaw slackened just a fraction. His expression lightened, shifting from pure frustration into a strange, intense curiosity.

"No?" Jungkook said, the word sounding more like a test than a question.

Jimin swallowed hard and finally forced his head to turn, locking his gaze directly with the Director's piercing eyes.

His own eyebrows were tightly drawn together, the pressure behind his eyelids building so rapidly he was pretty sure he might actually cry right then and there. But he fiercely fought the tears back, blinking them away, refusing to let a single one fall.

"Y-you said real practice is r-repetition," Jimin whispered, his vocal cords trembling as he held Jungkook's unblinking gaze. "I want to repeat it until it's... perfect. Please?"

On that last word, Jimin's eyebrows pulled even tighter together, the word slipping out as a soft, breathless plea that sounded dangerously close to begging.

Jungkook stared back. The silence in the kitchen stretched out, thick and heavy, but the Director didn't pull away. Instead, his eyes slowly tracked every single detail of Jimin's expression—taking in the flush on his cheeks, the fierce determination in his furrowed brows, and the desperate, raw sincerity in his gaze.

Jungkook didn't move for a long moment, his eyes continuing to dissect every micro-expression on Jimin's face. Then, slowly, he let out a low breath and cracked his neck to the side, the sharp sound echoing in the quiet kitchen. He hummed and began to round the counter, his steady, unhurried steps bringing him right back into Jimin's space. He never once broke eye contact, keeping Jimin pinned under the weight of his gaze the entire time.

Leaning his frame down, Jungkook reached into the crate, his tattooed fingers wrapping around another smooth, hollow bell pepper. He placed it squarely on the center of the damp cutting board with a soft, definitive thud .

Jimin inhaled shakily, as he forced his trembling fingers to grip the silver handle of the knife. He adjusted his stance, blinked back the blur in his vision, and began cutting again.

He slid the blade forward, trying to channel fluidity, but his hands were vibrating with too much nervous adrenaline. The edge of the steel slipped, tearing a jagged, uneven strip of skin. Fuck.

Jimin's throat tightened. He didn't say a word, quickly shifting his knife to a new, untouched section of the vegetable, desperate to correct himself before the Director could call him out.

"No," Jungkook said flatly.

The low, uncompromising word was the final break. Jimin squeezed his eyes shut, inhaling a jagged, broken breath as the hot, heavy tears he had been fighting so hard finally spilled over his lashes, tracking rapidly down his flushed, burning cheeks.

He stood there entirely frozen over the board, the knife vibrating in his weak grip, completely undone by the suffocating weight of his own failure and the presence of the man standing right beside him.

"Stop crying," Jungkook ordered, the words tumbling out rough and heavy, the thick edges of his accent bleeding heavily into the command.

Jimin choked back a sob, his chest heaving violently against the stiff cotton of his jacket. He lifted the heavy blade with a hand that was vibrating from exhaustion, his vision a blurred, watery mess.

"They will not care about your tears!" Jungkook yelled, his voice booming off the steel panels. "You cannot cry the moment a line gets hot! If you break down like this during a banquet service, they will throw you out of the kitchen and blacklist your name before the appetizers even leave the pass!"

A sudden, sharp bolt of white-hot anger flared through Jimin's chest, completely burning through his fear. His jaw clenched, his teeth grinding together as he glared down at the slick green pepper. The words stung worse than any reprimand. His chest heaved in ragged, angry pants.

"Ne pleure pas comme un enfant, montre-moi ce que tu vaux!" Jungkook hissed from across the table, his voice a low, biting lash that cut right through the hum of the kitchen.

The foreign words, paired with the harsh, booming authority ringing in his ears, made Jimin's brain completely short-circuit. He couldn't think. He couldn't . The pressure was too much, the

suffocating scent of Jungkook was too much, and his hands were vibrating with frantic flurry.

He wanted another fucking omelet. He wanted to go to his bed, bury his face in his pillows, and cry until his lungs ached.

But more than anything, the injustice of it cracked something wide open inside his chest.

"Je perds mon temps à rester debout-"

Before Jungkook could finish his sentence, Jimin's jaw clenched. Driven by a sudden, white-hot burst of pure anger, he lifted his right hand and slammed the heavy chef's knife down onto the cutting board.

The loud, violent *CRACK* of the steel echoing off the wood reverberated through the empty kitchen, slicing right through the Director's lecture.

Jimin snapped his head up, meeting the man's gaze head-on. Jungkook was leaning back against the edge of the opposite prep table, his long legs crossed at the ankle and his arms folded tightly over his chest. He had been watching over the space like an executioner, but the sudden bang of the blade made him freeze mid-breath.

"I-I can't do it if you're gonna yell at me!" Jimin burst out, his voice cracking with a mix of frustration and tears as he stared across the counter. "I... I can't speak French, I know, and I'm sorry! I'm trying, but I can't work if you yell!"

The final word hung heavily in the dead silence of the kitchen.

What followed was a brutal, agonizing stare-off. Neither of them moved a single inch. Jimin stood his ground, his shoulders squared and his chest heaving in ragged, angry pants against the stiff cotton of his chef whites. His brows were tightly furrowed, and though hot, heavy tears were actively spilling from his eyes and tracking down his flushed cheeks, his gaze didn't waver. He was crying, but he was entirely defiant.

Across from him, Jungkook's eyes were wide and completely unforgiving behind his glasses. He didn't blink. He just stared down at the smaller boy, his jaw clenching so tightly that the muscle ticked under his sharp jawline. The booming command had died right in his throat, replaced by a dangerous, quiet intensity that seemed to suck all the air out of the room.

The tension stretched between them, coiled so tight and hot it felt entirely intoxicating. Jungkook's gaze slowly drifted down to the knife on the board, then slid back up to track the path of a single tear dripping off Jimin's chin.

Slowly, deliberately, Jungkook uncrossed his arms. He pushed himself off the opposite table. He didn't look angry anymore—he looked entirely focused, his eyes locking back onto Jimin's as he began to walk slowly around the perimeter of the island, closing the distance between them with heavy, unhurried steps.

Jimin's heart hammered a frantic rhythm against his ribs, his breath catching in his throat, but he stubbornly refused to drop his head as the Director stepped right into his space.

"I'm sorry," Jimin breathed out, the words a fractured whisper in the room.

"Shut up," Jungkook rumbled.

The command came out softer than Jimin expected—not a shout, but a low sound that felt dangerous in the quiet space between them.

"You Américains are so obsessed with equal rights and holding hands and peace and it's all bullshit," Jungkook muttered, his thick accent wrapping around the bitter words. He leaned down just a fraction, his glasses catching the low yellow light. "Well, let me remind you of something. I am your teacher, and you are my student. There is a hierarchy here, and I hold more power than you know."

Jimin stared up at him, his chest still heaving in shallow pants.

"Your attitude and slamming stuff in my kitchen will get you expelled quicker than you can spell it," Jungkook continued, his eyes narrowing into an unforgiving, sharp line. "Do you think guests paying thousands of euros for a plate care if the chef is being too loud or too mean?"

Jimin stared back, the heat in his face burning a deeper, agonizing red. Slowly, helplessly, he shook his head.

"Speak," Jungkook commanded sharply.

Jimin's eyes flickered away for a split second, desperate for an escape, before snapping right back to lock with the Director's piercing gaze. "N-no, Chef."

"So, why should I?"

Jimin inhaled a shaky, uneven breath, the rich scent of sandalwood completely clouding his head. "I... I don't know."

"Exactly," Jungkook rumbled, his voice dropping into a dark, gravelly friction. "So do not tell me what I can or cannot do. I do not care about your feelings. I care about your compliance."

As the words left his mouth, Jungkook's dark, intense gaze suddenly dropped down to Jimin's lips. It was incredibly fast—a brief, heavy beat where his eyes traced the soft, parted curve of Jimin's mouth—but Jimin caught it.

The sudden shift in gravity made Jimin's stomach drop completely, a dizzying jolt of electricity snapping straight down his spine as he realized exactly how thin the line between discipline and desire had just become for him.

"I'm sorry," Jimin whispered again, the words slipping out as a breathless plea against the suffocating space between them.

Jungkook's broad chest puffed out a bit as he took a slow, heavy breath, his eyes glaring down at the smaller boy with a lingering, intense scrutiny. For a second, it felt like the heavy gravity in the room might pull them even closer.

"Pick up your knife," Jungkook commanded as he stepped back just an inch. "Focus."

Jimin swallowed the lump in his throat and nodded quickly, his fingers scrambling down to wrap around the silver handle. His hand was still vibrating from the adrenaline, but as he looked at the fresh bell pepper under the low lights, something shifted. The panic was gone, replaced by a desperate, hyper-aware focus. He couldn't mess up again.

Not after that.

He curled his left hand into a flawless, tight claw against the vegetable, anchoring the flat of the heavy steel against his knuckles.

"Wrist up," Jungkook murmured beside him, his gaze tracking every single millimeter of the blade. "Do not drag the heel. Fluid."

Jimin inhaled a shaky breath, letting Jungkook's guidance anchor him. He brought the blade down, rocking the steel forward in a smooth, calculated arc.

Click.

The knife slid effortlessly through the pepper, slicing the skin cleanly without a single tear. Jimin didn't hesitate this time. Driven by the intense, pinning weight of the Director's eyes, his wrist moved in a rhythmic, steady blur. Click-click-click-click. He shaved the pepper into paper-thin julienne strips, then turned them, rocking the blade with absolute precision.

"Good. Keep that angle," Jungkook rumbled, his voice low. "Don't rush. Let the knife do the work."

Jimin kept his eyes locked on the board. With every stroke, the uniform cubes fell away into a neat, pristine mountain on the wood. No bruised flesh. No ragged edges. Every single piece was an identical, perfect millimeter jewel of a brunoise.

When the last cut was made, Jimin smoothly wiped the side of the blade against the board and finally let out the breath he had been holding. He looked down at the flawless pile, his heart still hammering a frantic rhythm against his ribs, before slowly tilting his head up to meet the Director's gaze.

Jungkook didn't look right away. He slowly lowered, leaning forward slightly to inspect the pile of immaculate, glittering green cubes. He didn't look at the board for long, though; within seconds, his dark eyes slid sideways, locking onto Jimin's face.

The silence that settled over the kitchen was entirely different from the suffocating tension of before. It was quieter, and dizzyingly heavy.

"*Parfait*," Jungkook murmured.

Jimin's chest gave a small, uneven hitch. He stood entirely frozen, the heavy chef's knife still held loosely in his grip, his hand resting flat against the stainless-steel counter.

Jungkook slowly straightened up to his full height, but he didn't step back. Instead, his gaze lingered, tracking the faint, damp path where Jimin's tears had finally dried against his flushed

skin. Behind the sleek frames of his glasses, his eyes were incredibly dark, intense, and unblinking.

Jimin felt his tongue dart out to wet his lower lip—a nervous, instinctive habit—and Jungkook’s eyes instantly dropped to follow the movement. The Director's jaw tightened as his gaze held on Jimin's mouth for one, two, three agonizingly long beats.

The air felt entirely too hot, the yellow lights casting long, intimate shadows across the floor. Jimin’s pulse hammered a frantic rhythm against his ribs, his breath turning shallow. He found himself tilting his chin up just a fraction of an inch, completely mesmerized, helplessly waiting for... something.

But nothing came.

Jungkook just let out a slow, heavy breath that fanned warm against Jimin's skin. Slowly, deliberately, Jungkook broke the stare, turning his head toward the back door of the kitchen.

"Clean down your station," He rumbled, his voice snapping back into its usual professional, flat authority, though it was still rough around the edges. "We are done for tonight."



The shrill, piercing beep of the alarm shattered the quiet bedroom, but it didn't actually wake Jimin up.

He was already awake.

He had been like this the entire weekend—staring blankly at the ceiling, tossing and turning until the sheets were a tangled mess around his legs, completely restless.

Every time he closed his eyes, his brain betrayed him, replaying Friday night on a loop. He hadn't been able to shake a single detail. The pressure of Jungkook's hand on his, the low vibrations of his voice, the terrifyingly beautiful precision of his movements, and that suffocating, intoxicating scent of sandalwood and leather.

He had spent forty-eight hours thinking about his own teacher in ways that were definitively not approved by HR.

Jimin squeezed his eyes shut, burying his face in his hands as a fresh wave of heat rushed to his cheeks. It was exhausting. He was supposed to be focusing on graduating, not thirsting over the man who held his entire career in his hands.

"Jimin, remember what Chef said about being late!"

Taehyung’s muffled voice called out from behind the closed bathroom door, followed by the sharp rustle of a toothbrush.

The reminder hit Jimin like a bucket of ice water.

With a low, groggy groan, Jimin forced himself to sit up. He swung his legs over the edge of the mattress, his brown hair completely throssed and sticking out in wild, messy tufts all over his head.

He blinked blearily into the dim morning light, his muscles aching from lack of sleep, but his heart was already starting to hammer a familiar, nervous rhythm against his ribs. It was Monday morning. He had to face him again.

Jimin got dressed as quickly as his tired limbs would allow, shuffling across the room to grab the handle of his small black suitcase and his heavy canvas knife kit.

Taehyung stepped out of the bathroom a second later, completely dressed. He was wearing a crisp, tailored white button-up tucked perfectly into sleek black slacks, his own brown hair expertly styled back away from his face. He looked polished, expensive, and entirely ready for Europe.

Taehyung looked at Jimin once, started to turn away, and then snapped his head right back, his wide eyes tracking down Jimin's outfit in absolute horror.

"Um... my friend... please tell me you're not wearing that." Taehyung said, gesturing frantically to Jimin's worn clothes. "We are going to Paris... to a five-star hotel, and then straight to a world-class banquet!"

Jimin pressed his lips together, a heavy, self-conscious sigh escaping him as he looked down at himself. "I don't have anything fancy, Tae. You know this."

Taehyung's expression instantly softened, but he let out a dramatic groan and turned on his heel, marching directly toward his own wardrobe closet.

"Je ne peux pas te laisser traîner en ayant l'air sans-abri, mon pauvre ami," Taehyung mumbled to himself, his hands flying through the hangers as they clattered rhythmically against the metal rod. Suddenly, his movements stopped. With a triumphant flourish, he pulled out a stunning, soft baby-blue button-up shirt and a pair of perfectly pressed black slacks. He spun back around, holding them out. "Perfect. Put these on... and hurry, we don't have much time."

Jimin reached out, taking the high-quality fabric cautiously into his hands. It felt incredibly soft, miles away from anything he actually owned. "Tae... it's okay, I—"

"No. No. I insist... please," Taehyung cut him off, giving him a firm, pleading look that left absolutely no room for argument. "Now change!"

Jimin stepped out of the bathroom, and Taehyung was waiting for him, leaned back against the wall with his arms crossed. The moment his eyes landed on Jimin, his lips curled up dangerously into a wide, satisfied grin.

"Much better."

Jimin looked down at himself, smoothing his hands over the front of the shirt. The fabric was so impossibly soft against his skin, tailored perfectly to his frame, making him feel almost like a

mannequin on display. He smiled faintly, a genuine warmth blooming in his chest despite his nerves.

"Thank you, Tae. I appreciate it," Jimin said after a moment, looking up.

"I told you, I am so down to earth and what's mine is yours," Taehyung said with a dramatic wave of his hand, before his expression instantly hardened. "Except for my shoes... don't touch my shoes."

Jimin let out a breathless laugh as they finally grabbed their bags and began to walk out of the room. Halfway down the hall, a sudden wave of panic hit Jimin. He gasped, spun on his heel, and ran right back into the room to grab his Jellycat off the bed, hastily shoving the stuffed animal into the top of his suitcase before zipping it secure and hurrying right back after a judging but amused Taehyung.

When they pushed through the doors of the campus building, the crisp morning air hit Jimin's face, instantly making him feel more awake. Parked right along the curb was a massive, sleek charter bus.

It looked incredibly expensive—jet black with tinted windows that reflected the morning sun, and a high-gloss finish that made it look more like a private jet on wheels than a student bus.

A long, orderly line of culinary students was already formed along the sidewalk, everyone dressed in their finest traveling clothes, their chatter a nervous, excited hum in the quiet morning. Luggage tags flickered in the breeze, and the heavy underbelly compartments of the bus were swung wide open as a driver loaded row after row of suitcases.

Looking at the crowd, Jimin suddenly felt a tight knot of anxiety twist in his stomach. He reached up, his fingers nervously tugging at the crisp collar of the shirt, trying to loosen the suffocating grip it suddenly felt like it had on his throat.

He scanned the front of the bus, his heart instantly hammering a frantic, heavy rhythm against his ribs as his mind screamed a single question: Where was Jungkook?

Just in the heat of his wondering a very familiar voice boomed from across the concrete.

Jungkook stood right at the front of the line, towering beside the open doors of the charter bus. The morning light caught the sharp angles of his face, making him look softer than usual. He wore a crisp white button-up shirt with the sleeves rolled up his forearms, black slacks, and glasses, his dark hair falling into his face in messy but perfectly tamed sweeps. He held only a black clipboard in one hand, his piercing, unforgiving glare sweeping over the entire crowd.

"Everyone let's hurry and load up," Jungkook ordered, his heavy voice cutting right through the chatter. "We must arrive at the hotel before our check-in slot. Move."

Jimin froze, his breath catching painfully in his throat as the sound of that voice sent a sharp shiver straight down his spine.

As the students immediately scrambled to move their luggage forward, Jungkook's eyes scanned down the line. He paused, his gaze locking directly on Jimin.

Jungkook ripped it away just as quickly as he had held it, his pen snapping aggressively against the clipboard as he checked off the first few names.

"C'mon, let's hurry so we can get good seats," Taehyung said, nudging Jimin's shoulder as the line finally began to move forward.

As they reached the steps of the bus, Taehyung stepped up into the aisle first. Jimin took a shaky breath, his fingers tightening around the strap of his knife kit as he followed closely behind. He stepped up to the threshold, his eyes lifting to meet the dark glare behind Jungkook's glasses. The Director was standing so close Jimin could smell the sharp, crisp scent of his cologne mixing with the morning air.

He swallowed hard as he hurried up the remaining steps and into the narrow aisle of the bus, desperate to escape the heavy weight of that stare.

"Tae, please. Please let me have the window seat," Jimin begged, his voice a frantic, hushed whisper as he tugged at the sleeve of Taehyung's shirt. "I'll do your prep work for a week. I'll wash your knives. Just please let me sit by the window."

Taehyung sighed dramatically, rolling his eyes as he looked from the window back to Jimin's pleading, wide eyes. "Fine. I will," Taehyung said, pointing a stern finger at him. "But with one exception: when we get to the hotel, I get the bed furthest from the door. That way, if a serial killer breaks in during the night, they will get you first and not me."

Jimin blinked, completely perplexed by the bizarre logic. "I... what?"

"Take it or leave it."

"Okay, okay! Fine," Jimin said quickly, too tired and anxious to argue.

He scrambled past his friend, sliding into the row and sitting snugly by the window. He pressed his forehead against the cool glass, letting out a long, shaky breath as he watched the rest of the students load their bags outside. He felt safe tucked away in the corner, but as the bus engine rumbled to life, his chest tightened with the distinct, heavy knowledge that Jungkook was about to board.

A few minutes later, the front doors of the bus hissed shut, and the heavy atmosphere inside the cabin shifted instantly.

Jungkook boarded.

He moved down the narrow aisle with a cold, professional efficiency, his dark eyes scanning the rows of students before he finally stopped. Jimin's breath caught in his throat when Jungkook slid into the empty row directly across the aisle from them. He sat down, placing his clipboard flat on his lap.

The entire hour ride was spent in a dizzying loop for Jimin. He couldn't keep still. His morning became a frantic triangle of distractions: scrolling aimlessly through his phone until the screen blurred, whispering back and forth with Taehyung about the upcoming banquet, and staring

relentlessly at Jungkook across the aisle. Every time Jungkook shifted his weight, crossed his legs, or adjusted his glasses, Jimin's heart would do a dangerous, familiar flip.

By the time the bus was nearing the city limits, the sheer psychological exhaustion of it had Jimin completely exhausted. The tension across the narrow aisle was thick—he wanted so badly for it to just be gone, to go back to a time before Friday night when he could just breathe normally in the Director's presence.

Then, during a sudden, abrupt stop at a heavy traffic light, Jungkook had turned his head to the side, his dark eyes snapping directly across the aisle.

Jimin didn't have time to look down.

Before he could fake an interest in his phone, his gaze locked entirely with Jungkook's.

The short distance between their seats seemed to evaporate entirely. Neither of them backed down. Jungkook's expression was unreadable as always, his eyes boring into Jimin with the exact same unforgiving weight he had used in the kitchen. Jimin's chest heaved, his fingers gripping the edge of his phone so tightly his knuckles turned white, but he stubbornly refused to be the one to break it first.

The stare-off stretched, long and agonizing, holding them frozen while the rest of the bus chattered around them.

It wasn't until the traffic light clicked green and the bus began moving forward with a sudden jolt that Jimin finally ripped his eyes away, his heart hammering a chaotic rhythm against his ribs as he stared blindly out the side window.

Beside him, the sudden tension didn't go unnoticed.

Taehyung slowly squinted his eyes, his sharp gaze flickering suspiciously from Jungkook across the aisle, straight over to Jimin's burning, flushed face. He leaned back in his seat, his brows drawing together as a dangerous, knowing curiosity began to spark in his eyes.

The tension of the ride finally broke when the highway gave way to the grand, tree-lined boulevards of the city.

Jimin gasped softly, a small, involuntary sound that caught in his throat as his eyes widened. He immediately reached out, nudging Taehyung's arm frantically with his elbow. Taehyung, who had spent the last hour scrolling through his phone and looking thoroughly unimpressed by the whole ordeal, barely offered a lazy glance toward the glass, a stark contrast to the absolute wonder taking over Jimin.

Jimin lifted himself up just a bit in his seat, shifting his knees so he was turning fully to face the window, his palms practically pressing against the glass like a child.

The city unfolded before him like a living, breathing painting under the crisp morning sun. Rows of magnificent, cream-colored Haussmann buildings stretched out as far as the eye could see, their iron balconies and steep roofs looking impossibly elegant. The streets below were a bustling maze of tiny black taxis, locals walking, and charming sidewalk cafés with their woven chairs facing out

toward the pavement.

Then, as the bus turned a wide corner near the riverbank, Jimin's breath left him completely.

It didn't feel real.

For a fleeting second, the suffocating anxiety about Jungkook and the pressure of the upcoming banquet evaporated, replaced by an awe that left him utterly captivated.

The bus rounded a massive, cobblestone roundabout and finally pulled up to the front of a grand hotel. The building was an absolute masterpiece of old-world European architecture, towering so high into the sky that Jimin had to duck his head lower against the window just to see the top, Pristine doormen in velvet coats were already waiting at the entrance.

The moment the bus brakes hissed to a stop, the soft hum of student chatter died instantly.

Jungkook stood up immediately. His frame completely dominated the narrow aisle, easily commanding the attention of the entire cabin as he gripped his clipboard. His dark eyes slowly swept across the rows, pausing for a heavy, deliberate beat right on Jimin before he spoke.

"Listen to me carefully," Jungkook rumbled, his voice vibrating off the low ceiling of the bus, completely stripping the excitement from the air. "We are staying at one of the finest establishments in this city. I am sure most of you are used to such luxuries, but for those who are not..."

He let the sentence hang heavily in the air, his piercing glare narrowing just a fraction.

"...please do not embarrass me or yourselves, and act as if you have proper home training. You are representing this academy, and more importantly, you are representing me. If I hear a single complaint from the hotel staff, you will be on a taxi back before sundown. Am I understood?"

A chorus of quiet, nervous "Yes, Chef" echoed through the seats.

"Good. Get your things," Jungkook commanded flatly.

With that, he turned on his heel and stepped off the bus first. The second he disappeared down the steps, the heavy spell broke, and the students practically scrambled over one another, grabbing bags and jackets in a frantic rush to be the first off the bus and out of the line of fire.

Jimin stepped off the bus and onto the smooth cobblestones, immediately spinning around in a slow circle to take in the breathtaking view of everything. Up close, the hotel looked like a palace—towering white marble columns, sprawling red carpets, and massive crystal chandeliers glowing softly just inside the towering glass doors.

"Puis-je prendre vos bagages, monsieur?" a polite voice asked.

Jimin blinked, turning to find a hotel butler standing there, dressed in a sharp, pristine uniform and holding out a hand for his suitcase.

Instinctively, Jimin gave a small, polite bow, clutching the handle a little tighter. "Oh....it's okay, thank you! I can carry it," he said, a warm, sheepish smile on his face.

The butler's smile brightened instantly, his eyes crinkling at the corners. "Ah! You are American?"

Jimin nodded, his cheeks dusting with a faint pink. "Yes! This is my first time in Paris, actually."

The man beamed, completely charmed by Jimin's polite, wide-eyed earnestness. "Well, I hope you enjoy! You are truly in the best hands. This academy is the best our country has to offer!"

Jimin smiled warmly, nodding along. He was so completely indulged in the friendly conversation, so relieved to be talking to someone who wasn't barking orders at him, that he didn't notice the heavy presence lingering just a few feet away.

Jungkook was standing near the luggage bay, his clipboard resting against his hip. He wasn't checking in students anymore. His eyes were fixed entirely on Jimin, a strange, curious glint shifting behind his eyes as he watched the smaller boy laugh and charm the hotel staff so effortlessly. His jaw was set, tracking the way Jimin's eyes crinkled and how his soft laugh rang out across the lot.

"Well, it was so nice to meet you..." Jimin began, tilting his head slightly.

"Mateo," the butler supplied warmly.

"Mateo!" Jimin repeated with a bright grin.

Mateo beamed, giving a polite bow as Jimin waved goodbye, his cheeks warm.

All around them, the other students were eagerly handing over their heavy bags, letting out sighs of relief as a small army of butlers wheeled the luggage away on gold-rimmed carts.

Taehyung strolled up to Jimin's side, completely empty-handed and looking like royalty as he prepared to walk into the hotel. He glanced down, his brows furrowing in confusion. "Jimin, why on earth are you still carrying that?"

"Because I told Mateo I could handle it," Jimin muttered, shifting the weight of his small black suitcase and his knife kit. "Plus, imagine how tired they must be lifting everyone's heavy bags! It's fine."

Taehyung just shook his head, a fond, exasperated sigh escaping his lips. "You are entirely too kind for your own good."

Jimin opened his mouth to reply, but whatever else he wanted to say was cut off entirely the exact moment they stepped through the towering glass doors of the lobby.

The interior of the hotel was absolutely jaw-dropping.

It felt like stepping directly into a royal palace from the eighteenth century. The floors beneath their feet were made of polished white and gray Macedonian marble, buffed to such a high, brilliant shine that Jimin could see the perfect reflection of his own shoes. Towering Corinthian columns stretched up toward a vaulted ceiling covered in intricate, hand-painted frescoes of the sky, framed by thick bands of gold leaf's that caught the light from every angle.

Directly above the center of the room hung a massive, cascading crystal chandelier that looked like a frozen waterfall of pure light, throwing thousands of tiny, glittering diamonds across the space. The air itself smelled expensive—a rich, delicate blend of fresh-cut white lilies, polished wood, and expensive French perfume. Plush velvet sofas in deep emerald green and royal blue were arranged in seating areas, flanked by massive oil paintings in heavy, gilded frames.

Jimin stopped dead in his tracks right in the middle of the lobby, his jaw dropping as he stared upward. He felt completely microscopic in the face of such luxury, his fingers tightening around the handle of his suitcase as the weight of it all finally settled over him.

"The Américaine is impressed by a measly hotel,"

Eric's sharp, condescending voice cut through the air right next to him.

Jimin's eyes narrowed immediately, the breathtaking wonder of the lobby vanishing in an instant.

Ugh.

Eric was standing with his arms crossed, a smug, arrogant smirk plastered across his face as he looked Jimin up and down.

"Careful," Eric whispered mockingly, leaning in just a fraction so the surrounding students could hear. "Try not to drool on the marble. Some of us have actually seen luxury before. Then again, I suppose this is a step up from whatever diner you crawled out of."

Jimin's jaw clenched, a hot wave of frustration pricking at the back of his neck. His grip tightened around the handle of his knife kit until his knuckles turned white. He wanted nothing more than to wipe that smirk right off Eric's face, but the terrifying memory of Jungkook's warning about proper home training echoed in his head, keeping him frozen.

Before Jimin could even think about risking Jungkook's wrath, Taehyung smoothly stepped directly into the space between them, completely cutting off Eric's view of Jimin.

Taehyung didn't even look at the senior, simply brushing a non-existent piece of lint off his own tailored white sleeve with an expression of supreme, effortless boredom.

"Ignore him," Taehyung said, his voice dripping with an icy disdain so polished it could freeze the Seine. "Some people mistake a bitter, unprovoked attitude for a personality. It's tragic, really. On pourrait penser qu'un étudiant de dernière année aurait de meilleures choses à faire que de se focaliser sur les chaussures d'un étudiant plus jeune, mais je suppose que la médiocrité te laisse beaucoup de temps libre ."

Eric's smirk faltered, his face flushing a dangerous, angry red. "Qu'est-ce que tu viens de dire, Kim ?"

They were immediately interrupted by a low, gravelly sound. Jungkook cleared his throat behind them, his presence suddenly casting a long shadow over all three of them.

The heat in the air vanished instantly, replaced by a tense, freezing silence. Eric snapped his mouth

shut, his posture instantly straightening as he scrambled to look professional, while Taehyung smoothly stepped back, his face blanking into perfect innocence.

Jungkook's eyes narrowed, slowly sweeping over Eric, then Taehyung, before finally landing on Jimin. He lingered there, his gaze tracing the tight grip Jimin had on his heavy knife kit.

"Here are your room numbers," Jungkook began as he held out a stack of gold-embossed key cards. He didn't raise his voice, but the authority in his tone made Eric take a nervous step back. "Go get settled, unpack, and change. We leave for the banquet in exactly two hours."

He stepped closer before continuing.

"Full chef attire and your knife kits," Jungkook ordered, his voice dropping low, making Jimin's chest tighten. "The same rules apply in every kitchen on earth. If you are a single second late, you will be watching the banquet from the sidewalk."

With a final, warning glance that promised absolute hell if anyone stepped out of line again, Jungkook handed over the key cards. Eric practically snatched his and bolted toward the gold-plated elevators, desperate to escape.

Taehyung grabbed their room card with a tight, reassuring nod to the Chef. "C'mon, Jimin," he whispered, gesturing toward the lifts. "Two hours. We need to hurry."

Jimin swallowed the lump in his throat, nodding quickly as he dragged his small suitcase forward. As he turned to follow Taehyung, he could still feel the heavy, suffocating weight of Jungkook's gaze burning into the back of his neck, setting the rhythm for his racing heart.



The gold-plated elevators whisked Jimin and Taehyung up to their room, which turned out to be just as ridiculously fancy as the lobby. Taehyung immediately claimed the bed furthest from the door, diving onto the plush duvet with a dramatic sigh. But there was no time to lounge. The clock was ticking, and Jungkook's terrifying warning about being a single second late echoed in Jimin's mind.

They changed in record time. Slipping out of Taehyung's soft shirt and into his stiff, pristine white chef's layers felt like putting on armor. Jimin double-checked his knife kit, ensuring every blade was polished and in its exact place, before they hurried back down to the lobby.

The ride back on the charter bus was a blur of high anxiety. Jungkook sat across the aisle again, but this time his eyes never wandered. He was a statue of pure, intimidating authority, staring straight ahead, the tense silence in the bus so thick you could cut it with a knife.

When the bus finally pulled up to the banquet hall, Jimin's breath hitched.

He was once again in absolute awe. If the hotel was a palace, this place was a fortress of pure luxury. Nestled right along the shimmering Seine, the banquet hall was a massive, historic stone pavilion illuminated by thousands of soft, golden fairy lights. Towering glass arches revealed glimpses of a ballroom filled with velvet drapes, towering floral arrangements, and massive ice sculptures.

But they weren't here as guests.

Jungkook led the line of students past the grand entrance and straight through the heavy, industrial steel doors of the back entrance, plunging them directly into the underbelly of the event: the kitchen.

And it was gorgeous.

Waiting for them at the front of the main pass was a small line of incredibly wealthy-looking people. In the center stood a woman in a sharp, tailored black pantsuit, her hair pulled back into a tight bun. Beside her were two men in custom black suits, their hands clasped in front of them. All three of them had incredibly sharp, evaluating gazes that swept over the incoming academy students like wolves sizing up a herd.

Jimin stood awkwardly next to Taehyung, his feet shifting slightly against the kitchen tiles. All around them, the line of students was looking around wide-eyed, completely intimidated by the scale of the kitchen and the cold demeanor of the people waiting for them.

The suffocating pressure of the room felt like a physical weight on Jimin's chest. He reached down, his fingers unconsciously tracing the strap of his knife kit.

"I'm so nervous," Jimin whispered lowly toward Taehyung, his voice trembling just a fraction.

Taehyung didn't even blink, his eyes locked onto the trio at the front. "Don't be," he whispered back, completely deadpan. "The lady is American!"

Jimin slowly turned his head to stare at his friend, his expression entirely flat. He deadpanned right back, utterly bewildered as to how the woman's nationality was supposed to offer him a single ounce of comfort while standing in the most high-stakes kitchen in Paris.

"Welcome to L'Étoile Dorée," the woman said, her voice clear, confident, and carrying a sharp tone that echoed perfectly off the walls.

As she spoke, Jungkook moved with an effortless, slow stride, settling next to her. He crossed his arms over his chest, his eyes squinting heavily behind his glasses as his gaze swept over the tight line of students.

"I am sure Chef Jeon has trained you all well for what is to come tonight," she continued, her sharp eyes scanning the crowd. "Some of the wealthiest people in all of France will be in-house tonight, and it is up to you all to take the tickets and prepare each meal to standard. We will, of course, be here to help, but mostly to guide."

She stepped forward, her heels clicking sharply against the tile floor, her gaze hardening into something intensely serious.

"This is not handholding. This is shadow work," she stated flatly, her voice cutting through the nervous tension in the room. "You are experiencing the real thing tonight so that you can know for certain if this is what you are truly called to do. In my kitchen, mediocrity is a fireable offense. Do not let the pressure break you."

Jimin swallowed hard, a cold sweat breaking out down his spine as he listened.

"But, where are my manners," She began, a sharp but polite smile finally cracking her cold expression. "I am Emily. To my right is Theodore, and to my left is Enzo. Both have worked for me for over ten years, so listen to them, because they do indeed know a thing or two."

Theodore and Enzo gave tight, identical nods, their sharp eyes never leaving the line of students.

Emily smiled faintly, turning her head slightly toward the towering man standing beside her. "Okay, let's break and separate each student into a station," she said, directing her words more toward Jungkook now. "You know your students, Chef, so you put them where you see fit, and we will work from there."

Jungkook let his arms drop slowly to his sides. He stepped forward, his heavy leather boots clicking with an ominous weight against the kitchen tile. The entire line of students seemed to hold their breath at once, their spines straightening into absolute military precision.

"Boucher," Jungkook rumbled, his thick, low voice instantly slicing through the hum of the kitchen's refrigeration units. "Entremet. You're on the hot sides with Theodore."

Eric instantly bowed his head. "Yes, Chef," he said, stepping out of line with his knife kit and hurrying toward the designated station.

Jungkook's dark eyes narrowed behind his wire-rimmed glasses as he continued down the line, placing students at pastry, larder, and sauce stations with cold, calculating speed. He knew exactly what everyone's strengths and weaknesses were, and he was assigning them like chess pieces on a board.

"Kim," Jungkook called out, his gaze locking onto Taehyung. "Garde Manger. Cold appetizers. Enzo will monitor you."

"Yes, Chef," Taehyung murmured, giving Jimin's arm a quick, hidden squeeze before stepping away to join Enzo at the far side of the massive kitchen.

"Dubois, you're on pastry. Help with the plating," Jungkook commanded flatly, checking the name off his mental list.

The kitchen around them had erupted into a high-octane symphony of clattering metal, roaring burners, and sharp orders. The line of students had thinned out completely, leaving Jimin standing entirely alone in the center of the pass. He felt completely exposed, a ball of pure nervous energy as he clutched his heavy canvas knife kit to his chest.

Suddenly, Emily stepped into the space beside Jungkook. The heavy wave of her strong, expensive floral perfume filled the air as she leaned in close to the Director, her sharp eyes scanning the room

before locking onto a specific spot.

Jimin followed her gaze. Right in the very center of the kitchen was a massive, isolated island station under a glaring spotlight. It was the absolute heart of the line—the most challenging, high-pressure, and terrifying spot in the entire house.

And it was completely empty.

Emily leaned in closer to Jungkook, her voice dropping to a low, quiet murmur meant only for him, though her sharp eyes remained fixed entirely on that vacant, central station.

Jungkook's eyes flickered to the empty station. Then, they shifted slowly to Emily, his jaw tightening as he listened to whatever she whispered. Finally, his dark, piercing glare swung around and locked directly onto Jimin.

A dangerous, suffocating friction filled the space between them. Behind his glasses, Jungkook's eyes narrowed into a cold, calculating squint.

"Park," Jungkook's thick, low voice rumbled, cutting through the noise of the kitchen with an ominous weight. "You are on that central line. You will be handling the hyper-precision cuts and the final garnish prep for the main courses."

Jimin's breath caught painfully in his throat. His head spun. That station didn't just require speed; it required flawless accuracy under the highest pressure imaginable.

He gripped the canvas strap of his knife kit until his knuckles turned entirely white. Looking straight into the Director's unforgiving eyes, he refused to let his voice tremble.

"Yes, Chef," Jimin stated, his voice tight but fiercely steady.

He turned on his heel and stepped out of the pass, walking toward the glaring spotlight of the central island station. As his boots clicked against the tile, he could feel the weight of dozens of eyes slamming into him. All around the kitchen, the other students' gazes flickered over to his lone figure, their expressions a sharp mix of absolute surprise and heavy, bitter envy. Even Eric was staring from the hot line, his jaw slack with disbelief that an underclassman had just been handed the heart of the kitchen.

Jimin shifted uncomfortably under the sudden, suffocating wave of attention. He hated being the center of it all, his skin prickling with heat as he kept his eyes glued straight ahead.

He reached the cold table, his hands trembling slightly as he sat his kit down and began unzipping it. He was trying to focus on aligning his favorite knives, but the panic of the layout was making his chest tight.

Suddenly, the hairs on the back of his neck stood up. The familiar, sharp scent of crisp cologne and hot wool flooded his senses, and he felt a massive, towering presence materialize directly behind his shoulder.

Jungkook was standing so close Jimin could feel the faint warmth radiating from him.

"The first ticket drops in exactly thirty minutes when the doors open," Jungkook's voice rumbled. It was hushed, low, and rough—dropping into a private, intimate frequency that was meant for Jimin's ears and Jimin's ears alone. "The dinner rush lasts about two hours. In that time, over two hundred plates will be going out, and every single one will pass through your station."

Jimin froze, a polished utility knife clutched tightly in his hand, his eyes staring blindly down at the steel table.

"Do not let the pressure get to you. Do not," Jungkook commanded quietly, his voice carrying a strange, fierce intensity that sent a sharp shiver straight down Jimin's spine. "If you need help, you find me. Understood?"

Jimin's breath caught in his throat. He desperately wanted to turn around, to look up into those dark eyes, but he couldn't bring himself to do it. He stared stubbornly at his reflection in the stainless steel, nodding quickly.

"Yes, Chef," Jimin whispered.

He heard the faint rustle of Jungkook's stiff white shirt as the Director lingered for one more agonizing, heavy second, his gaze burning into the side of Jimin's face before he finally turned and strode back toward the main pass.

In those thirty minutes, Jimin forced his mind to go completely blank, channeling all his frantic energy directly into his hands. He took a deep breath, grabbed a crisp white onion, and began to cut.

Slice, slice, slice.

The rhythm was instantaneous. His fingers moved with a terrifying precision, practicing the exact fluid movements Jungkook had drilled into him on Friday night. He moved from the onions to a mountain of vibrant bell peppers, and then to a delicate assortment of fresh micro-greens and garnishes. By the time twenty-five minutes had ticked by, his cutting board was decorated with perfectly uniform, immaculate piles, each diced cube a match to the next.

Emily stepped forward from the pass, her sharp voice echoing over the hum of the ventilation hoods. "Dinner is beginning soon, so please, everyone prepare your stations."

The kitchen instantly shifted, the air tightening with a palpable, breathless anxiety. Beside him, several upperclassmen were visibly sweating, checking their timers and adjusting their heat with trembling hands.

Jimin inhaled a deep, steadying breath, his chest rising as a sudden, unexpected calm began to wash over his nerves.

He had done this his whole life.

His mind flashed back to the diner back home. He remembered the blinding rush hours, the screaming tickets, the way he would expertly plate six different orders at a time under a buzzing heat lamp, balance three heavy ceramic plates on his left arm, two on his right, and carry the last one in his hand, walking them out to rowdy tables from sunup to sundown. He had survived the

grittiest, fastest, most unforgiving diner rushes completely on his own.

This was nothing.

This was just a kitchen.

A smirk almost tugged at the corner of his lips. This was exactly like home—just slightly more upscale. And, well, with Jungkook and Emily watching, a little more life or death.

The printers at the pass suddenly exploded.

A sharp, violent screech-clack-clack-clack shattered the silence as a dozen tickets spilled out of the machines all at once.

"Orders in!" Emily's voice cut through the air like a siren. "Table four, table twelve, table nine! Six turbot, four sea bass, two roasted duck! Allez! "

Instantly, the kitchen erupted into a frenzy of high-octane chaos. Burners roared to life with terrifying bursts of blue and orange flame. Heavy copper pans slammed onto the iron ranges, hissing violently as butter hit hot metal. Shouted orders of "Yes, Chef!" echoed from every corner, bouncing off the walls until the noise was deafening.

In the center of it all, the first wave of prep trays slammed down onto Jimin's island station.

"Garnish for the duck! I need the micro-radish julienne now, Park!" Eric yelled, his face already slick with sweat as he threw a searing hot pan down at the station next to him.

Jimin didn't even blink. Muscle memory took over his entire body, freezing his nerves into pure focus. He grabbed a handful of radishes, his knife blurring under the bright spotlight. Tap-tap-tap-tap-tap. In less than ten seconds, a flawless, translucent pile of matchstick radishes was swept into a pristine ramekin and slid across the pass.

"Duck garnish, out!" Jimin called out, his voice ringing surprisingly loud and clear over the din of the kitchen.

More trays arrived. Portioned scallops needing a perfect sear prep, roasted fingerling potatoes that required a meticulous, angled bias cut, and plates of braised beef waiting for his uniform ribbons of chives. Tickets were flying, the heat from the ranges was rising, and the smell of searing meat, rich wine reductions, and burning butter filled the air.

Jimin moved quickly. He was spinning between three different cutting boards, his hands a blur of speed and precision. He didn't look up, he didn't breathe, he just listened to the rhythm of the tickets.

When an upperclassman staggered next to him, falling behind on their plating, Jimin reached across the line, grabbed a squeeze bottle, and made a flawless, artistic swirl of purée onto four plates at once, balancing two more trays on his forearm to clear space.

He was in his element after all.

The luxury of the hotel didn't matter anymore; the expensive French legacy didn't matter. It was just a rush, and Jimin knew how to ride a rush better than anyone in this room.

Through the heavy haze of steam and smoke at the front pass, Jungkook stood at the expeditor station, tearing tickets off the printer with lightning speed. But even as he barked out times and coordinates to the rest of the kitchen, his eyes kept snapping back to the center island.

He watched Jimin. He watched the absolute precision of the cuts, executed flawlessly under a pressure that was breaking the seniors. A dark, intense glint of satisfaction flared in Jungkook's eyes as he tracked the fierce, unyielding look on Jimin's face.

Suddenly, a massive tray of seared sea bass slammed down right in front of Jimin, the skin perfectly crisp but the plating completely unorganized.

"Pass is choking! I need the final herb oil and fennel chiffonade on these four plates in thirty seconds, Park, or the table is dead!" Enzo shouted from the hot line.

Thirty seconds.

Jimin didn't waste a single tick of the clock. His knife flashed under the glaring spotlight, reducing a bulb of fennel into a pile of ribbons so thin they looked like lace. He swept them up, scattering them perfectly across the four fish plates, and then grabbed the squeeze bottle, dripping vibrant green herb oil in identical, immaculate dots around the rim.

The plates needed to get to the pass immediately, but the runner was stuck on the other side of the kitchen.

Without a second thought, Jimin smoothly slid three of the heavy, blistering hot ceramic plates up his left forearm, balancing them flawlessly against his sleeve, grabbed the fourth plate with his right hand, and navigated the kitchen floor with a practiced grace. He slid them onto the main expeditor counter with a solid clack and slammed his hand down on the service bell.

Ding!

"Sea bass, hot at the pass!" Jimin called out.

Before the servers could even react, he spun around, raced back to his island, loaded up another three plates of braised beef, and marched them right back to the counter, slamming the bell again.

Ding!

"Beef entrees out!"

But just as he stepped back to his station, the dinner rush hit its absolute peak. The kitchen mutated from a high-octane symphony into a frantic, deafening war zone. The printers were screaming, vomiting a never-ending stream of white paper onto the floor.

"I need table twelve now! Where is my duck?!" Emily roared from the front, her tailored suit forgotten as she gripped the edge of the pass, her face flushed with stress.

"Move! Out of the way!" a senior panicked, slamming his hip into another student. Pans were clattering, oil was spitting, and from somewhere near the pastry station, Jimin thought he heard the muffled, pathetic sound of someone crying. But he was too terrified to look up.

Plates started piling onto his central island like a landslide. Six, twelve, eighteen plates at a time, all demanding garnishes, precise reductions, and flawless presentation. Jimin's hands were moving at a breakneck speed, but the physical toll was setting in. The muscles in his forearms locked up, and his fingers began to cramp violently, stiffening into a painful claw around the handle of his knife as he tried to chop through another mountain of chives.

He was falling behind.

Suddenly, the air next to him grew warm. A massive, towering shadow blocked out the harsh spotlight above his head.

Jungkook was standing right beside him.

The Director's sleeves were rolled tightly to his biceps, his apron splattered with dark stains.

"Why is your station backed up?" Jungkook asked.

Jimin flinched slightly, surprised that the question didn't come out as a deafening yell like the ones echoing through the kitchen all night. Instead, Jungkook's voice was low, a quiet tone right near Jimin's ear.

"I—the orders are coming so f-fast," Jimin stammered, his breath hitched as his cramped fingers slipped slightly on his knife. "My hands, they're—"

"Pick up the pace," Jungkook interrupted flatly, his voice cutting off Jimin's excuse.

"Y-yes Chef, I'm trying, but they're just throwing the plates at me and—"

"I don't care about them. I care about this station," Jungkook rumbled, stepping even closer until his shoulder forcefully nudged Jimin's aside. He didn't look at Jimin; his eyes were fixed entirely on the prep. "I thought you could handle a rush. Was I wrong?"

"No, Chef," Jimin bit out, a flare of stubborn frustration cutting through his panic.

"Then prove it." Suddenly, Jungkook reached out. His calloused hand, slick with the heat of the kitchen, gripped Jimin's cramped right wrist. He didn't squeeze to hurt, but his hold was tight, forcing Jimin's stiff fingers to realign correctly against the spine of the chef's knife.

The sudden, intense heat of Jungkook's skin against his sent a jolt straight down Jimin's spine.

"Loosen your grip," Jungkook commanded in a low, rough whisper, his chest practically brushing Jimin's back as he leaned over the station. "You're choking the blade. That's why you're cramping. Breathe."

Jimin swallowed hard, forcing a ragged breath into his lungs.

"Don't you dare cry. If a single plate leaves this island unpolished, you answer to me tonight. Do you understand?"

"Yes, Chef," Jimin whispered fiercely.

"Good." Jungkook let go of his wrist, the loss of his touch leaving a freezing void in the humid air. Jungkook snatched up a squeeze bottle from the rack, his own knife slicing through a bunch of tarragon with a speed that was almost terrifying. "Now, drop the oil. I'll clear the pass. Move."

Jimin didn't waste a single heartbeat.

With the ghost of Jungkook's grip still burning against his wrist, he plunged back into the frenzy. His cheeks were burning fiercely, a mixture of the roaring kitchen heat and the intoxicating adrenaline of having the Director looming so close.

He dropped the vibrant herb oil onto the plates in rapid, flawless succession while Jungkook's knife blurred beside him, clearing the garnish backlog in seconds. Once Jimin had picked up the pace, maintaining the precision they had practiced, Jungkook didn't offer another word. He simply gave a tight, satisfied nod and moved down the line, sweeping back to the front pass to manage the roaring flame of the hot line.

For the rest of the rush, Jimin didn't think. He didn't feel the ache in his back. He just chopped, garnished, wiped plate rims, balanced three or four blistering ceramic dishes up his forearm, and sprinted them to the pass, slamming the bell until his knuckles throbbed.

Finally, a full three hours into the absolute madness, the printer let out one final, solitary clack .

It was the last ticket.

Jimin's hands trembled violently as he placed the final delicate sprig of chervil onto a plate of seared sea bass. He grabbed the heavy dish, marched it to the counter with the very last ounce of strength in his legs, and slammed his palm down on the service bell.

Ding...

"Last... last sea bass, hot at the pass," Jimin called out, his throat so raw and dehydrated that his words came out slightly slurred, his tongue heavy in his mouth.

At the sound of that final bell, the spell over the kitchen snapped instantly.

The silence that followed was heavy and immediate. Almost simultaneously, every single student in the room collapsed. Some dropped straight to the hard tile floor, limbs sprawled out lazily. Others leaned heavily against the counters, burying their faces in their arms, while loud, exhausted groans echoed off the vaulted ceiling. Taehyung looked like he had dissociated, staring blankly at an ice bin as he leaned against a wall.

Jimin didn't even have the energy to make it back to his station. He staggered backward away from the pass until his shoulder blades hit the cool, tiled wall, and his legs completely gave out. He slid straight down to the floor.

He was an absolute mess.

His pristine white chef's attire was completely ruined, covered in dark smears of rich wine reduction, bright green herb oil, and god-knows-what else from the chaotic crossfire of the line.

The other students didn't fare any better; One was slumped on a milk crate, his face a bright, sweating crimson, his jacket soaked through with a multitude of colors.

A slow, rhythmic sound suddenly broke the heavy, panting silence of the room.

Clap. Clap. Clap.

Emily stepped out from behind the expeditor desk, clapping her hands slowly with a sharp, genuinely impressed smile on her face. Beside her, Jungkook stood with his arms crossed, his eyes scanning the battlefield of exhausted students, his gaze lingering long and heavy on Jimin's crumpled form against the wall.

"You all should all be incredibly proud of yourselves," Emily said, her clear voice ringing out over the sound of the low, exhausted panting. She stopped clapping, resting her hands on her hips as her sharp eyes scanned the room. "To be completely honest, that was probably the most successful rush run I have seen in this kitchen in a while. You handled the pressure like professionals."

Jimin heard the words, and a small part of his brain recognized it as a massive, career-defining compliment. He desperately wished he could smile, or feel some rush of pride, but he could barely even form a coherent thought. His mind was completely numb, his brain fried from the sheer speed of the last couple of hours, and his cramped fingers were still twitching against his knees.

Emily let out a soft laugh, taking in the absolute state of the kitchen—the splattered sauces, the empty pans, and the line of young chefs looking like they had just survived a nuclear war.

"Everyone should be proud," she said, giving them a warm, encouraging nod. "This is Paris. Go celebrate!"

A few students let out weak, pathetic groans at the mere mention of moving their legs.

Emily chuckled, shaking her head. "Or sleep... either works. You've earned it. Clean down your stations, pack your kits, and get the hell out of here."

The spell completely broke. A collective sigh of relief washed over the floor, and students slowly, painfully began to drag themselves up to start wiping down the stainless steel.

Jimin stayed leaned against the cool tile wall for one more second, trying to find the strength to stand. As he blinked past his exhaustion, his eyes inadvertently flickered toward the main pass.

Jungkook was still standing there. He hadn't moved an inch. He didn't look tired at all; his crisp white shirt was barely wrinkled, and his dark eyes were fixed directly on Jimin, watching him struggle to pull himself up from the floor with an unreadable, intense friction.

Jimin gave him a faint, barely-there look before turning away. He dragged his palms down the cool tile wall, forcing his trembling legs to lock as he stood up. His knees buckled slightly on the first

step, causing him to stumble, but he caught himself swiftly against the edge of a prep table.

Every muscle in his lower back was screaming. He kept his head down, as he moved back to the center island. He picked up a damp sanitizer rag and began to wipe down the surface, his arm moving at a completely lazy, mechanical pace.

The entire kitchen had transformed into a scene from a zombie movie. Nobody was talking. The loud, vibrant egos from earlier were completely crushed, replaced by the hollow scrape of steel scrapers and the splash of mop water. If anyone was prompted to speak, they didn't even use words—just guttural groans and low, unintelligible mumbling.

By the time the kitchen was finally restored to its natural, gleaming state, the clock had sailed past midnight.

The students dragged their feet out to the alleyway and boarded the charter bus like a line of ghosts. The moment Taehyung slumped into his seat, he tipped his head back against the headrest, letting his eyes close with a heavy, defeated sigh.

Jimin didn't even have the energy to take his knife kit from his shoulder. He collapsed into the seat next to his friend, his body completely giving up the second his weight hit the cushion. Without a word, he let his head fall sideways, sinking heavily against Taehyung's shoulder.

The ride back through the glowing streets of Paris was entirely silent. The stress of the night had evaporated, leaving behind a vacuum of pure, dead exhaustion. The only sounds in the dark bus were the rhythmic, heavy breathing of sleeping bodies, the faint, repetitive tick-tick-tick of the driver's turn signal at the roundabouts, and the soft, quiet murmurs of a few upperclassmen in the back who could still manage to whisper.

Up in the very front row, the bus's interior lights were completely dark. But through the shadow of the tall driver's seat, Jungkook sat perfectly upright, his broad frame unmoving against the glass. He didn't look back at the cabin, but his dark eyes remained wide awake, tracking the reflection of the passing streetlights in the dark windowpane.

Back at the hotel lobby, the sudden transition from the dark, quiet bus to the brilliant, glittering light of the Macedonian marble almost made Jimin's eyes water.

Taehyung was practically a corpse. The taller boy was completely slumped over, his long arms dangling uselessly as Jimin slung one of Taehyung's arms over his own shoulders. Jimin was practically dragging him across the slick floor, his own legs shaking violently from the hours of standing, his boots skidding slightly as he fought to keep them both upright.

Before they could even reach the gold-plated elevators, Jungkook's deep, commanding voice sliced through the quiet lobby.

"Stop," he rumbled.

The remaining students who could still walk halted in their tracks, their ears instantly perking up.

"You all are wise and old enough to know how to act," Jungkook began, his voice a low, smooth baritone that echoed with effortless authority against the high ceilings. "So, if you choose to go out

tonight, please look after yourselves. And be here on time tomorrow. If anyone misses the morning call, I will consider it a forfeiture of your place in this module. Am I understood?"

A ragged chorus of "Yes, Chef," mumbled through the lobby.

"Dismissed," Jungkook commanded flatly.

As the students scrambled toward the elevators, Jungkook didn't move. His gaze drifted slowly down, tracking the way Jimin's small frame was straining to hold up Taehyung's taller, dead-weight body. A microscopic shift occurred in his expression—his jaw tightening just a fraction, his dark eyes narrowing with an unreadable expression as he watched Jimin struggle.

For a terrifying second, Jimin thought Jungkook was going to march over and yell at him for looking sloppy in a luxury lobby. Instead, the Director just stood there, holding Jimin pinned under the weight of his silence.

"A-are we almost there," Taehyung mumbled against his hair, his voice entirely slurred as his feet stumbled. "The bed... it's calling my name."

While Jimin was struggling to take another step, a familiar, bright voice pierced through the heavy silence of the lobby.

"Jimin!"

Jimin blinked past his blurred vision and saw Mateo pushing a polished gold luggage cart toward the elevators. The butler's eyes went wide with shock as he took in the sight of Jimin's splattered white uniform and the dead weight of Taehyung draped over his shoulders.

Mateo quickly abandoned his path, wheeling the massive cart over with a hurried rattle. "Jimin, what has happened?" his thick accent was heavily laced with deep concern as his eyes darted over the stains on Jimin's jacket. "Are you alright?"

"Y-you don't wanna know," Jimin breathed, his throat raw as he shifted his feet to keep from collapsing right there on the marble flooring. "You really don't..."

"You don't!" Taehyung echoed right on cue, his voice a sudden, highly dramatic cry against Jimin's neck, though his eyes remained tightly shut.

Mateo's expression softened into immediate, intense pity. He stepped right into their path, resting his hands on the gold railing of the luggage cart. "Please, let me. It is the least I can do!"

This time, Jimin didn't even try to argue or protect his pride. The brutal reality of his aching muscles won. He let out a weak groan of gratitude and practically hauled himself up onto the plush luggage cart, slumping his back against the golden bars with a heavy sigh. Taehyung followed immediately after, practically crawling up the side like a clumsy koala, draping his long legs over Jimin's lap without a single care for decorum.

From where Jungkook stood near the grand entrance, he watched the entire absurd spectacle unfold.

Jimin, half-delirious from exhaustion, leaned his head back against the cold metal railing of the cart and let his eyes wander across the lobby one last time. He caught Jungkook's silhouette against the bright lights. He expected to see a frown, or a look of stern disapproval at their complete lack of professional composure.

But right before the Director could mask it, a tiny, genuine smirk cracked his usually frozen expression. It was incredibly soft, a microscopic lift at the corner of his lips that completely transformed his harsh features.

Jimin's heart did a strange flip at the sight. He blinked hard, his brain so fried from the dinner rush that he instantly questioned his own eyes. I'm too tired, he thought, his mind spinning. I'm hallucinating.

But deep down, a small part of him knew it was real. A warm, fuzzy sensation bloomed right in the center of his chest, a strange contrast to the cold exhaustion deep in his bones. Seeing such a soft, foreign look on the man was dizzying.

Before Jimin could question it any further, Jungkook's small smile vanished. The Director turned on his heel, his hands clasping behind his back as he walked away, his heavy boots clicking a slow rhythm into the quiet night.

"Hold on, my friends," Mateo murmured gently, a fond smile on his face as he gripped the handle of the cart.

With a smooth push, Mateo wheeled the gold cart forward toward the waiting elevators.

The gold elevator doors slid open with a soft chime, and Mateo carefully wheeled the cart right out into the carpeted hallway. Jimin managed to untangle himself from Taehyung's long limbs, sliding off the plush red carpet with a quiet grunt.

"Thank you so much, Mateo," Jimin whispered, his voice incredibly soft and thick with gratitude. "Seriously. You're a lifesaver."

Mateo offered a warm, understanding smile, waving a hand dismissively. "Of course, Jimin. Rest well."

With a final, sleepy nod, Jimin grabbed the back of Taehyung's ruined chef's jacket and steered him down the hall. They both sleepily trailed into their dark room, the door clicking shut behind them and sealing out the rest of the world. Taehyung didn't even look at his bed—he just face-planted directly onto the duvet, his boots still dangling off the edge, and was dead to the world in a matter of seconds.

Jimin, however, couldn't stand the smell of the kitchen lingering on his skin. With heavy, uncoordinated movements, he stripped out of his stained chef's whites, leaving them in a crumpled heap on the floor. He rummaged through his suitcase in the dark, pulling on a random, faded oversized t-shirt and a pair of striped pajama bottoms.

Crawling under the crisp, cool sheets of his own bed felt like heaven. He pulled the heavy comforter up to his chin, letting out a long, ragged exhale as his body finally relaxed into the mattress.

"Goodnight, Tae," he murmured into the darkness.

He was met with a loud snore in reply. Jimin let out a tiny, exhausted huff, his eyelids instantly feeling like lead as he let his eyes close, finally letting the darkness swallow him whole.



Jimin's eyes fluttered open.

He didn't wake up slowly; his mind just snapped awake into the darkness of the hotel room. He blinked, disoriented, before his gaze drifted to the glowing red numbers of the digital alarm clock on the nightstand.

2:00 AM.

Jimin frowned, his brain sluggishly doing the math. He'd only been asleep for less than an hour. A wave of frustration hit him, and he hurriedly squeezed his eyes shut, pulling the comforter tightly over his ears. Go back to sleep, he told himself fiercely. You have to be up early. Just sleep.

But sleep didn't come. His body was completely exhausted, but his mind was suddenly electric, buzzing with the lingering adrenaline of the dinner rush. Every time he closed his eyes, he heard the violent screech of the ticket printer, the roar of the burners, and the low sound of Jungkook's voice vibrating right against his ear.

He tossed to his left, burying his face in the pillow. Nothing. He rolled onto his back, staring blankly up at the dark, vaulted ceiling. His legs felt restless, a dull ache throbbing in his calves from the hours of standing under that central spotlight.

Finally, after what felt like an eternity of twisting the sheets into knots, Jimin sat up with a sharp, defeated huff, running a hand through his messy hair in the dark. He was wide awake.

Sleepily, he decided he couldn't just lie there staring at the ceiling anymore. Maybe he could walk downstairs, see if the hotel had any snacks, or honestly, just sit in the massive lobby until sleep finally hit him again.

Quietly, he tiptoed out of the plush bed, careful not to wake the snoring Taehyung. He slipped out of the room, turning the heavy door handle with agonizing slowness and shutting it with a soft, barely audible click. He hurried down the long, carpeted hallway and pressed the button for the elevator.

The lift ride down was silent and smooth, dropping him right back into the grand, cavernous lobby. Under the soft night lighting, the Macedonian marble looked almost ethereal.

At the front desk sat a lady. Even at 2:00 AM, her back was perfectly straight and her fingers

moved with lightning speed against her computer keyboard.

Jimin swallowed hard, suddenly very aware of his oversized t-shirt and striped pajama bottoms. He padded over to the high counter, resting his hands on the cool edge.

"Um... excuse me, ma'am..." Jimin began softly.

The receptionist looked up from her screen, her eyes blinking in slight surprise before a polite, professional smile split her face. "Oh! Hello, sir. How can I help you tonight?"

Jimin's cheeks instantly bloomed with a faint blush, his voice dropping an octave out of pure embarrassment. "I was wondering... do you guys have any snacks? Anything will work, honestly. I'm not a very picky eater... except seafood. No seafood, please."

The lady gave him a lingering, curious look, her mouth pulling tight as she took in his messy bedhead and pajama-clad frame. "Umm... let me see what we have available for late-night amenities."

She stood up and disappeared into a back room behind the counter. Jimin stood there awkwardly, peeking over the high desk with wide, curious eyes before shifting nervously from foot to foot on the polished floor.

A moment later, she returned carrying a velvet box. It was absolutely gorgeous—deep navy blue with gold embossed trim. She placed it on the counter, opened the lid, and tilted it gently toward Jimin.

"Will this do, sir?"

Jimin's mouth practically watered. The box was meticulously organized, filled to the brim with thick, honey-baked pretzels, rich dark chocolate-covered fruits, roasted almonds, and rare dried organic figs. It looked like a gourmet treasure chest.

"Y-yes! That's perfect, thank you so much!" Jimin beamed, a wide, relieved smile breaking across his face.

She beamed right back, nodding gracefully as she handed it over. "Yes, of course!"

Jimin didn't even wait to walk away. He was already stuffing his face, popping a chocolate-covered apricot into his mouth, entirely unaware of just how starving he truly was after burning a million calories in the kitchen.

The lady sat back down, her fingers returning to the keyboard. "That will be two hundred dollars, please."

Jimin stopped chewing immediately. His jaw locked around the pretzel he had just bitten into. "Wha—huh?"

"Two hundred dollars," she repeated, her voice perfectly pleasant, as if she hadn't just dropped a financial bomb into the quiet lobby. "It will be charged directly to your room, or we can settle it now. The curation features imported Swiss chocolates, artisanal honey-baked pretzels, and rare

dried organic figs. It's our premium late-night selection."

Jimin's soul practically left his body. Two hundred dollars? For snacks ? Panic flooded his veins, instantly wiping away any lingering traces of sleep.

"I—I didn't—I don't need the figs!" Jimin stammered, his eyes wide with horror as he looked down at the box like it was a ticking time bomb. "Can I put them back? I only ate two things, I can pay for the two things—"

"I'm afraid once the velvet seal is broken, we cannot restock the item," the woman explained, her professional demeanor tightening just a fraction.

Jimin frantically started reaching into his pajama pockets, his heart hammering against his ribs, only to realize with a sickening jolt that he didn't have his wallet. He didn't even have his phone. He was standing in a five-star Parisian lobby, covered in snack crumbs, completely broke.

"I can go get my card, I am so sorry, I can run upstairs—"

"Mettez-le sur mon compte personnel, s'il vous plaît."

A voice directly beside him cut through the air. It was deep, incredibly strong, and smooth, the flawless French flowing like heavy velvet.

Jimin froze, his breath catching painfully in his throat as he clutched the expensive velvet box tightly to his chest. He didn't even need to look up to know who it was. The sharp, intoxicating scent of crisp cologne instantly surrounded him.

Jungkook was standing right there at the desk. He had changed out of his chef's whites into a relaxed cashmere shirt, the sleeves pushed up to his forearms, but his presence was just as towering and suffocating as it had been on the line. His dark eyes were completely fixed on the receptionist when Jimin finally looked up.

With an effortless, fluid motion, Jungkook pulled a sleek black leather wallet from his back pocket, slid out a matte-black metal credit card, and slid it across the marble counter.

"I—It's okay—Chef, you don't have to—" Jimin began to scramble, his cheeks burning as he looked from the card to Jungkook's profile. "I can just go get my wallet, really, it's fine—"

Jungkook didn't even look at him. He simply raised a single, commanding finger, a silent instruction for Jimin to shut his mouth.

The receptionist didn't hesitate for a single second. Her professional eyes widened slightly at the sight of the black card, and she took it immediately, swiping it through the terminal. The machine let out a crisp, successful beep, and the payment went through.

Jimin's mouth pressed into a deep frown, his chest tightening with a complex mix of absolute mortification and overwhelming confusion. He stared down at the gorgeous velvet box in his hands, suddenly feeling very small, very underdressed, and entirely trapped under the heavy weight of the Director's sudden generosity.

"Thank you, Chef," the lady said smoothly, handing the matte-black card back.

Jungkook took it, sliding it back into his wallet with a slow, deliberate movement. Only then did he turn his head, his dark, heavy gaze dropping down to look at Jimin. His stare felt completely exposed, stripped of its academic barrier and vibrating with that familiar, intense friction.

He looked at Jimin's messy bedhead, then down at the oversized t-shirt that hung off his shoulders, and finally at the striped pajama bottoms.

Jimin bit his inner cheek, his face burning hotter by the second. "I didn't know it was that expensive," he mumbled defensively, looking everywhere but at the man's chest.

Jungkook just hummed, his gaze tracing the slight smudge of chocolate near the corner of Jimin's lip. He took a half-step closer, his towering frame completely blocking out the rest of the lobby. "Take the box and go. We have an 8:00 AM briefing."

Jimin nodded quickly, murmuring a soft, "Yes, Chef."

But as he turned away from the desk, he didn't head toward the gold elevator doors. His legs felt too heavy, and the thought of lying in that dark, suffocatingly quiet room while his brain buzzed with nervous energy was completely exhausting.

Instead, he padded in the opposite way, crossing the cool marble floor toward the deeply recessed lounge area. He slid onto one of the massive, cream-colored velvet sofas, tucking his knees up against his chest and tightly hugging the expensive box of treats to his ribs.

Jungkook stayed by the front desk, his hands resting loosely in his pockets as he watched Jimin, his dark eyes tracking the small, pajama-clad figure curling up on the furniture.

After a long, heavy moment of silence, the slow, rhythmic click of heavy leather soles echoed across the marble.

Jimin kept his eyes glued to the box, his heart doing a sudden, nervous skip as the shadow blocked out the warm amber light of the lobby lamps. He looked up, his breath catching in his throat.

Jungkook was standing right at the edge of the seating area, looking down at him.

"Is there something wrong with your room?" Jungkook asked.

Jimin was surprised by how quiet his voice was—devoid of the sharp, cutting authority from the kitchen. It was just a low and seemed to fill the empty space between them.

"Oh... no, Chef," Jimin stammered softly, shifting slightly against the velvet cushions under the weight of the man's attention. "The room is perfect. I just... I can't sleep."

"Why?" Jungkook pressed, taking a slow step closer, his shoulders casting a long shadow over the sofa.

Jimin bit his inner cheek, looking down at a chocolate-covered almond in the box. "I guess. Every time I close my eyes, I keep hearing the ticket printer. And the burners. My hands are still kind of

twitching." He let out a weak, self-conscious chuckle, his cheeks warming. "I think the adrenaline is just still inside of me"

Jungkook didn't laugh. He looked at Jimin's flushed face, his gaze dropping down to track the way Jimin's small, pale fingers were tightly gripping the edge of the navy velvet box.

"The first service rush always leaves a ghost in your hands," Jungkook murmured, his voice dropping into that private, hushed frequency. He walked around the edge of the low marble coffee table, and before Jimin could even process the movement, Jungkook sunk into the opposite end of the massive sofa.

The cushions shifted under his weight. Jimin stiffened slightly, his eyes widening. He was suddenly acutely aware of how close they were, the rich, sharp scent of Jungkook's cologne immediately overwhelming the faint smell of vanilla and sugar from the snack box.

Jungkook leaned back against the deep cushions, stretching one long leg out while his dark eyes locked onto Jimin's face with that familiar, intense friction.

"You," Jungkook started flatly, though his tone wasn't harsh. "You survived it. The food went out. Emily was impressed."

"Were you?" The question slipped out of Jimin's mouth before his brain could stop it. His breath hitched, his eyes locking onto Jungkook's features, terrified of the answer.

Jungkook's jaw tightened just a fraction, a microscopic glint of something unreadable shifting behind his dark irises. He didn't answer right away, letting the silence stretch between them until the tension in the air felt thick enough to suffocate.

"If I wasn't," Jungkook rumbled, leaning forward slightly, resting his forearms on his knees as he pinned Jimin with his stare, "You wouldn't be sitting on this couch right now."

Jimin beamed, his entire face lighting up as he quickly looked down at the box, trying and failing to hide the massive smile tugging at his lips. The praise felt like a sudden rush of warmth sweeping through his chest.

"Well," Jimin began, his voice lifting with a touch of newfound confidence as he reached into the velvet box and popped a dried fig into his mouth. "I guess diner work does pay off."

Jungkook didn't smile. In fact, the tiny hint of amusement that had been lingering in his eyes vanished instantly. His expression hardened, his jaw clamping shut into a rigid, stony line that made the atmosphere in the empty lobby turn freezing cold in a split second.

Jimin choked slightly on the fig, his smile dropping instantly as the suffocating weight of Jungkook's sudden disapproval slammed into him.

"Oh... um, sorry," Jimin mumbled, his cheeks flaring a bright, painful crimson. Panicking under the sharp shift in energy, he hurriedly reached into the box and shoved another chocolate-covered fruit into his mouth just to give himself something to do other than stare at the terrifying man in front of him.

Jungkook slowly straightened up, his broad back pressing flat against the velvet cushions of the sofa. His broad chest rose and fell with a heavy, deliberate breath, but his dark, bare eyes never left Jimin's face. The friction between them grew so thick it felt like static electricity.

"It's not wise to compare greasy-spoon diners to a Michelin-caliber service line," Jungkook stated. It wasn't a yell, but it carried a sharp, disciplinary weight that made Jimin's stomach drop. "Muscle memory is one thing. Technique is another. If you think what you did tonight was successful simply because you can run plates fast, you are severely misunderstanding the discipline of this craft."

Jimin swallowed hard, the sweet taste of the chocolate suddenly turning to ash in his mouth. He clutched the velvet box tightly against his ribs, feeling incredibly small beneath the Director's piercing, unblinking glare.

"What about you then?" Jimin began quickly, desperate to change the subject to something lighter before Jungkook completely iced him out. "What did you do before you became a star chef?"

Jungkook seemed completely taken aback by the question. His shoulders stiffened, and his brow raised a fraction of an inch, his eyes narrowing into a sharp squint as if he couldn't quite fathom a student asking him about his personal life. He let out a low, hum, leaning back against the cream velvet cushions. He stayed silent for so long that Jimin thought he was going to get yelled at again, but then Jungkook's jaw relaxed just a fraction.

"I was a motorcycle mechanic," Jungkook stated flatly.

Jimin stopped chewing immediately. A piece of honey-baked pretzel sat entirely forgotten on his tongue as his eyes went wide. He stared at the man in front of him—the pristine, elite director of an upscale culinary academy—and tried to map that image onto someone covered in engine grease and motor oil.

"No way, shut up!" Jimin burst out.

Jungkook's expression hardened instantly. His eyes turned into absolute ice, and his posture went terrifyingly rigid.

"Sorry! Sorry, it's an expression!" Jimin scrambled frantically, his face burning a fierce, bright crimson as he nearly choked on his pretzel. He tightly clutched the velvet box to his chest. "Umm... back home, it just means like... 'no way, you're lying,' or 'I'm shocked.' I didn't mean—I would never actually tell you to shut up, Chef...."

Jungkook didn't blink. He kept his piercing gaze locked onto Jimin's flushed, panicking face, letting the heavy silence stretch out until Jimin felt like he was shrinking into the velvet cushions.

Slowly, the intense tension in Jungkook's jaw dissolved, replaced by a subtle, dangerous tilt of his head. "Regardless of where you are from, you do not use that tone with me."

"Yes, Chef. I'm sorry," Jimin whispered, looking down at his lap, his heart hammering against his ribs.

"A mechanic," Jungkook repeated quietly, his eyes drifting down to his own large, heavily calloused hands resting on his knees. He flexed his fingers slowly. "Engines and kitchens aren't as

different as you think. They both require absolute precision, strict timing, and heat. If one component is off by a millimeter, the entire machine explodes. My dad owned a shop, and I worked there until I began school,"

Jimin hummed thoughtfully, his eyes lighting up with a sudden, quiet sense of shared information. It felt weirdly grounding to find a tiny piece of common ground with a man who usually felt like an unapproachable mountain.

"Wow," Jimin muttered softly, picking a dark chocolate-covered almond from the velvet box and popping it into his mouth.

He chewed slowly, his eyes drifting across the expansive, luxurious marble lobby before landing back on the man sitting across from him. The adrenaline from the kitchen, the lack of sleep, and the surreal nature of the 2:00 AM conversation were starting to make his filter slip again.

"I don't know much about mechanics, but..." Jimin began softly, a nervous, awkward chuckle escaping his lips before he could stop it. "Honestly, they really scare me. When I got my very first car—it was this totally beat-up, ancient sedan that rattled every time I hit forty—the alternator completely died on me one day. I took it to this shop down the road, and the mechanic there tried to tell me I needed a whole new transmission, an exhaust overhaul, and some part I'm pretty sure he just made up on the spot! He tried to rip me off for like two thousand dollars!"

Jimin let out a dramatic, breathless huff, waving a piece of pretzel in the air as the sleep deprivation completely overrode his mind. "I cried on the phone to my dad to get him to come down there and scare the guy into giving me a fair price. It was awful."

Then, realizing exactly who he was talking to, Jimin caught himself. His eyes went wide, and he hurriedly waved his hands, the color rushing back into his cheeks. "Oh! But—I mean, I'm sure your dad wouldn't do anything like that! I'm sure he's a really great guy and runs a totally honest shop. I didn't mean it like all mechanics are bad, just—well, that guy was a scammer."

Jungkook didn't interrupt him. Not once.

He just leaned back, sinking deeper into the velvet sofa. He rested his forearm along the top of the couch's armrest, shifting his weight slightly to the side. Then, he brought his hand up, curling his calloused fingers over his mouth and jawline—supporting his head, but really doing it to hide the persistent, quiet amusement tugging at his lips as he listened to Jimin go on and on. His eyes were completely focused, tracking every single animated expression, every flush of color on Jimin's skin, and the way his lips moved around the crumbs of the expensive snacks.

Suddenly, Jimin caught himself. He stopped mid-sentence, a piece of chocolate-covered fruit hovering inches from his face as he realized he had been talking non-stop for nearly five minutes straight to the most terrifying director at the academy.

The lobby fell into an incredibly thick, heavy silence.

Jimin frantically lowered his hand, his eyes widening in pure mortification as he stared at the velvet box. "I—I am so sorry, Chef. Ugh, I start talking a lot when I'm sleepy, it just..." He trailing off, burying his face slightly into the collar of his oversized t-shirt. "It just kind of spills out."

Jungkook slowly dropped his hand from his jaw, revealing that the small, rare smirk was still tilting the corner of his lips.

"You must be sleepy all the time then," Jungkook mumbled. His voice carried something soft. Something Jimin had never heard before.

Jimin's cheeks instantly flushed a fierce red. The tease caught him completely off guard, and his head snapped up, his wide eyes locking onto Jungkook's bare, unblinking ones.

Neither of them moved. Neither of them breathed.

They stayed exactly like that for a long, heavy beat, their eyes held captive by each other in the dim light of the empty lobby. The silence between them grew and it was overwhelmingly electric.

Slowly, Jungkook leaned forward, resting his forearms on his knees as his eyes dropped to the velvet box clutched to Jimin's chest before rising back up to hold his gaze.

"Hey," Jungkook began, his voice dropping into a quiet, serious baritone that completely shattered the playful atmosphere. "I was thoroughly impressed with you today," Jungkook said, the words heavy and deliberate in the quiet air. He didn't blink, his dark eyes anchoring Jimin to the sofa. "You handled a high-pressure line with more poise than most seniors I've seen in that kitchen. I want to see you continue to improve. This should be your goal always."

Jimin's breath caught, his chest tightening with a sudden, overwhelming rush of validation. To hear those exact words from him felt more intoxicating than any grade or trophy.

"Once we are back on campus," Jungkook continued, leaning a fraction closer, "I expect you to keep this same intent. Do not fall back into old habits or let the slower pace of the university labs make you lazy. If you continue showing up with this level of focus... I will continue to help you."

The offer hung in the air—an explicit, rare promise of personal guidance from the Director himself. Jimin could only nod dumbly, his heart hammering against his ribs as he clutched the box like a lifeline. "Y-yes, Chef. Thank you."

Jungkook held his gaze for one more lingering, suffocating second before he finally stood up. His towering frame cut through the ambient light of the lobby as he smoothed down the front of his cashmere sweater. He turned on his heel and took a step away, his heavy boots clicking against the polished marble.

Then, he stopped.

Without turning his entire body around, Jungkook tilted his head back slightly toward the lounge, his sharp profile silhouetted against the grand chandeliers.

"Goodnight, Jimin," he murmured softly.

Jimin's brain short-circuited at the sudden, casual use of his first name. He scrambled, his knees knocking against the snack box as he blurted out, "G-Goodnight! Chef! Goodnight."

Jungkook didn't reply. He walked away, his long, unhurried strides finally carrying him down the

corridor and completely out of sight.

The moment the Director vanished from the lobby, the suffocating tension in the room snapped.

Jimin let out a massive, ragged exhale that he felt like he'd been holding for an eternity. He immediately buried his burning face into his hands, dropping his forehead directly onto his knees. A small, muffled, high-pitched scream escaped his throat into his palms, his entire body shaking from a volatile mixture of pure exhaustion, disbelief, and a wild, fuzzy feeling.

He slid sideways, sinking further and further into the plush velvet cushions of the couch until he was practically a puddle of striped pajamas and oversized cotton. His mind was spinning out of control, replaying everything over and over and over and over.

He squeezed his eyes shut, his limbs feeling like lead as the lingering adrenaline finally began to drain from his veins.

Jesus, he thought, rubbing his tired eyes. *I need to go to fucking bed.*

Chapter 5

The trip came and blurred into a whirlwind of private classrooms, exclusive kitchen tours, and many, many chocolate croissants. And through it all, there were many, many lingering glances shared between him and Jungkook.

By the last day, Jimin was absolutely itching for freedom. He wanted nothing more than to go out and properly explore the city, and with only one more day left of the module, he was ecstatic when Jungkook announced they had been invited to attend a grand dinner ball right across from the Eiffel Tower.

Back in the hotel room, Jimin sighed and flopped heavily onto his bed, his head spinning with pure ecstasy and nervous excitement.

"Hobi... I think... I—"

"Don't you dare, Jimin!" Hobi's voice instantly exploded over the line. "How on earth do you go from 'I hate his fucking guts' to 'I want him to rearrange my guts' in just a few weeks?!"

Jimin's eyes went wide, and he frantically slammed his hand over the phone speaker, his face burning a bright red. He shot a paranoid look toward the bathroom door, listening closely to the steady, heavy hum of the shower. Taehyung was just feet away, safely distracted by the water, but Jimin still dropped his voice to a frantic whisper.

"Shhh! Shut up!" Jimin hissed into the receiver, curling inward on the mattress. "And I never said that! I never used those words! I just said he's cute... like an angry puppy..."

Hobi groaned so loudly it rattled the phone. "Well, don't forget that angry puppies bite, Jimin. They bite fucking hard, so—"

"But... this one is French," Jimin murmured softly, a helpless, dizzying warmth blooming in his chest. "Maybe he just kisses hard..."

"Remember that French guy I was talking to my senior year... he was so evil I sometimes still get nightmares," Hobi started voice laced with disgust.

"Yeah, well, this French guy isn't just a talking stage," Jimin shot back effortlessly. "He's rich, and... and—"

"—and scary, and mean, and your teacher," Hobi continued, checking off the boxes with a dramatic sigh. Then, the line went entirely quiet for a second. Jimin held his breath, waiting for the lecture, waiting for the voice of reason to slap him back into reality. "Wait..." Hobi began, his tone shifting from utter exasperation to a slow, wicked realization. "That's... kinda hot."

Jimin squeaked, his entire face bursting into a spectacular, burning blush. He fell back down against his bed, his spine hitting the mattress as he covered his face with his free hand, kicking his feet against the duvet in a sudden wave of pure, chaotic adrenaline.

"Look! Nothing is going on anyways!" Jimin whined into the empty room, desperately trying to quiet the wild thumping of his heart. "It's probably just me getting worked up over nothing. He's my teacher. He just... looks at me because I'm a student. It's just my brain making things up because we're in Paris."

"Jimin, honey, your brain might be in Paris, but your body is vibrating at a frequency that can be felt from across the Atlantic," Hobi laughed, though his voice softened into something a bit more comforting. "Just... enjoy the ball tonight, okay? Look gorgeous, eat the expensive food, and if a certain towering chef looks at you like you're on the menu-."

"Okay!" Jimin interrupted. "Love you Hobi I have to get ready bye!"

Jimin hung up the phone and tossed it onto the pillow, staring up at the white ceiling moldings. His stomach was a tangled mess of butterflies.



The grand ball had a strict dress code of luxury suits and high-end formal wear that Jimin certainly didn't own. So, once again, Taehyung had stepped in as his absolute saving grace.

He took his job a little too seriously, though. Currently, Taehyung had Jimin backed flat against the hotel room wall, fiercely swathing different fabrics and shirts against his chest with a look of terrifying, deep concentration.

"Your skin is very olive, but not deep olive... no, this won't do," Taehyung muttered to himself, tossing a rejection pile onto the bed behind him.

Jimin shifted uncomfortably, his eyes darting toward the clock. His overwhelming nervousness wasn't going unnoticed.

"Jimin," Taehyung began, his hands never pausing as he smoothed a crisp collar against Jimin's throat.

"Yes?" Jimin asked, his voice a little tight.

"Have you ever heard of the expression... *Amour secret des cagnards* ?"

A sly, devastating smirk pulled at the corners of Taehyung's lips. Jimin stiffened instantly, his breath hitching painfully in his chest.

"No," Jimin began, confused. "What is it?"

Taehyung didn't even look up from the selection of silk shirts draped over his arm. He just let out a low, knowing chuckle, his fingers flying as he tapped a sharp, tailored cream fabric against Jimin's collarbone. "It's a French saying. It translates roughly to... the secret love of the workers. Or more accurately, the blooming romance of a student towards his teacher," his, voice light, almost poetic, like he was admiring a painting.

Jimin's breath caught in his throat. He froze entirely, the blood rushing straight to his face. "Tae—"

"You are quite terrible at hiding your expressions, by the way," Taehyung added smoothly, his sharp eyes finally flicking up to lock onto Jimin's panicked face. The sly smirk on his lips widened. "You think I didn't notice you rolling back into our room at nearly three in the morning a few days ago smelling of expensive cologne? And don't think I don't see the way you look at him."

"We were just talking that night!" Jimin scrambled frantically, his hands coming up to swat at Taehyung's hands, his face burning so hot he was certain he was going to melt the fabrics. "—And I don't know what you're talking about so—"

"Relax, I'm not judging you." Taehyung sang, entirely unbothered by Jimin's crisis. He stepped back, discarding the cream shirt and selecting a breathtaking, deep midnight-blue silk button-down instead. He unbuttoned the top few loops and held it up to Jimin's chest. His eyes lit up. "Oh, yes. This is the one. Chef won't even know what hit him."

"Taehyung, please," Jimin groaned, covering his face with his hands to hide the sheer mortification. "He's, our.... teacher. He means nothing to me. Nothing is going on anyways."

"Whatever helps you sleep at night," Taehyung chuckled, tossing the silk shirt into Jimin's arms along with a pair of perfectly tailored, high-waisted black dress pants that looked like they cost more than Jimin's entire wardrobe combined. "Now, go put this on."

A few minutes later, Jimin stepped out again.

The silk shirt clung smoothly to his frame, the deep navy catching the warm hotel lighting and sharpening the lines of his collarbones where the top buttons were left slightly open. The high-waisted trousers shaped his waist perfectly, falling into a clean, elegant silhouette that made him feel like he had stepped into someone else's life.

Taehyung let out a low whistle from the bed, clapping once. "See? I'm a literal genius. You look incredible. Now let's fix that messy hair and get downstairs before the bus leaves."

By the time they reached the lobby, the atmosphere was thick with anticipation. The rest of the students were already gathered, dressed in an array of sharp black tuxedos and elegant gowns. But the second Jimin stepped out of the elevator, his eyes completely bypassed the crowd.

Standing near the entrance, speaking quietly with one of the coordinators, was Jungkook.

Jimin's breath caught instantly.

He had only ever seen Jungkook in his chef whites or in strict academic attire. Tonight, he wore a sleek black shirt, unbuttoned just enough at the collar to expose the strong line of his throat.

The sleeves were rolled to his forearms, revealing the dense muscle of his wrists and the dark ink of tattoos running down his skin. The mix of the refined tailoring and raw edge made him look almost unfairly striking.

His hair was pushed back neatly, exposing the sharp lines of his face, and his wire-rimmed glasses caught the chandelier light, giving him an air of quiet authority.

As if sensing the sudden shift in the air, Jungkook slowly turned his head.

Across the bustling marble lobby, through the sea of students and faculty, Jungkook's gaze didn't just linger—it tracked.

Down the silk shirt. Across the exposed line of his throat. Over the fitted shape of his waist and the clean fall of the trousers. It lingered for a fraction too long before moving lower, then dragged back up again with infuriating precision, like he was memorizing every detail.

By the time their eyes met again, the space between them felt charged, almost suffocating. Jungkook's jaw tightened slightly, his chest rising with a slow breath as he held Jimin in place with nothing but his stare.

Jimin instinctively reached for his ear, fingers brushing the small diamond studs Taehyung had insisted on, suddenly hyperaware of everything—the fitted clothes, the faint vanilla scent on his skin, the way he looked under these lights.

"I'm so incredibly hungry," Taehyung murmured, his voice cutting through the ambient chatter of the lobby as they finally moved forward into the crowd.

A few students stopped talking mid-sentence, their eyes tracking the pair of them as they walked past—Taehyung radiant in his emerald velvet, and Jimin looking impossibly sleek for once .

The sudden, intense scrutiny made Jimin feel instantly self-conscious. The ghost of Jungkook's heavy, sweeping gaze was still burning against his skin, and the added weight of his peers' stares made his stomach twist into nervous knots. He instinctively wrapped his arms around his front, his fingers digging slightly into the expensive fabric of his shirt.

When they stepped outside, the cool air hit Jimin's flushed face like a splash of cold water. It was completely dark out now, the evening leaving unwillingly as the sky turned a deep, heavy gray, bruised by the glowing neon and amber lights of the boulevard.

The city was still, however, very much alive. A low, constant hum of traffic, distant sirens, and the melodic chatter of locals drinking wine on heated patios drifted through the crisp air.

As they walked down the stone steps toward the bus, Jimin could feel the smooth, fluid slide of the silk against his skin. He felt exposed entirely wired on adrenaline. He took a seat next to Taehyung near the back of the shuttle, his eyes immediately darting out the window as Jungkook walked out looking so insanely hot it pissed him off.



The venue was everything Jimin had imagined....and somehow far more intimidating.

The pavilion was breathtaking, a masterpiece of glass and steel sitting directly along the River Seine. Massive glass walls stretched from floor to ceiling, offering an unobstructed view of the Eiffel Tower standing proudly across the water. Its golden lights reflected across the dark river in shimmering waves, making the entire scene feel almost unreal.

The moment the students stepped through the grand entrance, the scale of the place completely silenced them.

Soft gasps and excited whispers spread through the group as they looked upward at the glass ceiling and the enormous crystal chandeliers hanging above them. Thousands of tiny reflections danced across the polished floors, casting the ballroom in a warm, golden glow that made everything look like a scene from a movie.

Before anyone could fully take it all in, a line of waiters approached, each dressed in crisp white gloves and carrying silver trays covered with delicate crystal champagne flutes.

"Oh, thank you!" Jimin said brightly, accepting a glass with a polite smile.

The older waiter returned the gesture with a kind nod before continuing down the line.

Taehyung, however, showed no hesitation. With the confidence of someone who belonged there, he grabbed two glasses from the passing tray and finished them both almost immediately.

Jimin stared at him in disbelief.

"Tae..." he whispered, half amused and half shocked.

Ignoring him, Taehyung shrugged and reached for another.

Jimin lifted his own glass and took a careful sip. His eyes widened almost instantly.

The champagne was nothing like the cheap drinks he had tried before. There was no harsh burn, no unpleasant aftertaste—just a smooth sweetness that melted across his tongue. It was rich and delicate, almost like drinking something made specifically for people who lived in places like this.

Caught up in the excitement, the beautiful surroundings, and the sudden warmth spreading through his chest, Jimin found himself relaxing. He tipped his head back and finished the glass.

A second later, he reached for another one.

By the time he set the empty crystal flute back onto the tray, his cheeks were already glowing faintly pink.

"Wow," he said, looking at the glass in amazement. "Those are actually really good."

For a moment, Jimin forgot to be nervous.

Then someone walked past him.

A familiar scent.

Jimin froze.

Jungkook moved through the entrance with effortless authority, his tall figure immediately drawing attention without him needing to ask for it. As he passed, his shoulder brushed against Jimin's, and the brief contact sent a sharp jolt through him.

Jungkook's eyes only flicked toward Jimin's flushed face for the briefest moment before he turned his attention toward an older French gentleman waiting nearby.

"*Par ici*," Jungkook said smoothly, gesturing toward the ballroom. The students immediately followed, almost instinctively drawn in by his commanding presence.

Jimin followed behind them, but the moment he entered the main room, he stopped.

The ballroom was overwhelmingly full.

Everywhere he looked, there were elegant gowns sweeping across the floor, perfectly tailored suits, and influential figures from the culinary world mingling with European elites. Conversations flowed effortlessly in French, blending with the soft notes of a grand piano playing from the corner.

It was beautiful...but it was also very terrifying.

The champagne buzz that had made him feel lighter moments ago slowly faded, replaced by a familiar knot tightening in his stomach. Everyone here looked like they belonged.

And Jimin?

Even wearing Taehyung's expensive silk shirt, he felt like someone who had wandered into the wrong building by mistake. He shifted awkwardly, searching the crowd for something familiar.

Before he could say anything, Taehyung suddenly leaned closer.

"Wait, I think I see someone I know," Taehyung said, his eyes locking onto a figure across the room.

Jimin followed his gaze but couldn't recognize anyone.

"My old classmate," Taehyung explained with a small smile. "I'm going to go say hi."

Jimin's eyes widened slightly.

"Oh—wait, Tae—"

But Taehyung was already moving. He disappeared into the crowd of velvet gowns and expensive suits, leaving Jimin standing alone in the middle of the enormous ballroom.

Jimin slowly closed his mouth.

He knew Taehyung wasn't trying to leave him behind, but without him beside him, the room suddenly felt ten times bigger. Every conversation around him sounded louder. Every person looked more intimidating.

He couldn't understand half of what anyone was saying, and the confident, effortless way everyone interacted only made him feel more out of place.

His instincts screamed at him to find somewhere quiet.

His eyes searched desperately for something familiar. Anything that could distract him from the overwhelming atmosphere.

Then he spotted the food.

Along the edges of the ballroom sat long linen-covered tables filled with incredible displays: delicate pastries arranged like artwork, elegant hors d'oeuvres, colorful tartlets, glossy fruit geleees, and towering desserts that looked too beautiful to touch.

His stomach immediately reminded him that he had barely eaten since leaving the hotel. He slowly made his way toward the tables, focusing on the incredible creations in front of him.

He stepped backward to look at another display, completely unaware of anything else.

Until he bumped into someone.

Hard.

Jimin spun around instantly.

"Oh! I'm so—"

The apology stopped halfway.

Standing in front of him was an older man with sharp features, silver hair, and an intimidating presence. His perfectly tailored tuxedo made him look even more extravagant, and his posture was straight, almost severely so. His expression made Jimin's panic rise immediately.

Jimin glanced around, silently wishing the floor would open and swallow him.

"It's quite alright," the man said.

The deep British accent immediately caught Jimin's attention. The man adjusted his jacket and started to turn away.

"Now, if you'll excuse me, I must—"

Jimin stared at him. His tired brain suddenly connected the pieces, and his eyes widened.

"Wait..."

The man paused.

"Are you—"

He gave Jimin a polite but impatient look, clearly wanting the conversation to end there. "Yes. Now ___"

"Oh my gosh, I've read all of your cookbooks," Jimin blurted out, the words rushing out before he could stop them. "I watched your show every morning before school. Your section about traditional French reduction techniques in your third book—the 2018 edition—it completely changed the way I think about sauces. I practice those techniques all the time at my job back home, even if I'm just making gravy."

The man stared at him. Then, slowly, his stern expression softened as a small, genuine smile appeared.

"Using classical French reduction techniques for gravy," he repeated, amused. "How rebellious." Jimin laughed nervously. The chef studied him with curiosity. "You have passion, then?"

"Oh, I love cooking," Jimin answered immediately, his voice becoming softer. "It's difficult, and sometimes painful, but when everything comes together...the flavors, the presentation, the taste..." He smiled slightly. "There's nothing else like it."

The chef watched him for a moment, his expression warm. "That is a rare answer these days. Many young chefs want the recognition. The cameras. The awards. But they don't want the burns, the failures, or the years it takes to become great."

As the legendary chef spoke, Jimin's eyes drifted just a fraction over the man's shoulder, tracking a sudden shift in the ambient crowd.

His smile faltered.

Standing a short distance away near a towering marble pillar, completely framing the space, was Jungkook.

He looked impossibly intimidating, his dark eyes were locked directly onto them, tracking the animated conversation with a terrifyingly intense, unreadable focus. He held a crystal glass of amber liquor loosely in his hand. Sensing Jimin's gaze hitting him, Jungkook didn't blink. He simply tilted his chin up in a cold, wordless acknowledgment, raised the glass to his lips, and swung the liquid back in one smooth, aggressive swallow.

Jimin swallowed hard, his heart doing a violent flip, but he quickly forced his attention back to the man standing right in front of him.

"Well," Chef Ramsay said, entirely oblivious to what had just unfolded across the room. He adjusted the cuff of his jacket as he glanced toward the bustling ballroom. "I suppose I should

continue making my rounds before someone accuses me of hiding away."

His tone was light, carrying the same dry humor that had made Jimin love watching him on television for years.

"It was a pleasure meeting you, Jimin," Ramsay added, giving him one last approving, paternal look. "And I do hope I get the chance to hear more about these... unconventional techniques of yours later this evening."

Jimin's eyes widened slightly, a flush rising right back to his cheeks. "Yes! Of course. I mean, I would love that. Thank you so much, Mr. Ramsay."

The chef smiled, clearly amused by the young student's sincerity. "Enjoy the evening."

With that, Ramsay turned toward the crowd, effortlessly blending into the high-profile gathering. Jimin watched him leave, still completely dazed and breathless from the entire interaction.

Before he could even fully process what had just happened, Taehyung ran up, his hands gripping Jimin's shoulders as his jaw practically touched the floor.

"Was that... was that just—" Taehyung choked out, his eyes wide with absolute, disbelieving shock, his grip tightening like a vise.

Jimin just nodded numbly, cutting him off before he could even finish the sentence. Neither of them could fully comprehend the weight of the moment; between the legendary British chef praising his passion and the lingering heat of the Director's distant, heavy stare, Jimin felt close to fainting right there by the hors d'oeuvres table.

"Anyway," Taehyung cleared his throat, trying to shake off the collective daze as he looked toward the center of the room. "They're about to start dancing, so—"

"Dancing?" Jimin blurted out, frantically grabbing a pastry from the linen-draped table and shoving the entire thing into his mouth to keep from panicking.

"This is a ball, Jimin," Taehyung said, looking at him as if he were crazy.

"I've never..." Jimin mumbled around the pastry, his eyes widening as the grand crystal chandeliers overhead suddenly began to dim, casting a romantic, amber glow across the vast room. Immediately, the hum of casual conversation shifted. The elite crowd began moving in unison, clearing the center of the marble floor and forming elegant pairs as the soft piano music swelled into a rich, sweepingly beautiful orchestral waltz. Panicking, Jimin tried to back away into the shadows of the food table, his shoes slipping slightly on the polished floor. "No, no, Tae, I can't—"

But Taehyung was already grabbing him by the wrist, ruthlessly dragging him right out into the middle of the crowded floor. "It is not hard, just watch."

Before Jimin could protest further, Taehyung stepped in close, wrapping his arms firmly around Jimin's waist to steady him. Jimin instinctively clutched Taehyung's shoulders for dear life, using his friend as a physical anchor to keep the spinning room from swallowing him whole.

Jimin couldn't even bring himself to look at the crowd. He kept his head down, his brow furrowed in deep concentration as his dazed eyes strictly tracked the movement of Taehyung's feet on the marble, trying desperately to copy the rhythm.

Taehyung let out a low, amused chuckle at Jimin's clumsy, rigid movements. Leaning in close, a playful smirk dancing on his lips, he murmured in a perfectly smooth accent:

" Tu as deux pieds gauches, on dirait. "

"I can't do this, Tae!" Jimin expelled frantically, his cheeks burning. His head was still spinning, his steps feeling incredibly clumsy and heavy from the two glasses of rich French champagne he'd downed so quickly on an empty stomach.

Taehyung completely ignored his protests. He just hummed along smoothly to the sweeping orchestral music, entirely unbothered by the fact that Jimin was struggling to keep up with the rhythm.

Suddenly, Taehyung's eyes drifted past Jimin's shoulder, scanning the crowded floor. His gaze locked onto a specific spot across the room, and his eyes squinted with a sharp, calculating intensity.

Standing in the center of the glittering ballroom was Jungkook. He was dancing with an elegant older lady who seemed to know him well, his frame moving with an effortless, majestic grace. A wicked, brilliant idea flashed behind Taehyung's eyes. Without a word, he began intentionally backing them up, guiding Jimin across the marble floor with sharp, deliberate steps.

Jimin stiffened immediately, fingers tightening on Taehyung's shoulders as his footing wavered on the polished marble. "Wha—Tae, slow down—what are you doing?"

Taehyung didn't answer.

The orchestra swelled into a fuller, brighter crescendo, and the ballroom itself seemed to respond. Couples broke apart in smooth coordination, reforming into new pairs as silk gowns and dark suits spun through a practiced exchange.

Before Jimin could even process the movement, Taehyung caught him by the hand, a wide smirk breaking across his face. With a strong, practiced flick of his wrist, Tae spun Jimin outward into the shifting pattern of dancers.

Jimin's world blurred into a dizzying streak of crystal chandeliers and dark tuxedo jackets. The momentum sent him stumbling forward—his body betrayed by alcohol, momentum, and surprise all at once. Jimin gasped, closing his eyes. He braced instinctively for impact, already expecting the cold hardness of the floor.

Except the fall never came.

Instead, he was stopped mid-fall.

A firm hand locked around his waist, halting him so abruptly the air left his lungs in a quiet, stunned rush. The grip wasn't rough, but it was steady in a way that made everything else feel suddenly unreliable. Jimin's hands shot out on instinct, catching at the person holding him, fingers

gripping fabric as he tried to orient himself. He let out a breathless, confused sound, still half-convinced Taehyung was behind it all.

“Tae— I told you—”

Except when Jimin looked up, the words died instantly in his throat.

It wasn't Taehyung.

It was Jungkook.

The realization didn't come all at once. First the expanse of the chest beneath his hands. Then the scent. It was subtle mixed with something darker, expensive and terribly familiar. Then the stillness of the man holding him, as if the chaos of the ballroom simply didn't reach him. And finally, the face itself, calm and indecipherable, eyes fixed on him with a focus so direct it made Jimin forget the noise around them entirely.

Jimin's hands snapped back as if burned, heat rushing instantly to his face. He let out a small, embarrassed laugh that didn't quite land as confidence. “Oh—sorry, I thought you were—”

He tried to step back, but he couldn't. Jungkook's hand remained at his waist, firm enough to steady him but not so tight it felt restrictive. It just stayed there, holding him in place as the rest of the ballroom continued moving without them.

From over Jungkook's shoulder, Jimin's frantic eyes managed to spot Taehyung. He was already moving, swallowed into another turn of the dance, but not before throwing Jimin a quick glance—light, knowing, almost wicked in its timing.

Jimin swallowed hard.

"Drunk already?" The deep, voice vibrated right above Jimin's forehead, pulling his attention right back to the man holding him.

Jimin swallowed hard, his hands hovering awkwardly in the air between them. Under the heavy, unblinking weight of the Director's gaze, he timidly reached up, his palms settling like feathers against the planes of Jungkook's shoulders. "I... I just don't know how," Jimin whispered, his voice trembling slightly. "The dance. I've never done this before." He admitted, quieter now, his confidence thinning with every second he had to look directly at Jungkook.

For a moment, Jungkook didn't move. His expression remained controlled, but something subtle shifted in his gaze. It was an almost imperceptible tightening, as if he'd registered the answer more seriously than the question deserved.

He didn't let go of Jimin fully. Instead, moving with agonizing slowness, he slid one hand up from Jimin's waist, his fingers wrapping firmly around Jimin's forearm. Without a word, he guided Jimin's arm further up, draping it securely over the curve of his shoulder, forcing Jimin to step far too close for comfort.

"Then follow me," Jungkook murmured simply.

The Director shifted his weight, and suddenly, they were moving. Jungkook's hand returned to the small of Jimin's back, his palm a warm, steady guide.

Jungkook led without hesitation, each step certain, while Jimin struggled to match him at first, overly aware of everything. The pressure of the hand at his waist, the closeness of their bodies, the way Jungkook seemed completely unaffected by how near they were.

"You are incredibly bad at this," Jungkook suddenly mumbled a microscopic smirk tugged at the corner of his lips. " *Tu es d'une maladresse incroyable.* "

As the sweeping orchestral waltz swelled around them, Jungkook suddenly leaned down, his lips brushing dangerously close to the shell of Jimin's ear. Low beneath the roaring music, he began to count out the rhythm, a private, hypnotic cadence meant only for Jimin.

" *Un, deux, trois. Un, deux, trois...* "

The syllables rolled off his tongue in a smooth, rhythmic buzz. With every count, Jungkook's chest pressed firmly against Jimin's, until the distance between them entirely evaporated.

Jimin's eyelids slipped closed, his breath hitching as he completely surrendered his weight to the neat pulse of Jungkook's voice. Without the distraction of the spinning room, the cadence became his entire world, guiding his feet in a perfect, blind syncopation.

They were completely flush against each other, the fine silk of Jimin's shirt melting into the stark, heavy fabric of Jungkook's tuxedo. Every time Jungkook took a breath, Jimin could feel the warm, solid expansion of his chest, and the rich scent smoky radiating off his skin made Jimin's head spin faster than the champagne ever could.

Even with his eyes shut in desperate concentration, Jimin stumbled once, his shoe catching slightly on the polished marble. Jungkook's grip on his waist instantly tightened like iron, easily absorbing his weight and guiding him effortlessly back into the rhythm of the waltz without a single break in the count.

"Un, deux, trois..." Jungkook continued, his voice dropping even quieter, closer, until his warm breath fanned across Jimin's cheek. "Trust your steps. Look up."

Slowly, hesitantly, Jimin's lashes fluttered open, his gaze flickering up from the darkness. His eyes traveled past the stark black buttons of the shirt, tracing the rigid, sharp line of Jungkook's jaw, until his dazed, warm eyes finally locked onto the Director's.

The usual cutting sharpness in Jungkook's eyes—the kind that left no room for error in the classrooms—had dulled into something entirely unrecognizable. It was a deep, quiet tenderness, shifting beneath the amber light of the chandeliers, and it felt completely sacred.

Jungkook's counting slowed to a breathless whisper, his thumb tracing a slow, deliberate circle against the silk of Jimin's waist. They moved together in perfect harmony now, completely synchronized to the rhythm, spinning slowly beneath the crystal light while the rest of the world faded into a beautifully blurred background.

"I think I may be a little drunk," Jimin whispered, the confession slipping out in a soft, breathless rush as his boot caught slightly on the marble again. Yet, even with the room tilting, he didn't lose the rhythm; Jungkook's hand at his waist was steady, effortlessly correcting his balance before he could fully falter.

Beneath the sweeping swell of the violins, Jimin thought he felt the deep expanse of Jungkook's chest vibrate with a low, rough chuckle, but he couldn't be entirely sure. The sound was swallowed by the music, leaving only the ghost of a warm breath brushing against Jimin's forehead.

Determined not to look down again, Jimin kept his gaze locked upward, his dazed, warm eyes tracing every sharp line and subtle shift of the man's expression. Up close, the Director's features lost their usual rigid austerity. There was a dark, consuming intensity in his stare, a heavy friction that seemed to pull Jimin closer with every slow, deliberate step they took together.

Suddenly, the grand orchestral waltz reached its final, echoing note. The music died down into a soft fade, and the surrounding ballroom instantly erupted into enthusiastic applause, the elite crowd thoroughly amused and delighted by the performance.

But neither Jimin nor Jungkook reacted.

The rest of the world remained completely muted. They stayed frozen in the center of the floor, their bodies still pressed flush together. Neither of them moved to break the contact. Their eyes stayed locked, dancing across each other's features in a quiet, breathless trance—Jimin's gaze tracing the lines of Jungkook's features, while Jungkook's eyes drank in the flushed heat of Jimin's cheeks and the sparkle of the lights reflecting from his eyes.

The space between them felt dangerously thin, charged with an electric, suffocating heat.

Slowly, Jungkook's gaze dropped. His eyes tracked down the slope of Jimin's nose, anchoring heavily onto his softly parted, pink lips. For a fraction of a second, the grip on Jimin's waist tightened, a sudden, fierce possessiveness flaring in the Director's dark eyes.

Then, as if suddenly snapping back to reality, Jungkook's jaw clenched. He abruptly cleared his throat, the sharp sound cutting through their private bubble, and deliberately pulled his hands away from Jimin's waist. The sudden loss of his warmth made the cool air hit Jimin like a physical shock.

"Excuse me," Jungkook rumbled, his voice rough, deep, and entirely strained.

Before Jimin could even form a syllable to respond, the Director turned on his heel. He moved with a sudden, tense urgency as he disappeared quickly into the sea of pristine people, leaving Jimin standing entirely alone in the center of the marble floor.

Jimin just stood there, his eyes wide, his heart hammering violently against his ribs as his hands hovered in the empty air where Jungkook's shoulders had just been.

Jimin snapped back into himself only when Taehyung suddenly swept into view, circling him with theatrical ease before stopping directly in front of him. His emerald velvet blazer caught the chandelier light as he spun to a graceful halt, like he'd just finished performing on a stage only he could see.

"Je devrais recevoir un prix pour—" Taehyung began, grinning like someone about to announce a victory.

Then he stopped.

The words fell cleanly out of him as his eyes focused on Jimin's face.

Jimin was blinking slowly, unfocused, his lips still slightly parted as he tried to catch up with his own breathing. His expression looked suspended between shock and absence, as if whatever had just happened hadn't fully released him yet. His hands hovered loosely at his sides, fingers faintly unsteady. His body still hadn't decided what to do without Jungkook holding him in place anymore.

Taehyung's playful expression softened instantly.

"Whoa, Jimin," he said, voice dropping into something more personal. He stepped closer and caught Jimin by both shoulders, steadying him. "Hey. Hey—breathe. What did he do? Did he say something to you? Did he yell at you?"

Jimin shook his head quickly, almost too quickly, like the question itself didn't match what he was feeling. His fingers lifted on instinct, brushing against his earlobes where the diamond studs caught the light—anchoring himself to something physical.

“No,” he said, barely audible. His throat tightened as he tried to form the rest of it, but the words kept breaking apart before they could settle. “He didn’t yell. He didn’t say anything. He just... he looked at me.”

Jimin's brows knit faintly, frustration flickering through confusion. He tried again, slower this time, as if repeating it might make it make sense.

“He just looked at me, Tae. Like—” He stopped, exhaling shakily, staring past Taehyung into the drifting crowd as if Jungkook might still be there in the space between people. “He just looked at me.”

Taehyung went very still.

For a beat, there was only the distant swell of music and the low murmur of the ballroom around them. Then Taehyung’s mouth slowly opened, like his brain had finally caught up with what it had witnessed.

“*Putain de merde*,” he muttered, half awe, half immediate concern. A grin tried to surface and failed halfway through, collapsing into something more like disbelief. “Jimin...”

He grabbed Jimin’s forearm and gently pulled him toward a quieter corner of the room, steering him away from the center of the floor. “Okay. No. We need food. Now. Before your brain fully detaches from your body.”

Jimin didn’t argue. He let himself be guided, still slightly off-balance, still trying to process what had just happened.

Near a tall glass window framed by heavy curtains, Taehyung finally released him. Jimin immediately gravitated toward a small passing tray of pastries, grabbing one almost instinctively. He bit into it without thinking, the sweetness and warmth of it cutting through the lingering haze in his head. For a moment, his shoulders dropped. His breathing evened out. The world felt a little less tilted.

Then, across the ballroom, a shift in presence.

Jimin froze mid-bite.

Jungkook was there.

The softness from earlier was gone. Completely. In its place stood the Director as everyone else seemed to know him: composed, distant, razor-sharp.

Jimin swallowed slowly, pastry half-forgotten in his hand.

Yet instead of fear, something stranger stirred in his chest. A kind of alertness. Awareness. His own body recognized the shift before his mind could decide how to interpret it.

He lifted his thumb absentmindedly, brushing away a crumb with his tongue, eyes still locked on Jungkook without realizing how obvious his stare had become.

Jungkook stood surrounded by a circle of older, sharply dressed figures—men and women who carried themselves with the quiet authority of people used to being listened to. Investors, faculty, officials; people whose presence usually filled space.

And yet Jungkook still outshined them all.

He didn't smile. He simply listened, head angled slightly as one of the older men spoke, giving the occasional small nod that somehow redirected the entire conversation without him ever raising his voice.

Jimin couldn't look away.

There was something unsettling about the ease of it—the way the room seemed to orbit him without resistance.

Jimin forgot he was holding the pastry entirely.

“Ugh, I’m so bored,” Taehyung groaned beside him suddenly, breaking the spell as he flopped his head back dramatically and drained his glass.

Jimin blinked, snapping slightly out of it, though his attention didn’t fully leave the far side of the room. “Yeah,” he said automatically, though it wasn’t true. Not even a little. Jimin tipped his own glass back, anyway, letting the wine burn through the strange tension still sitting under his skin.

Taehyung set his empty glass down with finality. “We’re leaving. I’m suffocating in here. If I hear one more person say ‘deconstructed soufflé,’ I’m going to commit a crime.”

Jimin hesitated, glancing back toward the circle Jungkook stood in. “We’re not supposed to just leave though... Chef will notice.”

“Jimin,” Taehyung said flatly, grabbing his wrist, “look around. Half the students are either completely drunk or left an hour ago to find a club.”

Jimin blinked, looking around the grand ballroom, and well... Tae was right. The strict academic structure of the afternoon had completely dissolved into a hazy, late-night social blur.

Most of their classmates had already drifted off into the glittering night, disappearing in small groups to make the most of their last night in the city, no one quite sure where they’d ended up or what the night would turn into.

Taehyung tugged him gently but firmly, and Jimin followed.

They slipped through the side of the ballroom, past distracted staff and open doors, until the heavy warmth of the event collapsed behind them.

The transition from the stifling of the ballroom to the refreshing evening breeze hit Jimin instantly. He swayed a little on his feet, the sudden shift making his head spin in the most delightful way. A breathless, bubbly giggle escaped his lips as they began walking down the stone-paved sidewalk.

The alcohol was fully coursing through his system now, loosening the tight knot of anxiety in his chest and making absolutely everything ten times funnier than it actually was.

“We’re so getting in trouble,” he giggled, stumbling slightly as the uneven cobblestones caught his shoes. The silk of his shirt shifted in the wind, brushing against his skin as everything inside him finally loosened.

“Tae,” he added, still laughing under his breath, “I-I lost count of how many drinks I had,” he said suddenly, like the thought had just floated to the surface. He lifted his hand to try and count on his fingers, squinting down at them with intense focus—but the numbers didn’t come. The memory of them slipped away every time he tried to grab it.

His brows pinched in quiet confusion for a second, then his expression cracked. A laugh slipped out of him, soft and breathless.

Taehyung was just as gone as he was, his laughter spilling out in loud, unfiltered bursts that echoed down the quiet street. They kept moving forward in uneven rhythm, shoulders bumping, feet catching on every uneven cobblestone like the ground itself was part of the joke. Every few steps one of them would nearly trip, recover, and immediately dissolve into laughter again.

They rounded a wide basin of water, its surface still and dark, reflecting the soft glow of the city lights like spilled gold. Jimin’s balance finally gave out completely. His knees buckled beneath him, and he dropped onto the damp grass with no resistance, laughter breaking out of him so hard it left him breathless and aching.

“I can’t—I can’t walk anymore,” he managed between gasps, curling slightly as another wave of laughter hit him. “I’m gonna— oh my god—”

He tipped over fully, falling onto his side in the grass like gravity had simply decided for him.

Taehyung followed a second later with far less grace, collapsing beside him in a heavy thud, one arm flung across his stomach as he let out a long, exaggerated groan that quickly turned into laughter again. His blazer shifted as he settled, grass sticking to the velvet like glitter.

For a while, neither of them moved much. Just breathing, laughing in fading waves, staring up at the cloudy sky that looked soft and endless above them. The cool ground pressed into Jimin's back, steadying the heat still buzzing through his body.

Taehyung eventually rolled onto his side, propping his head up on his hand as his laughter softened into something quieter. His eyes flicked over Jimin's face, more focused now beneath the haze of alcohol.

"Jimin," he said, voice less playful than before, "once the semester ends... are you going straight home? Or staying in France a bit?"

Jimin's fingers, which had been absentmindedly picking at the grass, stopped mid-motion. He stared up at the sky for a moment without answering, the laughter still lingering in his chest but fading at the edges.

Then, slowly, his gaze shifted.

Past Taehyung's shoulder. Past the dim curve of trees. Past the dark water.

Something tall and familiar broke through the skyline.

Jimin pushed himself up on his elbows first, then sat up, blinking hard like he wasn't sure what he was seeing. He had been so incredibly drunk out of his fucking mind—*so thoroughly consumed by the night*—that he had completely forgotten where he actually was. His breath caught slightly as he rose to his feet, unsteady, shoes sinking a little into the grass.

The Eiffel Tower stood there like it had been waiting the entire time.

It was massive, lit in warm gold.

Jimin's mouth parted without him realizing it. The noise in his head thinned out, replaced by something softer and clear. The city around it felt smaller in comparison, like everything else had stepped back to make room for it.

“Oh...” he breathed, the sound barely there.

For a moment, he didn't move at all. Just stood under it, eyes tracing the iron lattice as it climbed into the night, catching light like it was holding it instead of reflecting it. It was close enough that Jimin felt like he could reach out and touch the glowing metal, the light reflecting perfectly in his wide, dazed eyes.

Then, without looking away, he spoke again—softer this time, like he was saying something he hadn't fully decided to admit.

“Stay,” he whispered.

Taehyung shifted behind him, but Jimin didn't turn. His eyes stayed locked on the tower, as if it might disappear if he blinked.

“If I go back right away...” His voice wavered slightly, not from humor now, but from something more uncertain. “It's just... the same everything.”

His throat tightened faintly, but he kept going anyway.

“But this...” He gestured vaguely upward, toward the golden light spilling through the night air. “I don't think I'm ready to leave it yet.”

Jimin began walking forward, his feet moving mindlessly across the grass as if he were under a total spell, drawn toward the towering monument like a moth to a golden flame. His head was tilted completely back, his eyes wide and unblinking as the brilliant, shimmering light washed over his face.

Taehyung sat up slowly on the damp grass, his head tilting lazily to the side as he watched his friend drift away into the night. “Jimin?” he called out.

Jimin looked back over his shoulder, his lips pulled into a dazed, brilliant smile. "Look at it, Tae," he slurred softly. But as he tried to turn back towards the tower, his shoes tangled on a root, and he tripped over his feet, letting out a sharp, breathless gasp as he stumbled.

"Whoa—okay, I'm coming," Taehyung muttered with a loose chuckle. He scrambled up, dusting off his velvet blazer with a completely uncoordinated swipe of his hands before jogging a few messy steps to catch up. He looped his arm right back through Jimin's, acting as a mutual, swaying brace.

Together, they walked the final stretch toward the base of the Eiffel Tower. The closer they got, the more massive and staggering the structure became. The cool night air swirled around them, carrying the distant, faint hum of traffic, but beneath the tower, it felt like they were inside a cathedral of pure light.

By the time they reached the giant, arching iron legs, Jimin was completely and utterly enthralled.

He leaned his weight entirely against Taehyung, his head rolling back against his friend's shoulder as he stared straight up into the infinite labyrinth of glowing golden beams piercing the gray sky.

"T-Tae... look't it," Jimin slurred, his words melting together into a soft, velvety puddle as the alcohol completely took the wheel. His fingers reached up, loosely pointing at the sky.

"It's so... it's like a giant gold star. It's so big. We're just like... tiny little ants in a giant, expansive world." He let out a bubbly, heavy giggle, his eyes crinkling shut for a second before fluttering open, glazed over with awe. "... everything is just... wow ."

A pause.

"I'm so happy!" Jimin suddenly wailed.

Before he even knew what was happening, the overwhelming awe, the rich champagne, and the feeling of being in Paris completely broke through his defenses. He began to cry. Loud, gasping, and incredibly dramatic tears that poured down his flushed cheeks.

The handful of late-night tourists and locals strolling beneath the monument immediately paused, stepping back with expressions that hovered somewhere between deep concern and disgust at the messy display.

" *Oh, non, ne pleure pas,* " Taehyung groaned in soft, wine-slurred concern, instantly wrapping his arms around Jimin and pulling him into a tight hug to shield him from the judgmental stares.

"I'm just—I'm so glad we're here, Tae!" Jimin sobbed into his friend's shoulder, his emotions completely dialed up to ten.

After a few minutes of dramatic weeping, the heavy wave of tears slowly subsided into a loose, comfortable exhaustion. Taehyung yawned loudly, his eyes half-closed as the late hour finally caught up to him. "Jimin, I'm so tired. I want to sleep. Let's go back to the hotel."

"Nooo," Jimin whined, completely protesting the idea. He intentionally let his knees buckle, sinking right back down onto the cold, hard ground beneath the golden tower. "I'm staying right here. I'm never leaving."

Ignoring any once of decorum, Jimin sprawled out completely like a starfish, his arms and legs flung wide across the pavement. He stared straight up into tower, his tear-brushed eyes twinkling brightly under the thousands of shimmering lights.

It was arguably very unhygienic, given the thousands of tourists who walked those stone paths daily, but Jimin was far too drunk, far too emotional, and far too captivated to care about a little dirt. He felt like he was floating in a sea of gold.

Taehyung sighed, stumbling forward and grabbing Jimin by his wrists, attempting to hoist him up. "Jimin, c'mon," Tae muttered, tugging with all his might, but Jimin intentionally made himself complete dead weight, his body glued to the ground. "Jimin, seriously, it's 3:00 AM. We have to be back at the hotel before the academy bus leaves tomorrow, and we still need to get some sleep."

"Go without me," Jimin mumbled slurry, waving a dismissive, limp hand in the air. "Go, Tae. I'll be fine. I'm gonna stay here all night. I'm part of the ground now."

Taehyung dropped Jimin's wrists with a frustrated huff, stumbling away a few paces into the shadows. Jimin loosely assumed he was actually abandoning him to go back to the hotel, but in reality, Taehyung's hazy, protective brain was frantically looking around the plaza to find some kind of help to haul his stubborn friend off the concrete.

Left entirely alone, Jimin lay there in total bliss, his face bathed in the warm, ambient glow. His eyes glittered, reflecting the sparkling lights of the monument as he traced the golden beams cutting through the dark sky.

Suddenly, the golden light washing over his face was completely cut off.

A massive, towering shadow loomed directly over him, crowding his view and blacking out the light of the Eiffel Tower entirely. Jimin blinked his dazed, blurred eyes, staring up into the darkness of the silhouette that had just stepped into his private universe.

Jimin's vision swam violently, the world folding in on itself in soft, drunken distortions. The Eiffel Tower above him fractured into two glowing silhouettes, then three, then slowly stitched itself back together as he blinked too hard against the light.

He pushed himself up slightly on his elbows, his head lolled as he tried to focus on the dark shape cutting into the light above him, squinting until the figure finally began to resolve into something familiar.

"Chef?" he murmured, the word slipping out in a soft, breathless slur, more question than recognition.

Taehyung suddenly stumbled into the frame right next to the towering man, his brows pulled tight in a mixture of guilt and exhaustion. "Sorry, Jimin. He found me first."

Jungkook just stood there, his expression completely unreadable. The harsh line of his jaw was set, and his hands were shoved casually into the pockets of his tailored trousers, his matte-black tuxedo jacket hanging open.

He looked down at Jimin without blinking for a moment too long.

Then, flatly, to Taehyung: "Go get some sleep. I can handle it," His tone leaving absolutely no room for argument.

Taehyung exhaled like he'd been waiting for exactly that permission. His expression softened into something almost amused, almost relieved, and he tilted his head in a lazy, theatrical little bow.

"Goodnight, my friends," he sang out lightly, already stumbling backward as he gave a final crooked grin toward Jimin before turning and disappearing into the dim path leading away from the tower.

Jungkook watched him leave with squinted, deeply unimpressed eyes before slowly turning his gaze back down to the starfish on the ground. "Up."

Jimin instantly closed his eyes, letting his head drop back onto the cold stone. "I-I can't."

Jungkook exhaled a heavy, sharp breath through his nose. "It is late, and I do not have time for games. Stand up."

Under normal circumstances, the authority in his voice would have had Jimin scrambled onto his feet in a microsecond, apologizing profusely. But the massive amount of champagne and wine currently coursing through his veins said otherwise. His muscles felt like absolute steel, and his heavy, emotional heart felt even heavier.

"If I leave..." Jimin whispered, his eyes fluttering open to look up at the towering man blocking the golden light. A soft, drunken pout formed on his lips. "What if I'm never back? What if I go back and I never see something this big again?"

Jungkook stared at him, a flat, thoroughly deadpan expression crossing his sharp features. "We are an hour away from the campus. It is not that serious."

"It is to me," Jimin whined dramatically, his emotions bubbling right back to the surface. He looked from the tower to Jungkook, his alcohol-addled brain suddenly striking a deal. Slowly, hesitantly,

he lifted one of his arms, his small hand hovering in the empty air between them, beckoning the chef. "Help me."

"I told you to stand up on your own," Jungkook rumbled, crossing his arms over his chest, his heavily inked forearms flexing under the ambient light. "I'm not carrying you."

"I'm not asking you to carry me," Jimin slurred, his fingers wiggling in the air as he suborned his jaw. "Just... if you get down here, then I'll get up. Deal?"

"I am your teacher. I do not make deals with students especially not drunk ones."

"Then I guess I live here now," Jimin muttered, closing his eyes again and comfortably folding his hands over his stomach. "Goodbye, Chef Jeon."

A heavy, suffocating silence stretched between them, punctuated only by the distant, rhythmic sparkling of the Tower.

Jungkook let out a low, venomous curse in French under his breath—something sharp and dark that made Jimin's eyes open a crack.

The Chef shot a quick, fiercely protective look around the deserted, shadowed plaza, ensuring no lingering tourists or faculty members were watching. Then, with a slow, deeply irritated sigh, he unbuttoned his tuxedo jacket.

Moving with a heavy, deliberate pace, Jungkook bent his knees and lowered his frame, completely abandoning his dignity as he sank right onto the ground beside Jimin.

Jungkook sat with his legs bent, resting his forearms on his knees as he stared straight ahead at the shimmering basin of water. He looked entirely out of place—an elite, devastatingly handsome chef, sitting flat on the gritty concrete at three in the morning just because a stubborn student refused to move.

Jimin turned his head slowly to the side, his cheek pressing against the cool stone as he looked up at the man beside him. Jungkook's profile was sharp against the golden glow of the tower, his glasses reflecting the intricate iron patterns above them.

The silence stretched between them, heavy and thick, but strangely devoid of the usual cold tension from the classroom. It was a private, breathless quiet.

Jimin, still sprawled out like he had melted into the pavement. Blinked once. Then again, slower. His breathing evened out into something soft and unbothered, like the world had stopped asking anything of him for the first time all night.

And then, very faintly, he began to hum.

At first, it was just air shaped into sound. It was barely there, unsteady, almost accidental. Then it settled into a melody. "*La vie en rose*," soft and wandering, as if he were remembering it piece by piece. The sound wasn't strong, but it was steady enough to fill the space between them in a way words hadn't.

Jungkook turned his head slightly.

His brows knitted just enough to show confusion rather than irritation. "What are you doing?" he asked, voice low, clipped, still trying to make the whole situation into something logical.

Jimin didn't stop humming.

He let the note trail off lazily before turning his head a fraction toward Jungkook, eyes half-lidded and unfocused, cheeks still flushed from alcohol and cold air.

"I'm humming," he said simply, like that should've ended the conversation. Then, after a pause, he lifted one finger into the air between them. "I saw it in a movie once. Just—shh."

Jungkook stared down at him for a beat longer than necessary.

Something subtle tightened in his jaw. Not anger exactly but something closer disbelief trying not to become expression. “Do not -,”

Jimin ignored him completely as his humming suddenly grew louder

The melody swelled in volume, spilling out of him with more confidence than his state should have allowed, as the song mattered more than anything Jungkook was saying. It wasn’t aggressive, but it was unmistakably intentional.

Jungkook stopped mid-sentence.

A quiet scoff left him through his nose, sharp with disbelief rather than anger.

Jimin still humming and still pushing his luck, was waiting for the correction. The reprimand.

But it didn’t come.

Only silence.

The humming faded on its own, thinning as Jimin’s confidence wavered in the absence of a reaction. Slowly, cautiously, he cracked one eye open.

Jungkook was still there.

Still sitting beside him on the cold ground, forearms resting on his knees, posture steady despite everything around him. But he wasn’t speaking anymore.

He was just looking at him.

His expression wasn't cold in the way Jimin expected it to be. It wasn't sharp or dismissive or irritated. It was still controlled— as always —but something in it had changed.

Jimin's hair was spread loosely across the stone, slightly tangled from earlier movement, catching thin streaks of gold from the tower above. His lashes fluttered faintly each time he blinked, his expression entirely unguarded now as the man above him stared.

Slowly, Jungkook exhaled, the white mist of his breath catching the golden light. He slid his hand from his knees to the ground just inches away from Jimin's hand.

"The deal was that you get up," Jungkook reminded him softly, his eyes tracking the way the light illuminated the small diamond studs in Jimin's ears. "Are you a man of your word, Jimin?"

Hearing his own name fall from Jungkook's lips made something in Jimin's chest tighten all at once. He swallowed, throat suddenly dry, eyes still unfocused but locked onto Jungkook as if the rest of the world had been quietly turned down in volume.

"Only if you help me," he whispered.

The words came out softer than intended, almost fragile, carried more by breath than voice. Slowly, he slid his hand across the cold stone between them. The movement was unsteady, delayed by alcohol and hesitation, but deliberate in its direction. His knuckles brushed first—light contact against the dark, intricate ink along Jungkook's wrist.

Jungkook went still.

Not visibly startled. Not reactive in the obvious sense. Just... still.

His gaze dropped immediately to the point where their skin met.

For a moment, he didn't move away.

Didn't correct him.

Didn't speak.

Jimin waited anyway, breath caught slightly in his throat, unsure whether he had crossed a line he wouldn't be allowed to step back from.

But Jungkook didn't pull back. He just watched him with a heavy, lingering gaze that felt entirely stripped of any hesitation, before his large, calloused hand turned over and wrapped firmly around Jimin's wrist, pulling him gently but inevitably upward.

Jungkook had barely managed to get a steady grip on Jimin's wrists when he started to pull him up.

Still, Jimin tried to push himself upward, however, his balance was completely thrown the second his feet hit the stone. The ground tilted violently under him, and instead of standing proud, he crashed forward so hard and sloppily that he had absolutely no control over his own body.

He collided heavily against Jungkook's chest, throwing his entire weight onto the man so suddenly that even he couldn't absorb the shock. Caught completely off balance, Jungkook stumbled backward, his leather shoes slipping on the smooth pavement before he fell flat on his back with a heavy, muffled thud, taking Jimin right down with him.

Jimin landed directly on top of him, a breathless gasp knocked out of his lungs. The world spun in a dizzying blur of golden light and dark fabric.

Clumsily, his limbs moving like loose gelatin, Jimin pushed himself up, straddling Jungkook's lap as he sat up on his knees. His small hands came down to rest heavily on the Director's chest for support, his fingers bunching into the fine fabric.

"Sorry," he blurted immediately, breathless and panicked. "I'm—I'm a man of my word, I swear, I just—I didn't mean to—" His words tangled as he tried to shift his weight, attempting to climb off in a flustered rush. "I can stand, I can stand, see? I just—I'll get up and—"

Jimin's voice cut off completely, the words dying in his throat when he realized Jungkook wasn't even attempting to push him off.

He was lying beneath him, still, one arm already secured around Jimin's waist, holding him in place not firmly enough to keep him from falling over. His other hand rested against the stone, stabilizing them both. His glasses were slightly tilted from the fall, catching fractured gold light from above.

Jungkook's eyes were completely unmoored, tracking the soft line of Jimin's flushed face before anchoring heavily onto his parted, pink lips.

The silence between them grew so thick it was agonizing. Sitting right on the man's lap, feeling the overwhelming weight of the friction, Jimin let out a breathless whisper. "T-this is very awkward, Chef."

A low sound escaped Jungkook's throat, barely anything at all.

His jaw tightened.

Then, slowly, almost imperceptibly, he flexed his hold at Jimin's waist.

"Tu me rends complètement fou, Jimin," Jungkook murmured, voice rough and low, the words rolling out like something he didn't fully intend to say out loud.

Jimin didn't need translation.

Not this time.

His gaze dropped instinctively to Jungkook's mouth and something in his expression softened into quiet confusion, like his body had understood before his mind had time to intervene.

The space between them shrank without either of them moving.

Just as quickly as it happened, it ended. Jungkook's expression suddenly hardened, reality snapping back into his eyes with a sharp, rigid force. Before Jimin could even process it, Jungkook's hands tightened on his waist, and he firmly but deliberately pushed Jimin off of him.

Jimin tumbled to the side, landing on the cold stone pavement with a soft, breathless "umph."

He lay there for half a second, his brain completely whirring from the alcohol, when he suddenly felt himself being dragged right back up by his wrists. Jungkook hauled him to his feet with an effortless pull. Jimin swayed immediately, unsteady, and for a second it looked like he might collapse again. But before he could Jungkook swiftly turned his back to him, dropping down into a low, sturdy bend right in front of him.

"Get on," he said, his voice tighter and rougher than usual.

Jimin blinked down at the man's shoulders. A giddy, bubbly giggle burst from his lips. Without a single shred of hesitation, he threw his upper body forward, wrapping his arms securely around the chef's neck and resting his hot cheek completely flat against Jungkook's solid back.

Jungkook reached back, his hands easily locking under Jimin's thighs, and hoisted him up in one fluid motion. He carried him as if he weighed absolutely nothing, his long strides steady and unbothered by the extra weight as he began walking away from the golden tower.

"Weee!" Jimin slurred happily into the cool night air, a huge, uncoordinated grin plastering his face as he swung his legs slightly against Jungkook's hips.

The heavy scent of the man completely enveloped Jimin, making him feel entirely safe, warm, and cocooned against the crisp breeze. He let his eyes flutter shut, his fingers loosely tangling into the fabric of Jungkook's collar as the rhythmic, heavy thud of the Director's shoes on the pavement rocked his brain into a peaceful daze.

Jungkook didn't say a word. He just kept walking through the quiet, shadowed streets of Paris, his mouth set in a tight line.

"Jungkook..." Jimin began, his voice melting into a soft, sleepy murmur against the heavy fabric of the shirt.

He instantly felt the Director's shoulders tense beneath his cheek. The rhythmic stride of Jungkook's legs hitched for a fraction of a second before continuing down the quiet street.

"Chef," Jungkook corrected him, his tone dropping into a low, warning sound that vibrated right through his spine and into Jimin's chest.

Jimin let out another loose giggle, entirely unfazed by the correction as his arms tightened just a fraction more around the man's neck. "Chef..." he amended slurrily, his breath warm against the dark fabric. "In the morning... please don't yell at me."

Jungkook didn't answer right away. He just kept walking, the steady clack of his leather shoes echoing against the old stone buildings. The cool night breeze swept past them, rustling the silk of Jimin's shirt, but trapped against Jungkook's back, Jimin felt completely insulated from the cold.

"If you do what is required, I have no reason to yell," Jungkook finally said, his voice rough but devoid of its usual sharp edge.

"But you're always *so* scary," Jimin mumbled, his eyelids growing heavier by the second as the steady, rocking motion of Jungkook's stride fully took effect. "In the kitchen... you look at me like you want to kill me sometimes. But tonight... you were soft. Your eyes were so soft, Chef."

Jungkook's grip on Jimin's thighs tightened slightly, his fingers digging into the fabric of his trousers. "You are drunk, Jimin. You are seeing things that aren't there."

"Am not," Jimin pouted, his voice slurring into a sleepy yawn as he buried his face deeper into the crook of Jungkook's neck, his nose brushing against the warm skin right above his collar. "Somewhere in there, you're just a big soft and squishy marshmallow."

A heavy, tense silence stretched over them again, but this time, Jungkook didn't curse or fight back. He just exhaled a long, slow breath. He adjusted his grip, hoisting Jimin a little higher onto his back with an effortless, protective tilt of his weight.

By the time they turned the corner onto the street of their hotel, Jimin's breathing had completely smoothed out into deep, rhythmic patterns, his forehead resting heavily against Jungkook's shoulder blade as he drifted off to sleep.

Jungkook stopped just outside the grand glass doors of the lobby, looking down at the quiet pavement for a long moment. He turned his head slightly, his eyes tracking the soft, peaceful expression on Jimin's sleeping face, before he pushed through the doors and carried him inside.

Jungkook stepped into the warm, quiet ambiance of the hotel lobby, the glass doors sliding shut behind them and cutting off the crisp wind. He walked toward the elevators, his steps unbothered by the sleeping weight on his back, when a sudden, annoying realization hit him like a physical blow.

He didn't have Jimin's room key.

Jungkook stopped dead in his tracks just before the elevator bank, his jaw clenching. He couldn't exactly fish through Jimin's pockets, and even if he did, Taehyung was probably the one with the key card. Knowing Kim's thoroughly intoxicated state when he left the plaza, the boy was undoubtedly passed out cold, sleep-drunk out of his mind, and wouldn't wake up even if Jungkook pounded on the door with a sledgehammer.

A heavy, deeply frustrated sigh escaped Jungkook's nose.

Begrudgingly, the Director shifted his weight, hoisting Jimin a little higher on his back. He turned away from the elevators and headed toward the long, carpeted hallway that led to the executive wing.

" *Incroyable...* " Jungkook muttered sharply under his breath, his tone dripping with utter disbelief towards his own actions."

Jimin merely let out a soft, completely oblivious snore in response, his warm breath puffing right against the sensitive skin of Jungkook's neck.



Jimin's eyes fluttered open, and he was immediately met by a vicious, pounding force right behind his temples. He groaned, the sharp ache of a champagne hangover vibrating through his skull as he instinctively tried to roll over away from the morning light. Expecting the narrow, familiar boundary of his small twin hotel bed, he reached a hand out blindly to catch himself before he fell off the edge.

Instead, his palm just landed on more bed.

Confused, Jimin reached his arm out further, his fingers brushing against crisp, impossibly high-thread-count sheets. He realized his bed had somehow grown a lot in the last twenty-four hours.

"Jesus, Tae... what time is it?" Jimin mumbled, his voice thick with sleep as he painfully pulled himself up onto his elbows. "Tae?"

Jimin finally forced his sleep-swollen eyes open, blinking around the space.

His heart sank immediately.

The room was a lot bigger than theirs. In the center of the vast, sunlit space was a massive, elegant king bed where Jimin currently sat. The dark mahogany paneling, the towering floor-to-ceiling windows overlooking a sweeping Parisian skyline, and the opulence of the furniture made it clear this was far more luxurious than anywhere he was supposed to be.

Confused and suddenly very, very scared, Jimin looked down at himself. He cautiously peeked under the heavy white covers, his breath catching in his throat. He relaxed just a fraction when he saw he was still fully dressed, even if they were thoroughly wrinkled.

"Thank God," he whispered entirely to himself, closing his eyes tightly in a wave of confusion.

Whose room was this?

How did he end up here?

And then... the fragments of the night before began to hit him.

It all suddenly became very, terribly clear.

Jimin let out a sharp, horrified gasp. But just as the sound left his lips, the handle of the adjacent bathroom clicked. The door swung open, and a heavy stream of warm, white steam rolled out into the bedroom, bringing with it the unmistakable, intense scent of smoky cedarwood.

Stepping straight through the mist was a shirtless and dripping wet Jungkook.

Jimin froze, his jaw dropping as his breath locked in his throat. The Director only wore a pair of low-slung black trousers, the fabric hugging his frame as water droplets tracked paths down his sculpted chest and rigid, shadowed abs. His hair was damp, curling slightly from the water and framing his face, completely devoid of his usual glasses. The intricate, heavy black ink of his tattoos practically gleamed against his wet skin under the morning sun.

Jungkook paused, towel in hand, his dark, piercing gaze locking instantly onto the utterly mortified student staring at him from his bed.

"Holy shit," Jimin breathed out before he could stop himself, his dazed, wide eyes tracking a rogue droplet of water as it slid down the carved line of his teacher's torso.

The second the words left his mouth; reality slapped him across the face. He caught himself, snapping his mouth shut and violently averting his eyes away, his face instantly exploding into a burning shade of red. He stared desperately at the white duvet, his heart hammering so hard against his ribs he was certain Jungkook could hear it across the room.

"I mean... How did I... when did I..." Jimin stammered, his voice cracking as the horror took over. "Did I... did I sleep here?!"

Jungkook didn't answer right away. He calmly brought the white towel up to his head, his shoulders and the ink on his arms flexing as he began casually drying his hair. The quiet rustle of the towel was the only sound in the suite for a few agonizing seconds.

Finally, Jungkook lowered the towel, draping it loosely around the back of his neck.

"Evidently," Jungkook replied flatly. He didn't look bothered by his lack of a shirt in the slightest, standing with an effortless, imposing grace.

"Oh my God," Jimin whispered, voice suddenly smaller. "Oh my God—"

He practically launched himself off the bed, only to immediately misjudge the distance and stumble, catching himself hard against the nightstand. His heart hammered so loudly he was convinced Jungkook could hear it.

His brain scrambled to assemble a timeline that made sense.

Ballroom. Eiffel Tower. Falling. Then—

Nothing.

As he steadied himself, his eyes dropped instinctively.

His boots were placed neatly on the floor beside the bed, aligned with unnerving precision. His phone sat on the nightstand beside them, face-down, perfectly centered within reach.

"I—Chef—I am so sorry!" he blurted, voice cracking with panic. His eyes flicked from his neatly lined boots to Jungkook's unreadable face and back again like neither could possibly belong in the same reality. "I don't... I don't remember—did I—how did I..."

Jungkook's gaze held steady on him for a moment, unreadable as ever, before flicking briefly to the boots and phone too.

Then back to Jimin.

"I—did I make you carry me?" Jimin suddenly exclaimed, mortification rising fast now, burning up his neck and into his face. "Chef, I swear I don't normally—I—and I just—"

"Jimin."

The single word cut cleanly through him.

Jimin snapped his mouth shut immediately.

"Put your shoes on," Jungkook commanded softly, the terrifying edge returning to his tone, yet missing any real venom. "The bus leaves for the campus in exactly forty-five minutes. If you are a single second late, I will leave you. Do you understand me?"

Jimin looks at the boots, then looks back up, locking eyes with the bare, imposing man. A few days ago, the threat would have sent him into a blind panic. But after last night—after the weight of the arms that carried him here—Jimin knows it's a lie. He doesn't believe him for a second.

"Okay," Jimin murmurs softly, his voice remarkably steady as a small, quiet nod slips from him. "Yes, Chef."

Jimin didn't make eye contact as he quickly dropped to the floor, shoving his feet into his shoes with frantic, trembling fingers. He didn't even bother lacing them up all the way. Snatching his phone off the nightstand, he gave a tiny, incredibly tense bow "Thank you, Chef,"

Jimin turned and walked toward the door, his strides steady as he crossed the suite. He reached out, his fingers wrapping around the brass handle of the heavy mahogany door. He pulled it open, the quiet hallway of the executive wing stretching out before him.

But he didn't move past the threshold.

Instead, Jimin paused, lingering right in the open doorway. A sudden, quiet curiosity cut through the fading haze of his hangover, overriding his instinct to simply bolt. He gripped the edge of the door, slowly turning his head back toward the center of the room.

Jungkook was still standing exactly where he had been by the bathroom, the plush white towel hanging loosely from his hand. He hadn't broken eye contact for a single second, his dark, heavy gaze tracking Jimin's hesitation with a slow tilt of his head.

Jimin swallowed hard, his thumb nervously tracing the wood grain of the door. "Chef..." he began softly, his voice dropping into a quiet, hesitant murmur.

Jungkook raised an eyebrow, waiting.

"Did I... did I say anything last night that..." Jimin let the sentence trail off, his warm, dazed eyes locked onto Jungkook's unreadable face. He didn't finish the question, but the unspoken weight of it hung heavily in the air between them—a desperate, quiet plea to know if his champagne-soaked brain had completely given away the secret passion swelling in his chest.

A dense, agonizing silence stretched across the luxury suite.

Jungkook's jaw set in a tight, rigid line. His dark eyes dropped for a fraction of a second, lingering on the open collar of Jimin's wrinkled silk shirt before anchoring back onto his face. The intimidating, untouchable Director didn't offer a single hint of a smile, but the intense, consuming heat behind his gaze flared all over again.

"You gave a grand musical performance to say the least," Jungkook began. He tossed the towel onto a nearby chair. A small, devastating smirk pulled at the very corner of his lips—subtle and impossibly handsome under the warm morning sun. "Nothing of substance. Go get dressed."

Jimin searched the man's face for a beat, trying to spot the lie. A tiny, knowing smile tugged at the corner of his own lips. He gave a respectful, calm nod.

"Yes, Chef," Jimin murmured.

As Jimin walked to the opposite side of the hotel, he couldn't stop smiling. The quiet hallway seemed to blur past him, his cheeks feeling incredibly warm and flushed under the soft lighting. Even though he couldn't remember a single detail about how he had actually ended up in that bed, he just knew—he knew something had to have happened last night. Something important, and something warm enough to make the terrifying, man actually crack a smile.

Reaching his own room, Jimin knocked softly on the heavy wood.

He waited, the silence stretching out for a full five seconds before he raised his hand to knock again. Just as his knuckles were about to hit the paneling, the lock clicked, and the door swung open.

Taehyung stood there, looking just as bad, if not significantly worse, than Jimin felt. His pristine, high-fashion aura from the grand ball had completely vanished; his messy brown hair stuck out in a dozen different wild directions all over his head, his eyes were sleep-swollen and squinting painfully against the hallway light, and It was honestly the very first time Jimin had ever seen his friend look so... normal.

Taehyung blinked, his gaze slowly focusing on the wrinkled midnight-blue silk shirt before traveling up to Jimin's radiant, blushing face.

"Oh—Jimin!" Taehyung rasped out, his morning voice incredibly deep and rough as his eyes suddenly went wide with a realization. "Oh, where have you been... wait, don't tell me! You and... Ju—"

"No, no, no!" Jimin cut him off instantly, his hands coming up in a frantic, waving motion to swat the accusation out of the air before Tae could even voice it.

"Quite the opposite," Jimin added, breathless sigh escaping his lips as he pushed past his stunned friend. Taehyung looked entirely confused, his brow furrowing as he watched Jimin step into the room with a strange, quiet confidence, looking entirely unfazed by his wrinkled clothes or his pounding hangover.



Jimin had never been the type of student to beg for attention. Back home, he was perfectly content staying in the background, working quietly, and doing just enough to get by without drawing any unnecessary eyes to himself.

Except now.

The Director made Jimin feel an entirely different kind of high—a reckless, giddy sort of way that he had been relentlessly chasing for the past week. Ever since that blurred night in Paris, Jimin had been, as Hobi so aptly put it during their morning call, under a spell . Whether that terrifying, intoxicating hold was a good thing or a bad thing, Jimin didn't even care anymore. It forced him to push his absolute boundaries, working past the point of exhaustion just to hear Jungkook utter that single word: *parfait* .

Now, standing at his prep station in the center of the bustling academy kitchen, Jimin was thoroughly, meticulously focused. He was bruising crisp, pale-green stalks of celery for a classic French mirepoix. His knuckles were curled tightly over the blade, the knife making a rhythmic, rapid thwack sound against the wood. Every single cube of celery had to be an exact, uniform two millimeters. If even a fraction of a millimeter was off, he knew the Director would toss the entire batch into the bin without a word.

Jimin breathed evenly, trying to steady his hands, his eyes glued to the board.

Then, the heavy, unmistakable sound of deliberate, polished leather boots echoed against the tile floor, pausing right behind his station.

An immediate, intense wave of heat rushed straight into Jimin's cheeks. The skin of his neck prickled yet didn't dare look up from his knife, but his breath caught in his throat as the formidable shadow of Director Jeon completely enveloped his workspace.

They hadn't spoken much since Paris, and Jimin counted himself lucky that whatever had occurred wasn't being held against him. Instead, almost scarily so, Jungkook was pretending the entire night had never happened. Despite Taehyung's persistent, daily egging, Jimin fiercely insisted to his

friend that absolutely nothing had happened. He admitted shyly that he had just passed out sloppy drunk, and their poor teacher had been forced to take care of him.

Yet, Jimin's cheeks still burned at the intrusive thought of the chef's intricately sculpted body. If he concentrated hard enough and squeezed his eyes shut just right, he could still feel the expansive luxury of the bed, the suffocating weight of the stare, everything.

"Stop."

The sharp voice broke his line of thought like a physical blow. Jimin instantly dropped his chef's knife, pinning his hands flat against his sides with his eyes trained straight ahead as Jungkook inched closer into his space.

The Director leaned over the surface, examining the neat pile of miniature green cubes with a critical, unblinking focus. He then clicked his silver pen against his clipboard, his jaw setting into its usual rigid line before he slowly turned his head to face Jimin.

" *Parfait* ," Jungkook murmured softly.

Internally, Jimin jumped straight off a cloud of cotton candy and landed headfirst into a warm, infinite ocean of gooey caramel. That was the exact, dizzying high that flooded his chest right now. Hearing that single word slip past the Director's lips made every hour of grueling labor entirely worth it.

Jungkook didn't linger on the praise, his dark eyes shifting down to track the rapid rise and fall of Jimin's chest before he turned on his heel to inspect the next station. Jimin let out a long, shaky breath, picking up his knife again with trembling fingers, the sweet taste of approval lingering in the air.

And so, painfully and predictably, the routine continued week after week.

Jimin threw himself deeper and deeper into his work, pouring every ounce of energy he had into perfecting his craft. He stayed late to redo preparations he wasn't satisfied with, arrived early to organize his station before anyone else, and pushed through exhaustion with one simple goal in mind: earning even the smallest piece of approval from Jungkook.

That praise had become something dangerously addictive.

A simple, quiet "good" from the Director could carry Jimin through an entire exhausting day. A rare nod of approval or a brief acknowledgment that his dish was acceptable felt like winning something priceless.

But that was all it ever was.

Nothing else followed.

There were no lingering glances across the kitchen. No moments where their hands accidentally brushed. No hidden warmth beneath Jungkook's words or secret meaning behind his compliments. The terrifyingly intimidating Director Jeon remained exactly what he had always been—professional, distant, and impossible to read.

If anything, things had become even colder.

The strangest part of it all was that Jungkook didn't even yell at him anymore.

Jimin noticed it every single day.

Around him, the rest of the class continued to experience the full force of Director Jeon's terrifying reputation. He watched as students were torn apart over careless mistakes, their confidence shattered under the weight of Jungkook's sharp criticism. Plates of poorly executed dishes were thrown away without hesitation, sometimes tossed across the room into the trash with a force that made everyone in the kitchen freeze.

Jungkook's deep, rough voice would echo through the room, cutting through the noise of boiling pots and clattering utensils.

"Is this what you call cooking?"

"Do you even understand what you just served?"

His words were brutal enough to make experienced students lower their heads and swallow their pride.

But Jimin was different.

Not because he was perfect but because Jungkook treated him differently.

When Jimin made a mistake, which had become increasingly rare, Jungkook never raised his voice. He never humiliated him in front of the class. Instead, he would quietly walk over to Jimin's station, examine the mistake with a disappointed expression, and explain exactly what went wrong. His voice would stay low and controlled, almost like a parent correcting a child who should have known better.

"You know better than this."

"Pay attention to what you're doing."

"Don't rush. Your hands are moving faster than your thoughts."

Then, without another word, he would take the dish and calmly throw it away.

And somehow, that was worse.

Some strange, embarrassing part of Jimin actually missed being yelled at. At least anger meant he had gotten a reaction. At least frustration meant Jungkook had been paying attention. This quiet disappointment—the clinical distance, the careful professionalism, the way Jungkook looked at him like nothing more than another student was far more unbearable.

As the weeks passed, the days began to blend together. The kitchen became a world of endless steam, sharp knives, copper pans, and the constant rhythm of cooking. The smell of herbs and roasted ingredients clung to Jimin's clothes long after he left. His hands became familiar with every tool at his station.

And somewhere between the exhausting mornings and the late evenings, something changed.

Despite every attempt to convince himself otherwise, Jimin had grown attached to Jungkook.

He admired Jungkook's skill, his discipline, his impossible standards. He admired the way the man commanded an entire kitchen without needing to raise a hand. He admired the passion hidden beneath his harsh exterior.

That explanation would have been believable if Jimin's heart didn't betray him every time the kitchen doors opened.

Every time Jungkook stepped inside, Jimin noticed.

It was ridiculous. Completely childish.

Director Jeon Jungkook was intimidating, demanding, and nearly impossible to please.

And yet, somewhere along the way, Jimin had developed a massive, undeniable crush on him.

A hopeless one.

That night, when Jimin quietly slipped back into the kitchen, he expected the familiar emptiness waiting for him.

It had become his own little ritual.

After everyone else left, after the noise of the day faded and the kitchen finally belonged to no one but him, Jimin would return. He would turn on the lights, tie his apron, and practice until his hands ached. He told himself it was about improvement. About becoming better. About proving that he deserved to stand in a kitchen like this.

But, at first, there had been another reason.

For weeks, Jimin had secretly hoped that one night he would walk through those doors and find Director Jeon already there. He imagined some impossible scenario where they would share the quiet kitchen, where Jungkook might offer some rare piece of advice, or maybe—ridiculously—where they might have an actual conversation.

But every single time, the kitchen had been empty. Not once had he found him there.

Eventually, somewhere along the way, Jimin stopped coming in hopes of seeing him. He came because he wanted to. Because he wanted to improve. Because cooking had become something that belonged to him.

Which was why he was completely unprepared for the sight waiting on the other side of the door.

Jimin froze.

The soft click of the door closing behind him seemed painfully loud in the silent kitchen.

Jungkook was there.

For a moment, Jimin genuinely wondered if exhaustion had finally caught up with him and he was imagining things. Director Jeon stood near one of the prep tables, leaning casually against the edge as he looked over a stack of papers in his hand. Unlike the intimidating chef uniform he wore during class, tonight he was dressed simply—a crisp white shirt tucked neatly into black trousers, the sleeves slightly rolled up.

It was unfair, Jimin thought. Somehow, without the chef jacket and the commanding presence of the classroom, Jungkook looked even more difficult to look away from.

As if sensing him, Jungkook lifted his head.

Their eyes met.

Jimin immediately straightened, caught somewhere between wanting to leave and wanting to stay exactly where he was. It was the first time in weeks—*a month, really*—that they had been alone together.

Jungkook pushed away from the table and walked toward him.

Jimin awkwardly shifted his weight, suddenly aware of everything: his messy hair, his wrinkled practice clothes, the fact that he was standing there like he had been caught doing something wrong.

"I assumed you'd be stopping by tonight," Jungkook said.

The simple statement made Jimin blink.

Jungkook adjusted his glasses, his expression calm and unreadable as always. "I want to start by saying that, as the semester comes to an end, you have managed to surprise me."

Jimin's eyes widened slightly.

"I do not compliment lightly," Jungkook continued.

Jimin couldn't help the small smile that appeared. He tried to contain it but failed.

"Thank y—"

"Now," Jungkook interrupted smoothly, already moving on.

Jimin immediately closed his mouth.

"The gala dinner is approaching." Jungkook looked down at the papers in his hand, flipping through them before holding them out slightly. "And only one student will be given the opportunity to participate."

Jimin's smile slowly faded. The excitement in his chest shifted into something else entirely. Something nervous. Something hopeful. Because if Jungkook had gone out of his way to tell him this personally... there was only one reason why.

The paper felt impossibly heavy as Jimin reached out, his fingers brushing against Jungkook's for a fraction of a second as he took the documents. That fleeting touch sent a familiar, electric hum straight up his arm, but he forced his eyes down, staring at the clean, typed text of the gala menu overview.

"I do not choose the representative based on simple class grades." Jungkook began. He stepped back just a fraction, resting a hand on the counter behind him, his shoulders shifting under the crisp white fabric of his shirt. "Any mediocre cook can memorize a rubric and follow a recipe under direct supervision. That is a given. That is expected."

Jungkook paused, his dark eyes narrowing slightly behind his glasses as he locked onto Jimin's dazed face.

"I look for the ones who return when the lights are off. The ones who bleed for the technique when no one is watching to give them a grade." The Director's jaw set into a rigid line, though his tone lost its sharp, clinical edge. "You had an incredibly rocky start. You were clumsy, you were loud, and your emotional reactions were a massive liability in my kitchen."

Jimin bit his lower lip, a soft, familiar flush creeping up his neck at the blunt reminder.

"But," Jungkook continued smoothly, his dropping lower, making the hairs on Jimin's arms stand up, "you have exceeded my expectations. Your growth has been... absolute."

Jimin's heart did a violent, chaotic flip. He stared at the Director, his chest tightening as he tried to process the weight of the compliment.

"Which is why," Jungkook stated, his expression turning entirely serious, "you will be the one executing the center-piece menu for the gala dinner."

Jimin opened his mouth to breathe a sigh of relief, a brilliant smile already threatening to break across his face, but Jungkook wasn't finished.

"You will be serving me, a panel of international Michelin-starred chefs, and the Dean of the global academy."

Jimin's breath caught completely in his throat. He let out a sharp, audible gasp, the sheets trembling in his hand as his heart instantly dropped like a lead weight straight into his stomach.

The room felt suddenly dizzying, the high of the praise instantly evaporating into a cold, suffocating wave of pure panic. Cooking for the strict Director Jeon was a daily battle—but cooking for a room full of elite, global culinary gods while his teacher watched his every single move?

"C-Chef..." Jimin squeaked out, his eyes darting from the paper back up to Jungkook. "I... I don't know if I can—"

"You can, and you will." Jungkook cut him off instantly, the certainty in his voice leaving absolutely no room for doubt. He stepped closer, crowding Jimin's space until Jimin had to tilt his head up to keep the eye contact. "Because if you fail, it is my reputation on that plate, too. I do not bet on losing hands, Jimin."

Hearing his actual name slip past those sharp lips in the quiet kitchen sent a fierce shiver straight down Jimin's spine, the nervous panic in his chest suddenly tangling with that familiar, dangerous heat.

"It is in exactly four weeks," Jungkook rumbled, his voice dropping into a deeper register as he leaned in just a fraction closer, trapping Jimin under the intense focus of his gaze. "So, let's get to work. I will not let you fail, and I will absolutely not embarrass myself... understood?"

Jimin's breath shattered in his throat. The overwhelming weight of the upcoming gala, the terrifying thought of the global culinary elite judging his every move, and the suffocating closeness of the man standing before him combined into a dizzying rush of adrenaline.

He clutched the papers tightly against his chest, his knuckles turning white as he forced his eyes to lock onto Jungkook's sharp, unblinking ones.

"Y-yes, Chef," Jimin breathed out, the words trembling but absolute.

Jungkook stared down at him for one long, agonizing second, tracking the fierce flush on Jimin's cheeks before giving a single, firm nod of approval. He turned on his heel toward the main line, his white shirt stretching across his back as he pointed a commanding finger toward the stainless-steel counters.

"Good. Tie your apron. Tonight, we start from the beginning."

Chapter 6

Jimin gulped, the sound painfully loud to his own ears in the empty kitchen.

Standing behind his station, he felt entirely exposed under the harsh lights. Jungkook stood a few paces away, the white fabric of his button-up shirt stretching across his shoulders as he looked down at him.

"Neither I nor the other panelists can know the exact details of the final centerpiece menu you chose to execute," Jungkook began. "The rules of the global academy are absolute. But it is my job. My sole responsibility over the next four weeks to ensure you can prep multiple high-end plates simultaneously under a ruthless time limit and do it flawlessly."

Jimin swallowed hard, his fingers nervously curling around the edge of the prep table as Jungkook slowly rounded the corner. The Director's polished shoes made deliberate, heavy sounds against the tile. He reached into his pocket and pulled out a heavy, matte-black stopwatch, sliding it onto the silver surface right in front of Jimin with a metallic clink.

Jimin's eyes darted from the timer up to Jungkook.

Jungkook crossed his arms over his chest, leaning back casually against the neighboring counter, though his posture radiated pure, commanding authority. Behind his glasses, his dark gaze locked onto Jimin's flushed face.

"Now," he stated flatly, his jaw setting into a rigid line. "You will have exactly sixty seconds."

Jimin blinked, his tired brain frantically scanning his station. The surface was entirely clear except for his knife roll and a single, uncut bundle of fresh chives. He looked around the empty room, completely lost, before his eyes snapped back to the Director.

"F-for what...?" Jimin squeaked out, his voice trembling.

Jungkook didn't blink. He just looked over Jimin with a cold, heavy stare, looking at him as if he were supposed to know exactly what to do, offering absolutely no hints as the heavy silence stretched between them.

"What do you expect to cook with?" Jungkook asked after a heavy beat, his voice smooth with unbothered authority. "You must have everything you need before you even begin cooking. If you realize at the gala that you are missing a single utensil, a single herb, you lose time. Time is money."

Jimin let out a nervous, airy laugh, stepping away from his station as his panic began to tick upward. He rubbed the back of his neck, his cheeks warming under the Director's unblinking gaze. "Oh... yeah. But... how am I supposed to know... what to cook?"

Jungkook shrugged, a microscopic, relaxed shift of his shoulders that did absolutely nothing to diminish his intimidating aura. "Something simple for now. This is only practice."

Okay... Jimin thought, taking a shallow breath to steady his racing pulse. *Practice. He could do practice.*

His mind scrambled through his mental recipe book, quickly filtering past the overly complex recipes until he landed on a few comforting, reliable dishes he had perfected back home.

If it was just a test, he didn't need to do anything new; he just needed to be fast. Turning around, Jimin hurried toward the large walk-in refrigerator at the back of the kitchen, already planning the exact path to the milk and vegetable boxes. Behind him, he heard the sharp click of Jungkook starting the stopwatch.

"Fifty-five seconds," the Director's voice boomed across the empty room.

Jimin hadn't even realized the timer had started. A sharp gasp tore from his throat, his eyes widening as the realization hit him.

He didn't have time to overthink.

He ran. He decided quickly on a simple rustic spaghetti with blistered tomatoes. Something simple but technically demanding to execute flawlessly. He lunged into the dry pantry first, his hands flying across the shelves in a frantic blur. He snatched a box of spaghetti, a head of garlic, and a tin of red pepper flakes, nearly knocking over a jar of expensive truffle oil in his haste.

"Thirty seconds," Jungkook echoed from the main line, entirely unbothered by the chaos.

Jimin spun on his heel, his sneakers squeaking loudly against the tile as he sprinted toward the walk-in fridge. He ripped the heavy steel door open, the blast of cold air hitting his flushed face as he grabbed a container of fresh cherry tomatoes and a block of aged Parmigiano-Reggiano.

"Twenty-five seconds."

He dashed out of the fridge, his heart hammering violently against his ribs. Jimin quickly veered toward the equipment wall, his fingers scrambling through the neatly stacked metal racks. He grabbed a heavy skillet, a deep pot for the pasta water, a metal colander, and a microplane. The metal clattered loudly in his arms, a chaotic symphony of iron and steel that felt impossibly loud.

"Ten seconds."

Panic seized him completely. Jimin was practically running by the time he cleared the prep island, his vision tunneling as he lunged toward his station. With a desperate, final surge of energy, he threw his upper body forward.

CRASH.

Jimin dropped everything onto the counter with a heavy, deafening thud. The skillet rattled against the pot, the cherry tomatoes rolled wildly across the silver surface, and the box of pasta skidded right to the very edge, stopping just an inch away from Jungkook.

Jimin stood there heaving, his chest rising and falling rapidly as he clutched the edge of the table for support, his messy hair falling into his eyes. He looked up through his lashes, breathless and sweating, his cheeks burning a furious crimson as his dazed eyes met the Director's.

"Tu sembles avoir des problèmes de coordination plus que toute autre chose." Jungkook muttered, mostly to himself, before he moved forward just as the stopwatch began to beep, the shrill sound cutting off abruptly as his thumb hit the button.

Jimin's chest rose and fell fast as he tried to catch his breath. Jungkook ignored it as he surveyed the pile of ingredients scattered across the counter. He hummed, a low, vibratory sound in his throat that made Jimin's stomach do a nervous flip.

Without giving Jimin a single second to recover, Jungkook reset the heavy black timer.

"One minute to finely dice the garlic and blister the tomatoes," Jungkook commanded, his eyes snapping up to trap Jimin under his intense gaze. "Starting... now."

Jimin's jaw dropped. "Chef I—"

"Fifty-five seconds," Jungkook cut him off, his voice flat.

A choked sound escaped Jimin's throat as he lunged forward. He ripped the garlic head apart, his fingers scrambling against the papery skin. He smashed a clove with the flat of his knife, his heart hammering against his ribs as he began to mince it as fast as his hands could move. The pieces weren't perfectly uniform, but he didn't have time to breathe, let alone measure millimeters.

"Thirty seconds. The stove isn't on. Your pan is cold."

"Right! Right, sorry—" Jimin frantically reached out with his left hand, his fingers slapping against the induction dial to crank the heat to high, while his right hand kept dicing the garlic. He tossed a splash of olive oil into the skillet, the metal heating up with a terrifying speed.

"Fifteen seconds."

With a desperate swipe of his blade, Jimin scraped the garlic off the board. He grabbed a handful of the cherry tomatoes, throwing them into the smoking pan alongside the garlic.

The oil instantly popped, a stray droplet of boiling grease snapping up and catching Jimin right on the sensitive skin of his inner wrist. Jimin hissed, flinching backward as the sting flared up, his knife slipping from his grip and clattering onto the cutting board.

Before he could even check the burn, the stopwatch began to blare its shrill, rhythmic beep.

Time was up.

Jimin stood frozen, his breathing labored as he cradled his burning wrist against his apron. The kitchen smelled of burning garlic and scorched tomato skin. He looked down at the pan, where the ingredients were already beginning to blacken too quickly because he hadn't stirred them.

Jungkook stepped in close, the heavy scent of him instantly overwhelming the smell of the charred food. He reached over, casually turning off the burner to save the dish from catching fire.

Jungkook didn't hit the button on the timer right away. He let the beeping fill the silence between them for three agonizing seconds before clicking it off.

"A single pop of grease, and you lose all you're training? What happens when a burner flares at the gala Jimin? Do you drop everything and cry?"

The use of his actual name, combined with the rough, bruising pain from his wrist, sent a violent wave of heat straight down Jimin's spine, making his knees feel dangerously weak.

Still, he swallowed hard. He hated the disappointment in Jungkook's voice more than any physical burn. Looking down at the blackened garlic and the wrinkled, split tomatoes, a sudden wave of determination washed over him.

"Let me try again, Chef," Jimin pleaded, his voice breathy but determined as he looked up through his lashes, his eyes locked onto Jungkook's. "Please. I can do it faster. I can make it perfect."

"No," Jungkook cut him off instantly, his voice flat and absolute. "You will work with what you have. If a dish catches too much color during service, you do not have the luxury of time to restart. Throwing away ingredients is a tactic for amateurs."

Jungkook leaned in a fraction closer, the heat radiating from his chest pressing into Jimin's back, trapping him against the station.

"Boil the pasta," Jungkook commanded softly, his warm breath brushing directly against Jimin's skin because he was standing so incredibly close. "The bitter notes of the garlic can still be balanced if you utilize the starchy pasta water correctly. You can still save it. Move."

Jimin scrambled into motion.

He grabbed the deep pot, filling it with hot water from the tap, and placed it onto the secondary induction burner, cranking the heat to its absolute maximum. He threw a heavy handful of kosher salt into the water, his hands moving with a frantic, desperate focus as he tried to block out the heavy weight of the Director's unblinking gaze tracking his every micro-movement.

"The water is boiling. Pasta in," Jungkook rumbled from right behind him, counting the seconds in his head.

Jimin gathered the dry spaghetti noodles, dropping them into the pot and forcing the strands down with a wooden spoon. He was *hyper-aware of Jungkook's presence*—the way the man didn't give him an inch of breathing room, standing close enough that Jimin could hear the faint, steady rhythm of his breathing over the bubbling water.

"Now, prepare the baseline for the sauce," Jungkook murmured, stepping in so close his chest faintly brushed against Jimin's back. He reached out, his hand hovering over the skillet containing the tomatoes. "Ladling the pasta water into the oil requires precision. If you rush, it will splatter again. Show me how you control the pan."

Jimin's wrist throbbed, a sharp, angry red flare rising where the hot grease had scalded the sensitive skin. Every time he moved his arm to stir or lift a utensil, the fabric of his sleeve brushed against the raw spot, sending a stinging jolt straight up his arm.

But Jungkook's eyes didn't look down at the injury. The Director's focus remained strictly on the boiling water and the temperature of the oil, his expression as unyielding as the steel surrounding them.

Jimin fiercely swallowed down the pain. He didn't want pity; he wanted to prove he belonged on the line. He braced his core, forcing his fingers to tighten reliably around the handle of the ladle.

With a steady hand, he scooped up a portion of the cloudy, boiling pasta water. He brought it over the skillet, tilting the pan slightly away from himself to redirect any potential spray, and poured the water into the oil and blackened garlic .

A violent cloud of steam billowed up, wrapping around his face and dampening the stray hairs at his temples, but Jimin didn't flinch this time. He held his ground, immediately using his tongs to swirl the liquid in rapid, aggressive circles, forcing the fats and the starches to bind.

The bitter, smoky aroma of the dark garlic mellowed out as the emulsification began to take shape, coating the blistered tomatoes in a glossy, light-amber sheen.

"Better," Jungkook murmured, the low rumble of his voice cutting through the steam.

Jimin quickly transferred the spaghetti straight from the boiling water into the skillet, tossing the noodles with practiced, frantic wrist movements. The heavy copper pan felt twice as heavy with his burning wrist, but the sheer adrenaline coursing through his veins completely numbed the ache.

But as he looked down at the pale, glossy noodles, a sudden wave of old habit took over. The tomatoes looked out of season. They were acidic and his mother's voice echoed in the back of his mind. Without thinking, Jimin gasped, his eyes widening.

"Oh, wait—"

Before Jungkook could even question him, Jimin ran off. He sprinted away from the main line, his sneakers squeaking sharply against the tile as he darted into the dry pantry. He scrambled through the shelves, his frantic hands knocking aside expensive oils until he found exactly what he was looking for.

When he hurried back to his station, Jungkook had stepped back. The Director was now standing a few paces away, his arms crossed over his chest, his expression completely unreadable behind his glasses. He didn't say a single word to stop him, but the silence he maintained was heavy, suffocating, and thick with an icy judgment. Jimin could almost feel the burning weight of the man's disapproval pressing into his skin as he worked.

Ignoring the warning signs screaming in his head, Jimin stubbornly incorporated the ingredients into the unrefined flavors of the pasta.

"Plate it," Jungkook commanded, his voice dropping into a dangerously flat, quiet register that made Jimin's stomach drop. He slid a pristine white porcelain bowl into the center of the station. "You have fifteen seconds to present."

Jimin snatched the long plating tongs. He grabbed a massive portion of the pasta, twisting his wrist expertly to form a tall, tight nest of spaghetti right in the center of the dish. He ladled the blistered tomatoes and the sauce over the top, then grabbed the microplane to shave a delicate, snow-like dusting of Parmigiano-Reggiano over the crown.

He dropped the tools with a quiet click and stepped back, his chest heaving as he tucked his injured wrist slightly behind his apron, trying to shake off the terrifying tension vibrating between them. "Done, Chef."

Jungkook stepped up to the plate, pulling a silver tasting fork from the counter. He didn't look up at Jimin immediately. He took a single, precise bite of the pasta, twisting the noodles slowly around the prongs, chewing as the silence in the kitchen stretched out.

Suddenly, Jungkook's eyes narrowed behind his glasses. He looked down at the dish, then up at Jimin, his jaw tight.

Did you try it?" Jungkook asked, his voice dropping low.

Shit.

Jimin's stomach dropped like a stone. He had completely forgotten the cardinal rule of the kitchen—the absolute baseline of any service, high-end or domestic. You always taste your food before presenting it to the pass. He cursed himself for forgetting.

Again.

He stammered, his fingers frantically twisting the fabric of his apron behind his back. "N-no, Chef... I was... the time, and the—"

Jungkook didn't wait for him to finish. He let out a loud, heavy sigh that echoed sharply off the stainless steel, the sound thick with irritation. Without a word, he dipped the silver fork right back into the noodles, capturing a perfect, single bite.

Jungkook leaned back against the edge of the heavy prep table as he held the fork out toward Jimin, his hand completely steady in the space between them.

"Taste it," Jungkook commanded softly.

Jimin froze.

His eyes locked onto Jungkook's unblinking ones. He stepped forward, his knees feeling dangerously weak as he closed the remaining distance. He didn't reach for the fork. He couldn't. Instead, keeping his eyes glued strictly to Jungkook's dark, intense gaze, he leaned in slightly. He parted his lips and slid his mouth over the cool silver, taking the bite directly from Jungkook's hand.

As the metal slid past his lips, a stray, chaotic thought flashed through Jimin's mind. He wondered why Jungkook liked sharing utensils so much.

Was it a French thing?

Some unwritten rule of the elite culinary world he hadn't learned yet, or something far more personal?

He didn't know, but he followed through anyway, swallowing the food while his heart hammered against his ribs under the crushing weight of the older man's stare.

The taste hit his tongue instantly. The bright, sharp tang of the hot sauce cutting beautifully through the heavy olive oil, followed by the rich, savory depth of the flash-fried garlic. It was vibrant, punchy, and unpretentious.

It tasted like home.

Jungkook didn't pull the fork away immediately, his thumb resting firmly against the silver handle as he tracked the way Jimin's throat swallowed the bite, his gaze dropping to the wet sheen on Jimin's lower lip.

"Tell me what you taste," Jungkook murmured.

"Ummm... p-pasta... tomato, and olive oil...garlic-" Jimin stammered, his voice losing all its defensive fire as the rich, savory sauce coated his tongue. He was distracted by the suffocating closeness of the man, his mind spinning from the closeness of the gesture.

Jungkook slowly pulled the silver fork away, his eyes never leaving Jimin's face. He deliberately swiped his tongue over his own lower lip, tasting the residual sauce left behind, his jaw tightening as he did so.

"What is the other thing I am tasting?" Jungkook asked, his voice dropping into a dangerously quiet register that made the hairs on Jimin's arms stand up. "There is something else, No?"

Jimin swallowed hard, his cheeks burning under the Director's intense questioning. He tucked his blistered wrist further behind his apron, feeling smaller by the second.

"Sugar... and hot sauce," Jimin confessed in a soft, breathy whisper. He dropped his gaze to the counter, unable to hold the terrifying heat in Jungkook's stare for a single second longer.

"It's a home recipe," Jimin added quickly, the words tumbling out in a frantic rush before his brain could filter them. He shifted his weight nervously, trying desperately to defend the habit. "The tomatoes weren't ripe enough, so they didn't have any natural sweetness. At home, when the produce is cheap or out of season, we always use a pinch of sugar to trick the palate into thinking they're sweet. It balances out the bitterness from the burnt garlic... and the hot sauce is just... a personal preference."

The words seemed to fracture the last remaining bit of Jungkook's professional composure.

The kitchen went entirely dead silent. The relaxed lean against the prep table vanished instantly as Jungkook stood up to his full height.

"This is not your home," Jungkook spat, his voice thick, rough, and entirely stripped of his clinical facade. He stepped directly into Jimin's space, crowding him so closely that Jimin's lower back pressed hard against the edge of the stainless-steel counter. "And the people attending the gala are not your family looking for a cheap domestic trick to cover up a clumsy mistake... they are looking for high-quality, not home recipes."

Jimin's brows snapped together, drawing down into a sharp, tight frown as a flare of pure offense burned through his chest. The word *cheap* stung violently, hanging in the heavy air between them like a slap in the face.

"What's next?" Jungkook continued, his voice dropping into a low, mocking tone that only fueled the fire rapidly spreading under Jimin's skin. He leaned in even closer. "Dumping a spoonful of white sugar into a dish because you feel like it? Using hot sauce to fake a real flavor profile?"

He let out a short, sharp huff that fanned hot against Jimin's skin.

"The gala guests are paying for elite precision, not the low-quality, lazy fixes you use when you panic." He let out a short, dismissive huff that fanned hot against Jimin's cheek.

A reckless, defensive heat flared up in Jimin's throat, burning right past his common sense. He took a half-step forward, tilting his chin up defiantly. Jimin stood there, his gaze flicking down to the plate of pasta on the counter before snapping back up to lock onto Jungkook's hard, unblinking eyes.

This was the exact same pasta his mom used to make for him after a terrible day at school. It was the same pasta he had cooked for himself almost every single day when the world felt too hard and heavy to face. It was his home, his comfort, his safety.

And here this man was calling it lazy, cheap, and insulting.

"My mom made this for me," Jimin whispered, his voice shaking with a dangerous mixture of raw hurt and boiling fury. He didn't back down from Jungkook's suffocating space, his knuckles gripping the edge of the steel counter until they turned entirely white. "It isn't cheap, Chef. And it isn't lazy."

Jungkook's eyes batted, wide with a sudden, genuine shock. He looked completely thrown off, as if the concept of Jimin actually standing up to him was something his brain couldn't instantly process.

Then, his face hardened, his broad chest rising as his features twisted into a look of pure, icy disbelief.

"Excuse me?" Jungkook whispered, his voice dangerously low, though it vibrated with a sharp, cutting edge. "You have no legacy. You have no family name in this industry, yet you stand here in my kitchen defending a failure of a dish?"

He let out a short, harsh laugh that lacked any real amusement, his dark eyes boring holes into Jimin's defiant face.

"I don't care about your sentimentality. I don't care about what your *mommy* made for you when you had a bad day," Jungkook rumbled, his voice thick with a harsh, arrogant finality. "You are here to learn how to cook at an elite level, not to whine over a plate of home-cooked garbage. If you can't handle real critique without hiding behind your family, then unpack your knives and get out."

"I'm not hiding." Jimin retorted back, the final thread of his restraint snapping completely. He didn't care about the rules, he didn't care about the hierarchy, and he certainly didn't about the consequences of his actions. "And don't you dare call it garbage!"

Jungkook's jaw clenched, a vein throbbing violently at his temple as he stepped so close their chests practically brushed. "It is garbage on a professional line! It is amateur, childish nonsense, and you are standing here wasting my time defending it!"

"Because it's the only thing I have!" Jimin fired right back, his voice cracking, hot tears of pure fury stinging the corners of his eyes. "You sit up there on your throne talking about legacies and family names like everyone just inherits a Michelin star! I don't have a name! I don't have a legacy!"

"Then you follow the *damn* rules until you build one!" Jungkook shouted, his voice booming off the walls, loud enough to shake the foundations of the room. "You don't get to innovate when you can't even execute the basics!"

"I did execute it!" Jimin yelled, matching the Director's volume note for note, his hands shaking as he pointed a trembling finger down at the plate between them. "You want precision? You want perfection? I don't have your *stupid* French techniques in my blood! This is my home, this is where I come from, and this—"

Jimin took a ragged, gasping breath, his chest heaving violently as he shoved his face closer to Jungkook's, screaming the final words directly into the man's face.

"You don't care about the gala, and you don't care about the food. You're just pissed off that a nobody like me could actually make it. You're a coward, Chef."

The kitchen slammed into a sudden, terrifying vacuum of sound.

Jungkook stepped back, a single, heavy stride that broke the suffocating heat of his frame. He blinked once, his eyes turning darker than Jimin had ever seen them. A bottomless, midnight black that looked entirely void of mercy. Slowly, he rolled his tongue against the inside of his cheek, his jaw working as he processed what Jimin had just said to him.

Jimin let out a sharp gasp, the sudden rush of cold air hitting his front as the adrenaline began to curdle into sheer terror. The heat of his actions finally crashed down on him.

Shit.

He shouldn't have said that.

He should have used his breathing techniques, just like his old counselor used to tell him to do whenever his temper threatened to blow his life to pieces. He needed to breathe, needed to ground himself, but his lungs wouldn't work.

"C-chef—" Jimin stammered, his voice cracking as he took a panicked half-step backward.

"Ferme ta gueule!" Jungkook screamed, the command ripping from his throat with a terrifying, primal ferocity.

Before Jimin could even flinch, Jungkook's surged forward. He snatched the plate of pasta off the counter firing the dish directly into the deep basin sink across the station.

The ceramic plate shattered into a dozen jagged pieces with a deafening, metallic ring that seemed to slice straight through the tense air. The red sauce and tomatoes exploded violently against the metal basin, dark drops spraying like blood across the tile floor and the faucets.

Jimin stood frozen. His breath caught completely in his throat, his wide, terrified eyes locked onto the sink. The echoing ring of the broken porcelain vibrated loudly in his ears, mirroring the frantic, erratic pounding of his heart. His mouth snapped shut instantly, the defensive retort dying on his tongue.

Jungkook stood panting slightly, his shoulders squared as he stood over the ruined station like a dark cloud. He slowly turned his head back to Jimin, his knuckles white where he gripped the edge of the counter. Behind his glasses, his dark eyes flashed with a dangerous, unbridled fury that made the room feel entirely devoid of oxygen.

The deafening echo of the crash was still ringing through the empty kitchen, but the suffocating fear paralyzing Jimin's chest didn't stay cold for long. As he looked at the sauce splattered across the stainless steel, something inside him snapped completely.

The humiliation of the past few minutes, the burning sting on his blistered wrist, the relentless, crushing pressure of the semester, and the absolute, heartbreaking unfairness of it all rushed to his head in a blinding, volatile wave of speed.

If Jungkook wanted a monster in his kitchen, Jimin was glad to fill the role.

Before his brain could register the insanity of what he was doing, Jimin's hand snapped out. He grabbed a damp, heavy kitchen rag sitting on the edge of his cutting board and hurled it straight at Jungkook's face with every ounce of strength he had.

The wet cloth struck Jungkook right across his cheek before dropping limply onto his shoulder.

The moment the rag left his fingers, hot, angry tears finally spilled over his thick lashes, scalding Jimin's flushed cheeks. He was crying from frustration, his chest heaving so hard it physically hurt.

But he didn't back away. Instead, fueled by a reckless bravery, he stepped right into Jungkook's space. He shoved his face close to the Director's, his fists clenched so tightly at his sides that his skin went entirely white, his vision completely blurred by the thick, wet sheen in his eyes.

"I'm done!" Jimin sobbed out, a breathless, broken sound as he stared up at the older man through his tear-soaked lashes. "You can go find someone else to torment! Go pick someone else who'll just stand here and let you talk to them like they're garbage! You think because you're the Director, you get to destroy everything I do? Like where I come from is nothing? I worked so hard—*so damn hard*—just to be in this room, and I'm not letting you treat me like I'm stupid anymore!"

Jimin's breath hitched. He was practically vibrating with a mix of adrenaline and anger.

Jungkook didn't move an inch. He stood completely frozen. The wet rag slid slowly off his shoulder, hitting the floor with a soft, heavy thud.

With an agonizing slowness, he reached up, taking off his glasses to wipe a stray droplet of water from the lens. His eyes locked onto the wet, shiny trails tracing down Jimin's face, and the anger in his expression suddenly shifted, hardening into something impossibly quiet.

Jimin didn't wait for him to speak. He couldn't. The silence stretching between them was too thick, vibrating with a dangerous, unpredictable energy that made his skin prickle with panic.

With a harsh, wet snuffle, Jimin violently wiped the tears from his cheeks with the back of his uninjured hand, his teeth grinding together to keep from sobbing out loud. He turned his back on the Director, his movements sharp and fueled by pure, survival-driven rage.

He snatched a fresh roll of paper towels from the under-counter shelf, ripping off a massive clump with a loud snap. He worked at the counter, scrubbing at the droplets of red tomato sauce, as if he were trying to scrape the metal itself away.

He slammed the salt cellar back into its rack. He gathered the stray garlic skins and hurled them into the trash bin.

Jungkook remained motionless. He stood exactly where he was in the middle of the kitchen, watching. He had put his glasses back on, the silver frames catching the overhead lights and obscuring his eyes as he tracked Jimin's movements.

He didn't offer to help. He didn't apologize. He just watched, his chest rising and falling in a slow, deep rhythm, his hands resting loosely at his sides.

The only sound left in the entire room was the violent, abrasive scrape of Jimin's paper towels against the steel and the ragged, uneven pattern of his breathing.

Needing a release for the pressure building in his lungs, Jimin snatched the heavy copper skillet he had used and slammed it into the sink with a deafening *CLANG* that rattled the pipes.

Even then, Jungkook stayed silent. But Jimin could feel the oppressive weight of the Director's dark, unblinking gaze burning straight through his spine, anchoring him to the spot.

It was a suffocating pressure, a wordless command that told Jimin that no matter how hard he scrubbed, or how loud he yelled, he wasn't actually escaping. He was still trapped in the man's orbit.

"And another thing!" Jimin snapped, turning around because the fire of his anger refused to let the heavy silence win. Fresh, hot tears spilled over his lower lashes all over again, cutting clean tracks through the sweat on his flushed cheeks. "I remember the night of the ball, okay? Even if it's the only damn thing I can remember from that night. I was actually starting to think you were a good person!"

He let out a sharp, fractured sob, his hands trembling violently as he slammed a metal canister back into its place on the shelf.

"I appreciated you! I respected you as my teacher, but how can I even do that when—"

Jimin's voice broke entirely, the force of his frustration finally snapping whatever invisible thread had been holding his composure together all semester. He sucked in a sharp, shuddering breath, his chest heaving as he stared blindly at the counter.

"If this is what it takes to be a chef," Jimin said, his voice dropping into a whisper that carried heavily across the empty kitchen. "If it means giving up every ounce of humanity just to break people down to build yourself up... then I don't want it."

Jungkook froze, his shoulders tensing slightly as the weight of the words hit the air. But Jimin wasn't finished. He wanted to hurt the man the way he had been hurt.

"I'd rather be an amateur for the rest of my life," Jimin breathed out, the tears finally stopping, replaced by a dull, aching exhaustion that made his bones feel heavy, "than end up as miserable, bitter, and mean as you."

Without giving the older man a single second to process the insult, or to assert his authority, Jimin turned his back.

He reached down to the lower shelf of the prep table and grabbed his knife kit. His knuckles turned white as he yanked the leather straps tight. He slung the strap over his shoulder, ignoring how it bit harshly into his collarbone.

For the first time all semester, Jungkook was rendered completely speechless. The Director remained frozen in the center of the aisle, his eyes tracking Jimin's every movement, his jaw locked tight.

Jimin didn't offer him another glance. He kept his chin high, his gaze locked ahead on the exit, his chest still aching with a hollow, profound emptiness. His footsteps echoed against the tile.

He didn't slow down as he reached the exit. Jimin hit the heavy metal crash bar of the double doors with his shoulder, pushing his way out into the cool, dimly lit corridor.



By the time Jimin made it back to the dorms, the adrenaline had completely burned off, leaving behind a shaking exhaustion that went straight to his bones.

He threw his knife kit onto the floor and collapsed face-first into his mattress, still wearing his stained kitchen whites. Heavy sobs shook his frame, his fingers clawing into the bedsheets as he wept into the pillow. He kept trying to wipe the tears away with the back of his sleeve, but his skin was already raw, and the moisture just kept coming, blurring his vision into a wet, miserable haze.

The click of the front door unlocking barely registered over the sound of his own crying.

Taehyung swept into the room, practically glowing with energy, a large, glossy paper bag from a luxury boutique slung over his forearm. He was mid-sentence, probably about to boast about his latest retail therapy find, when he caught sight of the crumpled figure on the bed.

The bag dropped to the floor with a dull thud, the expensive tissue paper crinkling beneath the sudden weight.

"*Oh, mon ami*, what happened?" Taehyung gasped, his glamorous aura instantly evaporating into one of concern and panic.

Jimin could only cry harder at the sound of his friend's voice, his shoulders heaving as he shook his head against the mattress. "I can't, Tae... I can't do this anymore."

Taehyung's face twisted into utter confusion. He moved quickly, crossing the small room in three long strides and dropping heavily onto the edge of Jimin's mattress. He reached out, his hands hovering over Jimin's shaking back, desperate to fix whatever had broken him.

"What? What can't you do? What do you mean, Jimin?"

Jimin rolled onto his side, curling his knees up tightly toward his chest. He shook his head, a bitter, laugh tearing out of his throat.

"Chef Jeon," Jimin choked out, his vision swimming as he stared at the wall. "He's... he's given me a run for my money. But I don't think... I think maybe..."

The words caught like glass in his throat. The realization that he might actually be walking away from his dreams, that Director Jeon had finally succeeded in breaking his spirit, made Jimin break down completely. He hid his face in his hands, crying harder than before, the sound muffled and agonizingly heavy in the quiet room.

"I don't know," Jimin began, his voice dropping into a dull, defeated whisper. He pulled his hands away from his face, staring blankly at the ceiling with wide, hollow eyes. "Maybe this just... isn't for me. The fancy recipes, and the fine dining, all of it."

Taehyung's chest fell, his heart breaking at the lack of fight left in his friend's voice. He shifted closer on the mattress, his brow furrowing deeply. "Jimin, look at me. You live for the kitchen just like the rest of us. What are you talking about?"

"Not *his* kitchen," Jimin choked out. "I thought I wanted to learn from the best, Tae. I thought if I could just survive Director Jeon's line, I could survive anything. But he doesn't just want perfect plating. He wants to strip away everything I am. He wants me to be an unfeeling machine, just like him."

He curled tighter into himself.

"And the worst part?" Jimin whispered, his lip trembling as he looked at Taehyung through a thick veil of tears. "For a second out there... I let him. I let him make me forget why I even love cooking in the first place."

Jimin closed his eyes, the darkness behind his eyelids offering no relief. The events of the evening kept replaying in his mind, but beneath the shock it all and the sting of his bleeding hand, a much heavier, more devastating truth began to settle in his chest.

He thought about the last few weeks.

The grueling prep, the burns, the constant, suffocating pressure.

And for what?

He realized with a drop in his stomach that lately, he hadn't been going to the academy to become a better chef for himself.

He had been going just to please Jungkook.

He had been tearing himself apart, bleeding over his cutting boards, and sacrificing his own culinary instincts just to chase a fleeting nod of approval from a man who would probably never be satisfied.

Even if Jimin flawlessly executed every single recipe exactly to the Director's clinical standards, it would never be enough. The realization made him feel physically ill. A deep, heavy wave of homesickness washed over him, completely burying whatever spark of ambition he had left.

He missed his family, he missed cooking with love, and he was just so entirely sick of it all.

"I'm going to bed," Jimin whispered, his voice hollow and devoid of life.

He didn't even bother stripping off his stained, wrinkled chef's coat. He just shifted his weight, curling onto his side, and slid numbly under the heavy covers, pulling the quilt up over his shoulders to hide from the world.

Taehyung sat frozen on the edge of the mattress. He reached out, his hand hovering hesitantly in the air just inches above Jimin's trembling shoulder. He desperately wanted to say something, to fix it, to pull his friend out of this dark spiral. But looking at the small, broken line of Jimin's back under the blankets, Taehyung knew empty comforts wouldn't work tonight.

Slowly, he let his hand drop to his lap.

"Okay," Taehyung said, his voice thick with a quiet, aching sadness. "Goodnight."

A sharp click echoed in the quiet dorm room as Taehyung reached over and turned off the bedside lamp, plunging Jimin into the heavy, absolute dark.



The next morning, the harsh glare of sunlight filtered through the dorm window, but Jimin didn't move an inch.

When his alarm blared at 4:00 AM—the alarm that usually had him scrambling out of bed, hyperfixating on his uniform and perfectly tying his apron—he simply reached an arm out from under his cover and swiped it off. The silence that followed was deafening.

It was the very first time he had ever missed a class, let alone a morning prep shift. The gravity of the absence should have sent him into a panic spiral, but instead, he just felt numb.

He stayed in bed as the hours ticked by, propped up against a mountain of pillows, mindlessly chewing on a bag of expensive, artisanal gummy candies Taehyung had left on his nightstand before leaving for class.

They were organic, vegan, and had no artificial dyes.

Without the chemical thrill of Red 40, Jimin's taste buds didn't exactly sing for joy. They tasted mostly like sad fruit leather, but he appreciated the gesture anyway. It was Taehyung's way of caring, and right now, the motion of chewing was the only thing keeping Jimin grounded.

His phone screen cast a pale glow across his tear-stained face as he endlessly toggled between apps.

First, the heavy, looming dread of his future. *Should I even go back?* he thought, chewing on a dull yellow gummy. He opened his browser, pulling up a travel site, and typed in a search for the quickest, cheapest one-way flights back to NYC.

The idea of just packing his bags, abandoning his passion, and disappearing into the crowded, familiar streets of New York felt dangerously tempting. He could almost smell the street carts. He could just go home, apologize to his family for failing, and get a job at a regular smegular diner where nobody cared if a tomato was cut with a ruler.

But looking at the departure times made his chest tighten. Running away meant Jungkook had won. Running away meant he was the weak, emotional amateur the Director had accused him of being.

Unable to handle the suffocating weight of the decision, Jimin furiously swiped out of the app and opened TikTok instead.

He doom-scrolled for what felt like hours, letting his brain turn entirely to mush, until a video popped up of a chunky orange cat miscalculating a jump from a kitchen counter and sliding into a trash can.

He watched it loop three times, his shoulders shaking with amusement, but the sound quickly fractured. The laughter caught in his throat, turning into a wet sniffle as a fresh wave of tears suddenly spilled over his eyelashes.

He wiped his face with the back of his hand, laughing and crying all at once in the quiet, empty dorm room, feeling like he was completely, unequivocally losing his mind.

The lock clicked sharply, breaking the stale, heavy silence of the dorm room. Taehyung stepped inside, taking in the sight of Jimin—still buried exactly where he had left him hours ago, a messy nest of tangled blankets, pillows, and empty candy wrappers.

Taehyung let out a tired sigh. He dropped his leather messenger bag and a stack of heavy culinary textbooks onto his desk with a dull thud.

"Chef asked about you," was all he said, not even turning around right away.

Jimin scoffed, a bitter, defensive instinct flaring to life instantly to protect his bruised heart. He rolled his eyes, throwing an arm dramatically over his forehead as he stared up at the ceiling.

"Yeah? Let me guess," Jimin snipped, his voice dripping with venom as he pitched it down, doing a terrible, exaggerated mock of the Director's accent. " That stupid American will fail my class, and I will laugh my French butt off and happily pay for his ticket back to New York? "

Taehyung didn't laugh. The room stayed painfully quiet for a moment. He just walked over to his own bed and sat down heavily on the mattress, leaning forward to start sliding his designer loafers off his feet.

"No," Taehyung began, his voice surprisingly gentle and lacking its usual dramatic flair. He tossed his shoes aside and looked across the small space between their beds, meeting Jimin's defensive glare with a soft, serious expression. "He pulled me to the side after class was dismissed... asked if you were okay."

Jimin froze.

His arm slowly dropped from his forehead, landing limply against the mattress. The biting, sarcastic retort he had lined up on his tongue died in his throat.

His brows furrowed as he stared at Taehyung, searching his friend's face for a punchline, a joke, or a hidden trap. But Taehyung was completely, entirely serious. Jungkook hadn't yelled. He hadn't gloated. He had just wanted to know if Jimin was alright.

Jimin swallowed the heavy lump that had suddenly reappeared in his throat, his voice slipping out as a tiny, fractured whisper.

"Oh."

"I told him you were feeling under the weather..." Taehyung added softly, the rustle of fabric indicating he was finally changing out of his stiff uniform. "...he said to make sure you eat."

Jimin rolled his eyes, though the motion lacked its usual fiery conviction. His heart gave a stupid, traitorous little flutter at the idea of the Director actually showing genuine concern, which only made him feel infinitely more pathetic.

"Yeah, well, I don't care," Jimin muttered defensively. He pulled the blanket higher up his neck and rolled over, turning his back to the room so he could stare blankly at the wall.

For a moment, the only sound was the distant traffic from the street outside. Then, Jimin heard Taehyung let out a long, deliberate sigh, the springs of the bed groaning as he shifted his weight to get comfortable.

"I think," Taehyung began, his voice losing that dramatic, breezy tone he usually wore, replaced by a quiet, piercing sincerity. "You two clash so much because you both challenge each other."

Jimin stiffened under the blankets, his breath catching slightly, but he didn't interrupt.

"I don't think you've ever really been told off before—not like that, not by someone who demands that level of absolute perfection," Taehyung said gently, his words hitting uncomfortably close to home. "And him? Honestly... I don't think he's ever been shut down. He's used to everyone just bowing their heads, saying 'Yes, Chef,' and taking whatever he dishes out."

Taehyung paused, letting the weight of the observation hang in the quiet room.

"But you don't. You fight back. You yell, you slam things.....you are not like most here," Taehyung continued softly. "He doesn't know how to handle someone who won't just blindly submit to him, and you don't know how to handle someone who won't just blindly praise you. And neither of you knows what to do with that."

Jimin sat up so fast the heavy cover pooled around his waist, the sudden movement making his head spin slightly.

"Trust me," Jimin said, his voice completely defensive as he crossed his arms over his chest. "He's the last person I want praise from."

The words hung in the air, tasting like a pathetic lie on his tongue. He knew it was a lie, his racing heart knew it was a lie, and the phantom heat of Jungkook's hands still burning on his skin definitely knew it was a lie.

And, unfortunately for him, Taehyung knew it too.

Taehyung's eyes instantly narrowed, squinting into a sharp, deeply skeptical glare that could have cut through steel. He didn't say a word, just let the absurdity of Jimin's statement settle into the quiet room.

Jimin flushed, his cheeks heating up as he broke eye contact, scrambling to justify himself before Taehyung could call him out on it.

"Plus," Jimin hurried on, his hands waving in a vague, dismissive gesture, "that still doesn't give him a reason to treat everyone like shit! Just because he's some Michelin-starred prodigy doesn't mean he gets to act like a dick. He's miserable!"

Taehyung tilted his head, leaning back on his hands as he studied his friend with an agonizingly perceptive gaze.

"Does he treat everyone like shit, Jimin?" Taehyung asked quietly, raising a single, perfectly sculpted eyebrow. "Or is he just pushing you?"

"He yells at everyone," Jimin countered instantly, though his voice lacked its usual bite.

"Not everyone," Taehyung corrected, holding up a finger to emphasize the point. He leaned forward, his voice dropping into a serious, grounded tone that made it impossible for Jimin to look away.

"With you? He watches everything you do like you're the only person in that kitchen. He doesn't just want you to fix a mistake, Jimin, he wants you to understand why you made it. He demands your attention because he actually cares what you do."

Taehyung let out a soft sigh, gesturing vaguely to the messy state of Jimin's bed. "And even when you constantly disrespect him to his face - *no offence* -, he doesn't suspend you. He asks me if you are okay."

Jimin swallowed hard, his throat clicking in the silence. His defensive walls were cracking, the anger that had been keeping him safe rapidly crumbling into something much more terrifying: hope, mixed with a devastating vulnerability.

"I don't know, okay Tae?" Jimin finally whispered, staring down at his bruised, bandaged hands resting in his lap. "If I ever do go back in there... I don't think I can look at him."

"Well, look at the food," Taehyung suggested with a simple, practical shrug. "But we've both come way too far to quit now."

Jimin bit his lower lip hard, worrying the soft flesh between his teeth as he looked over at his friend. The gentle logic in Taehyung's voice was comforting, but it didn't ease the chaotic storm still raging in his chest.

Jimin sat up further, letting the cover completely slide off his shoulders and pool around his waist, leaving him sitting there in his wrinkled, stained chef's coat.

"Tae, last night..." Jimin started, his voice trembling as the magnitude of what had happened finally began to sink in. "He... he told me I'd be cooking at the gala. That's how all this happened. I was trying to prove I was ready, and then there was the spaghetti, and the sugar and the hot sause.....and ugh- "

Jimin cut himself off with a frustrated, agonizing groan, running both hands fiercely through his messy hair. "...and I threw a rag at him! But, ugh , he just makes me so fucking angry!"

Taehyung's face went through a rapid-fire of human emotion. First, his eyes widened with joy—cooking at the gala!? Then, his expression contorted into confusion and dawning horror as the rest of the sentence registered. Finally, his jaw went slack, shock completely taking over his features.

"Y-you..." Taehyung stuttered, his voice jumping a full octave as he stared at Jimin like he was looking at a dead man walking. "You did what?"

Jimin squeezed his eyes shut tightly, completely mortified, his shoulders drawing up to his ears as if he were trying to physically hide from his own actions.

"I know, I know..." Jimin wailed miserably, his voice muffled as he buried his burning face in his hands. "It hit him right in the face. I assaulted a Michelin-starred chef with a dirty kitchen rag. My career is probably over!"

Taehyung sat frozen for a long moment, his brain visibly struggling to process the image of the immaculate, terrifying Director Jeon getting smacked in the chest by a dirty kitchen towel.

And then, a sound escaped him. It started as a tiny, muffled snort, quickly bubbling up into a full-blown, laugh that had Taehyung doubling over, clutching his stomach as he fell back onto his mattress.

"It's not funny, Tae!" Jimin groaned, though his own lips twitched against his will as Taehyung's laughter echoed in the small room.

"That explains why he looked so..." Taehyung gasped for air, waving a hand weakly as he sat back up, his eyes bright with amusement as he searched for the right translation. "What is the word in English..." He hummed in thought, tapping a finger against his chin. "*Troubled*. He looked incredibly troubled today."

"Yeah, well, maybe he shouldn't throw plates with the intent of breaking them!" Jimin shot back defensively, his cheeks flushing a deeper shade of crimson as he crossed his arms tightly over his chest. "And anyway, he has absolutely zero taste," Jimin tacked on. "Who gets that mad over a little bit of hot sauce in the spaghetti? It's literally *just* pasta."

Taehyung's laughter instantly cut off, his shoulders freezing mid-shake. The soft, understanding smile vanished from his face, replaced by a look of horror. He blinked once, then twice, staring at Jimin as if he'd just confessed to a crime.

"Wait. hold on," Taehyung said, his voice dropping into a flat, deadpan register. "Why on earth would you put hot sauce in spaghetti?"

"It's a personal preference!"

Taehyung just shook his head, looking deeply concerned for Jimin's sanity, though he managed to scoot forward until he was at the very edge of his bed, leaning in to close the distance between them.

"Okay, horrific culinary choices aside," Taehyung began, his tone losing the humor entirely and shifting into something deeply earnest and grounding. "Can't you see that yes, although maybe he is mean, and demanding, and sometimes violent... he sees something in you?"

Jimin opened his mouth to argue, to deny it, but the words withered on his tongue.

"The gala, Jimin. The gala," Taehyung stressed, his dark eyes wide and pleading. "He didn't pick any of the seniors. He didn't pick me. He picked the stubborn American who fights him at every single turn because he knows your hands are gifted. You sometimes have to deal with incredibly difficult people to get to exactly where you want to be."

"The culinary world is full of Director Jeons," Taehyung continued softly. "If you let him break you now, you'll never survive the industry. Don't throw everything you've ever worked for away just because your feelings are hurt."

Fuck.

Jimin hated him for being so right all the time.

The worst part about Taehyung being a dramatic, fashion-obsessed socialite was that underneath all the designer labels and theatrical sighs, he was incredibly, infuriatingly wise.

Jimin sank heavily back against his pillows, crossing his arms tightly over his chest in a stubborn, defensive pout. He chewed on the inside of his cheek for a long, tense minute, his eyes fixed on the

ceiling as a war waged violently in his head.

His bruised pride screamed at him to pack his bags and run, but that deeply ingrained, burning ambition—the one that had kept him awake practicing knife skills until 3:00 AM for weeks—refused to let him walk away.

Taehyung just sat there patiently, letting him fight it out.

"Fine," Jimin finally groaned out, the single word dragged from his throat like a physical concession. He let his head fall back into the mattress with a soft thud. "What did you guys learn today? I'll go later tonight to the kitchen and practice."

A slow, incredibly smug smirk tugged at the corners of Taehyung's lips. The tension in the room instantly evaporated, replaced by the familiar, electric spark of competition returning to the space.

"Oh, just a traditional Consommé brunoise," Taehyung said lightly, dusting off an invisible speck of lint from his trousers. "Chef Jeon was absolutely ruthless about the clarity of the broth. If it wasn't perfectly translucent, he dumped it down the drain. Half the class was in tears by 10:00 AM."



Jimin finally dragged himself out of the tangled nest of blankets. His body felt incredibly heavy, his eyes still slightly puffy and raw, but the familiar routine of splashing freezing water on his face and furiously brushing the stale taste of gummy candy out of his mouth helped clear the lingering fog. He changed into a fresh, crisp white chef's coat—ignoring the stained one crumpled on the floor—and grabbed his knife kit.

He hadn't given a single thought to the possibility that Director Jeon would be lingering in the kitchens. It was late afternoon, the awkward lull between the end of daytime classes and the start of evening prep. The kitchens were supposed to be empty. He definitely should have considered the alternative.

Jimin approached the main kitchen, his leather-soled shoes squeaking faintly against the polished, mirror-like linoleum corridor. The noise was small, but in the dead silence of the after-hours hall, it sounded like a warning. He reached out; his fingers wrapping around the cool metal of the heavy double door's handle and pushed it open.

The sterile, overhead fluorescent lights hummed quietly, casting a harsh, white glare over the expansive room. But the kitchen wasn't empty.

Chef Jeon was pacing.

His hands were shoved deep into his trouser pockets, his shoulders pulled rigid as he walked a tight, restless line behind the central stainless-steel prep island.

At the sharp click of the door breaking its seal, Jungkook stopped dead in his tracks.

His head snapped up.

The silence that crashed down over the kitchen was absolute, heavy, and deafening. Jimin stood completely frozen in the walkway, his fingers still wrapped tightly around the brass door handle, the leather strap of his knife roll cutting deep into his shoulder.

Their eyes locked across the massive expanse of the silver room. Jungkook's gaze was intense and overwhelming. It was a crushing weight that pinned Jimin exactly where he stood.

He couldn't do this.

Jimin's chest tightened, a physical ache blooming behind his ribs. He wasn't ready for a lecture. He wasn't ready to be berated, and he certainly wasn't ready to unpack whatever the hell had happened between them. He broke eye contact quickly, his gaze dropping to the tile floor as a hot, agonizing flush of anxiety crawled up his neck.

His grip tightened on the handle. He took a hasty, panicked half-step backward, intending to let the door swing shut and bolt straight back to the safety of his dorm room.

Just as Jimin began to pivot away, a voice fractured the silence like breaking glass.

"Wait."

It wasn't a barked order. It lacked the sharp, authoritative bite that usually came with it. It was lower, slightly rough, and laced with an uncharacteristic, almost desperate urgency that made Jimin's heart skip a painful beat against his ribs.

The door halted its swing. Jimin froze. He took a shallow, trembling breath, battling the urge to just keep walking, before slowly pivoting on his heel and stepping hesitantly back into the kitchen.

He let the door click shut behind him, sealing them inside together.

Jimin kept his gaze fixed stubbornly on the steel of the nearest prep station, refusing to look up as the slow sound of Jungkook's shoes echoed against the tile. The Director was closing the distance between them, his heavy, imposing presence radiating an undeniable, suffocating heat as he stopped just a few feet away.

"You missed class today."

Jimin gave a single, stiff nod, his jaw clenched so tightly his teeth ached. A spike of hot annoyance flared through the anxiety in his chest at the completely pointless interaction.

Obviously.

"Why?" Jungkook pressed, his voice dropping a fraction lower.

Jimin's eyes darted up, disbelief shattering his defensive stoicism for a split second. *Is he serious right now?* He stared at the Director, searching the older man's face for any sign of mockery or cruelty. After yesterday, the chaos, the shouting, and the absolute madness of what had happened between them, Jungkook was really standing here asking why?

"Are you sick?" Jungkook asked, taking half a step closer. His eyes swept frantically over Jimin's pale, exhausted face, taking in the faint shadows beneath his eyes and the tense, defensive set of his shoulders.

Jimin clamped his mouth shut. He didn't answer. He just glared, wrapping his arms defensively around his torso, letting the silence do the talking for him. He wanted Jungkook to squirm. He wanted the Director to acknowledge the elephant in the room instead of hiding behind clinical, polite questions.

The silence dragged out.

Jungkook's shoulders seemed to drop, the rigid, authoritative posture of the Director fracturing right in front of Jimin's eyes. The older man exhaled a shaky, ragged breath, running a hand through his dark hair, messing up the usually perfect strands.

"Jimin."

The sound of his name leaving Jungkook's lips wasn't a command. It slipped out with a raw, desperate tilt, completely stripped of its usual armor. It sounded as though Jimin's absolute refusal to speak was physically tearing the older man apart from the inside out.

"I didn't want to see you. There. happy?" Jimin finally said, his voice flat, though a dangerous tremor ran beneath it. He stubbornly kept his gaze fixed on the silver dials of the nearest stove, refusing to look up and meet the Director's eyes.

He hitched his heavy leather knife roll a little higher on his shoulder, trying to project a shield of absolute, unbothered apathy to protect himself. "But... after some words of wisdom, I decided that probably wasn't worth a zero. So, if you'll excuse me, I have a consommé to brunoise."

Jimin internally winced the very second the words left his mouth. Still, clamping his jaw shut, Jimin shifted his weight, aiming to step around the man and get to his prep station.

He didn't even make it two steps.

Before Jimin could clear the gap, a large, warm hand shot out into his path. Jungkook's fingers wrapped firmly around Jimin's wrist. The grip was sudden, halting Jimin's momentum in a split second.

With a single, effortless tug, Jungkook pulled him right back to where he had started. Jimin's breath hitched, his eyes snapping up in shock to finally meet Jungkook's dark, intense stare.

Jimin yanked against the hold, his pride flaring, but Jungkook didn't budge. He stood there, an immovable wall of quiet authority, blocking Jimin's path to the station.

Jungkook's gaze didn't waver, and when he spoke, his voice was stripped, sounding almost weary, heavy with a weight he had been carrying all day. "Jimin. You are talented. You're one of the most talented students I have ever had the misfortune of teaching."

Jimin felt his breath hitch, the sudden backhanded compliment hitting him with more force than any insult ever had. Jungkook looked down at him, his eyes searching, burning with that strange, desperate intensity. "Why can't you see help when it's knocking? Why is every single lesson I try to give you an act of war?"

Jimin let out a harsh, jagged scoff, a bitter, breathless sound bordering on hysterical. "Help? Is that what you call it? Because you'll have to excuse me, Chef, but 'help' definitely doesn't involve throwing dishes across the kitchen and screaming at me."

Jungkook sighed, a long sound that seemed to pull the very oxygen out of the room. He closed his eyes for a split second, his jaw clenching as if he were bracing himself to jump off a cliff. When he opened them, the dark depth of his eyes was entirely exposed, and he spoke two words that caused Jimin's entire world to screech to a sudden, jarring halt.

"I'm sorry."

Jimin blinked, his mind struggling to process the sound. The universe felt like it was tilting on its axis. He finally looked up fully, his defenses momentarily bypassed by the raw sincerity in the older man's eyes.

The Director of the academy was apologizing to him.

"I'm sorry for losing my temper," Jungkook began, his voice low, steady, and terrifyingly honest, vibrating in the small space between their chests. "But that does not excuse your behavior, either. You are like a child, fussing and fighting every command I give, when everything I do—everything I say—is to better you. To make you the chef you have the potential to be."

He held Jimin's gaze, the intensity in the room ramping up until it was almost unbearable. His grip on Jimin's wrist loosened slowly, the heat of his palm lingering against Jimin's skin, though he didn't pull away entirely. He was waiting, the ball in Jimin's court, the silence hanging between them like a tightrope.

"If you want my help," Jungkook continued, his tone shifting back into the familiar, firm cadence of a director, though his eyes remained dark and locked onto Jimin's lips. "Then stop acting like an adversary. Go to your station. Undo your knives. And be ready for prep."

Jimin stood frozen, the silence of the kitchen ringing loudly in his ears. The air between them was thick with the weight of the apology, yet it was tethered to the iron-clad reality of their dynamic. He looked at Jungkook, his heart pounding a frantic rhythm against his ribs.

"And Jimin?" Jungkook added, his voice dropping into a dangerous, silken whisper that fanned hot against Jimin's face as he leaned in just a fraction of an inch closer. "Don't test me again tonight. My patience is finite, and you've spent every last drop."

Jimin opened his mouth to retort, the familiar sting of a defensive comeback ready on his tongue, but the words died before they could form. He just closed his mouth, took a shaky, uneven breath, and stepped away.

Jimin carefully navigated the space around the Director, keeping his head down as his heart hammered wildly against his ribs, moving back to the familiar, defensive boundary of his station.

"Unroll your kit," Jungkook commanded. His tone was still sharp, carrying the sharp authority, but the cruel, mocking edge from yesterday was gone. He was trying to be fair, trying to teach, but his impatience still vibrated in the air.

Jimin reached his counter and unrolled his heavy leather case. The familiar, cold weight of the steel tools provided a much-needed comfort for his trembling fingers. He drew his finest chef's knife, the

steel gleaming under the lights.

With a heavy thud, Jungkook dropped a wooden crate of shallots and a bowl of ice water next to Jimin's board.

"A perfect small dice," Jungkook barked, leaning his hip against the opposite counter, his dark eyes locked onto Jimin's hands. "One-millimeter cubes. Every single one identical. If you want to build a legacy, Jimin, you start here. Two minutes. Begin."

Jimin's heart did a panicked flip. Two minutes for a crate of shallots at that precision was an impossible standard. He forced his fingers into a claw grip, stabilizing the first shallot, and began to cut. Slice, turn, dice. The rhythmic tap-tap-tap of the blade echoed against the tile.

"Your wrist is too stiff! Rock the blade!" Jungkook snapped from across the station, his voice booming off the stainless steel. "You're dropping your shoulder, Jimin! Speed up!"

Jimin's jaw clenched so tight it ached. The fumes of the shallots began to sting his eyes, mixing with the frustration he was trying desperately to suppress. He missed a line, a chunk of shallot rolling away ruined. He threw it aside and started on another, his cuts growing frantic.

"Keep your fingers tucked! If you lose focus, you lose a nail!" Jungkook shouted again, stepping closer, his heavy footsteps echoing loudly. "Watch your margins! You're rushing! It's sloppy!"

"Why are you yelling at me!" Jimin suddenly snapped, his voice cracking as he slammed the heel of his knife onto the cutting board, halting his movements entirely. He tilted his chin up, his eyes wild with frustration. "You just apologized! You said you were sorry for your temper, and now you're right back to screaming at me!"

"Because you don't listen!" Jungkook fired right back, his voice dropping into a low, intense register as he closed the remaining distance between them. He stood right at the edge of Jimin's station, his chest heaving. "I am not screaming to be mean. I'm doing it because you lose your form the second the pressure ramps up! You drift, you second-guess yourself, you—"

"I'm trying!" Jimin finished, his hands shaking as his voice rose into a frantic, breathless defense. He waved his free hand slightly, his words tumbling out in a desperate rush. "I missed class because

I couldn't look at you, okay? My head is a mess, my wrists hurt, and I'm standing here trying to do exactly what you want, but every time I move, you're right there telling me it's wrong, telling me I'm wrong—"

"Jimin, stop," Jungkook commanded, stepping directly into his space to cut off the frantic spiral. Seeing how violently Jimin's hands were shaking, Jungkook reached out, his palm coming down over the spine of the heavy chef's knife. "Give me the knife."

"No!"

Driven by a sudden, reckless surge of defiance, Jimin didn't let go. He knew keeping his hand locked around knife was childish—a petty, desperate play for leverage in a kitchen that belonged entirely to the Director, but he didn't really care.

He was sick of being told what to do. He was tired of handing over every single ounce of control to this man, tired of being forced to yield his autonomy the second Jungkook demanded it. His fingers fisted around the handle even tighter, pulling the knife back toward his own chest, determined to keep his grip on the only thing he had left.

Because they both refused to let go, the movement jerked them impossibly close. Jungkook's grip tightened on the cold spine of the steel; Jimin's knuckles turned white on the grip. Neither of them backed down.

The air in the kitchen instantly turned thick.

Jungkook didn't yank, but he used his frame to crowd Jimin, stepping flush against his front until Jimin's lower back pressed hard against the edge of the counter. They were trapped standing together, the sharp edge of the blade suspended horizontally between their chests, trembling under the force of their opposing strength.

"Jimin, let go," Jungkook rumbled, his voice dropping into a low, warning register. The steel hovering dangerously close to their skin. "You're going to hurt yourself."

Jungkook didn't once drop his eyes down to the knife. He kept them locked dead on Jimin's face, his irises dilated so wide behind his silver glasses they nearly swallowed the brown entirely.

"No," Jimin breathed, a hot, angry tear finally spilling over his lashes. A frantic, desperate determination took over his mind. He wasn't letting Jungkook win. Not this time. "I'm not giving it to you!"

"Fine!" Jungkook roared, his voice snapping under the terror of the moment. He slammed his chest forward, pinning Jimin firmly against the counter, his large hand sliding down to wrap brutally over Jimin's fingers on the handle. "You're in control! Is that what you want? Is this what it takes to make you listen?"

Jimin squeezed his eyes closed for a brief, agonizing second before snapping them open, his tear-filled gaze boring straight into Jungkook's frantic ones.

"Let go!"

Jungkook rolled his eyes, a harsh, panicked laugh ripping from his throat. "You are ridiculous!" He leaned in closer, his features twisting as he slipped into a low, breathless torrent, his accent thick and desperate. "*Tu me rends complètement fou... Je pense qu'il y a quelque chose de si profond entre nous, et tu—*"

"Let go," Jimin choked out, interrupting the words he couldn't handle right now. He stubbornly kept his grip locked on the handle, refusing to back down.

In a blind, frantic effort to break Jimin's leverage and wrench the weapon safely away from him, Jungkook pulled the knife forward. But the opposing force was too strong. The sudden, jerky movement sent the sharp edge sliding softly across the delicate skin of Jimin's chin.

Jimin let out a sharp gasp as the unexpected bite of the steel shattered his stubbornness. His fingers instantly went limp, dropping the knife. Jungkook released his grip in the exact same millisecond, his face going completely pale.

The heavy chef's knife clattered against the edge of the counter before tumbling to the floor, hitting the tile with a loud, ringing metal echo that bounced off the walls.

Neither of them moved to pick it up. Jimin stood frozen, his chest heaving as he slowly looked down at the floor. A warm droplet of bright crimson blood bloomed under his jaw, pooling for a fraction of a second before dripping from his chin and hitting the white tile below. He slowly pulled his gaze back up to lock dead onto Jungkook, his eyes wide, blown-out, and glassy.

"What is wrong with you?" Jungkook breathed, his voice a ragged, furious tremor. He stepped back just an inch, his hands hovering in the air as if he wanted to shake Jimin but was terrified to touch him. "I don't understand you. I don't understand what you want from me! You fight me on every single thing, you push me until I'm out of my mind, and for what? To prove you can?"

The overwhelming weight of the words—the adrenaline crashing out of his system, the stinging pain under his jaw, and the intensity of the man standing over him—finally broke something deep inside Jimin's chest.

A choked, heavy sob ripped from his throat. The defensive barrier, the sharp retorts, the guard he had worn all semester completely failed him, leaving him entirely exposed.

He started crying, heavy tears flooding over his lashes and pouring down his flushed face in a desperate, uncontrollable rush. He was so overwhelmed with himself, with the academy, and with the terrifying grip this man had over his entire mind.

"Shut up," Jimin sobbed out, his voice cracking violently. Moving on pure instinct, he brought his shaking hands up and slammed them hard against Jungkook's chest, pushing at him. "I hate you!"

Jungkook stumbled back a half-step, his eyes wide and completely vulnerable as he stared at Jimin's unraveled state.

"Jimin, I—I—" Jungkook stammered, his voice dropping into a breathless, fractured whisper that completely cracked his usual persona.

With a fierce, possessive yank, Jimin threw his remaining pride out the window. He lunged forward before the man could finish, grabbing Jungkook by his collar with a desperate, wild strength, and pulled the man down to slam their lips together.

Jungkook stood completely frozen for a second, his entire body rigid under the sudden, frantic collision. But Jimin didn't care. He was pissed, and he wasn't even sure if this was the correct way to show it.

He didn't care if it made sense, didn't care about the consequences, didn't care about the rules. He figured it didn't matter anyways.

Still crying, although silently now, the hot tears slipping down his flushed cheeks and smearing against the man's lips Jimin suddenly felt the sudden, overwhelming gravity of what he'd just done crashed over him.

His heart hammered against his ribs. Terrified by his own vulnerability and the raw, unfiltered emotion pouring out of him, he abruptly pulled his lips away from Jungkook's.

"Oh... I'm sorry, oh god..." Jimin stammered, his voice fractured and breathless as he tried to stumble back against the counter.

Jungkook didn't let him.

Without a single word, Jungkook reached up with one hand, yanked his glasses off his face, and threw them carelessly onto the steel counter behind him, where they slid with a sharp rattle against the metal. His eyes were completely blown, dilated so wide they looked nearly black under the harsh lights.

Before Jimin could even draw a breath to apologize again, Jungkook's hands shot forward, wrapping around Jimin's waist. With a possessive tug, he yanked Jimin right back, chest slamming against chest, eliminating every single inch of distance between them.

This time, Jungkook drove down and captured his lips.

The kiss was breathless, an explosion of pure hunger. Jungkook dived into Jimin's mouth like a starved man finally thrown a lifeline, his lips crushing against Jimin's with a desperate, heavy intensity that left absolutely no survival. There was no ego left just a terrifying devotion that seemed to incinerate the very air in the room.

Jimin let out a muffled gasp straight into the collision of their mouths, his fingers locking back into the fabric of Jungkook's shirt just to keep himself upright. His head swam violently, a dizzying, rush of heat pooling low in his stomach as he felt himself growing light-headed from the crushing pressure of the man's mouth.

They both seemed to be moving in desperate sync now, their heads tilting and twisting together to deepen the kiss, finding a rhythm born entirely of weeks of tension. Jungkook's grip on Jimin's waist tightened until it was bruising, a desperate hold, as he sighed deeply into Jimin's mouth.

With the frantic movement of their mouths, the bright line of blood from Jimin's chin was smeared across their skin—some of it staining the collar of his white chef's coat, some cutting tracks across his own face, and some transferring onto Jungkook's jaw and shirt. The man didn't seem to care about the mess at all, which surprised Jimin the most; the untouchable, clean-freak Director was unfazed by the blood, too possessed by the heat of the moment to notice.

The kiss turned smoother, melting into something that was aching need more than anything else.

Jungkook tasted like old mints and the cold, sterile air of the kitchen. He kissed exactly like he did everything else in life: with a meticulous, all-consuming passion. It was so intense, so deeply devastating in its focus, that Jimin found himself losing his grounding. His fingers tangled blindly into the dark fabric of Jungkook's shirt, his head swimming so fast that he forgot why he was even mad in the first place.

He forgot about the anger, forgot about the harsh voices, forgot why he had even bothered to fight at all.

Haltingly, Jungkook let out a deep groan. His hands slid from Jimin's waist down to the underside of his thighs, gripping the fabric of his trousers and effortlessly hoisting Jimin up to sit him on the edge of the counter.

Jungkook broke the kiss for a split second, his breathing a ragged, hot mess against Jimin's face. Moving with a sudden, impatient sweep of his arm, he pushed away the cutting board, the prep bowls, and the remaining tools on the station, sending them sliding across the metal island in a frenzy.

Jimin didn't hesitate. The second the counter was clear, he shifted and scooted back, his palms flat against the metal to hold himself. Their movements were frantic, sloppy, and rushed—lacking any of the careful precision of the kitchen—as if they both knew exactly what was coming anyways and neither could bear another second of delay.

Jimin's head tilted back against the cold air of the kitchen, his senses completely overwhelmed as Jungkook captured his lips all over again. He was losing his breath too fast. His vision blurred slightly around the edges under the sharp glare of the lights, his fingers tightening like a vice in the dark cotton of Jungkook's shirt just to keep his balance on the slick counter.

Jungkook's hands were wild. Abandoning all his usual rigid, calculated precision, his palms slid roughly up the expanse of Jimin's thighs, mapping the heat of his skin through the fabric of his jeans. They migrated up to grip Jimin's hips, pulling him to the edge of the counter before dragging all the way up his torso. Tracing the line of his ribs, bruising his waist, and then sliding right back down in a desperate, worshipful frenzy.

They were everywhere all at once, touching him with an erratic urgency.

Now, Jimin had been sexually active before— *not that it was anyone's business* —but to say the least, he had never felt so entirely desperate, so completely consumed by a feeling so great that he couldn't even wait another second. Every nerve ending in his body was screaming for a something that felt impossible to satisfy fast enough.

In a scrambling, frantic movement, his hands abandoned their grip on Jungkook's shoulders and ran down the front of the man's dark shirt. His trembling fingertips fumbled blindly against the placket, feeling for the buttons with a silent, desperate plea.

Sensing the struggle, Jungkook's hand left Jimin's hip for just a second. He caught Jimin's shaking wrist, his own hands guiding Jimin's up to the top of his shirt, placing his fingers directly onto the first button.

With the kiss still in full motion, Jimin clumsily worked the fastening free. He managed to undo the first button, then the second, his breath hitching as his knuckles brushed the hot skin of Jungkook's collarbone. But Jimin's focus began to shatter as Jungkook began kissing him even harder, with a renewed, desperate intensity that made his knees twitch against the counter.

Abandoning the buttons out of frustration, Jimin's hands migrated into Jungkook's dark hair, fisting the strands to pull him closer.

Jungkook let out a breath against Jimin's lips, instantly understanding the silent surrender. Without breaking the rhythm of their mouths for even a fraction of a second, Jungkook took over. His own hands moved down to his chest, his fingers catching the edges of the dark fabric and working their way down the remaining buttons with a practiced speed, forcing the fabric open.

Jimin's palms slid down, flat against the newly exposed skin, his fingers eagerly mapping the musculature of Jungkook's chest. The smooth skin beneath his fingertips felt incredibly warm compared to the cold metal of the counter, and he let out a light, trembling sigh directly into the man's mouth.

Then, Jungkook broke the kiss.

He stayed close, his forehead resting against Jimin's, his breath coming in ragged gasps. He looked an absolute mess, but Jimin figured he wasn't fairsing any better. \

The Director's usually immaculate hair was completely disheveled, wild and messy from where Jimin's hands had been fisting the strands. His lips were swollen, glistening and smeared in a chaotic mixture of Jimin's spit, tears, and the faint traces of blood from under his chin.

Jimin's breath hitched at the sight. His eyes dropped instinctively, tracing the sharp lines of Jungkook's collarbone down to the heavy contours of his exposed torso, before snapping right back up to lock onto the man's dark, unblinking eyes.

Without another sound, Jungkook shrugged his shoulders, letting the unbuttoned shirt slide effortlessly down his arms and pool onto the floor by his feet, leaving his torso completely bare. His eyes never wavered, remaining trained dead on Jimin's face with a heavy intensity.

Slowly Jungkook's tongue darted out to lick his lips, the faint smear of Jimin's blood disappearing with a single, slow swipe of his tongue.

The sight alone made Jimin's pants feel a little tighter than they'd been just moments before.

Jimin instinctively bit his lower lip, a sudden, nervous flutter cutting through the heavy haze of his arousal. His knuckles tightened against the edge of the counter as Jungkook leaned in impossibly close, his breath fanning across Jimin's flushed cheek.

"You've driven me completely beyond mad, Jimin," Jungkook murmured. "Is that what you want to hear?"

Jimin inhaled shakily, the cold air of the kitchen stinging his lungs. He didn't know what he wanted—his brain was too scrambled to formulate a single coherent thought. But right now? He knew who he wanted.

Deliberately choosing not to answer, Jimin brought his trembling hands up to the high collar of his own white chef's coat.

Instead of the frantic, scrambling panic from moments ago, Jimin began undoing the buttons slowly. One by one, his shirt parted under his fingers.

Jungkook pulled back just an inch to watch the movements, his eyes instantly tracking the slow progress, locked on the pale skin gradually being exposed beneath the uniform. He didn't move a single muscle, his jaw clenched tight as he watched Jimin work.

Jimin kept his head down, his focus entirely on his own hands until he reached the very bottom.

At the quiet pop of the last button, Jimin finally looked up through his damp lashes, his heart executing a violent flip against his ribs. He didn't even have to wait. Jungkook was already right there, his intense, blown-out gaze burning straight into Jimin's face, waiting for whatever was next.

"Yes," Jimin says finally, though it comes out lower and far more breathless than he expected it to.

Jungkook's eyes narrow into something trapped between sharp annoyance and enduring tolerance, his jaw tightening as he absorbs the quiet admission.

"You like having this over me?" Jungkook murmured, his grip tightening on Jimin's hips, his fingers digging in just enough to bruise. He slowly slid his hands up to Jimin's waist, his touch soft yet demanding, succumbing his space entirely to whatever Jimin wanted to do next. "You like knowing that you can completely ruin my line, ruin my focus... just by walking through that door?"

Jimin just sighed in response, the sound catching high and helpless in the back of his throat. The confession was far too much for him to handle, a devastating spike of heat shooting straight to his core. Hearing Jungkook admit to being completely broken by him stripped away the last of Jimin's defenses.

Unable to take the suffocating intensity of the words, Jimin blindly reached forward, his hands clinging tightly to Jungkook's bare shoulders as he yanked himself back into the safety of the man's mouth, desperate to drown out the confession with another kiss.

Jungkook responded instantly, his mouth crashing back into Jimin's as his hands brushed up against Jimin's bare torso.

"Tellement beau, que fais-je de moi-même," he murmured directly into the heat of the kiss, the words rolling off his tongue in a low, gravelly vibration.

Jimin let out a soft, fractured breath, his fingers tightening against Jungkook's shoulders. He wished he could know what that meant—wished he could know every single, crazy thing the man was thinking right now.

"What do you want, Jimin?" Jungkook breathed, his lips brushing heavily against Jimin's as he tore away for just a fraction of a second, his voice thick with a delirious, desperate restraint. "What can I give you to make you stop fighting me?"

Instead of answering, Jimin shifted forward on the counter, the cold metal sliding against his skin as he instinctively wrapped his legs tightly around Jungkook's waist, pulling the man flush against him.

"Please," Jimin whispered, the word breaking into a ragged, helpless gasp against the man's lips.

It was stupid, really. It was so incredibly stupid for him to spend so much time fighting this man, tearing the kitchen apart just to hold his ground, only to end up exactly like this.

Completely unraveled and begging in the end. But under the heavy weight of Jungkook's hands, none of the pride mattered anymore.

Jungkook looked just as desperate, if not more as his hands scrambled downward towards the button and zipper of his own pants.

Jimin found his own too, his trembling fingers matching the frantic rhythm as they both worked in a wild, uncoordinated panic to rid themselves of the remaining barriers. Jungkook smoothly rid himself of his pants, kicking the fabric behind him onto the tile floor without a single backward glance, before turning his attention right back to Jimin.

Jimin lifted his hips off the counter, bracing his palms flat against the metal. Jungkook's hands hooked into the waistband of Jimin's pants, his grip tight as he slid the fabric down his legs and threw them carelessly aside.

"Fuck, Jimin," Jungkook rasped out, his voice hoarse. His eyes, completely dilated, raked hungrily over Jimin's bare, shivering body, completely undone by the sight. "You are crazy," Jungkook said, the words a low, fractured murmur meant mostly for himself, as if he were trying to make sense of the absolute wreckage of his own restraint.

Jimin smiled clumsily at that, his lips parting in a breathless, half-dazed curve. He could take crazy. He would take crazy any day over being called a stupid American, over the cold, biting metrics that usually cut him to pieces over a prep line.

Although, Jimin wasn't entirely sure if Jungkook actually meant crazy, or if the word was just a poor translation for something far more intimate, because the man instantly dived down, burying his face in the crook of Jimin's shoulder kissing fiercely at his neck.

Jimin's head tipped back, his eyes slipping closed as a long, helpless shiver rippled straight down to his toes. Jungkook left a heavy trail of hot, open-mouthed kisses against his sensitive skin, his breath scalding against the chilled air of the kitchen.

But Jimin's eyes blew wide in pure shock a second later. He stiffened instantly when he felt the rough, wet expanse of Jungkook's tongue lick a thick stripe upward along his jaw, smoothly taking

all the dried blood with him.

Jungkook let out a deep, primal groan directly against his skin at the taste, his tongue lapping Jimin like a dog drinking water until he was entirely cleaned. Jimin swallowed hard, his throat tight as he stared blankly up at the white ceiling tiles; he supposed, in some warped, twisted way, that this was the man's messed-up attempt at an apology.

Crazy? Jimin thought, his knuckles turning white as he clawed blindly at Jungkook's bare shoulders, his heart hammering a terrifying, erratic rhythm against his ribs. *If he were crazy. That would make Jungkook completely beyond insane.*

Then, without a single word of warning, the silence returned, and Jungkook's grip on his hips tightened into an absolute vice.

Jimin's world was flipped in a fraction of a second. With a sudden, heavy heave, Jungkook spun him completely around on the smooth counter.

Jimin let out a sharp, startled yelp, his palms slamming flat against the counter to brace himself. He was left half-hanging off the edge of the table, his spine arching as his body was forced into a vulnerable exposed position. Before he could even scramble for leverage, Jungkook stepped in close behind him, eliminating every single inch of remaining air.

Jimin gasps, his knuckles turning white against the metal as he felt the thick, burning print of the man pressed directly and heavily against him.

Jungkook leaned down, his mouth hot and heavy against the cool skin of Jimin's back. He pressed a slow kiss into the exact center of Jimin's spine, before trailing a line of them all the way up and around to the crook of his shoulder.

"Est-ce que c'est ce que tu veux ?" Jungkook murmured, his voice thick and gravelly against the shell of Jimin's ear. He paused, his breath hitching as his jaw clenched tightly, before adding in a rough, low hiss, *"Est-ce qu'il faut ça pour que tu la fermes, ta jolie bouche ?"*

Jimin nodded dumbly, a helpless shiver rippling straight down his spine. His brain was too fried by the adrenaline and the intensity of the man behind him to even care that he didn't know half of what

had just been said.

Jungkook chuckled at the mindless reaction, the low vibration rumbling directly against Jimin's bare shoulder. Then, his hands moved, following the sharp curve of Jimin's waist slowly down to his backside.

Jimin weakly tilted his head down, looking over his shoulder through his damp lashes as he tried to follow the movements. Under the stark, lights, Jungkook's fingers toyed deliberately with the tight hem of Jimin's black boxers, his knuckles brushing against his bare thigh.

"Tell me what you want," Jungkook asked.

Except this time, the commanding authority completely failed him. The words came out incredibly strained, broken, and almost desperate, his chest heaving against Jimin's back as if the remaining threads of his tethered restraint were about to snap entirely.

"Please," Jimin whispered, his head dropping heavily onto his forearms against the cold metal. He couldn't think; his mind was entirely blank, completely consumed by the overwhelming weight of the friction, the fever, and the raw presence of the man pinning him down.

Jungkook leaned over him again, his lips pressing a slow, punishing kiss right into the center of Jimin's spine.

"Now you seem to have trouble talking?" Jungkook asked, his voice thick with a dark, mocking arrogance that sent a violent rush straight through Jimin.

Jimin could only let out a sharp, ragged gasp as he felt Jungkook's hand finally slip beneath the tight elastic fabric of his underwear. The heat of the man's palm brushed directly against the bare, sensitive skin of his ass, the contact purely electric against the chilled air of the room.

"Fuck," Jungkook hissed, heavy warmth of the friction making his voice crack completely. The clinical arrogance he had vanished in a fraction of a second, his jaw clenching hard as a low, desperate string of curses caught in his throat at the feeling of Jimin.

"C-chef," Jimin moaned, the title ripping from his throat completely unbidden as he instinctively arched his spine, pushing himself back into the heat of that touch. "M-more please?"

But the contact was gone in an instant. The sudden loss of warmth made Jimin gasp, his fingers clawing at the metal for a fraction of a second. When he weakly turned his head to look over his shoulder, his breath caught entirely.

Jungkook was slowly lowering himself down onto his knees on the hard tile floor, his dark eyes wide and unblinking, never leaving Jimin's for even a fraction of a second.

Jimin's eyes followed him all the way down, the visual of the formidable Director settling at his feet making his throat dry out completely.

"Fuck," Jimin panted out at the sight. If anyone had told him a week ago—or even an hour ago—that this would one day be his view, he would have never believed them. It was surreal, a breathless thing that made his stomach flip with arousal.

"I'll give you what you want," Jungkook said lowly, his voice vibrating right through the quiet room.

Jimin believed him. Looking down at the man who held his entire career—and now his entire mind—in his hands, Jimin nodded frantically, his heart hammering wild against his ribs. "Yes, please... please."

Jungkook smirked at that, although faintly, his swollen lips twitching with a dark, possessive satisfaction at the helpless sight of his student. Without a word of warning, his hands shot forward, wrapping securely around the elastic of Jimin's underwear. With a rough, impatient downward yank, he pulled the fabric completely down Jimin's legs until it pooled helplessly around his ankles.

He didn't waste another second. His hands moved to the back of Jimin's thighs, prying them apart with an authoritative, bruising grip that anchored Jimin firmly to the metal island.

Jungkook leaned in close, pressing a soft, lingering kiss directly into the small of Jimin's back. He didn't stop there; his mouth moved lower, leaving a trail of hot, open-mouthed kisses across the curve of his ass. The slick, wet pressure of his lips against Jimin's bare skin was overwhelming.

"Please..." Jimin whimpered softly, his head rolling back as he clutched at the counter.

Then, instead of diving straight in, Jungkook's hands migrated down, his heavy palms burying deep into the soft flesh of Jimin's ass, his grip tight and immovable as he deliberately spread him wide open. He leaned in, his face buried between the parted cheeks, and left a faint, deceptively soft kiss right against the sensitive skin.

Jimin let out a sharp, breathless gasp at the feeling, a violent tremor passing through his lower back as his hips twitched against the metal.

But his thoughts completely shattered before the teasing restraint vanished entirely. Jungkook tilted his head and licked a deep, heavy stripe from the very base of his hole all the way up, before swiping right back down in a slow, agonizingly wet stroke.

"*Si putain de bon,*" Jungkook growled against his skin, a deep, guttural sound ripping from the back of his throat as he drank in the slick heat.

Jimin's head dropped to rest against the counter, a loud, unraveling moan ripping from his throat and echoing off the tiles. Jungkook dived in with a wet, heavy hunger, his tongue swiping broad and deep, coating Jimin's sensitive flesh in slick spit.

The loud, ungodly noises of the friction filled the quiet kitchen—the heavy, wet sound of Jungkook slurping and lapping greedily at his skin, drowning out the steady hum of the industrial refrigerators.

Jimin's mind reeled in shock.

He thought to himself, his head spinning, that he had never seen Jungkook eat like this. Not during their grueling kitchen practices, and not even under the elegant, flashing lights at the ball.

Jesus.

The untouchable, meticulous Chef was completely gone, reduced to a desperate man slurping and lapping at him, groaning into his flesh as if the taste alone was the only thing keeping him sane.

Driven by the overwhelming sensation, Jimin blindly reached back, his fingers tangling desperately into the thick, dark strands of Jungkook's hair.

"F-fuck," Jimin choked out, fisting his hand and pulling back hard to force Jungkook's head away for a second. He was trying to catch his breath, trying to dictate the rhythm, but the moment he let up the pressure, Jungkook drove right back in with a sloppy, heavy slap of his tongue that made Jimin's hips arch off the steel.

"Tell me how you want it," Jungkook murmured against his skin, his breath hot and damp, his words breaking into a low hiss as he lapped at him again, completely unbothered by the wet, messy sounds filling the quiet room. "Tell me, Jimin. I'll do exactly what you want."

"Harder," Jimin cried out, his knuckles turning white as he gripped Jungkook's hair again, pulling him fiercely against his core to control the speed. "R-right there— fuck , j-just like—like that," Jimin gasped out, his voice a frantic, stuttering wreck as the overwhelming pleasure completely derailed his thoughts, his hands fisting desperately into Jungkook's hair to pull him even closer.

Jungkook obeyed instantly, his compliance turning ferocious and relentless. He used his hands to anchor Jimin's cheeks, prying him open further as his tongue worked with a frantic, rhythmic pace. It was filthy and entirely unraveled; the slick, wet sounds were so loud they filled Jimin's ears, driving him completely out of his mind. Every time Jimin tried to pull his hair to slow him down, Jungkook only sucked harder, his mouth devouring him with a desperate devotion.

The pleasure became too heavy, too thick to bear. Jimin's breath turned into a series of broken, high-pitched gasps, his stomach tight as a sudden, violent wave of an orgasm began to threaten him.

"F-fuck oh—I can't—" Jimin sobbed, his hands abandoning Jungkook's hair to claw at the stainless steel. Desperate to escape the heat of the man's mouth, Jimin began to scramble forward, his knees dragging against the counter as he practically tried to climb further up the metal island to get away from the intensity.

But Jungkook wouldn't let him.

Remaining on his knees, Jungkook crawled right along with him, his hands sliding up to grip Jimin's waist with a bruising hold, dragging him right back down to the edge. He buried his face even deeper, his tongue darting out frantically to chase every drop, following Jimin's frantic movements with a desperate, breathless hunger that left them both completely undone.

Jimin's cock was rock-hard, pressed flush and throbbing against his own stomach, but he couldn't even bring himself to reach down and touch it. His knuckles were white where he gripped the edge of the stainless steel, too terrified that he'd lose his balance and slide right off due to just how weak and trembling his legs felt under the heavy, consuming friction of the man's mouth.

The relentless, wet friction was too much. Jimin's vision went entirely white as a violent, shattering orgasm ripped through his frame. His thighs shook uncontrollably, his muscles seizing as he let out a loud, broken wail that bounced off the kitchen tiles, his release spraying blindly across the stainless steel.

But Jungkook didn't stop.

Even as Jimin sobbed into the metal, his body hyper-sensitive, Jungkook's tongue kept working, rough and heavy, driving him right through the peak. The continuous pleasure was so intense that Jimin's head swam; he was convinced he might pass out right there.

This man was fucking crazy, completely—but fuck, Jimin loved crazy.

Jungkook let out a deep, guttural groan against his slick skin. "*Tellement bon, putain—*" he growled, his voice raw and thick with satisfaction.

Slowly, he began to stand, pressing hot, wet kisses all the way up the curvature of Jimin's spine. Jimin was trembling from head to toe, completely spent, his flushed cheek pressed flat against the cool, soothing surface of the stainless steel.

"J-Jungkook," he murmured into the empty room, his voice breathless and delirious. Jimin let out a sharp, startled yelp as a palm slammed firmly against his bare cheek, the stinging pain of the slap instantly cutting through his haze.

"Chef," Jungkook corrected, his voice dropping into a low leaving no room for argument

Hearing rustle of fabric, Jimin weakly tilted his head back, peeking through his lashes. Jungkook was stepping out of his boxers. Under the stark lights, he was massive, veins standing out along his length, already leaking a thick drop of pre-cum that glinted in the light.

Jungkook gripped himself, giving a few slow, heavy strokes, his head throwing back as a tight, breathless grimace of pleasure crossed his handsome features.

But before he pushed inside, Jungkook reached forward, his heavy palms wrapping securely around Jimin's waist. With a sudden, yank, he pulled Jimin's upper body back against his chest, forcing him upright.

Jimin let out a gasp, his spine arching into Jungkook's frame as he instinctively tilted his head back, his throat completely exposed.

Jungkook leaned down over him, his dark eyes burning with an intense, unhinged heat. His mouth was covered in a glistening sheen of spit and god-knows-what from spending so long buried inside Jimin, and without a single word of warning, he crashed their lips together.

The kiss was wet, and deeply invasive. As Jungkook's tongue pushed deep into his mouth, Jimin immediately tasted himself on the older man's lips. A soft moan vibrated right from the back of Jimin's throat into the kiss.

Jungkook drank in the sound, swallowing Jimin's moans whole before finally breaking the kiss with a wet, heavy smack. He let Jimin slide back forward against the counter, keeping him anchored tightly at his hips.

"Hands flat on the counter," Jungkook ordered.

Jimin shook softly as he obeyed, bringing his arms up limply and pressing his palms against the cool stainless steel just to keep himself from collapsing. His muscles were completely spent, twitching from the aftershocks of his release, and he could barely support his own weight as his spine curved vulnerably under Jungkook's shadow.

He felt Jungkook positioning himself behind him, the blazing, thick heat of the man pressing heavily right against his entrance. A sharp, gasp leaving Jimin's lips as the man began to slowly push.

Jungkook's face contorted with the overwhelming intensity of the friction. His dark eyebrows furrowed deeply into a heavy frown, his mouth hanging open as he let out a ragged gasp. The thick, stretching fullness was so tight it made a low, frantic string of curses rip straight from his throat.

" *Ah, putain... Jimin* ," Jungkook growled, the words sounding heavy, dark, and utterly undone as his jaw clenched tightly.

Because Jimin was already completely coated and slick with Jungkook's spit, the older man slid inside him with a terrifying, seamless ease. Jimin's eyes blew wide and his face slammed right back down against the counter, a loud, long moan tearing from his throat as the thick, stretching fullness filled him all at once. Jungkook pushed all the way in until his groin locked hard against Jimin's backside, a ragged, shaking exhale leaving his lips.

"Look at you... fuck, taking me so well," Jungkook praised , his hands coming down to grip Jimin's hips, pinning him to the metal. He began to pull back and drive back in, his rhythm immediately turning fierce and demanding. "*Tu es si parfait pour moi... oui, comme ça, Jimin. Tout à moi.*"

The speed was relentless. The heavy, rhythmic slap of their bare skin colliding echoed loudly in the quiet kitchen, mixed with the slick, wet sounds of their friction. Jungkook's grip on Jimin's hips was absolute iron; his fingers dug into the soft flesh, leaving marks that held Jimin against the brutal momentum of his thrusts.

Driven crazy by the agonizing fullness, Jimin began to roll his hips, stubbornly fucking himself back against Jungkook, matching the older man's speed. He felt so incredibly full, every nerve ending inside him on pure, agonizing fire.

The kitchen was filled with the chaotic symphony of their undoing: Jimin's high, breathless moans rising in pitch with every deep hit, and Jungkook's deep groans vibrating directly against Jimin's bare back. Jungkook was completely unraveled, his head buried in the nape of Jimin's neck, his breathing a frantic, broken mess.

The friction hit that perfect, devastating spot over and over again until Jimin's vision began to blur all over again. His fingers clawed helplessly at the smooth steel of the counter, his hips jerking wildly as the second wave built too fast, too violently to contain.

"Fuck... oh fuck, shit," Jimin wailed, his head tossing wildly to the side as his voice cracked with pure, unfiltered ecstasy. "I'm gonna cum—Jungkook, Chef—fuck, I'm gonna cum!"

At the frantic warning, Jungkook's grip on Jimin's hips tightened until his knuckles went white. Instead of backing off, he slammed his weight forward, speeding up the pace into a brutal, voracious friction.

"Yeah? Wanna cum?" Jungkook rasped, his breath burning hot against the shell of Jimin's ear. He delivered a heavy, punishing thrust that made Jimin's toes curl. "You wanna shut your pretty mouth when you're asked too? Huh?"

Jimin could only let out a weak, broken moan as the rhythm suddenly shifted. Jungkook slowed down, but the thrusts turned incredibly hard and deep, the heavy momentum forcing Jimin's body further up the smooth stainless-steel counter.

"Look at you now, fuck..." Jungkook growled, a low, breathy laugh mixing with his ragged breathing as he looked down at the younger man's ruined posture. "*Il faut juste te baiser pour que tu écoutes.*"

Driven by a final, desperate spark of defiance, Jimin forced his heavy, sleep-lidded eyes open, tilting his head back just enough to glance up at the older man. "S-shut up," he breathed, his voice dripping with a heady, exhausted arrogance.

The command hit its mark instantly. Jungkook's dark eyes flashed with an intense heat, and without a single word, he completely dropped the slow rhythm, increasing his pace into a frantic, blinding sprint.

Jimin's head fell straight back down against the cold counter, his cheek pressing into the steel as his moans grew louder, higher, and completely visceral. The rapid, wet slap of their skin echoed wildly off the tiles.

By the time the overwhelming heat in his stomach surged past the point of no return, a breathless, delirious smile broke across Jimin's lips. He was so fucking happy—entirely possessed by the blurring, beautiful madness of the man pinning him down.

"Oh... I'm gonna cum—m'gonna cum—fuck, fuck, fuck!" Jimin wailed, his fingers clawing uselessly at the edge of the metal island.

He came completely untouched, the thick, hot friction driving his body into a violent, shaking release that splattered against the steel counter.

Right on his heels, the sudden clenching of Jimin's muscles snapped Jungkook's remaining control. The chef let out a loud, guttural groan, driving all the way in one last time as his own release hit him.

He buried his face deep into the soft skin of Jimin's shoulder, groaning directly into his flesh and biting softly at the damp skin to muffle the sound of his completion as they both dissolved into the quiet, heavy air of the kitchen.

Jungkook stayed buried inside him for a long, heavy moment, his chest heaving violently against Jimin's damp back as he tried to claw back any semblance of his usual composure. Then, with a slow, heavy drag, he finally pulled out.

Jimin let out a broken, low whine at the sudden loss of that blazing warmth, his sensitive walls instantly contracting against the cool air of the room. He couldn't move. He stayed pressed against the stainless-steel counter, his forearms supporting his weight limply.

His eyes remained squeezed tightly shut. He was too scared to open them—too scared to look up, to see the stark lights, and to face the crushing reality of what had just happened. He couldn't look at the Director. He couldn't look at the ruin of his uniform or the mess on the metal island, desperately hiding behind his closed eyelids just to prevent the inevitable transition into something suffocatingly awkward.

Behind him, the heavy, rustling sound of Jungkook gathering his discarded clothes cut through the quiet room, his uneven breaths slowly beginning to even out into a cold, professional silence.

Jimin finally forced his hands down, pushing his weight up off the slick metal with an exhausted, trembling effort. He slowly turned himself around, his torso sticking slightly to the counter before parting with a soft, wet sound. The second his eyes tracked downward, a sharp spike of heat and embarrassment hit his chest—he couldn't miss the mess of smeared cum drying against his own stomach and cutting slick tracks across the smooth edge of the stainless steel.

When Jimin finally forced his gaze upward, his breath caught.

Jungkook was standing right there and in his hand, he held a clean, white kitchen rag.

Without a single word, Jungkook approached him through the silence of the room. He stepped right into Jimin's space, moving carefully, and leaned down to meticulously wipe the wet mess from Jimin's stomach. He worked with a quiet, absorbing focus, his hand moving in slow, rhythmic circles to clean the skin before shifting his attention to the counter, dragging the rough cloth across the metal island until the steel was entirely spotless.

His touch was incredibly light, almost deceptively gentle against Jimin's skin, but the unhinged passion from moments ago had vanished entirely. There was an unmistakable, suffocating rigidity in his posture now—his shoulders were pinned back, his movements precise and distant, and his jaw was clenched so tightly the muscles jumped under his skin.

Jimin just stood there, his lower lip tucked firmly between his teeth, unable to look the older man in the eye. The dazed euphoria of the release was fading fast, and the immense weight of what they had just done settled heavily into Jimin's bones. Right here. In the academy kitchen. With the Director. The recklessness of it made his chest tighten with a sudden, anxious flutter.

Jungkook finished cleaning him without a word, tossing the soiled towel into a laundry bin beneath the prep tables. He reached down to retrieve Jimin's discarded trousers from the tile floor, shaking them out before sinking onto one knee. He guided Jimin's shaking legs into the fabric, pulling them up over his hips with a quiet, tight-lipped efficiency that felt incredibly jarring after the absolute filthiness they had just shared.

When Jungkook stood up, he picked up the white chef's coat. He slipped it over Jimin's bare arms, his movements slow and methodical. He smoothed the heavy canvas over Jimin's shoulders, his hands lingering on the fabric for just a fraction of a second before he began working his way down the double-breasted buttons. He did them up one by one, his gaze fixed entirely on the buttons, actively avoiding Jimin's face.

Jimin stood perfectly still. The adrenaline had completely drained, leaving behind a dull ache in his core and a sudden, intense wave of humiliation.

They had completely torn down the hierarchy, shattered every rule the academy stood for, and crossed a line that could never be uncrossed. But tomorrow, the sun would come up. Tomorrow, the kitchen would be full of students, the prep lists would be tacked to the pass, and Jungkook would be standing at the front of the room in his tailored suit.

How the fuck were they supposed to look at each other over a prep line after this?

When the last button clicked into place, Jungkook finally stepped back, breaking the physical connection entirely. He reached for his own dark boxers and trousers, pulling them on with a rushed, slightly clumsy haste that felt completely uncharacteristic for the usually flawless master chef. He tucked his shirt into his waistband, his fingers tangling slightly in the fabric before he cleared his throat—a sharp, awkward sound in the empty room.

He adjusted his glasses, his eyes finally darting over to Jimin, though they kept flicking down to the floor where the forgotten chef's knife still lay gleaming under the fluorescent lights.

"You should... go back to your station and pack up," Jungkook murmured, his voice low. It was flat, stiff, and heavy with a sudden, tense formality. "The night crew will be here to lock up the building in twenty minutes."

Jimin swallowed the dry lump in his throat, his fingers tightening in the fabric of his newly buttoned coat.

"Right," Jimin whispered, his voice cracking slightly. He kept his eyes locked on his own feet, suddenly hyper-aware of how loud the rustle of his clothes sounded. "Yeah. I'll... I'll go do that, Chef."

Jungkook didn't answer. He just stood there as he watched Jimin turn away, the heavy, suffocating silence stretching between them like a taut wire as they both tried to figure out how to navigate the wreckage of the power dynamic they had just utterly destroyed.

Jimin's fingers were trembling as he shoved his personal timers, tasting spoons, and notebook into his knife roll. The familiar clatter of his tools against the heavy canvas felt strangely loud in the cavernous, echoing kitchen.

Every movement felt clumsy, weighed down by the thick, bizarre tension still hanging in the air. He zipped the bag with a sharp tug, his eyes fixed resolutely on the stainless-steel prep table, deliberately avoiding looking toward the center island.

He reached for his jacket, but before his fingers could brush the fabric, a tall, broad shadow fell over his station. Jimin froze, his breath catching in his throat. Jungkook stepped into his peripheral vision. He had managed to fix his clothes, his dark shirt buttoned back up to the collar—though the faint, chaotic smear of Jimin's blood was still visible on the fabric, a stark reminder of what had just happened. He had his hands buried deep in his trouser pockets, his shoulders squared, but the cold, distant armor from moments ago had softened.

"Jimin," Jungkook said softly.

Jimin slowly turned his head, his heart immediately executing a frantic, erratic flip against his ribs. Jungkook was looking down at him, his dark eyes intense and steady.

"My last class tomorrow finishes at four," Jungkook murmured so low, the words meant only for the small space between them. "So, I want you to come to my office thirty minutes earlier. Make sure you aren't late."

Jimin blinked, a sudden wave of confusion washing over him. He stared at the Director, his chest tightening. For a fleeting, disappointing second, he thought Jungkook was trying to backtrack—putting the rigid boundaries back up, issuing standard, clinical orders as if they were simply returning back to normal. He felt a defensive retort bubbling up in his throat, ready to fight the sudden rejection.

Jimin opened his mouth to question him, but as he looked up, the words died instantly in his throat. He caught the sharp, wicked smirk toying at the corners of Jungkook's lips—a heavy, knowing expression that promised exactly what was going to happen behind the closed doors of that office.

Jimin's breath hitched completely, a brilliant, burning flush exploding across his cheeks and traveling all the way down his neck. His heart fluttered violently, a sweet, dizzying warmth rushing straight to his core at the quiet command.

Before Jimin could even stammer out a response, Jungkook leaned down.

The kiss wasn't rough or desperate like before; it was slow, deeply grounding, and incredibly sweet. Jungkook's mouth moved against his with a soft, lingering pressure that completely melted the residual awkwardness away, leaving Jimin breathless and tingling down to his fingertips. When Jungkook finally pulled back, his thumb gave a gentle, reassuring swipe across Jimin's flushed cheek.

"Go home and get some rest," Jungkook whispered, the smirk returning to his lips as his hand dropped back into his pocket. "I'll see you tomorrow."

Chapter 7



When Jimin opened his eyes that morning, he was met with a very incredible feeling of heavy, dazed exhaustion tangled up in something hot and electric. He rolled over, burying his face into his pillow, and let out a low groan into the fabric. He shifted, his side aching a little under the sheets. Frowning, he brought his hand down and rubbed at it, the deep ache leaving him confused for a brief, quiet moment... until it didn't.

He gasped, his sleep-lidded eyes snapping wider open as he peeked down under the blanket.

The memory slammed back into him like air coming into his body after drowning.

He and Jungkook. He and his teacher. He and the most renowned chef in all of France had sex. Jimin clenched his side, his fingers pressing right against the faint, reddened print of where Jungkook had held him to the cold stainless steel.

His chest tightened so fast he could barely draw breath as the full weight of the nightmare crashed over his head. It was a career-ending cliché. He had slept with the man who held his entire grade, his future recommendations, and his residency in his hands.

And the worst part? The most unforgivable, ruinous part?

He had liked it. Fuck, he had loved it.

Even now, with his heart executing a frantic, guilty rhythm against his ribs, a sudden, devastating spike of heat shot straight to his core at the memory of how effortlessly Jungkook had hoisted him up, how primal and desperate the man had gotten just from the taste of him. He had craved him. He had begged for it. He was entirely, beautifully obsessed with the madness that should have had him packing his bags and transferring schools by noon.

"Jimin? Are you alive under there? We're gonna be late."

Taehyung's voice shattered the silence of the room, making Jimin bolt upright so fast his vision swam.

Taehyung was already half-dressed, casually buttoning his own white chef's coat. He was humming something under his breath, entirely oblivious to Jimin's frantic thoughts.

Jimin couldn't look at him. He literally could not make eye contact. Taehyung was the person who had listened to him vent for months about how much he hated the Director's cold, biting metrics. If Taehyung looked closely enough, would he see the guilt written across his face? Would he notice the tiny, red spots just under Jimin's jawline where Jungkook had kissed?

"Yeah," Jimin croaked, his voice sounding a little too high. He scrambled out of bed, keeping his back turned as he snagged his clean uniform from the closet. "Yeah, I'm up. Just... slept weird."

"You look a little flushed," Taehyung remarked, leaning over to peer at him as Jimin frantically pulled his undershirt over his head. "Are you actually getting sick? Please don't skip again today, if you miss another demonstration, Chef's going to actually flay you alive."

He already did, Jimin thought, his jaw clenching as he began the agonizing process of doing up his double-breasted coat. Every single button felt like a physical reminder of the night before.

Taehyung paused his humming, tossing his knife kit onto his desk before squinting at Jimin thoughtfully. "Wait... I fell asleep before you got back. How did yesterday go? Did you get caught up with—"

Jimin coughed loudly, a harsh sound that cut Taehyung off entirely. He fumbled blindly with his collar, his fingers working in a wild panic to hide the flush creeping up his neck.

"Oh yeah..." Jimin stammered, his voice pitching a fraction higher as he waved a hand dismissively. "Pshhh, that was nothing! Finished all the notes and everything. Yep. All good. Now let's hurry, don't wanna be late!"

Before Taehyung could even blink, Jimin grabbed his toiletry bag and practically ran into the bathroom, slamming the door shut and clicking the lock into place.

He pressed his back against the cool surface, sliding down until his knees hit his chest. Burying his face in his hands, he breathed heavily, scolding himself for being so painfully obvious. It was a massive failure of basic instincts. He should have never kissed his teacher. It breached every rule, boundary, and professional contract binding him to this academy.

But Jungkook had kissed him back.

The spiral in his head slowed, caught in the heavy gravity of that truth. Jungkook hadn't pulled away. Jungkook had pinned him to that counter and ruined his rationality, and the memory still vibrated in the dark corners of Jimin's mind.

Slowly, the panic melted into a thick heat that pooled low in his gut. A swarm of golden electricity flooded his veins, so sweet and intoxicating it made his skin tingle. Before he could stop it, a helpless, breathless smile curved his lips.

It was a feeling of triumph tangled up in surrender. For months, Jimin had felt so small under Jungkook's biting gaze, cut to pieces by cold corrections and an untouchable ego. But last night, he had discovered the terrifying, beautiful secret hiding beneath the Director's rigid demeanor.

He was entirely spellbound. The power of knowing he could ruin Jungkook's perfect focus just by breathing the same air was a rush more addictive than any high-pressure service line. He felt ruined, yes, but he also felt intensely alive.

And worst of all, he still craved him.

Even with his academic career dangling by a thread, the hunger had only sharpened into something dangerous and all-consuming. He still wanted to stand at his station and prove he could match every brutal command, running the kitchen with the same ruthless precision the Director demanded.

It wasn't just about the cooking anymore. Jimin wasn't a passive victim of the Director's rage; he was an active player in whatever was happening between them. They were locked in a game of

mutual destruction, and Jimin had no intention of backing down first.

"Jimin? Seriously, the clock is ticking!" Taehyung's knock jolted him out of the haze.

Jimin blinked, the heat rushing back into his cheeks. He stood up, splashing cold water onto his face to shock his system before unlocking the door and bypassing a still-suspicious Taehyung.



By the time they left the dorm, the walk to the academy felt like a march to a firing squad, but the terror was completely laced with an underlying, electric anticipation.

When they finally pushed through the heavy glass doors of the culinary wing later that morning, the main demonstration kitchen was already humming with the quiet, tense energy of students setting up their stations. Knives were unrolled, cutting boards were sanitized, and the clock on the wall ticking mercilessly.

And there, standing at the pass in the front of the room, was Director Jeon.

Jungkook looked pristine as always, his silver glasses catching the harsh glare of the lights. There was no trace of the man from last night. He was locked completely back into place.

Jimin kept his head down, navigating to his usual station near the middle row. He unrolled his leather kit with shaking fingers, the metallic clatter of his tools sounding deafeningly loud to his own ears.

"Good morning, class," Jungkook's voice boomed through the kitchen, smooth, and entirely rigorous.

Jimin instinctively tilted his chin up, his gaze drawn to the front of the room like a magnet.

And as Jungkook scanned the rows of students, his dark, unblinking eyes swept across the room and locked dead onto Jimin.

He didn't react. But his gaze lingered for a fraction of an agonizing second too long, tracking slowly from Jimin's eyes down to the tiny, faint scratch under his jawline, before sliding back up. Slowly, Jungkook reached up with his left hand, adjusting the frame of his glasses by the bridge.

"Today, we will continue with a flawless clear consommé," Jungkook announced, his smooth, commanding voice cutting cleanly through the quiet hum of the room. "The baseline of foundational French cuisine. It requires absolute temperature control, precise skimming, and an uncompromising execution of the clarification raft. One stray boil, it's ruined. It is a test of patience and focus."

Jimin, however, found himself barely listening.

The words floated over his head, entirely out of reach, drowned out by the loud, rhythmic thud of his own pulse. Instead of tracking the technical requirements of the lesson, his eyes were helplessly locked onto the man at the front of the room. He watched the heavy musculature of Jungkook's forearms flex and shift beneath the rolled-up sleeves of his dark shirt. His gaze traced the intricate, dark patterns of the tattoos winding up Jungkook's skin, the exact ink Jimin had blindly, desperately clawed at with his own two hands just hours ago.

His fingertips pricked with the ghost of that memory, remembering the stark contrast of Jungkook's burning skin against the cold metal of the island. He remembered the deceptively gentle softness of Jungkook's hands as he buttoned Jimin's coat, the intense, low vibration of his voice, the suffocating proximity that had left him completely undone.

A sharp, loud clap echoed through the space, shattering the illusion.

"Thirty minutes for mise en place," Jungkook barked, his sharp eyes scanning the room as he dropped his hands back into his pockets. "Starting now."

Jimin blinked, his vision clearing as he looked around the room, completely caught off guard. The sudden eruption of movement around him was jarring. Students were already lunging for ice, cracking egg whites, and rapidly hacking through mirepoix.

Shit.

What were they doing?

What was he doing?

Panic spiked cold in his chest. He tried to frantically replay the lesson in his head, searching for the exact measurements, the vegetable ratios, anything—but all that came to mind was the memory of Jungkook's lips, the warmth of his hands all over his body, and the raw look in his dark eyes. His mind was an absolute blank.

From across the counter, Taehyung paused, his knife suspended mid-air as his eyebrows pulled together in deep question. He stared at Jimin's untouched cutting board, then at Jimin's wide, flushed face.

Jimin looked around frantically, trying to catch a glimpse of what the other students were pulling from the walk-in, but before he could even register the movement across the aisle, a very familiar scent filled his nose.

"Jimin," Jungkook said, stepping directly up to the frozen boy's station.

Jimin paused, his entire body locking up as his eyes completely failed to meet Jungkook's. After what had happened yesterday. After the secret intimacy of trailing his fingers over the man's bare chest and screaming into his mouth you'd think Jimin would be a little bolder. A little less scared. But no. Every single interaction with the chef was terrifying, especially when said man was standing here in flawless suit, pretending as though absolutely nothing had happened.

Jungkook leaned down slightly, resting his hands flat against the edge of Jimin's counter. The proximity alone made the air in Jimin's lungs evaporate.

"Care to explain why your station is completely bare?" Jungkook asked, his voice a low, commanding tone that carried easily across the row. "The clock is running, and you haven't even sanitized your board. What are you supposed to be doing right now?"

Jimin's throat completely dried out. "Um... c-chef... I—"

Out of pure, conditioned instinct, Jimin's shoulders braced. He subtly tilted his head down, waiting for the inevitable boom of Jungkook's temper. He waited for the sharp, biting criticism, the name-calling, or the public humiliation that usually followed a slip-up this massive.

The rest of the classroom seemed to hold its collective breath, too. From across the room, Eric leaned against his counter, his lips curving into a smug, expectant smirk as he waited for the scene to unfold.

But the explosion never came.

"I was notified that you were sick yesterday," Jungkook stated smoothly, his tone remarkably level, almost scarily so. "So, considering that you are still recovering your footing, I will let this slide. Once."

Jimin looked up at the man, completely stunned.

Jungkook's gaze was still incredibly sharp, but beneath it, there was something else. A tiny, microscopic shift in his pupils, a heavy, simmering heat meant just for Jimin to see.

It was a look that promised absolute, devastating ownership. It served as a silent reminder that Jimin's body was still vibrating from the exact reason he had been "*sick*."

"Go to the cold storage," Jungkook commanded, his finger tapping once against the metal counter to snap Jimin out of his daze. "Bring back two pounds of lean, ground beef. Five egg whites. A standard mirepoix—carrots, onions, celery. Do not use the pre-cut stock vegetables; I want your own knife work. You have twenty-five minutes remaining. Move."

"Yes, Chef," Jimin breathed, his voice a small, frantic whisper.

Jungkook gave him one last, lingering look before turning on his heel, as he moved down the line to critique another student. The suffocating tension in the air snapped, and from across the room,

Eric's smug smirk completely vanished, replaced by a look of confusion at the Director's unprecedented leniency.

Jimin didn't waste another second. He grabbed a metal prep bowl and practically flew toward the walk-in fridge, his heart doing a dizzying flip against his ribs.

Part of Jimin felt incredibly warm as he worked, the heat spreading from his chest down to his fingertips. He could feel Jungkook's eyes on him for most of the class. It didn't matter whether the man was actively pacing the rows of stations or standing perfectly still at the pass; Jimin could feel the heavy gaze tracking his every move.

Every time Jimin lifted his knife to slice through the celery, every time he carefully skimmed the surface of his simmering stock, he could feel the silent reminder in Jungkook's unblinking eyes. It was an unspoken countdown to 4 PM.

He could sense the anticipation humming in his own heart, a restlessness that made it hard to breathe, but he could also sense it in Jungkook's. The rigid perfection of the Director's posture seemed just a fraction too tight today. The way Jungkook's jaw remained clenched, the way his fingers occasionally flexed inside his trouser pockets whenever he paused near Jimin's station. It was all a beautifully masked craving.

Jimin wasn't just locked into the cooking; he was locked into the intoxicating rhythm of their shared secret. He kept his station spotless, his cuts flawless, and his movements entirely controlled, throwing himself into the work to burn off the restless energy threatening to consume him.

He wanted Jungkook to look at his station and find absolutely nothing to criticize. He wanted to force acknowledgment his skill before they stepped into a space where the titles of teacher and student no longer applied.

By the time the timers throughout the room began to chime, signaling the end of the block, the air in the kitchen felt suffocatingly thick.

Students began the frantic process of plating their final consommés for grading, lining up at the pass with their white bowls. Jimin took his place in the line, his heart beating heavy as he drew closer to the front.

Jungkook sat at the evaluation table, a silver spoon in hand, his face a mask of strict, professional indifference. He tasted each student's dish, offering sharp, monosyllabic critiques.

"too cloudy."

"under-salted,"

"sloppy presentation."

"It's okay."

"Good."

When Jimin finally stepped up, carefully setting his consommé down on the table, the silence between them was deafening.

Jungkook dipped his silver spoon into the liquid, lifted it, and inspected the clarity against the harsh, sterile lights. He took a sip.

The silence stretched into something suffocating, and stagnant. Jimin's breath caught in his throat, his hands trembling slightly behind his back as he waited.

Then, Jungkook's dark eyes darted up. He locked his gaze dead onto Jimin's face with an unblinking intensity that sent a sudden, devastating spike of heat straight to Jimin's core.

"Parfait," Jungkook murmured.

His voice was low, the words rolling off his tongue with a thick, certainty that made the hairs on the back of Jimin's neck stand. On the surface, the comment was meant strictly for the evaluation, but the dark, dilated look in Jungkook's eyes carried a heavy, filthy dual meaning.

Jimin swallowed hard, the air in his lungs turning to pure ice as he tried to maintain his posture.

"Thank you, Chef," Jimin breathed, his voice coming out much lower and more breathless than he had intended.

Jungkook didn't break the eye contact. He slowly lowered the silver spoon back onto the saucer, the tiny, metallic clink sounding much louder in the quiet space between them. For a fraction of a second, Jungkook's jaw clenched so tightly a muscle jumped in his cheek, his fingers flexing against the table as if he were fighting the sudden, violent urge.

"Clean your stations," Jungkook commanded softly, his tone dropping into that familiar, register that left absolutely no room for argument. "And do not keep me waiting."



Jimin was sure he went through all of the human emotion on his walk to Jungkook's office.

But by the time he reached the administrative wing, the adrenaline shattered, replaced by a restless, unsteady spike of denial that flooded straight to his core.

The hallway was silent, the cold air conditioning humming softly against the white walls. With every step he took toward the heavy, dark mahogany door at the very end of the corridor, his heart dropped a little lower. He was terrified. He was completely diffident. And yet, beneath the anxiety, he was so thoroughly possessed by the longing that his mouth went completely dry.

He stood outside the door marked Director Jeon , his hand hovering over the cold brass handle.
3:50 PM.

Jimin took one long, shaky breath, knocking softly before turning the knob and pushing the door open.

The atmosphere inside the private office was an instant, stifling contrast to the sterile, bright lights of the kitchen. The room was cast in deep, shadowed tones. Heavy wood paneling, leather chairs, and the rich, expensive scent of sandalwood and faint mint that immediately flooded Jimin's senses. The blinds were drawn tightly across the large windows, filtering the afternoon sun into a dim, amber glow.

Behind a massive desk in the center of the room, Jungkook was working.

He had already discarded his suit jacket, leaving him in just his dark dress shirt, the top two buttons undone to reveal the sharp, heavy contours of his collarbone. He didn't look up when the door clicked open. His glasses were perched firmly on the bridge of his nose, his focus entirely dedicated to the stack of papers before him. The only sound in the room was the rhythmic scratch of his pen dragging across the paper.

Jimin stepped inside, his shoes sinking slightly into the heavy rug. He stood perfectly frozen just past the threshold, his hands gripping the handle so tightly his knuckles turned white. The silence between them stretched, punctuated only by the steady, unbothered scratching of the pen.

Jungkook still didn't lift his head, his jaw clenched tightly as he finished a final note on the document.

"Close the door, Jimin," Jungkook murmured. He flipped the page over. "And lock it."

Jimin swallowed the dry lump in his throat and turned back to the mahogany paneling. His fingers were shaking so violently it took him two attempts to catch the small brass deadbolt, but he finally turned it. The heavy click echoed through the room.

He turned around, his heart hammering as he took a single, careful step forward. He felt incredibly small in the expansive, shadowed office, his heavy chef's coat suddenly feeling way too tight.

"I... C-chef... can I say something?"

Jungkook looked up.

Slowly, his unblinking dark eyes tracked up from the paperwork spread across his leather blotter. He set his pen down with a quiet, deliberate click that seemed to echo in the sterile silence of the office.

"When have you ever asked my permission to speak?"

The dry, mocking edge in the Director's tone hit its mark instantly. Jimin felt a scorching flush explode across his cheeks, traveling all the way down his neck. He knew he looked pathetic, standing there with his posture tightly wound.

Jungkook's gaze didn't soften. He leaned back slightly in his chair, his dark sleeves rolled up to reveal the dense black ink patterning his forearms.

"Sit," Jungkook commanded softly.

Jimin shuffled forward, his weak, trembling legs barely supporting his weight as he navigated the remaining distance toward the desk. He sank into the deep, black leather chair opposite the Director, his fingers tightly gripping the armrests just to ground his shaking hands.

Jungkook didn't say another word right away. He simply tracked Jimin's every movement, his dilated irises nearly swallowing the brown entirely behind his silver-rimmed lenses. The stifling silence returned with the unspoken weight of their last night, leaving Jimin completely exposed under that clinical scrutiny.

Jimin's thumbs dug hard into the soft leather. He had spent the last four hours rehearsing this exact confrontation back in his dorm, but now that he was sitting under the suffocating focus of Jungkook's undivided attention, the words felt entirely tangled on his tongue.

"I..." Jimin started, his voice cracking slightly before he forced himself to clear his throat.

He refused to back down or to be made a laughingstock, not when just twenty-four hours prior Jungkook had been completely worshiping his body. The memory of it shot a sudden, defiant spike of heat straight to his core, burning away the last of his hesitation. He looked right at the man from across the desk, his jaw clenching as he tilted his chin up.

"Yesterday... what I did was not okay," Jimin stated, his voice steady, regaining that familiar, sharp bite that usually defined him over a busy prep line. "It was more than not okay. It probably violated six different codes of conduct for this academy. I crossed a line. A massive one."

The silence that followed was thick enough to choke the remaining air right out of the room. When Jungkook finally spoke, his dark eyes were burning with a dangerous, heavy intensity that made Jimin's chest tighten.

"Codes of conduct," Jungkook repeated, the words rolling off his tongue in a way that sounded almost facetious. He slowly reached up with his left hand, sliding his glasses off the bridge of his nose and setting them carelessly onto the mahogany wood. "As the Director of this academy, I am the code of conduct, Jimin. I write the rules. I set the regulations. And I decide what happens."

Jimin's thumbs dug harder into the leather. He refused to look away. He refused to let the man see how thoroughly his composure was crumbling.

"Okay, so," Jimin challenged, his voice tight but carrying a sharp, breathless edge of bravado. "What's gonna happen?"

Jungkook didn't answer right away. He just stared at him. The tension between them stretched, turning agonizing before Jungkook finally spoke.

"I told you..... what happens," Jungkook murmured, his voice dropping into a low, commanding register that sent a sudden, devastating spike of heat straight to Jimin's core, "is exactly what I decide."

Jimin let out a low, shaky breath, his chest tightening as Jungkook tilted his head up slightly.

"Come here," Jungkook commanded softly.

Jimin stood, blindly following the command before his brain could even formulate a proper defensive comeback. Every instinct he possessed told him to turn the deadbolt and run out into the corridor, but his body was entirely consumed by the gravity of the man watching him.

Jungkook pointed to the space right beside his chair.

Not breaking eye contact for even a fraction of a second, Jimin rounded the desk. His heart hammered wildly as he stepped deep into Jungkook's personal space, the rich, signature scent of the Chef completely overwhelming his senses.

"Sit," Jungkook whispered, tapping his own thigh.

Jimin's eyelids fluttered, a burning red exploding across his cheeks as he hesitantly lowered himself down onto Jungkook's lap. The physical contact was purely electric. Jungkook's skin alone radiated a dense warmth that immediately made Jimin's lower stomach do a violent, reeling flip. He felt incredibly small, half-sitting against the Director's broad frame, his own hands gripping the edge of the desk just to stay upright.

Jungkook didn't instantly wrap his arms around him. Instead, maintaining that agonizing, rigid precision, he reached across and pulled the paperwork he had just been working on closer to them. He picked up the pen and slid it smoothly into Jimin's shaking fingers, his warm hand briefly brushing against Jimin's knuckles.

"What's going to happen now is you are going to sign some things for the upcoming gala," Jungkook murmured, his hot breath scalding against Jimin's neck. "The inventory lists for the prep needs your authorization before they go to the bursar."

Jimin cleared his throat, desperately trying to remain unbothered, though his vision blurred slightly around the edges from the suffocating proximity of the man. He stared down at the white document, his fingers tightening around the pen as he tried to force his trembling hand to find a rhythm. He lowered his eyes, blindly flipping through the pages of the contract, pretending to read the blocky paragraphs of text before signing them. He tried to focus on the words, on the inventory lists, on anything that could ground him, but the text instantly blurred into a useless smudge of black ink.

Jungkook's warm hands settled firmly onto Jimin's hips.

Jimin's breath hitched sharply, his fingers freezing on the edge of the paper as those heavy palms began to slowly, deliberately slide down to his thighs. The warmth of the contact bled right through

the cotton of his trousers, mapping the heat of his skin with a quiet, adamant friction that sent a violent rush straight to his core.

Suddenly, Jimin jumped, a soft gasp slipping from his lips as he felt the undeniable presence of Jungkook's lips grazing the sensitive skin at the back of his neck.

The touch was a tease. The faint, rough stubble of his jaw scraped light against his collar before Jungkook leaned in deeper, pressing a slow, deceptively gentle kiss directly into the center of his skin.

Jimin's eyes squeezed tightly shut, his head dropping back against Jungkook's shoulder as the pen slipped in his grip for a fraction of a second, the sharp metal nib scratching a messy, trembling black line straight across the crisp white document.

"You're not reading, Jimin," Jungkook murmured against his flesh, the vibration of his voice sending a maddening wave of electricity straight down Jimin's spine. His hands tightened on Jimin's thighs, his fingers digging in just enough, effortlessly pulling Jimin's hips back until there wasn't a single inch of remaining air between them.

"I-I am," Jimin lied breathlessly, his knuckles turning white as he blindly clutched at the edge of the desk to keep his balance on the man's lap.

"Tu es un si mauvais menteur," Jungkook whispered, his teeth lightly catching the soft skin just below Jimin's ear, making Jimin's toes curl inside his shoes. He slowly slid one hand up from Jimin's thigh, his long fingers trailing a line of burning heat up his torso until they reached the bottom button of his chef's coat.

"Now," Jungkook rumbled, his thumb popping the first fastening free with a quiet, agonizing snap. "Tell me what you want," Jungkook murmured against his skin, the words coming out strained, almost broken, as if all of his restraints were snapping one by one. His forehead dropped to rest against Jimin's shoulder, his breath hitching as his hands trembled slightly against Jimin's waist.

Hearing the most formidable man in the academy practically begging to surrender to him stripped away the last of Jimin's defenses.



The dim amber glow of the office lamp spilled across the mahogany desk as Jungkook gently pressed Jimin forward, his hands warm and steady on his shoulders.

Jimin's breath hitched as he bent over the desk, his palms flat against the cool wood. He felt Jungkook's fingers brush through his hair, tucking a stray strand behind his ear, before trailing down to his jaw.

Jimin bit down hard on the heavy fabric of his chef's coat, which had been messily rolled up and bunched under his chin. His fingers clawed at the desk, as his body trembling with anticipation. He couldn't see Jungkook's face, but he could feel his presence. The heat radiating from his body, the sound of his breathing, the rustle of his shirt as he freed his aching cock.

Jungkook's hands moved down Jimin's sides, unbuttoning his trousers slowly, pushing them down over his hips with deliberate tenderness. He knelt slightly, pressing kisses to the small of Jimin's back, taking his time. When he finally stood, he pressed his chest against Jimin's back.

"Tell me if it's too much," he whispered against Jimin's ear, his voice honeyed with care. "If you get too loud, I'll stop."

"C-chef, please..." Jimin whimpered, the fabric slipping from his teeth as he pleaded into the empty room. He reached around blindly, and Jungkook took his hand, lacing their fingers together tightly against the desk.

Then he guided himself to Jimin's entrance. He pushed in slowly inch by inch, letting Jimin feel every millimeter of the stretch. His free hand rubbed soothing circles into Jimin's hip as he bottomed out, then paused, letting Jimin adjust.

Jimin's muffled sigh trembled through the fabric, his body melting into the warmth of Jungkook's embrace.

When Jungkook began to move, it was with deep, deliberate strokes. Each thrust was a slow, rolling wave, timed perfectly to the rhythm of his whispered praises.

"Fuck, you feel incredible," Jungkook groaned, his voice rough with pleasure but gentle in its delivery.

Jungkook pulled back slowly, the head of his cock grazing the sensitive walls of Jimin's entrance, teasing him until Jimin let out a soft, broken whimper. The sound was small, a plea for the fullness to return. Jungkook leaned down, his lips brushing against the shell of Jimin's ear, his voice a low whisper.

"You're so tight for me," Jungkook rasped, his tone dripping with a sweetness that contrasted the power of his body. "Does that feel good? Tell me how much you want it."

Jimin couldn't find the words, only managing a clumsy nod at first. He arched his back instinctively, his hips tilting upward. He didn't want it; he craved it, his body humming with a tension that only Jungkook could break.

"So much," Jimin sobbed out breathlessly, his head tossing back against Jungkook's shoulder. "I want it so much, Chef..."

Responding to the desperate confession, Jungkook drove back in with a sudden, wet thud. The force of the impact sent a jolt of electricity straight to Jimin's core, forcing a sharp, strangled gasp from his lips. Jungkook didn't stop there. He began to move with a relentless, rhythmic precision, each thrust bottoming out deep inside, hitting Jimin's prostate with a blunt force that made the world blur into a haze of gold and heat.

Jimin's own cock was trapped beneath him, rubbing frantically against the mahogany. The friction was an agonizing torture, a slow-burn pleasure that built with every slam of Jungkook's hips. He tried to shift, his thighs shaking, his breath coming in ragged, shallow hitches. He felt completely undone, his mind slipping away as he focused entirely on the sensation of being filled and stretched by the man he secretly adored.

Noticing the desperate way Jimin was rubbing against the desk, Jungkook shifted his grip. He released Jimin's wrist, but only to slide his hand beneath Jimin's belly. His fingers wrapped around Jimin's leaking length, his grip firm yet careful. He began to stroke Jimin in perfect synchronization with the deep, punishing thrusts.

"Be quiet, Jimin," Jungkook hissed directly against the shell of his ear. His fingers dug deeper into Jimin's hips, leaving bruising, authoritative prints on the skin. "Unless you want the staff down the hall to hear exactly what I'm doing to you."

Jimin let out a choked, desperate whimper into the fabric, his eyes squeezing closed as Jungkook pulled back to the very limit before driving right back in.

The dual stimulation was overwhelming. Jimin felt his muscles clamping down violently, milking Jungkook with every frantic pulse. He was caught in a storm of pleasure, his chest heaving against the desk, his vision sparking. He didn't have to ask for more; Jungkook knew exactly how to push him over the edge.

Jungkook increased the pace, the wet, slapping sound of their bodies echoing through the silent office. He tilted Jimin's hips higher, angling himself to drive even deeper, ensuring every inch of his length was buried within. He could feel Jimin's orgasm building, the way his walls began to spasm in rhythmic waves.

The control Jimin had fought so hard to maintain shattered completely. He didn't care about the boundaries, the rules, or the stifling title of Chef anymore. He just needed the man holding him.

"Jungkook—Jungkook, please, Jungkook," Jimin rambled breathlessly, his voice breaking as he sobbed the name against the dark wood, chanting it like a desperate prayer over and over.

"Jungkook, I'm close—I'm gonna—"

Jungkook didn't seem to mind the loss of protocol at all. Hearing his own name torn from Jimin's lips only broke his own composure. His chest heaved as his breath came out quicker, his usually perfect rhythm stuttering as his hips faltered under the sheer intensity of the friction.

With one final, deep, authoritative thrust, Jungkook hit the sweet spot with absolute precision. Jimin's body stiffened, a loud, broken moan ripping from his throat as he came. His release splattered across the polished wood in thick, white bursts, his entire frame shuddering under the intensity of the peak.

The sight of Jimin completely breaking under him shattered the last of Jungkook's restraint. Hearing his name spilled so messily across the desk chased away every lingering ounce of his discipline.

"Fuck, Jimin—" Jungkook choked out, his voice a raw, unraveled groan.

He locked their bodies together, his fingers digging into the soft flesh of Jimin's hips as he pumped his hot cum deep into Jimin, filling him to the brim. He began to shower Jimin's shoulder blades with soft, lingering kisses, his lips grazing the skin with an almost reverent sweetness.

Jimin hummed weakly, a soft, vibrating sound of pure contentment that echoed against the dark wood as his face remained pressed flat against his forearms. He lay there perfectly still, his heart hammering a slow, heavy rhythm against his ribs, waiting for the heavy hammer to drop.

He fully expected the cold, stifling awkwardness of yesterday to come rushing back into the room. He braced himself for the distance, the sharp orders, and the immediate return of Director Jeon.

But it never did.

Instead, the heavy warmth behind him shifted. Jungkook's hands wrapped securely around his waist, effortlessly lifting his limp body off the desk. Before Jimin could even find his footing on the rug, Jungkook spun him around in one smooth, sweeping motion, catching him securely against his chest.

Jungkook cupped Jimin's flushed face in his hands and pulled him upward into a deep kiss that instantly left them both breathless.

Jimin went entirely slack in the man's arms, his fingers blindly tangling into the fabric of Jungkook's half-unbuttoned shirt for leverage as his knees gave out. Jungkook handled his weight effortlessly, holding him close, their mouths moving together in a slow, sweet, and entirely consuming rhythm. The sharp edges of the classroom, and the administrative rules completely melted away, leaving them completely lost in each other in the quiet glow of the office.



A week later, Jimin had learned two distinct things about Director Jeon Jungkook.

The first was that the man was terrifyingly, brutally good at hiding whatever the hell it was they had going on. In the light of the main kitchens, under the watchful eyes of the faculty and the other students, Jungkook was an unreadable monolith. He would look directly through Jimin during inspection, critique his knife work with a cold, clinical indifference, and still demand absolute perfection without a single flicker of recognition in his dark eyes. It was so flawless it was almost delirious.

But the second thing— *which Jimin guessed was just an extension of the first* —was that the very second they were entirely alone, Jungkook became a completely different person.

It wasn't that they had fallen into some soft, fairytale romance. No. It was quite the opposite, really. Their arrangement was unstable, fueled by heat and a shared, restless friction that threatened to burn the kitchen down around them.

Sometimes, during late-night practical sessions while practicing complex centerpieces for the upcoming gala, the pressure would push them both to the brink. Jungkook would stand over Jimin's shoulder, looking down his nose before saying something so stupidly arrogant, so completely impersonal and condescending, that Jimin's temper would instantly flare. Exhausted and spent, Jimin would combat him right back, snapping insults right back toward the man.

They would stand chest-to-chest, arguing fiercely, getting completely worked up until their breathing was ragged and their eyes were blazing—just for Jungkook to violently loop a hand around the back of Jimin's neck, drag him forward, and kiss him breathless until neither of them could remember what they were fighting about.

And other times? Other times there were no words at all.

Jungkook would just do what he did best. He would lock the door, trap Jimin against the nearest available surface, and fuck the absolute shit out of him until Jimin was entirely defenseless and reminded of who still governed him even when the uniform came off.

But somewhere in between, the dynamic would quietly shift. Jungkook would lean down and kiss him deep, sweet, and desperate and Jimin would find himself parting his lips to moan his name.

Soon, it came like second nature to say Jungkook. The formal titles and rigid protocols of the academy completely dissolved the moment they were behind closed doors. It happened so often, so easily, that it began to bleed into Jimin's everyday reality.

Sometimes, Jimin almost said it during class, the name slipping toward the tip of his tongue with how much it filled his thoughts while he stood at his station under the Director's cold, watchful eye.

And sometimes, like tonight, Jimin would see a side of Jungkook he rarely ever did. A softer, quieter side.

It came to be through Jimin's endless, exhausted rambling about New York. He was wiping down the edge of his prep station, his voice echoing softly in the otherwise empty, dark kitchen as he talked about how he couldn't wait to see his best friend again, detailing his plans and the restaurants he wanted to try. Caught up in the sudden wave of homesickness, Jimin had stopped his rag, looking across the space to where Jungkook stood leaning against the pass, and asked, "Do you ever go home, J-Jungkook?"

The clock on the tiled wall quietly clicked, the hands hitting ten minutes before midnight.

Jungkook was silent for a long moment, his posture still maintaining a little of that rigid, unyielding discipline that defined him. He didn't look up immediately, his fingers idly tracing the rim of a clean copper saucier.

"Rarely," Jungkook finally murmured, his voice low and lacking its usual sharp, commanding edge. "The kitchens there... they demand a specific kind of attention. You leave it behind, or it consumes you entirely. There is very little left to return to once you choose this path."

Jimin stayed completely still, listening intently to the rare cadence of vulnerability in the older man's tone. He opened his mouth, wanting to say more, to ask the millions of questions suddenly crowding his throat. What was Jungkook's mom like? His dad? Did they call him on weekends, or did they only speak once every month? Year? Did Jungkook retire them early with his massive director's salary, leaving them to live in some expansive, sun-drenched villa in the French countryside somewhere?

He wanted to peel back every single layer of the man standing before him.

"You should go one day," Jimin said instead, softening his tone as he gently dropped the damp sanitizing rag onto the stainless steel. "Back home... they'd be happy to see you."

Jungkook didn't respond right away. He simply stood there, his frame relaxed against the pass, watching Jimin through the dim, filtered shadows of the kitchen. A small, quiet look of fondness settled into the sharp lines of his face. An expression so faint and unguarded it completely transformed him.

Instead of dwelling on the past, Jungkook let out a slow, shallow breath, his dark eyes tracking the neat stack of prep bowls Jimin had just finished organizing.

"The gala is at the end of next week," Jungkook murmured, shifting his weight slightly. "I must say, I am very proud of you... you have exceeded all of my expectations."

Jimin's cheeks instantly flushed at the praise, though he stubbornly bit the inside of his lip, trying to force his face to remain completely unbothered.

"I am excited to see what you will cook for us," Jungkook continued smoothly, his voice dropping into a slightly lower register. "But... maybe do not let it include hot sauce."

Jimin snapped his head up at that, his wide, blown-out eyes locking onto the older man in disbelief before he caught the faint, undeniable tilt at the corner of Jungkook's mouth.

A small, breathless laugh slipped from Jimin's lips, his eyes crinkling at the edges.

"Shut up," Jimin mumbled under his breath, the easy comeback slipping out entirely by habit.

But the words had barely left his mouth before he froze. He saw Jungkook's expression instantly harden, the familiar, rigid look of the Director locking back over his features in a split second, his jaw clenching tightly under the harsh lights.

"I'm sorry," Jimin quickly corrected, his voice dropping into an anxious, breathless whisper. He gripped the edge of his prep table, kicking himself internally.

But instead of the sharp reprimand Jimin was bracing for, Jungkook's expression slowly softened.

The harsh, rigid lines of his jaw relaxed, and the intense hardness in his dark eyes melted back into that deep, quiet pool of fondness. He didn't move from his position leaning against the pass, his arms crossed over his chest as he simply continued watching Jimin, his gaze unblinking and impossibly heavy.

Jimin noticed his cheeks growing incredibly warm, the heat radiating all the way to the tips of his ears under that undivided attention. The silence was stretching again, but it wasn't the suffocating, dangerous kind from the administrative office. It was something else entirely thoughtful, entirely too intimate.

Jimin's fingers twitched against the metal, a sudden, sharp ache flaring up in his knuckles. Without realizing it, he began cracking his fingers one by one, a nervous habit that had turned into a painful necessity over the last few days from the relentless, punishing practice he'd been putting himself through for the gala.

Jungkook noticed.

Before Jimin could pop the last knuckle, Jungkook rounded the prep station and gently but firmly took Jimin's right hand.

Jimin held his breath, watching through the thick fringe of his lashes as Jungkook's hands completely engulfed his own. Jungkook's palms were broader, his fingers longer, marred by the neat, pale scars of a lifetime spent working the line. Slowly, Jungkook began to massage Jimin's hand, his thumbs pressing deep, circular strokes into the tight, strained muscles of Jimin's palm.

"My maman used to do this when I first started," Jungkook murmured, his voice dropping into a low, rhythmic cadence that matched the steady pressure of his thumbs. "I was young, stubborn, and I was always getting cramps from doing things too quickly."

Jimin let out a soft, trembling hum in response, his eyelids fluttering half-closed as a wave of relief washed through his hand. The dense, deep warmth of Jungkook's touch was entirely therapeutic, melting away the painful tension that had been building since early that morning.

"She was a chef... well, at least to me," Jungkook began softly, his dark eyes fixed entirely on the way his thumbs were working over Jimin's skin, his expression turning distant, wrapped in the quiet shadows of a memory. "She made the best tarte Tatin in the entire valley. It was always perfect, deep amber, bordering on burnt but never bitter. She taught me everything before I knew anything."

Jungkook shifted his grip, his long fingers sliding between Jimin's to gently stretch out the webbing of his hand, his touch incredibly careful.

"She used to tell me that cooking is entirely a matter of love," Jungkook continued, a faint, almost untraceable trace of a bittersweet smile gracing his features. "That if you only care about perfection, you will always miss the heart of the dish. You have to pour yourself out to let that passion do the work for you. I forgot that for a long time after she passed."

He finally paused, his thumbs coming to a rest over the center of Jimin's palm, the quiet hum of the industrial refrigerators filling the space between them. Jungkook lifted his head, his dark eyes locking onto Jimin's face with a profound, quiet intensity that made Jimin's chest tighten.

"But... lately something is making me remember."

Jimin's breath caught completely, his throat locking up as those dark, unblinking eyes held him completely captive. The vulnerability in the confession was vertiginous, far more consuming than any of the harsh commands or the heavy, bruising grips they usually shared. Jimin felt entirely stripped bare. His heart hammered, his chest rising and falling in shallow, uneven gasps.

For a long, suspended second, neither of them moved. The air between them turned thick and heavy with everything left unsaid.

Then, with a slow, deliberate neatness, Jungkook released his grip.

He stepped back, the familiar, rigid posture of Director Jeon locking seamlessly back into place as he smoothed down the front of his dark shirt. The shield was back, but the quiet softness in his eyes lingered for a fraction of a second longer before he turned toward the exit.

"Get some rest, Jimin," Jungkook murmured, his voice returning to its steady, low tone as he reached the double doors of the kitchen. He paused, looking over his shoulder one last time. "Have a good weekend. I expect you focused and ready on Monday."

Before Jimin could even find his voice to respond, the heavy doors swung shut with a quiet, hollow click, leaving him entirely alone in the empty kitchen, staring at the space where the man had just been.



By the time the weekend rolled around, the frantic energy of the academy felt like a distant hum.

Jimin was out on the phone with Hobi, tucked away in a secluded corner of the academy's stone garden where the manicured hedges offered some actual privacy. He was perched up on a weathered stone bench, his legs pulled up to his chest, resting his chin on his knees as he balanced his phone. On the other side of the call, miles away, Hobi was sprawled lazily across his own bed, completely unbothered... until Jimin finally spilled the truth.

"You what? Jimin? What on earth..." Hobi's voice exploded through the line, his sheets rustling violently as he sat bolt upright. "Holy shit, you're having sex with your te—"

Jimin aggressively hissed a quiet "Shh!" into his microphone, frantically looking over his shoulder even though his earbuds were in and there wasn't a single soul around the garden paths.

"You said you wouldn't react!" Jimin fiercely whispered into the mic, his fingers gripping his knee tightly.

"Yeah, that was before I found out you were fucking your teacher!" Hobi shot right back, his voice a mix of utter disbelief and panic.

"Okay... it's not that bad. It's not like high school," Jimin defended breathlessly, trying to rationalize the madness of the last few weeks. "I'm twenty-three and he's twenty-eight. It's completely—"

"This isn't about age, Jimin, this is about the ethics!" Hobi cut him off, pacing around his room now. "He grades your plates! He literally holds your entire future in his hands! If anyone finds out ____"

"If anyone finds out, he's the Director, Hobi!" Jimin shot back, dropping his forehead onto his knees as his heart began to do that familiar, anxious dance. "He basically owns the academy. He's basically untouchable. The board worships the ground he walks on."

"Okay, great for Director Jeon," Hobi snapped, his voice sharp with fierce, protective frustration. "But what about you, Jimin? He's untouchable, but you're a student. If this leaks, who do you think they're going to throw under the bus to protect the school's reputation? Hint: it's not the guy with the Michelin stars."

Jimin bit his lip, the cold stone of the bench chilling him through his jeans. He didn't have an answer for that, because deep down, he knew Hobi was right. In the hierarchy of the academy, he was completely defenseless.

"And what even is this anyways?" Hobi continued, his tone softening slightly, shifting from panic to genuine concern. "Are you guys... talking? Are you dating? Is he taking you out, or are you just a secret after hours?"

"We don't... go on dates, Hobi," Jimin mumbled, his voice dropping into a small, defensive murmur. "We can't. And it's not like we're sitting around holding hands and talking about our feelings. Most of the time we're either yelling at each other over stupid stuff or..." He trailed off, his throat tight.

"Or he's fucking you," Hobi finished flatly.

"It's complicated," Jimin groaned, burying his face in his arms. "But it's not just that. He can be so....so... *soft*, Hobi. I've seen him like that."

There was a long, heavy silence on the other end of the line. Jimin could hear Hobi taking a deep, slow breath, the anger draining away, leaving only a quiet, cautious worry.

"Jiminie," Hobi said softly. "Be careful. A man like that... he knows exactly how to build a wall, and he knows exactly when to let it down to keep you hooked. Just promise me you won't lose your head before the gala."

"I won't, trust me..." Jimin sighed, tracing a line in the weathered stone of the bench with the tip of his sneaker. "It's *nothing*. This is just like... everyday stuff."

Hobi let out a loud, incredulous chuckle through the speaker. "Everyday stuff? Jiminie, the last guy you talked to was a regular college dude, and it took you a year to get over him. Imagine what a hot, rich, daddy French chef is gonna do to your sanity."

Jimin groaned loudly, pressing his face into his knees to muffle the sound. "Okay, stop! Please. And it's not like I'm in love with him. This is just... a *thing*."

"Right... well... enjoy the thing," Hobi said, his voice softening into something genuinely grounding. "But don't let the thing keep you from doing what you actually came there to do."

"Yeah. I know," Jimin mumbled.

But the truth was, Jimin was barely even hearing him anymore. His eyes had drifted, staring blankly off into the lush, green distance of the academy garden. The vibrant summer leaves blurred into a soft haze as his mind instantly betrayed him, conjuring up the sharp, devastating symmetry of Jungkook's handsome face.

He could still feel the heavy, grounding weight of Jungkook's thumbs pressing into his palms, the quiet, low vibration of his voice, and the sudden shift from the cold Director to a man who looked at him with an undeniable, quiet yearning.

It was terrifying. Jungkook was a distraction he couldn't afford, a volatile fire in the middle of a high-pressure kitchen, but as Jimin sat alone on the stone bench, all he could think about was Monday morning and wanting to be trapped under those dark eyes all over again.

"Hello? Earth to Jimin?" Hobi's voice cracked loudly through the earbud, snapping the thread of Jimin's thoughts.

Jimin blinked rapidly, shaking his head to clear the image of Jungkook's eyes from his mind. "What? Sorry, what did you say?"

"I said that you need to keep your eyes on the prize," Hobi sighed, the sound of his shifting mattress bleeding through the line. "The gala is your ticket to everything!. Don't let some intense office trysts mess up your focus. You have to think about next semester."

"I am thinking about it," Jimin countered quickly, his defensive walls going right back up. "Plus... he won't even be my teacher next semester. I'm moving on to the advanced pastry rotation with Chef Dubois."

He had meant it to sound like a reassurance—proof to Hobi that the power dynamic was temporary, that the ethical gray area would naturally dissolve in a few weeks. But the moment the thought left his lips, a sudden, cold weight dropped straight into the pit of his stomach. His chest tightened painfully, the breath catching in his throat.

"Exactly," Hobi said flatly on the other end, completely oblivious to the sudden shift in Jimin's demeanor. "Then it's on to the next student for him."

The words hit Jimin like a physical blow.

The next student?

Jimin sat frozen on the stone bench, his legs pulled tightly against his chest as the reality of Hobi's casual comment settled deep into his bones. He hadn't allowed himself to think about it. He hadn't allowed his mind to wander past the end of the gala next week.

But what happened when the showcase was over? What happened when he was no longer the stubborn student breaking the rules in Director Jeon's kitchen?

The thought of not seeing Jungkook every day, of walking past the administrative wing and seeing the door closed, of becoming just another face in the crowded hallways... or worse, just a forgotten phase. The thought made a sickening wave of nausea and dread twist in his gut.

Suddenly, the air in the garden felt suffocatingly thin.

"I have to go, Hobi," Jimin interrupted abruptly, his voice dropping into a tight, strained whisper as he uncurled his legs, his throat burning.

"Wait, Jimin, are you okay—?"

"I'll text you later. Bye."

Without waiting for a response, Jimin tapped the screen, cutting off his best friend's voice and plunging the garden into a heavy, ringing silence. He stared down at the black screen of his phone, his fingers trembling slightly.



"And then I told him, this is Chanel, not Gucci, you animal!" Tae announced loudly across the dining hall table, gesturing dramatically with his fork.

The entire table erupted into loud laughter. Everyone found the joke funny—hilarious, even. They leaned over their trays, shaking their heads and swapping knowing looks about the ridiculous standards of the upper-class culinary world they were all trying so desperately to break into.

Jimin, however, just poked aimlessly at his salad. His mouth was set in a tight, flat line as he listened to the chatter bouncing around him, the loud clinking of silverware against plastic trays filling the room. His appetite was completely gone, his mind still stuck in the suffocating loop of his phone call with Hobi from the day before.

"Ah, vraiment... certains hommes n'ont absolument aucun goût," Tae added smoothly, leaning back in his chair with a roll of his eyes that made the rest of the table laugh even harder.

Jimin forced a small, hollow smile onto his face just to blend in, but his chest felt tightly restricted. Seeing how easily the others chatted, how effortlessly Tae threw around casual French phrases, only served to remind Jimin of the massive, unbridgeable chasm between his world and Jungkook's.

"Hey, Jimin," Tae suddenly said, his sharp eyes cutting through the laughter to lock onto Jimin's quiet posture. He leaned forward, resting his chin in his hand. "You've been spaced out all through lunch. What's going on in that head of yours? Are you still stressing over the gala menu, or is Director Jeon driving you to an early grave?"

"Oh... just a little tired, I guess," Jimin murmured, forcing a weak smile as he begrudgingly picked up a forkful of greens and forced himself to chew. The food tasted like absolutely nothing, completely dry as he swallowed past the tight knot in his throat.

"I bet!" another student chimed in, leaning over their tray. "I heard from some of the other students who got chosen for the gala that he doesn't even see them as human beings. We're all just tools to the man. He doesn't care if you're exhausted or bleeding, as long as the plate looks perfect."

Jimin kept his head down, staring intently at a cherry tomato on his plate. Hearing them talk about Jungkook like he was some distant, unfeeling machine felt deeply bizarre. It made his brain stall, caught in the jarring disconnect between the ruthless dictator his classmates feared and the man who had kissed him breathless hours prior.

Then it's on to the next student.

He couldn't shake the terrifying thought of what would happen when the semester ended. Would he just become another face in the crowd to Jungkook? Another name on a grading sheet?

"Hey, I'm gonna head back to the dorms early," Jimin said abruptly, grabbing his tray as he stood up from the bench. "I want to look over my prep lists one more time before tomorrow."

"Don't work yourself to death, Jimin," Tae called out, waving a hand casually. "See you later!"

Jimin nodded quickly and walked away, the loud, echoing chatter of the dining hall fading into a dull roar behind him. As he stepped out into the humid evening air, his chest tightened with a

frantic, agonizing impatience. He hated how much power Jungkook had over his thoughts, hated the reckless envy pulling at his gut, but more than anything, he just wanted the weekend to be over.



Monday morning arrived with a suffocating quickness.

Jimin stood at his station in the kitchen, his fingers gripping the cold edge of the counter just to stay focused. His eyes felt heavy, burning at the corners from the severe lack of sleep that had plagued him throughout the entire weekend. His head was a foggy, delirious mess, his thoughts still tangled in a loop of anxiety.

Jungkook walked into the room, and the casual murmurs of the students instantly died out, replaced by a tense, uniform silence. He was dressed in his all-black kitchen attire, the dark, heavy canvas of his chef's coat tailored perfectly to his broad shoulders. His dark hair was pushed back cleanly from his forehead, exposing the sharp lines of his face and the unreadable, icy focus in his dark eyes.

Jungkook walked up to the main demonstration pass, resting his hands flat against the metal surface.

"Good morning," Jungkook began. "As we enter the final stretch before the annual showcase, adjustments to the kitchen roster are being finalized. By now, everyone should know that I have chosen Park Jimin for this year's gala menu."

Jimin quickly lowered his head, his gaze trained down toward the empty surface of his prep station. He purposefully avoided making eye contact with the front of the room. He didn't dare look up, terrified that if his eyes met Jungkook's, the exhaustion and the frantic, lingering jealousy in his mind would be laid bare for the entire class to see. He kept his chin tucked, his focus locked onto the reflection of the overhead lights on the metal counter.

For the first half of the class, Jimin remained entirely in his own head, executing his knife work purely on instinct while Jungkook's voice echoed over the space. In fact, for the entire duration of the grueling three-hour block, Jimin didn't look up a single time. He kept his eyes rigidly glued to his cutting board and his simmering pans, utilizing his peripheral vision to navigate the kitchen and

completely blocking out the rest of the room. He refused to give Jungkook the satisfaction of catching his eye, and he refused to let himself slip past the safety of his own fortress.

The moment Jungkook announced the end of the session, Jimin shifted into hyper-speed. He wiped down his station with frantic efficiency, washed his tools in record time, and packed up his leather knife roll quickly, his fingers moving in a blur.

He wanted to be the first one out, to vanish into the crowded hallways before anyone could stop him. He already had his kit slung over one shoulder, his body half-turned toward the exit, when the sharp sound of Jungkook's voice cut through the noise of the room.

"Jimin, please stay behind. I need to discuss and finalize the gala prep timeline," Jungkook's voice rang out, authoritative and completely adamant. He didn't even look up from his clipboard as he smoothly pivoted to address the rest of the room. "Everyone else, have a good day. Tomorrow, be ready for line-testing at exactly six AM. Class dismissed."

Jimin froze in his tracks, his shoulders locking into a tight line. As the rest of the students began to chatter and stream past him toward the exit, he slowly closed his eyes, a heavy, defeated sigh escaping his lips.

He stood perfectly still, anchoring his feet to the tile as the loud scraping of chairs and casual murmurs faded into the corridor. He waited, counting the seconds, refusing to move a muscle until the very last student had crossed the threshold and the heavy double doors finally clicked shut. Only then, when the expansive kitchen was plunged into a ringing, absolute silence, did Jimin slowly turn around.

He still couldn't bring himself to meet the man's eyes. Instead, he kept his gaze rigidly fixed on the metal surface of the workstation.

Jungkook was standing directly on the other side of his demonstration counter. He let his eyes track the stiff, defensive slope of Jimin's shoulders before setting his clipboard down with a soft, hollow thud.

"What is the matter?" Jungkook asked quietly, his voice lacking its earlier performative authority, leaving only a raw, private gravity behind.

"Nothing," Jimin murmured, his voice tight and detached as he stared intensely at his own hands. "I was just working, Chef."

Jimin knew he was being frustratingly vague, but he couldn't force anything else past the constricting knot in his throat without completely coming undone.

Jungkook looked instantly taken aback by the rigid, formal reply. The title hung heavily in the empty air between them, a cold barrier that explicitly reminded the Director exactly where the boundaries lay.

"You look like you haven't slept much."

"I haven't," Jimin admitted quietly, the honesty slipping out before he could filter it. He finally looked up, his tired, heavy eyes locking onto Jungkook's across the empty distance of the kitchen.

Jungkook's jaw clenched slightly, a tiny, subtle shift in his expression that showed the director was fighting with the man beneath the coat.

"Is the gala causing you this much anxiety?" Jungkook asked, his voice softening by a fraction. "If the prep lists are overwhelming you, I expect you to speak to me, Jimin. Not run yourself into the ground before it even happens."

"It's not that," Jimin murmured, his voice cracking slightly. He looked down at the polished metal table between them, watching his own blurred reflection.

"Then what is it?" Jungkook demanded softly, leaning his hands onto the counter, tilting his head down to catch Jimin's averted gaze.

Jimin forced his eyes up, his chest heaving with a shallow, ragged breath. "Next semester," he whispered, the words tumbling out before he could stop them. "Next semester I'm on the pastry rotation. I won't be in your kitchen anymore."

Jungkook stayed completely still, his eyes widening just a fraction as he processed the sudden confession.

"And?" Jungkook prompted, his voice dangerously quiet.

"And nothing," Jimin said, a bitter, defensive edge finally returning to his tone as he tried to pull his knife roll over his shoulder.

Instead, Jimin turned on his heel and walked toward the heavy double doors, his boots practically slamming against the tile as he made a blind run for the exit. He hated himself. He hated how pathetic the words had sounded out loud, hated that he had let his guard down enough to reveal the pathetic, aching insecurity that had been clawing at his throat all weekend.

He hated himself for not explaining more, for not standing his ground and fighting back with the sharp, stubborn defiance Jungkook usually loved to draw out of him.

But he really couldn't cry. Not in this kitchen, and absolutely not in front of Director Jeon.

Not again.

His vision was already blurring at the edges, a hot, suffocating prickle burning the back of his eyelids as he reached the exit. He shoved his palm hard against the silver crash bar of the door, desperate to spill out into the empty hallway where he could breathe, desperate to put distance between his own unraveled heart and the man still probably standing by the prep line.

Jimin practically sprinted down the long corridor, his head ducked low as he blinked furiously to keep the hot tears from spilling over his lashes. He clutched his knife roll tightly against his chest like a shield, his breath coming in ragged, shallow hitches that echoed too loudly against the academy's walls.

A week, he thought, the reality settling into his chest like a block of ice. Just one week.

Seven days until the gala. One single week left with Jungkook, and then everything would end. The final plates would be served, the contract would be closed, the grades would be entered into the system, and Jimin would be shifted onto the next ledger. The thought was paralyzing.

He realized, with a sudden, devastating pang of clarity, that he was mourning the loss before it had even happened. Once next week ended, so would the praise. He'd lose that rare, intoxicating validation that made the burns and endless hours on his feet feel worth it. No more dark, unblinking eyes tracking his movements across a crowded kitchen, holding him completely captive with a single, unreadable glance.

Worse than anything, he wouldn't be close enough to smell him anymore. He would lose that signature, heavy scent that always heralded Jungkook's approach, an expensive and grounding blend. On the line, it was a scent that had once meant absolute terror during inspection. But behind closed doors, it meant an entirely different kind of breathlessness.

Jimin burst through the heavy exit doors of the building, the humid summer air hitting his face like a damp towel. He didn't stop walking. He needed to get to his room. He needed to find a dark corner where he didn't have to be Park Jimin, the star student, or the Director's secret entanglement.

Because as the sun began to beat down on the academy grounds, all Jimin could feel was the terrifyingly short countdown ticking away in his head, measuring out the exact hours he had left before he became a stranger to the only man who had ever managed to completely break him open.



Jimin practically threw himself into his room, letting the heavy wood door slam shut behind him. He didn't bother turning on the lights. He just let his knife roll slide onto the floor with a heavy thud, his body following it right down until he was sitting on the edge of his unmade bed, his head buried in his hands.

The silence of the room was deafening.

He pulled his phone out of his pocket, his thumb hovering over Hobi's name. His throat felt tight, a heavy ache blooming behind his ribs as he stared at the screen. He wanted to type it out. He wanted

to send the words that would fix everything, the words that would protect his dignity and save him from the inevitable crash at the end of next week.

You were right, he wanted to type. I'm calling it off.

But his thumb froze over the keyboard. The text box remained completely blank, the cursor blinking at him like a tiny, mocking heartbeat.

He couldn't do it. He couldn't send it.

The moment he tried to imagine walking into the kitchen tomorrow and entirely shutting it down, his mind completely betrayed him. He could still feel the phantom sensation of Jungkook's hand engulfing his own. He could still feel the heavy, consuming pressure of those warm lips pressing into his skin, the low words whispered directly against his ear.

It was a sickness, a total lack of control that made him hate himself, but as he stared at the phone, he knew the absolute truth. He was already too deep. He couldn't walk away from the fire, even if he knew he was going to get burned to ash the second the gala ended.

With a frustrated, miserable groan, Jimin tossed the phone onto the mattress beside him and pulled his knees tightly against his chest, staring into the dim shadows of his room as the countdown in his head kept ticking away.

If he couldn't text Hobi, if he couldn't walk away from the kitchen entirely, then he would just have to change the script. He'd stop it before Jungkook could. He would be the one to call it quits, to sever the line, to put the barrier back up before Director Jeon had the chance to neatly pack him away like a used set of knives. It was a matter of survival. If he took control of the ending, maybe he could salvage a single shred of his pride.

He rested his chin on his knees, staring blankly at the wall. Yeah, he thought miserably. Maybe that way it would only take me around two years to get over him instead of three.

It was a pathetic metric to measure his future by, but it was the only one he had left.

Jimin closed his eyes, drawing in a long, shaky breath that smelled faintly of the sanitizing solution from the lecture halls. He would rebuild his own walls brick by brick, even if his chest ached so badly it felt like it was splitting wide open.



Except Jimin couldn't avoid Jungkook forever. In fact, he couldn't avoid him at all.

The academy was Jungkook's kingdom, and he was omnipresent. In every lecture, during every inspection, the man was simply there, a towering, dark presence that Jimin tried with every ounce of his failing willpower to ignore. For three agonizing days, Jimin successfully turned himself into a ghost. He kept his head down, spoke only when spoken to, and followed commands with the exact same hollow, robotic compliance as every other student on the line. No lingering glances. No arguments. No office visits.

He thought he was winning. He thought he was finally building the wall high enough to save himself.

Until tonight.

It was past eleven, and the practical kitchens were dead silent, save for the hum of the overhead fans. Jimin had managed to dodge the Director during his late-night sessions for the past seventy-two hours, but his luck finally ran out. The heavy double doors surged open, the familiar, grounding scent of sandalwood and espresso cutting through the smell of burnt sugar before Jimin even heard the footsteps.

Jungkook walked into the room, his eyes fixed on a notebook in his hand, his dark hair messy, the top three buttons of his black shirt undone. He didn't look up until the rhythmic, sharp sound of Jimin's whisk hitting a copper bowl echoed across the tile.

Jungkook froze. "Oh," was all he said, the syllable dropping heavily into the empty kitchen.

It had been three whole days since they had exchanged a single word that wasn't formal or a clinical critique. The sudden silence between them made Jimin's chest ache violently. He

immediately looked down, his knuckles turning white around the handle of his whisk, busying himself by aggressively whipping the egg whites in front of him.

"You're practicing," Jungkook said, stating the obvious as he set the tablet down on the pass.

"Yes, Chef," Jimin replied, his voice flat, ice-cold, and entirely detached.

Jungkook squinted at that, his eyes narrowing as if he had just been slapped. The complete lack of heat, the absolute absence of the stubborn pushback he usually drew out of Jimin, clearly grated on him. He slowly stepped away from the pass, crossing the floor until he was standing just on the other side of the prep station, his broad frame casting a heavy shadow over Jimin's bowl.

"Why didn't you tell me?" Jungkook asked softly, his voice dropping into that low, gravelly cadence that made Jimin's heart do a panicked, treacherous flip. "I would have come to help you. We need to-."

"I... I've got it," Jimin muttered, his eyes glued to the frothing eggs, refusing to meet the intense, burning gaze he could feel searching his face.

"Jimin," Jungkook murmured, reaching out. His hand settled gently over the top of Jimin's left hand, the one holding the copper bowl, his thumb instantly brushing over the tight muscles of his wrist. "Stop."

The touch was ruinous. Every single brick Jimin had spent the last three days meticulously building instantly turned to ash under the heat of Jungkook's palm. He froze, his breath hitching sharply in his throat as he stared at Jungkook's fingers engulfing his own, the desperate, aching need to just cave in battling fiercely with his fading pride.

Jimin hated him for it. He absolutely hated how effortlessly direct the man was, how he could just march into a room and demand access to every single corner of his mind while keeping his own walls perfectly intact.

Jimin tried to yank his hand back, but Jungkook's grip was a firm. Jimin let out a sharp, frustrated sigh and tried to force his arm to keep whisking, the metal wire scraping loudly against the copper in a chaotic, uneven rhythm.

"I'm just trying to practice on my own," Jimin snapped, his voice trembling as he stared blindly into the frothing egg whites. "It's nothing. Just—"

"It is not nothing," Jungkook cut him off, his fingers tightening just enough to stop the whisk completely. "I'm confused," Jungkook murmured. "You were so open about yourself, and now..."

He paused, his jaw clenching tightly as his dark eyes searched Jimin's face. He looked genuinely at a loss, his brow pulling together as if he were trying to find the vocabulary for the sudden void Jimin had thrown between them.

Jimin paused, his hand going entirely slack against the handle of the whisk. He still didn't look up, his eyes locked on the dark fabric of Jungkook's shirt, desperately wanting him to finish the sentence, wanting him to admit that the distance actually affected him.

"I'm what?" Jimin asked, his tone sharp, challenging.

"You are different," Jungkook rasped, a rare flash of undisguised frustration cutting through his expression. "We cannot get anywhere with whatever this is. I cannot execute this menu if you are emotionally checked out. Is that it? Can you not handle it anymore?"

"Oh, so this is about the menu?" Jimin shot back, a bitter, breathless laugh ripping from his throat as he finally snapped his head up to lock eyes with the Director. The exhaustion and the days of built-up misery finally boiled over. "Of course. Heaven forbid your precious gala plates suffer because I actually have a personality."

"Jimin, do not twist my words," Jungkook warned, his voice low and dangerous, his fingers still pinning Jimin's hand to the metal counter.

"I'm not twisting anything!" Jimin cried out, his voice bouncing sharply off the tiled walls of the dark, empty kitchen. "You want emotionally stable? Fine! I've been giving you that for three days! But don't come in here pretending you care about anything else. It's not like what we've been doing after hours is very productive anyways!"

Jungkook's eyes widened, a sudden flash of panic crossing his features before his expression hardened.

"Keep your voice down," Jungkook hissed, his eyes dawning toward the frosted glass of the double doors leading out to the main corridor.

"Why?" Jimin shrieked, entirely unhinged now, the tears he had been fighting for days finally burning the rims of his eyes as he violently ripped his hand away from Jungkook's grip. "What, Director? You don't want your precious board to know that you fuck your students?"

"Jimin!" Jungkook spat, his voice dropping into frantic whisper as he slammed his palms flat against the steel. His face was pale under the fluorescent lights, the perfect, composed mask of Director Jeon completely fracturing right in front of Jimin's eyes.

He paused, running a tense hand through his hair as he paced a short, restless line behind the prep table. A small, dry laugh escaped his lips.

"It's not like that," he murmured, his dark eyes snapping back to lock onto Jimin's with a fierce, burning intensity. "And you know it."

"Then how is it?" Jimin shot right back, stepping into the space, his chest heaving as the inevitable truth poured out of him. "Because from where I'm standing, that's exactly what it looks like! I don't know how you guys do things over here, but back in America, this would be a very toxic sneaky link! We would be canceled if anyone saw the way we interacted! Do you not understand that? The dynamic, the secrets—it's too complicated!"

Jungkook closed his eyes, letting out a long, heavy sigh that sounded like it came from the very bottom of his lungs. He aggressively ran a large hand through his dark hair, pulling at the roots as he paced another short line behind the prep table.

"For starters," Jungkook rumbled, turning back to face him, his dark eyes ablaze with an uncharacteristic, restless frustration. "Half the time I do not understand you! You talk too fast, using these words I do not know, going on and on about absolutely nothing!"

Jimin let out a loud, incredulous scoff, his hands instantly flying to his hips. "I don't talk about nothing! See—this is exactly what I mean! You just dismiss everything I say! I'm trying to tell you how I feel, and you're critiquing my speaking speed?!"

"Because I don't understand you!" Jungkook argued, matching his volume, his accent turning thicker, heavier under the weight of his irritation. "I am trying to run a three-Michelin-level operation, Jimin! I do not have the luxury of dissecting every word or worrying about what people across the ocean think!"

"Oh, so my feelings are just a luxury now?" Jimin questioned, the tears finally spilling over his lashes, burning hot down his flushed cheeks. "I am a human being, Jungkook! Not just something you use whenever you finally happen to be in a good mood!"

Jungkook flinched, his jaw locking so hard a vein throbbed violently at his temple. "Do not say that. You know that is not what you are to me."

"Then what am I?" Jimin pressed, wiping his eyes angrily with the back of his sleeve, stepping closer until the metal counter was the only thing separating their chests. "Tell me! Because next week the gala ends, and next semester I won't be here, and you're just going to move on to the next student who stands at this line!"

Jungkook's gaze narrowed, his dark eyes tracking the frantic, shallow rise and fall of Jimin's chest. For three agonizing seconds, he stood completely frozen. Then, the defensive irritation drained from his face entirely. A profound look of clarity broke through his features as the true source of Jimin's panic finally clicked. The tension vanished from his posture, his brow relaxed, and his expression softened just a fraction.

"So," Jungkook murmured, his voice dropping lower. "You think this is a regular occurrence then? You think I do this every semester?"

Jimin's bravado instantly evaporated. He ducked his head, the fiery defiance leaving his posture as his cheeks reddened.

"I-I don't know," Jimin mumbled, his voice cracking as he shifted his weight from foot to foot.

Jungkook didn't say a word. Instead, he slowly walked around the edge of the prep station. Jimin kept his eyes glued to the floor, his heart hammering a frantic, deafening rhythm against his ribs as the heavy click of Jungkook's boots stopped right in front of him.

Before Jimin could even think to step back, Jungkook reached out. His warm hand hooked firmly under Jimin's chin, his calloused thumb tilting Jimin's face up with an uncompromising, gentle pressure that forced their eyes to lock.

Jungkook leaned down, closing the distance until his lips were brushing right against the shell of Jimin's ear. The thick, intoxicating scent of sandalwood and espresso completely enveloped Jimin's senses, making his head spin.

"I have not touched anyone in the five years I have run this academy. Do not insult me to my face ever again, and do not insult yourself by thinking you are easily replaced."

Jimin's breath caught completely in his throat, his lungs locking up as the weight of the confession left him utterly breathless. Before he could even process the words, Jungkook leaned in that fraction of an inch more and pressed a firm, lingering kiss to Jimin's parted lips.

When he pulled back, his dark eyes raked slowly over Jimin's flushed face, capturing every ounce of his stunned, wide-eyed reaction.

Jungkook released his chin and stepped back, the familiar, ironclad armor of Director Jeon locking seamlessly back into place over his handsome features. He looked down his nose at Jimin, his expression completely unreadable once again.

"Now," Jungkook commanded, his voice returning to its steady, authoritative tone as he gestured toward the counter. "Pick up your whisk. And do not yell at me in my kitchen again. Understood?"



The next morning, the dining hall was a cacophony of clinking trays and hurried morning chatter, but Jimin was in a world completely his own. A small, helpless smile threatened to escape his lips, tugging at the corners of his mouth as Tae gestured animatedly across the table.

Jimin wasn't really hearing a word of it. He took a slow, deliberate bite of a cream-filled pastry, the rich, sweet vanilla custard bursting on his tongue, and the taste instantly pulled him backward. He remembered Jungkook's. He remembered everything. His mind was on an endless loop replaying every moment they'd ever shared together.

Everything felt different today. The air felt lighter. The looming countdown to the gala didn't feel like an execution date anymore.

"Hey," Alexandre said, sliding onto the bench next to Tae and setting down his coffee mug. He leaned across the table, looking directly at Jimin. "Are you ready for next week? I heard some new chef's will be attending this year. Are you nervous?"

Tae scoffed playfully, waving a hand in dismissal before Jimin could even swallow his pastry. "Nervous? Please. Jimin's been working so hard he's barely even in the room anymore. I swear, he basically lives in the kitchens at this point. He comes back past midnight nearly every single night."

Jimin's throat instantly went dry. He swallowed the pastry with a hard gulp, a sudden, flush of pink rushing up his neck and heating his cheeks. He frantically grabbed his water glass, taking a quick sip to cover his panic.

"Y-yep..." Jimin cleared his throat, avoiding Tae's gaze. "Just... trying to get everything perfect. The Director is really.... precise."

Tae squinted at him, his eyes narrowing slightly at the stutter and the sudden deep blush, but the suspicion went unnoticed as the entire mood at the table abruptly shifted.

Jimin's lingering smile dropped completely.

Down the center aisle of the dining hall, Eric was strolling through, a small entourage of his usual minions trailing tightly behind his shoulders like a dark cloud. Eric's eyes scanned the room lazily until they locked directly onto Jimin. The moment they did, Eric's smug smile widened into something sharp, calculated, and deeply unpleasant.

Without breaking eye contact, Eric altered his path, heading straight toward their table.

He stopped right at the edge of their table, resting his hands casually on the back of an empty chair. He leaned forward, his eyes gleaming with a malicious, knowing light that made the hair on the back of Jimin's neck stand up.

"Well, look who it is," Eric drawled, his voice carrying easily over the morning chatter. "The star of the show. You know, Jimin, you're incredibly lucky you got picked for the gala. A lot of us have been pulling eighteen-hour days for months just to get a look from the Director."

Jimin kept his grip tight around his water glass, his knuckles stiff. "I-I worked for the spot just like you."

"Oh, I'm sure you did," Eric scoffed, a nasty, sharp chuckle slipping past his lips. He tilted his head, his smirk widening as his minions snickered behind him. "I just don't know what exactly you had to do to get the spot. But considering you're the only one allowed in his private office after hours... I sure hope it was worth it."

The surrounding tables instantly went dead silent. A sudden, heavy wave of murmurs and gasps erupted across the dining hall as students turned in their seats, whispering furiously to one another. Tae's jaw dropped, his head snapping between Eric and Jimin, while Alexandre froze with his coffee mug halfway to his mouth.

Jimin felt the blood completely rush out of his face, leaving him disoriented and cold under the bright lights. His chest tightened so fast he could barely breathe, his eyelashes fluttering rapidly as a wave of panic crashed over him.

"W-what..." Jimin stammered, his voice dropping into a breathless, horrified whisper. "What are you talking about?"

"Oh, come on, don't play dumb now," Eric said, leaning in closer, his voice dropping into a venomous purr that cut right through Jimin's defenses. "So, tell us... what's Director Jeon's rubric like behind closed doors?"

"I don't... I don't k-know—" Jimin stammered, his voice breaking as his chest locked up completely. The entire dining hall felt like it was closing in on him, hundreds of eyes suddenly boring into his back, the heavy murmurs of his classmates morphing into a deafening roar in his ears.

"I gotta say," Eric continued, throwing his hands out dramatically as he looked around at the murmuring crowd, his smirk twisting into something ugly and triumphant. "Who knew Director Jeon had a thing for Americans? With all his talk about discipline and high standards, turns out all it takes to get on his good side is a little..."

Eric trailed off, letting his eyes slowly track down Jimin's rigid posture with an explicit, disgusting implication that made Tae slam his hands flat against the table.

"Shut your mouth, Eric!" Tae yelled, standing up so fast his chair screeched violently against the tile. "Tu ne sais absolument pas de quoi tu parles!"

But Jimin couldn't even hear Tae's defense. With every sentence that spilled out of Eric's mouth, he felt himself growing smaller, completely paralyzed by a deep, suffocating embarrassment. The bright flush from earlier turned into a cold, mortified paleness. He sank back into his seat, his eyes fixed blindly on his half-eaten pastry, his hands trembling so hard beneath the table that he had to grip his own knees to hide it.

"Look at him, he can't even deny it," Eric jeered, his voice dropping into a cruel, mocking singsong as he leaned closer to the silent, unraveled boy. "But who am I kidding," Eric added, leaning his palms on the table, his eyes drilling into Jimin's frozen form, "it makes total sense. I mean, look at where you come from. Some trashy, loud American family from the slums, right? Did your parents have to buy their way out of it, or did they just raise you to throw yourself at anyone with a title to get ahead?"

The words hit like a slap, but the mortification that had been paralyzing Jimin instantly evaporated.

In its place, something violent and primal slammed into his chest. He saw red. Not a dramatic, theatrical way, but a cold, blindingly sharp rage that entirely consumed his senses. His hometown. His parents. The people who had loved him, supported him, and watched him pack his things to cross the ocean. Eric didn't get to talk about them.

Jimin stood up so fast his bench kicked back against the floor with a deafening CRACK.

He didn't hesitate. He stepped right into Eric's space, his chest practically colliding with the older student's. Jimin shoved his index finger directly into Eric's face, his hand steady as a blade, his eyes boring into Eric's with an unhinged anger.

"Say one more word about my family," Jimin hissed, his voice dangerously low, vibrating with absolute venom. "Say one more word about them, you pathetic piece of shit."

Eric's smug smile faltered for a fraction of a second, caught off guard by the heat radiating off the smaller boy, before his face hardened into an ugly scowl. "What? Are you going to cry to the Director about it? Go ahead, tell him I—"

"I don't need anyone to handle you!" Jimin yelled. "You're just a bitter, insecure bitch who can't stand the fact that your work wasn't good enough! You couldn't handle the heat on the line, so you resort to this disgusting, pathetic gossip?"

"Get your fucking finger out of my face!" Eric roared, his face turning purple as the entire dining hall stood up on their benches to see the confrontation.

"Make me!" Jimin shouted back.

With a loud curse, Eric brought his hands up and shoved Jimin hard across the chest. Jimin reeled backward, his boots skidding against the slick tile, but he didn't even register the pain. The adrenaline surging through his veins turned him entirely numb.

Jimin lunged forward, throwing his entire body weight into a massive, retaliatory shove that sent Eric crashing back into his own minions, throwing the group into a chaotic scramble.

"Jimin, no!" Tae screamed, reaching out to grab the back of Jimin's shirt, but it was too late.

Eric scrambled back to his feet with an angry snarl and charged. The two of them collided in a messy, violent blur of white uniforms and flying fists, crashing hard against the edge of a heavy dining hall table as the entire room erupted into screaming chaos.

In a desperate bid for leverage as Eric's fingers yanked viciously at his hair, Jimin's hand scrambled blindly across the table behind him. His fingers wrapped around the handle of Alexandre's forgotten mug, and without a second thought, he brought it forward in a sharp, violent arc, splashing the lukewarm coffee directly into Eric's face.

The dining hall collectively gasped, a silence falling over the crowd for a fraction of a second.

Eric froze mid-shove, his grip slipping from Jimin's hair as the dark liquid drenched his forehead, matting his styled bangs to his face and dripping rapidly down the front of his pristine white uniform. He looked down at his chest, his hands hovering over the dark, spreading stains as if he couldn't bear to touch himself.

"Ma chemise Chanel est foutue!" Eric shrieked, his voice cracking into a high-pitched, furious wail as he gestured wildly to his soaked linen. *"Espèce de sauvage! Regarde ce que tu as fait!"*

Jimin balled his lips together, biting the inside of his cheek so hard it throbbed, trying desperately to suppress the laugh bubbling up in his chest.

But his amusement didn't last long.

"I'm gonna kill you!"

Before Jimin could steady his footing on the slick tile, Eric lunged again with the force of a runaway train. His body slammed into Jimin's chest, the momentum knocking both of them off their feet. They went down hard, skidding through the puddle of spilled coffee and ceramic.

The fight turned completely primal on the floor. Jimin gasped as the back of his head cracked against the hard tile, but the adrenaline overrode the pain. Eric was on top of him, blindly throwing punches, one catching Jimin sharply across the jaw. Jimin saw stars, but the metallic taste of blood only fueled his rage. He brought his knees up, slamming them into Eric's ribs to create space, twisting his body frantically to reverse the pin.

They rolled over the wet floor, a chaotic tangle of limbs, stained white cotton, and flying fists. Jimin grabbed the collar of Eric's dampened uniform, hauling him down to plant a solid punch right against Eric's cheekbone. Eric hissed, swinging wildly, his nails clawing at the skin of Jimin's neck. Around them, the shouting of the students merged into a deafening wall of sound, chairs scraping and tables shifting as the circle closed in around the violent spectacle.

"Fils de—" Eric hissed, tearing at Jimin's scalp.

Jimin gasped at the sharp pain, his eyes watering, but he didn't back down. He used the leverage to plant his forearm directly across Eric's throat, pinning him down while his free hand buried itself into Eric's side, digging his knuckles hard into the senior's ribs in a series of brutal, frantic jabs.

"Let go of me!" Jimin choked out as he wriggled his knee up, trying to pin Eric's hip to the floor.

"Get him, Eric!" one of the seniors shouted, the crew immediately moving in a tight circle around them, hooting and slamming their hands against the tables to egg the fight on. *"Donne-lui une leçon! Renvoie-le chez lui!"*

Taehyung didn't wait another second seeing the fight grow more violent. He threw himself into the fray, his hands grabbing the back of Eric's soaked shirt to haul him off. "Let go of him, you freak!" Taehyung barked, while Alexandre grabbed Jimin around the waist, trying to pull the two apart as they rolled across the slick, coffee-stained floor, kicking and tearing at each other's uniforms.

The dining hall was in absolute, roaring shambles.

Then, a voice cut through the chaos like a lightning strike.

"Garçons!"

The word wasn't just shouted; it vibrated through the floorboards, heavy, dark, and carrying an absolute, terrifying weight of authority.

The seniors instantly froze. Alexandre and Taehyung dropped their hands, stumbling back a step. On the floor, Jimin's fist stopped mid-air, his knuckles hovering just inches from Eric's nose. He was out of breath, his hair messy and damp with coffee, his white shirt smeared with brown stains and gray floor grime.

Slowly, the heavy silence of the room settled over them, suffocating and thick.

Jimin kept his grip on Eric's collar for one more second before slowly turning his head.

Standing right at the edge of the circle, his large hands resting casually in his trouser pockets but his posture radiating a lethal, rigid fury, was Jungkook.

He didn't look at Eric. His dark eyes went straight to the floor, boring into Jimin's flushed, dirty face with an intensity that practically scorched the skin.

Fuck.

Chapter 8

Jimin squeezed his eyes tightly shut, trying to force the frantic, violent rush of his thoughts into something slower. Something manageable.

For one disorienting second, the chaos of the dining hall disappeared behind the darkness of his eyelids, and an old, painfully familiar voice surfaced from somewhere deep in his memory.

It had been years since he had last recalled the words of his former therapist. Specifically, since the last time his temper had gotten the better of him badly enough that someone ended up on the floor.

Now, Jimin wasn't some rabid animal who wandered around looking for people to fight. He didn't wake up every morning with his fists clenched, waiting for the smallest excuse to swing at someone.

But he had a limit.

Everyone did.

The problem was that people seemed to enjoy crossing his without ever considering what might be waiting on the other side.

Ground yourself, Jimin.

His therapist's voice drifted through his memory, gentle and frustratingly calm against the violent pounding inside his skull.

Inhale.

Jimin dragged in a shallow breath through his mouth. His nose was too blocked with blood to be useful.

Exhale.

The breath left him in a trembling rush.

Name the things you can see.

Jimin opened his eyes.

The dining hall came rushing back into focus in jagged, nauseating pieces.

He could see the destruction surrounding him. The abandoned trays, the shattered ceramic mug resting in a brown pool of coffee near the leg of a table. He could see the enormous swarm of students gathered in a loose circle around them, every face frozen in some mixture of horror and barely concealed delight.

He could see Taehyung several feet away, standing perfectly still with both hands pressed over his mouth.

He could see Eric sprawled on the white tile beneath him, one arm braced beneath his body as he attempted to push himself upright.

He could see thick, dark red blood dripping steadily from his own nose, splattering onto the clean floor in vivid little bursts.

And—

Oh!

He could see a very angry Jungkook staring down at him.

Think of the things you can taste.

Jimin swallowed cautiously, immediately regretting it when pain flared through the torn inside of his cheek.

He could faintly taste the sweet, buttery remnants of the pastry he had eaten less than ten minutes earlier. A trace of vanilla. Caramelized sugar. Something delicate and expensive that now felt completely absurd against the bitter metallic flood coating his tongue.

Things you can feel.

Jungkook's hand suddenly closed around his upper arm.

The calloused palm was hot even through the thick cotton of Jimin's uniform, the grip firm enough to feel like iron locking around his flesh. Without asking whether Jimin could stand, Jungkook hauled him effortlessly off the floor.

The abrupt motion sent the room tilting sideways.

Jimin's knees buckled beneath him, his weak legs trembling violently as a sharp, nauseating spike of pain shot through the back of his skull. He swayed forward, nearly colliding with Jungkook's chest before he forced his feet beneath himself.

Jungkook's grip tightened.

For the briefest second, his other hand lifted toward Jimin's waist, ready to catch him.

Then, as though suddenly remembering the hundred watching eyes surrounding them, Jungkook stopped himself.

His hand dropped back to his side.

Things you can hear.

The dining hall had descended into a state of absolute, stunned ruin.

Jimin could hear the frantic whispering of the students gathered around them, their voices bouncing off the vaulted ceilings and marble walls until the entire space seemed to hiss.

He could hear the shaky scrape of Eric's shoes against the tile as he finally managed to stand.

He could hear Taehyung sharply whisper his name.

He could hear the slow, rhythmic drip-drop of his own blood striking the floor.

Most of all, he could hear Jungkook breathing beside him.

The sharp click of Jungkook's boots suddenly cut through everything else as he turned toward the exit, keeping one hand locked around Jimin's arm while ordering Eric forward with nothing more than a lethal glance.

Lastly, Jimin, what can you smell?

As Jungkook hauled them through the dining hall, ignoring the sea of staring faces parting around them, the familiar scents of the academy crashed over Jimin's senses.

The sharp, chemical sting of floor bleach.

Fresh espresso drifting from the machines along the far wall.

Butter, burnt sugar, and warm bread lingering from breakfast service.

The thick metallic scent of blood pooling beneath his nose.

But overpowering everything else was Jungkook.

Sandalwood. Dark coffee. A faint, clean trace of mint clinging to the collar of his jacket.

The scent Jimin had spent the past week trying desperately to forget. The scent that now carried memories of warm hands, quiet praise, and lips pressed against his skin.

The grounding exercise was supposed to lower his heart rate.

It was supposed to pull him out of the panic, slow his breathing, and stop his body from reacting as though every second was a threat.

Instead, Jimin looked at the rigid line of Jungkook's jaw as they entered the privacy of the rear administrative hallway and accepted that the entire exercise had been a complete failure.

His heart was beating harder than ever.

The walk to Director Jeon's office felt like a public execution.

Jungkook moved several paces ahead once they reached the quieter corridor, his hand finally releasing Jimin's arm only after he seemed certain the younger man could remain upright on his own. He didn't look back. He didn't ask whether Jimin's head was spinning, whether his nose was broken, or whether he could breathe properly through all the blood.

Jimin followed with his head lowered, using one sleeve to wipe uselessly beneath his nose. The white fabric immediately bloomed crimson.

Behind him, Eric stumbled along in furious silence, pressing one hand to the swelling side of his face. His soaked shirt clung heavily to his chest, the expensive pale fabric now covered in coffee, grime, and several faint streaks of blood that Jimin sincerely hoped belonged to him.

Students and faculty members moved aside when they saw Jungkook approaching.

Some pretended not to stare while others didn't bother pretending at all.

Jimin felt every single gaze land on his ruined uniform, his bloodied face, and the violent tremor still running through his hands.

The story was already spreading.

He could practically feel it multiplying behind them as they walked.

By dinner, there would be six versions.

By morning, there would be twenty.

In at least half of them, Jimin would probably have attacked Eric with a butcher's knife over some secret affair with the Director.

"This is completely insane," Eric muttered behind him. His voice was hoarse with outrage. "He attacked me. Everyone saw it."

Jimin stopped.

The anger inside him, which had only barely begun to cool, flared back to life so violently that his fingers curled into fists before he could stop them.

He turned halfway around.

Jungkook stopped walking.

The abrupt halt sent a cold silence ripping through the hallway.

He remained facing forward for a long moment, his shoulders perfectly still. Then he tilted his head just enough for the severe line of his profile to become visible.

“Another word,” Jungkook said quietly, “from either of you before we reach my office, and I will have security remove you from academy grounds.”

By the time they reached the heavy mahogany door at the end of the administrative wing, the blood beneath Jimin’s nose had begun to dry against his upper lip. His head throbbed with every heartbeat, and the adrenaline that had carried him through the fight was draining fast enough to leave his entire body weak and nauseated.

Jungkook opened the door.

“Inside.”

Eric entered first.

Jimin followed more slowly, his legs feeling strangely disconnected from the rest of him.

The familiar scent of Jungkook’s office settled heavily around him the second he crossed the threshold.

Usually, the dim room felt private. Intimate, even. The heavy wood paneling, dark leather furniture, and amber light filtering through the closed blinds had become inseparable from the dangerous

secret they had built inside it.

But with Eric standing there, battered and bruised, the space felt exposed.

Jimin lowered himself stiffly into one of the leather chairs opposite the desk, his chest still heaving as he attempted to catch his breath.

His skull hammered with a vicious, pulsing ache. His weak legs trembled uncontrollably beneath his ruined trousers, and another slow drop of dark blood slipped from his nose, smearing messily across his upper lip.

His once-pristine chef's whites were completely destroyed.

Brown coffee stains spread across the front. Gray floor grime streaked one side of his coat. The seam near his shoulder had been torn open, exposing part of the thin undershirt beneath it.

Next to him, Eric looked arguably worse.

The senior shivered faintly in his seat, his ruined Chanel shirt plastered to his torso like wet paper. His jaw had already begun swelling, a dark purple shadow blooming beneath the skin where Jimin's fist had connected.

Jimin kept his eyes glued firmly to his lap.

The slow sound of leather boots crossed the rug as Jungkook moved around the side of the room. He didn't say anything. The weight of his presence was enough to make the office feel smaller, the walls pressing inward around the three of them.

Jungkook bypassed the chairs entirely. He walked behind the desk and placed both of his palms flat against the dark wood, leaning forward until he was staring directly down his nose at them.

At some point during the chaos, he had removed his glasses. Without them, his eyes were entirely bare and burning with a possessive fury that he didn't seem capable of concealing behind his administrative title.

“Look at me,” Jungkook rumbled.

The command was low, scraping across the silence like gravel but it was not directed at Eric.

Jungkook’s eyes remained locked entirely on the bowed crown of Jimin’s head, demanding the one thing Jimin had deliberately denied him for seven straight days.

Eric, believing the order was meant for him, straightened immediately.

“Director Jeon, he assaulted me,” he burst out, his voice cracking with righteous indignation. “He threw coffee in my face and attacked me in front of everyone. I was only defending—”

“I said,” Jungkook interrupted his voice dropping an octave. “Look at me.”

Jimin swallowed hard.

The metallic tang coating his tongue grew stronger as he ground his teeth together.

The stubborn, furious part of him wanted to refuse.

He wanted to keep his eyes lowered and continue the freeze-out even now, sitting bloodied and ruined inside Jungkook’s office. He wanted to prove that the man could not simply command his attention.

But Jimin guesses he's already pushed his luck enough.

Even with blood smeared across his mouth, gray grime streaked over his cheek, and his hair left in a sticky, disordered ruin, Jimin tilted his face upward with the same reckless, fiery defiance that Jungkook seemed to love so much.

Jungkook's chest expanded with one slow, heavy breath. His gaze tracked across Jimin's face with an intensity that felt almost physical.

Jungkook's gaze moved slowly across Jimin's face, taking in the blood beneath his nose, the split inside his lip, the swelling beginning along his cheek, and the breathless flush still burning beneath his skin.

Something savage shifted behind his dark eyes, something far too possessive and furious to belong to him. For several seconds, neither of them spoke, while Eric sat beside Jimin entirely forgotten in the margins of their quiet, violent war. Then, with visible effort, Jungkook straightened.

The emotion vanished from his face so abruptly that it was almost frightening.

He pulled his chair back but didn't sit. Instead, he remained standing behind the desk, resting one hand against the leather headrest as he looked between them.

"Explain."

Eric immediately leaned forward.

"I was sitting with my friends when he approached our table acting completely insane. He started threatening me, shoved me, and threw an entire cup of coffee into my face. Then he punched me repeatedly. There were witnesses everywhere."

Jimin let out a sharp, humorless laugh.

Eric twisted toward him.

“You think this is funny?”

“No,” Jimin said, his voice rough from the blood caught in his throat. “I think your sudden amnesia is though.”

“Silence.”

Jungkook didn't raise his voice but both of them turned toward him immediately.

“I will hear each account separately,” Jungkook said. “Neither of you will interrupt the other again.”

Jimin pressed his tongue against the torn inside of his cheek, swallowing down the argument burning at the back of his throat.

Jungkook's attention returned to Eric.

“Begin again. From the beginning.”

Eric shifted in his seat, attempting to straighten his soaked shirt with a dignity that no longer existed.

“I was eating breakfast with several other students,” he said carefully. “He approached our table and started causing a scene.”

“What caused him to approach you?”

“I don't know.”

Jungkook stared at him.

Eric's confidence faltered.

"You do not know," Jungkook repeated.

"He has always had a problem with me."

"That was not my question."

The room went quiet.

Jungkook leaned one hand against the desk.

"What were you discussing before Park approached?"

Eric glanced briefly at Jimin.

"Nothing important."

"Then repeating it should not be difficult."

Eric's jaw shifted.

"It was just... a joke."

"About?"

“The gala.”

Jungkook remained perfectly still.

“What about the gala?”

Eric hesitated long enough for the silence itself to become incriminating.

His eyes flickered toward Jimin before quickly darting back to Jungkook, searching the Director’s expression for some sign that he could still retreat from the accusation without looking like a coward. But Jungkook gave him absolutely nothing. He remained motionless behind the desk, his dark gaze fixed steadily on Eric’s face as the seconds dragged on.

“We were only talking about it” Eric finally muttered. “*Ce n’était rien de sérieux*. It wasn’t serious.”

Jungkook’s expression didn’t change.

“What did you say?”

Eric shifted uncomfortably in his chair, his fingers tightening around the damp fabric clinging to his thighs.

“I only said that...” He paused, swallowing hard. “That perhaps Park had not been chosen entirely because of his talent.”

Jimin’s fingers curled tightly around the ruined fabric resting over his thighs, his nails digging into his palms through the material.

Jungkook remained terrifyingly still.

“Continue.”

The quiet command made Eric’s face lose another shade of color.

“I—” Eric cleared his throat, glancing toward Jimin once more. “I do not remember the exact words.”

“Try.”

Jungkook’s voice was calm, but the single word carried enough menace to make Eric’s shoulders stiffen.

A thin sheen of sweat had begun to gather along the senior’s temple. He opened his mouth, closed it again, and shifted his swollen jaw as though the truth had become physically difficult to force past his teeth.

“I suggested there may have been...” His voice faltered. “*Une autre raison...*you selected him.”

Jungkook’s fingers slowly curled against the edge of the desk.

“What reason?”

Eric swallowed visibly.

“Director, I did not mean that—”

“What reason?”

The repeated question cut through the office with cold, surgical precision.

Eric's breathing quickened. He stared down at the floor between his shoes, his confidence rapidly collapsing beneath the unbearable weight of Jungkook's attention.

"I said that his relationship with you might be..." Eric began, but the sentence caught in his throat. "That the two of you may not be entirely..."

He trailed off again.

Jungkook leaned forward by the smallest fraction.

"Entirely what?"

Eric's lips parted, but no sound came out.

"*Je—*" He swallowed again, his voice dropping to a strained whisper. "*Je pensais que peut-être... votre relation n'était pas strictement professionnelle.*"

Jungkook's eyes darkened.

Jimin's stomach dropped so violently that nausea rolled through him. He stared down at the spreading red stains across his trousers, suddenly unable to look at either man.

The secret had always felt dangerous, but private.

Contained within locked offices, empty kitchens, and the space between Jungkook's body and his own.

Now it sat openly between all three of them.

Jimin waited for Jungkook to deny it.

He waited for a sharp dismissal, a furious accusation, or some perfectly worded administrative response that would make Eric sound ridiculous.

Jungkook didn't react.

“And what evidence,” he asked quietly, “do you possess to support that allegation?”

Eric's eyes flickered.

“I've seen things.”

“What things?”

Eric continued quickly, gaining momentum now that the accusation had been spoken aloud.

“Everyone notices that you treat him differently. He misses demonstrations, and you excuse it. He makes mistakes, and you give him additional chances. He stays in the practical kitchens after hours, and somehow you never notice when we do the same.”

Jungkook's face remained blank.

Eric leaned forward.

“And people have seen him leaving this office late at night.”

The silence changed.

Jimin noticed the smallest movement in Jungkook's hand. The fingers resting against the edge of the desk curled slowly inward.

"People," Jungkook repeated. "Who?"

"I'm not involving anyone else."

"How principled of you."

Eric flushed.

Jungkook moved toward the side of his desk and opened the top drawer. He removed a slim black folder, placed it on the surface, and pulled out a blank disciplinary form.

"Your personal suspicions do not authorize you to publicly accuse another student of exchanging sexual favors for academic advancement," he said. "Nor do they authorize comments concerning his nationality, his finances, or his family."

Eric stiffened.

"Your conduct falls under targeted harassment, defamation, disruption of academy operations, and behavior unbecoming of a student representing this institution."

"He hit me!" Eric shouted, gesturing violently toward Jimin. "Look at what he did to my face!"

Jungkook's eyes dropped briefly toward Eric's swollen jaw.

"I am looking at your face."

The flat reply silenced him.

Jungkook's gaze then shifted toward Jimin.

For the first time since the questioning began, his professional detachment cracked.

Only slightly.

His eyes moved over the blood beneath Jimin's nose, the scrape along his cheek, and the torn shoulder of his uniform. Something hot and terrifying flashed through his expression before disappearing beneath the mask once again.

"I am also looking at his," Jungkook continued. "Mr. Park will answer for his actions. That does not absolve you of yours."

"He threw the first punch."

Jungkook set the pen down.

"The dining hall contains multiple security cameras. Before bringing you here, I requested that the supervisor preserve the footage. The altercation was recorded from three separate angles."

The last of Eric's confidence drained away.

Although none of them would come away innocent, but Eric would no longer be able to reshape it into something clean and convenient.

Jungkook resumed writing.

"Effective immediately, you are suspended from all classes for the remainder of the academic year," Jungkook said, his voice perfectly calm. "Which means you will not be graduating with your peers."

Eric went completely still.

Jungkook tilted his head slightly, his expression unreadable.

“*Quel dommage,*” he murmured. “There is always next year.”

“What?” Eric surged to his feet so quickly that the chair scraped violently against the floor. “No.” His voice cracked with sudden panic. “Director, you cannot be serious! My family is attending. There will be chefs and recruiters from all over Europe—”

“You should have considered that before turning the dining hall into a public spectacle.”

“It was one argument!”

“It was sustained harassment followed by physical violence.”

Jungkook signed the bottom of the form with one sharp stroke.

“You will also be placed on disciplinary probation pending faculty review. You will provide a written statement by six o’clock this evening, and you will have no direct contact with Park Jimin until the review is complete.”

Eric’s hands tightened around the arms of his chair.

“And him?” he demanded, pointing toward Jimin. “He still gets to cook?”

Jungkook’s pen stopped moving as he slowly lifted his head.

The expression on his face turned so cold that even Jimin felt the temperature of the office plummet.

Eric's hand dropped, but the fury in his face only deepened. His chest rose and fell in quick, frantic pulls as he stared between them, his swollen jaw clenching hard enough to make the dark bruise beneath it pulse.

Then, with a bitter, humorless laugh, Eric leaned forward.

“ Je sais pourquoi il reçoit un traitement de faveur, ” he spat, his voice trembling with rage. *“ Je connais les heures supplémentaires, les portes fermées à clé... Ne me prenez pas pour un idiot. ”*

Jimin's entire body went rigid. He didn't need the words translated.

He understood enough by his tone.

Jungkook's face shifted.

It was not dramatic. There was no sudden shout or violent movement. But a dark, murderous shadow fell across his features, stripping away the last traces of administrative restraint. His shoulders tightened beneath his shirt, his fingers curling slowly against the mahogany desk as if he were physically stopping himself from reaching across it.

The sudden, suffocating tension told Jimin everything he needed to know.

Eric was dancing directly along the edge of a landmine.

“ Un mot de plus, ” Jungkook rumbled, his voice dropping into something dangerously quiet, *“ et je m'assure personnellement que vous ne mettrez plus jamais les pieds dans une cuisine en Europe. ”*

Jungkook's body had gone completely rigid, tense enough that it looked as if he might vault across the desk at any second. His dark eyes were fixed entirely on Eric, empty of warmth and burning

with an icy, controlled promise.

Any sensible person would have stopped.

Eric, however, seemed to have completely lost his mind.

The senior slammed both palms flat against Jungkook's desk, scattering several loose sheets of paper.

"Ce n'est pas juste!" Eric shrieked.

His face had transformed into an absolute mask of pure rage, the veins along his neck standing out as he spoke.

"It is not fair!" he shouted, his chest heaving. "I have worked myself to the bone for five years at this academy! I am at the top of my class! Do you have any idea who my father is?"

Jungkook didn't flinch.

He stood perfectly still behind the desk, his eyes dead and cold as he looked down at Eric's hands resting against the polished wood.

"Remove your hands from my desk."

Eric either didn't hear him or had become too furious to care.

"Mark my words, Director Jeon, this hypocrisy will not go unpunished!" he screamed.

He lifted one trembling hand and pointed directly toward Jimin again.

“You cannot remove me to protect your precious favorite ! People are going to start asking questions. They are going to wonder what exactly he did to earn those perfect marks!”

The words struck Jimin harder than Eric’s fist had.

His stomach twisted violently, a cold rush of humiliation spreading through his chest as his eyes dropped toward his lap. The blood beneath his nose suddenly felt scalding against his skin.

He could practically hear the dining hall again. The whispers, the laughter, the stunned silence as everyone waited for him to deny what Eric had said.

But before Jimin could react, Jungkook moved. His palm came down against the desk with a deafening crack. The scattered papers jumped beneath the impact.

“Enough.”

The single word shook through the office.

Eric froze.

Jungkook leaned forward slowly, placing both palms flat against the mahogany until only the width of the desk separated them. Every trace of warmth had vanished from his face.

“You appear to be under the impression that your family name grants you immunity from consequence,” Jungkook said, his voice smooth and terrifyingly controlled. “It does not.”

Eric’s lips parted.

Jungkook didn’t allow him to speak.

“You have publicly harassed another student. You have made defamatory accusations regarding his academic integrity. You initiated physical contact, disrupted academy operations, and have now threatened both a student and the administration of this institution inside my office.”

“I did not threaten—”

“You have also ignored three direct instructions.” Jungkook straightened. “Effective immediately, you are suspended from all practical instruction pending a formal faculty review.”

Eric went pale.

“No.”

“You will surrender your kitchen access card before leaving this room.”

“No, you cannot do that.”

“I just did.”

“My father funds part of this academy!”

“And he will be informed that his son was incapable of meeting its behavioral standards.”

Eric’s mouth fell open.

Jungkook signed the document with one hard, deliberate stroke before closing the folder.

“You will provide a written account of this incident by six o’clock this evening. You will have no direct or indirect contact with Park Jimin. That includes classrooms, kitchens, dormitories, messages, social platforms, or communication through another student.”

Eric stared at him in complete disbelief.

Jungkook’s eyes narrowed.

“And if one word concerning your allegations is repeated outside this office before the investigation is complete, your suspension will become an expulsion hearing.”

The threat hung heavily between them. Eric looked toward Jimin one final time, his expression twisted with hatred.

Jimin forced himself to meet the stare.

“This is not over,” Eric spat. “Watch and see! My father will see to it that he never steps foot into another kitchen in his life!”

Jimin began to rise from his chair.

“Sit down, Jimin.”

Jungkook’s command cracked instantly through the room.

Jimin dropped back into the leather seat, his chest heaving as Eric’s mouth curved into one last ugly sneer.

Jungkook stepped away from the desk and opened the office door.

“Leave.”

Eric remained still.

Jungkook’s expression didn't change.

“Before I call security and have you removed.”

That finally broke through whatever reckless fury remained.

Eric snatched his access card from his pocket and threw it onto the desk. The plastic struck the wood with a sharp clatter before sliding to a stop beside Jungkook’s hand.

Then he turned and stormed toward the exit.

The heavy door slammed behind him hard enough to rattle the framed certifications along the walls.

And then there were only two.

Jimin and Jungkook.

The accusation remained in the room long after Eric was gone.

He had thought Eric leaving would make it easier to breathe.

Instead, the office felt smaller than ever.

Jimin sat frozen in the low leather chair, staring down at the blood drying in dark, uneven spots across his trousers. His heart was still hammering from the confrontation, but the adrenaline that had carried him through the dining hall had begun to drain away, leaving his entire body weak, aching, and violently aware of the silence surrounding him.

He had expected Jungkook to speak immediately.

A cold reprimand.

Perhaps an explanation of exactly how badly Jimin had embarrassed himself and the academy.

But Jungkook said nothing.

The office remained suffocatingly still.

Jimin could hear the faint hum of the ventilation system above them. He could hear the soft ticking of the antique clock resting on the bookshelf. He could hear the uneven pull of his own breathing and the occasional, humiliating drip of blood slipping from his nose.

Jungkook still didn't move.

He stood behind the desk with one hand pressed flat against the dark mahogany, staring at the closed door Eric had just stormed through.

His shoulders were rigid beneath his black shirt. His head was slightly bowed, the dark fall of his hair casting a shadow over his eyes. The muscles along his forearm remained tightly flexed, veins raised beneath the skin as his fingers slowly curled against the wood.

Jimin watched him from beneath his lashes.

Nothing.

Not even a glance.

Maybe this was worse than anger.

Maybe Jungkook was finally realizing what a complete disaster Jimin had become. Maybe the fantasy had worn off the second he walked into the dining hall and found his precious student rolling around on the floor, bloodied and feral, in front of the entire academy.

Jimin's throat tightened.

He quickly looked away.

"I-I'm sorry," he muttered, his voice hoarse and bitter.

Jungkook remained silent.

The lack of response scraped against every exposed nerve in Jimin's body.

He pushed his tongue against the torn inside of his cheek, flinching at the sharp burst of pain.

"I know I messed up," he continued. "You don't have to stand there acting like I murdered someone though."

Still nothing.

Jimin's fingers tightened around the ruined fabric of his trousers.

The embarrassment began curdling back into anger.

“Actually, you know what? Forget it.”

He planted both hands against the arms of the chair and forced himself upright. The sudden movement sent a violent wave of dizziness through his skull, but he ignored it, blinking hard as the room tilted briefly around him.

“I’ll go to the nurse,” he said, reaching blindly for the front of his torn coat. “You can send me whatever punishment you decide on later. Suspension, probation, execution...whatever fits.”

Jimin took one step toward the door.

Jungkook moved.

He came around the desk so quickly that Jimin barely registered the blur of black fabric before a calloused hand clamped around his upper arm.

Jimin gasped.

With one sharp, powerful pull, Jungkook yanked him backward.

Jimin stumbled, his weak legs failing to catch up with the sudden movement. His body collided hard with Jungkook’s chest, the impact knocking a breathless sound out of him as the older man’s other arm locked around his waist to keep him upright.

For one suspended second, Jimin could do nothing but stare.

Jungkook’s face was inches from his own.

The cold look was gone.

Completely.

His dark eyes were wild with barely contained anger, his breathing heavy and uneven, the broad expanse of his chest rising violently against Jimin's. The hand around Jimin's arm remained firm enough to prevent him from pulling away, while the one at his waist pressed him tightly against the solid heat of Jungkook's body.

"What," Jungkook began, his voice breaking into a rough, furious rasp, "were you thinking?"

Jimin blinked.

"I—"

"What the hell were you thinking?"

The words exploded through the office.

Jimin flinched.

Jungkook's grip tightened as if the tiny reaction frightened him even more.

"You threw coffee in his face," Jungkook continued, his voice rising with each sentence. "You struck him repeatedly in front of the entire dining hall. You allowed him to drag you onto the floor like an animal while every student and faculty member in that building stood there watching!"

"He started it!"

"I do not care who started it!"

“Well, I do!”

Jimin shoved against Jungkook’s chest, but the man barely moved.

“He talked about my family,” Jimin snapped. “He talked about me like I was nothing. Like I was some stupid little charity case who only got chosen because I—”

“I heard what he said.”

“Then why are you yelling at me?”

“Because you could have been expelled!”

Jungkook’s voice cracked through the room with enough force to make Jimin go completely still.

The hand at Jimin’s waist flexed.

“You could have lost everything,” Jungkook said, his words coming faster now, stripped of all the measured precision that usually defined him. “Your placement. Your visa sponsorship. Your semester credits. Your future at this academy. Every single thing you have worked yourself sick to earn.”

Jimin’s lips parted, but Jungkook didn’t allow him to interrupt.

“And for what?” he demanded. “Because Eric said something we both know? Because he found the exact wound he knew would make you react and pressed his finger into it?”

Jimin’s face burned.

“You don’t understand.”

“I understand perfectly.”

“No, you don’t!” Jimin shoved him again, harder this time. “You weren’t the one sitting there while everyone stared!” Jimin shouted. “You weren’t the one being laughed at. You weren’t the one he called talentless and desperate and—”

“Stop it!”

Jungkook stared down at him, his dark eyes burning with something far more devastating than rage.

Fear.

“When I received word that a senior and a lower-classman were fighting in the dining hall, do you have any idea how quickly I ran?”

The sudden rawness of it emptied the rest of Jimin’s argument from his throat.

“I didn’t even have to ask who it was,” Jungkook continued, his chest rising harshly against Jimin’s. “I knew.”

Jimin blinked up at him.

“Of course it was you,” Jungkook said, a sharp, disbelieving breath escaping him. “No other student in this academy is reckless enough to risk months of work for something so fleeting.”

“I didn’t start it.”

“I do not care who started it!”

Jungkook's grip tightened around his arm. His gaze moved over his injuries again, frantic and disbelieving, as though he were only now allowing himself to truly see the swelling along Jimin's cheek, the torn shoulder of his coat, and the blood drying against his skin.

"You are so fucking stupid," Jungkook whispered.

Jimin's brows pulled together as the man continued.

"So completely incapable of thinking beyond the first impulse that enters your head."

Jimin's anger sparked again.

"Oh, fuck you."

"No." Jungkook's hand tightened even more, holding Jimin's gaze in place. "You will listen."

Jimin glared at him.

"You think defending yourself means destroying everything around you before anyone else gets the chance," Jungkook continued.

Jimin's breathing turned shallow. The words cut far too close.

"You don't know me that well," he muttered.

"I know you well enough."

"Clearly not well enough."

Jimin stumbled backward, nearly catching his heel against the leather chair before righting himself. His head throbbed violently from the movement, but humiliation and fury burned too hot inside him for the pain to matter.

“You think I don’t know I fucked up?” he snapped. “You think I don’t know everyone in this academy is probably talking about me right now?”

“Then perhaps you should have considered that before throwing a cup of coffee into another student’s face.”

“He deserved it.”

“That is not the point!”

“It is to me!”

Jimin’s voice cracked through the office. His hands curled into fists at his sides, reopening the torn skin across his knuckles.

“He stood there talking about my family, my upbringing, and everything I’ve worked for like it was some fucking joke. Then he told an entire dining hall that the only reason I was chosen for the gala was because I was fucking you!”

“And your brilliant solution was to prove that you have even less control than he accused you of having?”

Jimin recoiled as though Jungkook had struck him. For half a second, Jungkook’s expression shifted with regret.

But Jimin was already speaking.

“Okay. Fine.”

His voice came out low and trembling.

Jungkook's brow tightened. "What?"

"Fine," Jimin repeated, louder now as he threw both hands into the air. "I understand. I embarrassed you. I embarrassed the academy. I made myself look crazy in front of everyone. So, I'm not cooking anymore. Fine."

Jungkook went completely still.

Jimin laughed bitterly, blinking hard against the heat gathering behind his eyes.

"That's what this whole speech is about, right? You're taking me off the gala."

"I did not say that."

"You didn't have to." Jimin turned away, dragging a bloodied hand through his ruined hair. "I know. Eric gets suspended, and you have to punish me too, so no one thinks you're protecting me. So there. Fine. Take me off the list. Give it to someone who knows how to smile politely while people fuck them over."

"Jimin."

"Maybe Eric was right." His voice grew sharper, even as it began to break. "Maybe I never belonged there in the first place. Maybe-"

"Quiet!" Jungkook snapped pointing toward the floor between them, his expression furious and immovable. "You will stand in that gala kitchen. You will execute the menu you spent weeks developing. You will plate every course, face that panel, and prove to every person in that ballroom that you earned your position."

Jimin stared at him, stunned by the force behind the declaration.

“But the second it ends,” Jungkook continued, his voice dropping into something much colder, “do not expect a single offer from me.”

The words landed like a fist directly against Jimin’s chest.

“Do not expect me to recommend you for one of my restaurants. Do not expect a position in Paris, Seoul, New York, or anywhere else my name could open a door for you.”

Jimin’s lips parted soundlessly.

“You want to behave as though your future is disposable?” Jungkook demanded. “Then I will not attach my reputation to it.”

Jimin’s eyes began to burn.

“So that’s it?” Jimin whispered. “One mistake, and suddenly you don’t believe in me anymore?”

“One mistake?” Jungkook let out a harsh, incredulous laugh. “This was not an over-salted sauce, Jimin. You assaulted another student in front of witnesses. You risked expulsion, your visa, your credits, and every opportunity that could have come from this academy.”

“He hit me too!”

“And if he had injured you more seriously?” Jungkook shot back. “If your hand had broken? If you had struck your head hard enough that you could no longer stand at a stove next week? What then?”

Jimin swallowed painfully.

Jungkook stepped closer, his voice becoming rougher with every word.

“You expect me to recommend someone who allows one cruel man to control him so completely? Someone who can be provoked into destroying his own career before it even begins?”

“I-I wasn’t thinking.”

“That's the problem!”

The shout rang against the paneled walls.

Jimin flinched.

“You do not think. You feel something, and then you act. You become angry, so you yell. You become afraid, so you set the whole room on fire!”

Jimin’s throat closed.

“You don’t know what you’re talking about.” Jimin’s eyes filled despite his desperate effort to hold the tears back. “You think this is easy for me?” he asked, his voice thinning. “Everyone gets to look at you and see some untouchable prodigy . No matter what happens, you’re still Director Jeon. You still have your restaurants and your stars and everyone kissing your ass.”

Jungkook’s jaw tightened.

“But me?” Jimin pressed a hand against his own chest. “One rumor, one fight, one mistake, and suddenly everything I’ve done becomes questionable. They won't see my hard work anymore.”

“And that’s exactly why you should’ve walked away,” Jungkook said.

“I couldn’t.”

“Yes, you could’ve.”

“No, I couldn’t!”

Jimin’s voice broke into something raw and nearly hysterical. His chest heaved as he stared up at Jungkook, tears already beginning to burn behind his eyes.

“Because he was saying all of it out loud,” Jimin shouted. “Everything I’ve been terrified people would think since I fucking arrived here. He said it in front of everyone, and you weren’t there.”

Jungkook froze.

“You weren’t there,” Jimin repeated, quieter now. The anger drained from his voice, leaving only hurt behind. “I was by myself. Everyone was staring at me, waiting for me to deny it, and I knew that if I did, I’d be lying.”

Jungkook’s fury didn’t disappear, but it shifted. Something painful moved behind his dark eyes as he watched Jimin lower his head and wipe beneath his nose with the back of his wrist, smearing the blood farther across his skin.

“So keep your offers,” Jimin muttered bitterly. “I don’t need you to hand me a career because you feel sorry for me.”

Jungkook stared at him for one long, terrible second. Then his expression hardened with a cold, deliberate resolve that made Jimin’s stomach twist.

“Then if you intend to build a career for yourself,” Jungkook said, “you need to learn how to lie.”

Jimin’s head snapped up. “What?”

“This.” Jungkook stepped backward, placing several feet of deliberate distance between them before motioning sharply toward the empty space separating their bodies. “You pretend this is nothing. Everything. Whatever we did alone. The conversation we had after the rest of the academy went home meant nothing. If anyone asks whether there’s something between us, you say no.”

Jimin stared at him.

Jungkook continued before he could respond.

“You don’t hesitate. You don’t look frightened or angry. You don’t stand silently while an entire room decides your guilt for you.”

Jimin’s face tightened. “You want me to act like none of it happened?”

“I want you to protect yourself.”

“By pretending it meant nothing to me?”

“By understanding that the truth won’t protect you,” Jungkook replied. His jaw clenched visibly, but his voice remained hard. “You want a serious career? You want restaurants, awards, invitations, and positions in kitchens that’ll examine every weakness you possess? Then forget this.”

He gestured between them again.

“Forget what I said to you. Forget what happened behind this door. Forget every moment that made you believe you could look at me differently from the rest of your instructors.”

Jimin’s eyes began to water.

Jungkook noticed but he kept going anyway.

“You stand in front of them and tell them it meant nothing.”

“And if it doesn’t mean nothing?” Jimin whispered.

Something fractured behind Jungkook’s eyes for one fleeting second.

Then it vanished.

“It has to.”

Jimin recoiled as though the words had physically struck him.

“If you can’t say that convincingly,” Jungkook continued, his tone becoming even colder, “then every plate you serve from this point forward will be questioned. Every opportunity you receive will be credited to something else instead of your own talent.”

Jimin’s voice trembled. “So that’s what you think too?”

“No,” Jungkook said immediately. “That’s what they’ll think.”

“B-but you’re asking me to forget everything.”

“I’m ordering you to protect yourself.”

Jimin went still.

Jungkook lowered his voice, though it became no less severe.

“You think honesty will save you? It won’t. They’ll take the truth, reshape it, and use it to make every achievement you’ve ever earned look purchased.”

“And you can pretend?” Jimin asked, his voice thinning. “You can stand there and act like none of it matters?”

Jungkook said nothing.

The silence answered for him.

Jimin let out a small, broken laugh. “Right. Of course you can.”

“You think this is easy for me?”

“You’re making it look easy.”

“Because I need you to believe me.” Jungkook stepped closer again, his voice dropping into a low, brutal whisper. “I need you angry enough to leave this office and never hesitate again when someone asks. Your feelings don’t matter to the people waiting to use them against you.”

Jimin’s face crumpled slightly.

Jungkook’s fingers twitched at his sides, but he didn’t reach for him.

“So say it,” Jungkook commanded.

Jimin stared at him through the tears gathering along his lashes. “Say what?”

“That this means nothing.”

Jimin’s lips parted, but no words came.

“Say it, Jimin.”

“This means nothing,” Jimin whispered.

“Again.”

Jimin swallowed hard as a tear slipped down his cheek. “This means nothing.”

“Convince me.”

Jimin wiped furiously at his face and lifted his chin, forcing his voice into something steadier.

“There’s nothing between Director Jeon and me,” he said, stumbling slightly over the words. “He means nothing to me.”

Jungkook stared at him.

“And everything else?” Jungkook asked.

Jimin’s breathing shook.

“There was no everything else.”

The sentence struck both of them.

Jungkook's face remained perfectly still, but his hands clenched tightly at his sides.

Then he gave one short nod.

“Good.”

Jimin looked as though he'd been slapped.

Jungkook turned away before the expression could break whatever resolve remained inside him. He rounded the desk, sat down, and pulled open the top drawer. The black disciplinary folder scraped softly against the mahogany as he removed it and placed it in front of him.

Jimin's stomach dropped.

Jungkook opened the folder, removed a blank form, and picked up his pen.

“Park Jimin,” he began, his voice changing completely. Every trace of private emotion disappeared, replaced by the cold, measured cadence of Director Jeon delivering an official judgment. “Effective immediately, you're placed on formal disciplinary probation for the remainder of the academic year.”

Jimin stood rigidly before the desk, tears sliding silently down his face.

Jungkook lowered his eyes to the form and began writing.

“You'll complete forty hours of service under the dining hall staff, beginning the morning after the gala. You're prohibited from entering any practical kitchen outside scheduled classes or supervised gala preparation.”

The pen moved across the page in firm, deliberate strokes.

Jimin's fingers curled weakly against his thighs.

"You'll surrender your after-hours access card before leaving this office," Jungkook continued. "You'll have no direct or indirect contact with Eric until the faculty investigation has concluded. Any further physical altercation, threat, or disruption will result in immediate suspension and removal from the gala."

Jimin tried to breathe quietly, but a small, broken hitch escaped him.

Jungkook's pen paused.

Only for a fraction of a second.

Then it continued.

"Your gala placement remains intact," he said. "You earned that position before this incident, and you'll fulfill it. However, you won't receive any private preparation, additional access, or individual instruction outside the approved schedule."

Another tear slipped over Jimin's cheek though he didn't wipe this one away.

Jungkook signed the bottom of the form with one sharp stroke, closed the folder, and pushed it across the desk. The black leather stopped near the edge.

"There," Jungkook said.

His voice remained cold, but his grip around the pen had tightened so severely that his knuckles had gone pale.

“Is that what you wanted?”

Jimin stared at the folder through blurred vision. He tried to answer, but his throat had closed too tightly.

Jungkook waited.

Jimin reached into the pocket of his ruined trousers and pulled out his academy access card. His hand shook so badly that the plastic nearly slipped from his fingers before he managed to place it beside the folder.

The quiet click against the wood sounded final.

“I didn’t...” Jimin whispered, but the rest of the sentence died in his throat.

Jungkook’s expression flickered.

“You demanded that I give you no handouts,” Jungkook said.

“I know.”

“Then why are you crying?”

The question was quieter than everything else he’d said.

That made it hurt worse.

Jimin gave a trembling, humorless laugh and wiped his face with the heel of his bloodied hand.

“Because you’re really good at pretending.”

Something broke across Jungkook’s expression, but he quickly lowered his eyes to the paperwork before Jimin could fully see it.

Jimin remained standing in front of the desk for another long second, waiting despite himself. Waiting for Jungkook to take it back, waiting for him to admit that it had only been an act, waiting for any sign that the words had hurt him too.

None came.

Jungkook closed the folder completely, aligned it neatly with the edge of his desk, and said, “You are dismissed.” The finality of the words hollowed Jimin out. His mouth parted slightly, but no response came at first.

Eventually, he managed one stiff nod.

“Yes, Chef.”

The title visibly tightened something in Jungkook’s face, but Jimin had already turned toward the door.

“Go to the infirmary,” Jungkook said behind him, still refusing to look up. “Have your nose, hand, and head examined before returning to your dormitory.” Jimin wrapped his fingers around the brass handle and answered quietly.

“I will.”

Jimin managed to walk past two offices before the tears began falling too quickly to hide. By the time he reached the empty stairwell, his breathing had broken into painful, uneven gasps. He gripped the cold railing with one bloodied hand and pressed the other over his mouth, desperately trying to smother the sob that tore out of him.



By the time Jimin returned to the dormitory, the nurse had already cleaned the blood from his face, taped two of his swollen fingers together, and confirmed that his nose was not broken. He had a mild concussion, several bruises, and strict instructions to rest, avoid screens, and return immediately if the nausea or dizziness worsened.

Jimin had nodded through all of it.

He had answered every question correctly. His name. The date. Where he was. What had happened.

Physically, he was fine.

At least, that was what everyone kept telling him.

But as he pushed open the dormitory door, Jimin felt as though someone had reached inside his chest and scraped him completely hollow.

Taehyung was sitting on the edge of his own bed when he entered, still wearing the trousers from his uniform and a loose shirt he had clearly thrown on in a hurry. He had probably been waiting there for hours. His phone rested forgotten beside him, and the second the door opened, his eyes lifted anxiously toward Jimin's face.

Jimin didn't say anything.

Neither did Taehyung.

The room remained painfully quiet as Jimin stepped inside and allowed the door to close behind him. His movements were slow and strangely mechanical, as though his body had become something separate from him, operating only through a list of basic instructions.

He peeled the torn chef's coat from his shoulders and let it fall directly onto the floor. The white fabric landed in a crumpled heap beside his shoes, stained with dried blood, coffee, antiseptic, and gray smears from the dining hall tile. His undershirt followed. Then his trousers. He stepped out of everything without shame or urgency, standing in the middle of the room in nothing but his underwear and the fresh bandages wrapped around his hand.

Taehyung watched from the bed.

His face looked pale and frightened, his lips parting several times as though he wanted to say something but could not decide which question would hurt the least.

Jimin gave him nothing.

He shuffled toward his bed, pulled the blanket back, and lowered himself onto the mattress. He didn't bother changing into pajamas. He just turned onto his side, pulled the covers over his bare shoulders, and stared at the blank wall.

Then he lay there.

And he lay there.

And, after that, he lay there some more.

Hours passed without Jimin properly registering them. The sunlight outside the window slowly drained from pale afternoon gold into a murky blue, then disappeared completely. At some point, Taehyung quietly picked up the ruined uniform from the floor. At another, he placed a glass of water on the bedside table and whispered that Jimin needed to drink because of the concussion.

Jimin didn't answer.

He occasionally closed his eyes, though he was not sure whether he actually slept. His thoughts didn't settle long enough for rest. They drifted in and out of focus, repeating fragments of the office conversation until the words no longer sounded like language.

This means nothing.

There was no everything else.

Sometimes, the memory came with Jungkook's voice and other times, it came in Jimin's own.

Both versions hurt equally.

The following morning, Taehyung tried again. He sat carefully on the edge of Jimin's mattress and held out a piece of toast on a small plate.

"You have to eat something," he murmured. "Even if it's just half."

Jimin stared at the wall.

After several minutes, Taehyung placed the plate on the nightstand beside the untouched glass of water and quietly left for class.

When he returned hours later, the toast had not moved.

Neither had Jimin.

For two days, Jimin remained almost entirely in bed.

He got up only when his bladder began to ache badly enough that ignoring it became impossible. Even then, he moved like a ghost, shuffling toward the bathroom with the blanket draped around

his shoulders, using the toilet, washing his hands, and returning to the exact same position beneath the covers.

He didn't shower and he certainly didn't touch his phone.

He didn't check the academy group chats, though the constant vibration against the bedside table told him the fight was still spreading through the school in increasingly dramatic versions.

Taehyung eventually turned the phone off for him.

Jimin barely noticed.

Maybe it was the concussion.

The nurse had warned him that headaches, fatigue, and emotional changes were normal. His skull still throbbed whenever he sat upright too quickly, and sometimes the room tilted when he rolled onto his back.

Maybe that was all it was.

Maybe the strange emptiness inside him was just the aftermath of being struck, thrown onto a hard floor, and flooded with enough adrenaline to keep his body shaking for hours.

Or maybe it was the sudden, horrifying realization that he had wasted his entire life dreaming of becoming a chef only to discover that the entire industry was complete shit.

He had spent years imagining France as the center of everything beautiful. He had pictured brilliant kitchens, perfect plates, gleaming copper pans, and severe instructors who would push him toward greatness. He had convinced himself that if he worked hard enough, sacrificed enough, and made himself talented enough, he would eventually reach some glittering destination where all the pain became worthwhile.

Instead, he had found exhaustion.

Students who measured worth by family names and bank accounts.

A Director who could make him feel like the most extraordinary person in the world one night and dismiss him like an inconvenience the next.

Or maybe— and this possibility was somehow the most humiliating of all —it was simply heartbreak.

A very, very, very, very painful heartbreak.

Jimin hated that word.

It felt too dramatic. Too soft. Too adolescent for something as ugly and consuming as what had settled inside his ribs. Heartbreak belonged in cheesy romance movies and terrible pop songs. It belonged to teenagers crying into pillows over people they had dated for three months if that.

It didn't belong to him.

He and Hobi used to laugh about this exact kind of thing.

Years ago, sprawled across Hobi's bedroom floor with a bowl of popcorn between them, they had watched *Twilight* and mocked Bella relentlessly when she sat in the same chair for months, staring blankly out the window as the seasons changed around her.

Jimin had laughed so hard that his stomach hurt.

He remembered throwing popcorn at the television and shouting, "*Girl, stand up! He is not worth all that!*"

Hobi had nearly fallen off the bed, laughing as he agreed that no man—human, vampire, or otherwise—could ever make either of them behave that pathetically.

Now, lying in the same position for the second straight day, Jimin wished he could take every word back.

Sometimes a person didn't lie still because they believed the other person deserved that much grief. Sometimes they lay there because movement required imagining a future, and every version of the future had suddenly become unbearable.

Getting out of bed meant returning to the academy.

Returning to the academy meant facing the kitchen.

Facing the kitchen meant preparing for the gala.

And preparing for the gala meant standing before Jungkook as though none of it had mattered.

As though the late nights had been nothing.

As though the touch, the quiet praise, the kisses in the dark, and every rare glimpse of tenderness had been nothing more than something Jimin had imagined because he wanted to feel special.

There was no everything else.

On the second evening, Taehyung returned from class and found Jimin in exactly the same position he had left him that morning. He stood beside the bed for a long time. Then, without asking permission, he climbed beneath the covers and lay down behind him.

He didn't ask what happened in Jungkook's office. He didn't mention the rumors. He didn't tell Jimin to get up, eat, shower, or stop being so damn dramatic.

He simply pressed his forehead between Jimin's shoulder blades and wrapped one careful arm around his waist.

For several minutes, Jimin remained completely still.

Then his face tightened. A small, broken sound escaped him before he could swallow it down.

Taehyung's arm tightened immediately.

That was all it took.

Jimin curled inward beneath the blanket as the grief he had spent two days holding completely motionless finally tore through him. He covered his mouth with his bandaged hand, trying to muffle the breathless sobs that shook his bruised ribs and sent fresh pain pulsing through his head.

Taehyung held him through all of it without asking for an explanation.

And for the first time since Jungkook had dismissed him from the office, Jimin allowed himself to admit the truth.

It had never meant nothing.

That was exactly why it hurt this badly.



The gala approached without much of Jimin's permission.

One moment, he was lying beneath the covers with the curtains drawn, convinced time had slowed into something thick and endless. The next, Taehyung was standing beside his bed, quietly reminding him that there were only two days left.

Two days.

Jimin stared at the ceiling for a long time after that.

He had not realized how much time had passed. The hours had blurred together so completely that morning and night had become nearly indistinguishable, separated only by the faint changes in light leaking through the curtains and the sound of Taehyung coming and going from class.

But yesterday, Jimin had given life another try.

A very small try.

He had pushed the blanket away and sat up on the edge of the mattress, waiting for the room to stop tilting before placing his feet on the floor. He had walked to the window and pulled the curtains open, squinting against the afternoon light as though he had been hidden underground for several years instead of two days.

Outside, the academy continued existing without him.

Students crossed the courtyard in white uniforms, their knife kits slung over their shoulders. Delivery trucks moved through the service entrance. Somewhere in the distance, church bells rang over the city, soft and entirely unaware that Park Jimin's life had temporarily collapsed.

He had stood there for five minutes.

Then he had showered.

The water had stung the fading scratches along his face and made the bruises across his ribs ache, but he stayed beneath it until the last traces of dried blood, antiseptic, and despair had washed down the drain.

Afterward, he had put on clean clothes, walked to the small bakery near the dormitory, and bought a donut covered in powdered sugar.

He ate half of it.

Then he returned to bed.

It was not much of a comeback, but it was something.

He had seen better days, and he would see better days again.

He was sure of it.

At least, he was trying very hard to be.

There were only two days left until the gala, which meant there were only two days left until he had to return to campus and stand beneath the full weight of everyone's attention.

He would have to walk through the academy knowing that every student had heard some version of the fight. He would have to endure the whispering, the staring, and the sudden silences that would follow whenever he entered a room.

He would have to face the same students who had watched him bleed across the dining hall floor.

He would have to stand before a room filled with celebrated chefs, wealthy sponsors, instructors, alumni, and recruiters, all of them prepared to examine every decision he made.

And sitting among the panelists would be Jungkook.

Cold, unreadable, and perfectly composed.

Jimin would have to look at him as though nothing had ever happened.

Jimin's stomach twisted.

He rolled onto his side and pulled the blanket higher over his shoulder, though the room was not cold.

The gala had once been the brightest point in his future.

For months, he had imagined the room, the guests, the polished silverware, and the terrifying moment his plate would be placed before some of the greatest chefs in Europe. The thought had always filled him with a sharp, intoxicating excitement.

Now it made him feel sick.

He was expected to walk into the most important night of his academic life with a bruised face, a pounding head, and a heart that felt like someone had scraped it raw.

Since then, Jimin had developed a deeply personal vendetta against Jungkook, mostly because there was nothing else he could do with all the hurt still rotting inside him. He hated his face. He hated his stupid voice and the calm, commanding way it could still make his chest tighten even when he wanted nothing more than to forget it.

He hated that he had ever come to the academy, hated that he had allowed the man to become so deeply tangled into his mind, and especially hated that he was now mildly depressed because of him.

Hating Jungkook felt productive. It gave the pain somewhere to go, something sharp and simple to become instead of the humiliating heartbreak it actually was. As far as Jimin was concerned, it was the healthiest thing he could do for himself.

He was sure Eric had already launched some dramatic smear campaign of his own, whispering through the academy halls and twisting the fight into whatever version made him look the most innocent.

Under any other circumstances, the thought would have sent Jimin into another rage. Right now, however, Eric and his rumors sat very low on the list of things capable of ruining his life. Jimin had a gala in two days, a room full of Michelin-starred chefs waiting to judge him, and one cold, infuriating Director he would soon have to face as though the sight of him didn't still make something inside Jimin ache.



“So...” Taehyung began later that afternoon, stretching the word out as he leaned back against the edge of his desk and studied Jimin from across the room. “Any idea what you’re cooking?”

Jimin was sitting on the floor beside his bed with his knees loosely pulled toward his chest, staring down at a faint scuff mark on the wooden floorboards. He gave a small shrug.

“What?” Taehyung pressed, lifting one hand beside his face in a dramatic oath. “I promise I won’t tell anyone. Scout’s honor.”

He laughed lightly, clearly hoping the sound would pull something out of Jimin, but Jimin only looked up at him for a brief second before lowering his gaze again. The silence stretched long enough for Taehyung’s smile to falter, though he recovered quickly, pushing away from the desk and beginning to pace slowly across the room with exaggerated thoughtfulness.

“Okayyy,” he said, tapping one finger against his chin. “If my name was Park Jimin, and I had been bedridden and nearly mute for several days, what would make me happy?”

Jimin said nothing.

“Money?” Taehyung guessed. “No. Too obvious. A shopping spree? Maybe, but you’d have to actually leave the room.” He glanced toward the ceiling as if considering the matter very seriously.

“A very planned and dramatic assassination of Eric?” Taehyung narrowed his eyes, still pretending to think. “And...” he added slowly, drawing the word out with obvious mischief, “maybe Director Jeon too, if we’re lucky.”

Jimin’s head snapped up so quickly that a small ache pulsed through his temple.

Taehyung froze, then gave him an innocent smile.

“Good,” Taehyung said, grinning. “He’s alive.”

Jimin looked away again, but there was the faintest twitch at the corner of his mouth.

Taehyung noticed it but wisely chose not to make a big deal out of it. Instead, he crossed the room and lowered himself onto the floor across from Jimin, folding his legs beneath him.

“See?” he said, softer now. “Already better.”

“I’m not better.”

“I didn’t say healed. I said better.”

Jimin let out a quiet breath through his nose, his fingers worrying at the loose thread hanging from his sweatpants.

Taehyung watched him for a moment before continuing. “Seriously, though. You don’t have to tell me the whole menu. I know it’s probably under some dramatic academy secrecy agreement sealed with blood and Michelin stars. Just tell me you have something.”

Jimin looked down at his hands. The bandages were gone now, but the skin across his knuckles remained raw and pink, and two of his fingers were still slightly stiff when he flexed them.

“I had something,” he murmured.

Taehyung’s brows pulled together. “Had?”

“I don’t know anymore.”

The playful edge faded from Taehyung’s face.

Jimin kept his eyes fixed on his hands.

“I knew exactly what I wanted before,” he continued, his voice quiet and distant. “Every course. Every flavor. The plating. I could see all of it perfectly in my head.”

“And now?”

“Now it all feels... stupid.”

Taehyung frowned. “Your menu is not stupid.”

“You haven’t even seen it.”

“I’ve watched you work on it for months. That’s enough.”

Jimin gave a weak, humorless laugh. “That doesn’t mean it’s good.”

“No,” Taehyung said, leaning forward slightly. “But it means you believed in it.”

Jimin swallowed.

“I don’t know if I believe in any of it anymore,” he admitted.

Taehyung studied him for a long moment, then reached out and nudged the toe of Jimin’s sock with his own.

“Then don’t believe in all of it today.”

Jimin looked up.

“Believe in one part,” Taehyung continued. “One sauce. One garnish. One annoying little component that takes the cake and makes everyone else want to throw themselves into the Seine.”

Despite himself, Jimin’s mouth twitched. He lowered his gaze again, but the silence between them felt a little less empty than before.

Taehyung rested his chin in his palm. “So,” he added, bringing a trace of mischief back into his voice, “are you going to tell me what that one part is, or do I need to begin planning the double assassination?”

Jimin finally let out a small, exhausted laugh.

“Fine,” he murmured.

Taehyung’s eyes lit up.

“Now we’re getting somewhere.”



For exposure therapy, as Taehyung had so confidently called it, he suggested they take a short walk through the academy gardens.

Nothing dramatic. Nothing ambitious. Just one slow lap around the stone path, five minutes of fresh air, and then they could return to the dorm before Jimin decided life was terrible again.

Jimin had agreed begrudgingly, mostly because he knew Taehyung was right. He couldn't stay hidden beneath his blankets until the gala. Eventually, he would have to return to campus, and when he did, there would be no slipping quietly through the halls with his head down.

Better to face a few people now, Taehyung had argued, than freeze in front of hundreds later.

What Taehyung had conveniently failed to mention was that he had chosen the exact moment between afternoon classes, when nearly the entire student body flooded from the academic buildings at once.

The second Jimin stepped outside, he knew they had made a mistake.

This was not one of those dramatic moments in movies where a nervous character walked into a room, imagined everyone staring, and whispered, Why do I feel like people are looking at me?

No.

People were actually staring at him.

Openly.

Jimin barely made it three steps past the dorm entrance before the nearest group of students went quiet. Their conversation stopped so abruptly that it would have been comical under any other circumstance. Four pairs of eyes moved over him at once, tracking the oversized gray T-shirt hanging nearly to his thighs, the loose plaid pajama pants he had not bothered changing out of, and the yellowing bruise still visible along the side of his face.

One of them leaned toward another and whispered something behind a raised hand.

The girl beside him laughed.

Jimin's stomach twisted though he kept walking.

Beside him, Taehyung straightened slightly, his playful confidence immediately draining away as he realized that the reception was considerably worse than he had predicted.

"Do not look at them," he murmured under his breath.

"I'm not," Jimin replied tightly, though his eyes had already caught another group standing near the fountain.

They weren't even pretending to be discreet.

Two upperclassmen watched him approach with expressions of undisguised fascination. One nudged the other with his elbow before both of them turned their heads, whispering quickly. The second student looked toward Jimin again, eyes dropping to his bruised cheek.

Jimin felt suddenly, violently exposed.

He had left the room without styling his hair. Without putting on a proper outfit. Without doing anything that might have made him feel remotely protected from the attention. His shirt hung

loosely from his shoulders, his pajama trousers dragged slightly beneath his slippers, and the fading marks from the fight remained clearly visible against his skin.

He looked exactly how he felt.

The academy courtyard, usually bright and beautiful beneath the summer sun, felt more like a stage. Students streamed between the stone buildings in their spotless uniforms, carrying notebooks and knife rolls, while Jimin shuffled among them looking like he had wandered out of a hospital ward.

Another whisper followed him.

Then another.

He could not make out every word, but certain pieces reached him clearly enough.

“...the dining hall...”

“...Eric said...”

“...Director Jeon...”

Someone laughed again.

Jimin stopped walking.

Taehyung immediately stopped beside him.

For one frightening second, Jimin’s mind went completely blank. The surrounding students blurred at the edges, their voices blending into one low, ugly hum. His chest tightened, and every instinct

inside him screamed to turn around, run back to the dorm, lock the door, and crawl beneath the covers until the gala passed without him.

Taehyung's hand closed carefully around his wrist.

"Keep moving," he whispered.

A group of students crossed the path directly in front of them, slowing noticeably as they passed. One of the boys looked at Jimin, then murmured something in French that made the other two grin.

Jimin's fingers curled.

"No," Tae whispered quietly.

Jimin turned his head.

Taehyung's expression had lost all traces of humor. His eyes were sharp, serious, and fixed completely on Jimin rather than the surrounding crowd.

"You are not giving them another scene," he said. "That's what they want."

Jimin swallowed hard.

"They're laughing at me."

"I know."

The honesty hurt more than a gentle lie would have.

Taehyung tightened his hold around Jimin's wrist.

The courtyard still felt hostile. The whispers had not stopped, and several students continued watching them with shameless curiosity. Nothing about the situation had improved.

Taehyung stayed close enough that their shoulders brushed as they continued toward the garden path. He didn't release Jimin's wrist until they passed through the low iron gate and the noise of the courtyard softened behind the tall hedges.

Even then, Jimin could still feel the attention clinging to his back.

The garden was quieter, though not empty. A few students sat beneath the trees with notebooks spread across their laps, and every single one of them looked up when Jimin and Taehyung entered.

Jimin nearly laughed.

It was a dry, miserable sound that barely left his throat.

"This is going terribly."

Taehyung glanced around at the staring students and grimaced.

"I thought it would be like ripping off a bandage."

"It feels more like you ripped off skin."

Taehyung winced. "That is fair."

Jimin continued down the stone path, crossing his arms tightly over his chest. His head still ached faintly, and the warm sunlight felt too bright against his eyes, but he kept walking.

They reached the old fountain at the center of the garden before Taehyung spoke again.

“For what it is worth,” he said, “most of these people are only staring because their lives are boring.”



That night, after Jimin was absolutely certain Taehyung had disappeared into the shower, he finally turned his phone back on.

The screen immediately exploded with notifications.

Missed calls. Text messages. Group chat mentions. Social media alerts stacked so densely across the lock screen that Jimin could barely see the wallpaper beneath them. His phone vibrated continuously in his hand, catching up on two days of silence with an almost vindictive enthusiasm.

Jimin stared at it for a long moment.

Then, against every reasonable instinct he possessed, he opened the academy’s student page.

The video was the first thing he saw.

It sat directly at the top of the feed, already carrying several thousand views beneath a dramatic caption written in French. The thumbnail was terribly dark and grainy, caught from the far side of the dining hall by someone whose hands had clearly been shaking with excitement. Even through the blur, Jimin could make out his own body on the floor and the unmistakable white flash of Eric’s ruined shirt beneath him.

His stomach tightened.

Jimin clicked play.

The footage began halfway through the argument.

The audio was nearly useless—mostly shrieking students, chairs scraping, and someone repeatedly shouting for them to stop—but the image was clear enough to follow. Eric lunged first. Jimin stumbled into the table. Coffee flew through the air in a dark, dramatic arc.

Then everything became a blur of limbs.

Jimin watched himself grab Eric by the front of his shirt and drive him backward. He watched the two of them crash onto the floor. He watched himself climb directly on top of the older student and punch the absolute shit out of him.

Once.

Twice.

Again.

A small, deeply inappropriate smirk tugged at the corner of Jimin's mouth.

He had to admit; he looked surprisingly heroic.

He replayed that section.

Only once.

Maybe twice.

Then the camera swung wildly toward the entrance of the dining hall.

Jungkook appeared.

Even through the terrible quality, the change in him was immediate. His frame cut through the crowd with terrifying speed, students scattering before he even reached them. He grabbed Jimin first, hauling him off Eric with one arm before turning toward the older student with a look so dark that the blurry footage somehow still captured it.

Jimin's smirk disappeared.

He paused the video.

The frozen image showed Jungkook's hand wrapped firmly around his upper arm, his body positioned slightly in front of Jimin's as though shielding him from Eric without realizing it.

His thumb hovered over the screen before slowly moving toward the comments.

The page buffered for several seconds as the app automatically translated the French responses into English. A little spinning circle appeared in the center of the screen, turning endlessly while Jimin's pulse grew louder in his ears.

He almost closed it.

Almost.

Then the comments loaded.

The way he climbed on top of him??? Insane.

I know violence is wrong, but man, Eric had this coming.

Jimin's mouth twitched faintly.

He scrolled.

This is what happens when the academy admits unstable Americans.

The tiny amusement vanished.

Another comment sat directly beneath it.

Eric said Park attacked him because he exposed the truth about Director Jeon.

Jimin's thumb stopped his chest tightened.

He continued scrolling.

Everyone already knows Park gets private lessons after hours. This only confirms it.

Why else would a first-year student be chosen over seniors?

He is talented, though. Have any of you actually tasted his food?

Talent does not explain sleeping with your teacher.

Jimin's breathing became shallower.

The translations appeared one after another, cold and clean across the screen.

Watch the end. Jeon looks like he wants to kill Eric.

Maybe Eric was telling the truth.

Jimin scrolled farther, bracing himself for something even worse.

Instead, one comment caught his eye.

The profile picture belonged to a female student he recognized from one of his classes. He couldn't remember her name, but he'd seen her several times near the pastry stations, always wearing bright clips in her hair and talking too loudly during demonstrations.

Her comment read:

***So what? If I had the chance to smash, I would too. Don't be jealous he's cute and talented.
#TeamJimin***

Jimin blinked as he read over it again.

The comment had nearly three hundred likes.

Two hundred ninety-eight.

Three hundred and one.

Three hundred and five.

The number continued climbing right in front of him as more students reacted.

For the first time since opening the page, something warm stirred beneath the heavy ache in Jimin's chest. The corners of his mouth lifted before he could stop them.

Beneath the comment, other students had begun agreeing.

I support women's rights and Jimin's wrongs.

Why was everyone mad? Let him cook.

Everyone is so focused on whether they smashed and not enough on HOW Park managed to make that terrifying man like him.

Park didn't sleep his way to the gala. If anything, he slept with Jeon and still had to make consommé at six in the morning.

If sleeping with Jeon was an option, this academy would have a waiting list longer than admissions.

Also, Jimin won. Badly.

Jimin's smile widened by the smallest fraction.

Maybe the entire academy didn't hate him.

And apparently, at least three hundred and five people believed he was cute enough to justify poor decision-making.

Considering the week he had endured, Jimin decided he would take it.



Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

Hi everyone! I'm so sorry for the delay! Getting settled into college and working have been a pain in the ass but alas... here's another chapter!

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)



The email arrived the afternoon before the gala.

Jimin was sitting cross-legged near the edge of his bed, staring halfheartedly at the handwritten menu notes spread across his lap. Pages covered nearly every available space around him. Some had sketches drawn in the margins. Others had ingredient ratios, preparation times, and reminders written so small that even Jimin had to squint to read them.

He had been looking at the same page for nearly fifteen minutes without taking in a single word.

His phone buzzed against the mattress beside him.

Jimin barely paid it any mind.

Over the past several days, nearly every notification had been some variation of the same thing. Hobi asking whether he was still alive. Taehyung sending him ridiculous videos from only a few feet away in an attempt to make him laugh. Another rumor spreading through the academy group chats. Another message from someone pretending to be concerned while clearly fishing for information.

The phone buzzed again.

With a tired sigh, Jimin reached for it.

Then he saw the name glowing across the screen.

Director Jeon Jungkook.

Every muscle in his body went still and for several long seconds, Jimin just stared at the name. His pulse gave one violent, annoying jump before beginning to pound steadily beneath his skin. Even after everything, Jungkook still had the ability to do this to him.

He could make Jimin's chest tighten without being in the room. He could make his hands go cold with nothing more than a name printed across a screen.

Jimin had known it would happen eventually.

Some small and humiliating part of him had always known that one of them would break first. The gala still stood between them, too important to ignore forever. There was no realistic version of tomorrow where Jimin could cook in front of a panel that included Jungkook without the two of them speaking at least once beforehand.

He just hadn't expected Jungkook to be the one who reached out.

Although, technically, *this* probably didn't count.

This wasn't an apology. It wasn't a confession. It wasn't Jungkook admitting that the distance had become unbearable or that he had spent the last five days thinking about Jimin with even half the obsessive misery Jimin had devoted to him.

It was an email.

Jimin finally reached for the phone and opened it.

Park Jimin,

You are required to report to my office today at 5:00 p.m. for a mandatory meeting concerning final gala preparation and service expectations. Attendance is not optional.

Director Jeon

That was it.

No greeting beyond his name. No explanation for why the information couldn't have been sent electronically. Not even one useless, insincere *please* tucked into the words.

Jimin read the email once.

Then again.

Then a third time, just in case another sentence might magically appear beneath Jungkook's signature and explain what he actually wanted. Jimin didn't respond. He just sat there with the phone resting in his hand, staring at the cold black text until the screen dimmed and his own reflection appeared faintly over the message.

It had been exactly five days since he had last seen Jungkook.

Five days since his office.

Five days since Jimin had walked out of *said* office feeling as though someone had scraped every living piece out of his chest and left only the shell behind.

In those five days, Jimin had felt nearly every emotion his body was capable of producing.

He had cried over Jungkook.

He hated him.

He had missed him with such a violent intensity that it made his chest ache. He had wished he had never met him, never stepped into his kitchen, never challenged him, kissed him, or allowed himself to become attached.

Then, sometimes only minutes later, he had wanted Jungkook so badly that it made him angry all over again.

He missed Jungkook's voice.

His stupid face.

He missed the heavy weight of Jungkook's attention from across a kitchen and the way Jimin could always feel when he was being watched before he even looked up. He missed the rare approval buried beneath all the criticism. He missed the pressure of Jungkook's hands against his body. He missed fighting with him, which was perhaps the most humiliating part of all.

Jimin had wished he had never met him.

He had imagined what it would feel like to see him again.

Now he was going to find out.

At four-thirty, Jimin finally dragged himself off the bed and dressed for the meeting with all the enthusiasm of preparing for an execution.

He pulled on the first oversized hoodie he found crumpled near the foot of his bed, followed by a pair of gray sweatpants that had seen better days. He didn't bother fixing his hair beyond dragging his fingers through it once, and after staring blankly at the sneakers lined beneath his desk, he decided that even tying laces required more commitment than he currently possessed. So, slides it was.

Phone. Room key. Maybe some lip balm.

And dignity.

He should probably bring some of that too.

Whatever tiny, battered amount he had left.

Jimin stood in front of the narrow mirror beside the wardrobe, looking himself over with an exhausted frown. The bruising along his face had faded from an angry purple into a sickly yellow near his cheekbone, while the cut on his lip had mostly closed.

He tugged the hood over his head and shoved both hands into the front pocket, trying to imagine himself sitting across from Jungkook without falling apart.

He couldn't.

Part of him already knew what would happen the moment he saw the man. Something inside his chest would pull toward him before he could stop it. His body would remember every touch that his mind had spent days trying to bury, and some annoying part of him would begin longing all over again.

That was why he needed dignity.

Not much.

Just enough to make it through one meeting without crying, screaming, kissing him, or doing all three in a deeply embarrassing order.

Jimin left the room before he could change his mind.

Taehyung wasn't there to walk with him this time. He had gone to eat nearly an hour earlier, leaving Jimin to cross the academy alone for the first time since the fight. The dorm hallway was quiet, but the moment Jimin pushed through the front doors, the familiar weight of attention settled over him. Several students were crossing the courtyard between buildings, taking advantage of the final break before evening prep began. A group near the library looked up almost immediately.

Jimin lowered his head and kept walking.

The hood hid most of his hair and cast a shadow over his face, but it did very little to make him unrecognizable. If anything, the sweatpants and slides only made him stand out more among the clean white uniforms and neatly pressed academy coats moving around him.

He could feel eyes tracking every slow step.

He couldn't hear everything, but he caught his name once. Still, Jimin pushed his hands deeper into the front pocket of his hoodie and continued across the courtyard without looking up.

At least nobody laughed this time.

Or maybe they did and he just didn't hear it over the blood rushing through his ears.

The afternoon sunlight fell warmly across the old stone buildings, making the academy look beautiful in the way it always did. Ivy climbed the pale walls. The garden hedges had been freshly cut for the gala, and through the tall ballroom windows Jimin could see staff moving quickly beneath the hanging chandeliers. Everything was being polished, arranged, and transformed for tomorrow night.

Meanwhile, Jimin became painfully aware of how this must appear. Park Jimin, the student at the center of the academy's largest rumor, walking across campus in pajamas toward the private office of the Director accused of favoring him.

Excellent!

Very good for his reputation.

Jimin briefly considered turning around, changing into something better, and returning in a proper uniform. Then he remembered that this was a mandatory meeting sent with less than an afternoon's notice and decided Jungkook could be grateful he had put on pants at all.

Still, the closer he came to the administrative wing, the more his stomach tightened.

The whispers in the courtyard had already begun to fade behind him, but their implication followed closely.

Someone would see where he was going.

By evening, there would probably be another post claiming Park Jimin had been called for a secret pre-gala fuck behind the same locked door everyone had spent the week discussing.

Yet here Jimin was, walking straight back into the room where nearly all of it had happened.

The hallway beyond the door was nearly silent.

Jimin's slides made soft, embarrassing slaps against the polished floor with every step.

He hated the sound.

He hated the lights.

He hated the familiar route he still knew all too well.

His pulse began to climb as the door came into view at the far end of the hall. Even from a distance, the small gold lettering seemed to sharpen before his eyes.

DIRECTOR JEON JUNGKOOK

Jimin slowed.

Five days of crying, raging, longing, and trying to convince himself that he hated the man had led him right back here. He stopped outside the office and stared at the door. For one fleeting second, he considered ignoring the email and leaving. He could say his concussion had made him forget. He could say he got the time wrong. He could flee France entirely and open a small sandwich shop somewhere nobody had ever heard the name Jeon Jungkook.

Instead, he pulled one hand from his pocket and raised it toward the wood.

His knuckles hovered there. His heart hammered so violently that it seemed to shake the entire sleeve of his hoodie.

Jimin gathered the last pathetic scraps of pride he still possessed and knocked.

"Come in."

Jungkook's voice traveled through the other side of the door, low and muffled.

Jimin's hand remained suspended there for one second longer before he closed his fingers around the handle and pushed the door open.

The office looked exactly the same as it had five days ago.

The blinds were half-drawn, letting in narrow strips of pale afternoon light that stretched across the dark rug and climbed the side of Jungkook's desk. The room still smelled faintly of sandalwood, coffee, and polished wood. The black disciplinary folder was gone, the once scattered papers had been neatly stacked, and Jimin's access card was nowhere in sight.

There was no evidence that anything had happened here at all.

Jungkook sat behind the desk with several documents spread open in front of him, one hand resting near a pen while the other supported the side of his face. He was dressed in a black button-down shirt with the sleeves rolled neatly to his forearms, the collar fastened higher than Jimin was used to seeing it. His dark hair had been combed back, though a few strands had fallen loose near his forehead.

He looked tired though not messily so. Jungkook probably wasn't physically capable of looking messy. There were faint shadows beneath his eyes, and the usual sharpness of his posture had softened by the smallest amount. Even exhausted, he remained completely put together.

Jimin hated him for that immediately.

"Close the door," Jungkook said without looking up.

Jimin closed it.

He didn't lock it.

"Sit."

Jimin crossed the room and lowered himself into the leather chair opposite the desk. The hoodie bunched awkwardly around his waist, and his slides made a soft scraping noise against the rug as he pulled his feet beneath the chair. Then he looked anywhere except at Jungkook.

Jimin shifted his attention toward the wall behind the desk.

There were framed awards hanging there.

He began counting them.

One.

Two.

Three.

A certificate from Le Cordon Bleu.

Four .

A photograph of Jungkook standing beside an older French chef Jimin vaguely recognized.

Five .

Another award.

Six .

Jimin lost count when Jungkook turned a page.

He started again.

One.

Two.

Three.

Maybe he could count the frames twice.

Maybe he could calculate the distance between each one.

Maybe he could recite the United States Constitution.

Yea Maybe he'd do that.

He had memorized parts of it in high school for a test and forgotten nearly everything immediately afterward, but maybe the information was still buried somewhere beneath the concussion.

We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union—

Jungkook began speaking.

“Tomorrow’s service begins at seven, but all student chefs are required to report to the west kitchen no later than eleven in the morning. Ingredient inspection will begin at eleven-thirty, followed by equipment checks and the first preparation block at noon.”

Jimin nodded faintly, eyes still fixed on the wall.

Establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility—

“You’ll be assigned two assistants from the intermediate cohort. They’ve already received copies of your preparation list, but all final delegation remains your responsibility.”

Provide for the common defense—

“You’ll have access to your station, the pastry room, and the cold storage. You won’t be permitted inside the faculty kitchen unless specifically called by a panel member.”

Promote the general Welfare—

Jimin’s gaze drifted toward a small brass clock on the bookshelf. The second hand moved in steady little clicks.

Jungkook continued speaking, his voice formal as he reviewed timing, plating windows, allergen protocol, and the procedure for presenting each course to the judges.

Jimin heard basically none of it. He was far too aware of the man sitting across from him, the slight rasp beneath Jungkook’s otherwise controlled voice, the quiet turn of each page, and the feeling of his presence filling every corner of the office.

He couldn’t bring himself to look at him now. If he did, he might find nothing in Jungkook’s expression at all, and Jimin wasn’t certain he could survive that. Worse, he might find something. Regret, guilt, longing, or even the same pain Jimin had spent the last days trying unsuccessfully to bury.

Jimin began counting the photographs again.

There were eight.

No, nine.

The small frame near the bookshelf probably counted.

Did diplomas count as pictures?

Probably not.

Maybe he should recite the amendments instead.

Freedom of speech.

Freedom of religion.

The right to bear arms.

That one felt particularly relevant.

“Jimin.”

Jungkook’s voice cut through the useless noise in his head.

Jimin blinked but continued staring at the wall.

There was a pause.

“Jimin?”

This time, the name came quieter.

Jimin finally dragged his eyes toward the desk and found that Jungkook had stopped speaking. He was watching him with such quiet intensity that his gaze tightened something deep in Jimin’s chest and stole the breath from his lungs.

For several long seconds, neither of them moved.

Jungkook’s eyes traveled slowly over him, beginning at the hood pulled low over his disordered hair and moving down across the oversized sweatshirt swallowing his frame. They paused briefly at the faint yellow bruise still along Jimin’s cheek, the healing cut on his lower lip, and the exhaustion settled heavily beneath his eyes.

Then his gaze dropped and something unreadable shifted across his face. Then, Jungkook’s eyes returned to him.

“Are you listening?”

Jimin blinked

“Yes.”

“What did I just say?”

Jimin opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

He looked toward the wall again. “Things about the kitchen.”

“I’ve said several things about the kitchen.”

“The west kitchen.”

“And?”

Jimin searched his memory desperately. *There had been assistants. Equipment. Something at eleven.*

“I report at eleven.”

Jungkook studied him for another long moment, his eyes moving slowly over Jimin’s face as though he were trying to understand what had happened to him during the days they had spent apart. The attention made Jimin feel exposed, as though the shadows under his eyes, the fading bruise along his cheek, and every miserable hour he had spent alone were written plainly across his skin.

“You look...unwell”

Jimin let out a short, humorless laugh and lowered his gaze. “Thank you.”

Jungkook’s jaw tightened almost imperceptibly. Jimin noticed the movement from beneath his lashes and regretted the comment, although not enough to take it back or apologize. He was still angry, and Jungkook’s sudden concern did nothing but confuse the anger already sitting heavily inside his chest.

A silence settled between them before Jungkook looked down at the papers arranged across his desk.

“When did you last eat?”

Jimin stiffened. The question felt *way* too personal after the distance Jungkook had maintained since he entered the office.

“This meeting is supposed to be about the gala, *Chef*.”

The title left Jimin’s mouth quieter than the following words.

Across from him, Jungkook stiffened. His eyes batted once, almost like the word had caught him off guard, and for a brief second something uncertain passed over his face. Then it disappeared. He straightened one of the papers beneath his hand and cleared his throat.

Jimin kept his eyes lowered. He couldn't look at him.

Jungkook's voice was controlled when he answered. "It is."

Jimin's mouth tightened.

"That didn't sound like a gala question."

This time, Jimin flicked his gaze up.

Jungkook's eyes were narrowed, but something else appeared there with it. A small spark that Jimin caught only because he had gotten too good at noticing the tiniest changes in Jungkook's face.

For half a second, he *almost* looked pleased. Not enough to smile. Jungkook probably would have rather thrown himself out the window than make it that obvious. But there was something warm beneath the stare, something almost relieved, as though hearing Jimin argue with him again had given him proof that some part of Jimin was still there.

Jimin's heart gave an uncomfortable little pull.

Then Jungkook blinked, and it was gone.

"It concerns whether you'll remain conscious throughout service."

Jimin shifted in the chair, his gaze settling somewhere near the corner of Jungkook's desk. "I ate."

"What?"

The sharpness of it made Jimin's fingers tighten together in his lap.

He hesitated. "A donut."

There was a pause.

"When?"

Jimin rubbed his thumb along the side of his finger. "Yesterday."

The office went quiet.

He still wouldn't look up, but he could feel Jungkook staring at him now. The silence stretched long enough that Jimin finally tried to make the answer sound *slightly* less terrible.

"It was a...really big donut..."

Jungkook exhaled slowly.

When he spoke again, the restraint in his voice had thinned considerably. "Jimin." Hearing his name made Jimin's stomach tighten. "Are you listening to yourself? You're expected to execute a multi-course service tomorrow before several hundred guests, and you've eaten one pastry in the past twenty-four hours."

Jimin stared at his hands.

“I’ll eat later.”

“That isn’t optional.”

There it was again. That fucking tone.

Jimin’s fingers tightened in his lap.

Jungkook sitting behind his desk telling him when to eat, asking if he was well enough to stand through service as if he had any right to worry over him like this. As if he could spend one meeting stripping everything between them down to *nothing* and then call Jimin back into the same office and start taking care of him again.

The bitterness came quickly.

Whether Jimin ate mattered. Whether he slept mattered. Whether he made it through the gala mattered.

But everything else had been nothing.

Jimin looked down at his hands, anger curling tighter in his stomach.

Fine.

If kissing him was nothing, then this could be nothing too.

If having Jungkook’s hands all over him was nothing, if every private moment Jimin had been stupid enough to attach meaning to could be dismissed that easily, then Jungkook checking whether he had eaten a goddamn meal certainly didn’t deserve to mean anything either.

His irritation flared before he could contain it. “Neither was this meeting, apparently.”

The words came out harder than he intended.

Jimin finally glanced up, but only for a second.

Jungkook’s expression had changed. His jaw tightened, and whatever had shown on his face when Jimin had challenged him disappeared completely. The distance returned so quickly it almost made Jimin regret saying anything at all.

He dropped his gaze again.

“Just tell me what I need to know,” he muttered. “I’ll listen this time.”

Jungkook remained silent for several seconds. Then he reached for the printed schedule resting beside his hand and slid it across the desk. Jimin leaned forward to take it, carefully positioning his fingers so they wouldn’t touch Jungkook’s.

Jungkook’s hand remained resting against the desk for a fraction too long after Jimin took the paper. His fingers curled slightly against the surface before he slowly withdrew them and settled back into his chair.

“Everything is listed there,” he said. “Your arrival time, assigned staff, preparation windows, service order, and presentation procedure.”

Jimin looked down at the page, but the words blurred together almost immediately. He traced the printed schedule with his eyes without taking in any of it.

“And tomorrow,” Jungkook continued, his voice returning to its colder, professional rhythm, “you’ll keep your attention on your station. You won’t search the panel for guidance, and you won’t look to me for confirmation.”

Jimin’s fingers tightened around the paper.

“I know.”

“You’ll make your own decisions.”

“I said I know.”

The sharpness in his voice caused Jungkook to fall silent.

Jimin could feel the man’s gaze on him, as he finally got enough nerve to look up.

Jungkook’s gaze flickered downward. It rested briefly on Jimin’s mouth, lingering near the cut along his lower lip before snapping back to his eyes. The movement lasted less than a second but it was still enough to send a sharp rush of heat through Jimin’s chest.

God.

He needed to get a grip.

Jungkook straightened in his chair and began gathering the remaining documents, aligning their edges carefully against the desk. Though, the movement seemed more like an attempt to pull himself back under control.

“Well,” he said after a moment. “I suppose that will be all.”

Jimin looked away and nodded. “Okay.”

Jungkook stared at him across the desk, and for several long seconds, neither of them moved.

“Okay,” he whispered back.

The silence lingered strangely between them, filled with everything neither of them seemed capable of saying. Jimin finally pushed himself out of the chair. He folded the schedule once, shoved it into the front pocket of his hoodie, and turned toward the door before his body could betray him by lingering any longer.

“Wait.”

Jimin stopped.

Behind him came the quiet scrape of the desk drawer opening.

He turned slowly and watched as Jungkook reached inside and took out a small white tube covered in neat French lettering. The packaging looked expensive and clinical, stamped with the emblem of a medical institute Jimin had never heard of.

Jungkook stared at it for a moment before rising from his chair.

He walked around the desk and stopped several feet in front of Jimin, holding the tube toward him with an expression that seemed almost uncomfortable.

“I contacted a physician affiliated with the Institut *Médical de Paris*,” he began, his voice becoming unnecessarily formal. “He specializes in treating burns, cuts, and hand injuries in culinary professionals. He recommended this to reduce inflammation and prevent the skin from tightening while the tissue heals.”

Jungkook’s eyes dropped toward Jimin’s injured knuckles.

The bruising had faded, but the skin remained red and tender in several places. Jimin instinctively curled his fingers inward, hiding the worst of it inside the sleeves of his hoodie.

“I thought you might benefit from it,” Jungkook said.

Jimin stared at the tube, Then he looked at Jungkook.

The gesture should have felt kind. Instead, it reopened every wound Jimin had been trying to close.

It meant Jungkook had cared all along.

Except now... it was far too late.

“What happened to no handouts?”

Jungkook’s expression tightened. “This... isn’t a handout.”

“You called some private doctor and got me special medicine.”

“It’s ointment, Jimin.”

“From a specialist.”

Jungkook extended the tube farther, his patience visibly thinning. “Take it.”

Jimin folded his arms across his chest. “No.”

“Jimin.”

“No handouts, remember? No special treatment. I’m supposed to build my career by myself now.”

“*This* has nothing to do with your career.”

“It has everything to do with what you said though.”

Jungkook’s jaw clenched. For the first time since Jimin had entered the office, a visible crack appeared in his composure.

“I said you wouldn’t receive *professional* favors you hadn’t earned. I didn’t say I would allow your hand to scar improperly because you’re too stubborn to accept basic medical care.”

The irritation in Jungkook’s voice couldn’t hide the concern buried beneath it. That concern should have comforted him. Instead, it only made Jimin angrier.

"No, I'm not taking it."

Jungkook’s patience finally snapped.

He crossed the distance between them in two steps, caught Jimin’s wrist, and pulled one of his hands free from where he had folded his arms stubbornly across his chest. Before Jimin could protest, Jungkook pressed the tube into his palm and closed Jimin’s fingers around it himself.

“Take it.”

The command came out low and tired.

Jimin looked down at their hands. Jungkook’s hand remained wrapped around his wrist while the ointment sat trapped inside his fist.

Now... Jimin knew he shouldn’t have said what came next. He knew it before the words even reached his tongue. He supposed, somewhere between the sweatpants and the slides, he had accidentally forgotten to pack that dignity after all.

He should have thanked him.

He should have shoved the tube into his pocket, walked out of the office, and preserved whatever little pride he had left.

“What would you do if I went home next semester?”

Jungkook’s grip loosened.

Jimin lifted his eyes. “Back to New York,” he added, his voice quieter now. “If I decided I was done with the academy and left France, would you care?”

Jungkook looked away and Jimin couldn’t lie, that hurt more than an immediate no would have.

Still, Jimin searched his face, desperate for something. Jungkook’s jaw had tightened, and the muscles beneath his rolled sleeves had gone rigid, but he refused to meet Jimin’s eyes.

“I just want to know.”

“*This* has nothing to do with tomorrow.”

“I know.”

“Then leave it alone.”

“I can’t.”

Jungkook released his wrist and turned away. He crossed back toward the desk and planted both hands against the edge, his head lowering between his shoulders.

Jimin watched the tension gather across his back.

“Would you miss me?” he asked.

Jungkook’s fingers curled against the wood.

“Would you notice when I wasn’t in the halls anymore? Would you walk into the kitchen and look at my station before remembering I wasn’t there?”

“Stop.”

Jimin’s throat tightened, but he kept going.

“Would you ever think about calling me?”

Jimin’s voice came out quieter than he had meant it to, softened by the tightness building in his throat. Jungkook remained turned away from him, both hands braced against the edge of the desk.

“I said stop.”

Jimin should have listened. He knew that. Every part of this conversation had already gone farther than it should have, and Jungkook had made it painfully clear that he didn't intend to give him anything.

Still, Jimin found himself stepping closer.

“You could find my number easily, I bet...” Jimin said, his voice unsteady despite the faint attempt at humor. “If you really wanted to.”

Jungkook’s shoulders rose with a sharp breath. He didn’t turn around.

Jimin watched him for another second, his chest tightening with every moment that passed without an answer.

“What would you do if I left France?”

The question hung between them.

Jungkook stayed silent.

“What if I just packed everything up and went home?”

There was still no response, and the silence began to make Jimin feel foolish. He could hear how desperate he sounded now. He could hear the question underneath every other question, the one he had been too afraid to ask plainly.

His eyes began to sting.

“Would you let me?”

Jungkook spun around so suddenly that Jimin stopped in place. His breathing was no longer as controlled as it had been when Jimin first entered the office.

“What exactly do you expect me to do?” Jungkook snapped. “Take your passport? Lock you in this office? Drag you back from the airport myself?”

“At least that would be an answer!”

Jimin’s voice broke around the last word.

Jimin had noticed a long time ago that Jungkook’s accent got stronger when he was angry. Back in the kitchen, it usually came out when he was frustrated, slamming things down harder than necessary or barking orders across the room.

Now, though, it was thicker than Jimin had ever heard it. His brows were drawn together as he gestured in disbelief, words tumbling out so quickly they sounded almost unlike him.

“Drag you back here myself?” Jungkook asked again. “Is that what you want me to say?”

Jimin’s chest tightened.

Jungkook laughed once, but there was nothing amused in it. He dragged a hand through his hair and turned away for half a second before facing him again, visibly fighting to pull himself back under control.

Jimin held his gaze, even as his vision began to blur.

“No.”

Jungkook let out a sharp breath and looked away again. “Of course it isn’t.”

Jimin crossed the remaining distance and stepped directly into his line of sight. When Jungkook turned his head, Jimin shifted with him, refusing to let the man escape the question.

“What if I went all the way back to New York?” Jimin pressed. His voice had started shaking now, but he didn’t care enough to hide it. “What if I left and you knew I wasn’t coming back? Would you care?”

Jungkook finally looked at him.

“Would you?” Jimin asked again

The anger was still there, but underneath it was something exhausted, something Jimin had only ever caught in brief flashes before Jungkook forced it away.

“Yes.”

Jimin’s breath caught.

For a second, that single word seemed to quiet everything inside him.

Then Jungkook moved closer.

“You could cross the entire Atlantic,” he said, his voice rough and cracked. “You could go back to New York, leave New York, move to another country, another continent, and it still wouldn’t be far enough.”

Jungkook let out a breathless laugh. He looked angrier than Jimin had ever seen him, but there was too much exhaustion in his face for the anger to hide everything else.

“How could I not notice you’d be gone?” Jungkook’s voice had gotten louder now, his accent thicker with every word. “You fight, and you yell, and you just talk and talk and talk, and really... *really*, all you say is nothing. I don’t even think you know what you’re talking about half the time!”

Jimin’s expression tightened, but Jungkook kept going.

“You think acting like this is going to get you far?” Jungkook gestured toward him in disbelief, his brows drawn tightly together. “You think you can argue with everyone who tells you something you don’t want to hear? Question everything? Push and push until someone finally gives you whatever you’ve decided you need?”

Jimin stared at him, the ointment tightening inside his fist.

“No. It won’t,” Jungkook continued. His words were coming faster now, almost stumbling over one another before he could pull them back. “You ask a question, I answer it, and then you ask another. And another. Nothing is ever enough for you. You keep standing there looking at me like there’s some perfect thing I could say that would finally make you stop.”

His hand dragged roughly over his face before dropping back to his side.

“I can’t, Jimin.”

Jungkook shook his head, frustration written across every part of his face now. “I can’t keep doing this with you. You drive me fucking crazy. You argue with the answers I give you anyway.”

Jimin’s eyes began to burn.

Jungkook turned away for a second, muttering something sharply under his breath.

“Putain, je ne peux plus te supporter.”

Jungkook turned back toward him, breathing harder now.

“So yeah,” he said, his voice rough. “*Yeah*, I’d notice you were gone. Because for once, I’d finally get some damn peace in this building and in my life.”

Jimin’s fingers tightened into fist.

For a moment, he only stared at Jungkook. The answer he had begged for had been there, buried beneath whatever bullshit had just been said, and Jungkook had still managed to twist it into something cruel.

Jimin’s eyes burned.

“Fuck you.”

Jimin turned toward the door.

Behind him, Jungkook's voice followed.

"Fuck me?"

Jimin spun around so quickly that he nearly lost his footing.

"Yes, *fuck* you," he spat. "Fuck you times three! Actually, make it four, and fuck you for thinking you can talk to me like that! So make it fucking five!"

Jungkook's eyebrows lifted slightly, and the small reaction only made Jimin hotter.

He stormed back across the space between them and stopped so close to the man that he had to tilt his head back to look at him.

"You act like I'm some horrible problem you've been forced to deal with, but you're the one who called me here," Jimin said, his words coming faster now. "You're the one who wouldn't let me leave without giving me the stupid medicine. You're the one asking whether I've eaten. You're the one who keeps doing all this shit and then acting like I'm crazy for asking why. You're the one."

Jungkook's jaw tightened.

Jimin shook his head. "I didn't want anything from you. I just want you to stop being a coward and tell me."

Jungkook's expression sharpened, his eyes darkening as the last of his composure thinned.

Jimin was too angry to care. His eyes were wet now, and he could feel the tears building, but he refused to stop.

"You know exactly what I was asking."

"And you know exactly why I can't give you the answer you want."

"Then stop giving me pieces of it!" Jimin's shout carried through the office and seemed to sit there after he stopped.

Jimin stood in front of him breathing hard, the ointment still crushed in his fist. His eyes had finally filled enough that a tear escaped and slipped down his cheek. He wiped it away quickly, almost angrily, but another followed before he could pretend the first one hadn't.

"So what happens?" he demanded. "You care, but you're gonna keep pretending you don't. You'd miss me, but you're still gonna push me away. What am I supposed to do with that?"

"Jimin."

"No. Answer me."

Jungkook looked at him for a long moment. His gaze moved over Jimin's face, lingering on the tears he had failed to wipe away, and his throat worked as he swallowed.

"You need to leave."

Jimin laughed softly, though there was no humor in it.

“Fine.”

He turned away again.

This time he made it barely two steps before Jungkook caught his wrist.

Jimin stopped and looked down at the hand wrapped around him.

“Let go.”

Jungkook didn’t move.

Jimin tugged his arm.

“I said let go.”

Instead, Jungkook pulled him back.

Jimin stumbled into him, his chest colliding with Jungkook’s body. The ointment slipped from his hand and hit the rug somewhere near their feet, but neither of them looked down.

Jimin barely had time to draw a breath before Jungkook’s other hand came up and closed around the back of his neck.

Their mouths crashed together.

The kiss was rough and stripped of any of that dignity Jimin *thought* he had. Jungkook kissed him as though he were still angry, as though every word he had refused to say had become trapped behind his teeth and this was the only way he knew how to release any of it.

For one shocked second, Jimin froze.

Then all the hurt inside him twisted into something hotter.

His hands caught in the front of Jungkook’s shirt, gripping the fabric hard enough to wrinkle it beneath his fingers as he pulled him closer. Jimin kissed him back with equal force, refusing to let Jungkook control *this* too.

Every unanswered question, every cruel word, and every moment spent wondering whether he had meant anything at all poured into the way his mouth moved against Jungkook’s.

Jungkook made a low, frustrated sound against his lips.

The hand at the back of Jimin’s neck tightened, fingers pressing into his hair as he tilted Jimin’s head and deepened the kiss. His other arm wrapped around Jimin’s waist, pulling until there was no space left between them.

Jimin’s breath caught, but he didn’t pull away.

Instead, he rose onto the balls of his feet and dragged Jungkook closer by the collar, kissing him with everything he had been unable to explain. His fingers slipped higher, tangling briefly near the

back of Jungkook's neck, and the movement seemed to break whatever restraint the man still had left.

The tears that had been sitting in Jimin's eyes finally spilled over.

They ran silently down his cheeks while he kissed him. One reached the corner of his mouth, and Jimin tasted salt between them. He hated that he was crying now, hated that Jungkook would know how much all of this had affected him, but he couldn't stop long enough to wipe them away.

Jungkook stepped forward.

Jimin stumbled backward beneath the force of it.

His slides caught awkwardly against the rug, but Jungkook's arm stayed locked around his waist, keeping him upright as he guided him across the office without breaking the kiss.

The back of Jimin's thighs struck the edge of the desk.

A stack of papers shifted behind him, several sheets sliding sideways as Jungkook pressed closer. Jungkook leaned into him until Jimin was forced against the desk, the hard edge pressing into the backs of his legs.

Jimin's hands tightened in Jungkook's shirt again, pulling him closer even though there was nowhere left for him to go. He wanted to erase every inch of distance Jungkook had placed between them. He wanted the kiss to hurt enough to match everything else.

Another tear slipped down his cheek and disappeared somewhere between their faces.

Jungkook's mouth left his for only a fraction of a second, just long enough for them both to drag in a breath.

Their foreheads nearly touched.

Jimin could feel Jungkook breathing against his lips before the man kissed him again.

This time, the anger cracked around something more desperate.

Jimin felt it in the way Jungkook's grip changed from forceful to almost scared, as though he had suddenly remembered that Jimin could still pull away. It was there in the careful angle of his mouth around the healing cut on Jimin's lip and in the way his thumb brushed once beneath Jimin's jaw before tightening again.

Then Jungkook's thumb moved higher.

It passed gently beneath Jimin's eye and caught the wetness there.

Jimin's breath came out broken against Jungkook's mouth.

He didn't want Jungkook wiping the tears he caused away. Still, Jimin pulled him closer anyway.

His fingers tightened at the back of Jungkook's neck, and he kissed him harder because he didn't know what else to do anymore. More tears slipped free while he held onto Jungkook's shirt, and for several seconds he let himself stay there without trying to make sense of any of it.

There was only Jungkook pressed against him, Jimin trapped between his body.

Then, with breakneck speed, Jimin remembered who the fuck he was.

His body went still as Jungkook's lips still moved against his.

He remembered why he had spent the past several days depressed, angry, humiliated, and trying to convince himself that none of this mattered. He remembered sitting across from Jungkook and listening to him dismiss everything that had happened between them as nothing, then spending every miserable hour afterward trying to force himself to believe it.

And now Jimin was standing in the same office crying into the mouth of the perpetrator.

Jimin tore himself away.

His breaths came out in quick, uneven pants as he stared up at Jungkook, his brows pulling together while he tried to understand how he had allowed himself to fall back into this so easily. He could still feel the wetness on his cheeks, the heat in his lips, and Jungkook's hand lingering at his waist for the briefest moment before it fell away.

This went against everything.

This went against the nothing.

Jimin slowly loosened his fists from the front of Jungkook's shirt. His fingers uncurled one by one, but instead of dropping them, his hands stayed resting against Jungkook's chest. The fabric remained wrinkled beneath his palms, warm from the heat between them, and he could feel Jungkook's breathing beneath his hands, just as uneven as his own.

Jimin stood there for another second, searching desperately for some explanation that could make what had just happened feel less humiliating.

He couldn't find one.

His stomach turned.

He felt like he was going to be sick.

Without looking up, Jimin pushed himself away from the desk and slid to his feet. The moment his shoes touched the floor properly, the room tilted beneath him. His knees weakened, and he swayed slightly before catching himself against the edge of the desk.

Jungkook stepped back at once, giving him space.

Jimin still couldn't bring himself to look at him. He already knew what expression Jungkook was probably wearing. That stupid concerned look. Jungkook always seemed to become gentle once the damage had already been done.

Jimin wiped quickly beneath his eyes with the heel of his hand.

"I..." His voice caught, forcing him to swallow before he tried again. "I'm gonna go."

He kept his eyes fixed on the floor and pulled one unsteady breath into his lungs, trying to convince his body to move before the nausea could catch up with him.

“Jimin,” Jungkook called after him.

Jimin didn’t look back.

He bent down, picked up the ointment from the rug, and shoved it into the pocket of his hoodie before walking out of the office.

The tears stopped soon after he reached the hallway, which surprised him more than anything.

He had expected to fall apart once the door closed behind him. He expected his chest to cave under the weight of everything he had just done or for the crying to become worse now that Jungkook could no longer see him.

Instead, Jimin kept walking.

His body felt strangely numb as he moved through the corridor, one hand buried inside the pocket of his hoodie around the ointment. His lips still tingled, and every few steps his mind returned to the feeling of Jungkook’s thumb beneath his eye, wiping away tears he had helped cause.

Jimin pressed his lips together and kept going

By the time he reached the dorm, he couldn’t remember the walk back.

He entered his room, closed the door behind him, and stood there for several seconds without moving.

His chef’s coat was still folded inside the wardrobe, clean and untouched.

Jimin pulled it out and laid it carefully across the bed for the gala. He smoothed the white fabric with both hands, pressing out a wrinkle that wasn’t really there. Then he adjusted the sleeves, straightened the collar, and made sure the academy crest faced upward.

The movements were slow and mechanical.

After several minutes of staring at the chef’s coat, Jimin turned toward the desk.

His notebook was still open where he had left it, filled with notes for the gala. Every page held some part of the menu he had spent weeks building. Cooking times, flavor pairings, plating sketches, sauce ratios, and reminders written so small they crowded the margins. He had planned every detail around the academy’s expectations and the chefs who would be watching him.

Jimin sat down and began reading through it

The longer he looked, the angrier he became

Every note sounded like Jungkook. Precise. Perfect. Annoying. Every choice had been made with the panel in mind. Every flavor had been softened and forced into something respectable enough to sit beneath white tablecloths and crystal chandeliers.

Jimin stared at the page until the words began to blur.

Then he dragged his pen through the first course. Then again and again until the black ink nearly tore through the paper.

He crossed out the second course next, then the third. He scratched through the sauces, the garnishes, the presentation notes, and every careful correction he had made after one of Jungkook's lessons. The pen moved harder and faster until it caught against the page and ripped through the corner.

When there was nothing left to read, Jimin tore the sheet from the notebook, crushed it into a tight ball, and threw it toward the trash.

It hit the edge of the bin and rolled onto the floor.

Jimin stared at it.

Fuck the academy.

Fuck its rules, its rumors, its polished edict, and every person who had looked at him like he didn't deserve to be there. Fuck anyone who had watched the video and decided they understood his position.

Jimin leaned back in the chair and stared at the ruined pages spread across the desk.

He was still going to cook.

He was still gonna walk into that kitchen, and stand in front of the panel. He wasn't going to hide in his room and let them decide his story without him.

But he was done cooking for their approval.

If people like Jungkook were allowed to twist the rules whenever it suited them, then Jimin could bend a few too.

Jimin stared at the ruined page for a long moment. He had been so sure a second ago, but now the space in front of him felt almost too open.

Then a thought came to him.

His eyes shifted toward the phone resting beside the notebook.

He hesitated for only a second before reaching for it and calling his mother.

She answered after a few rings.

"Jimin?"

"Mom."

A soft laugh came through the speaker. *"You finally miss me?"*

Jimin smiled faintly and leaned back in the chair. *"Maybe."*

"Well, I miss you too."

He could hear her moving around in the background, the faint sound of cabinets opening and closing and something being set down on a counter. The sound of his home made his chest ache.

Jimin ran his thumb along the edge of the notebook before turning it to an empty page.

“Mom, can I ask you something?”

“Of course.”

He paused, suddenly feeling a little silly for not knowing exactly how to explain it.

“Do you remember that meal you used to make me all the time? The one I was always asking for?”

His mother was quiet for a second.

“You’re going to have to be more specific than that, baby.”

Jimin let out a small laugh. “You know which one I mean. The one you’d make when I had a bad day or when I was upset. I used to ask for it constantly.”

Another pause.

Then her voice softened with recognition.

“Oh. That one.”

Jimin smiled.

“Yeah. That one.” He glanced down at the page again. “Could you give me the recipe?”



Jimin spent the rest of the night working.

Once the recipe was written down, something inside him seemed to click into place. He kept the notebook open in front of him and began building around it, changing portions, adjusting, adding ingredients, crossing things out, rewriting them, then circling back whenever a better idea came to him.

Hours passed without Jimin noticing.

His desk slowly disappeared beneath loose sheets of paper, ingredient lists, old menu drafts, and scraps covered in rushed notes. His lamp cast a warm circle of light across everything while the rest of the dorm room grew darker around him.

At some point, Taehyung came back.

He paused near the doorway when he saw Jimin hunched over the desk, one elbow planted beside the notebook while scribbled furiously across another page. Jimin's hair had fallen into his face, his shoulders curved forward with concentration, and there was an intensity to him that hadn't been there in days.

Taehyung said something.

Jimin gave a distracted hum without lifting his head.

Whatever response Taehyung had expected, that apparently wasn't it. He lingered for a few seconds before deciding not to interfere. He changed, moved around the room, and eventually climbed into bed.

Jimin kept writing.

Every so often, he'd stop and stare at the page, tapping the end of his pen against his lip while he worked through another idea. Then something would come to him and he would lean forward again, writing so quickly that his handwriting became almost impossible to read.

The dorm grew quiet around him.

The voices in the hallway faded. Doors stopped opening and closing. Taehyung's breathing eventually softened into the steady rhythm of sleep, leaving only the scratch of Jimin's pen, the occasional turn of a page, and the faint hum of the lamp beside him.

By the time Jimin finally looked at his phone again, it was nearly three in the morning.

He blinked at the time, surprised.

Jimin slowly sat back in the chair and rolled the stiffness from his shoulders. His fingers cramped when he stretched them, and there was a faint ink stain along the side of his hand. He flexed them once before looking down at everything he had written.

He read through the menu from beginning to end.

His eyes moved over every course, every ingredient, every small correction squeezed into the margins. He followed the progression of the meal in his head, imagining each plate, each flavor, and what he wanted someone to feel when they tasted it.

For the first time, he didn't find something he wanted to change.

A smile slowly pulled at the corner of his mouth.

Jimin closed the notebook carefully and rested his palm over the cover for a moment, strangely protective of everything inside it.

Then he reached over and clicked off the lamp.

Jimin stood, stretched, and made his way toward the bed. He climbed beneath the blankets, settled into the pillow, and closed his eyes.



When Jimin opened his eye's again, pale morning light was already slipping through the curtains.

For a few seconds, he remained completely still.

The heavy pressure that had been sitting behind his eyes was gone. Even the headache that had become such a constant presence that Jimin had almost stopped noticing it had disappeared completely.

He stared up at the ceiling, almost suspicious of the feeling.

His body was tired from only a few hours of sleep, but his mind felt strangely clear.

Feeling this calm made him nervous. He had gotten so used to waking up with anxiety sitting in his chest that now, without it, his mind kept searching for whatever he was supposed to be upset about.

Naturally, it found Jungkook.

Jimin remained on his back and stared at the ceiling while memories of him drifted through his mind. His voice. His face. The things he had said in that office. Outside of it. If Jimin concentrated hard enough, he swore he could still remember the taste of Jungkook's lips against

His stomach turned a little at the memory, but that familiar pull in his chest never came.

Jimin frowned.

There was still something there. The anger hadn't magically disappeared overnight, and neither had the hurt. Jimin knew both were probably lingering somewhere beneath this strange, suspicious calm, waiting for the right moment to crawl back up again.

But that painful tug in his chest was gone.

For now, Jungkook wasn't the first and largest thing occupying his mind.

Jimin turned his head toward the desk where his notebook sat closed beneath the morning light.

A smile slowly pulled at his lips.

He *wanted* to cook.

He was *excited* about *cooking*.

Really excited.

He wanted to get into the kitchen. He wanted to see the ingredients laid out in front of him and hear the noise of pans and knives and ovens around him. He wanted to make the menu he had stayed up half the night writing and see if it tasted as good as it had sounded in his head.

For the first time in what felt like forever, cooking was the thing Jimin couldn't stop thinking about.

Taehyung came out of the bathroom already dressed, his hair still damp around the edges and a towel thrown over one shoulder. The second he noticed Jimin still lying in bed, his expression changed.

“*Mon ami*, get up. Are you trying to be late? The whole school is going to be there. Literally everyone. Students, professors, alumni, the panel, the dean, probably half of Paris at this point. But don't worry because I'll be there too, obviously. And you cannot let Director Jeon intimidate you today, okay? Whatever happened already happened. It's done. You walk in there, you keep your head up, and you show them Park Jimin. You show them why you were chosen. You show them you belong there and that nobody can take that away from you just because they have opinions or because some people at this school apparently have nothing better to do than gossip. And if anyone looks at you weird, ignore them. If Jungkook looks at you weird, ignore him too. Actually, ignore everyone. You just focus on your food and your station and—”

Somewhere around the mention of the dean, Jimin stopped listening.

Taehyung's voice continued filling the room while Jimin blinked slowly at the ceiling, pushed the blankets down, and sat up. He stretched both arms high above his head, his shoulders lifting as a long, almost musical groan left him.

Taehyung stopped mid-sentence.

Jimin twisted slightly at the waist, trying to work out the stiffness from spending half the night hunched over his desk. Something in his back pulled hard enough to make his face pinch.

“Don't—” Jimin started, then immediately winced. “Jesus, my back.”

He rolled one shoulder, then the other, stretching again until the ache eased.

Taehyung was staring at him now. His brows had drawn together in confusion, his mouth still half-open from the speech Jimin had interrupted.

Jimin finally looked over at him, a wide smile already pulling across his face.

“Don't worry, Tae,” he finished. “I'm not nervous.”

Taehyung's expression didn't change.

If anything, he looked more concerned. A small smile pulled at his mouth as he leaned against the dresser and folded his arms.

“It's okay... to *be* nervous, you know.”

Jimin reached for the hem of his shirt, already shaking his head.

“No, seriously. When I went to Dubai with my parents that one summer, my father made me attend this *stupid* dinner with some prince's family because apparently it was supposed to be *'good for*

networking. ' I had to sit at this table with, like, thirty people, and everyone was asking me questions about business and investments and I was seventeen so I had no idea what they were talking about. So I just kept nodding and saying things like, *'That's very interesting,'* and *'I'll have to do more research and get back to you.'* "

Jimin's lips twitched.

Taehyung smiled wider, clearly pleased with himself. "My point is, everyone gets nervous."

Jimin pushed himself to his feet, still laughing softly as he stretched the stiffness from his back.

"But...seriously, Tae. I'm fine."

Taehyung's smile faded into something more careful, like he was trying to decide whether to believe him.

Jimin looked at him for a second, then glanced toward the notebook resting on his desk.

"I'm actually..." He paused, almost surprised by the word himself. "Excited."

Taehyung blinked.

Jimin smiled again, smaller this time.

"Yeah...I'm excited."

Jimin turned toward the clothes he had laid out the night before, still smiling faintly to himself.

He showered again even though he had showered the night before, mostly because the idea of showing up to the gala feeling anything less than clean suddenly felt like a bad omen. He washed his hair, stood under the hot water until the room filled with steam.

By the time he came back into the room, Taehyung had kinda accepted that something strange had happened overnight.

Jimin stood in front of the mirror in nothing but a towel, combing through his damp hair while Tae sat on the edge of his bed watching him with open suspicion.

"You're smiling."

Jimin glanced at him through the mirror. "Am I not allowed?"

"You are. It's just...weird."

Jimin rolled his eyes and reached for the products scattered across the dresser. Most of them belonged to Taehyung, which meant they came in tiny glass containers with French names Jimin couldn't pronounce and prices he probably didn't want to know.

He picked one up.

"What does this do?"

Taehyung looked over. "Don't use that."

Jimin froze with his finger already halfway into the jar.

“Why?”

“It was expensive.”

Jimin stared at him.

“That doesn’t answer my question.”

Then he used it anyway.

Taehyung made a wounded sound from behind him while Jimin smoothed the cream over his face with satisfaction.

If he was going to stand beneath chandeliers and be judged by famous chefs, wealthy donors, the dean, half the academy, and one particularly annoying Director with an irritatingly attractive face, then his skin was going to look incredible while it happened.

Jimin paused.

Jungkook.

Of course.

His hands slowed for a second.

He could already picture him there, probably dressed in black, sitting somewhere near the center of the panel with that stupid expression he wore when he wanted the entire world to believe he had never experienced a human emotion.

Jimin stared at himself in the mirror.

No

Jimin reached for another cream.

He was *not* starting the day thinking about Jungkook.

He had food to cook.

Besides, Jungkook could sit there looking dark and tortured all evening if he wanted. That sounded like a personal problem.

The thought made Jimin smile again.

He finished his skincare, dried his hair, and then stood in front of the wardrobe for several seconds looking at the chef’s uniform waiting inside.

His clean one.

Thankfully.

The coat from the dining hall incident was currently hidden somewhere in the back of the closet where it belonged, and Jimin had no intention of ever looking at it again.

He pulled on his black undershirt first, followed by the tailored pants. Then he reached for the chef's coat.

He began fastening it slowly, button by button, watching himself in the mirror as the uniform came together.

Then his eyes caught on something near the collar.

Jimin stopped.

Just beneath the fold of the white fabric was a small, faded red mark. It was dull now, almost brown around the edges, and easy to miss unless someone knew exactly where to look.

Blood.

His eyes fluttered at the sight.

Funny. He had worn this coat, washed it, folded it, carried it from one room to another, and somehow he had never noticed the stain until now.

Jimin stepped closer to the mirror.

He lifted the collar between two fingers and studied the mark. It was faint enough that nobody else would probably notice it, but now that Jimin had seen it, his eyes kept returning to it.

And, naturally, so did his thoughts.

Jungkook.

This time the memory didn't come with shouting or slammed doors.

It came with a gentle hand closing around his wrist, fingers carefully turning his palm upward. Kisses on the shoulder and on the lips.

Jimin's gaze stayed fixed as the memories moved through him in small pieces. Jungkook's hands had always been like that. Strangely gentle when Jimin least expected it. His words could sound demanding even while his thumb brushed carefully over skin or his fingers lingered around Jimin's wrist longer than necessary.

Jimin swallowed.

His fingers loosened from the collar.

For another second, he studied himself in the mirror then exhaled through his nose.

He could change coats and he probably should.

Instead, he smoothed the collar back into place and left it exactly where it was.

Jimin wasn't expecting much from the day.

He knew people were still talking. By now, the entire school probably knew some version of what had happened, whether it was true or not. He hadn't seen Eric since the fight, and he had no idea what Eric had said afterward or how much of it had spread beyond the dining hall.

Still, Jimin couldn't find it in himself to be as angry with him as he probably should have been.

Whatever Eric had said had come from somewhere painful. Hurt had a way of making people cruel, and Jimin understood that more than he wanted to. In some strange way, he carried the same kind of anger toward Jungkook. Not the same situation, not the same reasons, but enough that Jimin could recognize what it felt like to lash out because something mattered too much.

He looked at himself in the mirror one last time.

Enough about Jungkook.

Jimin grabbed his notebook from the desk and tucked it beneath one arm before reaching for his knife kit. He turned toward Taehyung and let out a slow breath.

"Okay... I'm gonna head over there."

Taehyung nodded, but his eyes stayed on Jimin's face. He studied him for a second longer than necessary, like he was still trying to see whether this new calm was real or whether Jimin was one mildly inconvenient comment away from falling apart.

"Are you sure you don't want me to go with you?"

Jimin shook his head.

"No. I think...I think I need to do this part by myself."

Taehyung's brows pulled together slightly.

Jimin adjusted the strap around his knife kit and gave him a small smile.

"I'm okay, Tae. Really."

Taehyung still looked unconvinced, but he didn't argue. After a moment, he stepped forward and reached up to straighten Jimin's collar.

"You better be."

Jimin laughed softly.

"I'll see you there."

Jimin moved toward the door. His hand rested on the handle for a second before he opened the door and stepped into the hallway alone.



The main banquet hall was still being prepared when Jimin arrived.

The gala wouldn't begin for another few hours, but the space was already bustling with movement. Staff hurried between tables carrying folded linens, crates of glassware, and polished silver trays. Long streamers in the academy's colors were being hung along the upper balconies, and enormous flower arrangements were lifted carefully onto pedestals near the entrance.

Someone stood on a ladder adjusting one of the chandeliers while another group worked near the stage, checking the placement of microphones and name cards.

Jimin slowed.

The room looked completely different from the way it usually did. The tall windows had been cleaned until they reflected the afternoon light, and every table was dressed in crisp white linen with gold-edged place settings arranged perfectly around the plates. Flowers spilled from tall vases in soft layers of cream, green, and pale pink, making the entire hall smell faintly sweet beneath the sharper scent of polish and fresh fabric.

He kept walking, his notebook tucked beneath one arm and his knife kit hanging securely from his hand, but his attention continued drifting around the room. More decorations were being carried through the side doors. Someone tested the lights near the stage, briefly washing the entire hall in a warm golden glow before switching them off again.

It was beautiful.

And suddenly, Jimin remembered why he was there.

The thought hit him hard enough to slow his steps.

The nerve of him.

Somebody from a small town in New York had somehow ended up here, inside one of the academy's biggest events of the year, preparing to cook for people whose names carried weight far beyond the school. Famous chefs. Critics. Donors. Faculty. Alumni. The dean.

And somehow, Jimin was one of the people they were coming to see.

The thought felt almost ridiculous.

He glanced down at himself, at the clean white chef's coat fitted neatly around his body and his name stitched over his chest.

PARK JIMIN.

It still looked strange there.

There was something almost taboo about standing in the middle of all this elegance knowing what people had probably been saying about him all week. He had gone from being the unknown American student with too much confidence to the subject of one of the academy's favorite rumors.

People knew his name now.

Just not necessarily for the reasons he had wanted.

Jimin could already imagine some of the conversations that would happen once the hall filled. The glances. The whispers behind wine glasses. Someone leaning across a table to quietly point him out.

That's him.

For a second, the old instinct returned. He wanted to turn and run out.

Jimin caught himself before he could do it.

His grip tightened around the handle of his knife kit.

Jimin straightened his shoulders and kept walking, letting the sounds of preparation move around him. The nervousness was still there somewhere, faint and restless beneath his ribs, but it wasn't strong enough to control the way he carried himself. At least not anymore.

Whatever people believed, whatever they whispered, whatever reputation had attached itself to his name, none of it changed the fact that he could cook.

Jimin's eyes settled on the doors leading toward the kitchen.

His steps became more certain as he approached them.

That feeling lasted until Jimin pushed open the kitchen doors.

The room beyond them was enormous.

He stopped just inside the entrance, his hand still resting against the push bar as his eyes moved slowly over the space. The gala kitchen had clearly been prepared with as much care as the banquet hall. Stainless steel counters stretched beneath bright overhead lights, polished so cleanly that they reflected the glow above them.

Every counter had been arranged with fresh towels, sharpened tools, stacked plates, and small containers waiting to be filled.

Several ovens lined the far wall, larger and newer than the ones Jimin usually worked with, and tall refrigerators stood beside them with printed labels already taped to the doors. The air smelled mostly of metal, citrus cleaner and fresh herbs.

In the center of the room stood a large island workspace, wide enough for several chefs to move around comfortably.

Then he noticed the card.

It sat near the center of the island beside a single small flower placed in a narrow glass vase. The arrangement was so simple that Jimin almost missed it among all the equipment.

He walked toward it slowly.

The front of the card read:

Welcome, Park Jimin.

Congratulations on your selection for this year's gala.

Jimin's mouth softened before he could stop it.

He set his knife kit down carefully and picked up the card with both hands, turning it over.

There was more writing on the back.

Not printed this time.

Handwritten.

The letters were clean and sharp, slightly slanted, every line neat enough to look almost printed.

Jimin,

Your station has been prepared according to the requirements submitted with your original menu. Any additional ingredients or equipment requests should be directed to the assigned kitchen staff.

You earned your place here. Conduct yourself accordingly.

Remain focused. Trust your training.

J.K.

Jimin stared at the initials, then he rolled his eyes.

Of course Jungkook couldn't write a normal congratulations card. Even encouragement from him sounded vaguely like a command.

Still, Jimin didn't put it down.

His thumb moved slowly across the ink instead, brushing over the letters before drifting back toward the beginning.

His chest pulled strangely.

Seeing his name in Jungkook's handwriting felt far more intimate than it probably was.

Jungkook had written it.

He had sat somewhere, taken a pen in his hand, and formed each letter himself.

Jimin.

One letter at a time.

Jimin's fingers brushed lightly over his name again.

His heart gave an annoying little tug.

"Oh, for God's sake."

He placed the card face down on the counter before his brain could spiral.



Jimin kept himself busy with the things that didn't require thinking.

He wiped down the counters even though it was already spotless, rinsed every bowl he planned to use, checked the lids on his containers, and lined his utensils up in neat rows. He wiped the handles of the pans. He folded his towels. He opened and closed the pantry twice just to make sure he hadn't forgotten anything.

Then he sat his knife kit on the island and unrolled it carefully.

The leather opened with a soft flap against the counter.

Jimin ran his fingers over each handle before choosing the first knife and reaching for the sharpening steel. The blade scraped against it with a clean metallic sound.

His hand trembled slightly around the handle.

The murmur outside the kitchen had grown louder over the last half hour. At first, it had only been a few voices passing through the hall. Now it had turned into a constant low hum beyond the doors.

Jimin kept sharpening.

The blade slid against the steel again, but this time his grip slipped just enough to make his stomach tighten.

He stopped.

Before he could tell himself to calm down, the kitchen doors opened behind him.

Two student assistants stepped inside, both dressed in fresh academy whites with their sleeves rolled neatly to the elbows.

The girl was first through the door. She was short, with dark brown hair twisted into a tight bun at the back of her head and a few loose pieces already falling around her face. Her name tag read *Camille Laurent*. She carried herself with the kind of nervous energy that made her movements quick but timid.

Behind her was a taller boy named *Luc Morel*, broad-shouldered and pale, with sandy brown hair pushed back from his forehead. He looked calmer than Camille, though the folded copy of the gala menu in his hand had already been covered in little handwritten notes along the margins.

“Park Jimin?” Camille asked.

Jimin turned from the island.

“Yeah?”

Camille glanced at Luc before looking back at him. “We’re your assistants for service today. Do you want us to start prepping for the lunch menu? We studied everything last night, so we’re ready whenever you are.”

Luc nodded and lifted the folded menu slightly in his hand. “We divided the prep between us already.”

Jimin went still.

His eyes dropped to the paper in Luc’s hand, and for a second he stared at it. The printed menu looked painfully official now that it was sitting there between them, every course laid out neatly in the order he had submitted days ago.

Right.

Jimin bit his lip and looked away, rubbing one hand over the back of his neck while he tried to figure out the least alarming way to say what came next.

“Actually, guys...” He glanced back at them. “We’re not doing that.”

Camille blinked at him, completely dumbfounded. Her clipboard lowered a little against her chest while Luc slowly lowered the menu.

“What do you mean?” Luc asked.

Jimin looked between them and gave a small, awkward shrug.

“I mean... we’re not cooking *that* menu.”

Neither of them said anything.

Camille’s eyebrows pulled together as she looked from Jimin to the menu and then back to him again, as though she was waiting for him to laugh and admit he was joking.

He didn’t.

“But they’ve already printed the menus,” she said.

“I know.”

“The guests in the hall are expecting what’s written here,” Luc added, tapping one finger against the page.

“I know.”

Camille lowered her clipboard completely now. “And the panel? What are they going to think when you serve something totally different?”

Jimin sighed and dragged a hand down the front of his chef’s coat.

“I know. I know.”

Camille and Luc turned toward each other.

Neither of them spoke, but Jimin could almost hear the telepathic conversation happening between them anyway. Camille’s eyes widened slightly. Luc’s lips pressed together. Then both of them looked back at Jimin with the same expression.

They were definitely wondering what terrible thing they had done to deserve being assigned to him.

Fair.

Jimin’s attention dropped to the notebook lying open across the counter. The rushed handwriting, arrows, crossed-out measurements, circled ingredients, and little reminders he had scribbled sometime after midnight when his handwriting had begun leaning farther and farther to the right.

Seeing it made some of his confidence return, but only a little.

The menus were already printed and sitting on the tables outside. Everyone in the banquet hall had arrived expecting the courses listed on those pages. The panel had been given the same menu, probably studied it, probably already formed opinions about what they expected from him.

And Jungkook had absolutely no idea what Jimin was planning.

Jimin could already picture the look he was going to get when the first plate arrived and looked nothing like what had been submitted.

He pushed the thought away before it could turn into another reason to panic.

Jimin closed the notebook and looked back at Camille and Luc.

“I know this sounds bad.”

They both stared at him.

“Okay,” he muttered. “It sounds *really* bad.”

Jimin let out another breath and placed both hands against the edge of the counter.

“Look, I know you guys studied the original menu, and I know you probably spent all night learning the prep and the timing and everything and I’m so sorry I wasted your time.” His eyes moved between them. “And I know changing the entire thing a few hours before service is probably...”

He paused, searching for a word that didn’t make him sound completely irresponsible.

“Insane?” Luc offered.

Jimin slowly looked at him.

“I was going to say ambitious...” He nodded after a second. “But I guess that works fine.”

Camille finally smiled, just a little, and some of the stiffness left her shoulders.

Jimin straightened.

“But I need you both to trust me.”

That brought their attention fully back to him.

“I spent all night working on this,” he continued, tapping his fingers lightly against the closed notebook. “I know what I’m making. I know how I want everything plated, I know what has to be done first, and I know the timing. I went through it over and over before I came here.”

Camille glanced toward the notebook.

Jimin followed her eyes.

“I’m not just walking in here and changing everything because I woke up this morning and decided I wanted to cause problems.”

He paused.

“Not completely, anyway.”

Luc looked down at the menu still in his hand, then lifted it again.

“So we’re really throwing all this out?”

Jimin winced.

“Maybe don’t say it like that.”

Camille folded her arms. “What should we call it?”

Jimin looked toward the ceiling for a second, thinking.

“A creative change in direction.”

Jimin held their expressions for a moment before giving a small nod, mostly to himself. He reached for the notebook before either of them could argue and turned it around on the counter so the pages faced them.

Camille stepped closer first, curiosity beginning to replace the concern on her face. Luc moved beside her, setting the old menu down as he leaned over the island.

Jimin opened the notebook to the first page.

His fingers rested there for a second.

The nervousness was still somewhere underneath everything, but looking at those pages reminded him why he had changed the menu in the first place.

He pulled the notebook closer to the center of the island and looked between them.

“Now...” Jimin said, a small smile beginning to form. “Here’s what we’re actually doing today.”



Jimin wiped the rim of another plate clean and set it carefully with the others.

There were still more coming.

Camille had taken one side of the kitchen, moving between the ovens with her sleeves pushed higher now and a towel thrown over one shoulder. Luc was working through the sauces, checking one pot, then another, then hurrying back whenever Jimin called his name.

Somewhere in the middle of all of it was Jimin, bouncing between stations, answering questions, correcting little things, tasting, adjusting, and trying not to think too hard about the fact that everything they were making was completely different from what had been promised.

Camille had already asked him twice if he was sure about the menu.

Luc had asked three times.

“I just don’t know how they’re going to take this,” Camille said as she opened one of the ovens and leaned away from the rush of heat. “They’re expecting something *very* specific.”

Jimin looked over from the counter. “I know.”

Luc glanced up from the stove. “And are you sure we shouldn’t at least keep *one* of the original courses? Just so there’s something familiar?”

Jimin understood their concern.

He really did.

The people outside had arrived dressed in expensive clothes expecting elegant little plates arranged exactly the way the academy had promised them. There were probably people in that hall who could identify twelve kinds of wine by smell alone and had extremely strong opinions about the proper size of a garnish.

If Jimin were rich and French, maybe he would want tiny food on tiny plates too.

Unfortunately for everyone outside, he was neither.

So this was what they were getting.

“Trust me,” he said again.

He tried to make it sound convincing but the closer they got to lunch service, though, the sweatier his palms became.

Jimin wiped one against the side of his pants before reaching for the spoon resting beside a large saucepan. The sauce had been sitting over low heat for a while, thickening slowly. Jimin dipped the spoon in and stirred through the center, watching the sauce move around it before settling again.

“Okay,” he murmured.

Camille closed the oven and came closer. Luc stepped away from the stove.

Both of them stood there watching him.

Jimin lifted the spoon to his mouth and tasted.

His eyes closed.

He stood there for another second, letting the flavor sit.

It was warm and rich, exactly the way he remembered it. There was enough spice to settle at the back of his tongue without covering everything underneath. The flavor reminded him of home so quickly that for a moment the kitchen around him seemed farther away.

It tasted like good days and good food, the kind when everybody stayed at the table longer than they needed to because nobody was ready to leave yet.

It reminded him of his mother wrapping her arms around him after a rough day, holding him close without making him explain anything at all. It reminded him of sitting with his dad and talking until whatever had bothered him earlier didn't feel as heavy. A walk with his grandma where she talked and Jimin listened, slowing down whenever she did. A car ride with Hobi, music turned too loud while they laughed and talked over each other.

Jimin swallowed.

For a second, he almost forgot Camille and Luc were standing there.

Then he opened his eyes.

Camille's eyebrows were raised while Luc was staring at him confused.

Jimin gestured toward the clean tasting spoons.

“Taste?”

Neither of them moved. Jimin looked between them, waiting, but Camille only glanced at Luc and Luc glanced back at her like they were silently trying to decide who was going to risk it first.

“Guys.” Jimin sighed when neither of them reached for a spoon. “I'm not trying to poison you.”

“That is not what we're worried about,” Camille muttered.

Still, she stepped forward first, and Luc followed a moment later. They each picked up a clean spoon and dipped carefully into the sauce while Jimin leaned back against the counter, watching them with his arms loose at his sides.

Camille tasted hers first, and her eyes widened almost immediately. Luc's reaction came a second later, his brows lifting as he looked down at the spoon and then back toward the pot.

Camille swallowed. "Whoa."

Luc pointed toward the saucepan with his spoon, still looking slightly surprised. "This is...wow"

Camille took another taste, slower this time, letting the sauce sit on her tongue before swallowing. Her expression softened as she considered it, some of the concern she had been carrying all morning finally easing from her face.

"It's *really*...good."

Jimin felt something in his chest loosen.

Luc nodded, looking almost annoyed by how much he agreed. "Really good."

Jimin laughed. "Thank you."

Camille looked from the saucepan toward the growing line of plates waiting across the counter, and some of her uncertainty returned. "I still think they're going to be shocked."

Jimin picked up a clean spoon and gave the sauce one final stir. "Good."

Luc stared at him long enough that Jimin eventually glanced over his shoulder.

"What?"

"That doesn't concern you?"

Jimin gave him a look before admitting, "Oh, I'm terrified." Jimin set the spoon down and reached for the next plate. "But if they're going to talk about me anyway, they might as well have something good to say."

Luc looked down at the saucepan again, then over at Camille, and shook his head with a quiet laugh.

"C'est vrai ce qu'on dit... cet Américain est fou."

Jimin's head snapped toward him.

"Hey!"

Luc froze and stared at him. "You speak French?"

Jimin narrowed his eyes at him, suddenly defensive even though he had only understood not even half of what was said.

"Maybe. Maybe not."

He tried to make it sound convincing.

It didn't.

What Jimin did know was that, since coming to France, he had somehow managed to pick up on two words very quickly.

American.

And crazy.

Well, this *crazy American* barely had time to enjoy the moment before the kitchen doors opened again.

A line of servers entered one after another, and the sudden formality of them made Jimin straighten without meaning to. They were all dressed in fitted black suits with crisp white shirts underneath, each carrying a large silver serving tray balanced neatly against one hand.

A few of the older men had the sort of perfectly groomed mustaches Jimin had once thought only existed in movies about France.

The man at the front of the line stepped forward. He was older than the others, tall and thin with graying hair combed neatly away from his face. His eyes moved briefly across the kitchen before settling on Jimin.

“Park Jimin?”

Jimin swallowed. “Yes?”

“Lunch service is beginning.”

That sentence did something terrible to his stomach.

The man checked the watch beneath the cuff of his jacket before continuing. “The first course is expected shortly. We will collect each table together and serve the room in sequence. Once your plates are ready, they are to be placed here.”

He gestured toward the empty trays.

Jimin nodded slowly.

“Okay.”

This was it.

Until now, everything had stayed safely inside the kitchen. His menu could still exist as scribbles in a notebook and ingredients sitting in bowls. Camille and Luc could question him all they wanted, but nobody outside those doors knew what he had done yet.

The second one of those trays left the room, they would.

The servers had begun moving closer to the counter now, ready to collect the first plates, and Jimin noticed almost immediately that several of them were looking at the food with varying levels of

confusion.

One man leaned forward slightly, his brows drawing together as he studied the plate nearest him. Another looked down at the tray, then up at Jimin, then back down again as if he was waiting for someone to explain what had happened to the printed menu.

A younger server at the end of the line was less subtle. His mouth tightened slightly as he looked over the plating, and for a second Jimin could have sworn there was something close to disgust in his expression.

Jimin's stomach dropped.

Great.

Exactly what he needed to boost his confidence!

One of the older servers cleared his throat.

"This is the first course?"

Jimin nodded.

"Yes."

The man looked at the plate again.

"And *this* is what you wish to send?"

Jimin felt every bit of confidence he had gathered over the last hour wobble.

He looked at Camille.

Camille gave him the smallest nod.

Luc, from the stove, lifted his brows as if to say *well?*

Jimin turned back toward the server.

"Yes," he said, more firmly this time. "That's what I'm sending."

The man held his gaze for a second before giving a short nod and reaching for the plate.

Around him, the other servers began doing the same, though the looks didn't stop.

Jimin could feel them examining every detail as they lifted the dishes onto their trays. One server whispered something under his breath to another in French. Jimin didn't understand, of course, but the glance they sent toward the plate afterward told him plenty.

His palms started sweating again.

He wiped them quickly against his pants.

Beyond the doors, the muffled sound of the banquet hall seemed louder now. Hundreds of voices blended beneath the music, broken occasionally by laughter or the clink of glasses. Somewhere out

there, people were already looking down at their printed menus and waiting for something Jimin had absolutely no intention of giving them.

The servers began filing out one by one.

Each lifted a silver tray carefully onto one hand before turning toward the doors, their backs straight and their heads held high as they formed a single line. Their steps were identical, almost creepy.

The first server pushed through the doors.

They opened wide enough for Jimin to catch a glimpse of the banquet hall beyond them. A flash of white tablecloths. The warm glow of chandeliers. Someone in a dark suit turning in their chair.

Then the doors swung shut.

The next server reached them.

Open.

Jimin caught another sliver of the room. A raised wineglass. The edge of a flower arrangement. The back of someone's head.

Closed.

Then open again.

Closed.

Open.

Closed.

Jimin stood still beside the counter, watching the doors move back and forth as each tray disappeared through them. Every time they opened, the outside world appeared for barely a second before vanishing again.

He found himself trying to see too much through those tiny glimpses.

Anything.

Maybe even a small part of him searched for Jungkook.

But the doors never stayed open long enough.

Jimin rubbed his damp palms against the sides of his pants and stared at the narrow seam between the doors after the last server disappeared.



Jimin paced.

Back and forth across the kitchen, then back again.

His arms were folded tightly across his chest, but every few steps one hand came loose to wipe against the side of his pants. The first course had been out for nearly twenty minutes now, and the longer the doors stayed closed, the worse the silence inside the kitchen felt.

Camille and Luc had stopped pretending not to also be nervous.

Camille stood near the ovens with a towel held between both hands, her attention drifting toward Jimin every time he turned. Luc remained by the stove, one hand resting against the counter, his expression more worried than before.

Neither of them said anything. There was nothing useful to say anyway.

Jimin checked the clock again.

Twenty-one minutes.

His stomach tightened.

He tried to tell himself that twenty minutes meant nothing. People were eating, talking, and drinking. Plus, they were used to those tiny little portions that disappeared in three bites, so maybe an actual plate of food was just taking them longer to eat.

Still, his mind kept moving faster than the clock.

Maybe they hated it.

Maybe the panel was sitting out there discussing how badly he had screwed up.

Maybe they were deciding whether changing the menu without permission was grounds for expulsion.

Maybe the next person through those doors would be an executioner carrying a guillotine and Jimin would have to kneel down, stick his head through it, and wait for the chop.

The kitchen doors suddenly flew open.

Jimin audibly gasped. His body jerked as he spun toward the sound, one hand flying instinctively toward his chest.

A server stood in the doorway.

Jimin stared at him, heart pounding.

Thankfully, no guillotine.

The man looked more worn than he had earlier. A faint flush had risen across his cheeks, and the careful neatness of his hair had loosened slightly near his forehead. His breathing was frantic, as if he had been running.

He carried no tray this time.

The server straightened once he was fully inside the kitchen and looked directly at him.

“Mr. Park.”

Jimin looked around even though he was addressed.

The man continued.

“The dean and the members of the panel have requested your presence in the banquet hall.”

Jimin’s fingers curled against his arms.

Behind him, Camille and Luc went still.

The server’s face gave nothing away.

Jimin swallowed.

“They would like to speak with you before the next course is served.”

Chapter End Notes

Come say hi to me on twt!!! @starmaryberry

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

AT LASTTTTTT! 😭 Not gonna lie, guys, this chapter is kinda long but it is the finale after all, so I had to go all out.

Grab a snack, get cozy, and settle in because we've got a lot to get through. I really hope you guys enjoy it! 💕

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)



Jimin thought there were probably three things in life he had ever genuinely regretted doing.

Number one was trying the One Chip Challenge with Hobi in ninth grade.

At fifteen, this had seemed like a perfectly reasonable thing to do. Hobi had bought the stupid thing from some convenience store near school, and the box had been shaped like a coffin, which in hindsight should have been more than enough warning for any person with a functioning brain. Unfortunately, neither of them had one at the time. Hobi had dared him, Jimin had taken that to heart, and five minutes later he had been hunched over a cafeteria table with tears streaming down his face while Hobi alternated between laughing at him and shoving cartons of milk into his hands. His lips had felt like they were on fire. His tongue had gone numb. His nose had started running so badly that one of the lunch monitors had asked if he needed to go to the nurse. Jimin had refused on principle, mostly because Hobi was already recording him and there were certain levels of humiliation a person just didn't come back from.

Number two would definitely be something involving Jungkook.

The exact offense depended heavily on Jimin's mood.

Sometimes he regretted kissing him...and then doing it *again*.

Sometimes he regretted letting Jungkook kiss him.

Sometimes he regretted ever going into that office, or ever allowing himself to notice the irritating little changes in Jungkook's expression that nobody else seemed able to see, or ever finding out what he looked like when he laughed for real instead of giving one of those tiny, smug little exhales through his nose.

Other days, Jimin preferred to simplify the matter entirely and regret learning Jeon Jungkook ever existed.

That covered most of it.

Meeting him. Talking to him. Arguing with him. Wanting him. Kissing him. Missing him. Crying over him. Thinking about him at wildly inappropriate times. Developing the deeply unfortunate ability to recognize the sound of his footsteps in a hallway.

Really, there were several subcategories beneath number two.

He should probably make a list.

As for number three...

Well.

Jimin didn't actually have one yet.

You would think he might have chosen *this*.

Standing in the middle of the academy's largest gala after secretly replacing an approved menu that had already been printed, distributed, and placed in front of several hundred guests certainly felt like it deserved consideration.

But no.

Jimin wasn't ready to commit. Maybe tonight would surprise him. Maybe number three was still loading.

He became so distracted arranging this completely necessary ranking system in his head that he failed to notice something very important.

He had stopped walking.

Actually—

Jimin blinked.

A large round table sat directly in front of him.

For several seconds, Jimin just stared at it.

The white tablecloth fell in perfect folds toward the floor. Crystal glasses caught the chandelier light along their rims. Silverware had been arranged with the kind of precision that made Jimin feel small just looking at it, and several plates sat scattered around the table, most of them suspiciously empty except for streaks of sauce.

There were also people sitting around it.

Quite a few people.

Important-looking people.

Jimin's eyes moved slowly from one face to another without really registering any of them before landing on the man seated near the center.

The dean.

Oh.

Jimin's stomach dropped.

The server beside him cleared his throat.

The sound cut through his thoughts so sharply that Jimin's head snapped toward him.

The man extended one hand toward the table with the same calm professionalism he had maintained the entire walk.

"Chef Park Le doyen."

Jimin stared at him.

Then at the dean.

Then back at the server.

His brain took another second to catch up.

When the fuck had they crossed the ballroom?

Jimin glanced over his shoulder.

The kitchen doors were nowhere near him.

They sat far across the hall, barely visible between rows of occupied tables, towering flower arrangements, and the occasional server moving through the crowd with a silver tray balanced over one hand.

Jimin turned forward again, almost impressed.

Wow.

Apparently, when placed under enough emotional distress, he had excellent dissociation skills.

Good to know.

Maybe he could put that on a résumé.

Works well under pressure. Can mentally leave own body while continuing to walk in a straight line.

"Merci. Laissez-nous." The dean didn't raise his voice when he said it. The server beside Jimin gave a small nod, one hand folding neatly over the other before he stepped backward from the table.

Jimin watched him go.

For a second too long, probably.

The man disappeared between the tables with the same calm demeanor he had used to escort Jimin across the ballroom, and Jimin had the sudden, ridiculous urge to call him back. Not because the server could actually help him. He had said maybe five words to Jimin all evening. Still, there had been something comforting about having another person standing beside him, even if that person had technically been the one responsible for delivering him directly into whatever this was.

Jimin was alone.

Well.

Not *alone*.

He drew in a deep breath and felt it catch somewhere halfway down his chest. His lungs expanded unevenly beneath his chef's coat, and when he released it, the breath came out shakier than he would have liked.

Then he turned toward the table.

The dean was already looking at him.

Up close, the man was somehow more intimidating than he had been from any picture Jimin had seen of him. He looked to be somewhere in his sixties, maybe older, though age had done very little to soften him. His silver hair was combed neatly away from his forehead, every strand in place beneath the warm chandelier light. Deep lines framed his mouth and gathered at the corners of his eyes, giving him the permanent expression of judgment.

His suit was charcoal gray, perfectly tailored, with a white shirt underneath and a dark silk tie pulled neatly against his throat. A narrow pair of glasses rested low along the bridge of his nose. The dean rarely seemed to look through them. Instead, he watched Jimin over the top of the frames, his gaze focused.

There was no obvious anger on his face.

Jimin had always preferred knowing exactly when someone was mad at him. This?

This was terrifying.

The dean just... watched him.

Jimin could feel several other members of the panel doing the same, their attention moving over him in varying degrees of curiosity and scrutiny

-And then there was Jungkook.

Jimin could feel him.

No.

Sense him.

Like some kind of animal.

His pulse jumped hard beneath his skin, one sudden beat that seemed to strike directly against his throat. Goosebumps prickled faintly along his arms beneath the sleeves of his coat.

Jimin didn't have to turn his head.

He knew Jungkook was watching him.

Jimin could feel the stare boring into him from somewhere to the dean's right, so heavy that it almost felt physical. It crawled over the side of his face and settled against his chest, making his heartbeat pound harder until the sound of it began to fill his ears.

Every instinct in him wanted to look toward Jungkook. He wanted to know what expression he was wearing. Whether he looked angry. Whether he looked disappointed. Whether he already knew Jimin was about to be ripped apart in front of the entire panel and had decided not to warn him.

Worse, some smaller part of Jimin wanted reassurance.

He hated that.

Jungkook had already told him what to do.

Make your own decisions.

Don't look to me for confirmation.

Jimin swallowed.

Fine.

Jimin shifted his weight almost imperceptibly between his feet. His mouth had gone dry. He ran his tongue quickly along the inside of his lower lip and realized, with increasing horror, that nobody appeared interested in speaking first.

Okay...That seemed fair.

Jimin cleared his throat.

The sound came out a little too sharp in the quiet around the table.

Several pairs of eyes remained on him.

He tried to smile.

"Hello..." His voice came out smaller than he intended. Jimin straightened his shoulders. "H-hi. Thank you so much for allowing me this opportunity. I really appreciate being selected for tonight, and I just wanted to say that I—"

The dean exhaled through his nose.

Jimin stopped so quickly his teeth nearly clicked together. His lips remained parted for a second before he slowly closed them.

The dean lowered his gaze toward his plate. He reached for the white cloth napkin resting across one knee and lifted it with two fingers, dabbing carefully at the corner of his mouth.

Jimin could practically feel his remaining lifespan shrinking with every tiny motion.

The dean folded the napkin once.

Then again.

His expression remained unreadable as he placed it neatly beside his plate, adjusted one corner until it sat exactly where he wanted it, and finally lifted his eyes back to Jimin.

“When my father founded this academy in 1964,” he began, his accent thick but clear, rounding some of his vowels and sharpening others, “he had one thing in mind.”

The dean rested one hand lightly against the edge of the table.

“He believed cooking could be taught.” His eyes moved briefly along the table, passing over the other panelists before returning to Jimin. “Cooking.”

The dean gestured faintly toward the hall around them.

“He believed that a student could learn to understand heat, balance, timing, restraint. That a chef could be taught to respect an ingredient, respect his kitchen, and respect the people working beside him.” The dean leaned back slightly. “But he also believed there was one thing no academy could give a chef.”

Jimin’s brows pulled together.

“A reason.” The dean’s gaze held his. “A reason to cook.”

Jimin’s eyes brightened before he could stop them.

His shoulders loosened by the smallest amount, and his lips parted, already preparing some deeply relieved response.

“I—”

“Except.”

Jimin froze.

The dean reached for the printed gala menu resting beside his plate and lifted it carefully between two fingers. His gaze moved down the page before returning to Jimin.

“When this menu was submitted,” he said, “it was reviewed by faculty. Approved by the academy. Distributed to staff. Printed for our guests.”

With every sentence, Jimin felt himself being buried further and further into the ground bellow him.

The dean tilted the menu slightly.

“And yet nearly nothing written here appeared on my table.”

Jimin swallowed.

“No, sir.”

The dean’s brows lifted a fraction.

“No?”

Jimin’s fingers tightened against the seams of his pants .

“No, sir.”

“You replaced an approved gala service less than one day before it began.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Without submitting revisions.”

Jimin’s throat tightened.

“Yes.”

“Without notifying the panel.”

“Yes, sir.”

Then the dean lowered the page slightly. His eyes narrowed almost imperceptibly.

“Then...who approved these changes, Mr. Park?”

Jimin opened his mouth.

Then closed it.

The answer sounded worse when someone else asked the question.

Nobody.

No one had approved anything.

Jimin’s ears warmed.

The dean lowered the menu onto the table. Slowly, his attention shifted away from Jimin. Jimin knew where it was going before the man even turned his head.

His stomach dropped.

“Director Jeon....Did you approve Mr. Park’s decision to replace the menu?”

Jimin’s gaze followed despite himself.

And there he was.

Jungkook sat several seats away, dressed in black as usual, one arm resting lightly against the edge of the table. His posture was perfect, shoulders straight beneath the dark suit, but Jimin knew him well enough now to notice the tension sitting underneath it.

But, there was something in Jungkook's expression that made Jimin's stomach tighten before the dean had even finished the question. It wasn't surprise. If anything, Jungkook looked almost as though he had expected this, not just the panel's suspicion or the inevitable questions about the menu, but Jimin himself standing here at the center of them.

There was a quiet familiarity in the way he watched him, the faintest resignation settling beneath the tension in his face, as though somewhere between all of Jimin's arguments, impulsive decisions, constant questioning, and stubborn refusal to do anything the easy way, Jungkook had already learned that Park Jimin would eventually do exactly this. Of course he would change the menu last minute. Of course he would bend the rules. Of course he would walk directly into the consequences afterward with that same ridiculous mixture of fear and determination Jungkook had been dealing with since the day they met.

Jimin could see it now in the slight tightening of Jungkook's mouth and the almost imperceptible lift of his brows, not quite amusement and certainly not approval, but something dangerously close to *I knew you would do something like this..but why?* It made heat creep beneath Jimin's collar because there was something almost intimate about being known that well, especially by someone he was currently trying *very* hard not to need.

For one brief, humiliating second, Jimin wanted Jungkook to lie. Not some enormous thing that would place the entire decision on his shoulders, just something small enough to stand beside Jimin in it. He wanted Jungkook to say Jimin had mentioned making changes, that they had discussed the possibility, that he had approved one component or suspected something might be different. Anything that would make Jimin feel slightly less alone beneath the attention of the table.

Jungkook's eyes stayed on his for another long moment, and the terrible part was that Jimin could almost see that he understood exactly what Jimin wanted from him.

Then Jungkook's gaze finally broke.

He looked down toward the table, his jaw tightening once as his fingers shifted beside his glass, and when he answered, his voice was low and perfectly controlled.

"No."

He didn't look back at Jimin when he said it.

The dean's attention returned to Jimin with such complete focus that it felt almost physical. For a moment, he said nothing. He just studied Jimin from across the table. The silence stretched before the man finally spoke.

"So what does this say about your respect for your own teacher," the dean asked at last, his voice low and measured, "let alone this school...let alone me?"

Jimin opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

It might have been the first time in his entire life that words had failed him.

He could think of plenty of things he wanted to say. That he hadn't changed the menu because he didn't respect the academy. That it had nothing to do with humiliating Jungkook. That he hadn't spent the night plotting some elaborate act of rebellion against French culinary education. *Well... not really.*

He had just reached a point where every dish he looked at felt like something another person had told him to cook, and the thought of standing in that kitchen and serving it anyway had made him feel like a fraud.

Unfortunately, none of that arranged itself into a sentence.

Jimin's lips parted once more, then closed.

The dean watched the failed attempt with an unreadable expression before a quiet hum left him. The sound came out like disappointment, as if the man had already begun reaching his own conclusion about the situation.

The dean straightened in his chair.

"Park Jimin," he began, and hearing his full name spoken that carefully made Jimin's stomach twist. "The American who came here for...for what, exactly? To learn? To advance?" His brows drew together slightly as his gaze sharpened. "To lie? To deceive? To betray the loyalty expected of you and make a mockery of your director and my academy?"

Oh no.

This was bad.

Very, very, very bad.

Jimin felt the thought move through him with startling clarity.

His stomach dropped first, followed quickly by the heat rising along the back of his neck. For one horrible second, he could already imagine how this ended. His name removed from the gala program. His academic record destroyed. Some formal letter written in very elegant French explaining that Park Jimin had been dismissed from one of the most prestigious culinary academies in Europe because he had decided, at three in the morning, to change everything he'd ever learned.

He should say something.

He really, really should say something.

The dean had already started speaking again when Jimin finally found enough courage to force sound out of his throat.

"Sir...Dean...um, can I speak...may I?"

The words came louder than he intended.

Every member of the panel turned toward him at once.

One woman's brows lifted in open surprise. The older chef beside her paused with his wineglass halfway to his mouth, his fingers still wrapped around the stem.

All except Jungkook.

Jungkook barely reacted.

He remained exactly as he had been, his gaze lowered toward the table. The only indication that he had heard Jimin at all was the faint click of his jaw, a small movement beneath the skin that disappeared almost as quickly as it came.

The dean, however, looked taken aback.

His eyes widened slightly before his expression tightened into a frown. He blinked once, slowly, as though reconsidering whether Jimin had actually interrupted him or whether he had imagined it. Then he leaned back in his chair, one hand settling against the armrest as he regarded Jimin with a new kind of attention.

"I suppose," he said after a moment. His brows remained drawn together, but there was something almost curious beneath the irritation now. "Do you have anything to say for yourself?"

Jimin drew in a deep breath, the kind that filled his lungs until his chest hurt and lifted his shoulders beneath the white chef's coat. For a second, he held it there, desperately trying to gather every thought rushing through his head before they could come spilling out in the wrong order.

"Okay, I know you guys are all probably pissed—*shit*, I didn't mean to curse. I mean, I know you're all mad at me, and I know how this looks because, yeah, I changed the menu after it had already been approved and printed and everything, and I know that probably seems really disrespectful. But trust me, Mr. Dean, sir, I love cooking. I love this academy too, even when I complain about it, which is probably more often than I should, and Director Jeon...I..."

The name caught strangely in his throat.

Jimin's eyes betrayed him for half a second, flickering toward Jungkook before he could stop them. Jungkook had lifted his gaze again. He was watching him now with that same unreadable stillness, his expression composed except for the faint tension around his mouth and the slight narrowing of his eyes, as though he were listening to every word more closely than anyone else at the table.

Jimin swallowed and looked back toward the dean.

"Well." He inhaled again, quieter this time. "I would never do anything selfishly just to hurt someone. I wouldn't embarrass the school on purpose, and I wasn't trying to make anybody look stupid or disrespect anyone here. It's just—"

"Oh, I don't doubt that you love cooking."

The dean's interruption stopped him cleanly.

Jimin blinked.

The man had settled back into his chair, one hand resting near his plate. The severity in his face had eased by the smallest amount, though his eyes remained fixed on Jimin with the same sharp attention as before.

“In fact,” he continued, glancing briefly toward what little remained on the plate in front of him, “whatever it is you served us tonight was delicious.”

Jimin stared at him.

The dean’s mouth shifted faintly at one corner, not quite enough to become a smile.

“More than delicious, actually. It was one of the finest things I have been served in this hall in years.”

For a second, Jimin forgot what expression his face was supposed to make.

His brows lifted. His lips parted slightly. Whatever response had been sitting on his tongue disappeared, replaced by a stunned little silence that made him look almost younger than he had a moment before.

He glanced down at the dean’s plate as if there might somehow be evidence of a joke hidden there.

There wasn’t. In fact nearly every trace of the dish was gone.

Jimin looked back up slowly.

“Really?”

The dean gave a curt nod, his eyes still slightly narrowed as though he hadn’t entirely decided whether Jimin was charming, reckless, or just *this* ignorant.

Jimin let out a breath he hadn’t realized he was holding, and a small, disbelieving smile touched his mouth. “Oh. *Oh my God*. T-thank you? Seriously, thank you, that actually means so much to me.” The relief lasted for approximately two seconds before his expression shifted again. “But—wait. About the respect thing. I absolutely respect you, sir. I respect everyone sitting at this table.”

He looked down the line, suddenly more earnest than nervous.

“Chef Moreau, I know your work. I studied the way you build menus around one ingredient and somehow make every course feel different. Chef Laurent, I watched that interview you did about regional cooking like three times before deciding I didn’t want to be anywhere but here.” A few expressions around the table softened, and Jimin kept going, his nervousness gradually giving way to something more sincere. “Chef Dubois, your restaurant was one of the first places I ever looked up when I found out I was coming to France. Professor Mercier, you failed one of my practicals, and I was mad at you for like...a week. Maybe two. But you were right. I rushed it, and I knew I rushed it.”

That earned the faintest smile from her.

Jimin’s own smile flickered wider.

His eyes moved farther down the table.

Then stopped.

For a second, Jimin forgot the rest of the panel was there.

Jungkook was already looking at him.

His expression had softened, just barely, the tension in his jaw easing while his eyes stayed fixed on Jimin with that same unnerving steadiness that always made him feel as though Jungkook could see right through him.

Jimin held his gaze only for a second, then his eyes flickered down.

To Jungkook's mouth.

The movement was so small that nobody else at the table probably noticed, but Jimin did. He felt the heat rise beneath his collar almost immediately, and when he looked back up, Jungkook was still watching him.

Jimin swallowed.

“And Director Jeon...”

His voice came quieter this time.

He paused, suddenly aware of how exposed the words felt before he had even said them. There were a hundred things he could have chosen. Jungkook had taught him technique. He had taught him how to stop second-guessing every dish the moment it left his hands, how to trust his palate, how to stand in a kitchen and make a decision without looking around for someone else to tell him it was right.

Jimin's gaze dropped once more, then slipped away toward the table.

When he finally spoke, it was almost a whisper.

“He taught me to believe in myself.”

There were a thousand other things he could have said.

That Jungkook had made him better.

That he had made Jimin mad enough to want to improve just to prove him wrong.

That unfortunately, somewhere in the middle of all of that, Jimin had also become helplessly, undoubtedly in l—

His breath caught.

No.

Jimin lifted his head quickly, dragging his attention back toward the dean before his own brain could finish the sentence.

The dean dragged his tongue slowly along his front teeth, watching Jimin over the top of his glasses with an expression that had gone from openly critical to something harder to place.

“So what?” he asked. “Recognition and respect are two very different things.”

Jimin's smile disappeared.

"I know," he said quickly. "I know. Trust me, I do." He looked down for a second, gathering himself, then lifted his eyes again. "I know changing the menu was disrespectful. I know I should've asked. I know there were people who spent time approving it and planning around it, and I know I made everyone's jobs harder by changing everything at the last minute."

His fingers twisted together once before he forced them apart.

"But when I looked at that menu last night, I realized I didn't see myself in any of it."

The dean's expression shifted slightly.

"I saw everything I'd been taught. I saw the technique and flavors and all the things I knew would look right on a plate, but I didn't see *why* I was cooking any of it. It felt like I'd spent so long trying to prove I belonged here that I started making food for everyone except myself."

His voice softened.

"And I realized that way too late."

Jimin swallowed and continued.

"But once I realized it, I couldn't *un-realize* it. I knew I could serve the original menu and probably stay out of trouble, or I could take the risk and make something that actually meant something to me."

His gaze dropped briefly toward the empty plates scattered around the table.

"Something I actually wanted people to taste."

He looked back at the dean.

"I know that probably sounds selfish, but I don't think cooking is supposed to be selfish. I think if you're lucky enough to be good at something...if you're lucky enough to have something that feels like a gift, then you're supposed to share it with people. Not hide it behind whatever you think they want."

The room had gone very still.

Jimin's nerves were still there, but something bold had settled beneath them now.

"I thought...maybe getting in trouble was worth it if, for one night, I got to give everyone something that was actually mine."

The dean stared at him and for once, he seemed to have nothing ready.

His mouth opened slightly then closed.

The dean then glanced down at the table, reached for his wineglass, and took a slow sip. He swallowed, set it back down, then cleared his throat as though buying himself another second to think.

When he looked at Jimin again, the sternness in his face had softened despite his best efforts to keep it there.

“Well,” he said, almost reluctantly, “you certainly have a mouth on you, don’t you?”

Jimin covered his mouth almost immediately, embarrassment warming his cheeks as a small, sheepish smile broke through.

“Sorry.”

The dean shook his head.

“No, no.” His mouth twitched faintly, and for the first time since Jimin had been brought to the table, the expression on his face looked almost amused. “It is...how do you say...” He paused, searching for the word before finally muttering something in French. “*Audacieux.*”

Jimin blinked.

He had no idea what that meant. Still, the dean hadn’t thrown him out yet, so Jimin decided to assume it was something good. Or at least something that didn’t translate to *insufferable stupid American*.

From beside the dean, Chef Laurent finally spoke.

“Jimin, was it?”

Jimin’s attention snapped toward her so quickly he nearly gave himself whiplash.

“Y-yes.”

His heart gave another violent jump.

Chef Laurent knew his name!

Jimin had spent years knowing hers. He had watched interviews with her, read about her restaurants, studied photographs of her food. She was one of the most famous chefs in all of France.

And now she was looking directly at him.

Jimin tried very hard not to pass out.

Chef Laurent sat with her chin slightly raised, posture elegant without appearing stiff. Her dark hair had been swept neatly away from her face, leaving the sharp lines of her cheekbones exposed beneath the chandelier light. A pair of small gold earrings caught the glow whenever she moved her head. For several seconds, she didn’t say anything.

She only looked at him.

Her gaze moved slowly from his face to the white coat fitted around his shoulders, then back again. All the while Chef Laurent’s expression remained unreadable.

Then, slowly, one corner of those red lips lifted.

“I think,” she began, her English smooth beneath the soft weight of her French accent, “you have more guts than nearly any young chef I have ever allowed into my kitchen.”

Jimin’s eyes widened.

She held up one finger before he could get too excited.

“But...For your own sake, perhaps learn the importance of communication.”

A quiet laugh moved around the table.

Jimin’s cheeks warmed again.

“Yes, Chef.”

She tilted her head.

“*Before* you change an entire menu.”

Another ripple of laughter followed, slightly louder this time.

“Yes. Definitely. I will absolutely do that next time.”

Chef Laurent raised one brow, her smile disappearing.

“There will not be a next time.”

Jimin paused.

“Yes...right...yes...chef.”

The dean hummed at that, a low sound of consideration as his gaze lingered on Jimin for another moment before drifting toward the rest of the table. He adjusted his glasses with one finger and leaned back in his chair, the severity that had held his face earlier having loosened into something almost thoughtful.

“Well,” he said, switching back into French as he turned toward the other panelists, “*je suppose que je dois pratiquer ce que je prêche. Qu’en dites-vous?*”

The panelists began looking at one another. Chef Laurent leaned toward Chef Dubois and murmured something beneath her breath. The older man beside her answered with a quiet grunt before glancing down at the remains of Jimin’s dish again. Another chef lifted the printed menu and gestured toward it while speaking quickly in French, earning a dismissive wave from the woman across from him.

Jimin’s smile slowly faded.

Oh, God.

They were talking about him.

He shifted his weight from one foot to the other, trying to catch familiar words as the conversation moved around the table, but the words came too quickly. Every so often he recognized something

useful—*menu, technique*, —which really wasn't enough to build any comforting conclusions from.

Then Jungkook spoke.

Jimin's attention went to him immediately.

"J'aimerais voir de quoi il est vraiment capable."

His voice was quieter than the others but carried easily across the table, low beneath the surrounding conversation.

A smile slowly spread across the deans face as he turned toward Jungkook. *"Vous ne connaissez donc pas votre propre élève?"*

Something shifted in Jungkook's expression.

His gaze moved toward Jimin.

For a moment, the two of them looked at one another across the table. Then Jungkook's mouth pulled faintly at one corner, the expression so subtle Jimin might have missed it if he weren't looking for it..

"Vous n'en avez aucune idée," Jungkook replied.

Jimin narrowed his eyes.

The conversation continued for another minute or two, passing around him while Jimin remained standing awkwardly at the edge of the table with his hands clasped in front of him. At one point Chef Laurent looked at him, said something to Chef Dubois, and both of them smiled.

Jimin's face heated up. He hoped they weren't making fun of him.

Eventually, the dean lifted one hand.

The conversation quieted.

He turned back toward Jimin, studying him for a few seconds before his gaze dropped toward the empty plate sitting in front of him.

"Where did you learn this dish?"

Jimin blinked.

A faint smile touched his mouth, though embarrassment warmed his face almost immediately. After everything they had just said about technique, legacy, prestigious kitchens, and generations of culinary training, the answer suddenly felt almost painfully silly.

"My mom," he admitted. *"It's her recipe."*

Chef Dubois, who had been tracing one finger absently around the base of his wineglass, looked up. *"Your mother?"* he leaned forward slightly. *"Was she a chef?"*

Jimin's smile grew.

“No.” The answer came without hesitation. “She just cooks.”

“Just cooks,” the dean repeated.

He said it slowly, almost thoughtfully, as though the phrase had interested him more than Jimin’s answer itself. His tongue pressed briefly against the inside of his cheek while he considered it, gaze dropping once more toward the nearly empty plate in front of him.

Then he looked back up.

“I assume, then, that we will be tasting more from this mother of yours who *just cooks*?”

Jimin perked up so quickly it was almost embarrassing.

“Yes.” The answer came out before he had time to overthink it. “Yes, sir. Everything on my menu tonight is something I learned from her. Not exactly the way she makes it, obviously- I changed things and used techniques I learned here -but they’re all things I grew up eating.” His smile softened a little as he spoke. “I just thought it was the most fitting thing to make.”

Jimin glanced down for a moment, the confidence that had carried him through the explanation wavering beneath another small wave of guilt.

“And I’m sorry again. Really. I know I keep saying that, but I mean it. This isn’t something I usually do.”

He very deliberately did not look at Jungkook.

Because Jimin already knew what expression would be waiting for him if he did. That subtle narrowing of Jungkook’s eyes. Maybe the smallest lift of one eyebrow. Some infuriating little look that said *You expect me to believe that?*

Jimin had spent an entire semester challenging, arguing, questioning, ignoring at least half of Jungkook’s warnings and, on one memorable occasion, nearly setting the kitchen on fire.

So maybe *this isn’t something I usually do* was technically open to interpretation.

Still.

Jimin lifted his eyes toward the dean again, and whatever humor had briefly passed through him settled into something more earnest.

“But *please*, sir.” His voice was almost pleading. “Let me cook.”

The words were simpler than everything else he had said.

Jimin didn’t try to explain himself again. He didn’t add another apology or another rant about instinct and heart and everything he had realized far too late. He just stood there beneath the chandelier light with his hands resting stiffly at his sides and waited.

The dean studied him.

His eyes lingered over Jimin’s face before shifting toward the other panelists. Chef Laurent met his gaze first. Somewhere farther down the table, Chef Dubois gave a tiny shrug that looked

suspiciously like approval. Another panelist murmured something beneath his breath.

The dean looked last toward Jungkook.

After several long seconds, the dean turned back.

“Okay, then.”

Jimin’s breath caught.

The dean leaned back slightly in his chair, his expression settling into something calm and almost expectant.

“Just cook.” The dean’s mouth curved faintly.

Jimin’s eyes widened.

For several seconds, he stood there.

That—That had worked?

Please let me cook.

That was all?

Jimin had expected another argument. Maybe several. Possibly a written confession, three character witnesses, and a formal hearing before the French government. Instead, apparently, one heartfelt plea had done the job.

Shit.

Maybe he had missed his calling.

Jimin should really look into law.

Preferably a law firm with a kitchen in the back.

Jimin gasped.

The sound escaped him before he could stop it. One hand flew to his chest, clutching the front of his chef’s coat as though he could physically hold his heart in place now that it had decided to start functioning again.

Only then did he realize he had been holding his breath.

Jimin exhaled all at once.

The breath left him somewhere between a laugh and a sigh, his shoulders dropping as the tension that had kept his entire body rigid finally loosened. Relief washed through him so quickly that it made his knees feel weak beneath him. A smile broke across his face before he could control it, wide and bright and probably far too giddy for someone who had spent the last several minutes attempting to appear mature in front of some of the most respected chefs in France.

“T-thank you, Dean. Thank you so much.” Jimin looked around the table, his eyes moving quickly over each of them as though he needed to make sure they understood that he meant it. “All of you. Seriously. I won’t let you down.”

The dean watched his sudden transformation with what looked suspiciously like amusement before glancing toward the watch beneath the cuff of his suit. His brows rose slightly as he checked the time.

“Well,” he said, “your second course should be beginning shortly. If I were you, Mr. Park, I would get to it.”

“Right.”

Jimin nodded, then again.

“Right, yes.”

He knew he was smiling too much, but there seemed to be absolutely nothing he could do about it.

“I’ll be back.” Jimin paused. “Well, not *me*. I’ll be in the kitchen. But another plate will be back and I hope you like it. It’s a—” He stopped himself, eyes widening. “Actually, no. I won’t spoil it.”

The dean stared at him.

Jimin gave him an awkward little nod.

“I’m sorry. I’m leaving now.”

He took one step backward.

“To cook.”

Another.

“Oh, Jesus.”

Jimin turned on his heel before he could say anything else that might convince them to reverse their decision.

The second his back was to the panel, the smile he had been trying unsuccessfully to contain broke completely across his face.

He walked faster than he had on the way in, his steps suddenly light against the polished floor. The tables no longer seemed quite as endless as they had before. People still watched him as he passed, heads turning subtly in his direction, but Jimin barely noticed them now. Somewhere across the room, the piano continued its soft melody beneath the return of conversation, and this time he could actually hear it.

His chest felt almost painfully full.

They liked it.

They had actually liked it.

Jimin bit down on his lower lip, trying and failing to contain another smile as the kitchen doors finally came into view.



Jimin burst through the kitchen doors with enough force to make them swing hard against their hinges.

He had expected maybe for Camille to start asking questions. Maybe Luc pacing. Maybe both of them standing where he had left them, looking like they had spent the last several minutes preparing themselves for the possibility that Jimin had just been kicked from the academy.

What he had not expected was to find them cooking.

Camille stood over one of the burners with a towel thrown over her shoulder, one hand moving quickly through a saucepan while the other adjusted the heat beneath it. Luc was at the opposite counter, already halfway through organizing the next set of plates, sleeves pushed up and concentration written across his face.

Both of them turned toward the doors at the exact same time.

Their eyes widened.

For half a second, nobody moved.

Then Camille abandoned the spoon against the side of the pot.

“How did it go?”

Luc was already talking over her. “Were they angry? Did they yell at you? Are you expelled? Did they kick you out of the academy?” Luc’s expression grew more serious. “France?”

Jimin stared at him.

Whatever other catastrophic possibility Luc had been preparing to add died somewhere behind his teeth when he finally seemed to notice Jimin’s face.

Jimin was still smiling.

Not the tight, nervous little smile he had worn before leaving the kitchen. Not the kind he used when he wanted them to believe he was fine.

This one was uncontrollable.

Camille noticed it a second later.

Her own expression shifted almost immediately, worrying giving way to recognition before a slow, satisfied smile spread across her face.

“I told you,” she said.

Jimin blinked.

Camille turned toward Luc with smugness. “I told you they were going to like it.”

Luc groaned.

Jimin’s brows drew together.

Luc shoved one hand into his pocket, dug around for a moment, then pulled out a crumpled bill. Without looking particularly happy about it, he slapped it into Camille’s waiting palm.

She took it without even pretending to feel guilty.

Jimin watched the exchange and started opening his mouth.

Actually...he didn’t want to know.

Some things were better left unsaid.

Jimin shook his head and crossed farther into the kitchen, still unable to wipe the smile from his face. That was when he properly noticed what they had been doing.

Ingredients for the next course had already been pulled from cold storage and arranged in neat groups across the island. Several pans were heating over low flames, and a tray near Luc’s station had been lined with the first components Jimin had planned to prep himself.

Jimin slowed.

“You guys started?”

Camille tucked the crumpled bill into her pocket before turning back toward the stove.

“Yes,” she said, as though it were obvious. “I assumed you would be gone longer, so we gave you a head start.”

Luc lifted one shoulder. “Either you were coming back and needed help, or you were being expelled and we were going to finish cooking before they removed your name from the building.”

Jimin stared at him.

Luc gave him a small smile.

“Good news for everyone, apparently.”

Jimin looked over what they had done.

The mise en place was nearly exactly how he had written it in his notebook. Not perfect, but close enough that he immediately understood where they were in the process.

Something warm tugged at his chest. He had expected to come back to panic. Instead, they had trusted the plan.

Luc wiped his hands against the towel tucked at his waist. “So?”

Jimin looked at him.

Luc raised his brows. “You’ve been standing there smiling like an idiot for two minutes. Are you going to tell us what happened?”

Jimin’s smile returned in full force.

He looked toward Camille, then Luc, then the rows of waiting plates.

“They want more.”

Camille’s face lit up.

Luc let out a breath and tipped his head back toward the ceiling like a weight *Jimin didn’t know he had* lifted off him.

Jimin crossed to the island, already reaching for the towel near his station.

“So,” he said, tying it around his waist as he looked over everything they had prepared, “let’s give them more.”



And so dinner went out.

By the time the servers returned for the next course, the way they looked at Jimin’s food had changed. The judgment was gone. Now they leaned in closer out of genuine curiosity, studying the food with an expression that had lost most of its earlier suspicion.

One server paused before lifting a plate and asked another something quietly in French. The second man looked down at the dish, then toward Jimin, his brows raised with something like impressed confusion. They had clearly heard something from the dining room by now, because they no longer carried the plates like they were afraid to be associated with them.

And really, Jimin could understand why they were curious.

Why had the dean emptied his plate?

Why were chefs whose names appeared in magazines and catalogs eating food that looked like something served for a family rather than beneath chandeliers?

Why were wealthy donors and academy students, people accustomed to tiny portions arranged with tweezers and sauces painted across porcelain, sending dishes back to the kitchen practically licked clean?

Jimin tried not to dwell on it too much because every time he let himself think about what was happening outside those doors, his stomach fluttered all over again.

So he kept cooking.

The kitchen fell into a rhythm after that. Jimin moved between stations with focus that drowned out the nerves of earlier. Camille called things out before he had to ask. Luc started anticipating which pans he would need next. Jimin tasted, adjusted, plated, wiped rims, changed his mind about one garnish at the last second, changed it back, then sent everything out before he could overthink it again.

By the time dessert came around, the three of them were tired but in a satisfying way that made the kitchen feel warmer. The soft clatter of utensils, the hiss from the stovetop, and the smell of butter and sugar drifting through the air.

Jimin had saved his favorite for last.

Warm apple pie with vanilla ice cream.

Not deconstructed apple pie. Not apple three ways. Not some tiny pastry shell with a sphere of caramelized fruit on top.

Just pie.

His mother's recipe always started with the apples. She liked mixing tart ones with sweeter ones so the filling wouldn't turn into mush, and Jimin had watched her make it enough times growing up that he could almost hear her correcting him in his head as he worked. Brown sugar, cinnamon, nutmeg, lemon juice, a little flour, and butter. Nothing overly complicated.

He had changed a few things since coming to the academy, but only where it felt natural. He browned some of the butter before working it into the crust, something Jungkook had taught him months earlier when he had complained that Jimin's pastry tasted flat. He added a little vanilla bean to the apples before baking.

When Jimin cut into the first pie, the crust gave beneath the knife with a soft crack. Steam curled from the center, carrying the smell of cinnamon and warm apples into the kitchen, and the filling settled slowly into the space where the first slice had been removed.

Camille appeared beside him almost immediately.

Jimin looked over. "What?"

She leaned closer to the pie, eyes narrowing like she was inspecting it.

Jimin laughed softly. "Take some."

Camille looked at him. "Really?"

"Yeah, there's plenty."

That was all she needed.

She reached for a small plate and cut herself a slice while Jimin turned back toward the row of dessert plates. He placed one piece of pie on each, then added a scoop of vanilla ice cream beside it, letting the warmth soften the bottom just enough that it started melting toward the crust.

From the other side of the counter, Luc looked up. His gaze landed on Camille's plate. He glanced toward Jimin, then back to Camille, and lowered his voice.

"Put enough for me too."

Camille looked over at him, already chewing.

"You have hands."

"I'm *doing* something."

Camille rolled her eyes but cut another slice anyway.

Jimin watched the two of them with a small smile and shook his head before returning to plating.

By then, even the servers had relaxed around them. When they came in for dessert, one of them smiled as soon as he saw the pie and said something in French that Jimin didn't fully understand, though the word *tarte* was obvious enough.

Another looked toward the ice cream and nodded approvingly.

Jimin stood back for a moment and watched as the final plates were lifted one by one onto the silver trays.

There was something strange about seeing them leave.

The whole night had felt endless when it began. Every course had seemed like its own delima, every opening of the kitchen doors like another chance for something to go wrong.

Now there were only a few plates left.

Then two.

Then one.

Jimin wiped the rim of the final dessert plate with the corner of a clean towel, smoothing away a tiny streak of apple filling before stepping back to look at it.

The last thing they would taste from him tonight.

Jimin smiled faintly and slid the plate toward the waiting server.

The man lifted it onto his tray and headed toward the doors. They swung open, letting in a brief wash of music and conversation from the gala beyond.

Then they closed again.

And just like that, the last dessert was gone.



The ovens were cooling, the burners had been shut off one by one, and the frantic rhythm that had carried them through service had softened into the scrape of metal against counters, running water, and the occasional clink of dishes being stacked near the sink. Jimin stood at the center island with his sleeves pushed up, wiping down the stainless steel in tired strokes while Camille and Luc worked somewhere behind him. His feet ached, his shoulders were sore, and there was still a faint sweetness from the apple filling lingering in the warm air.

He had just folded the cloth beneath his palm to go over the counter again when the kitchen doors opened in front him. Jimin glanced up and found the same server standing in the doorway though, he looked different this time. The careful neatness he had worn earlier had loosened after hours of walking back and forth across the gala, a few strands of hair falling near his forehead and his cheeks still faintly flushed from the heat and constant movement. More importantly, he was smiling.

Jimin slowly straightened.

The server stepped inside and stopped a few feet from the door. “Mr. Park,” he said, his voice far less ominous than it had sounded the first time. “The dean has requested your presence again.”

Jimin’s hand went still around the cloth.

For a moment, he only looked at the man. The nerves returned almost automatically, settling low in his stomach, though they were nothing like the sick rush that had nearly swallowed him earlier. He had already stood in front of the panel once. Still, knowing that didn’t make the idea of walking back into that room any less scary..

Jimin set the cloth down, inhaled until his chest filled, and held the breath for a second before letting it out through his nose.

Then he nodded.

“Okay.”



So, Jimin stood before them again.

The dean looked a little rosier than he had earlier, the faint color gathered across his cheeks making him seem less intimidating than before. Jimin had the ridiculous thought that maybe it was his fault. He had not exactly been conservative with the portion sizes tonight, and judging by how clean the plates had been coming back, the man had apparently committed himself to finishing *every* last bite.

At the sight of Jimin, the dean straightened in his chair and dismissed the server with a loose wave of his hand. The man bowed slightly before slipping away, leaving Jimin standing at the edge of the table while the dean set his fork down beside the remains of dessert.

“Well...” he began.

Jimin barely heard him at first.

His attention had already started moving down the panel.

Everyone was looking at him, but it wasn't the same as before. The sharp skepticism had faded from their faces. No one looked as though they were waiting for him to explain himself or preparing to catch him in another mistake.

Instead, their eyes had narrowed with something more thoughtful now, curiosity sitting where suspicion had been earlier. Chef Laurent watched him with her head tilted slightly, the smallest smile still lingering near the corner of her mouth, while Chef Dubois looked between Jimin and the empty dessert plate in front of him as though he were trying to decide what he had just eaten and why he had liked it so much.

Jimin's gaze continued down the table.

Then, by *accident*, it found Jungkook.

He was looking at him too.

Jimin almost looked away out of habit, but something stopped him.

Jungkook didn't look angry anymore.

He didn't even look tense.

For once, there was none of that hard restraint sitting across his face, none of the tightness in his jaw or that guarded stillness that usually made him look as though he were always judging, always filing things away.. He looked...content.

The realization made Jimin blink.

Jungkook's shoulders had loosened slightly beneath his suit jacket, and there was a softness around his eyes that Jimin wasn't used to seeing in a room full of other people. His mouth wasn't quite smiling, the usual tight line eased into something warmer. There was pride there too, Jimin thought, though the idea made his chest tighten.

Maybe he was imagining it.

Then Jungkook's eyes softened a little more when they met his.

Jimin's cheeks warmed.

He looked away before the heat could spread any farther and forced his attention back toward the dean, who had already begun speaking.

"I feel," the dean said slowly, glancing down at the empty plates scattered around the table before looking back at Jimin, "as though I have spent this entire evening somewhere else."

Jimin's brows lifted.

"Perhaps your home." The dean leaned back slightly, his expression turning thoughtful. "Do you know what our school crest means?" the dean asked.

Jimin's expression went blank.

Shit.

There was a school crest?

He knew there *was* one, technically. It was stitched onto every coat he owned, engraved into half the doors in the building, stamped across official letters and menus and anything else the academy could possibly put its name on. But if someone had ever explained what it meant, Jimin had apparently filed that information somewhere beside the French subjunctive.

He gave the dean a small, embarrassed shake of his head.

"No, sir."

The admission came out softer than he intended, but the dean didn't seem offended. If anything, something almost amused passed across his face, as though Jimin's ignorance had been entirely predictable.

"Our crest bears the words *Le feu révèle l'âme*," he said. "The flame reveals the soul."

Jimin's eyes lifted.

The dean glanced briefly toward the embroidered crest over Jimin's chest before returning his attention to him. "My father chose those words because he believed cooking did more than transform food. He believed that when a cook was placed under pressure, eventually there would be nothing left to hide behind."

Jimin swallowed.

The dean's gaze traveled toward the empty plates around the table.

"Tonight, Mr. Park, you ignored an approved menu, disregarded procedure, frightened your assistants, confused my staff, and forced an entire panel to evaluate a service we had not prepared to evaluate." His brows lifted slightly. "Under almost any other circumstances, that would be an excellent argument for disciplinary action."

Jimin's stomach dipped despite everything.

The dean paused, letting that sit for just long enough to be cruel, before his expression softened.

“And yet...” His fingers rested lightly against the edge of the table. “I think, for once, the words on that crest have actually been fulfilled.”

Jimin’s mouth parted as a small, shaky gasp slipped from him before he could stop it.

The dean watched him closely. “There are only two explanations I can think of for what you did tonight. Either you are foolish...or you possess a spirit I had begun to think this academy had trained out of its students a very long time ago.”

The dean leaned back slightly, his eyes narrowing in thought. “Students come here wanting to become great chefs. They want approval. They want perfect marks, perfect plates, perfect recommendations. Eventually, many of them become so frightened of doing something wrong that they stop taking risks.”

Jimin felt something tighten beneath his ribs.

“You,” the dean continued, “appear to have the opposite problem.”

Jimin’s cheeks warmed.

“You seem almost incapable of leaving well enough alone.” The dean’s mouth twitched. “But perhaps that is not entirely a weakness.”

His gaze returned to Jimin’s plate, though there was nothing left on it now but a thin streak where melted ice cream had mixed with cinnamon and apple filling.

“What you served tonight was not sophisticated because it was complicated. It was sophisticated because you had the courage not to bury it beneath everything you had been taught.”

Jimin stared at him.

The dean let out a quiet breath through his nose. “There is technique here. Considerable technique. I can see this academy in your food. I can see the training. I can see where your instructors have corrected you.” Then his eyes sharpened.

“But I can also see *you*.”

The dean turned his head toward Jungkook.

“Director Jeon.”

Jungkook looked toward the dean. The dean studied him for a moment before a pleased smile settled across his face. “I am very satisfied with your selection this year.”

Jimin’s attention moved between them. Jungkook’s expression barely changed, but something quiet passed through his eyes at the words, something almost vulnerable beneath all that practiced restraint.

The dean continued speaking, his voice softer now, but Jimin only caught pieces of it. Something about instinct. About recognizing potential before it had properly revealed itself. About the responsibility of a teacher not only to correct what was wrong, but to notice what might become extraordinary if given the chance.

Jimin should have been listening. Instead, his eyes found Jungkook again.

The rest of the table seemed to blur slightly around the edges. The dean was still talking, Chef Laurent shifted somewhere beside him, someone lifted a glass, but Jimin barely registered any of it. There was only Jungkook across the table, staring at him with an expression Jimin had spent months trying to understand and somehow still never quite could.

There was something palpable there now.

It wasn't the reluctant approval Jungkook sometimes gave him after a good service or the tiny nod that usually had to be dragged out of him after Jimin did something right. This was different and almost painfully so.

The dean glanced between them. "You saw something in him."

Jungkook didn't answer immediately.

His gaze remained on Jimin, warm in a way that made Jimin suddenly feel far too visible. For a second, Jungkook's mouth parted as though there were several answers he could have given.

Then his expression softened.

"Yes," he said quietly.

The word carried easily across the table despite how softly he spoke.

Jimin inhaled shakily and finally looked away.

His eyes dropped toward the floor as heat climbed slowly into his cheeks, and he pressed his lips together, trying to hide whatever stupid expression had started forming there.

God.

Even now.

Even after everything Jungkook had said to him, everything they had done to each other, every reason Jimin had spent the last week inventing for why he should stop caring, the man could still look at him and make something inside him fold immediately.

It was getting ridiculous.

The dean let the silence sit for a moment longer before turning his attention back to Jimin. Whatever warmth had entered his expression remained there, though it was tempered now by something more knowing.

"Do not assume I have not heard of you, Mr. Park."

Jimin's stomach tightened.

That sounded less promising than anything he'd heard tonight.

The dean adjusted his glasses and studied him over the frames. "I have heard the good, certainly. Your instructors have spoken of your willingness to work until you understand something

properly.” His mouth shifted faintly. “I have also heard the less flattering stories.”

Jimin’s eyes dropped.

There were probably several.

“I have heard that you are argumentative. Occasionally disrespectful when you believe yourself to be right.” The dean paused. “And, judging by tonight, perhaps dangerously comfortable with asking forgiveness after ignoring permission.”

A few quiet laughs moved around the table.

Jimin gave a small, embarrassed smile.

The dean’s expression softened again. “But I have also learned something else tonight. You are not careless with what matters to you.”

The dean gestured lightly toward the empty plates around them. “You took us somewhere this evening, Mr. Park. Somewhere none of us expected to go. You spoke of your home without giving us some long explanation of it. You simply fed us, and that was more than words have to offer.”

Jimin felt his throat tighten.

“So,” the dean continued, “I find myself inclined toward a little grace.”

Jimin blinked.

The older man leaned back in his chair, looking almost amused by Jimin’s confusion. “Consider it compensation for so kindly taking an old man all the way to New York without requiring him to leave Paris.”

Jimin’s eyes widened.

The dean’s smile deepened.

“If there is one matter concerning your standing here that you would like me to reconsider, I am willing to hear it.”

Jimin’s breath caught and for half a second, his mind went blank.

Then everything rushed in at once.

His disciplinary record. The whispers that had followed him across the courtyard. The possibility that something buried in his academy file might follow him into every restaurant, every recommendation, every opportunity that came afterward.

Jimin’s fingers tightened slightly at his sides.

He could fix at least one part of the mess this semester had become.

And yet, almost immediately, something else came to mind.

Someone else.

“So?” the dean asked

Jimin hesitated.

His eyes flickered briefly around the table before swallowing.

“Can I...” He paused, already feeling stupid. “Can I whisper it?”

The panel went strangely still. Even Jungkook looked slightly taken aback.

The dean blinked at Jimin.

“You wish to whisper your request?”

Jimin nodded.

“If that’s okay.”

The dean stared at him for another second, then gave a slow, bemused motion with one hand.

“Very well.”

Jimin stepped around the edge of the table.

The closer he came, the more ridiculous the whole thing felt. He leaned down beside the dean, one hand resting lightly against the edge of the table for balance, and lowered his voice until only the older man could hear him.

He spoke quietly for several seconds.

When Jimin straightened again, the dean’s expression had changed. The faint amusement was gone. His brows drew together as he looked up at Jimin.

“You understand,” he said slowly, “that this would not benefit you.”

Jimin nodded.

“I know.”

The dean continued watching him. For several seconds, that's all he did. Not critically this time. The older man hummed quietly, his gaze lingering on Jimin’s face before moving briefly toward the table and back.

Then, slowly, he smiled.

“Very well.”

Jimin’s breath caught.

The dean gave him a small nod.

“I will see what can be done.”

What followed happened quickly enough that Jimin barely registered that the evaluation was actually over. The gala he'd been preparing for for weeks was now...over.

Chef Dubois was the first to rise. He pushed his chair back with a quiet scrape and came around the table, smoothing the front of his jacket as he approached Jimin. Up close, he was somehow even more intimidating, tall and broad through the shoulders with silver beginning to show at his temples, but whatever sternness Jimin had associated with him earlier had disappeared beneath an easy smile.

"What are your plans after graduation?" he asked.

Jimin blinked. "After graduation?"

"Yes." Chef Dubois reached into the inside pocket of his jacket and pulled out a small cream-colored card. "Surely you have considered it."

Consider it? Yes. Planned any of it? No.

"I mean...I have ideas," Jimin admitted, accepting the card when Dubois held it toward him. His eyes dropped to the embossed lettering across the front, and the sight of the chef's personal number beneath it nearly made him stop breathing. "I'd like to work for a while. Learn more. Eventually I want my own place."

"Good." Dubois nodded. "Do not know yet. It is better than deciding too early and spending years becoming someone you no longer wish to be."

Before Jimin could properly process that, the man caught him lightly by both shoulders, leaned in, and planted a horribly wet kiss against his cheek.

Jimin froze.

Chef Dubois pulled away as though nothing unusual had happened.

"We will be keeping in touch....*Merci, au revoir..*"

Jimin stared after him, one hand slowly rising toward the damp spot on his cheek. "I...okay."

Chef Laurent laughed as she stood. She took the card briefly from Jimin's fingers, flipped it over, borrowed a pen from the table, and wrote another number along the back before handing it to him again. "That one is mine. Keep in touch. I would like to see what you do when not threatened with academic consequences."

Jimin looked down at the two numbers now occupying the same card and felt something dangerously close to another emotional breakdown forming behind his eyes.

"Thank you," he said, quieter this time. "Seriously."

"I mean it." Chef Laurent gave him one last pointed look. "And next time you change a menu, tell someone."

Jimin smiled sheepishly. "I will."

"Before service."

“Yes, Chef.”

She seemed satisfied with that and moved away, leaving Jimin to tuck the card carefully into the inside pocket of his coat as if it were worth more than everything else he currently owned.

The dean approached next. Jimin instinctively straightened when he stopped in front of him, but the older man only extended his hand.

Jimin took it.

The dean’s grip was firm and warm. “I meant what I said, Mr. Park. I am very satisfied with what you accomplished tonight.”

Jimin’s smile softened. “Thank you, sir.”

“And if your mother is willing to surrender that recipe of hers...” The dean’s expression turned unusually serious. “I expect a personal pie before you graduate.”

A laugh escaped Jimin before he could stop it. “I think I can make that happen.”

The dean nodded once, pleased with the arrangement, and released his hand.

Professor Mercier was last before Jungkook.

Jimin barely had time to turn toward her before she wrapped her arms around him.

His eyes widened.

Professor Mercier never hugged students.

At least, she had certainly never hugged *him*. She had spent most of the semester standing over his shoulder with crossed arms and an expression that suggested *If you have to repeat my class i’ll make it a living hell*.

Still, Jimin relaxed into it after a second.

Her perfume surrounded him, floral and powdery, the same scent that had once made his stomach tighten whenever she leaned over his station during practicals. Strangely, with the semester finished and no possibility of her appearing beside him to tell him his reduction was too thin, it was almost comforting.

“I am proud of you,” she murmured before pulling away.

One by one, they began drifting away from the table, conversations starting again as they disappeared into the gala. Jimin watched them go, partly because it still felt surreal to see people he had admired from a distance walking away after giving him their numbers, shaking his hand, asking about his future.

And partly because watching them gave him something else to do.

He knew who was still behind him.

Jimin kept his attention fixed on their retreating figures until he heard footsteps approaching across the polished floor.

They stopped nearby.

“Jimin.”

His chest tightened as he turned.

Jungkook stood only a few feet away.

For a moment, neither of them said anything. Without the rest of the panel between them, the distance suddenly felt much smaller than it had across the table. Jimin became painfully aware of the black suit fitted over Jungkook’s shoulders, the piece of dark hair that had fallen loose near his forehead sometime during dinner, the softness that still lingered around his eyes.

Jimin looked down first.

“I’m sorry, Chef. I know I should’ve told you about the menu. I know you specifically told me to make my own decisions, but I’m pretty sure you didn’t mean completely changing everything without telling anyone, and I—”

“I don’t know how to say this,” Jungkook interrupted quietly, “so I will say it plainly.” Something about Jungkook’s expression made the rest of his apology disappear. Jungkook looked at him for a long moment before continuing. “It was perfect.”

Jimin stared.

“Everything,” Jungkook said. His voice remained quiet, but there was none of the hesitation Jimin had expected. “The progression of the menu, the presentation, the balance. You took dishes that could have been too heavy for a service this long and understood where to pull back. You knew when to leave them alone. The technique was there without becoming the point of the food.”

Jimin’s lips slowly parted.

Jungkook’s eyes moved briefly over his face before settling back on them.

“And the taste...” His expression softened. “The taste was...excellent.”

Excellent...

Jimin forgot to breathe.

Jungkook had complimented him before. Technically. Usually after making him work for it, and often buried beneath three criticisms and an instruction to do it better next time.

This wasn’t that.

There was no correction coming.

No *but*.

Jungkook inhaled quietly.

“I am very proud of you, Jimin.”

Jimin stared up at him.

His mouth opened, but the first attempt at speaking produced absolutely nothing. Heat slowly climbed into his cheeks as his chest tightened around an emotion he wasn't prepared to examine while standing this close to Jungkook.

“Oh,” Jimin finally breathed. He swallowed and tried again. “T-thank you.”

His voice came out smaller than he intended.

Jungkook didn't say anything else right away.

His gaze lingered on Jimin's face with a quietness that made the space between them feel strangely separate from the rest of the ballroom. Around them, chairs scraped softly against the floor, voices rose and fell beneath the music, and somewhere farther back a server laughed at something someone said, but Jimin heard almost none of it. Jungkook looked like he was trying to memorize him. Not in some obvious way, but slowly, carefully, his eyes moving over Jimin's face as if there were things there he had spent too long refusing to notice.

Then Jungkook exhaled.

Jungkook's eyes stayed on him. “I don't understand how you do it, Park Jimin. I don't believe I ever will. You make decisions that should ruin you, and somehow they don't. You walk into situations completely unprepared, say the wrong thing, challenge the wrong person, and somehow still leave people wanting more from you. You have... more than luck on your side.”

Jimin stared up at him, unsure of what Jungkook was really trying to say beneath all of that.

Jungkook looked down then, adjusting one of his cufflinks with his thumb and forefinger before clearing his throat. The movement was small, but Jimin knew him well enough now to recognize it for what it was.

Nerves.

That alone made Jimin straighten slightly.

“I owe you an apology,” Jungkook continued. “For what I said. I was angry, and I said something I knew would hurt you because I wanted the conversation to end before I said something worse.” He paused, jaw tightening faintly. “There are things about my life I stopped questioning a long time ago. Things I accepted because it was easier than admitting I wanted something different. Then you came here and questioned everything for me.”

Jimin's chest tightened.

“I don't know what I'm supposed to do with that yet. Maybe I won't for a while. But for that, Jimin, I am in your debt.”

Jimin's throat went dry.

This had to be the most Jungkook had ever said in one sitting.

Possibly ever.

Jungkook either didn't notice Jimin's stunned expression or chose to ignore it. "Whatever you decide after tonight, don't make that decision because of me. If you stay here, stay because there is still something you want from this place. If you leave, leave because you found something you want more. But don't let what happened between us decide it for you. There was someone you wanted to become badly enough to cross an ocean for it. You should still become that person."

His gaze softened.

"Whether I'm here or not."

Jimin's breath caught slightly.

He didn't know why that made something in his stomach twist.

Jimin looked down.

His vision had started to blur at the edges, and he bit at his lower lip, blinking quickly before anything embarrassing could happen.

This felt too much like goodbye.

Which didn't make sense.

They were both standing *right here*.

Jimin could see the shine of Jungkook's cufflinks, the slight crease in his jacket near his shoulder, the tiny movement of his chest when he breathed.

Jimin didn't realize he was crying until the heat reached his cheek. It slid slowly, burning against skin that already felt too hot, and for a terrifying second he just stood there, paralyzed by it. His body was grieving before his mind knew why. He inhaled a broken breath and dropped his gaze, staring hard at the floor as if he could somehow pull the tear back. His fingers twitched against his side, desperate to wipe away the evidence, but he forced them still.

It didn't matter anyway.

Jungkook had already seen.

Jimin jerked his chin up, staring aimlessly past Jungkook's shoulder at the ceiling, blinking violently to force the moisture back into his eyes.

He felt so small.

So stupid.

Nothing was ending. That was the lie he kept repeating to himself.

Jungkook was still standing *right here*. Jimin was still there too. The academy wasn't going to vanish into thin air overnight, and the next semester would arrive whether Jimin was ready for it or not. There would still be the kitchens, the stiff white uniforms, the strict professors standing over

his shoulder to correct his knife angles. There would still be the same hollow hallways, the loud dining hall, and those miserable back stairs he always sprinted up when he was late.

And Jungkook would still be at the center of all of it.

So why did it feel like his entire world was slipping through his fingers?

Jimin bit his lip until he tasted copper.

Because for the very first time, he understood. Whatever this *mess* had become between them couldn't keep *becoming*. Not without tearing them both to pieces. Not without turning every soft memory into something they had to hide, regret, or apologize for. Jungkook was still his director. Jimin was still his student. That cold reality hadn't changed just because they had kissed, had sex or screamed at each other, or learned the painful language of each other's silences.

Maybe this heartbreak had been waiting for them at the finish line all along.

"Jimin," Jungkook said softly.

The gentle, ruinous sound of his name nearly shattered what little control Jimin was clinging to.

He shook his head furiously before Jungkook could say another word. It wasn't a refusal of anything specific; Jimin didn't even know what he was fighting against. He just couldn't bear to hear another sentence, another piece of gentle closure disguised as wisdom, not when his heart felt like it was being squeezed to death inside his chest.

"I know," Jimin whispered.

His voice cracked down the middle and he hated himself for letting Jungkook hear just how deeply he was hurting.

Jimin kept his head down, gathering every ounce of pride he had left, before finally forcing his eyes up.

At first, he thought his eyes were playing tricks on him through the haze.

There was a faint, trembling wetness pooled along Jungkook's lower lashes, so subtle Jimin would have missed it if he hadn't spent months memorizing every line of the man's face. The harsh ballroom light caught the moisture when Jungkook blinked, turning his dark eyes glassy before he frantically looked away. His mouth tightened into a hard, desperate line, his jaw flexing once, then twice, as he tried to swallow down the emotion choking him.

Jimin's breath caught in his throat.

No.

He wasn't imagining it.

The realization went through Jimin so fiercely that his own grief stalled for a second.

Jungkook cleared his throat, his hand dropping to adjust one of his cufflinks even though it was already perfect. His fingers trembled slightly, turning the silver once, twice, smoothing the edge of his sleeve over and over as if that useless, mechanical task could keep him from falling apart.

It was such a characteristically guarded thing to do that it made Jimin's chest ache.

When Jungkook finally forced himself to look back up, his face was a mask of artificial composure. But he couldn't hide the shine in his eyes. He couldn't.

Neither of them could speak.

Jimin watched as the walls around Jungkook slowly dissolved. The sharp tension in his jaw melted, the tightness in his brow softened, until all that remained was an expression so quietly devastated it was louder than just outright sobbing. Jimin couldn't breathe. He couldn't to look at it, yet he couldn't look away.

Then, Jungkook extended his hand.

Jimin looked down at the space between them.

After everything, that was what this was becoming.

The gesture was so agonizingly formal it felt like a physical blow, yet Jungkook's hand remained suspended in the air asking Jimin to help him play the part.

Jimin swallowed the lump in his throat and reached out.

The moment their palms pressed together, a wave of warmth rushed through him.

Jungkook's fingers closed around his with a careful firmness, and the simple contact was suddenly a thousand times more painful than any touch had ever been. There was a terrible restraint in it, a polite finality that tore Jimin open.

Jimin's fingers tightened on instinct, refusing to yield.

Jungkook noticed, his eyes darting down to their joined hands, then snapping back up to Jimin's face. A hairline fracture appeared in his composure, his brows pulling together in a flash of agony before he smoothed it away.

"I wish you the best next semester," Jungkook said.

His voice was terrifyingly quiet, stripped of all its usual authority.

"Y-yeah." The words broke on the way out. "Yeah. You too."

Jungkook didn't let go.

Neither did Jimin.

For a few suspended seconds, time seemed to stop. They stood locked together, hands clasped, while the grand ballroom whirled on around them. Jimin could hear the faint murmur of laughter nearby, the clinking of champagne flutes, the romantic sweep of the grand piano, but it was all muffled, as if they were trapped underwater.

Jungkook's thumb shifted, pressing once, softly, against the side of Jimin's hand. Then, Jungkook slowly loosened his grip.

Their fingers slipped apart, millimeter by millimeter. Jimin felt every second of the separation, the heat pulling away from his skin until Jungkook's hand was back at his side

Jimin's arm fell back to his side too, his fingers curling tightly into a fist to try and trap the lingering ghost of Jungkook's skin against his palm.

Jungkook looked at him one last time.

The look was so heavy, so filled with unsaid words, it nearly brought Jimin to his knees. Jungkook's lips parted slightly, as if he were finally going to speak, but he caught himself. He closed his mouth, breathed out, and gave Jimin a single, tight nod.

Jimin nodded back only because he knew if he opened his mouth, he would start begging.

Then Jungkook turned away.

Jimin watched him go.

Jungkook wove through the crowded tables, his tall frame disappearing and reappearing among the sea of suits and evening gowns. For one pathetic, foolish second, Jimin prayed he would stop, that he would turn around and walk back.

He never did.

The crowd swallowed him whole, and he was gone.

Jimin stood frozen in the middle of the room.

At first, he forced his body to hold. He kept his chin lifted. He forced his shoulders to stay square. He pulled shallow breaths through his nose and fixed his eyes on a random table nearby, staring at abandoned wine glasses, dirty plates, anything to avoid looking at the empty space where the love of his life had just been standing.

Yes...he said it.

Jimin spun away from the center of the room and slammed his hand over his mouth just as a broken, strangled sob tore from his throat. He pressed his palm so hard against his lips that it muffled the sound before anyone could hear.

He squeezed his eyes shut, but it was useless.

The tears spilled over in a scalding torrent, streaming down his cheeks and soaking into the skin of his hand as he scrubbed at his face, trying frantically to hide the breakdown. Every attempt to breathe came out as a jagged, shaking gasp, forcing him to keep his mouth clamped shut.

The ballroom was still full of life.

People were clinking glasses and laughing at jokes. A group nearby was excitedly planning where to go for drinks after the gala. Servers glided past carrying silver trays, completely oblivious. A couple smiled for a photographer near the archway. The piano played a sweet, beautiful melody that felt like a mockery.

Nobody knew.

Nobody had any idea that Jimin was standing just feet away from them, shattered into a million pieces.



There was that old saying about time healing all wounds.

Jimin couldn't remember the exact wording, but quite frankly, he'd always thought it sounded like absolute bullshit. Time didn't heal anything by itself. Time was just indifferent. It kept dragging you forward whether you were ready to move or not, pulling you along until one day you realized the thing that used to tear through your chest had finally gone quiet.

By the time the semester wrapped up, that awful, suffocating ache Jimin had been lugging around since the gala had finally settled into a dull, manageable hum.

The gala itself had ended up being a success...a humiliatingly public one. He had barely made it ten feet through the ballroom after pulling himself together before someone intercepted him to offer congratulations. Then somebody else. Then a whole cluster after that. Students he'd never spoken to were suddenly coming up to ask about the dishes he'd served. Professors who had previously treated him like a future dropout were offering eager handshakes. By the end of the night, even kitchen staff from buildings he'd never set foot in seemed to know his name.

Within days, Jimin was no longer the unhinged American student who had thrown hands with Eric in front of the dining hall—and who was maybe, *definitely-not-but-everyone-implied*, involved with Director Jeon.

Now, he was the gala prodigy.

Which was a massive upgrade in reputation.

Then there was Eric.

The night of the event, when the dean offered Jimin one favor, Jimin asked him to drop the remaining disciplinary charges against Eric so he could graduate. It had felt strange coming out of his mouth, especially since a few weeks prior, Jimin would have gleefully watched Eric get launched into the sun. But staying angry was exhausting. And if Jimin was being annoyingly mature about it, destroying Eric's future wasn't going to help anything.

A week later, he ran into Eric in the library.

Jimin had been reaching for a book on an upper shelf when he turned and found Eric standing at the end of the aisle, one hand wrapped around the strap of his bag. For a second, neither of them moved, their eyes widening in unison. The air immediately thickened with that particular, heavy awkwardness only two people with far too much history can create.

Jimin parted his lips, though he had no idea what he would have said if anything had actually come out. Eric didn't speak either.

Instead, the rigid stiffness slowly bled out of Eric's shoulders. After a quiet moment, he offered Jimin a subtle, small nod.

There was a whole unspoken conversation buried in that single gesture: embarrassment, gratitude, and an apology he was far too elitist and emotionally constipated to ever say out loud.

When Eric added a faint, brief smile, Jimin stared for a beat before returning it. That was okay. He didn't need a dramatic speech, nor did he expect Eric to suddenly become a completely different person just because Jimin had done one decent thing for him. Whatever that gesture meant, Jimin accepted it for what it was.

They walked past each other, and that was the last time Jimin saw him

With the wreckage cleared, Jimin packed up his life in France, getting ready to fly back home to New York for the break.

His dorm room looked hollow stripped bare, suitcases littered across the floor while Tae sat on one to force the zipper shut. Alexandre eventually stepped in, fixing the jammed tracks in two seconds flat while Jimin stared stunned at him for making it look so easy.

When it was time to say goodbye, Tae grabbed him in a dramatic, bone-crushing hug, clinging to him like he was heading off to sea.

"How am I supposed to live without you?" Tae wailed into his shoulder. "Who's going to stop you from making awful life decisions? Who's going to save me from Alexandre's lectures?"

Jimin squeezed him back tightly, tears springing to his eyes despite himself. "Tae, it's just for two months," he choked out through a watery laugh. "I'll be back before you even miss me."

"I miss you already!" Tae sniffled, dramatically wiping his eyes before letting him go.

Jimin hugged Alexandre next, and then, with a chest lighter than it had felt in months, Jimin boarded his flight back to New York.

His mother cried the second she saw him, clutching his face and insisting he looked skinnier despite attending culinary school. His father tried to hide a proud smile behind her before pulling him into a tight hug.

Hobi was the worst of all. He had somehow tracked down every single article written about the gala, proudly reading aloud excerpts from *Cuisine Internationale* while Jimin buried his face in his hands and tried to snatch the laptop out of his grip.

"Listen to this," Hobi grinned, dodging Jimin's reach. "'Park Jimin shocked an elite panel of chefs with dishes inspired by his childhood.'"

"Give me that," Jimin groaned.

"Read the part about the pie!" his mother called out from the stove.

"The pie was transformative," Hobi quoted dramatically.

Even Mr. Frank got in on it, printing out one of the articles and taping them all around the diner. When Jimin demanded he take it down, Mr. Frank just reminded him of the three years he couldn't crack an egg without getting shells in the yolk.

Gradually, the embarrassment softened into something warm. Home wrapped around him in familiar layers: the sound of his mother in the kitchen, his father keeping the TV way too loud even at night, Hobi barging in to steal food, and the comfort of people who loved him long before France ever happened.

Jimin was okay.

He slept. He ate. He stopped waking up with a heavy weight on his chest. He stopped replaying the gala, the office, and that agonizingly formal handshake. Most importantly, he stopped thinking about Jungkook altogether. He'd instituted a strict personal policy never to speak his name again, a petty kind of reverse exposure therapy.

Out of sight, out of mind.

And it worked. Mostly.

If someone mentioned the academy, Jimin didn't think about him. If his mother handed him a bottle of hot sauce, Jimin absolutely didn't think about him.

The point was, Jimin was flourishing!

Really.

And okay—had he accidentally thought the phrase *love of his life* back at that stupid gala hall while spiraling? *Pshhhh*. Absolutely not! He meant *not* the love of his life. A dramatic, heat-of-the-moment exaggeration that didn't hold a single grain of truth. He was completely fine.

In fact, when Hobi brought up Jungkook for the thousandth time since Jimin had been back, leaning over the kitchen counter with that nosy, probing look in his eyes, Jimin just rolled his eyes and snapped his dish towel.

"Hobi, seriously... What did I say? It was just a *thing*. It's over!"

And for the most part, it really was. He was moving on.

By the time late August rolled around, Jimin felt like an entirely different person. The anxiety that had swallowed him whole a year ago was gone, replaced by a quiet confidence. He wasn't dragging his feet as he packed his bags in New York this time; he was ready to head back across the Atlantic.

At the airport, history repeated itself, only somehow worse. His mother clung to him at the security line, wiping away tears. Hobi was somehow crying even harder than he had the first time, dramatically wiping his face on his sleeve.

"You have to text me the second you land," Hobi sniffled, wrapping Jimin in a hug. "And don't let those French chefs bully you."

"I'm the one doing the bullying this year," Jimin laughed, squeezing him back before turning to his mom. "I'll be fine, Mom. I promise."



When he finally stepped off the plane in Paris and made the familiar trek back to the academy, the shift was immediate.

He wasn't a terrified, wide-eyed freshman anymore, stumbling over his luggage and dreading every step into the unknown. Walking onto campus felt natural. As he crossed the main courtyard, several returning students waved and called out greetings. A few lowerclassmen even looked at him with subtle deference—the gala prodigy back for round two!

Even the language barrier didn't hold the same terror. Jimin had spent the summer practicing consistently. He could actually hold a conversation now and more importantly, he'd mastered a handful of colorful French curse words that he was fully prepared to use in the kitchen if anyone crossed him.

He pulled his suitcase behind him, listening to the familiar click of his shoes against the cobblestone, breathing in the crisp morning air.

He was back. He was ready.

And nothing was going to throw him off his game this year.

Settling back into the dorms felt very easy. Sharing a room with Tae again made the space feel comfortable immediately, suit-jackets tossed over chair backs, mismatched mugs on the windowsill, and Jimin's jellycat leaning against his pillow..

The first two days were a blur of smooth, satisfying routine. Jimin breezed through registration, navigated the campus with a casual authority he hadn't possessed a year ago, and even exchanged a few fast, confident jokes in French with the third-years.

On the third evening, the energy in the main dining hall was loud and bright. Yellow light spilled over long wooden tables packed with students, the air thick with the smell of roasted garlic, cheap wine, and the frantic chatter of everyone catching up after the break.

Jimin sat near the middle of the long bench, balancing a forkful of roast chicken while listening to Alexandre debate Tae on the proper way to dress a post-summer salad.

"I'm just saying, if the acid profile is off, the whole thing is ruined," Alexandre argued, leaning back with his sleeves rolled up.

"It's a house salad, Alexandre! There should be *no* acid profile" Tae deadpanned, reaching across the table to steal two of Jimin's roasted potatoes.

Jimin laughed, shaking his head as he reached for his water glass. "Let him die on his hill, Tae. He does this every time."

"I do not *die on hills*," Alexandre grumbled, though a tiny smirk tugged at his mouth. "I have standards. Unlike Tae, who would eat cardboard if it had enough salt."

Tae ignored him, turning his head toward the upper staff table near the back doors before casually slinging an arm over the back of the bench.

"Man, the vibe in the kitchen really is different without him, though," Tae mused, taking a slow sip of his drink. "Ever since Director Jeon left over the summer, the whole administration feels more laid back."

The world stopped.

Jimin's fork slipped through his fingers, clattering sharply against the porcelain plate before rolling onto the scarred wood of the table.

Cue dramatic movie rewind andddd... play.

Ever since Director Jeon left over the summer.

Ever since Director Jeon left over the summer.

Ever since Director Jeon left over the summer.

Ever since Director Jeon left over the summer.

Okay, funny joke. Hilarious, really!

Except when Jimin looked up, expecting a punchline, neither Tae nor Alexandre was laughing.

Instead, they were both staring at him with matching expressions of deep concern. Alexandre's hand was frozen halfway to his glass, his usual laid back demeanor softening into something more worried. And Tae—Tae looked like he had just realized he'd accidentally set off a bomb.

Every drop of color drained from Jimin's face so fast his skin felt ice-cold. His chest seized, his throat locking up completely as the loud, booming dining hall dropped into a strange, muffled hush around him.

"Jimin?" Tae asked, his voice dropping an octave, completely stripped of its earlier casual tone. "You... you didn't hear?"

Jimin stared straight ahead at the salt shaker in the middle of the table.

He hadn't heard. He hadn't looked once. Not once all summer.

"Jimin? Are you alright?" Alexandre asked, his brow furrowing in quiet concern.

Jimin's chair scraped loudly against the floor as he stood up, his knees trembling so terribly he had to plant one hand flat against the edge of the table to keep his balance.

"Jimin, wait—" Tae started, reaching out a hand.

"I'm okay," Jimin rasped out, his voice thin and paper-dry. He forced his fingers to let go of the table, giving a tiny, frantic little wave. "I'm okay. I'm just... yep. I'm... I'm gonna..."

He turned on his heel and walked out of the dining hall, leaving his unfinished dinner behind.



Jimin didn't remember the walk back to the dorm.

One second he was retreating from the dining hall, and the next he was shoving his own door open, letting it slam shut behind him. The room was dark and suffocatingly quiet.

He dropped onto the edge of his bed, his hands shaking so much he almost dropped his phone twice while pulling it out of his pocket. His breathing was fast, shallow, dragging through his throat in jagged gasps as he typed it out.

Chef Jeon leaves academy.

The search results loaded instantly, a wall of bold black text and crisp headlines that felt like a physical slap to the face.

JEON JUNGKOOK STEPS DOWN FROM ACADEMY DIRECTOR ROLE

PARIS CULINARY LEADER ANNOUNCES SURPRISE DEPARTURE AFTER ANNUAL GALA

CHEF JEON RETURN TO PRIVATE RESTAURANT INDUSTRY? INDUSTRY INSIDERS REACT

Jimin stared at the screen, his chest heaving. He clicked the first article, then the second, then a third. He scrolled and scrolled until his thumbs ached, until his vision blurred and his breathing was shaky.

How could he? How could he leave?

Okay... this was what Jimin wanted... it was what he needed, right? And if he really thought about it, this was really, truly a blessing!

Said no one ever.

Boy, did Jimin cry.

All those weeks of bottled-up emotions didn't just disappear; they came rushing out like a dam breaking. Weeks of carefully constructed healing evaporated into sobbing into his pillow. Because what the actual fuck?

Couldn't he have called? Emailed? Said goodbye? Anything was better than finding out from Tae over a house salad.

Jungkook had known at the gala. Standing there in his sharp suit, shaking Jimin's hand with those glassy, stupidly beautiful eyes. He had known he was never coming back. He had let Jimin prepare himself for a year of awkward hallway run-ins, not a complete ghost town.

It was cowardly. Director Jeon Jungkook was an absolute coward.

Jimin's thumb hovered over one link near the bottom of the page. It wasn't a standard industry press release; it was an exclusive feature article in a prominent French culinary magazine.

He clicked it.

The headline spanned the top of the screen in sleek, elegant typography, followed by a high-resolution photo of Jungkook. He wasn't wearing his usual crisp director's suit or his chef's whites. He was in a simple black sweater, looking slightly tired, staring just off-camera with that quiet, unreadable expression Jimin knew all too well.

Jimin's breath hitched as his eyes dragged down to the body of the article. It was an interview conducted in Paris just two weeks after the gala.

Sentence by sentence, Jimin read:

When you spend your whole life chasing excellence, you often forget what actually matters. My parents are getting older. I realized recently that time is the one thing you can never get back. Work, success, status... none of it means anything without those you really, truly love.

Jimin sat frozen in the dim light of the bedroom, reading the words again.

A fresh wave of tears spilled over Jimin's lashes, hot as they tracked down his cheeks.

He cried for two completely ridiculous reasons at the exact same time. Part of it was the hollow, aching grief of knowing Jungkook was truly gone.

And the other part?

Jimin sobbed because he had just read every single word of that French interview without looking up a single translation.

Jimin wiped his nose with his sleeve, letting out a watery, exhausted breath as he leaned his head back against the headboard. He stared up at the dark ceiling, the screen dimming in his lap.

Jungkook was gone. He wasn't coming back to the academy, he wasn't going to be lurking in the hallways, and he wasn't around to see Jimin take on his second year.

Jimin swallowed around the tight lump in his throat and pressed his lips together.

Maybe... maybe this was actually good.

Except no... this wasn't good.

Not when Jimin finally looked Tae in the eye the next morning and tossed out a flippant, *"Pshh, yeah, I'm totally fine!"* before aggressively chopping onions at a speed that terrified the rest of his prep class.

And definitely not two weeks later, when the reality of daily life without Jungkook finally cemented itself into a dull, irritating routine.

Because as the weeks bled into months, Jimin wasn't even sure if he was angry anymore.

Some days he was. Some days he was so angry his hands shook while he prepped his station, silently screaming at the empty air where Jungkook used to stand. Other days he was just... exhausted. Hollow. Stuck in a weird, floating limbo where he didn't know whether to curse the man's name or miss him until his ribs ached.

He'd tried telling himself he was fine. He'd done the whole performance for Tae and Alexandre, tossing out bright, careless laughs and waving off every concerned look. But pretending didn't stop the quiet from creeping in during the late nights in his dorm, when the silence felt too big.

By the three-month mark, the academy had fully settled into its new era under Director Meunier — a friendly, middle-aged man who smiled constantly and gave out sweet, encouraging feedback like candy. He was infinitely nicer than Jungkook. He didn't loom over workstations like a storm cloud. He didn't make students question their entire existence with a single raised eyebrow.

And Jimin hated it.

Every time Director Meunier patted his shoulder and called his reduction sauce *"One of a kind,"* Jimin had to bite the inside of his cheek to keep from losing it. He missed the terrifying tension. He missed the sharp critiques that used to make his blood burn to prove himself.

Then came a quiet Tuesday afternoon in late November.

Jimin was sitting in a back corner of the library, propping his chin up with one hand while lazily scrolling through his phone between study modules.

A new article popped onto his feed, backed by a photo.

Jimin froze.

He clicked the link before his brain could stop him.

It wasn't a corporate press release. It was a feature on a small, local dining outlet far from Paris. Instead of opening some grand, sleek venue in a major city, Chef Jeon had quietly bought the old, run-down restaurant he used to go to as a child in his hometown. The place had been lovingly restored, keeping its weathered wooden beams and cozy, unpretentious charm—and Jungkook was now running and operating it full-time as the head chef, working the line himself every single night.

Jimin's thumb swiped down the screen, reading every word of the text effortlessly until he hit the end of the interview, where the writer asked about the shift in his cooking philosophy.

"I used to think control and perfection were the only things that mattered on a plate," Jungkook was quoted saying, beneath a picture of him wiping down the pass in a simple navy apron. "But someone taught me that the best food doesn't come from rules. It comes from memory. From comfort. From being brave enough to serve a piece of who you are, even if it breaks tradition."

Jimin's breath caught in his throat.

The interviewer hadn't pressed for a name, and Jungkook hadn't offered one.

But Jimin knew. He knew with a sudden, overwhelming clarity that made his fingers tremble against the glass.



It was December when Jimin bought it. He was quite proud of it.

And despite what Tae said, it was chic and it had a lot of *character*.

It was a 2004 Renault Twingo. A bright, sunny yellow car with a passenger-side seatbelt that sometimes got jammed, and cute little custom emoji pop up on the instrument panel. Jimin drove it all around the academy and took it out into Paris, which was so much cheaper than taking the bus or paying for trains every weekend.

Sure, his car would spurt and spat at him on cold mornings, coughing up a dramatic cloud of exhaust before settling into a loud, rhythmic rattle, she was doing her best.

Tae had nearly fainted the first time Jimin pulled up to the dorms in it, leaning out the window with a proud grin.

"Jimin," Tae had said, standing frozen on the curb with his hands on his hips, eyeing the tiny yellow hatchback as if it were a biohazard. "You bought *that*? "

"Yes," Jimin had defended fiercely, patting the dashboard, which immediately responded with an ominous highly suspicious clicking sound. "And her name is Buttercup."

"*Buttercup* is going to leave us stranded in the middle of nowhere one day," Tae deadpanned, though he still climbed into the passenger seat only to spend the next five minutes yanking on the jammed belt until Jimin had to reach over and slap the buckle to get it to click.

Despite Tae's constant slander, Buttercup became their ultimate escape vehicle.

Whenever the academy kitchen felt too quiet, or whenever Director Meunier overly cheerful voice made Jimin want to pull his hair out, he'd grab his keys, load Tae (and sometimes a very skeptical Alexandre) into the car, and blast old pop songs through the flickering speakers as they chugged down the French highways.

The heater only worked on the highest setting, sounding like a jet engine taking off, and the windshield wipers had one speed: light panic. But, steering his ridiculous yellow Twingo through the crisp December air, Jimin finally felt in control of his own life.

Bundled up in his oversized coat, a thick wool hat, and a scarf wrapped high enough to cover half his face, Jimin pulled Buttercup into a cramped parking spot outside a bustling bistro. The winter

air was vicious, turning their breath into thick white clouds the second they tumbled out of the car and into the cozy warmth of the restaurant.

After a hearty meal of fondue and fries, Tae and Alexandre were nowhere near ready to call it a night. Tae had already picked out a trendy bar a few blocks away, and he threw an arm around Jimin's neck, trying to drag him along.

"Come on, just one drink!" Tae pleaded, shivering as they stepped back out onto the frozen pavement. "What's the damage of just one? Plus, Alexandre's paying!"

"I can't," Jimin groaned, pulling his hat further down over his ears. "I have that practical exam tomorrow morning and I refuse to show up hungover!"

"Go home, go home," Alexandre said, zipping his leather jacket up to his chin. "Tae and I will just grab a taxi later or get a hotel room near the bar so we don't have to walk the city late. Take the yellow butterbean and get your sleep."

Jimin didn't need to be told twice. He waved goodbye, squeezed himself into Buttercup's icy interior, and cranked the jet-engine heater to full blast.

He pulled out onto the dark roads, the sudden wall of warmth from the vents making him dangerously cozy. The combination of a stomach full of heavy food, the low ambient light, and the monotonous *thump-thump* of the tires on the cold asphalt sent him into an autopilot trance. He zoned out completely, humming along to a faint pop song on the radio, his brain floating somewhere between the exam and the darkness outside.

It wasn't until the streetlights vanished that Jimin blinked, snapping back to full awareness.

He looked around. There were no more city lights. No highway signs. No other cars. Just a pitch-black stretch of rural road cutting through dense, towering trees under a starless December sky.

Oh, no.

He'd missed his exit. He'd probably missed three exits. He had no idea how long he'd been driving in a trance, but he was undeniably in the middle of absolute nowhere.

And right on cue, Buttercup made a horrific, gut-wrenching noise from under the hood.

Spurt. Cough-cough. Spurt...

"No, no, no, please, Buttercup!" Jimin gasped, sitting upright and frantically slapping the dashboard. "Not tonight, girl! Come on, just give me ten miles! Five miles! I'll buy you the expensive gas tomorrow, I promise!"

Buttercup gave one final, dramatic shudder, the battery light on the dashboard flashed a taunting red, before the engine died. The tiny yellow car coasted helplessly along the dark shoulder of the road before coming to a stop.

The roaring heater sputtered out, leaving only the icy winter wind howling through the bare branches outside.

Jimin sat frozen, staring at the steering wheel while his mind replayed Tae's eerily accurate warning from two weeks ago:

"Buttercup is going to leave us in the middle of nowhere,"

Curse him and his oddly prophetic warning.

He pulled out his phone. No Service.

Groaning, Jimin shoved the door open, the freezing wind instantly cutting through his coat. He stepped out onto the gravel, holding his phone high in the air and hopping up and down on his tiptoes like a madman, trying to catch a single bar of signal.

"C'mon, c'mon!..." he pleaded, jumping higher, but still....nothing.

He was just about to give up and climb back into the freezing car when he turned around and caught a faint glow through the dark tree line down the road. Jimin squinted, taking a few steps forward. A neon sign was buzzing in the distance, flickering against the backdrop of a shadowed building.

Thanks to those endless, agonizing late-night language lessons over the summer, the French words registered in his brain instantly: *Garage & Pneumatiques*.

A mechanic and tire shop!

Jimin gasped, a huge, ridiculous grin breaking across his face beneath his scarf. "Thank you, universe!" he breathed, clutching his phone to his chest.

Now, logically, if this were a horror movie, walking alone toward an isolated, flickering garage in the middle of a dark forest was a top-tier terrible judgment call. It was practically begging to be the opening scene of a slasher film. But right now? It was the only thing standing between him and freezing to death.

Jimin locked Buttercup, zipped his coat up to his nose, and took off into a fast jog down the pitch-black road toward the light.



Jimin threw his weight against the heavy glass door, the little bell above it chiming brightly as he stumbled inside and nearly tripped over his own boots.

The heat hit him first. A massive industrial space heater hummed from the corner of the front office, blowing out a steady stream of dry, scorching air that felt so good against his frozen face Jimin almost wanted to cry. He didn't bother pretending to have any dignity left. He marched straight toward it, held his gloved hands inches from the grate, and rubbed them together until the numb ache in his fingers slowly began turning back into feeling.

"Jesus Christ," he whispered, lowering his face toward the warmth.

Once he was sure he wouldn't lose any fingers, Jimin finally looked around. The front lobby was smaller than he expected, rustic in a way that somehow made the place feel warmer than it already was. Thick wooden beams crossed the ceiling, darkened by age and faint stains of grease. The air smelled heavily of motor oil and rubber, but beneath it lingered pine, old wood, and dark coffee brewing somewhere farther inside.

"Bonjour?" Jimin called, his voice still tight from the cold. He cleared his throat and tried again. *"Excusez-moi? Il y a quelqu'un?"*

Only the heater answered him, along with the faint rhythmic clang of metal striking metal somewhere in the back.

Jimin stepped away from the warmth and approached the counter. "Hello? Is anyone here?"

A heavy wooden door behind the desk creaked open.

An older man stepped through, wiping his hands on a dark shop towel. He looked to be somewhere in his sixties, broad through the shoulders with thick gray beginning to take over his dark hair. His face was weathered, and there was a dark streak of grease along one forearm where his sleeves had been rolled to the elbows.

His eyes landed on Jimin.

They narrowed.

"You come to rob me?"

Jimin froze.

"What?"

The man pointed the greasy rag at his chest. "Middle of night. Strange English boy. Very suspicious."

Jimin's hands shot up beside his head before he even thought about it. "No! What? No, I'm not—"

The man lasted maybe two more seconds before his head tipped back as a loud laugh tore out of him, deep enough to fill the tiny lobby. He had to brace one hand against the counter as his shoulders shook, coughing once before waving Jimin off.

"I joke! I joke!"

Jimin slowly lowered his hands.

The man's eyes crinkled faintly before he gestured toward the heater. "Go. You look like frozen bird somebody forgot outside."

Jimin frowned at him but returned to the heater anyway.

The mechanic tossed his rag onto the counter and leaned one hip against it. "My English is not perfect."

"Oh, thank God."

One eyebrow lifted.

Jimin immediately corrected himself. "Not because it's bad. It's good. Really good. I just don't know enough French to explain what's wrong with...my car...."

The man considered that.

"Fair."

Jimin let out a long breath and stretched his hands toward the heater again. "M-my car... Buttercup... that's... it's um..." Jimin stammered, his words tumbling over each other as he gestured wildly toward the pitch-black road outside. "Anyways, my car broke down just right outside! About a quarter-mile down the road. It just sputtered and died, and I really, *really* have to get back to my school for a major exam tomorrow morning. So if you could—"

The man tilted his head, looking out the frost-dusted window toward the dark trees. "What kind of car is a 'Buttercup'?"

"A 2004 Renault Twingo," Jimin said, his voice dropping into a sheepish whisper.

The mechanic froze, then slowly turned his head back to Jimin, an utterly dry, unimpressed look settling over his face.



Outside, the cold nearly knocked the breath from Jimin's lungs. He pulled his scarf over the lower half of his face and hurried after the mechanic, boots crunching over icy gravel as they headed down the road. The old man moved disturbingly fast for someone who had at least thirty years on him, forcing Jimin into an awkward half-jog just to keep pace.

"I just want to point out that the gas mileage is very good," Jimin called over the wind.

The mechanic didn't look back.

"And parking is easy."

Nothing.

"She's really cute once you get to know her."

The old man didn't even turn around. He just kept marching forward, his heavy canvas coat swishing against his jeans.

"No car is bad why did you buy this..." the man muttered into his scarf, tossing a glance over his shoulder. "...stupid American!"

Jimin froze in his tracks for half a second, his mouth falling wide open in shock. His breath hitched, his eyes going wide under his wool hat. Jimin opened his mouth to deliver some fiercely articulate

defense, but the freezing wind blasted straight into his face, cutting him off with a harsh cough. He shut his jaw tight, swallowing his pride, and hurried after the man. He needed his car fixed more than he needed to win a debate.

When they finally reached Buttercup, the tiny yellow Twingo looked pathetically small sitting under the shadow of the tall pine trees, covered in a light layer of frost.

The mechanic walked up to the driver's side, gave the bright yellow door two heavy, loud thuds with his fist, and shook his head in disgust.

"Key," the man demanded, holding out a thick, calloused palm.

Jimin frantically fished the keys out of his pocket and dropped them into the man's hand. The mechanic unlocked the door, leaned inside, popped the hood release, and then shifted the gear stick into neutral.

Instead of waiting for a tow truck or pulling out a set of jumper cables, the old man walked around to the back bumper, planted his boots firmly onto the slick pavement, and simply began to push.

Buttercup—weighing roughly the same as a heavy backpack—began to roll forward, her tires crunching smoothly over the icy asphalt.

Jimin stood there on the shoulder, flashlight shaking in his hand, stunned as he watched a sixty-something-year-old French mechanic push his entire vehicle down the highway like it was a grocery cart.

The man paused for half a second, glancing back over his shoulder at Jimin, who was still frozen like a statue.

"Little bird, help! Don't stand!" the man barked, gesturing aggressively with his head toward the back of the car. "Push! You want to sleep in the snow?!"

"Right! Right! Sorry!" Jimin yelled, scrambling over the ice and throwing his hands flat against the freezing yellow metal right beside the mechanic.

Together, they pushed the yellow Twingo down the dark road, the old man grunting instructions while Jimin huffed and puffed, his boots slipping on the black ice every three steps.

They finally managed to guide Buttercup through the open bay doors, steering her safely into the center of the heated workshop before the old man killed the momentum and set the handbrake with a heavy *clack*.

The mechanic dusted his hands off on his trousers, letting out a long, satisfied grunt as he surveyed the yellow hatchback under the bright fluorescent lights.

"My son will be here soon, little bird," the man said, turning toward Jimin and pointing a strict, grease-stained finger at him. "Sit and keep warm. Don't steal."

Jimin, far too exhausted and windblown to defend his honor again, just nodded meekly. "I won't steal anything, promise."

The old man gave a sharp nod and vanished through the heavy wooden door into the back quarters.

Jimin sank into a worn, cracked leather armchair near the front heater, pulling his coat tight around his shoulders. He pulled out his phone one last time, tapping the screen with a faint flicker of hope. No Service. He groaned, dropping his head back against the cushion, the rhythmic hum of the industrial heater lulling his aching muscles into a heavy, leaden warmth. He told himself he would just rest his eyes for two minutes. Just two minutes.

His eyelids slipped closed, and the world faded out.



Jimin woke slowly, pulled out of sleep by voices somewhere beyond the back wall.

For a few seconds, he didn't move. His body still felt heavy from the warmth of the heater, his neck stiff from the awkward angle he had fallen asleep in, one cheek pressed numb from the cracked leather armchair.

Then he heard the second voice again.

Jimin's eyes opened.

It was quieter than the mechanic's, lower and smoother, answering something in quick French from the room beyond the door. There was nothing unusual about it. Nothing Jimin could logically point to.

Still, his stomach tightened.

He sat up slowly, rubbing the heel of his hand over one eye before dragging both palms down his face. His hat had shifted crookedly while he slept, and the scarf around his neck was bunched awkwardly beneath his chin. He fixed neither of them. His attention had already on the door.

The voices came closer.

The mechanic said something Jimin couldn't make out, followed by a response that made a strange little pulse start beneath his ribs.

No.

Jimin frowned at himself.

He was tired. That was all. He had spent the last several hours stranded in the cold, pushed an entire car down a highway, and had fallen asleep sitting upright in a not so cozy chair. His brain was probably just grabbing at familiar sounds because it had nothing better to do.

The door opened.

The mechanic came through first, still talking over his shoulder, one grease-darkened hand moving animatedly as he spoke. Someone followed behind.

At first Jimin saw only pieces of the *someone*.

A black wool coat, hanging open as the man stepped through the doorway. A navy knit sweater beneath it, plain and fitted enough to show the breadth of his chest and shoulders. Dark pants. Black boots dusted faintly with ice from the road. One hand carried a leather bag, the other a set of keys that gave a soft jingle with each step.

Jimin's breathing slowed as the man reached up to pull his coat loose from one shoulder, and then his face came fully beneath the lights of the office.

Everything inside Jimin stopped at once.

Jeon Jungkook.

For one terrible second, Jimin thought he was still asleep.

There was no dramatic rush of recognition because recognition was never the issue. Jimin knew that face all too well. He could have picked it out in a crowd from the shape of the jaw alone, from the slight downward set of his brows when he was concentrating, from the way his mouth rested when he wasn't speaking.

What Jimin couldn't understand was *why* it was here.

Jungkook looked different.

His hair had grown out since the gala, the dark strands softer now and long enough to brush the tops of his ears, a few pieces falling naturally toward his forehead instead of being styled back neatly like how Jimin remembered. Without the chef whites, without a suit, without that severe little knot of authority tied around his throat, he looked younger.

The hard set that used to live permanently in his shoulders looked looser. His posture was still straight, still unmistakably Jungkook, but he no longer looked as though every muscle in his body had been trained not to relax. Even his face had changed a little. There was more color in his skin from the cold outside, a faint flush across the bridge of his nose and the tops of his cheeks, and the shadows that used to sit beneath his eyes after long academy days were gone.

He looked...good.

The thought came so quickly that Jimin hated himself for it.

"Ah, little bird is awake!"

The old mechanic's booming voice shattered the silence like a falling tray of tools. He clapped his heavy hands together, gesturing brightly toward Jungkook.

"My son is big and strong, much better than me, no?"

Jimin's fingers tightened around the leather arms of the chair just as Jungkook looked up. Their eyes met, and Jungkook stopped so suddenly that his father took another step before noticing he was no longer beside him.

The keys in Jungkook's hand went still. His shoulders stiffened beneath his coat, his eyes widening and his lips parting around a breath he seemed to catch somewhere in his chest.

For one rare, unguarded second, Jungkook looked completely caught off guard by the sight of him. Then the shock softened into something harder for Jimin to name, something almost painful in the way Jungkook kept staring at him, like seeing Jimin again had reached somewhere he hadn't been prepared for.

None of this happened dramatically. Jungkook never did anything dramatically if he could help it.

But Jimin saw the slight lift of his brows, the way his lips parted around a breath he hadn't meant to take, the tiny movement in his throat when he swallowed. Jungkook's fingers tightened around the handle of the leather bag until the tendons in his hand stood out beneath his skin.

Then his gaze moved slowly over Jimin.

The oversized winter coat swallowing his frame. The crooked wool hat. His scarf twisted around his neck. The faint crease probably still pressed into his cheek from sleeping. His eyes had to be puffy, and his hair was undoubtedly messy beneath the hat.

Wonderful.

This was exactly how he had imagined their reunion.

Not that he had imagined it.

Jungkook's eyes dropped briefly to Jimin's hands gripping the chair, then traveled back to his face.

They lingered.

And suddenly the seven months between them collapsed into nothing.

Everything came back with painful clarity. Jungkook's hand around his. The quiet wish for next semester. The warmth leaving Jimin's palm. Watching Jungkook disappear into the crowd while Jimin stood there trying not to cry.

He had spent months forcing that memory dull but one look from Jungkook and it was alive again.

Jimin's chest tightened so hard he had to remind himself to breathe.

Neither of them spoke.

The mechanic finally noticed.

He looked from Jungkook to Jimin, then back to Jungkook again, his expression gradually shifting from confusion to suspicion.

"What is this?"

Jungkook still hadn't looked away and neither had he.

Jimin had no idea how long they stayed like that. It could have been three seconds or thirty. All he knew was that the silence became unbearable first, and once Jimin got uncomfortable, his mouth usually made decisions without consulting the rest of him.

Jimin scrambled up out of the chair so fast he nearly tripped over the hem of his coat. His face felt like it was on fire, but his tongue moved even faster, kicking into full-blown, panic-induced damage control.

"Oh... um, silly me! Let me try to start it again!" Jimin choked out, waving his hands around in tiny, frantic circles. "Maybe I overreacted! She always biffers like that on cold nights. Honestly! If I could just have the keys, maybe I could try and start her again and be on my way!"

The old mechanic stared at him, his face unimpressed by the frantic performance.

"No, little bird," the man said flatly, crossing his arms over his chest. "You will die out there. Just sit down and let my son help."

He glanced back and forth between Jimin—who was vibrating with panic—and Jungkook, who had turned into a statue in the middle of the bay, his lips still slightly parted, staring at Jimin like he had descended straight from the clouds.

The old man frowned, rubbing the back of his neck as the silence stretched thin enough to snap.

"And why is this staring?" the mechanic demanded, squinting suspicious dark eyes at the two of them. "What is it? Is there something on my face? Be honest."

"No," Jungkook finally rasped out.

The sound of his voice. It was deeper than Jimin remembered, carrying that familiar weight. It sent a sudden, electric shock straight down Jimin's spine.

Jungkook took a slow, heavy breath, finally tearing his wide, stunned gaze away from Jimin to look at his father. His throat bobbed as he swallowed hard, trying to force his professional composure back into place, though the slight tremor in his hands gave him away completely.

Jungkook's father looked between them again, his expression sharpening with curiosity now that Jimin had apparently forgotten how to speak.

Jungkook cleared his throat and finally looked away from Jimin. When he spoke, he switched into French so naturally that Jimin almost missed the significance of it.

"C'est mon ancien étudiant. Park Jimin."

Jimin's eyebrow lifted before he could stop it.

Jungkook didn't notice. Or, more likely, he didn't think Jimin understood French at all to catch the wording. Jimin let his face settle back into something neutral and kept his mouth shut.

Recognition moved slowly across the older man's face.

"Park Jimin?" he repeated.

Jungkook's shoulders tightened almost imperceptibly.

The mechanic pointed at Jimin, his eyes suddenly widening. *"Le garçon du gala?"* Then the man's face brightened even more. *"Celui qui a changé tout le menu? Celui qui a cassé toutes les règles?"*

Jungkook looked toward his father with the first real warning in his expression.

“*Papa.*”

His father ignored him.

“*Celui dont tu n’arrêtais pas de parler?*”

Jimin’s breath caught in his throat.

He looked at Jungkook.

Jungkook’s eyes flicked to Jimin just in time to catch the understanding settle over his face. It happened slowly at first, the slight raise of Jimin’s brows, the way his lips parted, the sudden stillness that told Jungkook he had understood far more than he was supposed to. Surprise crossed Jungkook’s face before he could hide it, quickly followed by something warmer and far more inconvenient. His ears reddened almost immediately.

Jimin said nothing.

Jungkook cleared his throat and switched back to English. “Papa, please.”

His father lifted both hands in surrender, though the grin on his face said he was not sorry in the slightest. “Fine, fine. I say nothing more.”

Jungkook gave him a look.

The older man nodded toward the back room. “I make coffee. I am tired, and you two have this...” He gestured vaguely between them, as if whatever was happening there was far too complicated for him to name. “You two fix lemon.”

The man walked away leaving the two of them alone.

Jimin slowly turned back toward Jungkook.

Jungkook was still looking at him, the embarrassment not completely gone from his face.

Neither of them mentioned the fact that Jimin apparently understood French now.

Neither of them mentioned what his father had just said either.

Neither of them mentioned how long it had been, and neither made some awkward attempt to escape the moment with a, “*Man, look at the time, I gotta get going,*” even though Jimin was starting to think one of them probably should.

Jungkook looked down at the keys in his palm for a moment before turning and walking toward Buttercup.

Jimin waited several seconds before following.

He kept his distance.

The concrete floor echoed faintly beneath their shoes while Jimin trailed behind, his hands pushed deep into the pockets of his coat. All those months apart had somehow made looking at Jungkook harder rather than easier. Jimin could feel the old nervousness creeping back beneath his skin, the same tightness he used to get when Jungkook approached his station during the first weeks at the academy.

They had gone all the way around.

Right back to strangers.

Jungkook stopped beside Buttercup and studied her silently.

His mouth tightened faintly.

Jimin knew that expression.

Judgment.

Jungkook opened the driver's door, pulled the hood release, then walked around front and lifted the hood. The metal gave a tired groan as he leaned over the engine bay, both palms resting against the frame.

Jimin stayed several feet behind him.

Under the harsh lights, Jungkook's profile looked painfully familiar. The same sharp jaw, the same slight furrow between his brows, the same piercing eyes.

He watched Jungkook for a second longer, his fingers curling inside his pockets, before forcing his attention toward the shelves along the wall.

"How are you?" Jungkook asked quietly, his head still buried beneath the lifted hood.

"Good," Jimin answered quickly, his voice tight. "And... what about you?"

"Good," Jungkook said back.

That was it.

Good.

Jungkook reached deeper into the engine bay, prodding at a loose valve before pulling his hands back and wiping his oil-stained fingers on a blue shop rag.

He let the hood rest on its latch and finally turned around, leaning his hip against the bright yellow bumper.

"The battery is dead," Jungkook said flatly.

Jimin stared at him, completely deadpan. "Oh." He swallowed hard, his mind racing through every single worst-case scenario. "Well... how long will it take to charge? I really, *really* have to get back for my practical exam tomorrow morning, and I—"

"You'd need a replacement," Jungkook interrupted, his voice oddly calm. "We don't have this model in stock tonight. If we order one now, it should make it here by tomorrow morning."

Jimin froze, processing the sentence bit by bit.

Tomorrow morning.

"Tomorrow morning," Jimin repeated out loud, his voice flat and pitch-thin. He blinked slowly at the grease-stained floor, his chest tightening as the reality set in. "You mean..."

Jungkook held his gaze, his dark eyes unwavering, carrying a quiet depth that made Jimin's breath hitch.

"No, no, no, no," Jimin stammered, his head shaking so fast his wool hat nearly slipped off. "I'm sorry, but I *have* to be back. I have an exam, I can't miss it, and—"

"Hey," Jungkook cut in smoothly. He tossed the greasy shop rag onto a nearby metal tray with an easy flick of his wrist. "I can drive you back. It's only about an hour from here. Less, if the highway stays clear." He gestured vaguely toward Buttercup's popped hood. "We'll order the part tonight, I'll bring it back tomorrow, fix it, and it's all yours again. Simple. No?"

Jimin stared at him, his jaw practically glued shut.

Simple? *Simple?!*

For one, Jimin didn't need any favors—especially not from *him*.

And two, Jimin was tired, mad, and did he mention *tired*? The thought of being trapped in the tight, quiet confines of a car with Jeon Jungkook for an entire hour, after months of radio silence, felt like a messed up form of psychological torture.

"N-no..." Jimin squeaked out, stepping back and pulling his scarf tighter around his chin like a shield. "It's... fine. I'll just catch the bus. Thanks..."

Jungkook raised an eyebrow, crossing his arms over his broad chest. The ghost of a displeased frown played at the very corner of his lips. That infuriating expression Jimin hadn't realized he missed until right this second.

"The bus line through this route stopped running at ten," Jungkook said evenly. "And the next one isn't until seven tomorrow morning. You'll miss your exam, Jimin."

Jimin closed his eyes, letting out a long, desperate groan toward the ceiling rafters. The universe was playing a sick prank on him.

"Let me take you back."

Jimin snapped his eyes open, glaring at him. He didn't have time for this. Not tonight.

"Fine," Jimin snapped, his pride officially taking a beating. "Fine. But I am paying for gas."

Jungkook didn't argue. He just grabbed his heavy black overcoat off the bench, sliding his arms into the sleeves with smooth, practiced ease, his dark eyes fixed entirely on Jimin.



Jimin followed Jungkook out of the garage without saying much, the cold hitting him the second the heavy door shut behind them. The lot was washed in white floodlight and thin winter fog, gravel shining faintly where frost had started to settle between the tire tracks. Jungkook walked a few steps ahead with his hands tucked into the pockets of his coat, his pace steady and unhurried, while Jimin trailed behind with his scarf pulled high over his mouth and both arms folded tightly across his chest.

Jungkook's car sat near the edge of the lot, black and polished beneath the lights, a sleek Audi that looked almost offensively expensive next to Buttercup. Jimin glanced back through the open bay at his little yellow Twingo with its hood still cracked open and felt belittled by the comparison.

Jungkook pressed the key fob, and the car chirped softly, its headlights cutting through the dark road ahead. He kept walking toward it, but Jimin slowed.

Seven months.

Seven months of silence, and now he was supposed to casually climb into Jungkook's car like none of it had happened.

The realization settled with every step. Jimin had spent months convincing himself he was fine, that everything was something that belonged in the past, that the ache in his chest had finally dulled into something manageable. He had gone back to school, cooked, studied, laughed, ignored every article that mentioned Jungkook's restaurant, and refused to say his name even when it sat right behind his teeth.

And now here he was.

Jimin stopped walking.

Jungkook made it several more steps before noticing the silence behind him.

His pace slowed, then stopped.

For a moment, he stayed facing the car.

Jimin could see the slight rise and fall of his shoulders beneath his black coat, could see the wind push dark strands of hair across the back of his neck.

Jungkook turned.

The wind caught the front of his coat as he did, pulling it away from his legs for a second before it settled again. His hair had fallen across his forehead, and the cold had brought color into his face, faint red spreading across the bridge of his nose and high along his cheeks.

He looked at Jimin.

Just waiting.

Jimin stood several yards away with his arms still crossed tightly against his chest. His fingers had curled into the fabric near his elbows, squeezing so hard, he could feel the pressure even through his gloves.

Neither of them spoke.

The wind moved loudly between them, brushing dead leaves across the pavement and shaking the bare branches beyond the edge of the lot. Somewhere behind Jungkook, the Audi idled quietly under the floodlights.

Jimin lowered his gaze for a second.

He could get into the car. He could sit quietly for an hour, stare out the window, thank Jungkook when they reached the academy, and walk away.

That would be the mature thing.

Probably.

Jimin lifted his head again.

“You could’ve told me.”

Jungkook’s expression changed slowly. His eyes narrowed faintly, not in anger but in recognition, like he had known this conversation existed somewhere ahead of them and had only been waiting for Jimin to find it

“Told you what?”

Jimin almost laughed but instead, his arms dropped from his chest.

“That you were leaving.”

Jungkook remained still.

Jimin stepped toward him, anger finally giving his body somewhere to put itself.

“That you quit. That you were moving back here...” Jimin made a sharp motion with one hand, frustration catching in his throat. “Never thought it was worth mentioning?”

Jungkook’s jaw tightened. He looked away toward the road, the muscle along his cheek working once as he breathed through his nose. Then, so quietly Jimin nearly missed it, he muttered, “*Toujours pareil.*”

Jimin’s brows pulled together.

“*Et alors?*”

Jungkook’s head turned back so quickly that it almost startled him.

His eyes widened.

For half a second, Jimin could see the exact moment he remembered the garage. The French. The fact that Jimin had understood every humiliating word his father had said.

Jimin's French wasn't nearly as smooth as Jungkook's, and he knew his accent probably gave away every bit of irritation he felt, but he didn't care.

"Qu'est-ce que tu veux que je fasse?" he continued, the words slower now as he searched for them. "What about it, Jungkook? How am I supposed to act?"

Jungkook stared at him.

Jimin took another step closer, his boots grinding against the frozen gravel. "You leave, you don't call, you don't write, you don't even tell me you're going, and then I'm supposed to see you again and what? Be calm? Smile? Ask how the restaurant is?"

Jungkook looked at him for a long second, then toward the car. Some of the tension in his face eased, though his jaw was still set hard enough for Jimin to notice. "Can we talk about this in the car?" he asked quietly.

Jimin stared at him.

"You—"

A brutal gust of wind hit him directly in the face, cutting through his scarf and making his eyes water.

Jimin stopped.

Actually.

Fine.

Without another word, he turned sharply and stomped toward the passenger side of the Audi, yanked the door open, and climbed in with considerably less grace than he would've liked. The door slammed shut behind him, cutting off the wind.

Warm air immediately wrapped around him.

Jimin sank back into the leather seat before he could stop himself, the heat already spreading through his coat and into his frozen legs. He closed his eyes for one brief second and let out a slow breath.

Still angry...just warmer now.

For a few seconds, Jimin just sat there with his eyes closed, letting the heat work its way back into his fingers while his anger tried very hard not to dissolve into the comfort of the car. The interior was almost offensively nice. Soft leather, low amber lighting, clean lines across the dashboard, everything quiet and warm enough to make the freezing argument outside feel like it had happened somewhere else.

Then the driver's door opened.

Cold air rushed in with Jungkook before disappearing again when he shut the door. Jimin opened his eyes and looked straight ahead, refusing to turn toward him as Jungkook settled into the seat beside him. There was a faint rustle of wool as he shrugged his coat back into place, the quiet click of the key fob, then silence.

Jimin could feel him looking but he kept his eyes on the windshield.

Jungkook finally looked away and started the engine.

The car started so quietly it barely made a sound. Jungkook rested one hand on the wheel, the other near the gear selector, but he didn't pull away immediately. He sat there for a moment probably deciding whether there was anything he could actually say to justify his actions.

"I thought you knew," he said softly.

Jimin's jaw tightened.

There it was again.

"Hearing it would've been nice too." Jimin bit back. "And no, I didn't know," Jimin continued, finally turning his head. "I don't spend every day thinking about *you*, you know."

The words came out sharper than he intended. Jimin heard it the second they left his mouth and hated himself for it.

Jungkook heard it too apparently. .

His eyes moved over Jimin's face for a moment, but he didn't challenge him. He only let out a quiet breath, shifted the car into drive, and pulled away from the garage.

The road stretched dark in front of them, the headlights cutting through thin flakes of snow drifting across the asphalt. For a while, neither of them spoke. The hum of the tires filled the car, while Jimin stared through the passenger window and watched the black silhouettes of trees slide past.

He tried to let it go.

He *really* did.

But silence had always made Jimin worse.

"I just thought..." Jimin swallowed, his voice dropping lower even as the anger underneath it sharpened. "I thought you cared enough to say something."

Jungkook's fingers tightened around the steering wheel, knuckles paling slightly against the leather. His shoulders drew in beneath the sweater, and for a moment he seemed to focus even harder on the empty road ahead.

"It was complicated."

Jimin turned toward him. "That's your answer?"

The words came out incredulous, almost breathless. Outside, dark trees blurred past the windows while snow collected in pale strips along the shoulder, but inside the car everything felt warm. Hot

“I had no choice,” Jungkook said.

Something inside Jimin snapped.

“Everyone has a choice,” he shot back, his voice rising. “And yours was to leave like a coward.”

Jungkook’s jaw clenched hard enough to sharpen the line of his face, the muscle jumping once near his cheek. His grip stayed fixed on the wheel, but the tension in his hands gave him away.

Still, he said nothing.

That silence scraped against every nerve Jimin had left.

“What if my car hadn’t broken down tonight?” Jimin demanded. “What if I never came here? What if I never saw you again?”

No answer.

Jimin’s throat tightened as the anger twisted into something uglier, something closer to hurt. “Then what? We just never speak again? Ever?”

Jungkook kept driving.

The quiet stretched until it became unbearable.

“Jungkook?”

His name cracked apart in Jimin’s mouth.

The sound left a raw ache behind it, as if all the months of not saying it had collected there and finally forced its way out at once.

Jungkook’s breath caught.

A second later, the Audi moved sharply toward the shoulder.

Gravel cracked beneath the tires as the car crossed off the road, and Jimin grabbed the door handle on instinct, pulse spiking as the headlights swung toward the dark tree line.

“What are you doing?”

Jungkook pulled them to a stop and threw the car into park. For a long second he stayed facing forward, both hands braced against the steering wheel, chest rising slowly beneath his sweater while the engine idled beneath them.

Snow drifted through the headlights in soft white streaks. The heater hummed steadily. Somewhere outside, wind moved through the trees.

Jungkook stayed facing forward for several seconds after pulling onto the shoulder, both hands still wrapped around the steering wheel while the car idled beneath them. The heater hummed softly through the vents, completely at odds with the tension inside the car, and outside the windshield the snow kept drifting through the headlights in slow white streaks.

When Jungkook finally turned toward him, his expression looked worn down more than angry. “I thought leaving was better for you.”

Jimin went still.

For half a second, he genuinely couldn’t believe *that* was what Jungkook had chosen to say.

Then he gave a short, disbelieving breath and reached for the door handle.

Jungkook’s hand moved immediately. The locks clicked.

Jimin froze with his fingers wrapped around the handle.

Slowly, he turned his head.

“Did you just lock the door?”

“Sit back.”

“Unlock it.”

“Jimin—”

“Unlock the fucking door.”

Jungkook’s jaw tightened. “You are not getting out on the side of a highway in the middle of nowhere. Let alone at night.”

“Watch me.”

“That’s ridiculous.”

“Oh, I’m ridiculous?” Jimin let go of the handle and turned fully toward him, anger rushing back so quickly it made his face hot. “*You* disappear, don’t tell me anything, then I *find* out by accident that you moved here and built some entirely new life, and now you’re telling me it was *better* for me?”

“That isn’t what I meant.” Jungkook rubbed a hand over his face and exhaled hard. “I meant I thought distance would make it easier.”

“For who?”

Jungkook didn’t answer quickly enough.

Jimin’s eyes narrowed.

“For who, Jungkook?”

Jungkook looked away.

Jimin’s laugh this time had no humor in it. “Right.”

He reached for the handle again but Jungkook caught his wrist just enough to stop him.

“Jimin.”

“Let go!”

“Please-.”

“Then stop deciding things for me.”

That made Jungkook let him go.

Jimin pulled his hand back to his chest, rubbing at his wrist even though Jungkook hadn't hurt him. His breathing had gone uneven now, anger tangled so tightly with everything else that his voice came out rough when he spoke again.

“Y-you keep doing that.”

Jungkook frowned.

“That's all you ever do.” Jimin let go of the handle and turned toward him fully, his voice rising now. “You decide what I should know. You decide what I can handle. You decide when we talk and when we don't, when something matters and when it suddenly doesn't anymore. You decide what's better for me without ever asking me what I actually want.”

“That's not fair. I-.”

“Neither was leaving.”

Jungkook's mouth pressed shut.

Jimin looked away toward the window, blinking hard. The reflection staring back at him looked furious and miserable at the same time.

“I didn't leave because I didn't care.”

Jimin's eyes closed.

“Then why did it feel like it?”

Jungkook went quiet.

Jimin swallowed and kept staring at the glass, watching the snow gather faintly along the edge of the windshield.

That silence hurt worse than Jimin expected.

He looked down at his hands, blinking hard as heat gathered behind his eyes. He was so tired of crying over this man. It was embarrassing at this point.

Jungkook spoke again, softer now.

“Because I didn't know how to stay without making you part of the reason.”

Jimin's gaze lifted.

Jungkook had lost most of the anger from his face. What remained looked exhausted.

“The academy was killing me long before you came here,” he said. “I just didn’t know how to leave it. I had been there too long. I was good at it. People respected me. It was easier to keep going than admit I hated the life I had built.”

Jimin listened quietly.

“And then you came in and made everything impossible to ignore.”

Jungkook looked down at his hands for a second, rubbing his thumb along one knuckle.

“Y-you argued with me about things I had stopped questioning years ago. You made me angry enough to ask myself why I was angry in the first place.”

Jimin’s chest tightened.

“I knew if I stayed, eventually you would start making choices around me.”

“You don’t know that.”

“Yes,” Jungkook said quietly. “I do.”

Jimin frowned.

“Because I was already doing the same thing.”

Jungkook leaned back against the seat, eyes returning to the windshield. “I stayed longer than I should have because of you. I started looking forward to days I used to hate because I knew you would be there. And that scared me more than leaving did.”

Jimin’s lips parted slightly.

Jungkook’s voice dropped.

“I didn’t want you watching me waste another year there and deciding that was what loving someone looked like.”

Jimin’s breath caught.

The word sat there between them.

Loving.

Jungkook seemed to realize he had said it too, because his mouth tightened and his gaze moved away.

Jimin stared at him.

The anger inside his chest suddenly had nowhere to go.

His fingers twisted together in his lap, and he bit down on his lower lip hard enough to stop it from trembling. His eyes had already gone glossy, and he looked down before the tears could actually spill.

“Okay,” he whispered.

Jungkook looked toward him.

Jimin swallowed and tried again.

“Okay.”

The second one came out even smaller.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Jimin lifted his head.

His lashes were wet now, his expression stripped of most of the anger that had carried him through the argument. What remained looked younger somehow. Softer

“Then...”

His voice caught.

Jimin pressed his lips together, breathed in shakily, and looked directly at him.

“Was it nothing?”

Jungkook’s brows drew together at first, confusion passing over his face so plainly that Jimin almost wished he hadn’t asked. For one awful second, he wondered if Jungkook truly didn’t understand what he meant. Then the question seemed to reach him properly, and his expression softened. His eyes first, dark and glossy beneath the amber light from the dashboard, and Jimin could have sworn he saw the faintest shine gather there.

Jungkook looked away.

His head tipped back slightly, eyes lifting toward the dark sky beyond the glass as if he were silently cursing himself, or fate, or whatever was up there that had decided to drag the two of them back into the same place after months. His jaw tightened once before loosening again, and Jimin watched all of it through blurred vision, his lower lip caught between his teeth.

His throat tightened.

“Was it nothing, Jungkook?”

This time, Jungkook closed his eyes.

Only for a second.

When he looked back, whatever had been holding him together seemed thinner.

Jimin’s seatbelt clicked.

He looked down in surprise.

Jungkook had reached across the console and unbuckled him.

He watched through tears as the belt slid slowly away from his body and disappeared against the side of the seat. Jungkook’s hand stayed there for a moment before rising, careful and almost

hesitant, until his palm finally settled against Jimin's cheek.

Jimin's breath trembled.

Jungkook's thumb moved slowly beneath his eye, catching the tear that had already escaped before it could trail any farther. Then another. His touch was so gentle it made Jimin feel fragile, like Jungkook was handling something he was afraid he had already broken once.

Jimin leaned into his palm without meaning to.

"Oh, Jimin," he whispered.

That was all it took before Jungkook leaned across the console and kissed him.

The first kiss was almost careful, like he was still asking permission even after everything. His mouth pressed against Jimin's and stayed there for half a second, warmly and familiar and devastating.

Jimin's fingers curled into the front of Jungkook's coat.

Then he kissed him back.

The restraint between them gave way almost immediately.

Jungkook's other hand slid around the back of Jimin's neck, pulling him closer while Jimin twisted toward him in the passenger seat. Their noses bumped once, breath catching between them, and Jungkook adjusted without breaking away, kissing him again with more urgency this time.

Jimin made a small, helpless sound against his mouth.

Jungkook's thumb brushed his cheek again even while he kissed him, catching another tear.

For the first time in months, Jimin stopped wondering whether any of it had been real.

He could feel the answer.

Still, Jimin couldn't take it.

He couldn't kiss Jungkook without feeling like he might break open at the same time. Every touch seemed to drag something old and buried back to the surface, every press of Jungkook's mouth against his making his chest ache harder instead of easing it. Jimin finally put a hand against Jungkook's chest, meaning to push him back just enough to breathe, but Jungkook caught his wrist before he could.

He only held Jimin's hand there, flat against his chest.

Jimin let out a low, helpless sound at that, more frustrated than anything, but he didn't fight him. He wasn't sure he had much fight left anyway.

Under his palm, Jungkook's heart was beating fast.

"I'm sorry," Jungkook murmured against his mouth. The words were blurred by the kiss, almost swallowed between breaths. "I'm sorry."

His voice cracked the second time.

Jimin shuddered.

There was something almost unbearable about hearing Jungkook sound like that. His voice had none of the careful calm Jimin remembered, none of the clipped certainty he used to carry into every classroom or kitchen. The apology came apart against Jimin's mouth between uneven breaths, and for a moment Jimin could only keep one fist twisted in the front of Jungkook's coat and let himself hear it.

Then Jimin felt something wet against his cheek.

At first, he thought it belonged to him. His own face was already damp, his lashes clumped slightly from tears, and he had long since given up pretending he wasn't crying. But then Jungkook's lips trembled against his, and another warm drop touched the corner of Jimin's mouth.

Jimin went still.

Jungkook seemed to realize it at the same time. He pulled away, not far, just enough to turn his face toward the windshield. His hand slipped from the back of Jimin's neck, and he dragged the back of it roughly beneath his eyes. The gesture was almost angry. His gaze dropped toward the center console afterward, fixed stubbornly on nothing, his jaw tight while he tried to steady his breathing.

"It..." Jungkook started, but his voice caught. He swallowed and tried again. "I..."

Nothing followed.

Jimin didn't rush him. He sat very still, his hand still resting against Jungkook's chest where it had been caught earlier. Beneath his palm, Jungkook's heart continued beating far too quickly, each heavy thud almost startling. Jimin had known this man angry. He had known him irritated, tired, frustrated, quietly amused, even afraid in the few moments Jungkook had accidentally allowed that much to show.

He had never known him like this.

Jungkook pressed his lips together and drew in another shaky breath. "I couldn't let you destroy yourself," he finally said, still looking down. "I couldn't let anything do that. Not the academy, not me, not..." His throat moved as he swallowed. "Not everything I was feeling. I knew what people were already saying, Jimin. I knew whose future would suffer more if it did stay."

Jimin's brows drew together, but Jungkook kept going before he could interrupt. His voice had grown rough, words coming more easily now that the first few had escaped. "You were still a student. I was responsible for you. You had worked too hard to be there for me to let whatever was happening between us become the thing people remembered of you. And I knew myself well enough to know staying wasn't going to make it easier. Every time I tried to put distance between us, I found another reason not to. Every time I told myself I was finished crossing that line, I crossed it again."

His eyes finally lifted.

They were red around the edges now.

“I couldn’t let what I wanted jeopardize what you were becoming.”

Jimin listened without interrupting, and somewhere in the middle of it, something clicked in his brain as he looked at Jungkook. There was no Director Jeon sitting across from him anymore. No instructor whose rules could dictate Jimin, no man standing behind an office desk using titles to keep everything confidential and safe. The academy was an hour behind them. Jungkook’s resignation had stripped away the last piece of authority that had ever existed between them.

There was only Jungkook.

“Shut up.”

Jungkook blinked.

His head lifted, and the smallest flash of offense appeared through all that emotion, so immediate and stunned that under any other circumstances Jimin probably would have enjoyed it.

His heart hurt too badly though.

“It’s my turn.”

Jungkook’s lips parted as though he were about to object on instinct. Then he stopped himself. His shoulders lowered, and he leaned back into the driver’s seat, wiping once more beneath his eye before dropping his hand into his lap.

Jimin took a shaky breath.

“I spent ...months thinking I did something wrong,” he began. His voice trembled immediately, and his eyes dropped toward his own hands as his fingers tangled together. “Do you understand that? I went over every fucking thing that happened between us until I couldn’t even tell what was real anymore. I thought maybe I pushed you too hard. Maybe I asked for too much. Maybe I embarrassed you so badly that you woke up one day and realized the easiest way to get rid of me was to leave.”

Jungkook’s brows pinched together, his mouth opening, but Jimin shook his head immediately.

“No. You listen.”

Jungkook’s mouth closed again.

“And then I heard about the restaurant. Everybody did. There were articles and pictures and people talking about how good you were doing, and you looked...” His lips pressed together for a second. “You looked happy.” His lips pressed together, trembling slightly while he stared down at his lap. “You looked really happy, Jungkook.”

The silence beside him remained complete.

“And I...I was happy for you. I was. I wasn’t sitting around praying for your downfall or anything.” His voice cracked slightly. “But it was also like...okay. Cool. So he leaves, opens this amazing restaurant, looks ten times happier....”

His next breath caught halfway in.

“ -And I started thinking maybe that was because I wasn’t there.”

Jungkook’s expression fell.

Jimin looked away before he had to see it.

“Maybe I had been part of what was making you miserable. Maybe you left and suddenly everything got easier because you didn’t have some stupid student following you around anymore, arguing with you and asking you things you didn’t want to answer and...” His voice wavered badly. “Wanting things from you that you couldn’t give me.”

“Jimin—”

“No.”

The word broke.

Jimin pressed his lips together, fighting for another breath as the first sob caught painfully behind his ribs. One hand rose toward his mouth out of instinct, but he stopped himself halfway. He had spent enough time hiding how badly this hurt. He lowered it again.

“Let me finish.”

Jungkook went quiet.

Jimin’s eyes finally lifted to his. Tears blurred Jungkook’s face at the edges, but Jimin kept looking anyway. “You hurt me so much.”

The words were softer than anything he’d said because now, there was no anger left in him.

Jungkook’s face tightened, his eyes seemingly growing wet again, but Jimin continued before he could respond. “I don’t think you understand how much. And it wasn’t because you quit. It wasn’t because you didn’t stay at that stupid school for me. I never wanted that.” Jimin shook his head, another tear sliding over his cheek. “I wouldn’t have wanted you miserable just so I could see you every day. That’s not what I wanted from you.”

His breath broke again, and this time he had to stop for a second.

“I just wanted you to tell me.”

His voice fell almost to a whisper.

“That’s it.”

Jimin wiped impatiently beneath one eye, but another tear replaced it almost immediately. “You stood there that night and looked at me like...” He stopped, swallowing against the memory. “Like you were saying goodbye without actually saying it, and I felt it. I *knew* something was wrong.”

Jungkook’s lips pressed together.

“I didn’t need you to promise me anything. I didn’t need you to choose me over your life. I just needed...” Jimin’s lip trembled, and he bit down on it for a second before forcing himself to continue. “I needed to know I hadn’t imagined all of it.”

The car had gone so quiet Jimin could hear Jungkook breathe.

“I wanted you to tell me that I mattered before you left.” Jimin stared at him through wet lashes, every defense he had carried into the car gone now. “I wanted to hear you say it meant *something* to you.”

The words settled between them in a way all their shouting hadn’t done. Outside, snow continued to fall across the empty road, disappearing beneath the headlights while the engine hummed quietly under them.

Jimin didn’t look away this time.

Neither did Jungkook.

There was nothing left between them to misunderstand now

Jungkook looked down at his hands for a long moment, the tendons in his fingers tightening as they curled loosely against his thigh. When he spoke again, his voice had lost most of its volume.

“If I told you, I knew I wouldn’t do it.”

Jimin’s brows pulled together.

Jungkook swallowed. “Leave. I knew what would happen if I stayed. People are fickle-minded, Jimin. They talk until there is something else to talk about. What they don’t see, eventually they stop remembering.” His jaw tightened before he forced himself to continue. “So I removed myself. I thought if I disappeared from the academy, the rumors would die with me. You would have a chance to be known for your work instead of for whatever people saw happening between us.”

“And I needed a chance too,” Jungkook added, quieter now. “To figure out who I was without that place. Without being Director Jeon every second of every day.”

His gaze dropped toward the console.

“So yes.” He breathed out slowly. “You’re right. I am a coward.”

Jimin went still.

“I am selfish. I am miserable. I hurt you because I was afraid to face what staying meant and too afraid to tell you what leaving meant.”

Jungkook finally looked back at him.

“And every day you weren’t there was another day I had to sit with that.”

Jungkook’s voice softened.

“I would wake up and wonder whether you were late to class. Whether you were eating properly. Whether you were still ruining some poor instructor’s patience. I would make something and know exactly what you would say before I tasted it.”

His mouth tightened faintly.

“And then I would remember you weren’t there.”

Jimin’s breath caught.

Jungkook looked away for a second, blinking hard.

“I thought distance would make it smaller.”

His jaw clenched.

“It didn’t.”

Jimin stared at him.

Jungkook’s eyes were wet again now, and this time he didn’t hide it.

“There wasn’t a day that passed where you didn’t exist somewhere in it.” Jungkook breathed in slowly. “So if you’re asking whether you imagined it…”

His eyes held Jimin’s.

“You didn’t.”

Jimin stopped breathing.

Jungkook’s voice dropped almost to a whisper.

“You were the one thing I left behind that followed me anyway.”

Jimin didn’t say anything.

For once, there was nothing there.

No argument waiting behind his teeth, no nervous joke, no quick little defense to throw between himself and whatever this was. He just sat there, stunned, staring at Jungkook while his lashes clung together from tears.

He blinked slowly.

A shaky breath left him as he searched Jungkook’s face for something that would make this easier to understand. A smirk. A trace of sarcasm. Anything that might tell him he had misunderstood something.

There was nothing.

Jungkook only looked back at him. Open in a way Jimin had spent so long wanting from him that now he almost didn’t know what to do with it.

“S-so…” Jimin swallowed, his voice catching slightly. “It was something.”

He hated how small the question sounded.

He already knew the answer. He had probably always known it somewhere underneath all the anger and hurt and days of trying to convince himself otherwise.

Still.

A little reassurance would be nice.

Jungkook's expression softened.

"Yes, Jimin." Jungkook didn't look away. "It was."

Jimin's lower lip trembled faintly, and he bit down on it to stop it. His eyes burned again, fresh tears threatening to gather even though he was so tired of crying.

"You idiot," Jimin whispered, and then, because even after hearing the truth he was not any less angry, he shoved lightly at Jungkook's chest. "I hate you."

Except he didn't push very hard.

Not really.

His palm stayed pressed there, fingers curling slightly into the fabric of Jungkook's sweater instead of forcing him away, and Jungkook seemed to understand the contradiction immediately. His eyes dropped to Jimin's hand, then lifted back to his face.

Jimin's mouth trembled.

"I hate you," he said again, weaker this time.

Jungkook didn't argue instead he said:

"I know," Jungkook said quietly. "And I'm sorry."

Jimin's hand was still resting against his chest, fingers half-curved into the front of his sweater, but Jungkook reached down and covered it with his own. His grip was warm as he lifted Jimin's hand away from his chest and turned it over slowly in his palm, his eyes never leaving Jimin's face.

"I'll never hurt you like that again."

The words came barely above a whisper.

Jungkook brought his hand toward his mouth and pressed a kiss into the center of Jimin's palm. His eyes stayed on Jimin's the entire time, dark and soft and almost painfully open. Then, for just a second, Jungkook closed them and let out a quiet breath against Jimin's skin.

"I'm sorry," he murmured again.

When he opened his eyes, Jimin saw right through them..

There was something almost pleading in the way Jungkook looked at him now. Not weak but there was this quiet, vulnerable softness in his face, his brows drawn together just slightly, his mouth relaxed after the apology, like he was waiting to find out if Jimin was going to take the hand back.

He looked almost like a puppy waiting to find out whether he had finally been forgiven.

A very broad-shouldered, irritatingly sexy French puppy.

Jimin hated him.

God, he hated him.

Apparently no amount of anger was enough for Jimin to forget how perfect Jungkook was.

The longer hair falling over his forehead. The slight flush still lingering across his cheeks from the cold. The shadow along his jaw. His stupid dark eyes looking up at Jimin from over the back of his hand like that.

And the accent.

Jesus Christ.

Jimin's throat went dry.

Had the car always been this warm?

He shifted slightly in the seat, suddenly aware of the heat coming through the vents, the warmth beneath his coat, the way Jungkook's thumb was moving slowly over the side of his hand.

This was crazy.

He had spent months grieving this man and apparently all it took was one apology, one kiss to the palm, and that stupid face for Jimin's honor to leave him.

Jungkook was still waiting. Still looking at him like he wanted forgiveness but didn't believe he deserved to ask for it.

Jimin swallowed.

"You're making it really hard to stay mad at you."

Jungkook's thumb stilled.

"I can stop."

Jimin frowned.

"No." A beat passed and Jimin's face warmed. "I mean—don't."

Jungkook's eyes softened.

There was another saying Jimin had heard once, maybe twice, from his mother whenever she was feeling oddly wise and maternal, despite probably never having experienced anything remotely like this herself. Something about if you loved something, you had to let it go, and if it found its way back to you, then maybe it had been yours all along.

Jimin had always thought it sounded like something people said when they wanted something they couldn't have. But sitting there now, Jungkook's hand still wrapped around his, Jimin wasn't so sure anymore.

Jimin opened his mouth, then closed it again.

He looked down at their hands instead, at the way Jungkook was still holding his and wouldn't let go. His thumb rested against the center of Jimin's palm, right over the spot he had kissed, and every few seconds it moved in one slow stroke across his skin. It was distracting. Jungkook in general was proving to be extremely distracting tonight.

Jimin drew in a breath through his nose and tried again.

"I don't do *things*."

Jungkook's brows pulled together slightly

"Or flings. Or sneaky links. Or whatever you want to call it." His face warmed as he looked pointedly toward the windshield instead of at Jungkook. "I'm not saying we have to figure out our entire lives tonight or get married tomorrow or anything." Jimin paused, then immediately made a face. "Well, obviously not married. I wouldn't want to marry you."

Jungkook's brows lifted, though not in offense.

Jimin caught it and winced.

"I mean—no, that's not what I—" He squeezed his eyes shut for half a second. "Okay. Look. I just mean I'm not interested in being something you only want when it's convenient." His voice softened despite his best efforts. "I don't want to wonder what I am to you again."

Jungkook's thumb stopped moving.

Jimin finally forced himself to look over.

"So..." He shrugged, trying for casual and failing. "Do with that what you will."

He turned his head away before Jungkook could answer.

The silence that followed lasted maybe three seconds.

It felt like three years.

Jimin stared very intently at a patch of snow illuminated beside the road and considered opening the door after all. Freezing to death suddenly seemed less humiliating than sitting here while Jungkook processed his accidental relationship proposal.

Then Jungkook spoke.

"Neither do I."

Jimin glanced over.

Jungkook was already looking at him.

"Neither do you what?"

"Flings." His accent wrapped softly around the word. "Or..." He paused, visibly searching his memory. "Sneaky links."

Jimin stared at him.

Something about hearing Jeon Jungkook say *sneaky links* in that deep French-accented voice nearly made Jimin laugh.

Jungkook looked at him for a moment, something quiet settling into his expression before he answered.

“Toi et moi, on ne fait qu’un.”

Jimin’s brows pulled together.

That one he hadn’t heard before.

He searched Jungkook’s face as if the meaning might somehow be written there instead, turning the unfamiliar words over in his head. *Toi et moi* he knew. You and me. The rest—

“What—”

He never finished.

Jungkook’s hand slid around the back of Jimin’s neck before he could finish the question, fingers slipping beneath the soft hair at his nape and drawing him forward. Jimin barely had time to inhale before their mouths met again.

The kiss was gentle this time. Nothing like the desperate collision from minutes before, when feelings of anger and missing each other had come spilling out at once. Jungkook kissed him slowly, his mouth warm and careful against Jimin’s, lingering between each soft press as though there was nowhere else either of them needed to be. His thumb moved lazily beneath Jimin’s ear while his fingers stayed curled around the back of his neck, holding him close without forcing him any closer than he wanted to come.

Jimin wanted closer.

He shifted toward him without breaking the kiss, one knee turning awkwardly on the passenger seat as he tried to move around the center console. Sadly, his coat caught beneath him.

Jimin made an irritated little sound against Jungkook’s mouth and yanked at it blindly.

Jungkook’s hand left his neck just long enough to help, catching the back of the coat and pulling it free while Jimin somehow managed to get one knee onto the edge of the console.

His shin bumped something hard. His other foot got briefly stuck beneath the passenger seat. His elbow knocked against the dashboard, and somewhere in the middle of trying to maneuver himself across the cramped space, Jimin nearly hit Jungkook in the chin.

Neither of them stopped kissing despite it all.

Jungkook caught him around the waist before he could lose his balance, one strong arm pulling him the rest of the way over. Jimin grabbed at his shoulders for leverage, twisted sideways, and finally managed to settle across his lap with one knee pressed beside Jungkook’s hip and the other wedged awkwardly between the seat and the console.

There.

Much better.

Jimin shifted once more until he was comfortable, and Jungkook's hands settled naturally at his waist, warm even through the layers of his clothes. The position put them face-to-face now, so close that Jimin could feel Jungkook's breath against his upper lip whenever they separated for barely a second.

Jimin looked at him.

Jungkook's hair had fallen out of place by now, dark strands brushing his forehead. His cheeks were still faintly flushed, although Jimin doubted the cold had much to do with it anymore, and his lips were pink and slightly swollen. That open, yearning look hadn't entirely left his eyes either.

God.

Jimin had seriously forgotten.

It had been long enough for his memory to dull the exact details of how attractive Jeon Jungkook was. His brain remembered *handsome*. It remembered *annoyingly handsome*. It had failed to preserve the actual experience of having that face inches from his own.

Jungkook's gaze moved over him in return, lingering on Jimin's eyes before dropping briefly to his mouth.

"What?" Jungkook murmured.

"Nothing."

Then Jungkook leaned in again, and Jimin met him before he could cross the entire distance.

Their mouths touched softly, once, twice, and Jimin let his arms settle loosely around Jungkook's shoulders as the kiss deepened. One of Jungkook's hands moved slowly up his back, palm flat and warm between his shoulder blades, while the other remained at his waist keeping Jimin there.

Jimin could feel the difference in them.

There were no hurried glances. No guilt waiting for them the second their mouths separated. No title hovering over Jungkook's head, reminding them of everything they weren't supposed to want.

Outside, snow continued falling silently around the parked car, tiny flakes catching in the headlights before disappearing into the dark. The windows had begun to fog faintly, shutting the rest of the world farther and farther away until there seemed to be nothing beyond the warm little space they occupied.

Jimin pulled back just enough for their noses to brush.

Jungkook opened his eyes and Jimin's heart gave a stupid little squeeze.



And then, because whoever has been directing Jimin's life finally has decided he deserved a fairy tale ending, the camera would pull back.

Slowly.

Past the fogging windows of the Audi. Past the soft glow spilling across the dashboard. Past Jungkook's hand at the back of Jimin's neck and Jimin halfway in his lap, both of them far too occupied with each other to notice the snow continuing to fall outside.

A little farther.

A little to the left.

Oh.

Wait.

Where did their clothes go?

Pan away!

Pan away!

Jesus Christ, pan away!

Perfect.

The view would drift toward the empty road instead, snow gathering quietly along the shoulder beneath the wash of the headlights while the car sat warm and still against the winter dark.

Then the picture would soften.

Fade out.

And after just long enough to make someone wonder what happened next?!

Fade in.

Bright morning light.

A different place.

A different year.

And across the screen, in big obnoxiously dramatic letters:

THREE YEARS LATER.

The dough under Jimin's palms had reached that sticky, stubborn stage where it clung to his knuckles like wet paste, but he couldn't bring himself to care. Across the stainless steel pass, the line was already moving at a breakneck speed—a blur of white jackets, clattering copper, and the sharp, percussive rhythm of French orders being shouted over the hiss of searing butter.

His phone, sitting on the far edge of the wooden butcher block, gave another low, insistent buzz.

Bzzzz. Bzzzz.

Jimin blew a loose strand of hair out of his eyes, squinting through the heat haze rising from the flattop.

He scraped the heaviest clumps of flour off his thumbs, hauled himself around the heavy island, and swerved just in time to avoid taking a hot sheet tray of tart shells straight to the chest. With both hands hovering in the air like he was about to get fingerprinted, he leaned over the counter and awkwardly jabbed the green icon with the sharp point of his elbow.

“Hello?”

“Jimin!”

His mother's voice didn't just come through the speaker; it practically echoed off the high tiled ceilings. Jimin flinched, pulling his ear back an inch.

“Hi, Mom,” he said, a helpless grin already tugging at his mouth.

“Your father and I are sitting right here! We just finished watching the interview!” she practically yelled into the microphone. “Oh, sweetie, we are so proud of you! Hobi's been blowing up our phones all morning. Sending every little clip he could track down. Your father and I have rewatched the main segment four times already!”

Jimin chuckled, leaning his hip against the cool metal of the island and shaking his head. “I knew Hobi was behind this. I told him not to send you guys everything.”

“Oh, hush! We miss you so much, baby, but you looked so handsome! So professional! Are you at work right now? Jimin? Can you hear me over all that noise?”

“Yeah, Mom, I can hear you!” Jimin had to raise his voice as the dish pit behind him let out a metallic crash, followed immediately by the high-pitched whine of a stand mixer whipping egg whites. “I hear you. Thank you. Honestly... I was shaking the entire time.”

He tucked the phone against his shoulder with his chin, awkwardly leaning over to work the dough again so the pastry chef wouldn't murder him. “Could you tell?” he asked, adjusting his grip. “Did I sound nervous?”

“Not a bit, son!” his dad chimed in, sounding a little closer now. “You looked sharper than a knife!”

Jimin bit his lip to keep from laughing out loud. “Yeah?”

“Where’d you even get a suit like that anyway?” his dad asked. “Looked expensive.”

Ah. The suit. Jimin’s hands slowed over the dough. A slow, private little smile spread across his face. He remembered the box arriving at his place two weeks ago. No card, no note—just a heavy garment bag from a tailor in the 1st arrondissement and a single text from Taehyung that read: *If you wear off-the-rack on national television, I am revoking our friendship.*

“It was a gift,” Jimin said mildly.

“From who?”

His mom let out a sharp laugh on the other end. “Oh, leave him alone, honey. Let the boy have his secrets.” She paused, and Jimin could practically hear the mischievous grin forming on her face over three thousand miles away. “...And tell Jungkook we said hello.”

Jimin’s fingers froze mid-knead. In the background, his dad let out a low laugh.

“And tell that handsome boy of yours not to work himself into an early grave,” his mom added seamlessly.

Jimin dropped his head, letting out a long, suffering sigh. “Mom. Please.”

“What? I’m just stating facts!”

“You state the same fact every time we talk.”

“Because it’s still true!” she said, utterly unbothered. “Besides, Hobi sent us that photo from the magazine spread. You two look so sweet together.”

Jimin closed his eyes, his cheeks flushing warm under the kitchen heat lamps. He knew the exact picture she was talking about. It was taken outside a venue, right as they were getting into a cab, with Jungkook’s arm slung low around his waist and Jimin looking up at him mid-laugh.

Because... *yeah.*

Turns out Jimin didn’t hate Jeon Jungkook.

That had been an unfortunate miscalculation on his part.

In fact, for the last three years, it had been quite aggressively the opposite. Aggressively, completely, stupidly opposite. The kind where Jungkook’s black toothbrush was currently sitting in the ceramic cup next to Jimin’s pastel one. Where half of Jungkook’s closet had slowly been taken over by oversized hoodies. Where there was a framed, slightly blurry polaroid on their nightstand of Jungkook pressing a kiss to Jimin’s cheek while Jimin tried, *and failed*, to look annoyed.

So. Fine. Maybe he loved him a lot. *Whatever.*

Jimin glanced up at the clock mounted above the double doors leading to the dining room. His eyes went wide. *4:15 PM.*

“Oh, shoot.” The prep energy in the room was shifting fast. The easy banter was disappearing, replaced by the sharp, focused tension of pre-service. Linens were being wiped down, squeezable bottles of oils arranged in rows, saucepans lined up on the burners like soldiers. “Mom, I gotta go,” Jimin said, hurriedly scraping the dried dough off his knuckles into the bin. “Service starts in forty-five minutes. I’ll call you guys tonight, okay?”

“Oh, alright,” she sighed, sounding disappointed for about half a second. “We’ll let you go. But we’re definitely planning a trip out there soon! I was just telling your father, that week we spent in Paris for your graduation was magic.”

Jimin laughed, grabbing a damp towel to wipe down his arms. “You guys can come whenever. You know you don’t need an excuse. The guest room is always there.”

“Maybe around Christmas, then.”

“Mom. Last week you said spring.”

“Well, maybe Christmas *and* spring!”

Jimin shook his head, a soft smile tugging at his lips. “Okay, okay. We’ll figure it out. I really have to drop the phone now.”

“Go, go! We love you!”

“Love you, kid!” his dad called out.

He tapped the screen off with his wrist and let out a long breath, resting his hands flat on the counter for a brief second. Three years ago, phone calls home usually involved him hiding in a bathroom, sobbing into a paper towel because a chef had ripped his plating apart, or panicking over whether he’d passed a class. Now... his parents were watching him on TV. It was weird. Surreal, really.

He’d graduated top of his class—not that he bragged about it, except for the times he brought it up to Jungkook whenever they had an argument about anything ever. Never mind the missed buses, the breakdowns, the tears in walk-in refrigerators, the disastrous practicals, or the semester where he had considered changing his name and moving somewhere nobody knew what a béchamel was. None of that mattered anymore. Park Jimin had walked across that stage with honors pinned neatly to his chest while his mother cried loud enough for three rows of strangers to hear.

Jungkook had been there too.

Not as Director Jeon.

Just Jungkook.

Sitting beside Jimin’s family with one ankle crossed over the other, looking perfectly composed until Jimin’s name was called. Then Jimin had caught him smiling from the stage, small and private and so openly proud that Jimin nearly missed the dean reaching out to shake his hand.

After graduation, Jimin did exactly what Jungkook had once been so afraid he wouldn’t do.

He left him.

Well. Professionally.

He took a job at one of the best restaurants in Paris all *without* Jungkook's help. The restaurant was brutal in the way prestigious restaurants tended to be. Long hours, tiny margins for error, chefs who could look and tell an overworked sauce from color alone. For the first several months, Jimin came home with aching feet, burns scattered along his forearms, and the faint smell of butter permanently embedded in his hair no matter how many times he washed it.

He loved it.

His station sat near the back of the kitchen beside a narrow old window that nobody else seemed to care about. Most nights it reflected nothing but fluorescent light and Jimin's own exhausted face, but every once in a while, when the sky was clear and he happened to look up at exactly the right moment, he could see the Eiffel Tower glowing between the buildings in the distance.

He was almost fluent in French now too.

Almost.

Which meant nobody could mutter *stupid American* under their breath anymore without Jimin turning around and offering an extremely *detailed* response in the same language.

Professionally, things had gotten a little ridiculous.

A year into working in Paris, *La Table Française* named him *Rookie Chef of the Year*, describing his cooking as instinctive, fearless, nostalgic without being sentimental, and—Jimin's personal favorite—*impossible to ignore*.

And somewhere between the interviews, restaurant reviews, and Jimin slowly becoming a recognizable name outside the academy that had once defined him, the world also found out about *them*.

Apparently walking out of a restaurant holding hands with one of France's most recognizable young chefs while six photographers were standing across the street was not the subtle romantic outing Jimin had imagined.

Within twenty-four hours, the internet had lost its mind.

There were articles.

Pictures.

Fan edits, somehow.

One entertainment site called them *France's Hottest Couple—in and out of the kitchen*, followed by some terrible line about the two chefs "*turning up the heat*."

Somewhere, Eric was probably sitting with his arms crossed going, *I fucking knew it*.

Jimin would give him that one.

Because Eric *had* known before the articles, before the interviews, before photographs of them started circulating online, before either Jimin or Jungkook had been brave enough to put an actual

name on whatever had existed between them.

Eric had known Park Jimin and Jeon Jungkook had a *thing*.

Except Jimin didn't do *things* anymore.

Remember?

No flings.

Jeon Jungkook was his boyfriend. His boyfriend of three years, two months, and one day. Not that Jimin was counting.

And speaking of devastatingly attractive French men, Jimin lived with Jungkook now!

They had moved into a condo in the countryside roughly forty minutes outside Paris, far enough from the city that mornings were quiet but close enough that Jimin could still commute without Buttercup blowing up or something. Their building sat near a little stretch of road lined with trees, bakeries, small cafés, and houses with flower boxes that looked very picturesque in spring.

The apartment itself had slowly become an accidental combination of both of them. Jungkook's clean lines and dark furniture mixed with Jimin's habit of buying things because they looked "cute," which was how a bright ceramic rooster ended up living beside an extremely expensive espresso machine.

Jungkook still ran his restaurant.

Three years after opening, it had been named *Best Contemporary French Restaurant* by *Le Guide Culinaire* for the third consecutive year. Reservations disappeared months ahead of time. Critics wrote long paragraphs about Jungkook's precision, and ability to make familiar food feel completely new. Young chefs applied from across Europe just for the chance to spend a few weeks in his kitchen.

And Jungkook was different now.

That was what Jimin loved most.

The restaurant was busy, demanding, exhausting but Jungkook didn't disappear inside it the way he had disappeared inside the academy. He came home tired instead of hollow. He laughed more. Slept more. Took Weekends off. Sometimes Jimin would wake before him and find Jungkook sprawled across half the mattress with his hair messy, looking nothing like the mean Director Jeon who had once terrified an entire lecture hall into silence.

Jimin liked this version *much* better.

And somehow, despite all the attention their relationship received once it became public, the thing that made Jimin happiest was surprisingly small.

An article had come out a few months earlier.

There was a photograph of him and Jungkook near the top. They had been leaving some culinary event in Lyon, But it was the caption underneath that Jimin kept looking at.

Star Rookie Chef Park Jimin and Culinary Prodigy Jeon Jungkook.

Each with their own title.

Each with their own accomplishments.



Jimin stirred as the pale morning light began to bleed through the sheer curtains, stretching his arms high over his head until his joints gave a satisfying little click. He buried his face deeper into the feather pillow, letting out a sleepy, contented grunt, and reached out an arm to pull Jungkook closer. His hand struck an empty, cool mattress.

Jimin's eyes fluttered open. He blinked against the dim light, staring at the empty space beside him. The sheets were tossed back, the imprint of Jungkook's body still fresh against the sheets, but the man himself was gone.

Then, his nose twitched. Then sniffed.

Butter.

Eggs.

Something warm and savory underneath it.

Jimin lifted his head.

Oh.

He dragged himself out of bed and wandered toward the kitchen in an oversized shirt and sleep shorts, following the smell like a cartoon character floating through the air toward a pie.

By the time he reached the kitchen doorway, he was awake enough to appreciate what was waiting for him. He stopped, leaning his shoulder against the door frame just to take it in.

Jungkook was standing at the stove shirtless wearing only a pair of low-slung, dark pajama pants, his bare feet planted shoulder-width apart. His dark hair, longer now than it used to be, was pulled back into a messy bun, leaving the sharp line of his jaw and the long slope of his neck fully exposed. As he reached up to adjust the heat on the burner, the muscles across his back shifted, the intricate black ink of his tattoo sleeve catching the morning sun.

Jimin's eyes lingered on the line of his waist, then tracked slowly up the broad expanse of his shoulders. *God*, he thought, slightly dazed. *What a view.*

"Tu es réveillé?" Jungkook's deep, gravelly morning voice broke the silence before he even turned around.

Jimin blinked, startled. *"Oui,"* he rasped, his own voice thick with sleep. *Ça sent bon"*

Jungkook turned his head over his shoulder, a tiny, fond crease forming between his brows as he took in Jimin's disheveled hair and sleepy expression. "*J'ai fait ton préféré*," he murmured, nodding toward the pan.

Jimin's eyes lit up. He pushed off the doorframe and shuffled over, leaning his hip against the edge of the counter to peer over Jungkook's shoulder. An omelette. Pale, perfectly folded, shimmering with a light sheen of butter.

"Oh, wow," Jimin breathed, his mouth practically watering. Then, he paused. He leaned closer. He squinted. His smile flatlined. He slowly turned his head to stare at the side of Jungkook's face. Jungkook was already watching him out of the corner of his eye, looking suspiciously innocent.

Jungkook raised an eyebrow. "*Quoi?*"

"You know what." Jimin pointed a finger at the pan. "Where's the cheese?"

"Inside," Jungkook said smoothly, giving the pan a tiny shake.

"How much inside?"

Jungkook sighed, turning his full body around to face him, leaning his lower back against the stove. "Jimin. It's an egg dish. It's supposed to be delicate. You don't need a pound of cheese hiding the texture of the fold."

"It's a crime," Jimin corrected, stepping around him without an ounce of hesitation and yanking open the fridge door. "You are serving me a sad, naked egg."

"It is a *classic* French —"

"I don't care about classic," Jimin muttered, pulling out a heavy wedge of sharp cheddar and a stainless-steel grater. "I care about my happiness."

Jungkook folded his arms over his chest, a long-suffering look on his face as Jimin marched back to the stove. Jimin didn't hesitate. He held the grater directly over the hot pan and went to work.

Shred. Shred. Shred.

A light dusting turned into a generous layer. A generous layer turned into a thick, snow-like blanket. Jungkook watched the mountain grow, the corners of his mouth twitching slightly despite his best efforts to look stern. "*Incroyable*," he muttered under his breath, shaking his head. "Absolute barbarian."

"There," Jimin said proudly, setting the grater down on the counter with a metallic *clink*. "Now *this* is food."

"It's a heart attack."

They never actually made it to the table. Two professional chefs owned perfectly good dishes, matching silverware, expensive napkins, and a dining table they had spent far too much money on.

Instead, Jimin hopped up to sit on the edge of the kitchen island, his bare feet dangling over the edge, while Jungkook stood between his knees, holding a single fork. They took turns taking bites

straight from the pan, the steam carrying the rich scent of sharp cheese and rich butter into the quiet morning air.

Jimin swallowed a bite, watching the way the sunlight hit the sharp angle of Jungkook's jaw. His heart suddenly gave a strange, fluttery kick against his ribs. Right. He had to tell him. He'd been trying to figure out how to bring it up since he woke up, but now that they were here, his throat felt oddly tight.

"Hey," Jimin said softly.

Jungkook looked up, chewing slowly. "Hmm?"

Jimin tried to sound casual. Unbothered. "I got a letter yesterday."

Jungkook paused, the fork halfway to his mouth. "A letter?"

"Yeah." Jimin looked down at his own hands, picking at a loose thread on his shirt. "From Maison Étoile."

The kitchen went dead quiet. Jungkook didn't move. He didn't blink. The fork hovered in mid-air between them like time had suddenly stopped.

"...*Quoi?*" Jungkook whispered.

"I got in," Jimin said, a small, helpless smile finally creeping onto his face as he looked up. "They accepted the application. Co-sous chef."

Jungkook stared at him. Maison Étoile wasn't just a good restaurant. It was *the* restaurant. Three Michelin stars, an executive chef who was treated like royalty across Europe, and a kitchen that usually only took senior staff with decades of experience under their belts. For a twenty-something-year-old to walk in as co-sous chef was almost unheard of. It was the kind of career leap people sacrificed their entire personal lives for.

Jungkook set the fork down on the counter with a quiet clack. His eyes were wide, dark, and utterly motionless. "You're... serious?" Jungkook asked, his voice rough.

"Yeah," Jimin whispered, his cheeks flushing. "I was gonna tell you last night, but you came home so late and you looked so exhausted, and I didn't want to just t-throw it at you while you were half-asleep, so—"

"Jimin."

Jimin snapped his mouth shut.

Jungkook took a slow step closer, slipping his hands onto Jimin's waist, right where his shirt was riding up. His thumbs stroked gently against the soft skin above Jimin's hips.

A slow, breathtaking smile broke across Jungkook's face. One that crinkled the corners of his eyes and showed the tiny flash of his front teeth. "Wow," Jungkook breathed. "Baby... wow."

Jimin let out a nervous little laugh, feeling his whole body warm up under that gaze.

"I'm..." Jungkook shook his head, looking almost overwhelmed as he stared up at him. "I'm so fucking proud of you."

There it was. That look. The same look he'd given Jimin since the day they met.. The look that made Jimin feel like he was the only person in the room, no matter how loud the world got around them.

Jimin swallowed hard, his eyes stinging slightly. "Thanks," he murmured, looking down at Jungkook's bare chest to avoid making eye contact. "I worked really hard on the menu proposal."

"I know you did," Jungkook said softly. He reached up, his fingers gently cupping Jimin's chin and tilting his face back up. "You earned every single bit of this. On your own."

"Jungkook..."

"No, look at me," Jungkook demanded quietly, his voice firm, grounding. "You did this. You're brilliant, Park Jimin. Everyone else is just finally catching up."

Jimin's breath hitched. "You're gonna make me cry, shut up."

Jungkook chuckled, a sound that vibrated right through Jimin's thighs where they were wrapped around his hips. He leaned in and pressed his lips firmly against Jimin's.

Jimin smiled faintly against him, but Jungkook caught his lower lip on the next kiss, pulling back just enough to nip gently before deepening the press of their mouths. Whatever lightness Jimin had been holding onto vanished instantly, replaced by a sudden, heavy heat that pooled low in his stomach.

Oh. Okay.

Jimin's fingers dug into the firm muscle of Jungkook's bare shoulders. The kiss wasn't rushed at all. It was slow, deliberate, and entirely too thorough for a Tuesday morning. Jungkook's hands slid down to his waist, broad palms pressing warm through the thin cotton of Jimin's sleep shirt, hitching him forward until Jimin's thighs were firmly bracketing his hips against the edge of the granite island.

Jimin took a shaky breath through his nose, the rich scents of espresso, melted butter, and Jungkook's skin filling his senses. Jungkook dragged his lips across Jimin's, once, twice, before lingering at the soft curve of his cheek. Then his mouth strayed down, pressing a lingering kiss right to the sensitive turn of Jimin's jaw. Instinct took over; Jimin's head tilted back, his throat arching without a second thought.

Jungkook took full advantage. He dragged his lips down the sharp line of Jimin's jaw, one hand spreading wide over the small of Jimin's back while the other gripped his hip tight enough to bruise. When those warm lips found the exposed spot right under his ear, Jimin's fingers curled so hard into Jungkook's shoulders his knuckles turned white.

"Jungkook..." Jimin gasped softly.

A low, dark rumble of acknowledgment vibrated against his neck, setting off a chain reaction of shivers straight down Jimin's spine. Then Jungkook kissed him right over his pulse point. Slow.

Heavier this time. Jimin's eyes fluttered closed, a quiet sigh escaping him as his hand slid into the soft dark hair at the back of Jungkook's head, careful not to pull the black hair tie loose.

"You know," Jimin murmured, his voice entirely too raspy to carry any real authority, "most people just say congratulations but this works too."

Jungkook's mouth paused against his collarbone, his warm breath fanning over Jimin's skin. Jungkook lifted his head just an inch, dark eyes heavy-lidded and glittering with amusement as he looked up. His lips were swollen and warm, his hair was tumbling messily over his forehead, and that infuriatingly handsome smirk had returned to Jungkook's face.

"Do you want me to stop?" Jungkook asked softly.

Jimin stared at him for a beat, his pulse hammering in his throat. "No."

Jungkook's smirk widened into a slow, cocky grin.

"Don't look so pleased with yourself," Jimin huffed, rubbing his thumb over the line of Jungkook's jaw. "You're so annoying."

Jimin pulled him back down by his neck, pressing a quick, smug kiss to his mouth before pulling back just far enough to break the spell. His eyes flicked toward the empty stainless steel pan sitting on the stove behind them. A terrible, ridiculous idea took root.

Jimin straightened his spine on the counter, sitting up tall and dramatically smoothing down the front of his oversized t-shirt. Jungkook watched him, one brow arching in deep suspicion.

Jimin cleared his throat, slipping into his most stoic, terrifyingly formal tone. "So, Director Jeon."

Jungkook's eyebrows shot up.

Jimin nearly cracked right there, but he held his ground, putting on his best over-enthusiastic academy voice. "How was my omelette? Please remember that your evaluation may have serious consequences for my academic standing and career trajectory."

For a second, Jimin expected him to laugh. He didn't. Instead, the warmth in Jungkook's expression melted away with frightening speed. The slight curve of his mouth flattened, his posture straightened, and his shoulders squared into that rigid, terrifyingly composed line Jimin remembered all too well from years ago. The warmth in his eyes vanished behind a wall of pure, unreadable stone.

Jimin's stomach did a traitorous little flip, a sharp burst of nostalgia hitting him so hard he almost lost his grip on his professional posture.

Jungkook stepped back just half an inch, crossing his arms over his bare chest. He tilted his chin down, staring at Jimin with the exact same chilly, razor-sharp assessment he used to level at terrified students during practical exams. "You want an evaluation, Chef Park?" Jungkook asked, his voice suddenly dropping half an octave, smooth, icy, and completely devoid of inflection.

Jimin swallowed hard, struggling to keep his expression deadpan. "I *want* your feedback, Director."

Jungkook let out a slow breath, his gaze dropping to the empty pan on the stove, then back up to Jimin's face. He picked up the edge of a clean kitchen towel, wiped his thumb with methodical

precision, and tossed it onto the counter. "Where do I begin?" Jungkook murmured, stepping back into Jimin's space until his chest was inches from Jimin's face again. He didn't touch him. "The execution was... chaotic. You *completely* abandoned traditional technique midway through preparation."

"I—"

"I did not ask for a defense," Director Jeon cut in smoothly, his voice quiet, commandingly stern.

Jimin's mouth snapped shut, his cheeks flushing pink. *God, why was this still hot?*

Jungkook leaned down slightly, bringing his face level with Jimin's, his dark eyes locking onto his without a hint of mercy. "You overwhelmed a delicate egg base with an offensive quantity of aged cheese. The structural integrity was compromised. A classic French kitchen would have thrown you out onto the street before the butter even melted."

Jimin held his breath, biting the absolute hell out of the inside of his cheek to stop from bursting into a full grin.

"Furthermore," Jungkook continued, his gaze drifting down to Jimin's swollen lips before snapping back up to his eyes, "your attitude during service remains utterly insubordinate. You talk too much. You distract the executive staff. *Et toi, tu débarques avec juste un t-shirt et un minuscule short, en sachant très bien l'effet que ça me fait.*" He paused, letting the silence stretch between them in the sunlit kitchen until the tension was pulled taut as a wire.

Jimin leaned forward just a fraction of an inch, his voice dropping into a breathless whisper. "And?"

For three agonizing seconds, Jungkook maintained the stone-cold mask, staring down at him with ruthless intensity. Then, Jungkook's eyes darkened slightly, his smirk returning as his hands slid down to grip the underside of Jimin's thighs.

Before Jimin could get another word out, Jungkook shifted his weight and hitched Jimin straight off the high granite counter.

"Wait—!" Jimin gasped, letting out an airy laugh as he was pulled clean into the air.

His legs wrapped instinctively around Jungkook's waist to keep his balance, his arms locking tight around Jungkook's neck. Jungkook caught his mouth again mid-lift, deepening the kiss as he turned effortlessly on his heel, leaving the kitchen behind.

Jimin held on tightly, his fingers buried in the soft hair at the back of Jungkook's neck, laughing into the press of their lips as Jungkook carried him like he weighed absolutely nothing. Their noses bumped mid-stride.

"Watch where you're going," Jimin murmured against his lips, breathless.

"I can do both."

Jungkook carried him down the sunlit hallway with steady, unhurried steps. When they reached the end of the hall, Jungkook used his foot to push their bedroom door fully open, carrying Jimin straight past the threshold and toward the rumpled warmth of their bed.

Jimin pulled back just long enough to look down at him, his heart full and warm.



I guess you're looking for some kind of moral or ending.

Well...

Jimin would probably tell you not to date your professor.

Definitely don't kiss him in his office.

Actually, scratch that.

Maybe do.

And if you're really lucky, home might end up looking a lot like a barefoot Frenchman waiting for you in the kitchen.

Preferably shirtless.

As for the moral?

Cook what makes you happy.

Because this was a cooking story, after all.

Even if somewhere along the way, the recipe gets a little... complicated.

So... what did we think?

I really hope I gave you guys the ending you wanted. I also wanted to show how easy it can be to remember why you love someone, even when you're mad, hurt, or upset. Love has a funny way of melting some of that anger once you finally let yourself feel it again.

Now, that being said, DO NOT go running back to your crazy toxic ex. Pleaseeee.

Unless he's sexy, French, and rich, then—

JK. JK.

But seriously, Jungkook wasn't really toxic. He was just making decisions he genuinely thought would benefit Jimin in the end, even if there was a little selfishness mixed into his reasoning. And I think that's what made everything so complicated. He loved Jimin, but love doesn't automatically mean you always make the right choices.

Anywayssss, come talk to me on X!! @starmaryberry

Love y'all <3

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